The Heir Apparent

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32814388.

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Part 12 of The Heir Apparent

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The Heir Apparent

by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

Capella, daughter of Bow and Glimmer, has been protesting treatment of clones on Etheria. After a protest turned ugly, she's now more determined than ever to make sure that things turn out right for them. She has allies but she also has enemies she's not even aware of yet. But they're aware of her and they've been planning and acting in the shadows for longer than almost anyone knows. Will she find out soon enough?

Capella

Chapter Summary

> Capella finds herself in front of the Princess Council after the mayor of Poview lodged a formal complaint.

Chapter Notes

> "I'm not fighting myself, will not follow / 'Cause my choices are mine it's my fate / And I'll never bow down from the sorrow / I'll face all that is coming my way"
> - Let Us Burn by Within Temptation

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Capella and her mom had butted heads before but she thought this time might be a little different because this time the entire Princess Council had been summoned. Princess Prickly Pear looked nervous sitting at the table where Princess Perfuma would normally sit. She was next in line for the title of Plumeria it'd been decided and Perfuma had sent her in her place. Next to her sat her other mom, Princess Scorpia, whispering something to her. Princess Mermista looked bored, stretched out in her chair flipping through her data pad. Princess Frosta had sent one of her spouses to sit for her and Princess Tern sat in Frosta's chair with her feet on the table as she read a book waiting for the council to begin. As Princess Izzy came into the room, her advisor, a clone named Harpi, was beside her filling her in on something as she took her seat at the table. Capella had hoped Finn would be with her, at least as a friendly face, but they weren't anywhere to be seen. Then Capella saw Princess Huntara come in chatting with Princess Netossa and her wife Princess Spinnerrella and groaned inwardly a little. It really was going to be a full council.

What an overreaction. It's not like I tried to overthrow the guy, Capella thought to herself. It had just been a protest, not even

really that, in a town called Poview against a mayor and his policies. However, it'd turned ugly when the mayor had used the town guard to stop it and things had gotten a bit rough. Glimmer had come down on the protestors side but the mayor had filed a complaint that Capella had been leading the crowd and that since she was the crown princess, he said it constituted crown interference in what was supposed to be a town level matter in the first place. Because of that, he said it was a violation of the Etherian Charter for how independent towns were supposed to be treated and her presence had made the protestors feel they had crown approval for their actions. So what should have just been another tedious lecture from her parents had now turned into a full tribunal of the Princess Council.

Capella kind of hoped they'd at least play her speech to the crowd when the mayor's guards had filled one side of the square after pushing back the protestors to disperse them. It'd been a good speech she'd thought and the crowd had agreed since they'd charged the goons when she'd finished. Now she looked around the room and tried to decide who she could count on for support in this. She figured Izzy would be on her side but she was never entirely sure with her. When Izzy wanted, she had one of the most solidly still and unreadable faces that Capella had ever seen. She wasn’t too worried since the clones called her Brother Izzy and Capella had been protesting treatment of clones in the town. Because of that she was pretty confident in her support.

She figured Prickly Pear was on her side, she was a friend after all, but she also worried that she’d do what her moms instructed her to do. Plumeria and the Fright Zone treasured their neutrality and Capella figured they’d try to walk a narrow path between both sides. Huntara would probably be on her side because Huntara loved strength and a good fight but she also loved an underdog and that dust up had been all of those things. The rest, she wasn’t so sure. She figured Adora and Catra would go

whichever way her parents went and the rest she was just going to have to watch and judge. Not that the rest were against her in the sense they were her enemies but they might be persuaded to see her presence at the town as the mayor was trying to declare.

Her Aunt Castaspella came in then hand in hand with her wife Juliet and they both sat down against the wall. While Castaspella wasn't a member of the council, Mystacor held a unique place in the Etherian Charter, the document that governed relations between all the Etherian political entities. Mystacor wasn't ruled by a princess but was also considered a kingdom so it gave Castaspella the privilege to sit in and advise at the Princess Council as one of the only other large independent kingdoms on the planet. Juliet was the retired general of the guards of Bright Moon and had no standing but she went where her wife went. Capella had noticed that the Bright Moon guards still straightened up a little more when Juliet passed, even the ones who'd only heard about her. There were a lot of stories about her but the one Capella loved the most was how the two had hidden their romance at first as it blossomed in quiet evenings of tea, sweets, and poetry, and thought it sweet.

When both Princess Catra and Princess Adora came into the room shortly thereafter, as one of the last to join the group, she knew it wouldn't be much longer before her mom, Queen Glimmer, and her dad, King Bow, would come and the whole tedious affair would get rolling. She didn't like the fact that both Catra and Adora looked upset and wondered what that meant. Normally she'd just ask them but she was trying to treat this as seriously as she could and figured formality was the rule for now. Not long after Catra and Adora had sat down on the right side of Glimmer's chair, Glimmer and Bow came into the room and got seated. Mayor Tandini, the one who'd made the complaint, came in with a few people and sat down back against the wall as Glimmer, looking tired, began.

"Alright, I call this special session of the Princess Council to order. The only item of business are charges against Princess Capella of Bright Moon. The charges read as follows: interference in a town's internal business without leave of the crown or the mayor of said town and leading an unruly mob in an attack against the town's guards. We have decided on summary judgement and the King and I have discussed it with the mayor and he agrees. The punishment shall be confinement to the castle of Bright Moon for one month followed by confinement to the environs of Bright Moon castle and the town of Bright Moon for another month following. Also, Princess Capella is to not interfere with the town of Poview and its internal business without express written approval of the queen or the mayor. If nothing else need be said, I hereby move to close this session," Glimmer sighed as she said it and began to grab a gavel to close the session.

"Hang on! I don't get a chance to defend myself or even make a statement!?" Capella loudly stated across the table. Glimmer gave her a look that Capella read as her Mom was making this easy and to shut her mouth but Capella had never been about the easy route.

"You can if you'd like but I will state if it goes to a full vote, you may not fare as well, Princess," Glimmer said. Capella saw her dad looking down at the table with a grimace, read the tone of her Mom, and almost let it go at that point but she knew she was in the right and wouldn't roll over so easily.

"I have statements to make and I'm going to make them," Capella said. "First, ever since I've been involved, I've made it clear to everyone involved in organizing this that I was not acting in any

capacity except as a private person. Second, do you know why the protest was even going on?"

Glimmer nodded and her eyes shot sideways at the mayor for a moment as they narrowed.

"That's been taken into consideration," Glimmer responded.

"That's it?" Capella said. "It's been taken into consideration? Seriously? That clown set up laws that keep clones from owning property in his town! His guard tries to intimidate them on a regular basis!"

The mayor started to speak and Glimmer turned to him and almost snapped at him. "Sir, you were allowed into these proceedings to observe. You are not invited to speak. Remember that." Glimmer turned back to Capella as she said, "This has to come to my attention and it is being investigated. If there's truth to it, we'll find it out and it will be dealt with through the proper channels."

Capella gritted her teeth. The tone Glimmer was using could best be described as The Queen Speaks and she'd heard it off and on her whole life from attending state functions with her parents. She'd always thought it was kind of funny but now she found she really didn't like being on the receiving end of it.

“And the clones just suffer while you take your time investigating?“ Capella shot back.

Glimmer turned to Harpi, sitting beside Izzy, and said, “Harpi, does the Clone Council have any input on this?“

“We do not, Your Majesty,“ Harpi replied. Capella looked at him and then at Izzy and there was the still, unmoving face, one eye covered by a monocle attached to Izzy's tiara. The monocle slowly scanned the room and seemed to linger on Capella and the mayor before it went back to Glimmer.

“The Clone Council doesn't seem to share your concern, Princess Capella. What else do you have to say? Please, no more insults either,“ Glimmer said.

“That law is slippery. Each sale has to be approved by the town for 'zoning' and it's convenient a lot of the denials just happen to be clone purchasers, not to mention that it’s been backdated for approval so those who may already own property suddenly find themselves needing to spend a ton of money to meet the new zoning rules or sell out as fast as possible to avoid fines,“ Capella said. “That law has emboldened other towns to do the same thing or similar. This isn't just going to go away.“

“You still haven't given justification for why *you* were there though,“ Glimmer said.

“To stand up for what's right! We were having a perfectly peaceful gathering when the guard basically attacked us all with almost no warning! We got driven back and of course people who got hit were scared and mad so they pushed back. I didn’t even speak up until after we got attacked! I had just been sitting eating a picnic lunch and hanging out in the crowd. If he's going to say I was there as a member of the crown,“ Capella said pointing at the mayor, “then does that mean that his guards knowingly attacked the crown princess and heir to the throne of Bright Moon?“

Capella didn’t like throwing her title around but she figured the mayor started it so why not? She saw Huntara giving a savage grin at the description and the question at the same time the mayor started looking nervous. Then Glimmer spoke.

“You were either a private citizen at the demonstration or you were a princess. You can't claim both as your defense,“ Glimmer said.

Catra leaned forward as she eyed the mayor with barely disguised distaste as she said, “If I can toss in my opinion, I think she's pointing out that while she sees herself there as a private matter, if the mayor thought otherwise then he should have taken different steps.“

Capella nodded and held her hand out to Catra.

“Thank you, Princess Catra, for very succinctly saying what I was trying to point out.“

Glimmer wanted to just give a long sigh at that point. She'd hoped Capella would be quiet through this whole thing because it gave her more options both now and after this was over. She hadn't been confident of that, because she knew her daughter, but she'd hoped. Glimmer thought the mayor a twit, his law was more than likely exactly what Capella described and thus illegal, but she was bound by the rules and laws governing relationships between the independent towns and the various kingdoms in the Charter and that meant it had to be proved that what the law did was what Capella said it did. She'd have preferred it if Capella had just come to her with the problems and while she was proud of her for standing up as she did, it was still a massive headache.

"You being there, whether or not you let it be known you were there on your own and not as a representative of the crown, does carry for some the implicit implication that you are still a representative of the crown," Glimmer said. Capella started to speak up and Glimmer cut her off. "Whether or not this is fair is another discussion and not for this council. This does of course bring up the assumption as you said that Mayor Tandini and his guard did knowingly attack a member of the royal family if they knew it was you before they went into the square after the crowd."

Glimmer had turned to the mayor sitting with his small entourage as she said the last bit. The rest of the princesses turned to look at him as well. Tandini and his entourage all looked very much like they wanted to be anywhere but there at the moment as the look Glimmer gave them all was cold and steady before she turned back to face Capella.

"However, there is precedent for such a thing happening so it's not the defense you think it is," Glimmer said. "If it had gone worse… well, it didn't."

Prickly Pear carefully held up a hand at that point and Glimmer let a little flicker of a smile cross her face as she said, "You can just speak up, Princess Prickly Pear."

"Um… thank you. I think you could say the crux of the matter is how everything is being perceived. Princess Capella says she was there on her own accord with no intention of being a member of the crown. Mayor Tandini says he thinks she was there as a representative of the crown and thus interfering in what should have been a matter outside of the crown's business, for the moment at least. Why didn't he approach Princess Capella and make a formal inquiry or even try for some kind of dialogue with the crowd itself?" Prickly Pear said. "They are the people he's supposed to serve after all."

Capella managed to keep a grin off her face as the whole council turned to Tandini again. He was starting to look a bit wild-eyed as everyone waited for a response. Izzy finally broke the silence.

"Don't forget, we've told him he can't speak in these proceedings. I'll go ahead and invite him to be a temporary member of the contingent of Dryl so he can have some input at this point. If it's alright with you, Queen Glimmer?"

"That'll be alright," Glimmer said. Capella frowned a little. She was surprised Izzy would give him that opportunity.

“Mayor Tandini, go ahead and say what you need to say,“ Izzy said.

Tandini seemed as surprised as Capella was that he’d been given the chance by Izzy but he stood up and said, “Uh, thank you, Princess Izzy. There was rumor that Princess Capella was in the mob but we weren’t able to make any kind of contact with her to confirm this. The mob wouldn’t have been safe for just a few of my guards to go into and she was at the center of it. We only became aware it was really her when she gave her speech that drove the mob back at us and at that point it was too late.“

Capella slapped the table top as she said, “You’re lying! People kept asking for you to speak and you refused! Even right before we got attacked people were trying to get you to come and talk with us! I was standing at the gazebo in plain sight before the guard charged! You had every chance but you preferred to attack us instead!“

“Excuse me! I believe the multiple reports that have been given will back up what I have said!“ Tandini responded haughtily.

“Reports from *you* and your squad of goons! Of course they’re going to paint you in the best light possible!“ Capella shouted back as she jumped to her feet, sparkles flying off her hair.

Tandini looked her in the eye as he said, “We have tried to get statements from the organizers but we have not been able to

contact them. Possibly because to make such statements would implicate them in their crimes but I'd be happy to interview the organizers if you could tell me who they all were."

Capella was about to say something back when Glimmer spoke.

"Enough. This isn't a debate match between you two," Glimmer said quietly as the two turned to her. "Princess Capella, sit down. Mayor Tandini, you do the same."

"Your Majesty…," Tandini started to say as he sat back down and Capella started to protest.

"I will invoke formal speech rules if you both make me. Now sit down and be quiet!" Glimmer spat out. "Mayor, if you thought she was in the crowd as some part of the crown, you should have taken the time. I've read your reports and while they do paint the crowd in not the best light, I think you had more time then you let on. Capella, I've also seen video of your speech, and while it is stirring, it can also definitely be seen as inflammatory. So now what do we do?"

The room was quiet as everyone thought for a moment. Finally, Izzy broke the silence.

"You originally were willing to pass down a sentence of one month confinement to Bright Moon with another month of slightly less

confinement. I say we vote for two weeks to Bright Moon castle and no more," Izzy said.

Capella looked angrily at Izzy who just continued to look towards Glimmer, waiting to see what she had to say. Capella could see a few of the princesses nodding in agreement with Izzy when Tandini said, "Now hold on! She helped spread fear in my town!"

"What a joke! You weren't afraid! You should learn to be though and then maybe you won't be so quick to terrorize your own people!" Capella shouted back at him.

"That is enough! Both of you will be silent or you'll be removed!" Glimmer shouted at the top of her lungs as she came to her feet. "One month confinement to Bright Moon castle and no further involvement with the internal matters of Poview! Any further comments!? No!? Any objections!? None!? Then it passes by general consent and we're adjourned by same."

The room was silent except for the noise of Glimmer slamming the gavel down hard enough that Capella was surprised it didn't snap.

"Izzy, do you release Mayor Tandini from your delegation?" Izzy gave her approval and Glimmer turned to him. "Tandini, my office, right now! Capella, you'll be confined to your suites until I've spoken with you and I expect to see you immediately after I'm done with the mayor. Everyone else, thank you."

Capella considered just teleporting out at that moment but she got up instead and went muttering out a side door with one of the Bright Moon guards trailing her.

"You don't have to follow me. I know where my own room is," Capella said.

"I'm sorry, Princess, but I do," the guard said, discomfort in her voice. Capella sighed as she walked along.

"I know, I know. I'm sorry," Capella replied.

"It's alright," the guard said and then looked around for a moment. "For what it's worth, the guard corp here thinks you shouldn't have got anything. Should have been commended even."

Capella gave a little half-hearted chuckle. "I was hoping to get more said and then get it to a vote but I probably shouldn't have popped off at the end."

The guard nodded but didn't say anything more as they walked up to her rooms. She stepped inside as the guard took up position outside the door.

"What happens if I teleport out?" Capella said to the guard. "Say… to Salineas for some noodles."

"Could you not? At least on my shift?" she replied.

Capella nodded as she said, "Alright, I can do that at least."

Capella went inside and flopped down on a large couch. She grabbed her data pad and shot off a quick encrypted message to Gress letting him know what had happened and then another to her friends who'd organized the event letting them know they needed to lay low for a while. She checked the data board to see what activity was happening but it was mostly low level chatter and nothing of importance. She shut her data pad down and set it down beside her as she took a few deep breaths.

For over a decade, things had been getting slowly worse for the clones on Etheria, and Capella had been getting more and more involved with their struggle and those helping them. What she found strange was that Izzy was the princess of Dryl, treated as a clone by the clones themselves, and Capella couldn't understand why Izzy would let Tandini align with her for even a session, much less suggest punishment for what Capella did.

A little over an hour later, Capella was reading a book when she heard Glimmer teleport into the room. She sat the book down and looked up at her mom as Glimmer flopped down on the other end of the couch.

"Dad not coming for this chewing out?" Capella said.

“No, he’s being a good host to everyone who had to come down for this,“ Glimmer said. “Are you alright?“

“I’m fine, Mom,“ Capella said. “Well, I’m not fine, I’m mad but if you mean was I hurt in that whole mess, no. Gress is a wreck though but his caretakers are taking good care of him.“

“OK, I’m glad to hear that,“ Glimmer said.

“Mom, you didn’t come in here to ask how I am. You asked me that the night it happened,“ Capella said. “What do you want?“

Glimmer grimaced at Capella’s blunt tone as she said, “What in the world were you thinking? That’s what I want to know.“

“That I was helping people who were getting stepped on,“ Capella said.

“Not that, although yes, that too. I meant today. Why did you decide to argue the matter? You know I could have quietly commuted the sentence later, right? Now I have to let the whole thing stand or look like I’m being preferential because you’re my daughter,“ Glimmer said.

“Seriously, Mom? You could have been on my side! You know what he and his little town council are doing! Why didn’t you help!?“ Capella said.

“Because that’s not how this can work! I’m the queen! You know the Charter, there are actual penalties for if I just flaunt it. I have to do things a certain way and that doesn’t include rioting in the streets,“ Glimmer said.

“Says the woman who I know for a fact has attacked a field full of bots by herself among other things,“ Capella said. “And it wasn’t a riot!“

“That was then. Things are different now,“ Glimmer said.

“No, they’re not. It’s still oppression. The only thing that’s different is you,“ Capella said.

Glimmer gave a sad smile as she said, “Mom would laugh so hard right now if she heard this. She’d say it’s what I get for giving her such a hard time when I was your age.“

“Don’t deflect, Mom. What are you going to do about this? Because I’ll be upfront with you, I’m not done. If you think I won’t go from town to town on this, or even back to Poview no matter what you said, you don’t know me,“ Capella said.

"Don't I know it," Glimmer said as she looked down with a shake of her head and a short grin before looking back up as a somber look went back across her face. "I'm having your Dad, Catra, and Adora dig into their records. They'll figure out how biased the law is and give me something to work with."

Capella waited and when nothing was said she replied, "And?"

"And nothing. That's it for now," Glimmer said.

"You don't think we've done that already!? It's public record! People have already brought up that it was slanted against clones and the town council just said that it was just coincidence since most of the sales in the last year had been to clones and it would work itself out as more sales happened," Capella said. "Why do you think it ended up in the streets?"

"Could you put me in contact with the organizers so we could interview them?" Glimmer said.

Capella had only recently thought that the organizers should come forward but after what had happened in Poview, she knew what she had to say.

"No, I won't."

"You don't trust me?" Glimmer said, a little hurt.

"I don't trust who all might see the names," Capella said. "And you'll have to make it public if it's going to have any weight. I'm not compromising them."

"Would you at least ask them, let them make up their own minds if they want to come forward?" Glimmer said.

Capella thought for a moment before she shook her head. "No, I won't do that either. It took a long time to get their trust; they originally thought I was a plant from the crown. Some of them think you're giving tacit agreement for these laws since you haven't done anything about them and before you say why didn't I tell them there was a process for that, they don't care. People are hurting now."

Glimmer sat back with a sigh as she said, "I can't help them if they won't come to me."

"I know pretty much anyone could join the old alliance when you all were fighting but it's not the same here. They're careful who they allow into the inner ranks because they know it could be easy to break them apart. I take that trust seriously," Capella said.

"So you are in the inner ranks," Glimmer said. Capella looked away and silently berated herself for giving that away. "How well do you know these people? Are you sure you're not getting used?"

Capella looked back as she said, “Seriously? Yes, I know them and no, I’m not getting used. I’m proud to be part of this fight.“

Glimmer wanted to tell her she was proud of her as well but didn’t say it. Instead she said, “What do you hope to accomplish with this?“

“Letting the clones just live their lives, where and how they want, same as any other Etherian,“ Capella said.

“How far are you willing to go?“ Glimmer said. Capella looked away and didn’t answer as Glimmer looked at her and then quietly said, “I asked you a question.“

“Did you ask me that question as my mom or my queen?“ Capella said, turning to meet her eyes.

“Your mom who’s worried about you and your queen who’s worried about her realm,“ Glimmer said.

“To my mom I saw you don’t need to worry but to my queen I say she should do something to fix this so she doesn’t have to find out how far I'll go,“ Capella said, thinking of her friend Gress and how terrified he’d been when the guard had advanced on him. Her hands formed into fists at the memory and she fought to keep calm.

Glimmer sat back and looked away. “Not what I wanted to hear but I’m not going to push you on it. It’s already been a rough day. Will you have dinner with all of us tonight?“

“I’m in confinement, remember?“ Capella shot back.

“To the castle. You can still have dinner with all of us,“ Glimmer said softly.

“No, I won’t sit down and play happy and nice. Besides, I don’t want to see any of you right now, if you want me to be honest. I thought this would go a little differently and I’m a bit disgusted, not to mention disappointed, in all of you,“ Capella said. Glimmer flinched at her words.

“I understand. I’ll have something sent to you then. Let me know if you have a preference please and I’m… I’m sorry. I wish I could do more for this than what I’m doing,“ Glimmer said as she stood up.

“You can, Mom. On my ninth birthday you told me that it’s our job to use our privilege to help people. You’re the queen. Figure it out,“ Capella said as she turned her back on her mother.

Glimmer started to say something as she started to reach out to touch Capella’s shoulder and then just shook her head and

teleported out. Dinner arrived a little while later and Capella picked at it before finally pushing most of it away and left the room. A new guard silently followed her as she walked out into the garden and looked up at the stars for a moment.

"Do you have to follow right behind me?" she said, looking back at the guard. "Can you let me roam the gardens by myself? I give my word I won't leave them."

"Of course, Your Highness," the guard said.

"Thank you," Capella said as she walked along the wall and looked out over the bay. About ten minutes after she'd got into the garden, she looked up at a conversation at the door and saw Izzy talking with the guard. After a short conversation she entered the garden with Harpi and made her way over to Capella.

"What do you want?" Capella said, a little bit of scorn in her voice as Harpi stopped several paces back and Izzy came forward.

"To talk with you if you don't mind," Izzy said.

"Why did you side with the mayor!?" Capella said in frustration, jumping right to the point.

"I didn't. I just gave him a chance to speak. I was hoping to try and get him to say more, reveal more, about what he's doing but

it got heated too quickly," Izzy said. "I know exactly what he's doing and I'm pretty sure I know who's pulling his strings."

"Then why didn't you say so? Or why didn't the Clone Council say something?" Capella said, gesturing at Harpi.

"Because my brothers on the council don't want to make waves. Enough people distrust us as it is. We're trying to get them to play their hands more openly so others can see it and not just say it's some trick we've come up with," Izzy said.

Capella shook her head. "It's not going to help you know. By the time it's glaringly obvious, it'll be too late. Now's the time to act if you're going to do anything. Gress shouldn't have to be scared of his own town!"

Izzy nodded at the mention of Capella's good friend, a clone Capella's age, and she muttered under her breath for a moment, waited a moment longer, and then said, "Would you show me the greenhouse?"

Capella looked at her like she'd lost her mind but just shrugged and walked over to it. Once they were inside, Izzy looked around at the various plants growing along the shelves.

"I'll have to bring Emma," she said, referring to her mother, "here to see this some time. I think she'd like it. Bit different from the one she runs in the Kingdom of Snows."

"Yeah, sure, set up a tour I guess," Capella said, a little irritated.

"How serious are you about this?" Izzy said, still looking around at the plants.

"The greenhouse?" Capella said, suddenly confused.

"No, your opposition to these laws and the overall treatment of my brothers," Izzy responded.

"I'm really serious. I'm not going to let this just happen," Capella said.

"I liked your speech by the way. 'You got pushed so are you going to fall or are you going to push back' was an excellent line," Izzy said as she tucked her orange and yellow hair back behind her ear as she turned to look at Capella.

"Yeah, well, it would have been nice if you'd backed me up in the council today," Capella said.

"You're still not getting it. We can't just push back. Oh, as individuals we can to some degree, like the clones in your movement, but a Princess of Dryl and the Clone Council? We're afraid of what might happen if we openly fight or even openly

back those fighting in our interests," Izzy said. "But you can, and have, pushed back and you and the people in your groups have got results. You probably haven't heard yet since it's only happened in the last few hours but Poview's council went into an emergency closed session with the mayor attending through a secure remote connection. They can't change the law that way but if I had to make a guess I'd bet they're talking about how to make this not such a sudden nightmare for themselves."

"Ok, that was probably more Mom but I guess I got them to the table. It's not going to matter if they don't act," Capella said. "Or you act for that matter."

"You remember the first time you met me?" Izzy said.

Capella shrugged as she said, "Yep. It was at one of Aunt Catra and Aunt Adora's parties. You decked a guy that night."

Izzy shook her head at the memory of her abusive father showing up to the party as she said, "Yeah, that night. Do you remember that you didn't like me when you first met me?" Capella shook her head and Izzy went on. "You didn't but what I'm trying to say is that you came around then and I hope you can now and I'll do it the same way. I bribed you then with a big bag of cookies and I'm going to do the same now, metaphorically speaking. I'm offering you the backing of Dryl in your fight. For obvious reasons, it'll be discrete but I'm willing to offer you assistance in many ways. Do you accept?"

Capella stood there with her mouth open and then looked around before she stepped a little closer to Izzy and whispered, "Did you just… seriously?"

Izzy nodded. Capella stepped back as she said, "Why? What's the catch?"

"Because of everything I said. Because I think you can get results. In the end though, because they're my brothers and I won't see them stepped on, no matter what, and this is how I have to do this," Izzy said. "For now. As to a catch, there is none. Do what you've been doing and Dryl gives you its backing, discretely."

"I'll do it," Capella said.

"Good. Keep using your encryption for everything to do with this and keep it up to date. If you need me, you have my contact information but remember, full encryption, always," Izzy said. "Don't tell anyone in your group where it's coming from. Figure out a story for that because if it gets out we're helping, it could be very bad."

"OK. I got this," Capella said and gave a full smile for the first time that night. "Does Finn know?"

"No, and I won't tell them unless I need to," Izzy said. "Not because I don't trust them but because they're happy running

their theater, they're not much into politics, and if I can keep them out of this, I will."

"Thanks, Izzy," Capella said and left the greenhouse. Izzy sighed and sat down on a bench as Harpi came in after Capella had left. He sat down next to her and she looked at him. "She agreed. I hope this works, Brother."

"I do as well," Harpi said. "I love Etheria."

"I do as well," Izzy said and hung her head as she clasped her hands in her lap. "In the meantime, we need to be prepared. Make sure all our comms are secure and that we have some kind of backup for them. Get a schedule of every clone ship coming in or near the Etherian system for the next six months, and figure out how long between each one. Then check our provision stockpiles and make sure we have double the amount needed for each gap between ships. Check our routes to the spaceport as well as our other egress routes out of Dryl and make sure they're clear."

"You expect trouble," Harpi said.

"I've expected it ever since that first run in with Aeron," Izzy said, referring to someone she'd butted heads with over his hate of clones years before and was pretty sure was still involved. She looked up at the plants for a moment before going on. "I knew what I was promising Brother Priz when I said I understood it could be just me beside my brothers against the universe. I'm not backing down now."

“We won’t go to war though,“ Harpi said. “The Council is not happy about even this level of involvement or your other activities.“

“I remember,“ Izzy said. “But I’m not asking for war. It’s the same as I say at each council. I’m only asking for us to protect ourselves and hopefully head it off before it ever gets to war.“

“I understand, Brother. I’ve been with you since the start,“ Harpi said. Izzy gave a small smile at him and went back to looking at the plants.

Chapter End Notes

> And here we go. Long time readers will notice that I didn't start the chapter notes with "Shall we?" like I normally do. Nope. Trying something different here. I'm going to be posting lyrics, quotes, poetry, etc that I feel helps give a tone to the story and/or the chapter itself. When I was a teenager, the books I loved the most had some little thing like that at the beginning and I figured, why not? I'm hoping I can pull off what I'm planning here. I'll also be weaving several different character stories back and forth and I'll be titling the chapters after the main character's viewpoint.
>
> Other than that, I don't have much to say right now. Thank you for reading!

Capella

Chapter Summary

> It's been a week now and Glimmer still hasn't been to seen Capella after that first night after she was sentenced. Now Capella is catching up with Gress and Sert not realizing that she has a visitor coming.

Chapter Notes

> "Never opened myself this way/ Life is ours, we live it our way / All these words I don't just say / And nothing else matters" - *Nothing Else Matters* by Metallica

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A week later, Capella had been talking with Gress all morning and they were wrapping up so he could get some rest.

"I’m still waking up in the middle of the night shaking," Gress said, his large green eyes peering out from the data pad at Capella.

"I’m sorry I got you involved in that buddy," Capella said. "I never thought it’d go that way."

"I do not blame you, Cappe, and I went in willingly. You did not charge us with guards," Gress said. "I take solace in that I was able to have a hand in helping people that day."

"You did so well," Capella said with a smile. "I wish I could have been stronger and done more."

"You did plenty," Gress said. "Not only did you pull a lot of people back from being hurt but your speech turned the tide that day."

"Ugh, I wish I'd just helped people escape instead but I was so *angry,"* Capella said. "It was just people hanging out and then… that."

After a brief pause, Gress said, "How are your Listener sessions going?"

"They're going alright," Capella said. "I hope yours are helpful."

"They are," Gress said. "P-Pears sister, Artho, knew a group that specialized in clones and put my caretakers in touch with one. He is very helpful."

"I miss you, Gress," Capella said with a sigh. "I still can't believe Mom did this or the other princesses for that matter."

"I have seen the video of the meeting," Gress said. "I think she did what she could with what she had. You did well in keeping people out of it as well."

"Well, yeah, although I’m never going to give Sert the satisfaction of letting them know they were right in keeping themselves hidden," Capella said with a grin.

"They have said as much on the data board, that they made the right decision, so you do not need to let them know. I did want to say that I am coming to Bright Moon with my caretakers in a week," Gress said. "I will see if it is acceptable for me to visit you. Do you wish me to bring you anything?"

Capella started to say she wanted some of the hot chocolate Ulip, one of his caretakers, made when she suddenly stopped and frowned.

"Maybe you shouldn’t visit me right now," Capella said.

"Why?" Gress said, confused.

"Because they haven’t asked for you and I don’t know, I feel worried that if you show up it might raise questions," Capella said. "Maybe it’s best if you lay low."

"You teleported into danger and pulled me out of it without hesitation," Gress said. "Cursed Prime himself couldn’t keep me from visiting my friend."

"Whoa, watch your language, buddy," Capella said with a grin before she got a little shy. "You would have done the same."

"I do not know if I could have and hope I never have to find out," Gress said. "But I do know you did."

"OK, well, I hope you do come see me. I miss you," Capella said with a smile. "Get that nap now. I'll talk with you later."

"I miss you as well and I will. Talk to you soon," Gress said.

Capella watched the link break as Gress hung up and the smile slipped from her face. She hadn't meant to be some kind of hero or leader or anything. If she was honest with herself, she'd just wanted to be a friend to Gress and help him. Helping other clones was a good benefit of it as well. She stared out the window of her room for a little bit before shaking off the moment and picking up her data pad again to call Sert. They chatted for a little bit and Capella let them know she had some new backing to help them out and to start ordering new stuff.

"Listen, I know it'll take resources but I promise you I can provide them," Capella said.

"If you take something from Bright Moon, it'll have hooks in it," Sert said. "Besides, I thought your mom didn't want you involved with all of this. You know, what with being confined to the castle by royal edict and all."

"First, it’s not a royal edict. It’s a binding resolution as handed down by the crown through the authority of the Princess Council as defined in the Etherian Charter,” Capella said in a mockingly official voice before laughing and switching back to her normal speaking voice. "Second, she probably doesn’t want me to but we really haven’t talked about it. Doesn’t matter, I’m not going to stop. Besides, it’s not from Bright Moon. I’ve got a backer."

Sert laughed as they said, "Oh, well when you put it that way. And who’s the backer?"

"Uh… I don’t think they’d want me telling you but they’re very much into helping the clones," Capella said.

"Did it ever occur to you that they might be trying to break the group?" Sert said, their eyes narrowing in suspicion.

"Well, yeah, but if you knew who it was, you wouldn’t be worried," Capella said.

"But I don’t, so I am," Sert said. "Besides, it’ll take weeks to get together again for that."

"It’ll take that long before I can move about freely anyway," Capella said. "Listen, just send me a list of what we’re going to

need or even just a few things. I'll get them delivered somewhere safe and you can see how it's going to be."

Sert looked at her for a long time, the dark fur on their face making them look more playful than they probably felt at the moment. They'd been one of the people who'd distrusted Capella when she'd joined but had come around to trust her. Sert typed for a moment and then Capella saw a short list show up.

"Markers, paint, heavy paper… yeah, I can do this," Capella responded. "Print twice as many handbills too and give me the payment details. I'll handle that as well."

"Are you sure?" Sert said. "That was one of our biggest expenses."

"Yeah, I am," Capella said. "I'm all in on this and I can do this so I'm going to."

"Alright," Sert replied. "You doing alright otherwise?"

"I guess. Just kind of bored. You'd think being confined to a castle would be fun but really, it's just grating after a while," Capella said.

Sert laughed as they said, "I grew up in a place smaller than one of your rooms, not much sympathy here."

"That’s fair," Capella said with a grin. They chatted for a few more minutes and then signed off. Capella picked up a book she’d been reading and was a few more chapters in when there was a knock at her door.

"What?” she said. The door opened and Bow stuck his face in.

"Mind if I come in, honey?"

Capella smiled as she sat her book down. "No, I don’t mind."

She stood up and went over to hug him as he came in the door.

"Mom still mad at me?" Capella said when she noticed Glimmer wasn’t with Bow.

"She never was," Bow said. "She’s just busy."

"Dad, you’re a terrible liar," Capella said as they sat down. "I’ve only seen her once since the first day I was here."

Bow sighed as he said, "I know, I’ve told her she needs to come see you. She really isn’t mad but she’s feeling uncomfortable

about the whole ‘having to sentence my own daughter’ thing."

"She should be," Capella said. "She should have gone with backing up her own daughter thing but she went that way instead. You could have done the same you know."

"If it makes you feel any better, your Aunt Catra and I have reviewed the town’s file and we found enough to take it to the Intergovernmental Review Panel," Bow said.

"So? The next one isn’t for a while, people are getting hurt now, and some of the people on that panel are doing the same in their towns. It might not have anything happen. It might even shore up justification for those laws. Then what?" Capella said.

"We can worry about that then," Bow said.

"No. I’m going to worry about that now, Dad. You fought against a tyrant, why is now any different?" Capella said.

"Because we have ways of addressing it that aren’t fighting," Bow said.

"And if those ways aren’t working?" Capella said.

"Then we find another way that isn't a fight," Bow replied. "Look at Catra and Adora. Their love saved the universe. It wasn’t a fight."

"But it's not saving us now. I know this is tiny compared to Prime but it's still important. To those it's hurting, it's everything," Capella said.

Bow sighed as he stood up and paced. "We're trying, I promise. I know it's not as fast as it should be and I'm sorry."

Capella sprawled back as she said, "What would you have me do? This is the most direct way to change it."

"Is it the best though?" Bow said.

"Yes, because it helps them now," Capella replied sharply. They were both quiet for a minute while Bow stared out a window.

"Do you want to play a game?" he said.

"What?"

"A game. You pick. Cards, board game, whatever you're in the mood for," Bow said.

"Dad, seriously?" Capella said.

Bow came over to her and sat down. "Seriously. I didn't come down here to argue or debate. I really just wanted time with my little girl."

Capella gave a little smile as she said, "Alright. Let me grab a deck."

The first few hands were quiet. Capella and Bow went back and forth on dealing before Bow smiled and made a comment about something innocuous. Capella responded and soon they were casually talking, still a little tension in the air but overall alright as they passed a few hours playing cards and talking of nothing of importance. At the end, Bow finally leaned back with a smile as he threw in another hand he'd lost.

"I think I'm going to call it good. I've gotten trounced enough for the time being," he said.

"You sure you don't want another hand?" Capella said as she shuffled the cards. Bow watched as she cut the deck with one hand, did a fancy shuffle, and then splayed them across the table before gathering them back up again in one swoop.

"Naw, I think I’m good," he said as he watched her. "You know I tried to learn card tricks once."

Capella laughed as she remembered the story he’d told her when she was younger about trying to cover for Glimmer and Adora sneaking into a room with bad card tricks.

"I remember," Capella said. "Honestly, when I got bored with trying to learn magic, I always thought about learning stage magic instead. Card tricks are about as far as I got there."

"Why did you get bored with learning magic?" Bow said. "I never wanted to push you on it but I’m curious."

Capella shrugged. "I don’t know. The early stuff was fun. The illusions and such like this,” she said as she conjured a card that perfectly matched the deck in front of her. "Then the rest got really involved and it just wasn’t my thing. I know Mom is a natural but for me, not so much. I kind of felt bad about it because I know Grandpa Micah really wanted me to learn, Mom too, but it just wasn’t for me. Grandma Angella was really supportive about it though."

"I remember. We talked about trying to get you to keep pushing but she told us to lay off, it was your choice," Bow said.

"What do they think of all this?" Capella said.

Bow frowned as he said, "They haven’t said much. We told Angella but I don’t know if Micah knows. Angella might not have told him because his health is slipping again."

"He was doing alright the last time I saw him. That was just a few weeks ago, right before I went to Poview," Capella said.

"It’s not scary bad like a couple of years ago but he hasn’t really gotten any better from where he was at Finn and Izzy’s wedding," Bow said unconvincingly.

"Well now I’m going to worry," Capella replied.

"I understand. I worry too but he’s got good healers helping him. They’re doing all they can," Bow said. They were both silent for a moment as Capella fiddled with the deck of cards.

"What about Grandpa George and Grandpa Lance?” Capella said quietly as she looked at the table.

Bow tried not to smile as he remembered them both teasing him that it was what he got for lying to them when he joined the Rebellion.

"They understand," Bow said. "Honey, no one is mad at you. They all understand but…"

"Dad, stop, please. It's been a good visit and if you try to justify what's happened, it'll end on a sour note," Capella responded.

Bow gave a slow nod as he said, ""OK, I won't." He then stood up with a dramatic arm gesture like he was stretching. "Well, I hate to cut and run but I have to go. Can I get a hug?"

"Of course you can, Dad," Capella said as she smiled and teleported to his side to hug him. Her smile slipped as she said, "Could you… could you tell Mom to come see me? I mean, if you can, she can too."

"Yes, I'll tell her. When she does though, give her a chance. You always clashed with her more than you did with me but she loves you," Bow said.

"I love her too," Capella replied. "I don't know why we fight so much."

"Because you're both pretty similar," Bow said. "Don't give me that look, you are and that's not a bad thing but you butt heads because you're both stubborn. Just… give her that chance. It's all I'm asking."

"Alright, Dad, I will," Capella said as she hugged him again. "I love you."

"I love you too, my little star," Bow said.

When Bow left, Capella sat down on the couch. She wiped at her eyes for a moment. There weren't tears there but she could feel where they could be, like a cold breeze before a storm. She didn't like this. It wasn't that she liked fighting with her mom, she loved her mom, it was just that she and her mother grated at each other, like two continental plates. Most of the time, stable, placid, but occasionally earthquakes and maybe a volcano or two. This one felt particularly volcanic but she felt hurt that Glimmer wouldn't come down and at least face her. They'd always worked it out in the past but she didn't know how to move forward.

It was late into the evening and Capella had just finished brushing her hair, getting it into a wrap, and was dressed for bed when she heard the knock at the door. She wasn't sure who would be there that late but she went over anyway and opened it up to see Glimmer standing there, looking uncomfortable.

"May I come in, please?" Glimmer said, all formal tones. Capella opened the door wider and held her arm out without a word. Glimmer walked in and looked around at the room like she'd never seen it before, her arms crossed in front of her and her wings tucked in close to her. Capella had her dad's height but she'd never really noticed how much taller she had gotten than her mom until then as Glimmer seemed so small at that moment.

"Surprised you came down," Capella said. "Figured you'd wait until I was the good child again."

Glimmer turned around and Capella felt bad at the look of hurt on her face.

"Cappe, do you think I liked doing that?"

Capella heard the hurt in her voice but she said, "Do you think I care, Mom? You could have stood by me. You could have let someone else do it but you did it yourself."

"Because you're my daughter. You probably don't know but Tandini wanted you to go to his courts. How do you think you'd have fared there?" Glimmer said.

Capella shook her head as she said, "That never would have happened either way. I'm a *princess,* remember? Whole reason this is even a thing. You'd never have allowed that, so it's not like it was a favor to me."

"When Peekablue got into that bit of trouble over those tax bills, we let him get tried in a local court," Glimmer said. "So yes, I could have let you go to Tandini's court."

Capella laughed but there was no joy in it. "Peekablue isn't a sitting member of the Princess Council though or a part of the

royal family! So don’t try to blow dust in my eyes."

Glimmer sighed. "I know you said you weren’t hurt but are you doing, you know, OK? After the fight and everything."

"Yes, I’ve been seeing the Listener and I’m doing fine."

"I was in a lot of fights. They… drag on you," Glimmer said. "Your Dad and I, we hoped you’d never be involved in something like that."

"Well, I was," Capella said. "Why didn’t you come down here sooner?"

Glimmer looked away as she said, "I don’t know. You asked me to though and I knew it was wrong I’d taken so long so I came. I’m sorry."

"But why did I have to ask you to!? Dad has been down a few times since this all began but you just came down right afterwards and not once since," Capella said and fought back the crack she felt in her voice as she said what she’d been thinking about. "Am I that big of a disappointment to you?"

"No, of course not," Glimmer said immediately and stepped forward to hug Capella. "I’ve just been…, no, I won’t say I'm too

busy. That’s not true. Bow has been just as busy. I… I don’t know. Like I said, it’s wrong that I waited and I’m sorry."

"Don’t hug me," Capella said simply as she stepped away from Glimmer. "Dad said it’s because you’re messed up over having to sentence me."

Glimmer flinched but nodded as she said, "I am. I didn’t want to have to do it but I have a duty to the law as well. I’m not some all-powerful dictator."

"All I’m hearing are justifications, Mom," Capella shot back. "Excuses. I asked Dad this and I’ll ask you this. You fought a tyrant once, why won’t you do the same thing now?"

"Because this isn’t some single tyrant, they’re our fellow Etherians. Because we have ways to handle this and we’re doing it and because it doesn’t have to be a fight," Glimmer said plaintively.

"It does if they fight first," Capella said. "I know you saw what they did! They marched into that square without hardly any warning with stun spears! Did you know I got hit with one?"

Glimmer’s face went still but her eyes were furious as she said, "No, I did not. Why didn’t you tell me?"

"Because it shouldn’t matter! I took a shock when I pulled a person back. They were getting hit with it and I was lucky I was teleporting already or I’d probably have been dropped as well," Capella said. "Plenty of others took the full brunt. Why does it matter if I did or not? They are just as important as I am."

"I agree but I could have done something with that! Especially if we could have got some people to back that up!" Glimmer said.

"Mom! I was at the front! The only people paying attention to me were the ones who *lied* in those testimonies because they were the ones driving spears into the crowd!" Capella said. "I know it’s hard to believe since the crowd charged armed guards but those same people are terrified now! They were terrified *then!* There’s a very good reason hardly anyone swore out a statement!"

Glimmer sighed as she seemed to deflate a little. "Cappe, I don’t want you doing this anymore. We can find another way for you to be involved but this… I can’t imagine you facing down a stun spear."

"No, I’m not stopping and I don’t care what you say," Capella said coldly. "They went after Gress. Gress! He was just standing speaking into a sound system trying to give people directions to escape and *they went after him!"*

She stood, fists clenched, as sparks started to fall through Capella's headwrap as she fought to from screaming any louder. She could still hear Gress’ terrified scream as they marched up the steps towards him and she turned her back on Glimmer as she

tried to compose herself and did her best to not think of that memory. Glimmer stepped forward and put her hand on Capella's shoulder. Capella stiffened up for a moment but didn't shake it off.

"Can I tell you something?" Glimmer said carefully.

"What?"

"The reason I'm here so late tonight was because I got word that the Poview Council rescinded the zoning law. It was close but it went through," Glimmer said. "Tandini is facing a vote of no confidence tomorrow. If it goes through, by Poview's charter, he has to resign. I imagine some of the council will face similar votes."

"And?" Capella said as she turned half way around.

"That means you won," Glimmer said. "What you did mattered."

"Then why do you want me to stop doing it?" Capella said, turning around so she was face to face with Glimmer.

"Because it's not needed," Glimmer said. "You're Dad, Aunt Adora, and Aunt Catra will go before the Intergovernmental Review Panel with the law. It'll get reviewed and probably declared against the Charter which means people who were hurt by it can at the very

least get some kind of compensation and any town that has something similar will have to take it off the books and do the same. You don’t have to risk something like that again."

"Mom, you say I don’t have to risk something. Me doing something risky though? That’s your fear, not mine," Capella said. "I have my own fears and one of them is standing by and doing nothing and my friend gets hurt and I’d face down a line of guards every day to keep that from happening."

"What if I forbid you from doing it?" Glimmer said, her voice quiet.

"What do you think would happen?" Capella said, just as quiet. "People keep saying we’re alike so ask yourself something. What would you have done?"

Glimmer nodded as she gave a sad smile.

"I don’t have to wonder. I already know. I won’t forbid anything but Capella, please, don’t do this anymore. Find another way."

Capella felt tears coming to her eyes at the look of worry on her Mom’s face as she said, "No, Mom. I won’t. This is right and you know it or you wouldn’t be trying to get me to find another way to do it; you’d just tell me to stop. You find another way."

"I’m trying," Glimmer said, her arms crossed in front of her. They stood in silence broken only by the sound of a night breeze through the window. Finally, Capella partially put her arms up and the two hugged for a moment.

"I love you, Mom," Capella said as she stepped back.

"I love you too, Cappe," Glimmer said and then stepped out the door.

Capella turned out the lights and went to bed but sleep wouldn’t come. She stayed up late into the night, staring at the ceiling, wondering just what the future was going to bring.

Chapter End Notes

> It's weird to write a grown-up Glimmer, trying to be a good queen and following the law has it has been set down because let's be honest, if she was Capella's age, we already know the reaction would have been even more over the top than Capella has had. Speaking of the law, here's a little meta for you. The Etherian Charter came about shortly after the war when all the independent towns came forward and wanted a framework for how they interacted with the various princess kingdoms, not to mention the queen in Bright Moon. Everyone was involved in it, including Catra and Adora and the other princesses, and got it hammered out.
>
> Now, why have I never mentioned this before? Because it wasn't relevant to the other stories... and because it's been created for this series. Honestly, almost entirely for this story because I needed a legal framework to have shenanigans with. I have absolutely not gone into detail and written up an entire planetary form of government because I prefer my

world building to be way more off the cuff. Anyway, I hope you're enjoying how this is going and thank you for reading. Can't wait to see what you think of it!

Adora

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra go up to Bright Moon palace to try and get help from their old friends.

Chapter Notes

> “Atque in perpetuum, frater, ave atque vale.” Catullus 101 (excerpt) by Gaius Valerius Catullus

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer walked down the hall back towards her bedroom, lost in her thoughts, and almost ran straight into Catra and Adora rushing around a corner.

"Glimmer, we need to talk to you right now," Adora said, her face uncomfortable.

Glimmer sighed as she said, "Can this wait until morning? Please? It’s been a long day."

"Sparkles, you think we’d be up here right now if it could wait until morning?" Catra said.

Glimmer shook her head with a sigh and took them to a comfortable sitting room. As she lay back on a couch with her arm over her eyes she said, "Alright. What’s going on?"

"I lost She-Ra," Adora blurted out. Glimmer took her arm off her eyes and sat up again.

"What do you mean you *lost* She-Ra? She's part of you Adora," Glimmer said. "She's not like a pen or something."

"I mean exactly what I said," Adora said and Glimmer saw now that the discomfort on her face was tinged with sorrow as well. Adora went on, as she started to pace the room. "I've been having weird dreams off and on for years with her but I just figured it was… I don't know, just dreams. Then right before the last council meeting… um, you know the one."

Glimmer nodded as Adora cleared her throat a little and went on. "Anyway, right before that, I had a dream that seemed to last the whole night. She came up to me and put her hand on my shoulder and seemed to just stand there, for a long time. Little flashes of all the times we'd been together went past. Then she squeezed my shoulder and walked away. I tried to follow her but no matter how I tried, she kept getting further away until she was just a little dot that faded out. Then I woke up."

Adora wiped at her eyes as she stopped pacing and Catra went up behind her and put her arms around her as she rested her head on Adora's shoulder. Adora reached one hand back and rested it on the side of Catra's face while Glimmer looked at them both for a moment.

"And you think she's gone? How do you know?" Glimmer said.

Adora sighed and held her hand out. Nothing happened. As nothing continued to happen, she said, "I can’t get the Sword of Protection to show up. Not even when I say… well…"

Adora paused and then said, "For the honor of Grayskull!"

Glimmer instinctively narrowed her eyes a little, waiting for the flash of light that always accompanied Adora doing that but nothing happened. Glimmer’s eyes widened as Catra said, "We’ve been messing around ever since that night trying to figure it out."

Catra didn’t say she’d actually spent a long time holding Adora as she’d wept. Adora had wanted to be known as Adora and not for She-Ra but the presence of She-Ra had been in her life for so long that Adora had said it’d felt like something had been ripped out of her. They’d tried everything they could think of on their own and finally decided it was time to go and let Glimmer know.

"I just… I always thought She-Ra was going to be with me until I died. That’s what I understood the other She-Ra’s before me had. I know her and I hadn’t worked together in a long time but people still occasionally come to me for her help," Adora said. "What am I going to do now? I don’t want to let them down."

"Adora, what others want isn’t that big a deal," Catra said, rubbing her shoulders. "Obviously you need to consider how this is affecting you."

"I know, I know," Adora said with a little sniffle as she tried to smile. "I get that I’m worth more than what I can offer to others but that doesn’t mean I don’t still want to help others."

"Alright, I get what you’re saying," Glimmer said. "What do you need from me?"

"Well, you’re the most powerful sorcerer we know," Catra said. "I thought maybe you could figure something out."

Glimmer shook her head as she said, "I’m powerful but that’s kind of a raw power thing. I think this is way over my head. You two need Mystacor. Someone there is going to know way more than I do."

"I kind of don’t want to spread this around," Adora said. "For a lot of reasons."

Glimmer nodded as she said, "Understandable. Then let’s contact Juliet. She can talk with Aunt Casta about it and she knows about keeping things quiet."

"Like their relationship?" Catra said, trying to bring a little levity into the room. Adora snorted a little, remembering how shocked she’d been that Juliet and Castaspella had started dating quietly after the war had ended.

"There you go," Catra said, giving her a hug.

"I’m not going to break you know," Adora said, gripping Catra’s arm around her chest.

"I know but that doesn’t mean I’m not going to try and make you laugh occasionally," Catra said.

"I hate to bring you back to this but I have some questions," Glimmer said. Adora finally sat down on the couch as Catra curled up next to her.

"It is kind of why we’re here," Adora said.

"OK, ummm… are you sure she’s gone? Maybe she just… I don’t know, left for a moment?" Glimmer said.

"I don’t think she takes vacations," Catra said.

"I’m just brainstorming here," Glimmer said.

"I thought the same but no, there’s a hollow where she once was," Adora said. "I can feel her absence. Imagine if I carved out

a piece from your chest and then instantly healed the resulting damage. You'd be physically alright but you'd still know something was missing. That's what it feels like."

Glimmer shuddered at the description as she said, "That's a visual. OK, maybe it's because you're sick? Can sickness affect her?"

Adora shrugged as she said, "I feel fine."

Catra said, "She's not running a fever or anything like that."

Glimmer stood now and began pacing as she thought.

"How about First Ones tech? Have you run into anything like that lately that might have affected you?"

"Does she look drunk to you?" Catra said.

"I don't mean like that virus," Glimmer replied. "Just maybe there's some First Ones tech that could affect you or cut her loose. It's possible."

Adora was nodding a little as she said, "It certainly is. She-Ra is way older than them but they definitely had leverage on her with their tech but no, I haven't been around any First Ones tech."

"That does bring up an idea though. Maybe we need to go to the Crystal Castle," Catra said.

Adora slowly shook her head as she said, "I don’t know about that."

"Maybe ask Mara," Glimmer said.

"You know it’s not really Mara, right?" Adora said. "I mean, it is but it isn’t."

"Whatever she is, she is still there and maybe knows something," Glimmer said.

"I was thinking more just seeing if you needed to, I don’t know, recharge or something," Catra said.

Adora snorted as she said, "I’m not a battery, Catra."

"You know what I meant," Catra said. "But Sparkles, you’re right. Maybe that’s who we need to consult."

Glimmer said, "Then let’s get going."

"Wait, right now?" Adora said.

Glimmer walked forward as she said, "Yes, right now. This is the best time, I'm coming along on this, and you got me involved. Hang on just a moment though."

She disappeared from the room and then a minute later appeared with Bow looking a little wild eyed in his baggy night pants with little red, purple, and pink hearts on them and his matching bedtime crop top.

"Fluffy, you're going to have to put up with a teleport," Glimmer said. "I don't have time to walk out there."

"Uh, maybe Bow needs to change first," Catra said as Glimmer advanced on her.

"I'm fine," Bow said.

"Adora, do you need to maybe rest?" Catra said as Glimmer reached for her.

Adora said, "I'll be there for you on the other end."

"You guys…," Catra started to say before she was cut off by the teleport. When she appeared on the other end with the rest, sitting in front of the Crystal Castle, she groaned out, "... suuuccckkk. Ugghhh."

"Did you take the couch with us?" Adora said as she realized it was sitting in the middle of the clearing in front of the Crystal Castle.

"Seemed easier than letting you two drop to the ground on the other end. It'll be fine, I'll bring it back with us," Glimmer said. As Catra and Adora stood up and started walking towards the entrance, Bow stayed back a little and spoke with Glimmer.

"Did you go see Cappe?" he said.

"Yes, I did," Glimmer said, looking away.

"Didn't go well?" Bow said, taking her hand in his as they walked.

"No," Glimmer said. "I want her to be involved with this because I do understand the importance and it obviously means a lot to her but I don't want her to be in harm's way."

"I don't either," Bow said. "I'll bring it up with her."

"You might have more luck," Glimmer said. "I just know that I need to make a point of going to see her every day. I can’t believe I went that long without seeing her."

"Did she take the apology?" Bow said.

"Not really. I don’t think it mattered to her and I don’t blame her," Glimmer said. "I screwed up on this one, Bow."

"Kind of," Bow said. "But you’ve got time to make it right."

Glimmer nodded and was about to say something more when she noticed that Catra and Adora had disappeared from sight. They both hurried to catch up and found the two of them standing in the tunnel together.

"Sorry we got behind," Glimmer said.

Adora shook her head as she said, "It’s alright. Needed to take a moment to get ready for this anyway. This place always takes me by surprise."

Catra looked around as she said, "Let’s get this over with."

The four descended into the darkness, lit only by a ball of light that Glimmer sent ahead of them. They weren't sure how to get Mara to show up. It seemed to be hit or miss the few other times they'd tried and so they roamed through the structure for a little while until Catra finally noticed they were going back and forth over the same ground.

"We're repeating ourselves here. We're all trying to stay away from where the Heart was," she said. "I think that's where we're going to have to go. At least close to it."

Adora sighed as she said, "I figured as much but I kind of hoped we could avoid that."

"It's where you seemed to connect the few times you've been here before afterwards," Catra said.

"And it was a horrible memory every time I had to walk down there past…," Adora said and then trailed off as she tried not to mention the room where Shadow Weaver had died.

"Let's just get it done," Bow said quietly as he put a hand on her shoulder. Adora gave him a weak smile and they started walking. As they entered the chamber where Shadow Weaver had died, the walls still scorched from the flames that consumed her and the guardian, Adora suddenly stopped as she thought she heard talking.

"You hear that right?" she whispered. Catra was nodding as were Bow and Glimmer. Glimmer brought the floating orb in close and dimmed it as they all started forward carefully. The four of them suddenly jumped when a voice shouted out from the hallway.

"Who’s there!? Who’s poking around in the dark!?"

Glimmer shot the globe to the top of the room and it burst into light as Catra dropped into a fighting stance. Bow went over his shoulder for arrows that weren't there and Adora instinctively reached out for the Sword of Protection but nothing came to her hand. Then everyone calmed down as Madame Razz came toddling out of the shadows.

"Mara dearie, we have guests! No, I don’t have any pie for them right now, it’s not pie making time yet," she said. No one was there but that didn’t matter much, Adora was more than used to her talking to the air. Then she looked at Adora closely. "Now I know the sparkly one, the cat, and of course Bow it’s always good to see you but you… why do you look familiar? Razz feels like she should know you but you look different."

Adora swallowed hard. In all the times Adora had spoken with Razz, Razz had always recognized Adora and if she hadn’t she had thought she was Mara. She'd never just not known her at all.

"It’s… it’s me, Adora," she said.

"No, you’re not Adora. Your hair is all wrong," Razz said and then stepped forward and grabbed Adora by the shoulder to pull her down. "Shorter too."

"Razz, it is her," Catra said.

Razz looked at Catra and said, "Catra, this can’t be her. She doesn’t look like her."

"It’s her," Bow said and Glimmer nodded.

Razz squinted in her glasses and adjusted them with one hand, the other holding Adora’s face. She finally smiled as she said, "Adora! Dearie! What did you do to your hair? And how did you get so short? You don’t look like yourself at all!"

"Razz, is Mara here? I need to speak to her," Adora said.

"Mara? Mara isn't here," Razz said. "I haven’t seen Mara since two days from tomorrow. Or was that yesterday? No, I haven’t seen Mara."

"I thought I just heard you talking to her," Adora said.

"No, can’t be, can’t be," Razz said as she stepped back.

Then Adora gasped as the room disappeared and the five of them were standing on a clifftop, overlooking the Whispering Woods. Adora never had figured out where the cliff was and wondered if it had ever even existed.

"Mara! There you are! You just wandered off!" Razz said.

Adora turned around to see Mara come walking out of the forest and caught a brief glimpse of what she swore was Light Hope disappearing into the trees.

"Sorry, Razz, I had to do something," Mara said. "I thought I mentioned it."

"You may have," Razz replied. "Or not. You're always forgetting things."

Mara smiled warmly at Razz as she said, "I sure am. Hello, Adora. It's good to see you again."

"I'm sorry it's been so long," Adora said. "And I'm here with a problem too."

"Adora, time is essentially meaningless to me here," Mara replied. "What's the problem?"

Razz was poking around at Catra who was trying her best not to push her away and Bow and Glimmer stood there with their arms around each other as Adora said, "I… I think I lost She-Ra."

"I can tell," Mara replied. "I wondered if you'd be able to pass her on."

"What do you mean?" Adora said. "I thought I was She-Ra for… well, life. I'm not dead. I'm not about to die am I!?"

Mara put a comforting hand on her shoulder as she said, "No, I don't think so. I know the other She-Ra's, they had it for life but Adora… our lives were really short. You're probably the longest lived person who ever had the mantle of She-Ra. I kind of wondered if she'd stay around or move on."

After a moment of silence as Adora absorbed that, she said, "I think she moved on."

Adora described her dreams and what had been going on.

"I think she's gone for good."

"I think so too," Mara said.

"What do we do?" Bow said.

Mara shrugged.

"I'm not sure," she said. "It's completely outside of my understanding. She could be gone for good. She could have already moved on to someone else. I'm sorry, Adora, I just don't know."

"When I saw Razz, I was kind of hoping she'd let something slip, the way she used to say your name to me before I understood," Adora said with a sigh.

"Where did she go?" Catra said, looking around. "She was by me but then I got to listening to Adora and I just realized she left."

Mara smiled as she said, "Who knows? She used to do that to me all the time. Just up and leave."

"I don't know what to do," Adora said.

"Yes, you do," Mara said. "The same thing you've been doing. It's time to let her go. It's what I wanted and it makes me happy to know you were able to."

Adora sighed and nodded her head as she said, "You’re right."

Mara smiled and then the image from the top of the cliff fuzzed out and they were standing back in the room in the Crystal Castle.

"I will never get used to that," Glimmer said, shaking her head.

Catra put her hand around Adora as Adora looked at the floor.

"I can’t believe she’s really gone," Adora said.

"Mara made a good point though, Adora," Bow said. "You’re still here."

"I agree," Catra said.

"I want to go to Mystacor and see if we find someone who can figure something out," Adora said.

"Why?" Glimmer said. "She’s gone."

"But what if she’s settled on someone else?" Adora said. "That person is going to have questions. I want to be there for them, I want to be honest. For now, we keep it under wraps though. Glimmer, if you could contact Casta like we talked about."

"I will," Glimmer said. "Now come on. Let’s go get my couch and head to bed. You two can use your old room if you want and I can get in touch with Aunt Casta in the morning."

"Sounds good," Adora said as they all began the walk out of the Crystal Castle.

Chapter End Notes

I'm sorry for the late update. If you don't follow me on Tumblr, I was doing some traveling, having some adventures of my own. Nothing as wild as what I write about but my wife and I took our little skiff (our car) and went out into the wild places of where we live. It was a good weekend.

As I mentioned before, this story is going to have multiple viewpoints and here's the first viewpoint shift! I have my own personal opinion on just what Mara is in the Crystal Castle and I've touched on it a little bit in another story that I don't necessarily consider canon to this storyline. I like the way Adora puts it though. "You know it’s not really Mara, right? I mean, it is but it isn’t." If you were wondering, yes, that's Light Hope in there with her and yes, I ship Marahope. It's my way of giving them some kind of happy ending together because dang if I'm still not over the end of season four and Light Hope's final words.

Anyway, thank you for reading and I hope you're enjoying this!

Aeron

Chapter Summary

> Tandini has been ousted as mayor of Poview and now waits for the inevitable fallout.

Chapter Notes

> "To do evil a human being must first of all believe that what he’s doing is good, or else that it’s a well-considered act in conformity with natural law." Gulag Archipelago (excerpt) by Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Several days had passed and Tandini, the now former mayor of Poview, sat in his home office by himself. It was the evening of the day he’d been removed from office and he’d tried to forestall the vote of no confidence with procedural hang ups, tricky language, and a few backroom offers. He’d managed to drag it out, but only for a few days, and in the end he’d only angered the council and he’d lost after one of his own group had voted against him. He stared into the glass of kib fruit brandy in front of him and watched the single large ball of ice move as he gently titled the glass one way and then another in the dim light of the room.

There were only two lights on in the wood paneled room, both lamps by the door into the room. He had the curtains pulled tight and he wondered if he should have packed up and left after he got tossed out. Then he thought that maybe he should have got a weapon of some kind but he had a feeling that wouldn’t have mattered much. He took a sip of the brandy and kept a constant watch on the door as he waited. He was pretty sure he was going to get a visitor soon.

Tandini was half-way through the second glass when the visitor showed up. He thought he heard a very faint high pitched noise as the visitor stepped into the door, dressed in overalls and moving on felt soled slippers that made no noise. Between the overalls and the small bag he carried, he looked like a tradesperson out and about on their rounds. The rubber gloves though, that was what caught Tandini's eyes. He felt like he should be scared but the strong liquor made him feel a little bold.

"Wondered when you'd come around, Aeron," he said as he took a sip.

"Why's that?" Aeron said as he stepped into the room and set his bag down on a small table between two overstuffed chairs.

"Figured you'd come to cover your tracks eventually," Tandini said. "And you're organized, so I figured it'd be pretty fast."

Aeron looked at him, a little confused, as he said, "What tracks?"

Tandini took a sip before saying, "Me."

Aeron looked at him for a moment before he walked over to the small wet bar. He looked through the crystal decanters on it as he let the silence linger, picking up a decanter, taking the stopper out of it, and sniffing at the liquid inside. He put the stopper back in as he shook his head and set it down. Tandini watched in horrified fascination as Aeron took a crystal glass, dropped one of the large

round ice cubes into it, and then filled it with spring water from an elaborate crystal carafe. Aeron went back to the chair and set the glass down on the table by his bag before settling into the chair.

"Can you at least not play with me and just make it fast?" Tandini said. "I did what we planned. It just didn’t work out."

"Ah, now I understand why you said you were a track to be covered up," Aeron said, nodding his head a little. "I was trying to figure that out while I made my drink. You think you’re some, I don’t know, goon or lackey."

"No, but I failed you," Tandini said. "I know what happens."

Aeron was quiet for a moment and then said, "I think I see the problem."

He pulled the gloves off carefully and laid them next to the glass. Then he picked up the glass and took a sip before setting it back down.

"You know, you really learn to appreciate good cold water when you’re in the Waste," Aeron said and then gave a slight tilt of the head at Tandini’s drink. "You shouldn’t drink that filth. It’s made from kib fruit. Those blankeyes brought that to us. It’s just one way they’re trying to worm their way into our society. I digress though. You think I’m like Prime or that Hordak. You think if you fail at something, I’m going to come in here all melodramatic and

tell you how you failed me and then kill you. Something like that?"

Tandini was confused now but slowly nodded.

"What's tattooed on your shoulder?" Aeron said.

Tandini said, "Mara was right."

"Who put that there?"

"You did."

"You're right, I did," Aeron said. "Do you remember why?"

Tandini did. He remembered being unhappy with how things were going for himself. He started listening to things people said about the clones and how they were making things difficult. He started reading up on his own about the clones and how they shouldn't even be on Etheria, especially after trying to conquer them, and he remembered the first time he'd read the phrase, "Mara was right," and the justification behind it. How she'd pulled the whole planet into Despondos to protect them and hide them from the rest of the universe and how if they'd only stayed there, they'd have been safe, free from the influences of others but especially the clones. He had thought about it and it rang true. After all, it wasn't until they were out of Despondos that Horde Prime had

invaded. Eventually he'd met Carl and then Aeron and they'd formed plans and Aeron had shown Tandini their tattoos and explained how it brought them together as a force to be reckoned with, one that wanted only what Mara had wanted for the planet and its people.

"Because it was a way to show that we were together in our cause," Tandini replied.

"And we're still together in our cause," Aeron said as he took a sip of the water. "I may not have told you but I failed when I tried the first time to fight them. You think I should have quit or been killed?"

"No, of course not!" Tandini said.

"Then why would I do that to you?" Aeron said.

Tandini slowly nodded and felt some of the tension start to leave him. Aeron stood up and stepped over to the desk. Tandini felt the tension come right back because for all the things Aeron had said, Tandini knew just how dangerous and ruthless he was and still wasn't quite sure how this was going to play out. Aeron sat his glass down on the desk and picked up Tandini's and walked to the wet bar with it to pour it out. He took a moment and made another glass of ice water and went back to Tandini and set it down in front of him.

"Drink that instead," Aeron said as he picked up his glass and went to sit back down. "Keep your wits sharp."

Tandini took a sip but didn’t say anything.

"I followed the council meetings," Aeron said. "I know you did your best to stay on top but some of our people are still on the council. Unfortunately, I think we’ll lose one more when they meet again tomorrow so for now, we do not control Poview."

"That damn Germar! If they’d just voted in favor, it would have deadlocked! The next vote may have worked in our favor after that!" Tandini said. "I helped them get on the council! I can’t believe they stabbed me in the back!"

"They betrayed us," Aeron said and Tandini’s blood ran cold at the look on his face. "They might think they were just being pragmatic, hanging on to their power, but they betrayed us all the same. No worries though."

Aeron took another sip and Tandini mustered up the courage to ask, "What… what’s going to happen?"

"Do you really want to know?" Aeron said softly. Tandini quickly decided that no, no he did not and shook his head.

"Good choice," Aeron said. "Minimize the amount that you don't need to know. We have smart, clever, and above all, powerful enemies. We have to be very careful in how we move and what we do but we're winning. Most of the princesses don't even understand that this is coordinated and the only one that I believe does know, well, she is hampered because she can't just outright shout it out or risk looking like she's fabricating things."

"Why not take her out?" Tandini said. "Make it look like an accident or even just something random?"

Aeron's hand tightened on his glass as he said, "I tried to get her once. She was lucky and I failed and ended up in the Waste because of it. She's one of our most dangerous foes and a lot of our work is just trying to stay ahead of her and her brothers."

Tandini thought for a moment and then his eyes went wide as he realized that Aeron was talking about Princess Izzy of Dryl.

"You mean…," he started to say before Aeron cut him off.

"Yes, her," Aeron said. "Don't say her name."

"You think she's using magic?" Tandini said, looking around.

"No, she has no capabilities in that area but she's good at surveillance and has a very good intelligence network," Aeron

replied. "Call it paranoid but don’t say her name."

"I won’t," Tandini said as he took a sip of the water. He had to admit, the cold water in his mouth felt like the most wonderful thing ever.

"Good. Now, to the subject at hand. I have work for you," Aeron said.

"You do?" Tandini said.

"Of course," Aeron replied. "Why do you think I helped you become mayor? You’re smart and you have a talent for getting people to listen to you. If we’re to win, if we’re to drive this scourge from our home, there’s no reason to waste talent. We learn from our mistakes and we move on."

Tandini took a sip of the water and marveled at how good the cold water felt as he swallowed it. He felt it run down into his stomach like sweet relief as he said, "I’m ready."

"I need you to do three things," Aeron said and then frowned as Tandini reached for a pen and paper. "What are you doing?"

"Taking notes," Tandini said, a little confused at why Aeron would say something like that.

"Absolutely not," Aeron replied. "From here on out, you do not take a single note. You remember things. If I find out you've been taking notes, well, I'll consider that you've been trying to betray the cause. Written records only aid our enemies. Do you understand?"

Tandini nodded as he pushed the pen and paper to the side.

"I need you to find three people. Just three. Do not rush this. They need to be loyal and smart and ideally part of the government or an important business. I'll let you know what I consider important in a moment. Bring them into the cause, slowly. Get them to give you small things, information and such, so that you can use that against them to give you larger things," Aeron said. "You remember what they do and Carl or I will come by every once in a while and get that information. You'll be in charge of this area for now but in your public life stay out of politics, stay off the data boards, and just act like you're finished with all of that. Start a little shop or something, we'll get you funds if you need them. Remember, slow and careful. This is for the long haul. Do you understand?"

Tandini held the glass of ice water in his hand and was shocked. Not long before he was sure he was going to die tonight and Aeron had just now put him in charge of building up a network. He took a deep breath as he said, "I do and… thank you for trusting me with this. I won't fail you."

Aeron shrugged as he took a sip and set his glass down as he stood up. "If you fail, you fail. We'll try to recover and move on

like we are now but honestly, at this point, with what you're going to be doing for the Cause, if you fail it won't matter. You'll end up in the Waste or facing the Dark Moon guards. Hope for the Waste."

Aeron was unzipping his bag when Tandini said, "Who are the Dark Moon guards?"

"You haven't heard of them?" Aeron said as he took out a small box with a single button and a small dark blue light lit up on top.

"No," Tandini said.

"They're Queen Glimmer's elite guard. She uses them as a hit squad against her enemies among other things," Aeron said.

Tandini turned a little pale as he said, "I've never heard of that."

"Few have," Aeron said. "If they come for you, well, you just disappear. Some are trained in magic and they're all top notch warriors. You really didn't think she'd just send her political opponents off for a few Listener sessions and then let them go do you? She's queen and she's ruthless. I'm lucky I wasn't on her radar when I got caught or I wouldn't be here. One reason to keep your mouth shut. We don't want them involved."

Tandini really wished he had his old drink now but he just nodded and took a sip of the ice water to try and steady himself. Aeron sat the small box down on Tandini’s desk.

"That’s a jamming device," he said. "Use it when you meet with people, it should keep anyone from listening in and you can hide it in a pocket or a bag so they don’t know. Blue light means it’s on, button turns it on and off. You can turn it off when I leave."

"OK," Tandini said. "Can… can I ask you a question?"

Aeron nodded as he picked up his gloves and slipped them back on and picked up his bag.

"Why me?" Tandini said.

Aeron turned to him and didn’t say it was because he knew of half a dozen petty little schemes and embezzlements Tandini had been involved in that he could use as leverage against Tandini. He didn’t say that Tandini was in so deep now it made more sense to keep him close rather than risk him running to a princess with a story and then having to deal with him. Aeron said something else that was more flattering but still true.

"Because of what I said earlier. Because you’re loyal and smart and you saw the truth of the blankeyes sooner than most," Aeron said. "Because you’re my partner in this and I trust you. Because on the day we drive them out or crush them down, I hope you’re

standing by my side so the people of Etheria can celebrate their freedom again and know who did the work to bring it to them."

Tandini nodded and came around the desk finally and walked up to Aeron.

"I’m your man," he said before hugging Aeron.

Aeron hugged him back and smiled over his shoulder as he said, "I know."

As Aeron turned to leave he opened up the bottom of the wet bar and saw the bottles in storage there. He pulled out one of the kib fruit brandy bottles and held it up.

"I’m taking this with me. It’s for the Cause," Aeron said.

"There’s another one down there. Take it with you. I don’t want their filth in my home anymore," Tandini said.

Aeron nodded and took the second bottle and started out the door again as Tandini said, "Good luck. Mara was right."

Aeron titled the bottles at him in a salute and said, "Mara was right."

Later that night, two flaming bottles of kib fruit brandy smashed through a window of a house, setting a back room ablaze. A minute or so later, Germar came running out the front door as a masked figure rose up out of the bushes with a length of wood in hand. Germar came to halt, their eyes wide, as the figure yelled, "Maybe now you'll think twice about trying to harass our brothers!"

"Wait, what?" Germar said, confusion on their face and then the length of wood cracked across their ribs. They screamed as they felt ribs crack and doubled over in pain to have the scream cut short as their breath was knocked out of them as the wood came crashing down across their back, dropping them to the ground.

"Leave the spacebats alone," the figure yelled as they threw the piece of wood down on top of Germar. "Next time, you won't be so lucky."

The figure ran off into the night as Germar's neighbors came out at the sounds of sirens from the fire trucks in the distance and Germar rolled on the ground moaning.

Chapter End Notes

Who missed Aeron!? *resounding silence*

I have to say, I have seen people dislike Aeron so hard, I love it. When I'm reading these to my wife, I'll just mention his name and she reacts immediately, cursing him and Carl both. I've said it a lot before but I'll say again, I really believe in the saying that a good protagonist needs a good antagonist. Aeron? I aim to make him a very good antagonist and seeing

people growl when his name is mentioned just tells me I'm well on the way.

I'm posting a bit early this week because I posted a bit late for the last installment and I figured why not. So enjoy, I look forward to hearing your thoughts on everything, and thank you for reading!

Izzy

Chapter Summary

> Izzy is getting a report on the latest events when Finn surprises her.

Chapter Notes

> "So if I could I'd wish it all away / If I thought tomorrow would take you away / You, my peace of mind, my all, my center / Just tryin' to hold on one more day" Jambi by Tool

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izzy looked at the report from the firebombing of Germar's house in Poview. She'd already skimmed through it once and was now reading through it again in detail. She muttered under her breath to her data pad's AI as she did, making little notes and things to check up on. Sitting across the desk from her was a short squat and balding satyr. He leaned back in the chair and stared at the ceiling as she read. Harpi sat in a comfortable chair on the side of the desk and listened quietly.

"So the club they used was kib wood, the bottles they threw through the window were kib fruit brandy, and the attacker basically screamed at Germar about clones using a term that's not in wide circulation except inside of certain pro-clone data boards," Izzy said as she tapped her data pad and sat it down. "Must have been a clone sympathizer then."

A higher pitched voice than expected came out of the satyr's mouth as he said, "Sure, sure. Gotta be."

Izzy reached up and ran her hand over the short cut hair above her ear as she sighed and looked at the man.

"You think this was him or do you think it was someone working for him?" Izzy said.

"I'd say it was him and Carl. We know they were in the Poview area when this went down," the satyr said. "Don't know which one was the attacker but it doesn't really matter."

"I'd say he's clever with this but it's about as subtle as a brick," Izzy said. "Of course, it's going to get picked up by everyone who is already against us and used as fuel for the fire."

"Hates *you* ," the satyr said with a grin. "They don't know me."

Izzy looked long and hard at the satyr and he shifted a little uncomfortably after a moment.

"Sorry, just joking," they satyr said.

"Not really in the mood, Blu," Izzy said. "In fact, I'd appreciate it if you looked like yourself."

"You know this is just my chosen default," Blu said as she shifted to a tall woman with blue swirls over her skin. "I don’t really have an outward appearance of ‘myself.’"

"Fine, look like this, like you did when I first met you. You remember. It was when you tried to kidnap me and actually did kidnap my spouse and our friends," Izzy said flatly.

"Ouch. OK, fair enough, I won’t talk about it," Blu responded. "Just thought you’d be interested in the philosophical ramifications of the ability to look like whatever you like."

"Not at the moment I don’t," Izzy said.

"You’re not the joyous creature you were when I first met you, you know that?" Blu said.

"I can always get Adora here and blow out a wall again if that’s what you’re missing," Izzy said with no trace of humor. "Maybe have Catra throw someone across a room."

"I could volunteer for the throwing, Brother Izzy," Harpi said in the same tone of voice. "I believe I could roll with it."

Blu grinned as she said, "There’s the humor. You know, clone humor is grossly underappreciated. It’s a dry delight."

Izzy cracked a thin smile and shook her head as she said, "Enough. What's our next move?"

"I think Germar isn't someone to watch much anymore," Blu said. "They betrayed Aeron's grand cause and this was the response. I'd be surprised if they stayed around Poview to be honest and really, kind of surprised that Germar is still alive."

"I'm not," Izzy said. "If they'd been killed it'd have been too obvious. This clouds the waters enough that it's useful for him."

"I'd say we need to shift our attention to Tandini," Blu said. "The fact nothing seemed to happen to him tells me that Aeron isn't done with him."

Izzy nodded as she mumbled at Pat, her AI, to pull up her chart she had of Aeron's organization. It had very few solid bits of information and was mostly guesses, suspicions, and vague assumptions but it was something to work from. She moved Tandini up into what she called Aeron's Sphere, a spot that only had a few people in it.

"I agree. I'm upgrading him into Aeron's Sphere. He's definitely a true believer and the fact Aeron was in town, and probably did the Germar firebombing and assault, makes me think he probably had a little conversation with him. I think he's been upgraded to top command of some kind," Izzy said. "Brother Harpi, Tandini gets full attention, immediately."

"Agreed. Any preference on who keeps an eye on him?" Harpi said as they made a note.

"Someone subtle," Izzy said and as Blu started to smile she looked at her. "I said subtle."

"You wound me," Blu said with a hand to her chest.

"I've certainly tried before," Izzy responded. "Besides, that job is a little below your level. I need you to oversee something else."

"I hear Salineas is a hotbed of activity," Blu said.

"I'm sure you have," Izzy said. "Let me guess? At the beaches? Maybe The Enchanted Grotto?"

"Be fair," Blu said. "The Enchanted Grotto probably actually is a hotbed of activity."

"True," Izzy said with a little hand gesture conceding the point. "No, I'm sending you up to the Kingdom of Snows. Details to follow."

"Izzy… it’s winter or close enough not to matter," Blu said.

"I’m aware," Izzy responded.

"It’s dark and cold up there," Blu said.

"I’ve spent time up there around this time. Flew in on an open skiff I might add," Izzy said. "I remember what it’s like."

Blu looked at Izzy with her hands carefully held together on her desk and a blank expression on her face.

"Clone humor?" Blu said.

"You wish," Izzy responded.

"Why me?" Blu groaned as she leaned back in her chair.

"Because against all my better judgement, I trust you," Izzy said.

"You’d think they’d be too cold to be hating people up there," Blu said.

"It’s not like it’s a rational decision. Your contact is Snow-by," Izzy said.

Izzy was about to continue when she heard Finn say from the outer room, "Did you just say Snow-by, Iz?"

She looked up in surprise as she watched Finn walk into the room, the only person not cleared for what was going on in the room that could have, and saw their face go from relaxed to confused and then upset as they saw Blu sitting in the chair.

"Iz… why is she here?" Finn said as they backed up a little. Izzy looked at the clock and realized that they’d run over on their meeting and it was time for her and Finn to have their evening quiet time together.

"Can you give me five minutes, Finn? Please?" Izzy said, her face going soft as she looked at the person she loved more than anyone in the world.

Blu looked at Finn and then back at Izzy before she quietly said, "No need. I’m going to go. I’ll message you later."

Izzy just nodded as Blu shifted into her satyr form and quietly went out the door. Finn stepped into the room and backed away from her, keeping an eye on her the whole time. Harpi gathered

up a few things and said, "Brother Izzy, I'll see you in the morning. There's nothing pressing until then."

"Thank you, Brother Harpi," Izzy said. As Harpi left, Izzy got up and walked over to Finn. She held out her hand and Finn hesitated for a moment before they took it. "What do you want to know?"

"What was she doing here and why are you talking about Snow-by?" Finn said, not quite meeting her eyes but still holding her hand tight.

"Remember how you once told me you didn't really care about the whole princess thing and politics and how I ran Dryl?" Izzy said.

Finn nodded as they said, "What does that have to do with this?"

"I'd have to talk about some of that to explain why she was here," Izzy said.

Finn sighed as they sat down on a couch and Izzy sat down beside them.

"It's not that I don't care," Finn said. "I know it's very important to you."

"It’s just not your thing," Izzy said, tacking on the unspoken part. "I understand. I just wanted to let you know what I was going to talk about."

"Go ahead," Finn said.

"OK, so you know about all the anti-clone stuff," Izzy said. Finn nodded and Izzy went on. "I needed information. I needed someone who’d walked the shady side so to speak and still knew people there. I didn’t know anyone really except Blu and Snow-by so I got in contact with them. They both work for me."

"For how long?" Finn said.

"Since not long after I got my title," Izzy said.

"Iz, that’s been years! Why didn’t you tell me?" Finn said.

Izzy looked down with a sigh as she said, "Because I knew you wouldn’t like it."

She looked up to see tears pooling in Finn’s eyes as they said, "You’re right. I don’t. I really don’t like finding out my spouse hired people who not only kidnapped me but abused me as a kid."

Izzy felt shame flow over her as she thought about how she'd just used the kidnapping as some kind of verbal fencing move with Blu earlier. She knew exactly what to say though.

"I'm sorry, Finn. I should have told you sooner. I'll let them both go if you want," Izzy replied as she held Finn's hand tighter.

Finn thought about the offer. They'd spent a lot of time with Astile, their and Izzy's Listener, talking about those two. They remembered standing up for Blu and Snow-by when Catra had been leaning over them with imminent violence in her eyes and knew it had been the right thing, not holding on to hate. Finn thought they'd put it to rest but now they could feel a pounding in their chest and a sick feeling in their stomach and hated the thought of Izzy talking with the two of them much less working with them.

"Yes, I want that," Finn said.

Izzy was afraid that was what Finn would say because Blu had proved incredibly capable for her job and Snow-by was as well on top of having found meaning and purpose for his life in the work he did, helping keep the clones safe with the information he got and fed back to Izzy. Letting them go wouldn't cripple her intelligence network but it would certainly make it much more difficult to run for a while. It'd mean her brothers would be in more danger but she just nodded.

"Done," she said and started talking to her AI. "Pat, I need you to prep a message please. Standard format and use cryptographic

key Aleph-459."

"Wait," Finn said as they heard the word cryptographic. Izzy told Pat to hold and Finn went on. "What do they do for you?"

"It doesn’t matter," Izzy said.

"You said you needed information and you needed someone who had walked the shady side," Finn said. "You’re using some code to send them a message I presume. They’re not running the Dryl bot factory are they?"

"Finn, it really doesn’t matter. If you don’t want me to work with them then I won’t work with them," Izzy said.

Finn wiped at their eyes as they took a deep breath.

"Please tell me."

Very few people know about Blu and what she did for Izzy and the same could be said about Snow-by as well as all the other people Izzy had in her network. She kept everything behind the best encryption and counter-surveillance available, she was incredibly careful about who she mentioned her sources and methods to, and she heavily vetted anyone who might remotely come into contact with any of it. Finn hadn’t been through any of that so she

knew the proper way she had to respond if she wanted to keep things safe and secure.

"Blu helps me run my entire intelligence network and Snow-by is one of my main agents who feeds information back to me," Izzy said without hesitation, ignoring the proper way.

Finn blinked once as their eyes widened.

"I'm sorry, did you say your intelligence network? Like a spy ring?"

"Yes," Izzy said. "Blu has been involved since the beginning of it and Snow-by came on not long after."

"You've been doing this for years?" Finn said, their distress momentarily eclipsed by the surprise of the announcement.

"I have. Almost as soon as I became Princess of Dryl, I started gathering information. First it was just about the towns and such under my kingdom. Stuff like census data to help me make better decisions," Izzy said. "It grew from there. When I realized I needed more than just public data stuff, which was pretty quick, I contacted them."

Finn sat back and looked away from Izzy as they thought, their hand still in hers.

"Why not use Auncle DT?" Finn said, looking back to Izzy.

"I don’t trust them," Izzy said. "They’re good, they have a reputation on the shady side of course, but they’re also more interested in drama and flash among other issues I have with them. That being said, I have actually used them on a few occasions. They don’t know that though."

"They probably do," Finn said.

Izzy thought of the layers of cutouts among other safety features she used to hire people and shook her head. "Nothing’s certain but I’d be surprised if they did."

"I don’t want to know, do I?" Finn said.

"I’ll tell you if you want," Izzy said. "It’s just a process, nothing inherently bad."

"No, it’s not important. What do you do with this network?" Finn said.

"Protect my brothers and of course, us," Izzy said.

"If I went ahead and had you let them both go, it’d cause problems for you wouldn’t it?" Finn said.

"It’d be an issue, yes," Izzy said.

"Iz, that’s kind of a non-answer," Finn said. "How bad?"

"It wouldn’t fall apart if just two people left it," Izzy said. "That said, yeah, Blu is essentially the top of my network and does a lot of stuff for me. Snow-by is a field asset but a very good one. Replacing them both wouldn’t be easy but I’ll do it."

Finn took their hand away from Izzy’s hand and covered their face. Izzy’s face fell as they did and felt her breath catch.

"I know we’re supposed to hold hands while we talk about problems but I need a moment," Finn said, their voice muffled. "I promise I’ll take it again when we start talking again."

Izzy’s breathing returned to normal as she waited. Finn’s thoughts were running around as they tried to pin down how they felt. They tried to calm down but just kept thinking about Blu sitting in the room when they walked in and got anxious all over again.

Finn finally reached out and took Izzy’s hand again and Izzy couldn't help but feel a little relieved at feeling their hand in hers.

"I want to say I'm ok with this but I'm not. I could be blase about them when I thought they were in our past but this… it's just a lot," Finn said. "However, I'm not going to tell you to get rid of them. I just… don't make me ever have to see them, please."

"I won't. I can warn you when either one is going to be around. Snow-by rarely is but Blu comes by frequently," Izzy said.

Finn nodded as they said, "Yes, please. I'll just hang out at the theater more during that time."

"I'm sorry I didn't tell you about it," Izzy said. "I should have."

Finn sighed as they squeezed their hand. "I'm still not OK with this and I'm sure we'll talk more about it but this seems like a solution for now. Do a lot of people know about this?"

Izzy shook her head. "Hardly anyone. Brother Harpi of course and Brother Priz did before he left. The Clone Council does as well and you. There's not a lot of people directly in the field. I value security and secrecy so I'm super careful about who knows."

"But you told me without hesitation," Finn replied.

"Because if I can't trust you then nothing matters," Izzy said.

Finn gave a little smile as they said, "I'm still upset but I love you."

"I love you too," Izzy said.

The two stood up and hugged each other tightly before they walked out of Izzy's office and over to their living space. They always tried to spend a little bit of time together every day, just the two of them, before bed. They didn't have to talk or interact but they couldn't do what either one would consider work. So Finn couldn't work on anything with the theater and Izzy had to leave any princess duties alone. That night was particularly quiet, as Izzy spent a little time tending the plants Emma had sent to her before sitting down to work on a scale model of one of the towns of Etheria. Finn wrote in a journal for a little bit before quietly meditating in their chair.

As it came close to time to go to bed, Finn looked over to where Izzy was pulling apart a wiring job she'd done on the model. Finn knew that there probably wasn't anything wrong with it but she'd more than likely had an idea to make it better and that usually seemed to require a full overhaul. It was a frequent habit for her and Finn gave a little smile before frowning as they thought about what they wanted to ask her.

"Iz?"

Izzy immediately looked up.

"Yeah?"

"Is what you're doing with this whole thing… is it dangerous?" Finn asked quietly.

Izzy set down her work and nodded.

"Yes. I don't go out and do field work but yes, it's not safe," Izzy said. She clenched her fists together as she looked away from Finn and said, "I've actually lost two people so far."

"What do you mean lost?" Finn replied.

"They were trying to do something and I've lost contact with them," Izzy said carefully. "I tried to find them, thinking maybe they just bailed out, but it's like they were here one moment and then just snipped out of existence."

Izzy looked away. She wiped her eyes as she thought about it. She'd known a lot about them and she'd tried to find them but after all the looking and nothing, she knew they had to be dead. It'd happened only about a year before and it still weighed heavy on her. She wondered if the weight would ever feel less and partly hoped it never would. She didn't ever want to be cavalier about something like that.

Finn stood up and went over to her. She put her arms out as she leaned into them and Finn wrapped their arms around her.

"I’m sorry. I… I never would have thought about that," Finn said.

"I’ve had people get roughed up, some pretty seriously, but that’s the first time I’ve actually lost someone," Izzy said as she hugged Finn a little tighter and buried her face into their stomach. "It hurts."

Finn could feel a knife up Izzy’s left sleeve and they knew there was a thin tube up the other sleeve that was a small stun rod and along her lower back was a large curved dagger. Finn knew that Izzy had other little things like that tucked around her and had sometimes teased her a little bit at night about stacking a small arsenal onto the nightstand while she got ready for bed. Finn didn’t find it so funny now.

"Do you want to talk about it?" Finn said.

Izzy shook her head as she said, "No, I don’t."

Finn crouched down in front of her as they said, "Are you talking about it with Astile?"

Izzy shook her head again as she said, "No, I haven’t cleared her for that kind of thing."

"Iz, you can’t do this," Finn said. "You can’t just cram that down in you."

"I have to," Izzy said. "But it’s not like I never talk about it. I talk about it with Brother Harpi."

"Who’s probably just as hurt by it as you are," Finn said. "You both need someone who’s a step away from it."

"Finn, I don’t think you understand. I can’t talk about this with someone who’s not involved. It’s not safe to talk about that or anything like that," Izzy said. "I can’t risk letting something slip."

"Is this why you didn’t go under general anesthesia for that oral surgery last year?" Finn said after thinking for a moment.

Izzy nodded as she said, "Yes. I didn’t trust that I wouldn’t babble about stuff while I was looped out on the anesthesia."

Finn sighed as they looked up at the ceiling to fight the lump in their throat at the thought of what Izzy was carrying. Finn always marveled at how much Izzy had changed over the years, from a quiet, timid person who’d tried to handle any of her problems herself because she was too anxious to involve someone else to a confident, capable ruler of an entire kingdom. Finn realized she

hadn’t changed so much though. She was still trying to handle things herself.

As they swallowed the lump in their throat, they looked at Izzy and said, "Then you’re going to have to talk to me about it."

"No, Finn, I’m not going to put this on you," Izzy said, looking them in the eyes. She didn’t have any of her filters up and Finn could see the hurt flaring bright in her eyes as they leaned their forehead into hers.

"Iz, I love you but I’m not going to let you pull yourself apart. You need to talk with me or you’re going to figure out how to get a Listener who you can trust to talk to," Finn said. “I won’t quit bugging you about this either.”

Izzy sniffled a little as she leaned back and wiped at her eyes. She was nodding as she said with a little smile, "Are you seriously trying to boss around the Princess of Dryl?"

"No. I’m hoping to get my love to take care of herself," Finn said. "I’ve never been able to make you do anything and I never wanted to anyway."

Izzy sighed and let some silence stretch before she said, "Their names were Aerie and Siggie. Aerie was such a sweet guy. Always took immaculate care of his plumage, preening and primping. Siggie, he was quiet and dependable. Built like a short brick wall.

They were a couple and they were adorable. I hired them through a cutout and ended up meeting with them after they'd been working for me unknowingly for about a year. I…"

Izzy went quiet and covered her eyes as she started to quietly sob. Finn leaned forward and hugged her tight as they let her cry.

"I killed them, Finn," she finally said through her sobs. "They wouldn't have just disappeared. I killed them."

"No, you didn't," Finn said, stroking her back.

"Yes, I did," Izzy said. "I talked about how I needed to get close to someone who I thought knew things I needed to know with the secondary goal of getting close to that person's boss. It was dangerous but they were confident they could do it and I let them, even though I felt like it wasn't a good idea. It's my fault they're dead."

Izzy went silent again, not sobbing but with tears still running down her face, as she took a few deep breaths.

"What happened then?" Finn said.

"They checked in on schedule for about three weeks," Izzy said, her voice going into a monotone recitation. "Then they missed a

check in. No problem. It happens. Then they blew the backup check in and Blu went in to figure out what happened."

Izzy leaned back away from Finn, gently pushing them away, as she looked away and went on in the same flat tone, wiping at her eyes with her sleeve as she did.

"She found nothing. She found where they'd been staying and it was neat and tidy. Nothing busted up but also none of their things were there and they were paid up for three more days. She tried to speak to people she knew were contacts. Nothing. Some wouldn't even speak to her. Then someone tried to grab her off the street after she'd been there a few days and she had to flee."

Izzy sat with her hands folded, looking down, as Finn carefully put their hands on her shoulder.

"Iz, it's not…," Finn started to say.

"Not my fault? Yes, it is. I put them into that situation," Izzy replied without looking up.

"But you didn't… make them disappear," Finn said, not wanting to mention their death.

Izzy said quietly, "I still look for them. It's a standing order. If anyone finds any trace of Aerie and Siggie, they're to report and

follow it, no matter what. I will find out what happened to them."

Izzy looked up and the only thing that Finn could think to say was that her expression was haunted, a ghost in each eye.

"Siggie had a few younger siblings they were sending money to," Izzy said. "It's why they were both on the shady side. They were helping them. I've been sending them money, anonymously, and they'll have it for as long as they live."

"Do they know they're gone?" Finn said.

Izzy nodded. "I had a report filed with the local guard of the town they disappeared from. They contacted them and told them about it. They'll be declared legally dead in a few years if they don't resurface but Finn…"

Izzy trailed off and Finn gently massaged her shoulders for her.

"You don't think they will," Finn said gently. "You can't know that though."

Izzy nodded as she said, "Yes, I can because the person's boss that I was trying to get them close to was Aeron."

Finn froze, their ears flattening out. They'd met Aeron and knew what he was like. They knew he'd tried to kill Izzy when she was about to become Princess of Dryl, and they'd got up many times over the years in the middle of the night to comfort Izzy after a nightmare about him.

"Is… is he… why him!?" Finn finally got out.

"He's one of the big players in the whole anti-clone thing; the biggest I think. His time in the Waste just made him and Carl more determined," Izzy said. "If I could expose him or break up his network, well, things wouldn't be perfect but things would improve for my brothers."

"Iz, I don't like this at all. He terrifies me. What if he comes for you!?" Finn said.

Izzy gave a cold smile as she lay a hand on the dagger in her sleeve and said, "If only he'd do that again." Then the smile ran off her face as she said, "What I'm terrified of is that he'd come for you or someone we love instead. I think he tried to get Ellie a while back."

"You mean that break in?" Finn said.

"Yeah. Ellie doesn't know it but she has a truly stupendous amount of security now. So does Grandma, Emma, and your Moms," Izzy said. "Our friends have some as well."

"What did Mother say when you offered that to her?" Finn said.

"She doesn’t know either," Izzy said. "None of them do."

"You put security on She-Ra and the most successful Etherian Horde commander ever?" Finn said, a bit incredulous.

"No, I put security on an aging surveyor and her professor wife," Izzy said. "I know they’re formidable but they’re getting old and I’m not losing someone else."

Finn sat down next to Izzy and she leaned into them as they put an arm around her. She ran a hand up and down Finn’s back as they both thought.

"I’m supposed to be comforting you," Finn said.

"It’s been a rough evening for both of us," Izzy said. "No reason I can’t return the favor."

"Iz?" Finn said after a little while. Izzy made a little grunt to show she heard them. "What you’re doing is important. I bet Aerie and Siggie knew that too. It’ll be worth it if you get Aeron."

Izzy sat up, her voice low and angry as she spoke.

"No, it won't. They're dead. They can't rejoice in his downfall. They won't go home to their friends and family to celebrate and tell stories about what happened. Someone dying isn't going to magically save us and that's what makes this so hard. I know more will probably die and to back out now is to let him win, and all the awful things that means, but to keep going means that death toll is going to happen. It's awful and I hate it so much," Izzy said as her anger drained away and she gripped down tight on Finn's hand. She shook her head and gave a sad laugh. "I'd say why me but considering I actively tried to get this position, I don't get to be all poor pitiful me."

Finn scooted up closer as they said, "You absolutely can if you want but you never really struck me as pitiful."

"Not even when you first met me?" Izzy said, looking at Finn. Finn leaned over and kissed her forehead.

"I just thought you were the greatest person I ever met," Finn said. "I'm proven right every day I'm with you."

Izzy snorted a little as she wiped at her eyes and said, "You don't hate me, knowing that I got Aerie and Siggie… you know."

"You didn't and no, I don't hate you. I love you more than I can say," Finn said as they bumped their forehead with hers. "I am

still upset about Blu and Snow-by but I promise I don’t hate you."

Izzy curled in next to them with a sigh and they sat for a long time while Finn ran their hand up and down her back, avoiding the dagger strapped to her lower back. They both started to drift off to sleep when Finn shook their head.

"Come on," Finn said as they sat up. Izzy made little grumpy noises as she reached out for Finn to pull them back to her. "We’re falling asleep. Let’s at least go to bed."

"OK," Izzy said as she sat up with a yawn.

They went back to their bedroom, a cozy spot with a curved ceiling and Finn smiled to see their old stuffed whale they’d had since they first lived with their Moms sitting on Izzy’s side of the bed. She’d told them about how she’d slept with Mx. Whale on the nights they were living apart while they worked on their relationship and it had carried forward. As they both got ready for bed, Finn watched as Izzy started taking her weapons off and carefully placing them on the nightstand.

"What security do you have for me?" Finn quietly said. Izzy sat on the edge of the bed with her back to them as she replied.

"If you want to know, I’ll tell you but I don’t want you to know. Not because I don’t trust you but because I want you to just be

Finn. I want you to be able to just live your life and not have to worry about it or always be trying to spot it," Izzy said quietly.

She turned around and looked Finn in the eye as she said, "It's extensive though because if something happened to you…"

She looked down and Finn leaned across the bed to take her hand.

"I understand," Finn said as they squeezed her hand.

Izzy wanted to say that she didn't think they did. She wanted to tell Finn that the thought of losing them horrified her. She knew what would happen if that happened. She didn't have magic and unfathomable strength like some of the other princesses but she would seek her revenge against anyone who took Finn from here. She would scream defiance at anyone who tried to stop her.

She wanted to tell Finn that there wasn't a corner of the universe that someone could hide in from her and that she'd burn everything down to get her revenge and anyone who stood in her way would burn right along with it. She had many people in her life that she loved but Finn… Finn was everything to her and she'd be damned if anyone hurt them or took them away from her. She'd either get them back or the person who did it wouldn't have long to regret their actions. She wanted to say all of that but she held back and instead said the thing that meant the same thing to her.

"I love you, Finn," she said.

Finn smiled at her as they said, "I love you too, Iz."

They both lay down and she cuddled back against Finn as they put their arm around her, a soft purr escaping their throat as she turned the light out. Izzy carefully picked up Finn’s hand and gave it a kiss before pulling it tight against herself. She knew that tomorrow she’d have to face the same problems, deal with the same stress, and continue on with the constant grinding low level fight to keep her brothers and her friends and family safe. She knew she’d make mistakes like the one she’d made in not telling Finn sooner about Blu and Snow-by and hoped she wouldn’t make another one that would get someone killed but for now, listening to Finn’s purr slip into deep, contented breathing, she was right where she wanted to be and she fell asleep with a little smile on her face as she clutched Finn’s arms tight.

Chapter End Notes

> When I first read those last few paragraphs to my wife, I looked at her and chuckled and paraphrased a line from *The Mitchells vs. The Machines* by saying, "Izzy's scary now." Honestly though, that's not fair. Izzy's always been like this when it comes to Finn. It's both a character trait and flaw. She has a temper and she is fiercely protective of Finn. Anyway, I posted a little early this week because I wanted to get this chapter up and I hope you enjoy it!

Capella

Chapter Summary

> Gress comes to visit Capella for the first time since she got confined to Bright Moon castle.

Chapter Notes

> "Friend, our closeness is this: anywhere you put your foot, feel me in the firmness under you." - Rumi

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Capella was bouncing on her feet as she stood in the main hall of Bright Moon because that day was the day she'd get to see Gress for the first time since she'd been confined to the castle. True to Gress' word, and at absolutely no surprise to Capella, he'd contacted Glimmer and asked her for permission to visit. Glimmer had come in a few days before and asked her why Gress was asking for permission to visit when there was no reason he couldn't.

Capella had looked at her and curtly answered, "Because I'm under the binding resolution… remember?"

"That doesn't limit your guests," Glimmer said, trying not to answer curtly back. "He could have been coming this whole time if you had wanted."

"Did you tell him it was alright to visit your… daughter?" Capella had said, cutting herself off from saying disappointment instead of daughter.

Glimmer nodded as she said, "Of course, I did. Could... would you come to dinner that night with him please? We'd like to see you for dinner again."

Capella had been eating by herself the whole time, in silent protest, and she shrugged at the request.

"If that is what my Queen commands," Capella had replied in an unconscious imitation of Glimmer's official voice. She realized she'd stepped over a line when Glimmer's face first fell and then went cold.

"No, Cappe, that is not what *your Queen* commands. It was what your Mom asked you," Glimmer said. "You can just say no."

Capella clasped her hands in front of her as she said, "No, Mom. I don't want to have dinner with you that night."

Glimmer's mouth clamped down into a tight line and she nodded as she managed to say, "Alright. I thought I'd ask."

Capella suddenly realized Glimmer was fighting back tears. She looked away as she said, "Mom, I'm sorry. We'll come to dinner that night if Gress' caretakers don't have to leave before then."

"I don’t want you to come if you feel like I’m trying to force you or order you," Glimmer said.

Capella still wouldn’t look at her as she said, "We’ll be there."

"Cappe…," Glimmer started to say softly before Capella cut her off.

"Mom, we’ll be there," Capella said. "I’m sorry I was rude but I don’t want to talk about it right now."

Glimmer tried to step forward for a hug and then stopped herself.

"May I…," she said and then stopped herself.

Capella looked at her finally as she said, "May you what?"

Glimmer’s arms came up a little and then fell back down and Capella felt a pain in her chest as she almost told her no and then gave a brief nod as she got up. The hug was short and Glimmer had teleported out afterwards without them sharing another word. Capella had flopped down on her bed and stared at the ceiling for a long time.

Now, several days later, she wasn’t thinking about that time. She was too excited that Gress was on his way. As he stepped into the main room, Capella was already running towards him and finally just teleported at him, catching him in a big hug that had them both spinning around laughing. He leaned over her, hugging her tight, as he said, "I have missed you so much!"

"I missed you too!" Capella said. "I’m so excited you’re here!"

Gress held out a small bag for her with a smile as he said, "I bring you a gift."

Capella grinned as she took the bag from his hands and said, "I’m sorry. I didn’t think to get you one!"

"No problem," Gress said as Cappe opened up a bag to see several clear bags filled with various powders.

"You got me powder?" Capella said, a little quizzically.

"I got you Brother Ulip’s hot chocolate or as close as we have been able to make it using powdered ingredients," Gress said with a grin. "We spent several evenings testing and perfecting it. It’s not quite the same but it is still quite good. I have included instructions for making it. You just need hot water."

Capella wrapped her arms around him again as she said, "You are the best friend. I have been absolutely *craving* this!"

"I thought you may," Gress said. "We should make some this evening."

Capella suddenly remembered what she had said to her Mom and got a little uncomfortable.

"Uh… I told my Mom that you and I would have dinner with her and Dad tonight," Capella replied.

"OK," Gress said. "Why is that a problem?"

"Because I haven't had dinner with them since the council," Capella replied.

Gress looked down at her, his green eyes crinkling in slight disapproval as his ears folded back a little.

"Cappe, that has been weeks now," he said.

"I know, Gress," Capella said.

"I know you had mentioned it before but I thought you had worked that out," Gress said.

"I didn't," Capella said. "I'm still mad at her and to a lesser degree, Dad. It seemed best."

"They are your parents," Gress said. "I cannot imagine doing such a thing to my caretakers."

"Are you really going to lecture me on the first time we get to hang out in weeks?" Capella said.

"I am not lecturing," Gress said. "I would not have stopped speaking yet if I was lecturing."

Capella gave a little grin as she said, "That is true. Gress, I'm not trying to punish them. At first it was because it was too uncomfortable to be in the same place and then it just kind of kept going."

"I understand. Have you tried to work out your problems?" Gress replied. Capella grimaced. Bow came by pretty regularly and she talked with him and played games occasionally, though some tension was still there under the surface. Glimmer had started coming by every night to talk with her but every time it had been awkward and the tenison had very much been out in the open. Her visits didn't last long.

"We've tried," Capella said simply.

"When you give a short answer like that, you usually are trying to keep something back," Gress said.

"You're right," Capella had said. "Maybe we can talk later about it, over the hot chocolate. For now, I want to do something fun."

Gress' mouth split in a smile as he said, "Discuss the latest philosophical book I have been reading!?"

"Fun for both of us, goofball," Capella had said with a laugh. "But you know what? We have all day. Let's walk the castle and you tell me about something I'm not going to understand."

"You undersell yourself," Gress said. "You understand as well as I do.'

As they started to walk, Capella said, "You undersell yourself. I do not."

They went back and forth like that as they walked before Gress started talking about the book he was reading and telling Capella about it. She didn't quite follow it but it was still great to listen to her friend talk about something he was so interested in. Afternoon

found them lounging in the garden under an umbrella as they talked about nothing of importance. Capella sighed contentedly.

"Thanks for coming," Capella said. "I didn't realize how much I missed having you around."

"I am surprised you have stuck around Bright Moon," Gress said. "I thought you would have snuck out a few times to see me at least."

Capella rolled over on the grass to look at him as she said, "I thought about it but honestly, I'm already a disappointment to Mom. What would have happened if I'd got caught?"

Gress said, "I doubt you're a disappointment to your Mom."

Capella almost said she sure felt like one but she just shrugged and then brightened up a little.

"Hey, I will say that I thought about sneaking out and I got really good at something I thought might help while I sat around," Capella said. "Want to see it?"

Gress nodded as Capella grinned as she looked around to make sure no one was watching and then waved her hand down her face, concentrating as she did. Gress' eyes widened as Capella's

face disappeared and another face showed up. She kept it there for a few seconds and then wiped it away again.

"I can tell by your eyes that you at least noticed," Capella said. "Whatcha think?"

"Is that magic?" Gress said.

"Yep. I always liked the illusion magic but never really bothered with the rest. Dad was asking me why I stopped the other day and I started thinking that well, I had time to fill, why not practice the part that I liked?" Capella said.

"It is impressive. Most magic has some kind of circle of light though," Gress said. "How are you doing it without it?"

Capella said, "Oh yeah, sigils. Illusion doesn't really need it. It's why they teach it to kids first so they can learn to channel the magic first before having to worry about the intricacies of a sigil. Though if I was making an image of like, the whole castle, yeah, I'd need one but I don't care about all that. I just like making faces and stuff like that."

Gress looked around and then leaned in a little closer. "Can you do another one?"

Capella grinned as she ran her hand down her face and put Gress' face over her own. Gress' ears stood up and his mouth opened in surprise to see himself looking back at him. Capella only kept it for a moment before dismissing it.

"Like that?" she said, laughing at his expression.

"That was uncanny!" he said, shaking his head. "Can you only do it for a few seconds?"

"No, I can hold it as long as I want," Capella said. "I'm just dismissing them quick because I don't want someone to see me doing it. I just know it'd lead to a whole, 'Have you been slipping out of the castle?' conversation."

"It is very interesting, although there's something about it that seems incorrect but I think because I can still see your face a little under it," Gress said.

Capella looked a little confused as she said, "How? I practiced a *lot.* It should cover my whole face."

"Your facial structure," Gress said. "I can still sense the structure under the illusion."

"I didn't even think of your echolocation thing," Capella said as she nodded slowly.

"They are not calling us spacebats for nothing," Gress said with a smile and a flap of his ears.

"Don’t get too cocky. I’ve seen you trip over a shirt in the dark before," Capella said with a laugh.

"Well, it is not perfect echolocation," Gress said, acting offended. Capella laughed because she’d seen how an offended clone looked and they didn’t cross their arms and look affronted. They just went silent and still and spoke in clipped tones. Gress was imitating her and how she acted when she got offended.

"OK, you can stop imitating me. I know you’re not out there mapping out whole rooms in the dark," Capella said as she gave him a little push.

"Just keep that in mind though if you ever try to fool me with it," Gress said.

"I’m not going to prank you with it or try to hide with it," Capella said. "It was more just something to do. I’ve read so many books and gone down to the training room and I even went down to the Archives. Gress, do you have any idea how bored you have to be to talk with Ledgeren?"

"I like her," Gress said. "She is interesting."

"She is a goblin that lives in my basement and delights in messing with me," Capella said.

"Hence why I find her interesting," Gress said. Capella shook her head as he went on. "Why were you trying to get into the Archives?"

"I wasn't," Capella said. "I was just bored and thought, 'Wonder what Ledgeren is up to.' The answer was drinking coffee, devising devious puzzles, and occasionally running the Archive, in that order."

"This explains why you were on the data boards in the middle of the night," Gress replied.

"Hey, be fair. Half the people there are on at odd hours," Capella replied.

"Doesn't matter," Gress said. "Speaking of that, I am glad we could get the printing changed. I would hate to have paid for that and then had it go nowhere. This Seaweed place sounds like it's going to be pretty straightforward though.

"I know Tropistar is saying so. They said the council only passed it because they thought it'd be a good way to make some money. I think a lot of the towns are doing something like that. I believe

many will back out soon. And you mentioned the printing which brings something up I want to ask."

"You want to know how I managed that," Capella said.

"Yes, because unlike the others who are just assuming you're tapping into Bright Moon's funds, I know your Mom would never go for that," Gress said.

"You're right, and that's one of the reason I've been circumspect about it," Capella said.

"Can I ask who?" Gress said. Capella almost said it but then looked around. She wasn't sure why, maybe it was how insistent Izzy had been about being careful, but she motioned for Gress to lean over.

Gress obliged and she very quietly whispered in his ear, "Just between us… it's Dryl."

"I suspected that was the source," Gress said quietly.

"You don't seem surprised," Capella said.

"I will not say why I am not as you have shown you wish to be discrete," Gress said.

Capella sighed as she said, "This feels so silly to be honest. I wish this could be more open. We're not doing anything wrong! We're just asking that you be treated the same as anyone else. I don't see why that's so hard."

Gress picked at the grass for a little bit in silence and Capella kicked her feet behind her as she rested her head on her crossed arms. Finally, Gress said, "I don't think I ever thanked you for pulling me out of the gazebo that day."

Capella shrugged as she said, "You don't need to do that. You're my friend squared. There's nothing I wouldn't do for you."

"Still, I wish to thank you and I hope you do not take this the wrong way when I say that I hope I am never in a position to be able to repay that favor," Gress said.

Capella smiled at him as she said, "I hope we're never in a position like that ever again either. If nothing else, I think I wouldn't just get a month of fancy grounding."

"Do not joke, please," Gress said and Capella noticed his face was more somber than normal.

"Sorry. I won’t. I accept your thanks and say that it is never needed. I know you’d do the same for me," Capella said.

Gress nodded and went back to picking the grass.

"Hey, we have a few hours before dinner," Capella said. "Want to go dye your hair?"

Gress looked up with a smile on his face.

"I certainly would," he replied.

Several hours later, Capella and Gress walked down the hall. Capella grinned at the bright red of his hair standing straight up from his scalp. His eyes were lined in black eye makeup and he was smiling as they went.

"You sure you like it?" Capella asked.

"As I said the last two times you asked, yes!" Gress said.

"I didn’t think it would be so red!" Capella said, laughing.

"I do not think the makers of the product expected natural hair that is as white as mine is," Gress said. "You should do yours later!"

Capella patted the curly mass of hair on her head and said, "Naw. I like it this way. Maybe a new style though. That'll fill a few hours of the day sometime."

As they got close to the dining room, Capella started to slow down until Gress noticed.

"You do not wish to do this do you?" he said to her as he stopped.

"No, I really don't," Capella responded as she stopped beside him. "But I told Mom I would and I hurt her feelings when she asked. I might be upset with her but I have to try and get over this somehow."

"Well, come on," Gress said. "You can't do that standing out here."

Capella looked up at Gress as she said, "I most certainly can try."

"Cappe…," Gress said.

"You say that a lot," she said as she started walking again.

"You require it a lot," he said with a smile.

The two were smiling when they walked into one of the smaller dining rooms, the one that the family used the most, and Capella kept the smile when she saw Catra and Adora sitting at the table with her parents. She hoped that meant they'd been invited in an effort to make it less awkward if it had just been them with only Gress. The two took a seat on opposite sides of the table facing each other with Capella sitting down next to Adora and Bow sitting next to Adora. Her mom was across the table sitting next to Catra with Gress sitting next to Catra.

No one said anything as they got seated and after they did, the silence stretched out. Capella began to realize that if Catra and Adora were there to make it less awkward, it wasn't working. Before the silence became unbearable, Gress spoke up.

"Catra and Adora, it is a pleasure to see you again," he said in his best formal tones.

"It's good to see you as well, Gress," Adora said. "I like the hair. New?"

"It is!" he said as his ears moved in happiness. "Cappe dyed it for me this afternoon. And what is new with you?"

Adora shuffled a little in her seat and cleared her throat as she said, "Umm… you know… not much."

Capella looked at Adora strangely as Catra jumped in and said, "Classes are going well for me. Lots of interesting things going on."

"Good to hear," Glimmer said and then turned to Capella. "And… uh, did you and Gress do anything interesting today?"

Capella almost replied that they'd spent the day plotting overthrows of various people but she bit back the sarcastic comment as she tried her best to smile and said, "Just talked and of course, did his hair and makeup. The usual."

Capella felt a little better at the grateful smile Glimmer gave her to her response.

"It sounds relaxing," Glimmer said and then silence dropped over the table again. Bow looked up as a small window opened in the side of the room and he spotted the dinner dishes getting put out. He and Adora both hopped up to go and grab them. Glimmer took that opportunity to turn to Catra and say, "I heard that Melog might be coming to pay us a visit?"

"Uh, yeah," Catra said. "They said the repopulation of Krytis is coming right along. Be good to see them, it’s been years now."

Capella looked sharply at Catra at the comment, feeling like there was some veiled jab at her not being around her parents hidden in there, but she stayed quiet as her dad and Adora got back to the table. They sat out the dishes and everyone busied themselves getting things on their plates and passing everything around the table. Gress gave a delighted noise when he saw a plate full of a fairly standard clone dish of fruits, veggies, and protein cubes and loaded up on that.

"I take it from the noise you like that," Glimmer said with a smile. Gress smiled back at her as he filled up his plate.

"It looks really good," Gress said. "Thank you for having it available."

"You’re welcome," Glimmer said.

Capella took the bowl after Gress and loaded up a lot on it as well and Glimmer watched her with interest.

"I didn’t know you liked it that much," Glimmer said. Capella looked up, looking for the criticism and then chided herself when she realized her mom was just making an innocent statement.

"I eat it all the time when I'm at Gress' house," Capella replied. "The cubes took a little getting used to but they really soak up the juices from the fruit and it's great."

"Should we start serving it more?" Glimmer said.

"I'd like that, yes," Capella said as she passed the bowl across to Adora. Adora put some on her plate with a smile as well.

"It reminds me of having dinner with Finn and Izzy," Adora said.

"The big ones they have at Dryl?" Gress said.

Adora nodded as she passed the bowl to Bow and replied, "That's the ones. We need to go see them. It's been too long."

Again, Capella looked at Adora, wondering if something was hidden in that statement but let it go. She said, "Did they not make it to the party this month?"

"We didn't have it this month," Catra said as she took a bite of her food. "Things were hectic and we took a break."

"Glad I didn't miss anything then," Capella said and then realized the way she'd spoken was probably a little too flippant. Everyone

at the table shifted a little as Adora nodded.

"We’re looking forward to the next one though," Adora said. "It’s going to be a crowd. Scorpia and Perfuma and their group of course. Finn and Izzy are coming as well as Emma and Grandma. Ellie will be there along with Frosta and her spouses. Artho, Oak, and Chitin are going to be there. Catra has invited her entire class as a, ‘You made it through my class’ kind of thing too."

"Seahawk and Mermista are coming as well as Cowrie. Netossa and Spinne are bringing a new game for big groups they thought up," Catra said. "I think Finn said some of their troupe might come and I know some of Adora’s work friends are coming as well. Kyle and Rogelio are even planning on coming and they haven’t been to one in a while. They said if Lonnie is on planet they’ll bring her along."

"You sure you have the room?" Bow said. "We can always host it here."

"Same as we’ve been telling you for years, it’s not our party if it’s not at our house," Adora said. "I’m putting up one of my large tents and tying the sides up as a pavilion for the backyard. We’ll manage."

"Hopefully not too many people stay over," Glimmer said.

"We got tents for that too if it comes to that," Catra said with a laugh. "Besides, packing people into the house seems to be a tradition at this point. Finn and Izzy stay in Finn’s old room when they’re down and Artho, Oak, and Chitin usually stay with them."

The conversation got quiet again as they ate. It flared up every once in a while but Capella began to feel exhausted as she kept trying to pay attention to every little nuance. She kept telling herself it was just dinner but she also kept thinking there was some hidden jabs that she was missing. Finally, dessert came and she couldn’t hold it back anymore.

"OK, I’m just going to jump right out and say it," Capella said. "You’re all mad at me aren’t you?"

Gress started to clear his throat and Capella said, "I know you’re not but the rest of you, I just feel like you’re upset with me."

"No, honey, I’m not mad at you," Bow said. "I don’t think any of us are."

Catra shook her head as she said, "How could I be mad at you? You did what I would have at your age."

Glimmer elbowed her and gave her a look.

"What!? OK, to be fair, at her age, I would have done something far worse but still, the point stands," Catra said.

"You’re not helping," Glimmer said.

"Mom, talk to me, not her," Capella said. "I know you want me to be a good little princess and act accordingly but I told you before, I’m not going to stop doing what I’m doing."

"Could we maybe talk about this later?" Glimmer said.

"No. Aunt Adora and Aunt Catra probably know all about this already, Gress does as well, and honestly, I’m tired of trying to guess," Capella said.

Glimmer said, "OK, then we’ll do this now. No, I’m not happy about what went down in Poview. Not the idiot former mayor and the town council, not you being involved in what looks like a riot you started, and most certainly not with the stupid law that is finally getting pulled back. All of that though is in the past but it hurts me that it took you this long to come to dinner again and yeah, it’s felt really uncomfortable trying to get back into it."

"It really hurt what happened with the whole not backing me up thing," Capella said. "You as well, Aunt Adora and Aunt Catra."

"You know, your Dad and I have been working on this," Catra said. "We haven’t just been standing around."

"And I got treated like a criminal before that," Capella said.

"I told you, there was a plan…," Glimmer started to say.

"That you were going to commute the sentence? Why didn’t you tell me? Why didn’t you fill me in? You hashed it out with Tandini but you didn’t even come to me about it," Capella said. "Why not?"

"I didn’t hash anything out with Tandini, I told him how it was going to be," Glimmer said curtly. "I told him to keep his mouth shut and I’d make it seem like he had been able to give some input on the matter and save him a little face."

"Why did you even give him that!? He attacked us and basically got to walk away! Oh no, he lost his job! How horrible for him! And the guard commander is still in charge!" Capella almost shouted. Gress looked down at the table, his face going red as his ears folded down.

"It’s how the politics worked out," Glimmer said. "I’m not happy about it."

"Politics," Capella said and the word came out of her mouth like a foul curse. "While people suffer."

"They’re not suffering," Catra said. "Sorry to butt in but every place that had some version of that law is holding off on it."

"Until the Intergovernmental review," Capella said. "If it fails, then what?"

"Why would it fail?" Catra said. "It’s pretty obvious what it’s for now."

"Because it’s a vote of the panel," Capella said. "What if there are enough of the independent towns to push it the other way?"

Catra was trying to think of something to say when Glimmer said, "It sounds like you’re borrowing worry."

"I’m being realistic, Mother," Capella said as she stood up. "All I’m hearing are excuses. Again."

She reached out for Gress’ hand and said, "I’m sorry, Gress. I made this uncomfortable for you. Let’s leave."

Gress looked up and shook his head.

"No," he said. "You need to work this out. You know you need to address how you feel with your parents."

"I don’t want to talk about this anymore," Capella said.

"I love you, Cappe, but you need to address this," Gress said.

"You too?" Capella said, her face falling.

"You know that it is not a case of betrayal," Gress said. "I am with you. Just like you were with me at the gazebo."

"Don’t," Capella said as a scowl formed on her face. Gress continued talking.

"You pulled me out of a bad situation that day. I am doing the same thing for you now, although it does not require the bravery you showed then. I’ll be right here for you without fail."

"Gress…," Capella said before trailing off.

"Cappe, please. Talk it out," Gress said.

Capella sat back down with a sigh as she said, "OK. We'll talk it out."

"Thank you, Gress," Glimmer said quietly.

"I did not do it for you," Gress said, his voice rising, full of anger, before he shoved it back down. In a flat, even tone he went on. "I am not happy with how the politics have worked either. I understand that it is how it is going to be and I trust that you all are doing what you believe to be best but you will have to forgive me if I am worried. In my worry, I shall do what I believe to be best. For now, that is helping my friend mend her relationship with her family. For the future, that is yet to be fully seen."

Capella looked at her friend and nodded while the other four looked at Gress with looks of shock and respect. They took a moment to compose themselves and started talking again. It didn't feel very helpful but it still felt like some kind of movement. Glimmer, Bow, and Capella all took time to talk about the things that had happened and how they each felt. At the end, the three got up and hugged, Adora wiping at her eyes and Gress nodding.

"We'll talk again," Capella said. "For now, Gress needs to head back to his inn in Bright Moon."

"Do you want to take him?" Glimmer said.

"Mom, I can’t leave the castle," Capella said.

"It’s dark," Glimmer said. "Just be quick about it. No one needs to know."

Capella looked at Glimmer a bit surprised as Gress spoke up.

"Thank you but I’d prefer to not run a chance of causing any more problems," Gress replied. "I do not mind walking."

"Do you want us to walk you back?" Catra offered.

"No, thank you," Gress said. "Bright Moon is a lovely town. I do not have any worries about walking by myself."

"I’ll walk you out," Capella said.

As the two walked down the hallway, Gress said, "Are you mad at me?"

"For making me talk to my parents? Not anymore," Capella said. "It needed to be done and you got me to back off my temper. Thank you."

"As I said to your Mom, I did not do it for her but I did do it for you," Gress said. "I know if you pulled apart from your parents, it would hurt you and I do not want to see you hurt."

Capella pulled Gress to her in a hug as they got to the door of the castle.

"I'm glad you came today," Capella said as Gress hugged her back.

"I am too," Gress said. "I expect to see you the minute you are allowed to move again."

"Maybe a minute before," Capella said. "Gotta keep up that troublemaker reputation after all."

Gress laughed and said, "Alright. A minute before. I will accept that."

Capella stood at the door and watched him walk away until she couldn't see him anymore and then with a sigh, teleported back to her room.

Chapter End Notes

I remember when I was first writing this and Glimmer thanked Gress for stepping in. My original thought was that Gress would be a little gracious but then I heard the character in my head get angry and I realized, "Yeah, that's

legit. This poor guy has had to move out of the comfort of Dryl, to another town, that he then got chased away from with his caretakers, and then watch politics play out as people try to chase him out of the town he's in now. He's going to have some anger."

That and Gress has been hanging out with Cappe for almost ten years now. She's definitely influenced him just like he has to her. I see Gress as a pretty even keeled person but that doesn't mean he doesn't get angry and sometimes he lets that anger be known.

Adora

Chapter Notes

> "I cannot say and I will not say / That she is dead, she is just away. / With a cheery smile and a wave of hand / She has wandered into an unknown land." Away (excerpt) by James Whitcomb Riley

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora sat in the backyard, watching the stars overhead as Catra came out and handed her one of the two steaming mugs she had in her hand.

"That was an awkward evening," Catra said as she took a sip from her tea and sat down in the chair next to Adora.

"She is so much like Glimmer," Adora said as she leaned in and took a deep breath to smell the tea.

"Finn's the same way. They remind me of you," Catra said.

"No way," Adora said. "If anything Finn's more like you. They've got your drive."

Catra shrugged as she took another sip and said, "That's probably more with how they grew up."

"Yeah, with you," Adora said with a grin.

"With both of us, goofball," Catra said. "Probably why we see both of ourselves in them."

Adora sighed as she sipped her tea before saying, "I miss having them around."

"You sure you're just not feeling the loss of… her?" Catra said.

"Maybe," Adora said, taking another sip. "I'm glad Casta said she'd take a look but I feel kind of guilty about it."

"What about?" Catra said. Adora didn't answer for a long time. Catra finally nudged her and Adora looked at her.

"I'm not sure I want her to come back," Adora said.

"And you feel guilty because you think you're letting people down somehow," Catra said. Adora nodded. "Adora, you don't owe anyone anything. I know you thought it was for life but like Mara said, you lived longer than any of the others did. This is new territory and I'm glad because I think about what it means, that the others had short lives and…"

Catra trailed off as she looked away and took a deep breath.

"I understand," Adora said. "I don’t want to die either. It just feels so odd. It is new territory, like you said."

Catra looked back at her with a smile as she took Adora’s hand.

"You’re a surveyor and cartographer. New territory is kind of your thing. Map it out," Catra said.

Adora snorted as she said, "That’s true. I’m still going to see what we can do. If nothing else, I still need to figure out if I can figure out who she went to so I can be a mentor."

"Going to be incredibly cryptic and call them by the wrong name?" Catra said with a sly grin.

"First, Razz is an incredibly sweet person and second, you’re thinking of the old Light Hope with the cryptic part," Adora said. "Razz’s stuff always made sense to her. Just because we didn’t share the same frame of reference isn’t her fault." Adora got a faraway look for a moment. "That actually makes me think. What if she doesn’t return in my lifetime? Should I write down everything I know?"

"If you want to," Catra said.

"I think I will," Adora said. "I can give copies to Ledgeren and George and Lance for safekeeping."

"Give one to Finn too," Catra said.

"Why?" Adora said.

"They may want to know," Catra said. "Even if they don't, if they ever raise any kids, they might want to know. If nothing else, Izzy has a pretty good library going at the Crypto Castle. She'll make sure it's safe there as well."

"I think I'll spread it out to all the kingdoms," Adora said as she thought. "Maybe some of the big towns as well. Make sure it doesn't turn into a myth too fast."

"You've thought this out I see," Catra said.

Adora shook her head as she said, "I haven't actually. It just seems like a good plan."

Adora turned her head when she heard a quiet rustling in the bushes that went still after a moment.

"Seems kind of late in the season for something to be rummaging around out here," Adora said.

Catra nodded as she said, "Late at night too. Probably one of the bots Izzy put around the house as security and thinks we don’t know about."

"Wait, she did what?" Adora said, her head snapping around to look at Catra.

"Yeah, it’s been a while. You haven’t noticed them?" Catra said.

"No!" Adora said, getting up and walking towards the bushes.

"You won’t catch one if that’s what you’re trying to do," Catra said. "I’ll be surprised if you even see one walking up on it like that."

Adora stopped halfway before turning around.

"You’re not messing with me?"

"Nope. I see them every once in a while but only for like a split second," Catra said. "They’re around Grandma’s house and Ellie has a really large amount too. That’s why I figured it was Izzy."

Adora came and sat back down with a shake of her head.

"I can’t believe you didn’t tell me," Adora said.

"I always forget you have the dullest senses," Catra said as her tail flicked back and forth in amusement.

"Makes it easier to ignore your burned cooking," Adora said.

Catra’s mouth opened in mock shock as she said, "I am wounded!"

"Seriously though, why does Izzy have bots around us?" Adora said.

"Security I assume," Catra said. "DT told me there’s rumors she’s running some intelligence ring. They were actually quite offended she hadn’t hired them for anything, it was hysterical. She’s probably just being cautious."

"Izzy? We’re talking about the same person here?" Adora said.

"She’s not a kid anymore," Catra said. "I can’t say I was surprised. Although like I said, it’s a rumor but the bots make me think there’s some truth to it maybe."

"I’m going to ask her about it," Adora said.

"Don’t," Catra said, pointing a finger at her. "She obviously doesn’t want us to know or she’d have said something already. Finn may not even know about it."

"What if it’s not her?" Adora said.

"I mean, I guess it might not be but I’d be surprised," Catra said.

They both lapsed into a comfortable silence then, watching the stars with Adora straining her ears to pick up another sound.

"You think they’re in the house?" Adora said.

Catra laughed as she replied, "I don’t know. I’ve never seen or heard one there."

"I guess we’d notice if there was a hole in the wall or something," Adora said as she stretched and changed the subject. "So how long do you think we’ll be at Mystacor?"

"Probably long enough for you to visit that room you love so much," Catra said.

"You mean… the hot springs?" Adora said with a smile.

Catra gave an exaggerated shudder as she said, "Yes, that place. I still can’t believe Ellie loves it so much."

"Well, Finn does as well," Adora said.

"I know. Makes me feel a bit like an outcast to be honest," Catra said.

"I’m sure it’s rough as you get extra-long massages instead," Adora said.

Catra gave a little purr as she said, "Oh, yes. It’s so difficult to deal with."

"I can’t get it out of my head that I did something wrong," Adora suddenly blotted out. "That she’d still be here if I’d done something different."

Catra’s face fell as she got up and went to kneel down next to Adora.

"Stop. For all we know she’s gone for good," Catra said. "She didn’t attach to anyone for a thousand years. Maybe it’s just time."

"She didn’t attach to anyone for a thousand years because she was attached to the sword," Adora said. "But now there’s no physical sword because I broke it. If she’s gone, maybe it’s because she finally lost her attachment to this world. Maybe it’s because I haven’t worked with her in so long and she didn’t have a way to stay."

"Let’s go back to the dream then. Did it seem like she was worried?" Catra said, carefully holding Adora’s hand as she heard a note of panic in Adora’s voice..

Adora shook her head as she said, "Well, she was just a figure of light so it’s hard to say but no, I didn’t get that feeling. It felt like good-bye but not in a bad way."

"Then you need to stop beating yourself up over it. It’s not like we know a lot about her. The only real research was done all those years ago when we rescued Angella," Catra said. "That was more about the sword than her though."

"At least Casta did that. Well, her and Micah…," Adora said and trailed off.

"Anything new?" Catra said, after a pause.

"No," Adora said. "At least not that I've heard."

Catra nodded. The last they'd heard he rarely remembered even close friends and he could barely move about. He hadn't forgotten anyone in his family yet but the healers said it would happen eventually, towards the end, and they both dreaded the day that happened because they knew it would break their friends.

"We'll be sure and stop in and see him while we're there," Catra said. Adora almost said she didn't want to, she didn't want to see him like that, but she knew that it wasn't about her.

"OK," Adora said. "We should probably get ready for bed. Got an early morning tomorrow."

"You act like we're flying there," Catra said. "We're just riding the public skiff."

Adora said, "I still can't believe you can just take the public skiff to Mystacor now. It was all hidden when I first went there."

"Lots of things have changed since then," Catra said.

"You know what hasn’t changed?" Adora said as she reached her hand out and put it on Catra’s cheek.

Catra purred a little as she said, "You’re going to say your love for me aren’t you?"

"Yes," Adora said as she leaned forward to kiss her.

"I love you too," Catra said. "We’ll get through this together. Same as we always have."

Adora gave a little sigh of contentment and the two picked up their mugs and went inside, hand in hand.

Chapter End Notes

I was going to post this early anyway and then I realized, hey this chapter is really short. So I'll be posting the next chapter sometime this weekend. Thanks for reading!

Aeron

Chapter Summary

> Aeron and Carl talk about their plans, the future, and meet someone new.

Chapter Notes

> "Hateful to me as the gates of Hades is that man who hides one thing in his heart and speaks another." The Iliad by Homer

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Aeron lay with his head on Carl's chest, listening to his breathing while Carl held a data pad in one hand and had his other hand resting on Aeron's back. Outside the walls of their small room, they could both hear the wind howling as a snowstorm raged over the small town they'd been staying at since they'd left Poview. Inside though, it was warm and quiet.

The world may be full of nightmares and evil but here… this is right, Aeron thought as he let out a contented sigh and tightened his arm that was thrown over Carl just a little as a hug.

"OK, Equal is going to be at Seaweed," Carl said. "Just got confirmation of it."

"Confidence level?" Aeron said.

"High," Carl said. "Several independent confirmations. We'll see public announcements soon."

"They've got a triumvirate running Seaweed right?" Aeron said.

"Yeah, that's the one," Carl responded. "Stand back or not on this one?"

"You think that princess will be there?" Aeron said.

"Possibly," Carl said. "It's only a few days past when she'll be allowed to move about again but I'd bet she will be. Tropistar for sure though."

Aeron sat up and got out of the bed they were in as he padded across the small room to a simple kitchen setup.

"You want something from here?" Aeron said.

"Get me one of the pears if you could," Carl said.

Aeron pulled a pear out of a small hanging basket and got himself a bottle of seltzer water before walking back. He sat on the edge of the bed and handed Carl the pear, a soft smile on his face as he looked at him. Carl took the pear from him and got a small pocket

knife off the nightstand to cut a slice. He offered the first slice to Aeron.

"Thank you," he said as he took it and then leaned forward and put the slice in Carl’s mouth instead. Carl chewed up the slice with a smile.

"You know, I think they have the best pears up here," Carl said.

"Those greenhouses they got everywhere," Aeron said as he opened his bottle and took a sip. "Easy to control the growth factors."

"Don’t care," Carl said as he cut another slice and offered it to Aeron. Aeron shook his head as Carl went on. "It’s cold and it’s sweet. That’s the important part."

Aeron took another drink and lay back on the bed, setting the bottle on the floor within reach.

"The nightstand is right there," Carl said, pointing at it with the tip of the pear.

Aeron said, "I don’t want to leave a ring on it."

Carl rolled his eyes as he took a bite of pear.

"Back to the point at hand," Carl said. "What do we do at Seaweed?"

Aeron looked at the ceiling in thought for a moment before he said, "Nothing. We still have our person in Seaweed's triumvirate?"

Carl nodded as he said, "Yep. Tang-y."

Aeron smiled as he said, "Ah yes. I can't believe I didn't remember. She did a good job getting the other two to agree to the law. Tell her to stand down and to have the guard stand down as well. Let them win this one."

Carl said, "I think we can still pull it off at this one."

"No," Aeron said. "I want to wait. We still have the Intergovernmental Review Panel and I don't think they realize just how much influence we can move on that one. There will be more protests no matter how that decision goes. We'll wait until one of those. Besides, got to let the rumor circulate more."

Carl shrugged as he said, "Still a lot of people on the fence too. Gotta get them into the game one way or another so we can truly see who's with us and who isn't."

Aeron grinned as he said, "That is another reason."

They both sat and listened to the storm outside. Aeron sipped at his drink every once in a while as Carl took time to enjoy his pear.

"Think this will be done tomorrow?" Aeron finally said, nodding at a tightly shuttered window covered in heavy curtains.

"Maybe," Carl said. "Probably not safe to fly for another day though. You really in that big a hurry to get to Candila?"

"A place that might actually rival the Waste for inhospitality? Oh yeah, jumping for joy but it’s important," Aeron said.

"I know. We’ve been over it," Carl said.

"You have some worries?" Aeron said as he rolled over and put his hand on Carl’s hand. "Please let me know."

Carl said, "Nothing I haven’t said before. Just not sure the Princess Council will let it fly."

Aeron shrugged as he said, "It’s in the Charter they designed. Probably thought it would never actually happen but it’s there."

"Yeah, but come on. They’re ruthless. Why would they let it happen?" Carl replied.

"Worried the Dark Moon guard is going to come for us?" Aeron said, poking gently at Carl.

"Oh yeah, the big bad Dark Moon guard," Carl said as he fought to keep a straight face and failed. "Truly a terrifying presence. We should all live in fear of them."

"I’m still surprised how fast it got around the data boards. I mean, I shouldn’t be, but come on. Bright Moon? With a hit squad? It just…," Aeron said before sputtering in laughter. "Ah, it’s so great."

Carl leaned over with a little smile as he said, "I believe you owe me an, ‘I was right’ about now."

Aeron looked up at him and stretched up to kiss him.

"You were right," Aeron said as he fell back with a happy sigh. Carl lay his head on Aeron’s shoulder and gave him a hug.

"We’re winning aren’t we? It’s really going to happen isn’t it?" Carl said quietly. Aeron looked down at Carl and gently put his hand on Carl’s back.

"I think so," Aeron said, almost too quiet to hear. "It could happen. It really could."

He closed his eyes tight as the emotions rushed forward and he dared again to hope that he would live on Etheria the way it was meant to be. He didn’t like some of the things he had to do but he knew they were necessary. He knew that not just anyone could have done what he had done because they required someone with the vision of what could be and then the will to do it. It would be worth it. He rarely dared dream about what it would be like when it was over but just for a moment, in that quiet room, he was willing to try.

"What do you think we’ll do when it’s done?" Aeron said.

"I don’t know," Carl said. "I hope there is a, ‘when it’s done.’ I worry we’re going to be taking care of things forever."

"So many have helped us. Let them rule," Aeron said.

"You don’t want even a little hand in that?" Carl said, his voice teasing.

"I'll help get it set up right," Aeron said. "Then retire to a little house, just the two of us. Maybe I'll become an architect. What about you?"

Carl said, "I don't know. Maybe design electronics or do some coding. Maybe just stay home and take care of the place. Raise some horses maybe."

Aeron looked at him in surprise. "Never took you for a horse guy."

Carl turned around as he said, "Oh yeah. Loved them when I was a kid. Took riding lessons and everything."

Aeron hugged him as he said, "We've been together this long and I still learn things about you."

"Gotta keep the mystery," Carl said. They both lapsed into a comfortable quiet.

"You want to hit the restaurant?" Aeron finally said.

"Sure," Carl said as they both started to get up. They got ready and grabbed their heavy coats. The restaurant served not only as a place to eat for the little inn but also as a place for the people of the little town to hang out in and because of that, even with the storm outside, it was packed to the brim. As they came in from

the hallway and started across the room towards a table with a few empty chairs and only one person at it, they both spotted another table full of clones and kept their face neutral as they passed.

"You mind if we share the table with you?" Aeron said over the noise to the satyr sitting at the table they'd spotted. The man looked vaguely familiar but Aeron couldn't quite place why. The satyr looked up from his drink, saw them both, and shrugged.

"Yeah, I don't care. Have a seat," he said, his voice tired. Aeron and Carl both hung their coats over the one empty chair at the table. "They got a coat rack at the door if you want."

Carl smiled as he said, "It's alright. I get chilly. I like to have them on hand. My husband here keeps his with him as well so I don't feel out of place."

The satyr looked at them both a bit odd because the air in the room was warm and humid with all the people in it but he just shrugged again.

"Not from around here?" he said.

"I'm from a little bit of nowhere south of Seaworthy," Carl said.

"Explains why you get cold. I moved up here years ago after I bought a place for my family," the satyr said, his voice going bitter before he took a long drink. "I guess I’m a native now. The cold doesn’t bother me like it used to."

Aeron said, "Originally I’m from down around Bright Moon myself. Gotta admit though, I kind of like the cold."

"Bright Moon," the satyr said, the words said like an obscenity, his voice now bitter and angry as he took another long drink that almost finished it off.

Aeron gave a little grin to himself as he leaned forward a little, "Yeah, that’s kind of how I feel about the place. It’s why I’m up here."

"That place ruined me," the satyr said as a server came to the table. He held up his mug. "Same."

Aeron smiled as he said, "My husband and I will have two Plumerian Fizzs, please. I’ll pick up this round."

"Thanks, buddy," the satyr said with a smile. "Why the fruit punch? Not an alcohol person?"

"Doesn’t agree with me," Aeron said with a shrug.

"Nor me," Carl said.

"Well it does with me," the satyr said as he finished off his drink. They chatted for a few minutes, a little nagging in Aeron's head that came and went saying this guy seemed familiar, and when the drinks showed up the satyr raised his new mug at them both. "Here's to you two. Been a crappy day and you both are making it better."

"Sorry to hear that friend," Carl said as he took a sip of the fruit drink. "Any particular reason?"

"Just saw some story about my daughter and it just reminded me what an ungrateful little brat she is," the satyr said. "I made her what she is and she won't have anything to do with me."

"Sorry to hear that," Aeron said, doing his best to show he really did even though he didn't care one bit about this guy's daughter or how he felt about it. "If they're doing stories about her, she must be someone important."

"Oh, she is," the satyr said and then his voice went into a high mocking tone. "She's a princess."

With that comment Aeron suddenly realized why the satyr looked familiar. It took everything he had not to spray his drink across

the table and still keep an outwardly calm appearance when he did. He heard Carl start coughing a little as he swallowed his drink wrong and assumed he'd had the same realization.

"You ok, buddy?" the satyr said to Carl.

"Um… yeah," Carl said. "Just swallowed wrong. And you can call me Nettie, short for Sea Nettle."

"Oh yeah, never did introduce ourselves. I'm Bryce," Bryce said.

"And I'm Seraph," Aeron said and he didn't have to fake interest in Bryce anymore because suddenly he had to know more. "Your daughter really a princess?"

"Now that is a Bright Moon name. Seraph. Like it though. You're a good dude, and yeah, she's the Princess of Dryl," Bryce said before taking a long drink. "Supposedly won that title but come on, I've heard the rumors. She got it because of who she's connected to. Just like her mother, just using people and getting rid of them when they don't suit her. That Finn is in for a rude surprise one day, I'm here to tell you."

Aeron flagged a server when he went past and indicated more drinks.

"I've heard the same rumors," Aeron said as he turned around again. Carl nodded in agreement as Aeron went on. "Heard those clones are using her for a stodge too."

"Wouldn't surprise me. Creepy things. Gotta work for one up here," Bryce said.

Carl leaned in as he said, "Really? That's a shame, smart guy like you. You should be doing your own thing, not toiling away for someone. Especially someone like that."

"I know! I used to have my own thing going but you get stuck in a Bright Moon rehabilitation sentence because you got set up and things aren't like they were when you get out," Bryce said.

"What's your job now?" Aeron said.

"Working for the water works up here," Bryce said.

"Sounds like tough work," Carl said. "But you look like you can handle it."

"Thanks, Nettie. It's mostly desk stuff but I gotta go out on the floor occasionally," Bryce said as he flexed a muscle that wasn't really there. As the drinks arrived, Aeron waved away Bryce's attempt to pay.

"Don’t worry about it," Aeron said. "Not going to let a friend who’s had a bad day cover it. We got you tonight, Bryce."

"You’re alright," Bryce said as he finished off his drink and picked up the new one.

"Thank you," Aeron said and smiled as he took a drink, his eyes almost glittering. "Daughters should be more grateful to their parents. You don’t deserve that."

"You’d think so but she’s the one that set me up!" Bryce said. "You haven’t heard half the things I could tell you about her or what she’s done to me."

Aeron leaned back with a comforting smile as he took a sip.

"Do tell."

Several hours later, Aeron and Carl were back in their room. They’d got more drinks for Bryce and then food for him to keep him from getting too plastered and then at the end of the night, helped him to his little house through the freezing cold night and storm to make sure he got to bed safely. They’d left him with a contact for them and in return he’d done the same. They’d told him they travelled a lot but would love to drop in again sometime

and hang out. Now, sprawled across their bed again, Aeron was shaking his head in surprise.

"Can you believe the luck?" he said.

"I swear, it almost feels like a setup," Carl said.

"Oh, we'll vet it but I know she's estranged from her father," Aeron said. "Some of that stuff he said about her? That could be useful and then to find out he works in the water facility here as well? That's an asset worth grooming. We should send someone up to be his buddy. He obviously needs some friends. Let's get him some."

"You sure?" Carl said. "He's awfully loose with his words when he drinks."

"If it turns out that's a liability, then we just don't bother but if it's something he's keeping in control or quiet… well, that's a good lever," Aeron said.

Carl nodded as he said, "And the best part, I bet she'd still be messed up if something happened to him."

Aeron laughed as he said, "Stop reading my mind."

Carl gave him a kiss as he laughed and reached over to turn out the light. They both settled down together and were soon fast asleep, dreaming of the future they planned.

Chapter End Notes

> That's right! Two chapters this week! The last one was short and this one isn't much longer so I figured why not. Not much to talk about on this one except to say, Bryce, come on. Honestly, I never really intended for Bryce to come back after his first introduction in *Finn and the Moms of Power* but dude just keeps popping up. He may have just popped up in the wrong place for the last time though. Time will tell.

Capella

Chapter Notes

> "In love, nothing exists between heart and heart" Reality by Rabia al-Basri

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As promised, as the clock hit one minute before the time she was allowed to be out of the castle, Capella began her run to teleport to Gress' room. Gress started to laugh as she appeared in the room, looking up from the work he was doing.

"What? I said a minute before," Capella said as she threw herself at her friend for a hug.

Gress caught her as he smiled and said, "I should always take you at your word."

"Of course," Capella said.

"Has it gone alright with your parents?" Gress said as they both sat down on the couch.

"It's… better," Capella said.

"I noticed a pause," Gress said.

"I’m not surprised. It was a big pause," Capella said. "Seriously though, it is better. Dad and I are getting along well. Mom and I are… getting along."

"Again with the pause," Gress said.

"Going to point out every one?" Capella responded.

"You’re avoiding my question," Gress said.

"OK, yeah, it’s still tense with Mom and I but really, we are getting along. Just gotta watch what we talk about," Capella said.

"How is that better?" Gress said.

"We’re talking aren’t we?" Capella replied.

Gress sighed as he said, "That is fair. I do have to ask you though, have you seen the data board this morning?"

"Nope," Capella said. "Last time I was on was yesterday afternoon."

"Oh, then you have not seen what is happening," Gress said, his ears folding down a little.

"What happened?" Capella said. Gress walked over and got his data pad off the desk and brought it back to Capella. Capella opened the data pad and saw a new discussion in one of the channels. It had a dozen unread messages. "When was the last time you looked at this?"

"A few minutes ago," Gress said. Capella opened it up and started scrolling back. She kept seeing references to Glimmer and herself and something called Dark Moon.

"OK, this is way too much to read right now. Can you give me a rundown?" Capella said.

"There is a rumor going around that your Mom has some secret guard called Dark Moon that she uses for political intrigue and, um… assault," Gress said.

Capella stared at Gress, her mouth wide open, before she finally managed to say, "My Mom? Queen 'The Law Is All Important?' That one?"

Gress nodded.

"I have been telling people it is absurd but others are saying that there may be some merit to it," Gress said.

"OK, I gotta log into my account," Capella said. "You mind?"

"No, go ahead," Gress replied.

Capella logged in and then cringed as she saw how many private messages were sitting waiting for her. She quickly looked through them. A few were rude but most seemed to be on the order of, "Is this *true!?"*

"I'm calling Sert," Capella said and hit the call button. It only took a moment before Sert answered.

"Just saw the data board didn't you?"

"Yes! I haven't really read anything. Gress gave me a brief catch up on what's happening," Capella said. "And before you get all… you, no, this isn't true!"

"Oh, please," Sert said. "I'm not against you on this one. Some of these people need better BS detectors. I'd buy this about one or two of the princesses, maybe, but this? I just don't see Bright Moon doing this."

"You thought I was a spy for them," Capella said.

"OK, spy is one thing," Sert said. "Hit squad? That's an entirely different ball of wax."

"So I'm not going to have a problem with this?" Capella said.

"Not from any of us that were at Poview," Sert said. "There's a few people asking for you to be kicked off the board but it's been pointed out that you had a chance to sell us all out and didn't."

"I said I was serious about this," Capella said.

"And you were right. Besides, after seeing you at Poview, for all I know you are the entirety of the Dark Moon guard and I wouldn't mind having that fighting for me," Sert said with a grin.

"OK, haha," Capella said. "That was actually really scary, thank you very much."

Sert's grin slipped as they said, "I remember."

Capella was quiet for a moment as she looked at Sert and had a thought.

"Humor is how you cope isn’t it?"

Sert nodded. "Yep. Always has been."

"I’m sorry. Tease if you need," Capella said.

"Nah, I’m OK," Sert said as they ran their hands back through their fur. "Do you want to draft a statement or something? How do you want to handle this?"

"Can we just do a big group discussion by video?" Capella said.

"You sure you want to do that? That’s a lot of people hollering at you," Sert said.

"I’ll have Gress handle crowd control if he wants to," Capella said, tilting the data pad so Sert could see Gress better as he nodded. "I’ll just have to run home and get my data pad. I didn’t think I’d need it today."

"No problem. I’ll say I’ve talked with you and put out the announcement. Figure two hours from now? Give everyone time to get on?" Sert said.

"Sure," Capella said. They waved at each other and signed off. Capella leaned her head back with a long groan. "This is ridiculous."

"Then you shouldn't have allowed your Mom to do such a thing if you did not want to deal with it," Gress said.

Capella looked at Gress with a raised eyebrow as she said, "Oh yes, my Mom, the one who freaked out and had me restricted to the castle grounds, by full approval of the Princess Council I might add, over a little disturbance. Is that the Mom you're referring to?"

"Of course," Gress said, keeping an utterly straight face. "She's truly terrifying how she offers me cake. I can see it in her eyes."

Capella gave Gress a long suffering look as she said, "I'm going to go get my data pad. You want anything from the Castle of Doom while I'm there?"

"Cake please," Gress said.

"I'll bring an assortment," Capella said. She blinked out and started her teleporting jumps to get back to her room. She popped into her room and moved the shirt that was sitting on top of her data pad before jumping into the kitchen. She saw an array of small cakes sitting out on the table the chefs stocked for random grabbing and started packing up a few in a box before

she teleported out again. After several jumps she was back in Gress' room and set the box of cakes down on his desk.

"Cakes, as requested, only mildly poisoned," Capella said. Gress gave a little noise of happiness as he opened up the box and saw several of his favorites inside. Capella dropped back onto his bed and got herself logged into the data board as Gress started daintily eating one of the cakes.

Capella took a little time to answer a few of the messages, read some of the more amusing ones to Gress, and then sat the data pad down after she'd read through some of the posts to see what people were saying about the whole Dark Moon thing.

"OK, how do I handle this?" Capella said.

"I don't see where it really needs handling as you put it," Gress said. "Just say you're there to say this is ridiculous and then answer some questions. I'll mute anyone who's being too overbearing but it's not like there's going to be a bunch of people in there. Just our server crowd."

"Which is actually fairly large," Capella said, looking at the numbers of users. Something nagged at her for a moment before she finally realized what it was. "Wasn't this server supposed to be kind of secret? Like Sert made a big deal out of letting us in."

Gress shrugged as he said, "It was but anyone who’s been in for more than a few weeks gets board privileges to add someone else. I think some people share an account as well. It’s just kind of grown."

Capella frowned as she said, "Probably a good thing I kept quiet about who’s doing the whole backing me thing. Although, it isn’t like we’re running a rebellion or something. We just have to keep it kind of quiet for a little while. After all, we make public announcements of where we’re going to show up."

Gress nodded as he said, "That is true. Thank you for the cake by the way."

"Not a problem. If you can get some hot chocolate for me later, we’re even," Capella said.

"Brother Ulip should be home soon," Gress said. "I will see if he will make some for us. Have you already used all that I brought you?"

"Oh yeah, a while back," Capella said. "Like, really quick after you gave it to me. I didn’t want to say anything about it but it really was pretty good and I want more to take home with me if it’s possible."

"Should I find the ingredients in bulk for you?" Gress said as his ears twitched in amusement.

"Just tell me what they are and I'll have them ordered in bulk," Capella said.

Gress' face got somber as he said, "I cannot do that, Cappe. As I have heard others say, that recipe is a closely held family secret that we have kept private for a long time."

Capella gave him a long-suffering look as she said, "You said you and Ulip figured out the powdered version when you gave it to me. That was what, not even two weeks ago?"

"Time is relative," Gress said.

"But your bull is infinite," Capella said with a laugh. "Fine, you may keep the recipe but yes, I would like more please."

"Deal. I will try and get you more before you leave today," Gress said. Capella clapped in glee and then looked at the data pad and sighed.

"We gotta start soon," Capella said.

"I have the room ready if you want to be the first in," Gress said.

Capella nodded and got logged in. Sert came in shortly afterwards followed by Laho and Aden, two clones from the Bright Moon group. They were talking back and forth as more and more people logged in. Capella was shocked to see multiple faces in the little boxes and realized that many of the people had logged in with friends who probably didn't normally have access to the data board. She briefly froze her camera and mike as she looked over at Gress who didn't have his camera or microphone on.

"Do you see that crowd!?" Capella said.

"It is quite the crowd. It's a pretty interesting rumor and to have you addressing it, well, that's a big deal," Gress said.

Capella groaned as she said, "I better start off saying I'm not representing the crown. Maybe put it on a crawl under my video. I do not need that fight with Mom."

Gress said, "I can make that happen if you want."

"You know, I was kind of joking but yeah, do that," Capella said. Gress tapped away for a few moments and then nodded.

"It'll start when you start talking," Gress said.

"OK. Put out a notice that I'll start talking in a minute and that you'll mute everyone. Then we can open up for questions,"

Capella said.

"You've done this before haven't you?" Gress said with a little smile as he sent out the note.

"No, but I've watched Mom and Dad do it enough," Capella said before she took a deep breath and reactivated her setup. She heard everyone's volume cut off as Gress muted everyone and she started talking, making sure to smile as she did.

"OK, so as you can see scrolling beneath my face, I'm not doing this as a representative of the crown. I'm just doing it as me, Capella, a private Etherian citizen. You may ask why I'm making a big deal about this and all I have to say is that I already had to try and fight against that perception once and ended up cooling my heels for a month over it. Not wanting to do that again," Capella said. She saw people put up laughing faces in the chat function and went on. "Alright, so I'm going to say, I just heard about this whole Dark Moon thing only a few hours ago. In other words, you actually heard about it before I did. I could go on and on but there's not much to say. It's silly.

"Let me take one example I saw just reading through over the last hour. Supposedly they leave no trace of their activities but that they have a distinct badge. How do we know if they leave no trace? Are they just these scary, ultra-competent people who are also showing off their badges at the local cafe afterwards and bragging?"

Capella delivered it as a bit of a joke and watched as some questions started to come in as well as people laughing. She nodded as she went on.

"Seriously, I don’t know what else to say about it. I got Gress here handling the chat and I’m going to answer some questions now that he sends to me and try to catch a few off the chat myself."

Capella spent the next two hours fielding questions that slowly changed from Dark Moon to just general chat as more and more people dropped out of the meeting when they realized they weren’t going to have some wild show out of the whole thing. She finally waved good-bye to everyone and logged out herself and then collapsed backwards across Gress’ bed.

"That. Was. Exhausting," Capella said. Gress set his data pad down and came over to sit down next to her.

"You did well," he replied. "Kept it light and upbeat."

"I don’t think this is going to go away though," Capella said.

"Of course not. Legends and rumors happen," Gress said. "There’s still some of us who think that Prime is still alive and hiding in a vessel waiting to emerge again. Why not something like this?"

"I should start some rumors about it myself," Capella said. "Something silly like that they send a pink cake with immaculate decoration to your doorstep as a warning."

"Why the decoration?" Gress said.

Capella looked at him as she said with a straight face, "Don’t you know that all Dark Moon guards are trained in the confectionery arts as a way to hone their deadliness. The best of them can take a person’s life simply with the right application of frosting to the top of a sugar cookie."

Gress responded back just as seriously as he said, "Be careful who you tell that to or you will find out that the desert Death by Chocolate is literal."

Capella laughed as she said, "Death by Chocolate. Violation by Vanilla. Silenced by Cinnamon. Strawberry Tart… OF DOOM!"

Gress laughed as his ears twitched in joy and Capella put her arms behind her head, staring at the ceiling as she laughed. After they both stopped laughing, Gress lay down on the bed next to her and stared at the ceiling with her.

"Cappe?"

"What’s up?"

"Can I ask you a question?"

"You know you can."

"It’s kind of… personal."

"It’s good, really. What’s up?"

"Do you want to be queen?"

Capella got a frown on her face as she rolled over and looked at Gress.

"What do you mean?"

Gress looked at her as he said, "Just… I don’t know. I’ve been thinking about this while you’ve been away. You don’t really seem to care about all the things you need to be queen. Your Mom, she worries about all the laws and rules and stuff but you don’t."

Capella shrugged.

"Grandma Angie says Mom was the same way when she was younger."

"I guess. I just don’t see you being the queen," Gress said. "I know you could do it but you seem like you wouldn’t want to."

Capella thought about it for a moment. When she thought about her future, she knew she’d be queen. She’d thought about what she would do and how she would try and be a good ruler.

"I mean, I’m the heir, it’s not really what I want, although Mom has told me before that I have a choice in the matter and I think about it sometimes, what I’ll do," Capella said. She shrugged, sighed, and went on. "I’ll worry about it when the time comes. I don’t want it to be anytime soon anyway because um, Mom has to… go away for that to happen."

"But Angella is still around," Gress said.

"Special circumstances, remember? She did go away," Capella said. "I asked Mom about that once. She told me that Grandma formally abdicated when she came back so there wouldn’t be any problems. Mom said Grandma looked relieved when she signed the document."

"I feel a little sad for you sometimes," Gress said after a pause.

"Don’t feel sad for me, buddy," Capella said, cupping his face in her hand.

"It’s not a big sadness. It’s just, you know, when my caretakers and I moved out of the Crypto Castle, when Brother Izzy helped us all get settled, I didn’t want to leave there. It was all I’d known. Brother Ulip told me though that it was so we would have a chance to do something new and so that I would have a chance to be whatever I wanted to be," Gress said. "I didn’t ever fully get that until later but that’s why I get sad for you. Because you’ve got this one thing that you’ve known you will do your whole life, and it’s not a bad thing, but I just wish you could do whatever you wanted as well."

Capella found tears creeping into her eyes as she said, "That’s so sweet but really, please, don’t worry about me. I’ve seen what my relatives have done. I know even if I become queen, I can still do lots of other things as well. Look at Aunt Frosta. She rules the Kingdom of Snows and also publishes lots of stuff. Izzy builds models. Aunt Mista and Uncle Sea Hawk travel all the time. I’ll be alright."

Gress nodded and scooted over to her to rest his head on her shoulder. Capella sighed as they both became silent again. She’d never seriously considered not taking the throne and it bothered her that Gress thought she wouldn’t want to do it. She knew she could do whatever she wanted but this was the thing she was prepared to do.

Besides, I have years, decades probably, before I ever have to worry about all of that, Capella thought and gave a little nod as

she hugged Gress a little. He hugged her back and she smiled, the happiness of the earlier moment coming back.

Chapter End Notes

> It's early for me so I don't have much to say beyond thank you for reading!

Izzy

Chapter Summary

> Izzy finds out something that amuses her, Finn decides to confront some of their past, and someone else is going to come in with a surprise.

Chapter Notes

> "So here we are / This is the end / But all that dies / Is born again / The scars will still remain / From the ashes, I will rise again" From the Ashes by In This Moment

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Wait, say that again. Aunt Glimmer has a what?" Finn said, a spoon halfway to their mouth as they and Izzy sat at breakfast together in private.

"A hit squad called the Dark Moon guard," Izzy said as she looked at the report. She'd had Pat reading her the morning updates while they both quietly ate and had almost snorted her cereal out her nose in laughter when she'd heard it. Then she'd had to explain to Finn what was so funny as she brought the report up to read it in more detail.

"Aunt Glimmer. The woman who made up an imaginary fish to make me feel safe when I was a kid?" Finn said. "The Aunt Glimmer who'd let me interrupt her no matter what she was doing to talk with her. She has a *hit squad?*"

"There’s no way. That’s why I laughed so hard," Izzy said. "I’d like to think if she did she’d come up with something less melodramatic than Dark Moon for the name."

Finn grinned as they said, "Have you met Aunt Glimmer? That’s the part I’d actually believe. My whole family is melodramatic."

"I’d say that’s just you, sweetheart, but naw, you’re right," Izzy said, bumping them in the shin with her toe.

"I’m trying to imagine it and it’s just so weird," Finn said. "I mean, the Bright Moon guards are efficient but I can’t imagine any of them doing that. Aunt Juliet would blow a gasket if she thought that was true. Dark Moon would have to run for it; she’d come for them just to protect the honor of her former guard."

Izzy said, "Well according to this, they have magical powers that keep them from being caught so it might be tough."

"Naw, Aunt Juliet would still handle it. Besides, she knows a little magic," Finn said.

"She does?" Izzy said, her eyebrows going up.

"Oh, not like Aunt Casta. She learned just enough to make things like flower illusions," Finn said. "She uses it to woo Aunt Casta."

Izzy gave a soft smile as she thought about that and said, "That is so sweet."

"That's the two of them alright," Finn said. "It's why she'd win against this Dark Moon thing. She cares."

"Finn, it's not real," Izzy said.

"Or is it?" Finn said in a spooky voice.

Izzy rolled her eyes as she said, "You know I would have heard about this before now if it was."

Finn grinned as they said, "Come on, Iz, you have to appreciate the story potential there. Ruthless warriors twisted by a tyrannical queen against the retired general who once trained their ranks before they went bad. It practically writes itself!"

"You know you just called your aunt a tyrant, right?" Izzy pointed out.

"In the story, yes," Finn said. "I'd change her look up, give it an evil queen look by changing the normal purples darker with some red in the mix. The Dark Moon guard would be in spiky armor I think. No! Dressed as regular Bright Moon guards but in the same

color scheme as the evil queen’s scheme. And maybe some spiky armor too. Mel could do something up that’d be fantastic I think."

"I can hear you writing the play in your head and I am almost tempted to commission it from you just to see the look on everyone’s face on opening night," Izzy said with a snort.

"Caladium could probably put on some really big set pieces," Finn said and then looked at Izzy with a knowing look. "Assuming he’s not too busy with his… other work."

Izzy sighed as she said, "Finn, for the last time, I’m not telling you if I have a bodyguard for you in your troupe so please stop trying to guess."

Finn laughed as they picked up their drink. "But it’s so much fun!"

Izzy shook her head with a little smile as she said, "I’m glad you’re still being very much Finn about this whole thing. Besides, Cal would be the last person I’d pick because it’s the first person somebody would suspect with all the time he spends near you."

"I’ll figure it out," Finn said with a little nod.

"Please don’t," Izzy said with another sigh. "It actually makes it harder if you’re actively poking around trying to figure out the security."

"I just meant trying to figure out who you have in my troupe," Finn said.

"You know, I never said I had *anyone* in your troupe," Izzy replied. "You assumed that."

"It seems the most reasonable for security," Finn replied.

Izzy thought of the various ways she had Finn protected and just smiled at them as she said, "I love you."

"Love you too, Iz," Finn said as they reached out to squeeze her hand. They ate quietly for a little bit longer and Finn got a little quiet as they thought about what was happening that day. Izzy had told them the night before that Blu and Snow-by were going to be at the castle that day and Finn had let her know they'd be in their theater until she said they were gone. Ever since she'd told them though, Finn had been thinking about it and wanted to say something.

"Iz?" Finn said. Izzy looked up from what she was reading on her data pad and made a little noise to indicate she was listening. "Are those two people you told me about still coming today?"

"They are," Izzy said. "I expect them both in a couple of hours."

Finn was quiet for a moment and Izzy leaned forward to take their hand. "Do I need to meet them elsewhere?"

Finn was tense as they took a deep breath and said, "No. I've thought about this and… I want to talk with both of them if I can, after your meeting. If that's OK."

"Are you sure?" Izzy said, holding their hand a little tighter. "I can feel the tension in your hand even if I couldn't see it everywhere else on you."

Finn gave a short nod as they said, "I'm sure. I just… I don't know. I want to talk with them both."

"Do you want me to tell them you're going to show up?" Izzy said.

Finn shook their head as they said, "No, because I might change my mind and honestly, I want to take them by surprise for once."

"That's fair," Izzy said. "It'll be right before lunch. We're meeting down in the beacon room."

Finn thought about the little tiny room in the bottom of the maze that was Dryl and was a little confused.

"Why there? You were meeting with Blu in your office."

"Because Snow-by can’t change his shape and I can bring him into the castle through the tunnels without being seen," Izzy said. "Other reasons as well, such as it’s quiet and out of the way. Also, I have a soft spot for that room. We can change it if you want. Brother Entrapta’s old lab would work as well."

Finn understood why she loved the room. It was the room in which Izzy had formally claimed her title as the Princess of Dryl and but more important to her, and Finn, it was where they both had started the repair of their relationship that had been badly tattered at the time.

"I’ll need a guide," Finn said. "I still haven’t figured out these tunnels after all these years."

"I don’t know why. Your theater is just as confusing backstage," Izzy said with a little teasing note in her voice.

"It is a well-oiled machine and you know it," Finn said.

"So are the tunnels," Izzy said.

"I know and that’s why I want a guide, so I don’t get caught in the machine," Finn replied.

"I'll have a bot meet you whenever you want," Izzy said.

"A bot?" Finn replied.

"My brothers are busy with their science. Besides, you live in Dryl, you're married to the head of Dryl, and it's only right you be escorted by a Dryl bot," Izzy replied.

"You just want to keep it quiet," Finn said.

"I can want many things and serve them all at once," Izzy said.

Finn snorted as they said, "Yeah, say that to Mom sometime, see what she has to say about that."

"I know her history, so, no," Izzy said.

"OK, I'll be watching for a bot," Finn said. "Any particular one?"

"You'll know it when it shows up," Izzy said with a little smile.

Several hours later, standing in the lobby of the theater looking up at the imposing bot looming over Finn, they had to admit she was right.

"Princess Finn of Dryl, will you follow me please," it said and Finn, expecting a booming voice, was quite surprised by how normal it sounded. Finn gave a few instructions to some people and then followed the bot as requested. It went down into the maze of Dryl and Finn was almost immediately lost after only a few twists and turns. After what seemed like longer than Finn remembered from the last time they'd been down, they finally were walking down the hall towards the door. Finn stopped as they looked at the closed door and wondered if this was a good idea. The bot turned and looked at them and just waited.

"Sorry, I'm good from here. You can, uh… go on about your business. Thank you," Finn said.

The bot curtsied at Finn and Finn had to grin at that as it lumbered past them. Finn went up to the door slowly, checking the time on their data pad before taking a long breath and letting it out. As they raised their hand to knock, the door opened. Izzy stepped out and shut the door behind her. She looked at Finn and her eyes were full of worry.

"You sure about this?" she said quietly as she put her arms around them.

"No, but I want to do it," Finn said.

"OK. They’re both sitting down against the back wall in chairs. I’ve got a chair for you by mine. Whenever you’re ready," Izzy said.

"Ready," Finn said and then looked Izzy in her eyes. "All the way?"

Izzy smiled as she remembered what they had both said to each other when they were roaming Etheria together looking for Finn’s biological parents and responded.

"All the way to the end and beyond, my love," Izzy said back to them.

When they entered the room, it was Snow-by that noticed first. Blu was fiddling around with some little block she had and only looked up when Snow-by sucked in a deep breath of air and sat up straighter. When she did though, she looked just as shocked as Snow-by did.

"This is a little off our normal routine," Izzy said as Finn stayed behind her and went to their chair sitting on one side of the small room. They noticed the controls to the beacon were tucked away in the wall and weren’t sure why they were noticing a detail like that as Izzy went on. "Finn recently found out that both of you work for me and they were not happy about it, understandably so I believe. They and I had agreed that I would just warn them when you would be here so they could avoid you but they decided

this morning that they wanted to talk with both of you. Finn, it’s your floor."

Finn leaned forward with their hands clenched tight as they went through the calming exercises they’d learned as a child. Because of that, several minutes of silence went past while they collected themself. Izzy leaned back in her chair, her face neutral as she took in the room. Blu and Snow-by both looked away from Finn but because the room was nothing but the few chairs and the controls in the wall, there wasn’t a lot to look at unless they just found the purple walls enthralling.

"I’m not sure what I want to say right now," Finn said, finally breaking the silence. "I’ll be honest, I thought you both were in my past, so to find out you were working for my spouse… that was a huge shock. Iz knows I was mad about it but we’ve worked through that. Snow-by, you in particular, the last time we really talked was in that little pub in Moraine."

"You still want to know why don’t you? Why I left you," Snow-by said quietly, meeting Finn’s eyes before looking away again.

"Maybe? I don’t know. I do wonder a lot what my life would have been like if you hadn’t. If you had raised me or if you had," Finn said, nodding at Blu. "In the end though, my moms did so I don’t know if any answer you give me is going to matter. It’s the past. What If? is fun for writing plays, not so much for actual lives."

Finn sat back and silence fell again. After a long uncomfortable minute, Finn said, "You know, Mother sentenced you both to

something. You remember I presume?"

They both nodded as they remembered Catra sentencing them to live a good life and make the world better.

"Are you serving the sentence?" Finn said.

"Yes," Snow-by said while Blu just nodded again.

"Is what you're doing for Izzy helping that?" Finn said. Snow-by and Blu both looked to Izzy.

"Finn knows what you do. Not details because they didn't ask but they know. You're free to talk about it if they ask," Izzy replied.

"It's why I'm here," Snow-by said, looking back at Finn again. "After I got out of Bright Moon, I went on to work at the Crab's Corner Community Center. Really working at it, doing the hard stuff, not just kind of screwing around like I used to. When Blu approached me about this, I didn't want to at first until she explained what it meant. I've been on board ever since. This is a just cause."

"Yes, it is," Finn said. "Izzy was ready to let you both go if I gave the word. She didn't tell me what you did at all until I figured something out and asked her. I want to let you both know, that's not going to happen. I don't like either one of you and I doubt

that’s going to change but you’re both doing something important, really striving, and I’m not going to damage that. I’m… I’m glad you both decided to do the right thing."

"Thank you," Blu said. Snow-by just looked down and wiped at his eyes.

"I guess that’s what I came down to find out. With that being said, I’m going to go back to what Izzy was talking about and avoiding you both when you come here. I’d say I hope you don’t take offense but I really don’t care," Finn said. "Iz, I’m going to go back to the theater. Have a bot catch up to me in the hall before I get too lost please."

Finn stood and stepped over to the door and then stopped when Snow-by spoke up.

"I… I always wanted to tell you that I love the plays you put on here," he said quickly. "I don’t come to the theater but I’ve caught the broadcasts you put on. Just… I just wanted to say that."

Finn stood there and gripped the doorknob tight before they turned a little and said, "Why would you tell me that?"

"I don’t know," Snow-by said. "I just admire the work you do and I just wanted you to know."

Finn stared at Snow-by. They wanted to hate him. Snow-by had left them on a street corner when they were five. Finn reached down inside themself, looking for the hate, looking for something to spit back at him, but nothing was there. Snow-by was changed and Finn recognized that but Finn also didn't want to deal with him. They finally answered.

"Thank you but the cast and crew deserve the praise," Finn said. "I haven’t acted in forever."

Finn stood there in silence a moment longer before sighing and going on.

"The broadcasts aren’t the same as seeing it in person. I still don’t want to see you but if you ever want to come to a show, let Izzy know. Iz, put them in one of the good boxes and let me know what night so I can arrange to have someone cover my work, please," Finn said.

Snow-by looked surprised as they said, "Thank you. You don’t have to. I’m fine catching it on screen."

"Everyone should be able to see the theater in person and I can’t seem to find it in myself to hate you or even dislike you enough to take that from you," Finn said. Then their face went hard. "Don’t abuse it."

"I won’t," Snow-by said. "And thank you again."

"Blu, do you have anything to say to me before I go?" Finn said.

She looked at them for a moment before she replied, "Not really. Just… thank you for that second chance in that living room all those years ago. You were a good kid and you grew into a good person."

"Both of those are because of my moms," Finn said. "If that's all?"

They both nodded and Finn walked out the door and shut it behind them. Snow-by was turned away from the other two in the room, composing himself, and Blu was just looking down at the floor when Izzy said, "You two need some privacy?"

"No, I'm alright," Snow-by said. "Wasn't expecting that."

"I was surprised myself when they asked but you two owe them more than you can ever repay so blindsiding you like that was a small way for you to repay that," Izzy said. "I know the Listeners' say you're not supposed to think of relationships or any kind of personal connection like that but I disagree with them on that."

"They told us that in Bright Moon when we were serving the sentences Queen Glimmer passed down," Blu said. "I don't really agree with it either, not when it comes to Finn."

"Well, I’m going to go catch up with them before they get lost," Izzy said. "Blu, figure out why in the world no one seems to know where Aeron is at the moment. Snow-by, go by Seaweed and try to keep an eye on this protest that’s coming up. Poke around, get information, the usual. You know the way out."

Izzy got up and left the room and saw Finn standing at the end of the hallway. She walked up to them as they turned around.

"You don’t have to guide me out," Finn said with a tired smile.

"Those two know a way in and out and I’m going to show you the way out myself so we can have lunch together," Izzy said as she kissed Finn on the cheek and the two started walking.

"You don’t have to disrupt your day for me," Finn said.

"I’m not. You know, when I thought about getting this position, I was partly thinking of all the cool stuff I could learn and build. You were also a part of that dream, so if I’m not taking time for you, what’s the point?" Izzy replied.

Finn smiled at her as they said, "I’m not taking too much time at the theater am I?"

"Finn, if you didn’t pour yourself into that theater, I’d think there was something wrong with you," Izzy said as she bumped them

with her hip. "And no, you’re very good at making sure your life is balanced. I worry that I don’t do the same."

"You absolutely do," Finn said. "You’ve got time carved out for us every night after all."

Izzy flinched a little as she heard them say it like that and said, "It sounds so cold that way."

"Sorry, that’s not how I meant it. I know you’re busy and I appreciate it," Finn said. They walked on, hand in hand, Izzy taking turns without consulting her AI and Finn marveling at how she seemed to know the way without any trouble. After a little while, Izzy spoke up again.

"Are you ok?"

"You mean after seeing those two?" Finn said.

"Yeah, that," Izzy said.

"I thought I wasn’t going to be but I’m doing alright," Finn said and squeezed her hand. "It helps that you’re here."

Izzy gave a little smile at Finn as they both walked on.

Later that night, Finn was sitting in their and Izzy’s living room when their data pad chimed at them. They sat down the play they’d been reading and picked it up to see Artho calling.

"Artho! How’ve you been?" Finn said.

"I’ll be happy to fill you in on that in person. I’m at the gate. Come get me so I don’t have to risk getting lost in your castle," Artho replied.

Finn hopped up and walked out to the front gate to see Artho leaned against the welcome booth, grinning and chatting with the clone on duty that night.

"Finn!" Artho shouted when they saw them and came rushing over to catch them up in a hug.

"Artho! It’s good to see you! What brings you by?" Finn said as Artho sat them back down on the ground.

"Sorry for the sudden appearance but I don’t have any Listening sessions any time soon and something has happened!" Artho said with a huge smile.

"What is it?" Finn said.

"Now, now, I want to wait until Izzy is around. You both need to hear this," Artho replied.

"I’m right here," Izzy said and Finn and Artho both jumped from her voice coming out of the ground near their feet.

"Iz! You scared the heck out of me!" Artho said with a huge grin as they both looked down at Izzy coming out of a trapdoor. "A true Princess of Dryl, coming up out of random trapdoors."

"Brother Entrapta went through the trouble of installing them, I figured I could use them," Izzy responded.

"Finn, you didn’t have to bother her. I know she’s busy. It could have waited a little bit," Artho replied.

"I didn’t," Finn said.

"Artho, I’m the Princess of Dryl and you’re in my castle. Of course I know one of my best friends is here," Izzy responded. "So what brings you here unannounced when I know for a fact you were up in the Kingdom of Snows and therefore were a pretty long way away."

"I needed to share this in person and I've already told Mom and Mom so you two are next. Honestly, it would have been Oak next but she and Chitin are out on their ship somewhere and I'll have to wait until they hit port in a few days," Artho said. "So I figured I'd tell you both next."

"You're rambling. What is it!?" Finn said excitedly.

Artho held out her hands and took one of Finn's and one of Izzy's and said, "You ready for this?"

"How could I know that if you don't tell us," Izzy said, giving Artho a raised eyebrow.

"Fair enough. OK, here we go," Artho said and took a deep breath. "I'm getting married."

Chapter End Notes

Artho for the surprise announcement! She deserves some happiness.

Adora

Chapter Summary

> Adora is at Mystacor as Castaspella tries to discover just what has happened and Angella is trying to care for Micah as best as she can.

Chapter Notes

> "I grow old ... I grow old ... / I shall wear the bottoms of my trousers rolled. / Shall I part my hair behind? / Do I dare to eat a peach? / I shall wear white flannel trousers, and walk upon the beach. / I have heard the mermaids singing, each to each. / I do not think that they will sing to me." The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock by T.S. Eliot
>
> Note: This chapter deals with a character who has a dementia/alzheimers like disease and the effects on both themself and their family. If you wish to skip this chapter, I have included a summary in the end notes.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The healers at Mystacor wore dark blue robes with a lighter blue collar and Adora had liked them the first time she'd seen them but now, after being poked and prodded by people wearing them and answering questions about her health and such, she was learning to really dislike the look of them. It didn't help that the healers didn't know why they were doing any of it, Castaspella having kept the information from them, and were a little cranky about it. Now, sitting in Castaspella and Juliet's living room, looking out a window towards the cloudscape that lapped up against the side of Mystacor, she just sighed. The healers couldn't find anything wrong with her physically and Castaspella and a handpicked team of sorcerers hadn't been able to figure out anything magically wrong either.

"I did that when I first came here," Juliet said as she walked up to Adora and sat down.

"What's that?" Adora said.

"Stare out the window and sigh a lot," Juliet replied. "Maybe not sigh but I can definitely see you're at loose ends."

"It's silly. It's not like I called on her anymore," Adora said. "I wanted the world to appreciate what I did on my own. Now she's gone though and it just feels… wrong."

"Like something that was a part of you has been ripped out, right?" Juliet said.

"Exactly like that," Adora said, nodding.

"Want some advice?" Juliet said. Adora shrugged and Juliet went on. "You're still you. Find out what that means."

"I know that," Adora said.

"I don't think you really do yet," Juliet said. "I'm not saying this to be annoying. When I got here, I'd retired from being the general of Bright Moon and I felt lost. I had the love of my life, I had a

good position, but I needed to figure out who I had become because I'd given up what had defined my life since I was a teenager. You need to think about that."

"What if the world needs She-Ra?" Adora said. "That mess at Poview is a good example."

"The one where your niece rallied the crowd to charge against those waste of spaces calling themselves a guard? That one?" Juliet said.

"OK, maybe not the best example but you never know!" Adora said.

"How long do you think you'll live?" Juliet said.

"That's morbid," Adora said.

"There's a point to it. How long?" Juliet said.

Adora shrugged. "I don't know. No one really knows how long a First One could live. I'm aging like the typical Etherian though I think."

"Then you have another thirty or forty years on the outside," Juliet replied. "What happens after that?"

"I was hoping I'd be able to pass her on," Adora said. "Help train the next generation."

"Did you make any effort to figure out how that worked?" Juliet said.

Adora was getting a bit irritated but she saw the truth and said, "No. That's what I'm here now though."

"Understandable," Juliet said. "Why worry about the future though, even if she doesn't show up again? Look who comes after. Queen Glimmer is a capable ruler and Princess Capella will be as well when the time comes. Princess Izzy is a bit close to the chest but what I've seen of Dryl I can tell she's a good ruler as well. Princess Cowrie, if she ever decides to take the throne, will definitely be an interesting ruler but a capable one as well. Princess Prickly Pear is a bit soft spoken but she's a princess of Plumeria so that's not surprising and she has insight. She'll do fine. What I'm saying is even without She-Ra, the world will still spin, and those who come after us will hold their own."

"You're saying it's selfish, what I'm feeling?" Adora said.

"No. You're used to being able to respond to anything that comes your way. It's why I told you to figure out who you are now,"

Juliet said. "Maybe what you are now is what you've been for many years. An excellent person who doesn't have to serve the whole world."

"I don't want to serve the world. I just worry about what's going on in the world now," Adora said.

"Do what you can then but from what I've seen, I'll say I'm not overly worried," Juliet said.

Adora sighed again and leaned back against the window. "I guess. I'll give it some thought."

"I know we don't talk much but I'm here for you if you have questions," Juliet said.

Adora nodded and then grinned a little as she said, "I do have to ask. Are you not worried about the future because you know the Dark Moon guard has it covered?"

Juliet shook her head as she scowled.

"I cannot believe people are buying into that. The very idea is offensive."

Adora’s grin slipped off her face as she said, "I’m sorry. I wasn’t trying to be offensive."

"I know. It’s just… a guard is supposed to guard, to protect. They’re supposed to be servants of the people and keep them safe. Not charge a square full of people or kill people like this Dark Moon guard supposedly does. If I found out it was true, I’d be right back at Bright Moon and Queen Glimmer would not be happy to see me," Juliet replied.

"I know it’s not true, I don’t see Glimmer hiding that from us, but how do you know it’s not?" Adora said.

"Because I trained my guards to think for themselves and to refuse an order. If it had been my guards at Poview that day, it never would have happened," Juliet replied. "Besides, I would have heard by now. People I trained are in high positions in the Bright Moon guard now. They would have told me."

Adora feigned a gasp as she said, "Are you spying on the Bright Moon guard for Mystacor!?"

Juliet smiled as she said, "If you consider old friends getting together every once in a while to sit around chatting and singing old songs spying then, yes."

Adora grinned back at Juliet and then looked to the door as Catra came into the room, looking like she had just been poured out of

a cup with how relaxed she appeared.

"And there’s my wife, who’s had such a hard time staying here at Mystacor," Adora said. Catra flowed onto a recamier that sat in the middle of the room and smiled at Adora.

"It is very difficult. I mean, they brushed my fur, massaged me, rubbed oil into the toe beans, lit scented candles, and played soft music. I’m surprised the Horde didn’t use that as a punishment, it's so rough," Catra said. "How did the thing go this morning, Adora?"

"It went," Adora said. "Casta is off with her little group checking into something and Juliet was talking to me about figuring out who I am."

Catra hung her head backwards off the edge of the seat and said, "She’s not wrong. You have been kind of moping about since this happened. You know I support you but you gotta get it figured out what happens if she never returns."

Adora stood up and went over to sit down beside Catra and started scratching her ears.

"I know," Adora said as Catra started purring a little. "Maybe I’ll go to the school and teach like you did."

Catra said, "I know you're joking but you might consider it. You could definitely teach surveying or cartography. I know I've enjoyed teaching in my twilight years."

Juliet raised an eyebrow as she said, "I'm sorry, did you just say you're in your twilight years?"

"Yep. I'm ancient, decrepit, in my shadow years," Catra said dramatically.

"And that would make me…?" Juliet prompted.

"One step from a corpse?" Catra said with a grin.

"I'm more than willing to go and spar with you," Juliet said.

"It's alright. We don't need to do that," Catra said as she lazily raised a hand and idly waved it at Juliet. "Wouldn't want you to hurt yourself."

"OK, you two, stop flexing at each other," Adora said, rolling her eyes as she had every time the two had started teasing each other since they'd been staying there.

"Juliet’s flexing?" Castaspella said in a hopeful voice as she came sweeping into the room.

"Do you have a spell set up for that word combination or something?" Catra said as Castaspella went over and sat down next to Juliet.

"No, I just have a connection to my darling," Castaspella did as she picked up Juliet’s hand and kissed it while Juliet looked away with a blush.

"You’re back sooner than I expected," Adora said. "Did you find something out?"

Castaspella turned to Adora with a somber look on her face as she said, "We may have and I want you to understand, you’re probably not going to like this."

Adora took a deep breath as Catra sat up and put her arms around her.

"Tell me," Adora said.

"You remember when we freed Angela, we looked into connections with runestones right?" Castaspella said. Adora nodded and she went on. "So we know that each princess can feel their runestone in a way and can channel the magic through that.

We’ve known that you can do that as well even though your runestone is no longer a physical thing. That’s what we did with the ceremony earlier. Only She-Ra should be able to really influence and feel other runestones besides the princess attached to one but we figured out how to reach out and at least see the connections. Well, see isn’t the right word but let’s just use that."

"I’m not attached to the runestone anymore am I?" Adora said as she took Catra’s hand and squeezed and was surprised when her voice broke a little.

Castaspella was shaking her head as she said, "No, we don’t think you are but that doesn’t necessarily mean anything. The runestone isn’t She-Ra, that’s just how we think you may be connected to her. It’s possible she’s still connected but in a different fashion. We want to keep trying if you’re willing to try."

"Can you at least tell where the runestone is?" Adora said.

"No," Castaspella said. "We can see the connection to a person, not the stone itself. It’s of course possible because your runestone is different from the others that’s why we can’t see the connection but I don’t want to give you false hope."

Adora sighed as she looked down. She thought she would cry when she heard this but she couldn't feel the tears. She just felt tired. She nodded before looking back up.

"I've known since that night she's gone. I guess this just confirms it," Adora said. "We're going to keep going though. I want you to find out as much as you can because I just don't think she's just gone away and if she's attached to some poor person who doesn't know what's going on, I want to be able to go and help them if I can."

Castaspella nodded as she said, "I understand. We have a lot of ideas to try and some of them will depend on the alignment of the various moons to do it. Are you OK with staying here?"

"I am. Catra, will you be OK?" Adora said.

"I've got classes starting up in a couple of weeks. I'd like to be there for them but I can get someone else to cover if you need me here," Catra said.

Adora kissed Catra's hand as she said, "No, you go and do your classes if we're still here then. I have a feeling this may take a long time."

"It may or it may not but I'm willing to keep going if you are," Castaspella said. "Besides, I was working on a sweater for both of you and it'll be easier to finish if you're here."

"Is it new sweater time already?" Adora said, a little smile creeping onto her face.

"It is," Castaspella said with a look of delight. "I have matching socks as well!"

"If haven't said it yet, thanks for this," Adora said. "And I don't just mean the socks and sweater."

"Adora, I am happy to help you. Besides, this is quite the mystery and I'm enthralled with what we're learning," Castaspella said.

Adora chuckled a little as she said, "Well, that's good at least."

"I'm going to go on now. We'll probably need you in the early morning hours if you're alright with that," Castaspella said.

"You just let me know, I'll be there," Adora replied.

Later that evening, Catra and Adora were walking through the halls towards another set of rooms. They both felt apprehensive about their meeting that evening as it was going to be with Angella. The apprehension was nothing to do with Angella, who they both considered family, but because they were afraid to hear any news of Micah. He had been declining in health and they were afraid of what might have happened since they'd last seen him. When they arrived at Angella's room, they had smiles on their faces as she answered the door though.

"Adora, Catra, it’s good to see you again," Angella said as she stepped aside. "Please, come in."

The room they walked into was decorated like Bright Moon, full of soft pastels and comfortable furniture. Micah was sitting at a table, not doing much, when they came in. He looked up, confused, and said, "Angel, we’re having visitors?"

Angella smiled at him as she said, "Yes, honey."

Micah nodded at them and said, "I’m sorry, you seem familiar. Have we met?"

Both of their hearts broke at the look on his face, of confusion and uncertainty, and Catra stepped forward with her hand out to shake as she said, "It’s been a while, King Micah. My name is Catra."

He shook her hand and said, "Catra. I believe I remember you, yes. And this is?"

"Sorry, this is my wife, Adora," Catra said and Adora could hear the pain in her voice.

"Ah yes, I remember, I remember," Micah said, nodding before turning to Angella. "When is Glimmer supposed to be back from the nanny?"

"Any time now, sweetheart," Angella said, putting her hand on his shoulder and leaning down to kiss his forehead.

Micah smiled again, full of pride, as he said, "She’s a wonderful child. A firecracker, like her mother here. I can’t wait for you to meet her."

Angella squeezed his shoulder as she said with a smile, "Have a seat, please. Dinner will be here in a few."

They sat and talked, of little things that had no consequence, as Micah sat quietly listening. Dinner arrived and Adora hopped up to help get things set out. As they did, Micah looked at Adora as she sat a plate in front of him and said, "Adora, how is Finn doing?"

Adora smiled, grateful to see that his memory seemed to be drifting back, as she said, "They’re doing great. The theater is doing well and they and Izzy are happy and healthy."

"Theater? What do you mean?" Micah said.

"Their theater in Dryl," Adora said.

"A theater in Dryl? They’re so young though. You let them go all the way out there for that? Why not go to one in Bright Moon?"

Micah said as he pushed at his plate a little.

"Finn is grown, dear," Angella said gently as she sat down next to him and set a hand on his arm.

"Oh," Micah said, the confusion settling on him again. "I'm sorry."

Adora surprised Micah as she put her arms around him in a hug.

"You don't have to be sorry," she said. "We all forget things."

Micah smiled at her as he hugged her back and dinner progressed. He didn't say much after that and finally as dinner wrapped up, Angella looked up as a healer came into the room. They kneeled down next to Micah and spoke with him for a few moments before looking back at the rest.

"Micah said he's tired. He and I are going to go and get him cleaned up and ready for bed if that's alright," the healer said with a gentle smile.

"Of course," Catra said. "Micah, it was good to see you again."

"Thank you, it was good to meet you," Micah said with a little distracted nod. "You'll have to come again when my daughter and

her friends are here. They’re great people. I think you’d like them."

Angella gave a warm smile as she leaned down to kiss him. "I’ll be sure and invite them when she’s going to be here. I’m going to talk with our guests for a little bit and then I’ll be in to see you before bed, OK?"

Micah smiled up at her, warm and loving, as he said, "Of course, Angel. I love you."

"And I love you too," Angella said and watched as the healer helped Micah towards the bedroom. Catra and Adora stood, not knowing what to say, as they watched Angella standing ramrod straight with a smile on her face until the door shut. Then she sagged into a chair and covered her face as she started to quietly cry. Catra and Adora quickly went to her side and hugged her from both ends.

"I’m sorry, I shouldn’t have let you see this," Angella said as she picked up a tissue to dab at her eyes.

"Stop it," Catra said. "You’ve seen me just as bad when we were trying to get used to raising Finn. I’m just returning the kindness."

"Angella, it’s OK. We’re here to help you out," Adora said. "You don’t have to hide this from us."

"I know," Angella said. "It's just so *hard* every day. He hasn't forgotten me yet, he's never done that, but it's going to happen the Healers say and that I should prepare myself for it. My Listener is trying to work with me to get me ready for the inevitable and I just… I don't know how I'm going to be able to do that."

"With us," Adora said as she put a hand on Angella's forearm. "You'll do it with all of us."

"You don't have to go through this alone," Catra said. "Adora and I will be here in Mystacor for a while more than likely. You don't have to just have us here for dinners. Do you want us to start dropping in? We can spend time with Micah while you step out for a bit if you want."

Angella sniffled a little as she looked at them both.

"Yes, I'd like that. As long as I'm not interrupting your vacation here," Angella said.

"It's not a vacation," Adora said. "I'm here for a research thing with Casta."

"I didn't know you knew magic," Angella said.

"It’s not about that. It’s research into She-Ra but I have plenty of free time between that," Adora said, trying to keep the sadness out of her voice. Catra jumped in then.

"And I have nothing to do with it so that means I’m just sitting around until my classes start in a few weeks. So find something for me to help you with or I’ll be helpful on my own," Catra said, trying to be lighthearted. Angella gave a sad smile at them both.

"I will. You know I still think of you both as those young women I got to know all those years ago. You’ve grown up though," Angella trailed off. She looked towards the room where Micah had gone with the healer and said in a voice both wistful and bitter, "How our minds play with us."

Chapter End Notes

These chapters with Micah are difficult to write. It's probably because I've seen someone go like this before and it's so hard to watch. I considered giving a special tag in the opening notes about this but I ultimately decided not to do so. Emotional Hurt/Comfort though seems like such a weak tag for such a thing.

OK, something funny. If you've been on Tumblr you've seen the joke running around about the whole red on white and, "Oh, wouldn't this be great for a children's hospital because of color theory!?" I originally was going to put the healers in red robes and decided to go with blue because I felt red was too close to blood. I should also mention that this was before the whole children's hospital/color theory thing went around. So when that hit, I had a good laugh. Still do.

Chapter Summary: Adora is beginning to get tired of seeing the healers at Mystacor, dressed in dark blue robes with a lighter blue collar, because of how much she has to see them

as part of the research. Casta reveals to her that while they have discovered what they think is a trace of the runestone on the sword, Adora does not appear to be attached to it any longer. Adora and Catra go to visit Angella and Micah, who are both living in Mystacor now, and Micah has progressed far enough in his disease that he no longer remembers Catra and Adora at first, although his memory slips back for a moment. After Micah goes to bed, Catra and Adora offer to help her with him as much as they can. Angella realizes just how much the two have grown up and the chapter ends with her remarking how she still thinks of them as young adults and she says, "How our minds play with us."

Capella

Chapter Summary

> Capella prepares for the next protest and worries about what it might bring.

Chapter Notes

> "Now let the night be dark for all of me. / Let the night be too dark for me to see / Into the future. Let what will be, be." Acceptance (excerpt) by Robert Frost
>
> Note: On chapters with Micah, which doesn't include this one, I'm going to put a warning so those who need to skip it can. I'll put a summary of the chapter in the End Notes on those chapters.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"And that's why I think this Dark Moon guard thing is real," a young woman said in the video Capella was watching on her data pad. "Siggie never would have just taken off, disappeared, and neither would have their partner Aerie. Both of them at the same time? There's just no way. I know they were doing stuff maybe they shouldn't have done but there's ways of handling that. So that symbol?" The young woman pointed to a drawing of several nested black crescent moons on a dark purple background that was sitting up on a board behind her. "I believe it. Watch out for it everyone. I'm putting this out there to try and knock more loose. Maybe it's endangering me but it's something I have to do."

Capella stopped the video and called up Sert.

"Finished watching it?" Sert said.

"Yeah," Capella replied.

"Still don’t think it’s real?" Sert said.

"Nope. Still don’t think it’s real. She’s putting a whole bunch of stuff together and making wild jumps," Capella said.

"I checked up on it," Sert replied. "There really was an Aerie and Siggie and there’s a little town where someone made a report that they’d gone missing. I should mention that the someone who reported it has a name that doesn’t seem to exist."

"I saw that in the video but that doesn’t mean some super-secret group made it happen. It could just be someone wanting to be anonymous," Capella said. "And before you say it, I’d say this even if it wasn’t implicating Bright Moon."

"I know. I still trust you," Sert said. "This whole thing has got a lot of people riled up and worried."

Capella sighed as she leaned her head back. "I know. I’ve seen the posts. I’ve seen the messages directed at me. I don’t know what else to say. Why is this coming out now? There’s got to be a reason."

"I haven’t a clue," Sert said. "Doesn’t matter. We got Seaweed coming down on us fast. You got your end done?"

Capella gave a thumbs up as she looked back at the screen. She’d paid the final bill from the printers out of an account that Izzy had given her access to. It was out of some bank in some small town in southern Plumeria, one of the only permanent towns in the whole kingdom. It was in some company's name that Capella had never heard of before named Flower Drone Systems.

"Invoice paid for the printing, it’ll be delivered tomorrow to Tropistar," Capella said. "Same with the other supplies. I’m going to come in tomorrow evening and help make signs."

"You sure you’re not going to cause a huge problem all over?" Sert said.

"You mean with Mom? I mean, maybe, but I told her I’m not stopping," Capella said. "I’ll have to tell her that I’m going to Seaweed but I’m not going to say why unless she pushes me and I’m not telling her until I’m about to leave."

"I didn’t mean with your Mom, I meant with you being a princess and everything but I guess it’s kind of the same thing for you," Sert replied.

Capella groaned as she said, "Don’t I know it. I’m tempted to make a giant sign that just says, ‘Not a princess today!’ It’d be

easier. Speaking of easier, are we sure we can’t apply pressure on the three running the town? I know we've talked it out before but it still seems like it’d be easier."

Sert shrugged as they said, "I actually looked into it with Laho after our last go round about this on the data board. We feel confident this is still the way. It would be easier if it was a true triumvirate style government but it’s some weird hybrid."

"Yeah, I looked into it as well. The Scorpioni that founded the place really seemed to like a kind of top down government didn't they?" Capella said.

"Well, they were fleeing the fall of their kingdom after the Horde started up there," Sert said. "Maybe they were nostalgic for the king."

"Not too nostalgic obviously since there’s three rulers and there’s still some checks on them," Capella said with a laugh.

Sert shrugged as they said, "Meh, it still means we can have our gathering and have some influence. Between that and our letter writing campaign going to the triumvirate heads, I’ve got a good feeling about this."

Capella didn’t want to say that when she thought about it, her gut clenched a little and judging by the expression on Sert’s face, they had the same feeling but neither one of them brought it up.

"I do too," Capella said. "OK, if you need anything else, let me know, otherwise I'll see you tomorrow night."

Capella signed off and took a deep breath. She'd planned and planned this whole thing with everyone. They'd argued the how and the when over and over and many people didn't want to go back out into the streets but in the end, Laho, Gress, and Aden had said they wanted to go back into the streets and because Equal was a group to help clones, they'd agreed and gone along. Now she sat there, trying to keep herself calm as she thought about the gathering again. She'd spent the previous evening with Gress and the two of them had talked a long time about being involved.

"I'm terrified, Cappe," he'd said towards the end of the conversation, his ears laid back against his head and his green pupiless eyes wide. "I don't want to do this but I feel I have to."

"We don't have to do anything," Capella said. "However, anyone else asked me to drop out of this and I'd say no. You say we're done and we're done."

"Don't put your involvement on me like that," Gress said.

"I'm sorry, that's not how I meant it to mean. It's just, if you're going to be out there, I'm going to be by your side," Capella said.

Gress gave a little distressed chirping noise that Capella had rarely heard and only when he was particularly worried as he said, "I know. It’s odd to me. I will be there partly because you will be there and you will be there partly because I will be there."

"And we’re both there because we know it’s the right thing to do," Capella said. "I’m scared too. I don’t want to go through that again but I will. At least we’ll be more aware this time."

Gress gave a little short nod of his head and the two hugged each other tight on the couch to try and still the others shaking. Capella thought about that as she sat in her room. She knew she’d have Gress with her. She knew she’d be able to do it because as she said, it was the right thing to do, but more importantly it would be because her friend would be there with her. That didn’t make what she was facing any easier. Seaweed was run by three people with a lot of power in the town and she was worried what that might mean.

She finally stood up, got changed into some gym clothes, and went down to the training gym. She figured she’d burn some energy off there and hopefully get herself feeling a little better about the whole thing. When she got down there, she saw there were twenty guard cadets being coached through training by one of the Bright Moon guard sergeants. The sergeant turned and nodded at Capella as she walked in.

"Princess Capella, it’s good to see you. Is there something you need?"

"No, Sergeant Ruth. Just need to burn off some energy," Capella responded as she started towards an exercise machine.

"We're about to start sparring if you'd like to join us," Ruth said. Capella stopped on her way to the machine and turned around with a smile.

"I believe I would, Sergeant," Capella said. She'd been trained by the Bright Moon guard and it'd been too long since she'd sparred and the offer struck her as an excellent way to work out her jitters.

"Recruits! Princess Capella will be sparring with us today! Now, you know it is part of our duties to protect the royal family and part of that protection is making sure they can protect themselves so I do not expect you to hold back! Do you understand!?" Ruth hollered at the assembled cadets.

Capella grinned at the slightly confused looks on the recruits face as they said they agreed. Capella was almost whistling as she picked up one of the training poleaxes and put on the protective equipment hanging on the wall while the cadets all looked at her as they got ready. She went to take her place at the back of the group but Ruth gestured at her. "Oh no, Princess. I need you up here please."

Capella shrugged and came up to stand beside Ruth. Ruth leaned over to whisper to her.

"I know normally we ask that you not teleport or use magic but this is an advanced class and they’re starting to feel a little cheeky," Ruth said. "Do what you can."

"Certainly, Sergeant," Capella whispered back.

Ruth nodded as the cadets finished getting arrayed and pointed at one.

"Cadet Demona, you will go first against Princess Capella," Ruth said. "Three strikes rule in effect."

Demona and Capella took their place in the middle of the floor as the rest of the cadets stepped to the side. Demona could have been on a recruiting poster for the Bright Moon guard. She was immaculate in her muted purple training clothes that looked freshly laundered and pressed even with the protective padding strapped over it all. She stood tall and had a relaxed, confident look about her. Capella was wearing a rumpled t-shirt under the protective padding and a pair of sweatpants that had been cut off at the knee. They used to say The Beautiful Imperfection Theater down both legs but now they just said, The Beautiful Imperfect where they’d been trimmed.

Capella hefted the training poleaxe a few times and grumbled to herself a little. They were made of carbon fiber, high density foam, and hard plastics that were weighted to be like the real thing the Bright Moon guard used but she’d hefted her mother’s poleaxe several times and loved how much more balanced that one was, not to mention shorter and faster. She figured she’d do just fine

with the training one though. Besides, she'd seen the Bright Moon guard training with the real thing that the training poleaxe simulated. She knew those could be pretty fast and dangerous themselves.

Demona looked at her across the small gap that separated them, raised the poleaxe in a salute, and then did a low sweeping bow. Capella did the same and was coming back up from the bow just in time to see Demona already striking straight out of her bow. Capella grinned as she simply teleported to the side and brought her poleaxe sweeping low into Demona's legs and knocked her to the ground.

"First strike!" Ruth shouted from the side and Capella grinned around her mouth guard. Demona took her mouth guard out while she still lay on the ground.

"Hang on! She teleported!"

"Never said she wasn't going to, did I? Do you think real enemies won't use magic? On Etheria? Come on, adapt, Cadet Demona! Adapt!" Ruth said back with a cheerful voice.

Demona grumbled as she put her mouth guard back in and got to her feet. The two faced off again and Capella felt herself getting calm as she relaxed into the training. Demona faked one way and then another and drove the poleaxe forward towards Capella. Capella was already sliding sideways right before the strike and as she did, she cast an illusion of herself. Nothing detailed, just a general blur of shape that made it seem like an image of herself

being smeared across a pane of glass. It was just enough to be confusing and the strike aimed a bit off center. Capella stepped forward after her sidestep and struck Demona in her chest. Demona was wearing a chest protector but Capella had been taught not to pull punches and the heel strike of her hand landed solidly and knocked Demona back onto the ground.

"Second strike!" Ruth said.

Demona didn't bother getting up. Capella could tell she was angry and was expecting the leg that came striking out towards her. Capella simply teleported back a few feet and then brought her poleaxe streaking down in an overhand strike. Demona's eyes went wide as she managed to get her weapon in place in time to block it with a loud clacking noise. Capella came back in for another strike and Demona rolled out of the way and did a backflip to get to her feet. Capella grinned as she did the same strike Demona had tried, stabbing the poleaxe forward, but her strike was successful. Demona managed to move the pole of her poleaxe and deflected it off center but it still struck her shoulder with enough force to push her back a little.

"Third strike and that's match!" Ruth shouted. Demona was panting and her face was red and angry. Capella stepped forward with an outstretched hand and for a moment she didn't think Demona was going to take it but she finally did for a short perfunctory shake.

"Cadet Demona, do you wish to say something?" Ruth said.

"No, Sergeant," Demona said stiffly.

"You know you can say whatever you're feeling. We don't hold back here. We're a corp," Ruth said.

Demona looked at Capella for a moment before she turned to Ruth. "Fine. Yes, I feel like you set me up."

Ruth nodded as she said, "I absolutely did. Princess Capella has been training in this for years now. She knows magic, she's clever, and she's quick. You didn't expect to get clobbered because you weren't thinking. I need people who think! Those who stand tall in the history of the guard were smart! Like Private Lyre when she turned the tide of the invasion from Princess Electra of the Fright Zone! Like Sergeant Hilde when she foiled the assassination attempt against Queen Seraphina! And of course, General Juliet when she led us in the desperate fight against Prime! Do you understand, Cadet Demona?"

The last sentence was said gently and Demona's face had gone from angry to contemplative.

"Yes, Sergeant, I do."

"Alright, back in line. It's time for someone else to take a shot at our Princess here if she doesn't mind."

Capella nodded and spent the rest of the afternoon sparring and laughing and chatting with the cadets and sergeant. After a while, a few started to figure out strategies for the things Capella could do and it started to get a little more even in the fights. Finally, they wrapped up and the cadets were going to get cleaned up when Ruth called Capella over for a moment.

"Earlier, when I was calling off the different people's deeds I wanted to mention you but I didn't want to make you uncomfortable. I do want to say though that what you did in Poview was brave and smart," Ruth said.

Capella looked down as she took a breath and said, "I hate that it happened. I just did what I could."

Ruth nodded as she said, "You should avoid a fight but that doesn't mean you should run from one either, especially in a situation like that. I've seen video of the incident and read the reports. You figured out the situation, knew the gazebo would be a spot that would disrupt the forward advance, and got people behind it. Would it have been better if there hadn't been a fight after the town guard stopped? Sure but it would have been better if those guards had refused the order to go in too. Like they should have. Be proud of what you had to do because we are."

Capella looked up as she said, "Thank you but I just want the world to be better for my friend."

"With you and your friends working towards it, it will be," Ruth said. "Now I have to go and get this group on to their next thing.

Thanks for sparring with us today."

"Thank you for having me," Capella said. They parted then and Capella went and hung up her gear before teleporting back to her room. The nervous energy was gone, only to be replaced by a deep contemplative feeling. She got cleaned up and left her room, heading towards the family dining room. She walked in with a smile as Glimmer looked up.

"Hey, sweetheart," she said.

"Hey, Mom," Capella said, hugging her before she sat down next to her. "Where's Dad?"

"Working late," Glimmer said. "The Intergovernmental Review Panel is in four days. He wants to be sure they're ready for it."

Capella went quiet for a moment before she said, "Uh, about that. I was going to tell you this tomorrow but… I'm going to Seaweed tomorrow evening and staying overnight. I'll be back the following evening."

Glimmer looked at her quizzically before her face got concerned.

"You're going to go for a protest aren't you?" Glimmer said.

"I am. We've been slowly letting it known and we're already putting out notices. They'll start hand billing tomorrow and I'm going to make signs tomorrow night," Capella said.

"I said I didn't want you involved in this," Glimmer said quietly.

"And I said I wouldn't stop, Mom," Capella responded back carefully.

"Why though?" Glimmer said.

"I've thought about that and it's because people need to know that if they do this, they don't get a free pass until it can get challenged in some formal way and that people will immediately stand up and say they're wrong," Capella said.

Glimmer nodded as she said, "Be careful. Let me know when it starts and as soon as you're finished. Please."

Capella's mouth dropped open.

"I… I will, Mom," Capella said as she composed herself. "Why are you suddenly alright with this?"

Glimmer looked away as she said, "I’m not. Your Dad isn’t either. However, you’ll be eighteen soon and you can make your own decisions but also… you were right when you said we should have done more."

Capella couldn’t resist as she said with a little smile, "Did that hurt to say? That I was right?"

Glimmer looked at her with a little shake of her head as she said, "Yes. It was excruciating. Seriously though, I wish you would find another way to do this but you’re not going to so I just ask that you be careful."

"I’ll let people know I’m not there as a member of the crown either. I mean, the organizers know but I’ll carry a sign or something," Capella said.

Glimmer sat for a moment and Capella began to get a little uncomfortable before Glimmer finally responded.

"I don’t care if you do or not. People will assume what they want. You don’t have the approval of the queen but you do have the approval of your mom," Glimmer said, holding her hand out to Capella.

Capella started wiping at the tears that formed in her eyes as she jumped out of her chair and grabbed Glimmer up in a hug.

"I love you, Mom."

"I love you too."

Chapter End Notes

I love that the Bright Moon guard is basically, "That's our princess!" over the whole Poview thing and view a guard that wouldn't refuse an order like the one given to the Poview guards as bad guards.

Aeron

Chapter Summary

> Aeron and Carl walk out into a place even more desolate than the Crimson Waste, to begin the next leg of their plan.

Chapter Notes

> "Between the essence / And the descent / Falls the Shadow / For Thine is the Kingdom" - The Hollow Men (excerpt) by T.S. Eliot
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Aeron and Carl walked down the dusty road towards a small collection of stone buildings in the distance. Red dirt hills with dead trees loomed over the little buildings as the two looked around. There was almost no sound except for the wind and the occasional insect noise.

"Why is every barren place on this planet miserable red dirt?" Carl mumbled as they walked.

"Be fair," Aeron said. "The Waste is red sand. This is actual dirt at least."

"I never thought I'd actually prefer the Waste over another place," Carl said as a breeze kicked up a cloud of dust in their faces. "I'm not sure how much more I got in me today."

"We'll stay here tonight," Aeron said. "That's the independent town we're looking for."

"Wait, that!?" Carl said.

"Yep. Officially admitted to the Independent Community Board two months ago," Aeron said.

"I know you said you were setting up towns but that…," Carl said as he saw people starting to peek out of the windows at them as they got closer.

"Well, the Etherian Charter doesn't really define what an independent community is, simply that it be a group of people, the majority of which wish to be recognized, that they have a governmental structure, and aren't in an area that is recognized as a kingdom or other town," Areon said with a grin and a nod towards the buildings. "That is a group of people, they have a town council of five people, including the town manager, this is not in a kingdom or other town, and they unanimously voted to be recognized. So they were."

"And you've got ten of these setup out here?" Carl said.

"That is correct, my little dumpling," Aeron said.

Carl rolled his eyes as he said, "Could you not with that?"

"But you're so cute when you get irritated with me," Aeron said. "Anyway, there were more but they didn't make a go of it. I understand. It's not easy out here."

They both looked around at the desolation surrounding them as they passed a wooden sign with Marasville carved into it with fresh paint in the cut out letters. A few people were outside looking at them a bit suspiciously as they walked up to a large water pump in what could loosely be called the town square. Aeron gave them a warm smile as he said, "Hello, I'm Aeron. Is Berryboo around?"

The people's faces changed in a heartbeat as they smiled and more came out of the little houses. One of the people, a tall willowy woman with green hair that seemed almost to glow against the reds of the landscape said, "I'm Alk, Aeron, and I'd like to say it's an honor to meet you."

Aeron stepped forward and shook her hand with a smile as he said, "Alk, it's good to meet you in person and I have to say, I'm way more honored." He raised his voice a little to address the small crowd that was forming. "I'm honored to meet all of you. What you're all doing is incredibly important to make sure we can fulfill the dream of Mara. You'll be remembered when we've rid Etheria of the blankeyes!"

People were smiling now and crowding around Aeron and Carl, shaking hands and chatting with them. Aeron asked Alk again

about Berryboo.

"I’m sorry, I didn’t answer earlier, I was so excited!" she said. "He’s off in the hills with a few people. They’re checking a few places to see if there’s anything worth mining out here. He should be back tonight."

Aeron wanted to say that he certainly hoped so since he’d sent Berryboo a message that he was coming. Instead he said, "That’s good! I’d love to see this place full of people and some mining will help. Marasville deserves to be known far and wide and I promise, when we win, it will be."

There was a little cheer and after a little while, Aeron and Carl were shown to a small one room building they could use. It was made from local stone and the inside was nicely finished, with a hard packed dirt floor that was smooth and glossy and the few furnishings were handmade but well done.

"There’s water in the tank attached to the house," Alk said. "If you didn’t know, we’re rationing the water so try and be careful please. The well doesn’t produce very much and we’re trying to make sure it’s not going to go dry."

"Not a problem," Aeron said. "And thank you for making us comfortable."

Alk left with a smile and Aeron and Carl eased their packs off. Carl sat at the table while Aeron found a large bowl and filled it with a little bit of water from a simple tap. He brought it over and the two spent a moment washing the dust off their face and hands.

"This is much nicer than I was expecting," Carl said, looking around at the inside.

"Me too," Aeron said. "They've taken pride in what they've done here. It's good to see."

Aeron pulled a data pad out of his pack and opened up a map. In the center was marked Candila and he looked carefully at a boundary line that surrounded it. Dots indicating towns were scattered around the area but only a few were within the boundary line. Carl watched Aeron as he made a few clicks, moved the map a little, and then nodded as he put the data pad to sleep and stowed it away again.

"That's a really good map," Carl remarked with a smirk.

Aeron laughed as he said, "I wonder what Ms. Adora of Bright Moon would say if she knew that her maps have been such a great help to us."

Carl chuckled as well before his face went serious.

"I’m less worried about her and more worried about… well, her," Carl said.

Aeron shuddered a little as he said, "Yeah, She-Ra is a worry. That kind of power… well, there’s a reason we work slow. Hopefully by the time she thinks to try something, it won’t matter."

Carl heard his data pad beep and got it out. He looked at an incoming message and then back to Aeron.

"It’s Tang-y," Carl said. "They want to confirm what you told them."

"Seriously? Please tell me that’s at least encrypted," Aeron said.

Carl looked and then nodded.

"That idiot right there is one reason to let Seaweed be a loss," Aeron said. "They can’t do anything right. Yes, confirm that we want them to revoke the law but not to say anything until the crowd has had their little speeches."

Carl nodded and typed away for a moment and a little smile crept onto his face as he hit send. Aeron recognized it and said, "What did you add on?"

"That they need to not contact us until we contact them again, like we said, and if they do again, well, we won’t be happy when we show up in person," Carl responded.

Aeron laughed again as he said, "Perfect!"

The two spent the afternoon relaxing and were starting to think about dinner when there was a knock at the door. Hands shifted slightly to be closer to concealed weapons as Aeron said, "Come on in."

A small man with dark pink hair and light pink skin dressed in clothes made of heavy fabric stepped in. He held a floppy hat in one hand as he said in a high, gravelly voice, "Aeron, I heard you were in town before I even got here. Someone came running out to where we were camped."

"Berryboo, I didn’t want to pull you away from your work, we could have waited until later tonight. I know I sent the message but mining is important to make this town viable," Aeron said as he got up and went over to shake the man’s hand.

"Don’t shake my hand, it’s filthy," Berryboo said. Aeron took it anyway and shook.

"Filthy with hard work. Nothing wrong with that," Aeron said as he guided Berryboo to sit down. Carl filled a glass with some water and set it in front of Berryboo who took it and drank it back.

"Thank you and it was no problem. I expected you later tonight so when I heard you were here; I just came back early. Rest of my crew understood," Berryboo said. "Are you here because of what we talked about last time?"

"You can talk freely here," Aeron said. "Yes, I'm here to settle at Candila."

Berryboo nodded as he said, "We've got stockpiles to send to you for as long as you need to be in there."

"Thank you," Aeron said. "I know that could be a hardship for you but I've got good news on that front. I've got someone leaving their job in the Kingdom of Snows and coming down here to help you get an aquaponics setup going."

Berryboo's smile was relieved as he said, "Thank Mara! We've tried to grow stuff here but nothing takes. It'll be good not to have to get our food shipped in constantly. Water will be a worry but I think we can figure something out."

"I knew that would be an issue. Whatever the Fire Princess did really messed this place up. But you've held on well. I hope you know that," Aeron said.

"We do," Berryboo said, his shoulders squaring up with pride.

Aeron leaned forward and clapped a hand on Berryboo’s shoulder as he said, "Stay and have dinner with us?"

Berryboo nodded and the three helped get something simple together out of Aeron and Carl’s packs. They chatted through dinner, Aeron and Carl telling Berryboo stories about the struggle but also humorous things they’d seen along the way. As dinner wrapped up, Aeron picked up a small pitcher and poured some water into their cups. He lifted his glass up in a toast.

"It was an honor to have dinner with you," Aeron said. "Never forget, you build the future out here, a future free of blankeyes and their insidious influence on our beloved Etheria."

"I’m proud to know you and know you’re with us," Carl said as he lifted his glass at Berryboo who looked awestruck. "Mara was right."

"Mara was right," Aeron echoed and Berryboo managed to say it himself as he raised his cup and the three drank together.

Later that night, Aeron sat in the doorway of the little house they were in and looked up at the stars as Carl worked by lamplight in the building. Meteors shot overhead as the ever present shifting aurora of the Etherian sky put on its nightly show. Aeron watched the moons rise with a little sigh.

"Seashell for your thoughts?" Carl said as he shut off the lamp and came over to stand behind Aeron.

"I love the stars, I haven't ever known a sky without them, but a while back I made the connection that they came with those… things. They remind me of what we lost," Aeron said.

Carl leaned against the door frame and looked up with him in silence for a while. As a meteor shot through the sky, leaving a glowing green trail behind it, Carl quietly said, "That was a good one."

Aeron said, "They are beautiful."

They were quiet for a little bit longer. They watched lights turn off one by one in the little houses and Carl finally knelt down and kissed the top of Aeron's head.

"I'm going to bed now. Don't stay up too late," Carl said.

"Be there soon," Aeron said. "Love you."

"Love you too," Carl said.

The next morning found them out the door as the sky was getting light. Aeron left a note on Berryboo’s door thanking him for the hospitality and telling him he’d be in touch. The walk to Candila was a long one for them, going over broken ground and weaving through what had obviously been a lush forest at one point before a firestorm had swept through and left nothing but a tangle of burned trunks across the ground. Carl kept a watch on his data pad as they walked and in late afternoon they stood on a ridgeline looking down at a mountain with a shattered ruin at the base of it.

"Welcome to your castle, Your Highness," Carl said with a grin at Aeron.

Aeron grinned back at him as he said, "Not Your Highness. Not yet. But soon, very soon."

Chapter End Notes

I thought about doing a double post this weekend and then realized that this was a short chapter and I'm seventeen chapters ahead of this one. Which at my current pace of a chapter a week would put that at a little over four months of updates before I ran out of buffer, assuming I didn't write another thing in that time. So with all that in mind, boom, double update. :)

As to the chapter, I'm stepping just a touch outside of main canon here and referencing the graphic novel that got put out called *The Legend of the Fire Princess*. It takes place sometime in season two. It's pretty good, I recommend it. If you're not interested in reading it, all you need to know for this is that long ago there was another runestone called the Spirit Ember in a place called Mount Candila that was ruled by The Fire Princess. She became angry and destroyed her

kingdom with it, tainting the land all around. And now Aeron is there. That's not going to be a problem though... right?

Also, I don't think I've said it in a while but thank you to everyone who's reading this! I'm really happy you're enjoying it!

Capella

Chapter Summary

It's time. Capella goes to Seaweed.

Chapter Notes

"Those were the days, my friend / We thought they'd never end / We'd sing and dance forever and a day / We'd live the life we choose / We'd fight and never lose / For we were young and sure to have our way" - Those Were the Days by Mary Hopkin

Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Capella stood on the outer edge of the town square of Seaweed, the day bright and hot with a breeze coming off the water and up the road, giving a little relief to the crowd starting to form in the square. The buildings surrounding the square were the typical coral construction found along the coast of Salineas and Capella watched as a Scorpioni woman came out of a building to stretch, adjust an awning, and look around at the people milling about. A few of her small children peaked out of the door behind her with curious expressions.

Gress stood beside Capella, wearing a huge hat in the bright light to shade his pale skin, and taking long deep breaths. Capella held his hand and she could feel a faint tremor as they both watched two town guards walk through the crowd. Capella was pretty sure she could tell the few people in the crowd who'd been at Poview because they all backed away from the guards as they passed and gave them a worried look. Mostly though, the crowd seemed to be locals, mostly a mix of Scorpioni, clones, and sea elfs, and they

were chatting and looking at Sert as they carried out a heavy podium and set it down.

"That's the cue," Gress said. Capella nodded and started clapping as did a few other people in the crowd. Soon the crowd was politely clapping, not really knowing why at first and then Aden walked out of the crowd with another clone. That clone walked up to the podium and Aden melted back into the crowd, as well as a clone well over six feet can, and the crowd went quiet as the clone standing at the podium looked around.

"Um… hello," he said, his voice quiet but picked up by a hidden microphone in the podium and a speaker built into the front of it broadcast it across the crowd. A few people shouted back hello at him. Capella could tell by his body language he was nervous but he went on.

"The name I chose for myself after I was no longer blinded by the Light is Avro. I live in this town," Avro said as he waved at a small clone child sitting on the shoulders of another clone. "I just… I don't want to cause problems but I just wanted to come out and say that I just want to pilot my tugboat and maybe one day be a caregiver. I want to live with the people who call me friend. I want to… after being blinded by Light for years, I've finally learned what it is to be in a real community with real friends. I don't want to lose that. Um, thank you."

Capella and Gress were getting ready to clap to get the crowd clapping again but they didn't have to because the crowd was already clapping as Avro said he didn't want to lose what he'd found. They clapped enthusiastically and Capella looked over to see the guards clapping right along with them. Gress noticed as

well and Capella heard him let out a little sigh as his shoulders relaxed.

Aden stepped up then and started talking, explaining what the goal of the day was and stressing that everyone wanted it to be peaceful and cheerful. He talked a little bit more about facing problems like this in other places and how he just wanted to live like anyone else. As he talked, Sert came up to Capella and Gress with a tight smile on their face.

"It hasn't dissolved into screaming and running yet so I'm calling it successful so far," Sert said.

"The day is still young," Gress responded with a deadpan expression.

"I like you, you get me," Sert said as they leaned up against the rough coral wall beside them.

"What about me?" Capella said.

"I won't tell you. Don't want it ending up in a report to the crown," Sert said in a teasing tone of voice. Capella rolled her eyes.

"You must be nervous if you're making that joke," Capella said.

“That’s because there’s four pairs of guards around the square,” Sert said. “Remember my cousin?”

Capella took a moment before she realized the person Sert was referring to, a mercenary who Sert had sent her to without warning to try and test Capella to see if she was a spy. Their meeting in a bar in the Crimson Waste had been bumpy.

“Yes,” Capella said dryly.

“Her and a few of her group are in the crowd,” Sert said. Both Gress and Capella turned to them in alarm as Sert raised a hand. “Calm down. They're to warn us in advance if things go bad. I brought them out of my own pocket. I couldn’t afford much.”

“Then why are you nervous?” Capella said.

“Well, the guards again but also, because of that,” Sert said as they nodded at a ship that was coming into the harbor. Capella looked and suddenly broke into a grin.

“You know who that is don’t you?” Sert said.

“Yes! It’s Cowrie’s ship!” Capella said. “Why does that bother you!?”

“Of course you know her,” Sert said with an eye roll. “It’s not just that. I got word that her parents are on board. I want to know why the rulers of Salineas are coming here.”

“I’ll go find out,” Capella said as she started towards the dock. Sert grabbed her arm.

“Wait! You can’t just go and ask them,” Sert hissed under their breath.

“Sure I can. That’s my Aunt Mista and Uncle Sea Hawk,” Capella said. “But I have to meet them at the dock or I won’t get a chance without being obvious. It’s not like they’re going to be subtle when they show up. I don’t think that whole family knows the meaning of the word.”

“Shows what you know,” Mermista said as she came around the corner in a suit and hat. Capella almost didn’t recognize her as she ran over and grabbed her in a hug. Sert looked a bit wild eyed as they tried to figure out what they were going to do.

“I’m surprised! You showed up somewhere and nothing’s on fire!” Capella said.

“OK, mini-Glimmer, very funny,” Mermista said with a sigh. “It’s not like that’s not something we do all the time.”

“Just on date nights?” Capella said and then noticed Sert starting to slowly go backwards. “Aunt Mista, gotta ask, why are you here?”

“I can’t come to a street fair or meeting or whatever this is you’re putting on?” Mermista said with an innocent look as Sert stopped a little behind Gress.

“First, how do you know I’m putting this on? Second, dressed completely out of the ordinary for you?” Capella shot back.

“Gee, I remember a fun conversation that wasn’t awkward at all in your home a little over a month ago. I think a few of us were there, you might remember. That’s one way I know you’re putting this on,” Mermista said. “Also, this suit looks good on me, thank you. I had a lovely time in it back during the war. Well, part of a lovely time.”

“OK, so you’re wearing your old clothes and you’re here on land while Cowrie is still making her way into the harbor,” Capella said. “Which tells me you swam on ahead. Did you bring Uncle Sea Hawk with you? Is he on Cowrie’s ship? Is that what’s taking so long? She’s got to keep knocking the matches out of his hand?”

“You’re ornery,” Mermista said. “That’s why you’re my favorite child that your parents have.”

Capella rolled her eyes at the old line Mermista had been saying for years.

"You're still not explaining your presence in a town that is not part of your kingdom," Capella said.

"You're in a town that's not a part of your kingdom. Why can't I do the same?" Mermista said.

"And you say I'm ornery," Capella said. "Did Mom tell you to come keep an eye on me?"

"No, she didn't. She simply mentioned to us that you would be here," Mermista said. Capella looked around, trying to see what other princesses were milling around the crowd. "It's just us, Cappe."

The crowd applauded and cheered for another speaker and after the noise subsided, Capella said, "You don't have to come keep an eye on me."

"I'm not actually. I think my presence will make the guard think twice if they want to pull a stunt like they did in Poview," Mermista said. Sert gave a tight smile and put their hand on Capella's shoulder.

"Cappe, could I talk with you for a minute?" she said.

“Sure,” Capella said. “Be right back, Aunt Mista.”

“Gress will keep me company; won’t you Gress?” Mermista replied.

“I shall certainly try,” Gress said with a nod.

Sert almost dragged Capella down a short distance before she whispered, “Tell me you didn’t do this.”

“No! I didn’t do anything of the sort!” Capella hotly whispered back. “And she’s obviously here to help! What’s the problem!?”

They both looked back towards Mermista who was looking up at Gress while she told some story. They then turned and looked at Cowrie’s ship as the sails lowered and a small boat edged up beside her to help her into the dock. When they turned back to look at Mermista, she smiled and waved at them.

“I’m inclined not to be real trusting right now,” Sert said.

“And I get that but I didn’t invite her but you have to admit, she’s right about her presence,” Capella said. “Is it so bad that she’s here?”

Sert looked back at Mermista who was leaning against the wall now as Gress told her something.

"I guess not. I mean, we want them to be on our side but it still makes me nervous," Sert said.

"You know, I was them not too long ago," Capella responded.

"And I definitely think of you as an us so I guess let's go and expand the definition of us," Sert responded with a sigh. The two walked back over to Mermista and Gress as Mermista smiled.

"Everything worked out?" Mermista said. Capella was about to say it was fine when Sert spoke up.

"Nope. I figure you're a spy and I'm going to turn you over to the guards for conspiracy against the town of Seaweed," Sert replied with a serious tone. Capella and Gress looked at them in shock as Mermista rolled her eyes.

"Kid, I'd like to see you try that one out but I like your attitude so I won't wash you down the street."

"I mean, you can certainly try," Sert said. "It's so hot out here I wouldn't mind getting my fur a little soaked."

“This isn’t hot,” Mermista said.

“You’re not wearing the equivalent of a full body fur coat,” Sert said.

Capella saw some street vendors starting to set up and said, “Listen, you two gripe at each other but hold this spot. I see a shaved ice place setting up. That’ll help with the heat. Aunt Mista, I assume coconut as always. What about you Sert?”

“Lemon if they got it,” Sert said.

“Never would have pegged you for a citrus shaved ice person,” Capella said.

“Really? I’ve only known them for a few minutes and I can already tell they’re as sour as can be,” Mermista said dryly.

“Oh, that does it, Dolphin Girl,” Sert said with a grin. “It’s on.”

Capella walked away with Gress to get into the line forming for the ice.

“Are you sure you should leave those two alone together?” Gress said, leaning down to say it quietly.

“One of two things is going to happen,” Capella said. “They’ll either become great friends or Sert’s going to get washed down the street. As long as we’re not getting washed down with them, I’m OK with either outcome.”

“I’m glad she’s here though,” Gress said, looking back to see Mermista make a bored hand waving gesture at something Sert was saying.

“I am too. The other two as well,” Capella said.

Ten minutes later and the two were walking back holding two shaved ices a piece. Mermista and Sert were laughing as they walked up.

“Here you go,” Capella said as she handed Sert their shaved ice as Sert noticed Capella’s multiple striped shaved ice.

“Is it just a Bright Moon princess thing to be that colorful?” Sert responded.

“Yes,” Mermista said. “Don’t get her sparking though. You see sparks coming off her, you know she’s ticked.”

Capella shook her head as Sert said, “I’ve seen it and trust me, I’m glad I wasn’t on the receiving end.”

“When did you… oh,” Mermista said and shut her mouth.

Gress took a bite of his strawberry flavored shaved ice as he said, “I will not stand here and let you disrespect my good friend. She is nothing but level headed.”

Capella bumped him with her shoulder as she said, “The fact you can say that with a straight face is a testament to your ability to deliver the driest of humor, my friend.”

“It is not humor, it is an observable fact,” Gress said solemnly. The other three looked at him in silence for a moment before Sert responded.

“This is the problem with dry humor. You can never tell when they’re serious,” Sert said as they pushed back the black fur around their face.

“I am serious. I understand her reputation but she is always thinking. It may appear she is only reacting sometimes, and perhaps that is the case occasionally, but I assure you, she is most certainly thinking things through and has a reason for what she does,” Gress responded.

Capella looked at her friend and smiled.

"Thanks, buddy. You really do get me."

"I would think so. I've known you over half your life now," Gress said.

"That's a weird way to say since we were kids but yeah, you're right," Capella responded as she stepped up and gave him a hug.

"Weird? Nothing I say is weird," Gress responded as he hugged her back.

Mermista grinned as she replied, "You're absolutely right. You're a fount of normal."

"And from what I understand you're a fount in the original sense of the word," Gress said back.

"Did… did you just sass me!?" Mermista said with a delighted smile on her face.

“Of course not. That would be disrespectful,” Gress said, deadpan, before taking another nibble on his shaved ice.

“I like you,” Mermista said and they all jumped as a blast split the air from the dock. Capella, Gress, and Sert all spun around to look down the road to the dock as Mermista sighed.

“That’s Cowrie announcing she’s docked,” she said. “One of her new crew used to work at Finn’s theater making pyro mixes. They figured out how to make a nice big boom with it and she’s been using it to announce she’s docking ever since.”

The rest of the crowd was looking but after nothing else happened everyone went back to talking as the speeches continued. A little while after they finished their shaved ice, Sea Hawk and Cowrie came walking up the road and joining them by the wall. Sea Hawk was swept off his feet by Mermista as she grabbed him and dipped him back for a quick kiss before putting him back on his feet.

“You saw nothing,” she said with a stern look at the rest.

“Mom, it’s been how many years now that you two have been together? Everyone gets that you two are stupid for each other,” Cowrie said with a long sigh as she adjusted the long sleeveless jacket she had on. “I mean, come on. I exist because of it. It’s obvious.”

“Don’t harangue your mother, dear,” Sea Hawk said with a smile as he smoothed out his moustache.

“Dad, I just had to spend the last three hours keeping you away from my wheel. If anyone is going to get a harangue as you put it, it’s going to be you,” she responded.

“You needed to bring it over just a little!” Sea Hawk responded. “It would have run so much smoother!”

“May I remind you that you’re the one who was cowering on the deck of that same ship when I made The Gale Breath Gauntlet run in record distance?” Cowrie responded. “I think I can handle my ship.”

Sea Hawk grinned as he remembered her standing firm on the ship as she shot through the narrowest part of the run called the Traitor’s Gate, a spot normally too shallow but timed just perfectly with an unusually high tide, and said, “You certainly can. That doesn’t mean you shouldn’t have…”

Cowrie rolled her eyes as she said, “Just don’t finish that, Dad. I’m getting something cold. You all need anything?”

Everyone shook their heads as Cowrie walked out into the crowd. Capella couldn’t help but notice she was armed with a saber as she crossed over to a drink stand that was set up. The crowd gave a roar as one of the speakers called on the triumvirate heads to

come out and speak to the crowd and Capella was forcibly reminded that she was not there for a little outing in the warmth with her friends and family.

"Uncle Sea Hawk, I asked Aunt Mista this but why are you here?" Capella said.

"The adventure of it all! A fight for what's right! Why else would we be here?" Sea Hawk responded.

"Just wondering," Capella responded as another speaker stepped up and started off with a call for the triumvirate heads to speak and the crowd once again responded with a roar. Capella and Gress unconsciously moved a little closer to each other as Sert looked around quickly. Mermista noticed the movement and leaned in a little.

"Don't worry, we got this," she said with a nod.

Sert looked at her.

"If you're here then I gotta ask that you listen to what I say," Sert said.

"Why?" Mermista said.

“Because she’s calling the shots today, Aunt Mista,” Capella said as she leaned in.

“I figured you’d be in charge,” Mermista said.

“No, but I let her think that,” Sert said as the crowd cheered. Capella could hear the uncomfortable edge to the joke and just nodded.

“OK, your command then but if something happens, I’m responding if you take too long,” Mermista said.

“Please don’t flood the town out, Aunt Mista,” Capella said.

Sea Hawk grinned as Mermista said, “Oh, no worries there.”

Capella then remembered the stories she’d heard about flaming ships and thought she should change her request when the crowd cheered and the speaker stepped down. Cowrie came back with a huge paper cup full of juice and ice with a big paper umbrella sticking out the top.

“You all look way too tense,” Cowrie said as she leaned against the wall and took a long sip from her cup. “I’ve got it covered.”

“How can you possibly have it covered all by yourself?” Capella responded.

“Oh, dear cousin, you’ve sailed on my ship and you ask how I can have it covered?” Cowrie said with a grin. Capella didn’t know what she was talking about for a moment when she suddenly thought of Cowrie’s crew.

“Do you mean…?” Capella said and then gave a little nod towards the ship.

“See the great part is that I wouldn’t even have to tell them to jump in the fray. They’d do it just for the fun of it,” Cowrie said as she took another drink. Sert was back to looking out of their depth.

“Not if Sert doesn’t give the word. They’re in charge today for any fracas,” Mermista said as she clapped Sert on the shoulder. Cowrie touched a knuckle to her eyebrow in salute and gave a little nod.

“I’ll look to you then,” Cowrie said. “Seriously though, it doesn’t have the air of a problem.”

“I hope not,” Sert said, nervously looking about.

A few hours went past and the six were sitting around chatting. Sert and Mermista were good naturedly bickering with each other,

Sea Hawk was chatting with people as they came by and Cowrie, Gress, and Capella talked and played little word games. Then Capella noticed a person dressed in a long robe with a veil and headscarf on headed towards them.

"Gress," Capella said, lowering her voice and leaning in. "Is that Coalfire?"

Gress looked at the woman as she made her way around a little crowd of people and went up to Sert.

"It is," Gress said and he and Capella immediately went over to where she was talking with Sert, Cowrie coming along with an intrigued look. The woman, Sert's cousin and head of a small band of mercenaries, was talking with Sert.

"It's not like Poview. They're not armed for a fight like that," Coalfire was saying. "But the triumvirate heads are definitely standing there with what's probably the rest of the town guard that's not already out here in the square."

"What do you advise?" Capella said. Coalfire looked at her and back at Sert and Sert gave a little nod.

"Don't pull any illusory daggers would be my first piece of advice," Coalfire said and Capella could almost hear the smile in her voice.

“You already told me that one when we first met. Seriously though, what do you think we should do?” Capella said.

“Honestly? Nothing. You’re not arrayed for a fight and you shouldn’t be with what you’re trying to do,” Coalfire said. “If they give any resistance, get out.”

Cowrie laughed as she said, “Yeah, I’m not running.”

Coalfire looked at her and said, “Princess Cowrie, I would highly recommend that you and your parents not get involved with this if it turns into a fight. There’s already a lot of talk about overreach by the princesses and it messes with the Charter. Observe by all means but do not interfere.”

“Forget that,” Mermista said in a scoffing voice. “I don’t know who you are but I won’t stand aside.”

“I agree. I will not see innocents suffer!” Sea Hawk said as well.

“That’s my advice,” Coalfire said with a shrug. “Your choice.”

“Thank you,” Sert said. “What are you going to do?”

“I think our usefulness is at an end here and frankly, I’ve already done more than you paid for,” Coalfire said. “I’ve already pulled out my group and I’m leaving now as well.”

“Coalfire, stay and help and I’ll pay you,” Capella said, wondering if there was enough money in the Flower Drone Systems account to cover something like that or if Izzy would be upset.

Coalfire looked at her with a raised eyebrow.

“I reject your offer but that doesn’t mean we can’t do business in the future. You know where to find me if you need me. Good luck.”

Coalfire turned and walked back into the crowd as Capella huffed.

“What’re your orders?” Mermista said to Sert. Sert looked at her and realized she was serious and Capella saw Sert try to hide their fear and uncertainty.

“I’m taking her advice. We do nothing for now,” Sert said and looked out at the crowd and then back at Gress and Capella. “I think we need to warn the rest though.”

“You take this side, I’ll go up the center, and Gress you take the other side. Warn any of our people we see,” Capella said, thinking

about how if something happened, Gress would be safer on the edges where he could run.

"I'm coming with you," Cowrie said as she stepped forward.

"Go with Gress," Capella immediately said. Sert looked at Capella and Capella could almost read her thoughts. "It's not the time for secrecy. Aunt Mista, Uncle Sea Hawk, cover our rear."

Mermista snapped a sarcastic salute at her and Cowrie nodded and they took off into the crowd. Capella quickly whispered to a few people what was going on as she went along and then she heard the crowd go quiet. She remembered that quiet from Poview and she felt her whole stomach clench. It was the quiet of a crowd noticing something and not quite sure what to make of it. Then she heard the shout echo out over the crowd.

"Make way for the heads of the Seaweed Triumvirate! Make way! They will now address the matter at hand!"

Capella couldn't see but she didn't hear screaming and the voice, while loud and commanding, didn't seem to have a tone of threat to it. She teleported back to Mermista and Sea Hawk who were both leaning against the wall with Mermista's arm over Sea Hawk's shoulder.

"Deep breath, mini-Glim," Mermista said as she saw Capella appear.

“Where’s Gress?” she said, looking around.

“Heading up the side with Cowrie as you said,” Mermista said and Capella started making her way through the crowd. It wasn’t long before she saw Gress above the crowd and she teleported over beside him. The people around Gress jumped a little and Capella noticed that Gress was talking with Laho and Aden. She also couldn’t help but notice that Cowrie had her hand on her saber.

“Do you want to go?” Capella said, cutting into their conversation.

“Brother Laho and myself are staying,” Aden replied. “We fled last time and have felt shame that we did not stay and help.”

“If Brother Laho and Brother Aden are not leaving, neither am I,” Gress said. Capella didn’t say anything but laced her hand through his and held tight as she heard a voice come over the podium’s speaker. Capella could just see the person at the podium, a sturdy Scorpioni in a dress with a little sash across it.

“That’s Tang-y,” Laho said. “They’re one of the triumvirate.”

“Citizens and those who are visitors to our fine town, I welcome you and thank you for a chance to hear your voice,” Tang-y said in a friendly tone. “When this town was founded by our ancestors

fleeing the devastation of the Fright Zone and the fall of the Last King, we knew that we wanted a strong government as we once had under the Scorpioni Kings. We have that. We on the triumvirate work for the good of our people and we make decisions that are important, that in our wisdom we know are the right ones, even if they're unpopular. That is why we are structured as we are, so we can make those unpopular decisions for the good of all."

"I don't like where this is going," Cowrie muttered as she inched the saber out a little. The crowd started muttering as Tang-y continued on about the responsibility and honor of being a member of the triumvirate and Capella could almost feel herself vibrating. Laho and Aden both put an arm around the other and Capella couldn't help but notice the scars from where ports had been removed from them after the fall of Prime.

"When it starts, Gress, I'm pulling you to the back by Aunt Mista," Capella whispered.

"No," Gress whispered back. "Take Brother Laho and Brother Aden first. I'll stay by Cowrie."

"You all should take care of yourself," Aden responded. "We will hold for you."

"It's because of all this that we rarely reverse a decision but I'm here to say today that we have met, swayed by the impassioned fervor of our subjects, to discuss the law you have argued so

fervently for," Tang-y said. The little group suddenly went silent and looked towards the podium.

"Do you think…?" Laho said.

"It can't be," Capella said, a little flutter of hope coming down into her world.

"We have heard you and we have come to a decision," Tang-y said and held up two scrolls, sealed with wax. She held one out for the crowd to see. "This one is the law as it stands now." She closed her claw and snipped it in half and utter silence fell over the crowd as she dropped the two halves to the ground and then held up the other one high over her head. "This is the one repealing it. You have been heard. It is no more."

The silence lasted for a moment longer and then the crowd exploded into cheers and hands waving in the air.

"We did it!" Laho shouted as the five of them grabbed each other in a hug and jumped up and down in glee. "We did it!"

"We did!" Capella shouted. "I can't believe it!"

Suddenly a huge ball of water shot up over the crowd and then burst, showering the crowd in a fine, cooling mist, rainbows

streaking through it as the light caught it and the crowd laughed and shouted and danced.

Several hours later, the evening light was stretching up the street as Capella and Gress sat at a little outdoor cafe with Laho and Aden. Mermista and Sea Hawk lounged at a table next to them with Cowrie and Sert. Crowds still roamed the street in a festive mood as Capella sighed and took a sip of her fizzy drink.

“Why the sigh?” Gress asked as he fiddled with an empty plate in front of him.

“Just tired,” Capella said.

“You feel like you wished it’d gone bad like you hoped,” Cowrie said.

“No!” Capella said. “I just… I was all keyed up and now I feel a bit…”

“Drifting?” Mermista said.

Capella thought for a moment and then nodded.

Sert said, “I know what you mean but don’t worry, mini-Glim, there’s always the next fight.”

“First, only Aunt Mista gets to call me that. Second, I sincerely hope not,” Capella responded. “I hope they’re all like this or even that it doesn’t get that far. That they just see what’s right and do it.”

Sea Hawk reached over and patted Capella on the shoulder affectionately as he said, “You were all brave and I’m proud to have been by your side today.”

“Thank you,” Capella said with a little smile. Laho, who hadn’t spoken in some time as he sat and thought, looked up.

“It’s not over,” he said simply.

“Brother?” Gress said hesitantly.

“It’s not over,” Laho repeated again. “Those who hate us are blinded. I do not know how to remove the light from their eyes so that they may see again. Maybe… maybe if I think harder, it will come to me.”

He looked back down again and Aden put an arm around his shoulder and hugged. Laho leaned into him as Capella watched his ears fold back a little in resignation. The group split up not

long after, each going their separate ways and after dropping Gress back at his home, she made the teleporting jumps to get back home. It was late but she found Glimmer and Bow waiting in her room when she arrived.

"I'm sorry. I didn't let you know I was running late," Capella said as she flopped down onto a couch.

"We're not mad," Bow said. "We heard the news from Seaweed."

"We're proud of you," Glimmer said with a smile. Capella looked up at them both, emotions rolling inside of her.

"It wasn't just me. There were so many who helped," Capella said as she fought tears and a smile as Glimmer and Bow came over to sit down on either side of her.

"But they aren't our daughter," Glimmer said as she hugged her.

"And you're home safe," Bow said as he hugged them both.

Chapter End Notes

> My wife asked me if I was going to use the lyrics to *One Day More* from *Les Mis* as a starting quote for one of these protest chapters. I jokingly said no but I might use *Empty Chairs at Empty Tables* for the chapter after one of them and she was not amused with me.

Anyway, new chapter and thank you for reading!

Finn

Chapter Summary

> It's birthday time for Capella and Finn and Izzy are at Catra and Adora's house for the big party.

Chapter Notes

> "Monday you can fall apart / Tuesday Wednesday break my heart / Thursday doesn't even start / It's Friday I'm in love" Friday I'm In Love by The Cure
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Finn sat on the bed in their old room at their moms' house. The room hadn't changed much in the years since they'd left home and moved to Dryl. Part of the room was still taken up by the little hidey hole fort with the tunnel to their bed that Finn hadn't tried to get into in years. The dresser was mostly empty except for a few pieces of clothes that Finn kept there for the occasional surprise overnight visit. The desk was also tidier than Finn had ever kept it but other than that it was still the same room. It was a place of comfort and happy memories and Finn felt a little purr escape their throat as they looked around. They could hear the huge crowd outside as Izzy came out of the bathroom adjusting the long sleeves on her long sleeved thermal shirt she was wearing with her overalls.

"You think Capella will appreciate the gift we got her?" Finn said as Izzy sat down at Finn's old desk.

“Yes, just like the last three times you asked this afternoon,” Izzy said with a little smile. “I thought I was supposed to be the worrying one.”

“Well, birthdays were always a thing for me,” Finn said, recalling the first one they could remember. They’re moms hadn’t known their birthday so they’d picked a day and celebrated it as their birthday. It wasn’t until they found Elliepurr, their biological mother, years later that they’d found out their actual birthday and had been surprised at how close it had been to the day Catra and Adora had chosen, off by only a few weeks.

Finn remembered their birthdays because while their moms had done their best every year to make sure it was a big event for Finn, and Finn did the same for their friends and family, it was also the time of year that Finn would reflect back on where they’d come from. Finn realized at that moment that was probably why their moms had thrown so much effort into the events when Finn was young, to keep Finn from feeling sad.

“I know,” Izzy said with a little smile. “And yes, I think she’ll like it. At least we’ll get to see her; unlike the official party.”

That had been a week before at Bright Moon castle and had involved ceremony, pomp, and representatives from all over Etheria. Finn had almost skipped out on that one but Izzy had insisted they come along and so they’d attended in their best suit, unlike tonight when they were in shorts, sandals, and a shirt covered in a colorful flower print they’d snatched out of Adora’s closet.

“Well, no reason to sit around wondering. Let’s get out there and mingle,” Finn said with a grin. Izzy gave a deep sigh and nodded, following them out the door and down the hall to the crowded living room.

“Not feeling the mingle?” Finn said as they went down the hall.

“No. Just thinking about my other stuff,” Izzy responded, using the phrase she used to talk about her intelligence work with Finn. She’d told Finn that Aeron had dropped completely out of sight about the same time as the Seaweed protest and hadn’t been seen since. It’d been weeks, starting to go to months, and she was getting more and more worried. Finn placed their hand on her shoulder as they walked into the living room filled with people.

“I understand. Try not to worry too much,” Finn said and leaned forward to kiss her. “You gotta relax sometime.”

“I know. Astile keeps telling me so,” Izzy said with a thin lipped smile referring to her Listener.

“And your spouse is as well,” Finn said with a smile. “I’m going to go to our spot back in the yard and your usual fizzy drink will be waiting for you.”

“OK. I’m just going to say hello to Glimmer,” Izzy said. “I’ll see you in a few.”

Finn gave her a hug and made their way through the kitchen and out into the backyard. They were happy to see Oak and Chitin sitting out on the lawn holding hands. The backyard was filled with people Finn recognized as Adora's work friends, Catra's students and work friends, various family members, and a few people Finn was pretty sure they'd never seen before. They waved and greeted people as they made their way back to the lawn chairs at the back of the main backyard where it went down to the firepit and then the more overgrown and wilder section of the rest of the yard, stopping only to grab some fizzy drinks from tubs of ice.

The Team, as Oak had named the group of four who'd gone out on the big adventure to discover Finn's biological parents, had claimed that space for themselves years before during the roughly monthly parties that Adora and Catra held. This was the first one they'd had in a few months now and Finn had made a note to ask their moms why it'd taken so long. For now though they were looking at the six chairs set up as they sat down.

"Is Artho finally going to show up with her mysterious partner?" Finn said, nodding at the extra chair.

"She didn't say but I figured she'll get the hint if she shows up alone and the empty chair is just sitting there, accusing," Oak said with a nod.

Chitin shook her head as she said, "You need to just tell her to bring them sometime or at least let us talk to them."

“You haven’t talked to them yet either?” Finn said.

“No! She made the announcement and then kept it completely quiet after that! I don’t think Mom or Mom knows either,” Oak said. “I’m supposed to be the dramatic one!”

“Maybe she’s making them up,” Finn said as they opened the bottle and took a sip.

“Naw, there’s no way,” Oak said. “I would roast her for the rest of her life if she did something like that.”

Chitin nodded as she said, “I try and stay out of their little arguments but I’ll be honest, I’ll be right in there with her if that happens.”

“I like how you would frame the vile things my sister does to me as little arguments,” Oak said with a mock frown.

“At your last family dinner, you two argued over who got a certain roll. She smacked you in the head with her tail and you dumped a cup of water on her,” Chitin responded.

Finn was laughing as they said, “That sounds like them.”

“Then you ate the roll,” Oak said. “Betraying me I might add but I’ve forgiven you.”

“Seemed the best way to end it,” Chitin said with a grin. “It was a good roll too.”

“Finn, you see what she does to me?” Oak said as she leaned into Chitin’s shoulder with a smile.

“I certainly do,” Finn said and held up Izzy’s fizzy drink for her as she came and sat down next to Finn. “Hey, hon. Did the inter-kingdom summit go well with Aunt Glimmer?”

Izzy opened up her drink as she said, “It wasn’t business. Your moms made that real clear that we’re not allowed to do that at their parties. I was telling her about the gift and making sure we didn’t need to deploy the backup.”

“I told you, she’d be fine with it,” Finn said.

“Then why do you keep fretting if Cappe is going to like it?” Izzy said.

“That’s a whole other worry loop,” Finn replied.

“What did you get her?” Oak said.

“It’s a surprise, thank you very much,” Izzy responded. “You’ll find out when she opens it.”

“You think I’m going to go and tell her?” Oak said, putting a hand to her chest. “You wound me.”

“Operational security,” Izzy said. “You don’t need to know.”

“Come on, we’re all princesses here,” Oak said.

“Speak for yourself,” Chitin said. “I’m quite happy being not a princess over here.”

“You know, if we ever get married…,” Oak started to say before Chitin cut her off with a look.

“I do not have to take a title and we’re not having that discussion again,” Chitin said, serious at first but putting a little smile at the end to keep it light.

“Having been around princesses for years now, I’ve seen how they gossip and chat,” Izzy said. “If anything, I feel like it would just magically seep from one to the other if I said anything. Enough about that, how’s the ship coming along?”

“Whelp, Izzy changes the subject. We must be close to something. Are you the mysterious operator behind Dark Moon? Is that why you spoke with Glimmer? You needed to coordinate something?” Oak said, leaning forward as she tried to create an air of conspiracy and only managed to create an air of a raised eyebrow.

Finn laughed at the long suffering expression on Izzy’s face as they said, “Come on now. You think Izzy would be running that and not let me design the outfits? Have you seen those supposed leaked videos? Do you think I’d ever let my spouse’s goons be that badly dressed?”

Chitin grinned as she said, “I don’t know, those bulky jackets with the high collars looked pretty intimidating.”

Izzy, who’d been training in how to fight since she had become princess with several different highly proficient people, had said, “Yeah, I’m sure restricting your peripheral vision is just a fabulous way to handle it. Seriously, just tell me about the boat.”

Chitin and Oak both stopped smiling as they looked at her.

“I know you did that on purpose,” Oak said.

“Did what on purpose?” Izzy said, her face still and unreadable as Finn’s grin got wider.

“It’s not a boat,” Chitin said.

“Oh, you know, there’s no difference really, I’m sure,” Izzy said as she made a little shooing gesture with her hand.

“Iz, I’ve seen you talk for half an hour on the difference between two identical looking rocks. I know for a fact you know the difference,” Oak said.

“Dryl does a lot of mining,” Izzy said with a shrug.

“You know, I remember when you weren’t so feisty,” Oak said. “Finn has been a bad influence on you.”

“Don’t put that on me,” Finn said. “This has always been there. She’s just found a way of delightfully expressing it.”

“Fine, I’ll change the subject if you never refer to our ship as a boat ever again,” Oak said.

“I make no promises,” Izzy replied. “I might need to use that again but for now, yes, I will admit to knowing the difference between a ship and a boat and you have a ship.”

The four chatted and after a while, Finn heard voices raised in greeting. They looked up to see Capella and her friend Gress coming into the backyard. Several other clones followed them, two that Finn recognized as Laho and Aden, and a person covered in black fur that Finn was pretty sure they’d heard referred to as Sert.

“I was wondering when she’d show up,” Chitin said.

“I think I heard Mom say she was teleporting around getting some of her friends,” Oak replied and then nodded as Oak’s younger sister came out at the end of the group. “Yeah, there’s P-Pear with her.”

Capella walked off to the side of the house with her group and sat down in a big circle. Finn waved at her when her gaze went over them and she waved back.

“We should go and wish her a happy birthday in a few,” Finn said to Izzy.

"Uh… first we need to find out why Artho is carrying a kid," Izzy said, not looking at Capella but looking towards the back door of the house.

Finn snapped around at the same time they heard Oak draw in a huge intake of breath. Artho was slowly making her way towards the group while her two Moms followed her out peppering her with questions. A short stocky woman dressed too hot for the weather stood beside her with her hand in Artho's and a hesitant, nervous smile on her face. Finn could understand why as Perfuma had already crowned her and the child with a flower crown and had her arm around the woman.

"I'm going to go save my sister," Oak said.

"I'll get another chair," Izzy responded as they all stood up.

Finn watched as Oak went up and hugged her sister and talked with the little group for a few minutes. Izzy came back with a chair and put it next to the two empty ones. Finally, Oak walked over with her arm around Artho and went over to the group.

"Everyone, I'd like to…," Oak started to say and then jumped back as Artho's tail bopped her on the back.

"I'll introduce them, thank you very much," Artho said.

“You better, as mysterious as you’ve been,” Finn said.

“Finn, give me two seconds, please,” Artho said. Finn made a hurry it up gesture with their hand while Artho shook her head, all smiles. “Everyone, this is my fiance Skua and her daughter Puffin.” Artho started pointing at each person. “Honey, this is Izzy, her spouse Finn, you just met Oak of course, and this is her partner Chitin.”

The four said hello as they were introduced and Finn waved at Puffin, who was starting to burrow her head into Artho’s shoulder as she got shy. Artho whispered something to her and she looked back out again before burrowing her head back into Artho’s shoulder.

Skua spoke up, her voice low and quiet. “She’s not used to being around so many people.”

“It’s alright,” Finn said. “Can I talk to her?”

“Sure,” Skua said.

Finn walked up to the side of Artho, where they could see a single eye that Puffin had peeking out. Finn could remember what it was like to be so overwhelmed by so many people and not knowing what was going to happen and figured they knew what to offer.

“Hey, Puffin. My name’s Finn,” Finn said quietly. “If you need a quiet place to go, just tell any of us and I have a hiding place in the house that no one will bother you in, ok?”

Puffin looked at them and Finn began to wonder if she was going to respond when she made a little hand gesture that Finn recognized. Listeners taught it to people who might become non-verbal as a way to communicate that they understood and Finn smiled and said, “I understand. Hold up one finger if you need to go right now and two if you’re ok for now.”

Puffin seemed to think for a moment and then help up two fingers before covering her face with her hand.

“She says she’s good to go for now,” Finn said as they looked at the rest. “But if she lets you know, take her to my room. She can use my old hidey hole.”

Skua looked at Finn with a bit of relief on her face as she said, “Thank you.”

“If Artho hasn’t told you, I used to be really quiet and scared by large groups when I was her age. My moms built me a place in my room where I could hide out,” Finn said. “If she needs it, she’s more than welcome.”

“Of course now they’ll talk to a brick wall and run one of the most prestigious theaters on Etheria,” Oak said with a laugh.

"I'd say most prestigious in Dryl but thank you," Finn said as they all began to sit down.

"OK, so you're going to get sick of answering this tonight I imagine but how did you meet my sister and why *her* of all people? You seem a woman of discerning taste after all and well," Oak said as she made a gesture towards her sister.

"Very funny," Artho said with a roll of her eyes.

"We met when she was in the Kingdom of Snows," Skua said. "I was meeting with a Listener she knew and we ran into each other a few times. We got to talking and hung out a lot and Puffin really liked her and after a while it just…"

Skua gave a smile and looked at Artho. Finn watched as Artho gave the same smile back, full of love, and felt their heart just melt. Izzy reached out and squeezed Finn's hand as Chitin put an arm around Oak.

"I get it," Finn said with a smile. Puffin kept looking out towards the kids running around the yard playing and Artho whispered something to her. She looked again and nodded and Artho set her down on the ground as she looked at Skua. She nodded as well and Puffin went over to a group of kids. They all gathered around her and started talking to her.

“It’ll be alright,” Finn said as they watched Skua’s eyes track Puffin.

Skua turned back to Finn as she said, “I worry about her. We live in a very small town and honestly, she hardly sees people. I work a lot at the aquaponics facility there and I… well, I worry I’m not giving her the best.”

Izzy said, “She seems healthy and she seems happy. Shy isn’t anything she needs to be ashamed of and neither do you.”

“Thank you. I’m worried because I accepted another job somewhere else but it’s a tiny village again,” Skua said.

“That’s why we’re here,” Artho said. “I’m going there with her to be the Listener. I’m trying to get a few of the Listeners in Bright Moon to come along and form a group with me. Otherwise, it’s much more difficult.”

“That’s why you’re here?” Oak said. “Not so we can meet your lovely other half?”

“You’ve already met her. So that part’s over,” Artho said.

“Be nice to your sister,” Skua said with a smile as she patted Artho’s hand.

“Yeah, be nice to me,” Oak said.

“The same goes for you,” Skua responded.

“Oh, you’re going to try and keep peace between them,” Chitin said. “Best of luck.”

Skua said, “Oh, she’s already in trouble when I found out she hadn’t told anyone about me. I have leverage.”

“That’s a good point, Artho,” Finn said. “Why did you keep her quiet for so long?”

“Maybe because I didn’t need the entire Princess Alliance showing up?” Artho said. “Just wanted a little peace and quiet?”

“Are you ashamed of me?” Skua said with a little faked lip quiver.

“Never,” Artho said, leaning over and giving her a kiss.

“She makes it sound like it’s a huge ordeal,” Finn said. “We would have only arrived in small packs. Maybe even bearing gifts.”

“I was being courteous to Aunt Glimmer as well,” Artho said. “I know she would have had to teleport everyone out.”

“We very easily could have got Cappe to bring us,” Izzy said. “Maybe not as many at once but she’s got the capability.”

“Either way, I’m glad she finally brought me,” Skua said. “I’ve been on her case for a while now to get her to do so.”

“Well, welcome to The Team,” Finn said as they threw their arms wide to encompass the whole group.

Skua smiled as she said, “Thank you. OK, I think we’ve been polite enough. Tell me all the embarrassing stories that Ms. Artho here won’t tell me about herself.”

Oak leaned forward with glee in her eyes and Finn began to rub their hands together as Oak said, “With pleasure.”

Half an hour later, Skua was roaring with laughter and Artho was teasing them with a threat of never speaking to any of them again when Adora called everyone over to the patio. The six stood up and made their way over along with the rest of the huge crowd. Puffin was standing with the other little kids at the front of the group, holding hands with kids on either side of her. Finn could see Skua keeping an eye on her as they leaned over to her.

“Do you need to go get her?”

“No, I’m OK. I just worry,” Skua said. “Good to see her with some friends though.”

“It’s a friendly place around here,” Finn said. Skua smiled back at them but said nothing more as Adora started singing a birthday song for Capella. Everyone sang along as Capella sat at a table with Gress, looking a bit embarrassed by the fuss but happy as well. After the song, she began to open the presents everyone had brought and Finn watched as towards the end, she pulled a slender box towards her.

“This one’s from Izzy and Finn,” Capella said as she looked at the simple tag on it. She carefully removed the wrapping paper and saw a plain wooden box with the emblem of Bright Moon carefully burned into the lid along with her name. She ran her hand over the polished wood for a moment and then lifted the lid. She froze for a moment as she looked inside and then back up at them both. Finn looked towards Glimmer and Bow, both standing behind her and saw a look cross Bow’s face in a flash that made Finn worry about the gift before it was replaced by Bow’s usual friendly face.

Capella reached into the box and pulled out what some would call a very short sword and others would call a very long dagger. Straight edged with the back angling down towards the tip, the grey blade didn’t appear to be made of steel but some other metal that seemed almost warm in the early evening light. The grip was wrapped in tightly bound thin cord and Finn knew for a

fact it was quite comfortable to hold. Capella looked at it as she held it up and the crowd got a little quieter as she moved it a little to test the balance. Finn couldn't quite tell what she was thinking as she carefully laid it back on top of the moulded sheath that lay inside the satin lining of the box.

"Izzy, Finn… thank you," she said to them.

"It's the same material we use on high speed bearings for our bots," Izzy said. "Shouldn't need sharpening but if it ever does, there's a tool and instructions for it tucked in the box."

Adora, standing beside Glimmer, said, "Glimmer had a huge hoard of hidden weapons in her room at your age. You can start your own with that or add to the one that's already there that we may not be aware of."

Glimmer bumped Adora with her hip as she gave a little laugh and Capella shut the box and carefully sat it next to herself. She picked up another gift and Finn let out a little sigh of relief that she seemed to have appreciated it. The rest of the present opening went well and Bow brought out a huge cake for her as everyone clapped and watched her blow the candles out. Finally, Finn was sitting back in their chair at the back of the yard with the other five.

"Finn, I know it's tradition at this point for us to have a sleepover at your moms house but…," Artho started to say before Finn stepped in.

“I get it. It’d be a bit crowded,” Finn said with a smile.

“Don’t stop a tradition on my account,” Skua said. “Puffin and I can stay at our inn tonight.”

“It’s alright,” Finn said. “We’ll just have to come and visit you at your new place. Which does bring up, where are you three going?”

Skua said, “We’re going to a really tiny town called Marasville. It’s out by Mount Candila. We’d love to have you but the house we’re getting, well, it’s very small.”

“Sounds like an excuse to bust out the tents,” Oak said with a huge grin. “Been too long since The Team has roughed it.”

“Says the woman who routinely does wild stuff in a ship,” Finn says.

“Be fair. I do that. She’s just the first mate,” Chitin said with a laugh.

“What happened to co-captain!?” Oak said with a look of faked outrage.

“You know we said we’d trade off. It’s my week,” Chitin said.

Oak leaned into her shoulder again as she said, “That’s true. Alright, Captain, I’ll let you take the blame for that bump to the Bright Moon docks.”

Finn laughed as they watched the two banter for a few minutes but was distracted when they noticed Izzy looking carefully at Skua. When there was a lull in the conversation she said, “How’d you find that job out in… what was the name again?”

Skua smiled at her as she said, “I can’t blame you for forgetting. It was Marasville. I work in the aquaponics place in our little town. It’s not huge like the ones at Princess Frosta’s castle. Have you seen those?”

Izzy gave a smile that Finn knew was faked as she said, “I have. My mother runs one of them.”

“Oh! That’s neat!” Skua said. “Anyway, I got approached by a woman who is running a small company helping small towns get that kind of thing setup. That whole region is a wasteland and it’s going to be a mess getting things going as there’s not a lot of groundwater but I’ve got some ideas of how to minimize any water loss from the setup. I think it’ll be a great challenge.”

Izzy sat back with the same smile still as Finn said, “It sounds like it. You’ll have to show it off when we come to visit.”

Izzy nodded as she said, “I’d love to see it myself. I think I’ve heard of the place. I want to say they sat on the most recent Intergovernmental Review Panel for the first time along with some other towns out that way.”

“I think so,” Skua said with a shrug. “I don’t really pay attention to that kind of thing. I just like my plants and my fish. I do worry about the education Puffin will get out there but it’s not forever. I do feel a little bad that Artho is uprooting herself to come with me as well but she keeps assuring me it’s fine.”

Finn gave Izzy a look and she smiled back at them, not a fake one but a warm one, and Finn smiled back as they took her hand.

“Well you’ve certainly made Artho happy so I don’t think she’ll mind as long as she’s with you,” Finn said, nodding at their grinning friend. “I wish you all the best.”

“Thanks, Finn,” Artho said as she squeezed Skua’s hand. “She really does.”

Artho and Skua went off shortly afterwards to sit and talk with Perfuma and Scorpia so they could talk more with their daughter’s fiance. Oak and Chitin wandered off to get some beverages for

the rest of them and Finn leaned over to Izzy and in a low voice said, “Alright, what was that?”

Izzy looked back at Finn and Finn could see her thinking about evading the question before she said just as quietly, “Marasville was founded by people aligned with Him. They and a bunch of others made the Intergovernmental Review Panel… interesting the last time it met. The Poview law almost got upheld because of them. It seems a bunch set up in the wasteland out by Mount Candila and they all have some ties to him.”

Finn shrugged as they said, “OK, but what does that have to do with her? Sounds like she just got a job. I’ve only seen the area around Candila once. It makes the Crimson Waste look lush in places. Setting up a greenhouse makes sense.”

Izzy looked back towards the house and then towards the group of people gathered around Capella before answering.

“I don’t know. Maybe it’s a coincidence. Maybe it’s not,” Izzy said with a sigh.

“Let’s just be happy for Artho. It was really good to see her so happy,” Finn said.

Izzy just nodded but didn’t say anything more as Oak and Chitin returned.

After a long evening, Artho and Skua went and found Puffin asleep under a table with a few kids and gathered her up. There were hugs and promises to visit before they left Bright Moon and Izzy gave Skua a big hug.

"I'm glad to see my friend so happy," Izzy said. "If you two ever need anything, well, just remember that I'm there to help with all the resources I can manage."

Artho grinned as she put her arm around Skua's shoulder while the other arm held Puffin snoozing against her shoulder. Skua put her arm around Artho's waist as she replied.

"I appreciate the offer," Skua said. "Thank you."

"I'm serious. Artho, I know you won't be shy about it. You need help getting settled or getting something set up, you know you can come to me," Izzy said.

"Thanks, Iz, and you're right. I won't be shy," Artho said.

Finn put their arm around Izzy and said, "And if you get out to Dryl in the next few months, we're doing a run of plays for kids. The new crop of theater students are putting them on. You're always welcome."

“I’ve told them both about the place,” Artho said. “Puffin in particular is excited about it.”

“You know I’ll give her the full tour,” Finn said with a grin.

“I’m looking forward to it,” Artho said. “We’ll be in touch!”

The three left then with Izzy and Finn waving as Oak and Chitin followed them out. Finn couldn’t help but notice Izzy’s face going from friendly to contemplative after she was out of sight and it stayed that way all the way up until they got into bed for the night.

“Seashell for your thoughts?” Finn said.

“I’m alright. I love you,” Izzy said with a smile. Finn leaned in and kissed her and pulled her close as they turned out the lights in the room.

“Love you too.”

Late that night, Finn woke up. They couldn’t figure out why at first. They went to the bathroom and got a drink of water and then as they passed their open door they realized they could hear someone quietly talking down the hall. They listened for a moment and could hear both their moms quietly talking. Remembering something Adora had said once, about how

someone could move soundlessly but you'd still know they were present by other noises changing based on someone standing and altering the sound's path, Finn got low to the ground and snuck up the hallway until they could hear them both talking in the kitchen.

"... that's why Casta says she needs me back," Finn heard Adora say with a sigh.

"You can certainly manage it," Catra replied before a short pause followed by her saying, "And Finn, you can stop lurking in the hallway and come on in here."

Finn got up off the ground and went into the kitchen. It was dark and quiet in there but in the dimness they could still see that Adora had been crying.

"Mom, what's wrong?" Finn said as they went up and put a hand on her shoulder.

"Nothing," Adora said with a weak smile.

"You're a terrible liar, Mom," Finn said. "You two don't normally stand around in the kitchen late at night crying. Not to mention it's weird that you two haven't had a party in months. What's going on?"

Adora looked at Catra and then sighed as she looked back at Finn.

"I've… there's… I've lost She-Ra, Finn."

Finn stood there for a moment, trying to process that before they finally said, "Define lost."

"She's gone. I don't have a connection with her anymore," Adora said and gave Finn a brief accounting of what had happened. "Ever since then I've been back and forth at Mystacor to try and figure out what happened and where she might have gone."

"I'm sorry, Mom," Finn said as they hugged her. "I know she was a big part of your life."

"She really wasn't though," Adora said. "Not anymore."

"That's true," Catra said. "Finn never did see you become her and they're ancient now."

Finn rolled their eyes as they said, "Mother, stop trying to be funny. She's right though, Mom. You just didn't rely on her anymore. I'd say you're just as well known as Adora of Bright Moon as you are as She-Ra, Princess of Power."

Adora gave a little smile that ran off in a moment as she said, "There's so many that count on her though. They might not even think about it but if something happened…"

"Then people like Izzy will step up and handle it," Finn said, thinking of how Izzy already was doing that to some degree.

"Not taking that on yourself?" Catra said with a grin.

"I'll support her 100% but come on, can you imagine me standing before an army or something?" Finn said.

"People keep saying that and I know it's true. I just hate the idea of letting people down," Adora said with a deep sigh. "I can deal with it though."

"Then why are you still going to Mystacor?" Finn said.

"Because if she's settled on someone, or might, I want to be able to help that person," Adora said. "I want to be there to train whoever it is if I can."

"OK, but if you need anything from me, you let me know," Finn said.

“Kiddo, we can…” Catra started to say before Finn cut her off.

“Just accept your grown, fully capable child’s offer of help, alright?” Finn said, looking Catra in the eye.

“OK, yes, if we need your help, we’ll let you know,” Catra said.

“That’s all I ask,” Finn said as they took them both up in a hug.

Chapter End Notes

We get to meet Artho's fiance finally! How fantastic!

Capella

Chapter Summary

It's Capella's birthday and this time, we see it from her perspective at Catra and Adora's house.

Chapter Notes

"Just like the seed / I don't know where to go / Through dirt and shadow, I grow / I'm reaching light through the struggle"

The Seed by Auora

Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Capella had spent part of the afternoon gathering in people she'd invited to the party. She'd found she could bring in two people at once in her teleporting. It was pretty tiring but not awful.

Sert had argued that they didn't want to go but Capella had pointed out that no one knew exactly who they were in the Equal group and for all they knew, they were just a friend. Sert had finally given in and when Capella had brought in Prickly Pear as the last person to her room, she was pleased to see Sert spread out on a couch with a snack tray by their elbow.

"For someone who was complaining about not wanting to come a few days ago, you sure look comfy," Capella said with a grin.

"If I'm going to go through it, I might as well enjoy it," Sert said as they grabbed a piece of kib fruit and took a bite. "Besides, I might end up seeing one of the mysterious…"

"Say Dark Moon and I'm taking the snack tray away," Capella said as she sat down on the couch next to her. Gress was sprawled out on a large cushion beside the couch and Prickly Pear sat down on

the floor in front of Capella. Aden and Laho were seated side by side on another couch.

"Why do people keep believing that vile rumor?" Prickly Pear said as she snaked a vine over to the snack tray and grabbed a cracker. "It's such an ugly thing to believe about Bright Moon and Aunt Glimmer."

"Some people like to believe the worst," Laho said. "This is sensational and mysterious and people want to believe it because it will add those things to their lives."

Gress asked for an apple and Prickly Pear used another vine to toss it to him as Capella said, "It's bizarre though. I just want to know who's making those videos that keep popping up."

Sert laughed as they said, "I know what you mean. Some of them look so silly. Besides, you think if someone was running a super-secret intelligence network, they'd be smarter about it than letting video get all over the place."

Capella managed not to react as she thought about Izzy and how Capella was actually a part of such a thing. She smiled as she said, "Yeah, it's silly."

"What time are we supposed to be at the party?" Aden said.

"It's already started," Capella said. "We can show up anytime we want though."

"It's already started!?" Aden exclaimed.

"Brother Aden, it is alright," Gress said. "It is a very informal affair."

"Brother Gress, it is not polite to be late! Especially if we're with the guest of honor for the evening!" Aden said, gesturing at Capella.

"Aden, really, it's alright," Capella said. "Trust me, neither Aunt Adora or Aunt Catra is shy. If they wanted us there, we'd have already heard from both of them. Besides, this is the first one of these they've had in months. It's probably packed. I doubt they've noticed we're not there yet."

Sert flipped a grape into the air and caught it in their mouth before they said, "Honestly, you all need to learn to chill."

"Thus says the person who was pulling their hair out during the whole intergovernmental panel," Gress said. Sert shot a look at Prickly Pear and then back to Gress that Capella caught.

"P-Pear might not be in the group but she's trustworthy," Capella said.

"Is this about the Equal group?" Prickly Pear said. "Do I need to excuse myself for a few?"

"No, P-Pear, it's fine," Capella said. "Sert, it's fine, I promise."

"I know. Habit, really," Sert said. "I'll admit, I was a bit tense."

Capella snorted as she said, "That's a fine way of saying we were watching the panel as they got into shouting matches. I didn't realize how many towns were ready to fight for that Poview law."

"Some of those were new to the panel," Laho said. "That one group who formed that caucus were all from that waste out towards Mount Candila and had never sat before."

Prickly Pear shook her head and Capella thought just how much the gesture looked like her mother, Perfuma.

"Those people are misguided. They were blinded by what they were getting that they didn't realize who they were hurting," Prickly Pear said. "Hopefully they understand better now."

"Considering how narrow the vote was, I'm not so sure," Gress said. "It has been quiet though but I almost feel like it's the

proverbial calm before a storm."

"There have been some incidents," Aden said. "Just people though, no businesses or governments that I've heard of."

Prickly Pear looked at him as she said, "What do you mean by incidents?"

"Some assaults on my brothers, property damage, things like that," Aden responded. Capella had heard about these and had been amazed the first time at how calm Aden seemed until she learned how to read the older clones body language. It deeply disturbed him. Prickly Pear's eyes widened as she heard that.

"That's *horrible!"* she said.

"That's why we do what we do," Sert responded. "We can't stand by while this happens. We're lucky in that the town guards are catching them, mostly, and they're going to rehabilitation but it keeps happening."

"It's not happening in the kingdoms is it?" Prickly Pear said, her hands fiddling with a tiny flower that suddenly grew between them.

"Sometimes," Gress said.

Prickly Pear shook her head as she said, "That's not right."

"Going to join up with us?" Sert said casually and Prickly Pear looked right at them in surprise.

"I… uh… maybe," Prickly Pear said as she carefully tucked the tiny flower behind her ear.

"That easy, huh?" Capella said with a shake of her head.

"You said she was trustworthy," Sert replied with a grin.

"I know but I'm never letting you live down the grief you gave Gress and I," Capella said.

"It wasn't that bad," Sert said.

"You sent us to the Crimson Waste to meet with mercenaries while telling us it was a group that wanted to get started," Gress said while calmly picking through the snack tray at Sert's elbow.

"You did alright," Sert said. "Maybe don't pull an illusion on them next time."

Prickly Pear's eyes were wide as she listened and Laho said, "That is good advice, Capella."

Capella put her hands together and then pulled them apart as the words, "I heard it the first time" spread out between them in sparkling purple letters.

"P-Pear, don't listen to them. We do stupid stuff. You can just show up to meetings and offer whatever help you feel like you can do," Capella said as she dismissed her illusion. "You don't even have to plan if you don't want to."

Prickly Pear said, "I do want to help I just… you know Mom is getting me ready to assume the title of Plumeria. I worry that I'll cause problems."

"You mean like this one?" Sert said and then spread their arms wide to indicate the room they were sitting in. "You're worried you're going to get stuck in a place like this?"

"It wasn't fun," Capella said. "Just because it's nice doesn't mean I enjoyed it."

Sert grinned as they grabbed the last cracker from the tray and said, "I know. I shouldn't tease but it's so easy."

"They're right though," Prickly Pear said. "Cappe, I understand you did the right thing but you know Plumeria and the Fright Zone

are both neutral."

Laho looked her right in the eye as he said, "For how long?"

"I'm sorry?" Prickly Pear replied.

"How long will you remain neutral? I'm sorry, this is maybe not polite to say to someone who I barely know but how long will you remain neutral? How long until your neutrality helps those who hate us?" Laho said.

"That's not what we're doing," Prickly Pear said.

"I'm not trying to accuse you of anything," Laho said. "But as I was once blinded by the Light of Prime, I feel compelled to show others when they may be blinded by a light of their own. Again, I'm sorry, I know this is maybe not polite."

Prickly Pear paused for a moment before she said with a smile, "You are only speaking your truth and I have heard it. I'll think about it."

Laho gave a smile as he said, "Thank you."

"OK, before this gets going any further, how about we go to my birthday party?" Capella said.

The group agreed and Capella spent a minute teleporting each one to the road in front of Catra and Adora's house. As she jumped back and forth, a few more clones coming up the road had joined the group and started chatting. When Capella finally arrived with Sert as the last person she waved at the clones, a few that she knew from Equal or around Bright Moon, and everybody went up to the front door. Adora had the door open almost before they were on the porch.

"Was wondering how much longer you were going to stand out in the road," Catra responded over Adora's shoulder.

"I was going to say happy birthday but you'll have to excuse my wife's manners, she was raised in The Horde," Adora said, glancing at Catra with a grin.

"As was my wife, hence why she's being so ungracious in her language," Catra said.

"You're spending too much time around the language department at school," Adora said with a roll of her eyes.

"It's good to see you two," Capella said with a laugh as she hugged them both. As Capella hugged Adora, Catra draped her arm over Gress' shoulder, reaching up to make it possible.

"Been awhile. It's been quiet so I assume you've been keeping Cappe out of trouble?"

Gress looked at her with a serious face as he said, "Cappe is more than capable of keeping herself out of trouble."

"And getting herself out," Sert chimed up from the pack as they made their way into the house.

"Very funny, move it along, move it along," Capella said as she turned to look at her friends. The small group gathered around the table in the kitchen for a moment to grab some snacks while they said hello to some of the people in the living room. Sert and Mermista saw each other and traded a few friendly insults back and forth as Sert headed for the table.

"When did those two meet?" Adora said.

"At Seaweed," Capella said. "I'm honestly a bit irritable still that she showed up but it worked out. Thank you by the way for not showing up with She-Ra."

A look passed over Adora's face that Capella caught but it was only there for a split second. Catra looked over for a moment and Capella felt that something had happened that she didn't understand.

"You alright, Aunt Adora?" Capella said quietly. Adora grinned at her as she hugged her across the shoulders.

"I'm fine. Just getting older and Catra's spicy dip isn't agreeing with me like it used to."

Capella could tell that wasn't anything of the sort but she didn't feel like pressing her on it.

"I'm going to go round everybody up and go on outside," Capella said.

"I'll get the cake ready," Catra said.

"You know you didn't have to do that, Aunt Catra," Capella said.

"You know it wasn't necessarily for you," Catra said.

Capella laughed as she went along, stopping to hug Elliepurr sitting on the couch in the living room before getting everyone together and going for the backyard. She said hello to people sitting on the back porch and noticed Izzy sitting with Finn at the back of the yard. She felt odd every time she saw Izzy now. She'd thought about it a little and it wasn't in a bad way, it just felt odd to share such a momentous secret with the woman and it made her go quiet when the two were close together.

She didn't think long on that as she moved to the side of the house with the rest of the group and got settled in. Prickly Pear began to sit on the ground as vines grew up out of the grass and cradled her.

"Nice," Sert said as they nodded at the vines.

"I enjoy being held by the natural," Prickly Pear said with a smile and then her face went from happiness to surprise as she looked towards the back porch. Everyone turned to see what caught her attention and they saw her older sister, Artho, walking out holding a child with a woman beside her and Scorpia and Perfuma trailing along asking questions.

"Is that your sister?" Gress said. "I did not know she had a child."

"Neither did I!" Prickly Pear said in surprise.

Oak crossed the lawn and spoke with her sister and her moms. After the woman, Artho, and the child followed Oak back across the lawn, Prickly Pear excused herself and quickly went into the house after her moms.

"What do you think that was all about?" Capella said.

"I would think that her sister has been keeping a secret and quite a big one," Aden responded.

"You think!?" Sert said with a laugh.

"I do, quite often," Aden responded back. For a moment Sert was confused before they started laughing.

"It's a figure of speech," Sert said.

"It is? Could you explain it to me?" Aden said.

"Wait, seriously?" Sert said, looking at Aden who gave every indication they were serious. Laho sat next to him and seemed interested in what Sert had to say as did the few other clones. The only one who didn't was Gress who was taking a sudden interest in the lawn in front of him.

"You're messing with me, right?" Sert said. "You know what I meant."

"You asked if I thought. I do," Aden said. "I do not quite know how to prove it beyond doubt to you if you require a formal definition. I believe we could reach several ways of proof though through several avenues."

Sert sat silent for a split second before a grin split their face.

"You are messing with me," Sert said.

"How can you be sure though?" Laho said. "Perhaps we are just literal minded."

"You're a literal mind, Brother Laho!?" Gress said and Capella laughed to see the look of feigned surprise. "You do not look like a mind!"

Laho burst out laughing, as did the rest, as Aden said, "Well played, Brother Gress."

"Thank you, Brother Aden," Gress responded. The conversation picked up as they all chatted about various things. Prickly Pear came back after a while to tell them what she'd heard from her moms but after a while the talk drifted to talk of Equal.

"We really need to focus on some kind of awareness campaign," Sert said. "It doesn't seem the towns are doing anything anymore and no company is either that we're aware of but people are still people and like was said earlier, it's getting ugly."

Laho nodded as he said, "I've thought about this. We need to show people who we are."

"They already know who you are," Capella said. "Clones have been on Etheria for decades now."

"No, they know what they see in history books," Laho said. "They know what they hear other people see. Those of my generation, we're quiet, we try to not interact too much but we need someone who can get out and speak. Who people can see with someone they know, someone they have a positive association with."

"That's not a bad idea," Capella said. "We should put out a shout to the other groups, see who we can find for that."

The rest were looking at her and Capella looked back, waiting for a response as Gress moved a little closer to her.

"What? Is that not a good idea?" Capella said.

Prickly Pear scratched at her eyebrow with a pinky finger as she said, "Uh, Cappe, I know I'm new to this and all but even I think I see what they're trying to say."

Capella's mind clicked as she realized why they were all looking at her and why Gress was trying not to look at anything.

"Hang on a minute," Capella said. "You haven't even asked me or Gress for that matter."

"We're doing it right now," Sert said. "You two have known each other for years. You're both friends. You both joined Equal together and Capella, you're known. I know you can't use your princess status and all that but people have a pretty good idea of who you are and with Gress standing by your side, they'll know who he is and see that even Bright Moon thinks clones are just fine."

"OK, first, Bright Moon has always thought that," Capella said.

"There's been talk," one of the other clones in the group said.

"I know there has," Capella said. "But I'm putting an end to it here."

"Put an end to it for good," Laho responded. "You did a big question and answer back when the whole Dark Moon thing came out. Let's do those but in public."

"Yeah, we can rent a hall in places that we figure have been kind of hostile to clones and have people come in. Serve some food, have clones talk about what they do for their lives like family and work, and then have you and Gress give like, I don't know, a joint talk on stage about being friends," Sert said.

"This is not a good idea," Capella said and then stopped when Gress set a hand on her hand.

"Cappe… I don't think it's a terrible idea," Gress said.

Capella looked at him as she sighed and said, "It's just not a great idea. It's kind of all over the place."

"We will refine it," Aden said.

"I would be willing to talk about my little group here in Bright Moon," one of the other clones said. "We write code and live together."

"Ialo, that's a good idea," Sert said. "Come on, Cappe. You know we're going to go over this a million times."

"What about the cost?" Capella said.

"Use that mysterious backing you won't talk about," Sert said with a grin. "They covered the cost of the printing at Seaweed and the supplies. You think getting us a place to set up like this is going to be particularly difficult for them?"

Capella looked down at the ground so she wouldn't look over at Izzy sitting just across the yard as she thought for a moment.

"Cappe…," someone started to say and Gress hushed them.

"Let her think. Don't push her," Gress said as he lay a hand on her back.

"Listen, it's not that I don't want to," Capella said. "I'm just… I don't know, nervous I guess. I just immediately feel like it's a bad idea when we talk about it. Let me think about it and we can talk about it but just the Bright Moon Equal group, OK? Let's not bring this up outside just yet."

The rest were nodding their heads as Sert said, "That's fine. Sorry for pushing."

"You didn't push," Capella responded. "Just caught me by surprise."

"If you need to talk to me about something, Cappe, I'm there for you," Prickly Pear said. Capella grinned at her.

"I'm still surprised you're not going to be a Listener like your sister or your mom," Capella said. Prickly Pear looked away and Capella got a confused look on her face as she saw the conflict there. She was about to say something but shook her head and let it go. As she did, Adora came walking up to the group.

"Everything alright?" she said as she looked around the group.

"We're fine, Aunt Adora," Capella said. "And thank you again for allowing us to have my party here."

Adora looked around at the large amounts of people in her backyard with a smile as she said, "It's been good to do something. Been a… busy last couple of months." Adora turned back to the group again and looked each of them in their eye. "And considering that I can tell this is a bunch of people from Equal, I do have to say that we have a bit of an unwritten rule here. No discussion of business. We're here to relax."

"Aunt Adora, you can't seriously mean that applies to that," Capella said. "That's more to keep my Mom and everyone from turning your parties into an inter-kingdom roundtable."

"You'd think so," Adora said. "It's not though. Catra and I made that rule when we first started these. I was having business friends over and we kept talking about the next job. Catra suggested it and I agreed to it with her."

Capella was nodding along and then gestured towards some of Catra's students sketching with her in part of an herb garden.

"And that is…?" Capella said.

Adora looked at them and then back at Capella before she answered with a deadpan face, "Catra flaunting the rule like she has for as long as I've known her. She claims it's not work, it's relaxation."

The group laughed as Adora finally grinned at them and said, “Seriously though, keep it off business, please.”

“It could be that we find this relaxing,” Capella responded. “I promise though we’ll just talk about what we would normally talk about when we’re all together.”

Adora let out a long sigh as she said, “Cappe, if you think I’m going to just say, ‘Ok!’ and walk off after making a statement like that, well, I mean, I’m going to but I still hear the language you’re using there.”

“Aunt Adora, I have no idea what you mean,” Capella said with the innocent look of Sea Hawk caught with matches on his boat.

“I know how to handle this,” Adora said. “Come on over to the patio and let's open presents.”

“A bribe. I see how it is,” Capella said with a laugh.

“It’s worked in the past from what I understand,” Gress said.

“Hey, only in the small things,” Capella said with a grin as everyone started to stand and she put an arm around Gress’ waist.

Capella loved the presents she got such as a plant from her Aunt Perfuma and Aunt Scorpia, same as she got every year, new boots from Cowrie, a fancy jacket from her Aunt Mermista and Uncle Sea Hawk with a note that said she had been underdressed at Seaweed and other little items. Towards the end of the presents, she pulled a box towards her wrapped in nice paper. She saw it was from Izzy and Finn and wondered what the two got her as she told everyone who the gift was from.

She carefully removed the paper to see a box made of blonde wood, carefully polished. On the lid she saw the emblem of Bright Moon burned into it along with her name. She ran her hand over the wood and then carefully lifted the lid. Sitting inside on top of pale blue satin she saw what she immediately thought of as a

dagger and she froze. Her mind raced as she thought about what kind of hidden meaning might be there. Did Izzy expect something more? Was there something she didn't know yet and this was a coded message of some kind? She looked up at Finn and Izzy and Finn had a smile on their face while Izzy's face seemed to be parked in neutral.

Capella reached in and took the hilt and carefully lifted the blade out of the box. The tightly bound thin cord wrapping the hilt, in the same color as the satin in the box, gave a comfortable grip and the balance of the blade felt just right as she moved it just a little. She wondered where the style of the blade came from, with its straight edge and the spine angling down towards the tip, as most Bright Moon blades tended towards a curve. She was tempted to touch the edge to test it but something about the way the metal looked in the early evening light convinced her not to do so. She loved it.

"Izzy, Finn… thank you," she said to them.

"It's the same material we use on high speed bearings for our bots," Izzy said. "Shouldn't need sharpening but if it ever does, there's a tool and instructions for it tucked in the box."

Capella put it back in the box, noting the sheath inside had multiple attachment points so it could be worn in various ways as she heard Adora make some comment about Glimmer and her armory she used to have when she was Capella's age. Capella carefully shut the box and set it beside her as she began to open another present.

Later that evening, she was back home with Gress, Prickly Pear, and Sert. The rest had headed home and Glimmer had helped Capella bring back her presents. She'd spent some time getting them all put away and now sat at a table in her room with the dagger before her, it's handle towards her hand.

"That was from the Princess of Dryl, right?" Sert said as they picked at the snack tray they had at their elbow again and

everyone looked at the dagger.

"I just call her Izzy but yeah, it was from her," Capella said.

"Is it *normal* for princesses to get short swords for their eighteenth birthday?" Sert said.

Capella looked over at them as she said, "It's not a short sword; it's a dagger."

"Does that difference matter when it's that large?" Prickly Pear said.

"Kind of. It's more in the realm of daggers. We can go down to the armory and I can show you the difference," Capella said.

"I'm sure Brother Izzy and Finn had a good reason for giving you such a thing," Gress said.

"Probably because she's exactly what you just said," Sert replied. When the other three looked at them, they went on. "You called her Brother. She's probably thankful you stood up for her, um, people I guess you'd say."

"It's a strange way to show gratitude," Prickly Pear said.

"I don't think so," Capella said and carefully picked up the blade again and felt the balance. The hilt was a bit oversized for her hand but that just gave it plenty of room for her hand to grip it in different ways. A ring sat at the end and Capella wondered if it helped with the balance of the blade. "It's definitely well made."

"I didn't know Dryl did that kind of thing," Prickly Pear said.

"I don't think they do but come on. How hard would it be to design it on a computer and then stick the design in one of their fabricators?" Capella said.

Gress nodded as he looked at it and said, "That certainly does seem easy. Is it sharp?"

"I haven't had the guts to test it yet," Capella said. "I don't even know what I would test it against. Gress, you got any ideas?"

"I will gladly watch you test it from the other side of the room," Gress said with a little flap of his ears in amusement.

"Oh, come on! You're not going to help?" Capella replied.

"No, thank you. I do not wish to lose my arm," Gress said as a little grin escaped onto his face.

Capella stuck her tongue out as Prickly Pear said, "I could give you a vine if you wanted to cut it."

"Are you sure? I know how you feel about plants?" Capella said.

"It's a vine, Cappe. Just please make sure you compost it so it is properly put back into the system," Prickly Pear said.

"Fair enough," Capella said and stood with the dagger in hand. Gress scooted back to the wall as Capella rolled her eyes at him. Sert moved back a little as Capella looked at them. "You've never even seen me with a blade before."

"No, but I figure Gress has and he's retreated to the wall. I figure I'll be prudent in case it's not entirely a joke," Sert said.

"Ready?" Prickly Pear said. Capella nodded and a wrist thick vine grew past her. She carefully cut downwards and almost gasped as it passed through the vine with light resistance.

"Dear sweet Mara, that is *sharp!"* she said with a laugh as she brought it back up again to catch another part of the vine and it cut easily again.

"I'm moving to another room until you're done then," Gress said with a laugh.

"OK, you big baby, I'll put it away for now," Capella said with a grin as she found a cloth to carefully wipe it clean with and put it

back in the box it came in. Gress came back over to the table, as did Sert, and they talked for a little while before Sert headed home, Prickly Pear following them down into Bright Moon to where her family was staying for the night. Gress and Capella both sat on the balcony, watching the moons of Etheria, sipping at some hot chocolate that Capella had made from her powdered stash.

"Why do you think Izzy gave me that?" Capella finally asked. "It feels like some kind of… I don't know, message."

"Is there maybe a message tucked into the box? She said there were instructions and a sharpener if you should ever need it," Gress said.

"I didn't think about that," Capella said as she sat her mug down and went inside. She came back out with the box and set it on a small patio table. She rummaged around inside, finding the tool and instructions in a small compartment. Inside the compartment was a small folded note in Izzy's handwriting.

"She did leave a note," Capella said as she turned it over a few times.

"What does it say?" Gress said, his ears perked up.

"Give me a moment, I'm savoring," Capella said with a little wink to hide the anxious feeling she suddenly had. She finally unfolded the small note and read it.

Dear Cappe,

May you never need this but if you think you need to use it, remember the words of one of your predecessors and may it ever be the last argument of a queen or princess as the case may be.

Sincerely,

Izzy, Princess of Dryl

Capella looked at it and handed it to Gress after a moment. He read it and looked up at her.

"I don't understand," Gress said.

Capella looked up Bright Moon Peak. Near the top, out of sight, she remembered the room Glimmer had taken her to when she was nine. The room was called the Chamber of Names and each queen of Bright Moon had their name etched into the floor. She was thinking of the queen that Izzy was referencing.

"There was a queen of Bright Moon a long time ago. The weapons of her guards had engraved on the blades, 'The Last Argument of Queens.' It's said she did that to remind herself that if she went to war, arguing was at an end and to remind herself of the ugliness that would follow. She was in a lot of wars though so I don't know how well that helped but it was something I remember learning," Capella said.

"Is Izzy saying to expect a war?" Gress said as he read the note again.

"No, I think Izzy is trying to say I should be careful in how I use this," Capella said as she looked at the dagger as it dimly reflected the overhead aurora. "She's using that old saying to remind me of the intent and that's to be cautious."

Capella took the note back from Gress and put it back in the box and closed the lid on it. Gress sat a hand on the box for a moment before saying, "That is good advice. I hope you never need to use it."

Capella put her hand over Gress' as it sat on the box and said, "I do too."

Chapter End Notes

If you follow me on Tumblr, you already know this but *The Heir Apparent* is now officially the longest thing I've ever written. Currently, it's about 140,000 words long. My previous

longest, Finn's big story, was 137,000 words. Now I just got to finish it and it will be the longest, finished thing I've ever written. This update puts the published bit at about 60,000 I believe so that means you're not even half way to where I'm at currently in my writing. Thank you to everyone who's reading this and know that you've got a long way to go in this still.

As to the plot up to this point, I made a comment to one of the comments on the last chapter that I feel like this is the lead up in Grieg's *In The Hall of the Mountain King*. Just slowly building and building and building. It could also be like that one Tumblr post about anxiety in which it says it's just like hearing *Santa Clause is Coming to Town* but all you hear is the "You better watch out, you better watch out, you better watch out," over and over again. Either way, things are happening.

Capella

Chapter Summary

> Capella breaks the news to her parents that she's going to Wheatland soon. They seem to take it in stride but afterwards, Capella gets an urgent call from Gress.

Chapter Notes

> "I will water the ground where I stand / So the flowers can grow back again / 'Cause just like the seed / Everything wants to live / We are burning our fingers / But we learn and forgive" The Seed by Aurora
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A few weeks later, Capella was having dinner with her parents when she told them, “I think there might be a protest at a little town between Plumeria and the Fright Zone.”

Bow carefully sat down his chopsticks as he pulled his glasses off with the other hand. As he pinched the bridge of his nose he said, “What’s going on?”

“Dad, I get the feeling you don’t like this news,” Capella said.

“I kind of thought things had gotten better; that you wouldn’t have to do this anymore,” Bow said as he sighed and replaced his glasses.

“No town has done anything just yet,” Capella said. “This is more an anti-clone group in the town who’ve been having rallies and some of the clones in the town have been attacked. It’s kind of less protest and more visible support.”

Glimmer leaned back in her chair as she said, “Sounds a bit like marching out to meet an enemy.”

“No, Mom, nothing like that,” Capella said and did her best not to think about how she’d been considering bringing her dagger with her. “We’d actually been talking about getting into little community centers and doing gatherings where clones in the town would talk about what they love about the town and what they do. Then Gress and I would get up and talk about our friendship and it just sounds silly describing it to someone now.”

Glimmer was shaking her head as Capella said her last bit before she said, “No, I think I see where you’re going. I assume you’re still working it out.” Capella nodded her head before Glimmer went on. “So what does that mean with this?”

“Some of the clones in the town asked us to go so we’re going to just kind of go there and show support. They’re doing a rally and they asked our group to show up,” Capella said. “Gress and I may speak.”

Bow was leaned forward, one hand nervously fiddling with his glasses, as he listened. Glimmer looked at him and said, “Bow, you look like you want to say something?”

“Is this something we need to worry about?” Bow said.

Capella shrugged as she said, “It shouldn’t be. It’s just us showing up to try and raise awareness. Seaweed was way more nerve wracking than this. We’ve got no reason to think the town guard will be a problem, especially since the local group has already got a venue for us to be at.”

Glimmer thought for a moment before she said, “What if your Dad and I go with you?”

Capella blinked in surprise for a moment before she said, “Won’t that be a big problem if you both show up?”

Glimmer shrugged a little as she said, “Possibly. You being of age now could cause some issues as well.”

Capella thought about it for a moment before she said, “Honestly, I’d love to have you along but not at the risk of causing trouble.”

Bow said, “We can always work it out with the town government. Which one is it?”

“Wheatland,” Capella said.

Bow thought for a second and then nodded. “I know the place. Farming community.”

“That’s the one,” Capella said.

Bow turned to Glimmer as he said, “There’s something about their government but I can’t remember what it is. I don’t think it’d be a big deal though.”

Glimmer was slowly nodding as she said, “If Capella agrees, I say we go.”

Capella was smiling wide but a thought crossed her mind that wiped it away.

“Ummm, when I think about it, I’d prefer it if you didn’t,” Capella said. Before either one could say something, she quickly added on, “But there’s a tactical reason for it!”

Glimmer grinned a little as she said, “Tactics. I’ve heard of those before.”

“No you haven’t,” Bow responded back dryly to Glimmer before turning to Capella. “What are you thinking?”

“This isn’t a big deal here and you two are kind of a big deal kind of thing,” Capella said before raising her eyebrow at Glimmer. “Stop preening, Mom, you know what I mean.”

Glimmer grinned as she pushed a carrot around her plate. “I do but it’s nice to hear my daughter call me a big deal.”

“I just think that if I’m going to bring you in, it should be for something really big,” Capella said. “Not some little gathering like this.”

Bow nodded as he listened before he said, “I see where you’re going. That is a good point. Would some of the Bright Moon guards coming help?”

Capella looked him in the eye with a look that could best be summed up as, “Are you kidding me?”

“Dad, no. Please, don’t do that,” Capella said. “If you haven’t seen, rumors of the Dark Moon thing are running rampant and the last thing I need is for a bunch of Bright Moon guards, or even a few, at this to feed the speculation.”

“That’s ridiculous,” Bow replied. “Should we really be worried about that?”

“Maybe you don’t but I do,” Capella said. “When the original rumor came out, some people wanted me out of the group over it. I’m thinking of how it’d look if I showed up with a squad at my heels.”

Glimmer nodded as she said, “I understand. OK, well, do you have catering set up at least? You know Bright Moon is renowned for that.”

Capella laughed as she said, “Yes we are. No, we don’t, but it’ll be the local group's job to set that up.”

Bow sighed as he picked up his chopsticks and said, “Be careful, please.”

“Dad, is there something you’re not telling me?” Capella said.

Bow shook his head as he said, “No. I worry about you. A lot. I know Seaweed went well and you haven’t had one of these in a while but I’m still going to worry.”

“Imagine how your dads felt,” Capella said.

Bow gave a sad smile as he said, “I don’t have to. We talked about it after the war was over. We’ve talked about you in fact and how I feel about it.”

Capella sat quietly for a moment as she took a bite.

"You know you can talk to me about it if you want," Capella said.

"I know," Bow replied. "It's not that kind of thing though. I love you, I know this means a lot to you, and I want to support you but that doesn't mean I'm not scared every time you go out now."

Glimmer put a gentle hand on Bow's leg and he smiled at her as she said, "I don't get as nervous as he does but I worry too. Just promise you'll be careful and if you need us, let us know. I'll send a special squad if I have to. Don't think I can't find one."

"Special squad? You mean Aunt Juliet or would it be Aunt Catra and Aunt Adora? Don't worry. I promise that I'll be careful, Mom," Capella said. "I'll call on you if I need it."

Bow nodded as he said, "I guess that's all we can ask. So, cake or pie tonight?"

"That's it?" Capella said.

"I think there might be some mango sticky rice too," Bow said.

"No, Dad, that's not what I meant but yes, the sticky rice please if we have it," Capella said. "I meant, that's it? I kind of expected more of a… debate to be honest."

Bow got up from his chair as he went over to the door that led back to the kitchens.

"Honey, you're grown. We have to accept that you're going to do things we don't like or that worry us. What we can do is be there for you."

He smiled before he disappeared back into the door and Capella turned to Glimmer.

"Mom? What do you think?"

Glimmer pushed her plate away from her as she leaned back in her chair. She didn't look at Capella at first, studying the ceiling for a long breath before she looked back down.

"I think that I keep thinking that if I was your age now, I'd be right there beside you. The danger never bothered me back then, not for myself. I spent a long time thinking about this though. I was always more about charging forward. You think though. You're a lot like your Dad there. I should have thought this through more back when… well, I don't want to get into that. I'm

as comfortable with it as I think I can be. I still don't like it but you're smart. I trust you," Glimmer said. Capella teleported over to Glimmer's side and sat down.

"I wish you'd have said all this after Poview," Capella said as she hugged Glimmer.

"I should have," Glimmer said. "I really screwed that one up."

"Kind of," Capella said with a shake of her head. "Although, seeing me get punished really helped when I had to go and refute the whole Dark Moon thing to the group. I'm not thanking you though for that."

"You're just seeing the bright side," Glimmer said.

"I've gotten kind of good at that lately," Capella said and then heard what she'd just said. "Sorry, that kind of came out wrong."

Glimmer grinned at her as she hugged her again.

"It's alright, I know what you meant. I love you."

Capella smiled as she said, "I love you too."

They both looked up to see Bow standing in the doorway with a happy smile and tears in his eyes.

"Get over here," Glimmer said as he quickly came over and sat down the tray and gave them both a hug.

Later, sitting in her room going over the data board messages, Capella found herself feeling cheerful. She wasn't sure why. Both her parents had said they weren't thrilled about her continuing this but they seemed willing to support her in it and she kind of figured that was enough for her. She wondered though why Gress wasn't on the data board. He usually was at this time and she missed him. She debated again calling but figured she'd wait just a little bit. After the third time she had that argument with herself, she was just getting ready to call him when a little flashing icon lit up at the bottom of the screen with a stylized pictogram of Gress. She answered with a smile.

"What's happening? I thought tonight was… what's wrong?" Capella said as she saw his face trying to stay neutral.

"Someone burned Brother Hort's supply building at the orchard," Gress said. "And you remember Brother Heson and Brother Imance?" Capella nodded. They lived down the road from Gress and were raising a clone that was only a few years old. "Someone tore apart their garden and shattered all their lawn statutes. A few others along our road got other vandalism in just the last few hours. The burning was the worst."

Capella stood up and went towards her closet where her dagger was sitting on a shelf.

"I'm coming over there right now," she responded as she sat the data pad down and pulled the box down off the shelf.

"Cappe, no, wait," Gress said as he saw her pulling the dagger out of the box and sheathing it.

Capella stepped over to the data pad as she started putting the dagger on.

"Gress, you've got a minute and then you can explain it to me in person."

"First, we're not at home," Gress said. "So you need to take a breath and please let me talk."

Capella nodded as she threaded her belt through the sheath.

"I'm listening."

"We're all gathered together in a home for protection. Brother Hort and Brother Ulip are trying to get people to come to our house. I am trying to get them to go to the town guard but no

one is willing to go. They all remember what the guard did," Gress said.

Capella took a long breath as she threw on a long coat before she spoke.

"I'm sorry I jumped too quickly. You called me for a reason. What do you need?" Capella said.

"Will you come here and lend your voice to mine? Offer to go to the guard with us?" Gress said.

"You know I will," Capella said as she grabbed her bushy hair and tied it back. "But I have to know where you are."

Gress gave a tired smile as he said, "I understand. I just didn't want you to jump to our house. I don't know what's happening."

Capella nodded and Gress gave her an address down the street from where he lived.

"Please come in through the front door. There's a lot of jumpy people here," Gress said.

"I will. I'll be there in just a moment," Capella said. She quickly typed out a message to her parents telling them she was going to see Gress but left out the why and then tucked her data pad into a bag, slung it over her shoulder and started the teleport jumps to get to Gress' neighborhood. When she was almost there she remembered a story that she'd overheard her mom tell once about how she'd helped rescue Finn one day and took a page from it.

Her last teleport ended several hundred feet in the air and she took a moment to freefall and get a look on the street. When she saw that no one seemed to be out, except for a few clones standing around the house she was going to, she teleported down into the middle of the street. She was breathing heavily in the darkness as she started walking towards the house. She could feel fear clenching her stomach as she wondered if someone was hiding, just waiting for help to arrive but she pushed that down as she got closer while at the same time being glad the coat she'd picked was a dark purple that allowed her to blend better into the shadows. The clones standing outside turned to look at her as one came up to meet her where a small walkway passed through a stone fence into the yard and a single lantern on a post over the walk swayed in the wind and cast wavering shadows.

"Princess Capella," the clone said. "May I ask why you're here?"

Capella looked at him for a moment and remembered that his name was Weeup. She'd met him a few times hanging around Gress' house and realized that it was his house they were standing in front of at the moment.

“Weeup, I’m here to see Gress. He said there’s been a problem and he’s asked me to help,” she responded.

“We do not wish to stir up more problems,” Weeup replied. “Thank you but we’d appreciate it if you did not involve yourself.”

Capella gave a smile at him, warm and friendly and one that would have reminded people of Bow, as she said, “I understand but at the very least, may I please see my friend? He was very worried and he did ask me to come over. I’d like to at least let him know I arrived.”

Another clone came walking up to them and said, “Brother Weeup, that’s a reasonable request.”

Capella smiled and said, “Thank you. I do want to help but if it’s just checking on my friend, that’s what it shall be.”

Weeup seemed conflicted but finally nodded.

“OK, you may see Brother Gress,” Weeup said. “But do not start trouble.”

“Thank you,” Capella said. “I promise I will not start any trouble in your home.”

Weeup seemed relieved and Capella continued her smile as he stood aside and she walked up the walkway. She noticed none of the clones seemed armed and wondered why. She knew they were afraid of seeming dangerous but she figured now might be a time to project a little danger. She knocked on the door before opening it carefully.

Inside the living room, it was packed wall to wall with what looked like every clone family that lived on the street. They all turned to look at her, their conversation ceasing, as she stepped inside and closed the door. To someone not familiar with clones, the group would look stoic. To Capella, they looked terrified and she felt her heart clench in sorrow. Ulip saw her and began to stand when Gress came out of a back room and carefully made his way across the room to hug her tight.

“You made it,” he whispered.

“I made it,” she whispered back as she hugged him. “You doing OK?”

He nodded and then shook his head with his ears laying back.

“That bad, huh?” Capella whispered as she put a hand on the side of his face.

“That bad,” Gress responded. As they talked, Ulip and Hort made their way through the group, who were quietly muttering amongst

themselves, and stood beside Gress.

"Ulip, Hort, I'm sorry to hear about this," Capella said and then raised her voice a little so she could be heard in the room. "I'm sorry to hear about everything that's happened to you all tonight."

"Capella, why are you here?" Hort said as his eyes looked at the dagger and then back to her face.

"Gress called and asked me to come," Capella said as she pulled her coat a little tighter around the dagger.

"We do not want additional problems," Hort said.

"I do not intend to start any," Capella said and turned to the room. "I intend to stay here by your side but I also think it would be best if you involved the town guard as soon as possible."

There were a few mirthless laughs in the room as one of the other clones spoke up.

"They were very helpful at your rally," he said.

“And I know the same commander is still in charge,” Capella said. “That is why it’s best to go right now to him and I’ll go with you.”

“What? There’s no logic in that,” Hort said.

Capella nodded as she said, “We present him with a chance to clear his name. He can take this on and we can be sure and make it open every step of the way. If he drags his feet or pretends like nothing can be found, well, we will not let that go unanswered.”

Capella could hear some start talking in favor, while others talked against it. She didn’t respond or give any arguments, she just let the conversation go back and forth. She knew that while clones differed among themselves in many things, one of the things most had in common was the necessity to talk things over. It was what they did after the Fall of Prime, during the Great Reckoning, and she knew they would want some kind of consensus as a community if possible. Gress leaned on the wall beside her and she put her hand on his shoulder and when she felt like the conversation was starting to stall she spoke again.

“OK, I can understand that some of you are worried about this. I do. How about, say, just a few of you,” Capella said. “We file just a few complaints tonight. I’ll go with that group so you have an outside person along.”

Hort was looking at Ulip and Ulip was looking back at him and for a brief moment he nodded.

“I will go with Capella,” Hort said. “I wish to file. Is that satisfactory?”

There were some mumblings and a few agreed but more disagreed and Capella was thinking about what she might do to move it along when Gress stepped forward.

“Brothers, this town is our home. We have every right to live in peace here as anyone. If you do not agree, then that is the will of the group. However, I do agree and I will go and file myself for things that I am aware of because that is my will and I believe it to be right,” Gress said. Capella looked at him in surprise. His ears stood up, he stood straight, and while his tone was even, it was still raised. With the way he met each person’s eyes in the room, she knew he might as well be shouting at the group. “We stand together but we are still our own person, responsible for our own actions and I will do this thing, unblinded.”

The room went silent and when no one spoke up, Gress turned to Capella.

“Come, Cappe. Let’s go make our report,” Gress said as he turned his back on the room. Weeup had come into the house at the tail end of Gress’ announcement and was looking around in shock. Capella reached her hand out for Gress’ hand when a voice spoke.

“Brother Gress, wait, I’m coming with you,” the voice said.

Capella turned around to see one of the clones who'd argued for reporting kissing another clone on the forehead and carefully placing a hand beside a baby clone's face before coming forward. A few others stood up and started coming forward as well.

"I thought you said you would not start trouble in my home," Weeup said to Capella.

"I did say that and I have not," Capella said. "I simply started a discussion."

Weeup gave her a hard look before shaking his head.

"We know that discussion can be some of the worst trouble," Weeup said. Capella almost replied but instead just gave him a warm smile as she walked out the door with the group of clones.

Capella quickly noticed as they walked that a lot of the streetlights had been broken as they walked down the street and towards the center of town. As they approached the square, Capella found herself getting more nervous as she remembered the big fight that had happened all those months before. Most of the businesses were closed as they crossed through the square towards the guard headquarters.

"Who is that?" Gress whispered to her and nodded at a group of eight people sitting off to the side on one of the benches that dotted the town square. Capella couldn't tell but didn't like the

look of them, particularly when they all stood up as the group passed through.

"Stay up here," Capella said. "I'm going to the back of the group."

"Don't start anything," Gress said.

"I won't," Capella said and stepped to the side and let her group pass and then fell in behind them. Hort and Ulip were walking hand in hand in the rear as well and watched her as she walked up beside them with nervous eyes.

"Gress is fine. He's walking up front," Capella said. "I just wanted a look at those people over there."

"That's why we are back here as well," Ulip responded. Hort just clenched his hand tighter. Capella wanted to say something when she saw the eight people start slowly walking after them.

"What are you going to do?" Ulip asked.

"Nothing," Capella said as she tried to swallow around a sudden lump in her throat. "Let's just get to the guard headquarters."

"What if they help them?" Hort said.

“I don’t think they’ll do anything of the sort,” Capella said and then had an idea. She pulled her data pad out of her bag and turned it on and quickly got to the private data board that Equal’s leadership hung out on. “I’m going back up front with Gress. Shout if something happens.”

Hort and Ulip nodded and Capella quickly walked back up to the front as she made a brand new room and typed the heading, “Problems in Poview - Live” and then put it out on the board.

“Gress, I’m going to start a stream with the board,” she said as she walked along with him. “I want you to carry the data pad. Can you give some kind of commentary on what’s going on?”

Gress looked at her for a moment like she was out of her mind before it dawned on him.

“I can,” he said.

“OK. It looks like people are already starting to come into the room. I’m going to start it up and hand it off,” Capella said. Gress nodded as she started the main camera. “Hello everyone. There’s been some attacks here in Poview tonight. I’m walking with a bunch of clones to the guard headquarters to help them file complaints. I’m handing this off to Gress.”

She'd muted everyone in the group so they couldn't talk but she could see the chat function suddenly explode with questions as she handed it off. Gress took the data pad, let everyone see his face for a moment and then switched the camera to show the area and began trying to answer questions and give an account of what had happened.

Capella went to the back again and saw the eight people had picked up a few more as she went up to Hort and Ulip.

"When did they show up?" she said.

"Right after you went back up," Ulip said.

"What was your idea?" Hort said.

"I've got Gress on a live chat with our group. I figure witnesses might be useful," Capella responded.

"I hope so," Hort said as they all watched three more people come out of an alley to join the group. Two people were hanging even further back, trailing the group as if keeping a long watch on everything and Capella figured they were maybe leaders and marked them in her mind before looking around their group and saw they were coming up on the guard headquarters.

“We’re there,” Capella said and felt a little bit of relief before a huge wad of anxiety dropped on her as she wondered if this was the best idea. Maybe the guard wouldn’t respond or worse decide that this was some kind of riot again.

“I’m going to the front,” Capella said and didn’t bother with walking this time. She teleported up beside Gress as the first few clones entered the guard headquarters. She could hear the guard on the desk sounding bored and a bit argumentative as she got on tiptoes to Gress and whispered in his ear. “See if you can get a shot of everyone behind the group.”

Gress nodded as he kept up a steady, calm stream of talk about the situation and Capella gripped his shoulder before she went inside.

“Listen, I don’t know who you all are,” she heard the desk guard say. “I need some kind of proof of identity before I’ll take any kind of statement.”

Capella got up beside one of the clones standing at the desk and the guard looked down at her and she swore he swallowed a little as the feathers along his head lay back a bit.

“Good evening, sir,” Capella said, putting on her mother’s best official voice. “I am Capella of Bright Moon, here as a private citizen to help my friends. Why won’t you take their statement?”

“Princess…,” the guard started to say before Capella held up a finger to interrupt him.

“Just Capella, please. As stated, I am not here in an official capacity. I don’t think that’s necessary,” Capella said and the way she said the last sentence made it clear she was more than willing to make it necessary.

“Capella,” the guard went on tentatively. “We have a policy of not taking statements from anonymous sources.”

“OK, so? What do you want for proof?” Capella said.

“How can I be sure that whatever proof I’m given from them is the right one? How can I tell them apart?” the guard said. He leaned back as sparks started to form in Capella’s hair.

“Oh, I’m sorry,” Capella said. “Since your eyes don’t seem to be working, what do you suggest to help you?”

The guard got a little heated as he said, “My eyes are just fine but…”

“No, there is not a but here. If you want positive identification, then I will provide it and you can put me in the report as the person to contact if questions arise,” Capella said as she leaned forward.

The guard took a deep breath and gave a last ditch effort.

"Uh… you're armed. You can't be in here with that."

Capella gave a sweet smile as she lay her hands on the desktop in plain sight, but this wasn't one of her father's smiles. It was one of her mother's smiles and it was not one of her friendly ones.

"Well, sir, do you wish to take it from me?"

She had no intention of getting into a fight with a guard and if he got belligerent she was more than willing to surrender the weapon. That didn't mean she was going to make him understand that easily.

The guard looked at her, looked at the cold smile, and then said, "I'll make an exception. Keep it sheathed."

"Of course, sir. I had no intention otherwise," Capella said and made a gesture at the clone beside her.

The clone stepped up and Capella told the officer his name. The clone made his statement, answered a few questions, and then stepped calmly aside for the next clone. Capella kept quiet as the officer started taking the clone's statement.

“Oh, I’m sorry, sir,” Capella suddenly cut in. “I forgot to tell you which one this was.”

The officer’s feathers lay all the way back on his head as he realized what he’d done and stammered out, “It’s… um, ok. I think I recognize him. Um, in fact, I think I know a few of them. If you want to step aside, I’ll call you if I need you.”

Capella gave the same cold smile as before and said, “Of course. I’ll just step out for a moment.”

She spoke quietly with a few of the clones, let them know to come get her if there were further problems before she stepped outside. Gress was still keeping up a stream of commentary as he sat on the flat concrete of the balustrade on the side of the stairs going up to the front door of the headquarters. Capella looked out towards the street. It was a lovely road, split in the middle with a grassy median with trees growing in it. On one side, the headquarters and their little group but leaning up against the trees in the median was a group of about twenty-five. Capella went over to Gress who smoothly hit mute on the data pad.

“The last few came in while you were inside,” he said.

“You ok?” Capella said, looking up at his face as she put a hand on his hand and felt the faint tremors. He just nodded but she could see the tension around his eyes. “I’m sorry I put you in this again.”

"I put myself in this again," Gress said with a little amused flap of his ears that only lasted a split second. "If I didn't want you here, I would have waited until tomorrow to contact you."

Capella squeezed his hand and then looked across the street again. She saw someone standing back in the shadows of an alley and realized it was one of the two people who'd been following a little distance back from the group who'd been following them.

"Gress, I'm going to step away for a minute," she said. He just nodded, turned his microphone back on, and went back to talking. She got a good look at the group and went back inside. Capella smiled as she saw that two more guards had come out to process the complaints and hoped they could get everyone back home as soon as possible. She went into a little bathroom in the main room and taking a deep breath, pulled an illusion over her face, changing her looks enough she wouldn't be recognized. Then she teleported out to the next street over.

Capella looked around but didn't see anybody on the street but she did see the alley that went between the street she was on and the street the guard headquarters was on. She peeked around the corner and spotted someone leaning against the wall at the far end but otherwise the alley was empty except for a few small trash cans. She ducked back around and took a deep breath as she pulled her coat tight around her.

This is a terrible idea, she told herself before she came back around the corner and then froze. The person was gone. She could see the group in the median and then the clones hanging

around the steps of the guard headquarters as they waited their turn to go in and make their complaint. She looked around but didn't see anyone crouched down. She started carefully making her way up the alley, doing her best to keep her hand off her dagger. She was almost to the front when she heard movement behind her.

Capella spun around, her heart thumping in her chest as she looked around, trying to see where the noise had come from when a voice from almost directly in front of her said, "Could you please be a little quieter, Cappe? We're trying to be subtle here."

Capella was about to go for her dagger when a figure appeared. Behind them was a large cat shape with a blue diaphanous mane and Capella almost sobbed in relief when she realized it was Catra, followed almost immediately by a flash of irritation.

"Aunt Catra, what are you and Melog doing in this alley!?" she said, forcing herself to keep her voice down.

"Step back here, we're a little too obvious," Catra responded as she stepped back a few feet. Capella almost argued with her but followed along as Melog shrunk themselves down to a little smaller than a housecat and hopped onto Catra's shoulder.

"OK, I saw you earlier but I didn't recognize you and you were with someone else," Capella said. "So where is Aunt Adora hiding?"

“She’s not here,” Catra said, “but…”

Capella already knew the answer when she heard wings above her for a split second as Glimmer used them to slow herself down after jumping down from the roof overhead.

“Mom,” Capella said, a little uncomfortably.

“She is,” Catra said, finishing her sentence with a little hook of her thumb at Glimmer.

“I didn’t see your wings,” Capella said. “How did you hide them when you were walking down the street earlier? Illusion?”

“You didn’t look up,” Glimmer said as she came to stand with them. “That was your dad standing next to Catra. I was flying over their head keeping an eye out.”

“Dad’s here too!?” Capella said.

“He’s on the roof,” Catra said simply, as if that explained everything. Capella looked up quickly but didn’t see anything. She looked back out at the crowd again before she turned back.

“Why are you all here?” Capella said.

“I could ask you the same thing you know, young lady,” Glimmer said. “And could you dispel that illusion, please? It’s a little weird hearing your voice come out of what looks like a version of your dad’s face.”

Capella sighed as she ran her hand down and the image disappeared. “It’s not dad. It’s just a random face I’ve been practicing.”

“It does look a bit like Bow,” Catra said.

“Can we not do this right now? Mom, I’m here because Gress contacted me about stuff that happened tonight,” Capella said. “I came right away. I did leave you a message that I was going to be out.”

Catra grinned as she saw Glimmer roll her eyes.

“You did fail to mention in your message that you were coming to something that was possibly dangerous and before you try to say it’s not, you’re carrying your dagger Izzy gave you,” Glimmer said dryly. Capella looked away from Glimmer for a moment as she again pulled her coat a little tighter around the weapon in an effort to conceal it.

"OK, so yeah, I knew. I just didn't… you know… want to have a whole conversation about it," Capella said.

Glimmer shook her head before she said, "We'll talk about this later. Do you have a plan at least?"

"I've got the guard to start taking statements, Gress is out front with a live broadcast of the whole thing, and I was coming back here to see who was lurking in the alley," Capella said. "Beyond that, nothing solid at the moment."

"Ah, just like the old days," Catra said with a grin.

Glimmer fought to hide a smile but failed as she said, "Be fair. She's thought this out way better than we ever did."

"True, you can tell by the lack of running and screaming," Catra responded. Her ears perked up at the sound of a sick owl. "I see he hasn't got any better at that."

They all looked up to see Bow peeking over the edge of the two story building.

"More people are coming, good sized crowd," he said and Capella was surprised to see his quiver and bow. All the old photos she'd seen of him, he carried it everywhere but she'd never known him to carry it at any time in her life except when the two of them

went to the archery range together. Bow gave a little wave at her and a tense smile as he said, “Hey, sweetheart. Be careful.”

Capella gave a tentative wave back at him as he ducked back out of sight. She was about to move up to the head of the alley again when Catra shook her head.

“You get back to your group. You got backup,” Catra said. “Let us handle our end.”

“Are you sure?” she said. Glimmer nodded as she threw her arms around Capella, surprising her.

“If it gets ugly, do what you did last time,” Glimmer said. “Teleport them somewhere safe. Don’t worry about us. We’ll hit them from behind, give you a distraction to get people to safety.”

“Mom, are you sure?” Capella said. “There’s at least twenty-five right now and if more are coming…”

She trailed off as she thought of it and then jumped a little when Catra gave a little laugh.

“Yeah, seems unfair… to them.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes but had a tight grin on her face. Capella looked between the two before she just shook her head and said, "You two worry me."

Glimmer's face went serious again as she said, "Then we're even and don't think we're not talking about this later. Now be careful and get going."

Capella teleported back into the guard headquarters main room, causing a few of the clones to jump as they saw her come in. Most of them had moved inside and she asked a few how much longer. They informed her most of them were almost done. She wondered how she'd get them all back through town to their homes as she made her way out to the front stairs again. Gress wasn't talking, he was just looking down the street at a crowd of about a hundred people walking their way. Capella looked another way as another crowd, not quite as large but still sizeable, headed their way. Capella's heart started racing so hard she was worried it was going to jump out of her chest until she saw Gress grinning.

"What's going on?" Capella said. Gress just held the data pad and pointed at the messages. She began to read a few.

We're on our way.

Not again! Headed your way!

Called my buddy! They and their friends are getting dressed and headed your way!

Got your back.

Capella looked at Gress with a grin starting to form on her face and flung her arm around his waist as he put an arm around her to hug her tight.

"Good job, buddy," she said, tears of relief pricking her eyes.

In the end, the crowd that had followed them, the crowd that had seemed so threatening, had just kind of melted away. Capella didn't see her mom and dad or Catra and Melog again until she got home. She'd walked with the clones, surrounded by a crowd of their fellow townsfolk, back to their homes and the townsfolk had stayed out on the street that night to protect them so they could rest. She'd almost gone home but as she was walking with Gress, Hort, and Ulip back to their home, she'd spotted a blonde woman in the crowd talking with two others. Normally it wouldn't have been anything but a little badge on the woman's collar had caught Capella's eye. It'd been a small enamel badge of several nested black crescent moons on a dark purple background.

Capella had wondered just why that seemed so familiar and when she'd suddenly realized she'd seen it before on a data board. It was supposed to be the badge of a Dark Moon operative. She'd immediately gone back into the small crowd to try and find the woman. She thought it was in poor taste to be wearing it and wanted a word with her but no matter where she looked, she

couldn’t find the woman. Capella had ended up just standing in the middle of the road, looking back and forth as people milled about, watching out for their neighbors.

Chapter End Notes

Gress for the win! I'll be honest, when I got into this chapter again to clean it up for posting, I had forgot part of it! I was so delighted to remember that the good people of Poview turned out for their neighbors. Good on them. I also really loved Glimmer giving Cappe a look and giving her grief about carrying a dagger on her. Glimmer of all people but then again, what we're fine with for ourselves, we often don't want our children to do.

Now, for those of you who are uncomfortable with the Micah plotline, the next chapter is Adora and by extension, Micah. It is incredibly uncomfortable, writing it hurt, and editing it is difficult. That being said, when I post it, I will provide plenty of warning in the opening notes so if you do not want to read it, you can skip to the end notes and read a summary of the chapter.

Thank you as always for reading and I hope you're enjoying reading as much as I'm enjoying writing.

Adora

Chapter Summary

> Adora is at Mystacor when she receives some news of She-Ra from Castaspella. Then she goes to visit Micah to find out an awful truth.

> Note: This chapter talks about Micah and his illness. You can skip to the End Notes for a brief summary if you feel you don't want to deal with this.

Chapter Notes

> I know I just posted the other day but I want this chapter posted and done. This chapter hurt to write and it almost got cut completely but part of the story I've been building up to over this series was partly the need to tell this. I hope I did it well.
>
> If you do not want to read about mental decline of Micah, and I completely understand, you can jump to the end and read a summary of the chapter. I give a one sentence summation of what happened with Micah but nothing in detail.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora sat in a small room in Mystacor, looking out the window. Catra was back home, teaching, and only came by on the weekends. They talked a lot by data pad but Adora couldn't help but feel like she did those first few years when she lived in Bright Moon alone. She didn't see her friends hardly at all, she'd put her surveying work on hold while she dealt with this, and she just felt confused and isolated. She looked down at the journal she was writing in and continued on.

It's really not something I should feel so gloomy over. Everyone agrees that I should be relieved that I was able to live long enough to just be me again. That's what I wanted for so long as well. I didn't want to be known only as She-Ra. I wanted to be known as Adora and I am. Finn is getting more recognition these days than I am and I love that but I still feel guilty. I feel like I'm letting people down. Like the other night when Catra went with Bow and Glimmer to Poview. I know they didn't have time to come and get me but I can't help but feel like I was an afterthought. I know it's not true but it's how I feel. At least I was able to talk with Bow afterwards when he had his little freak out over Cappe being there and was able to help that way.

Also, it's a personal thing. She was with me for so long, maybe it's just I'm feeling like there should be more than just a dream of goodbye and then silence. I don't even know if someone like her would even understand that. Maybe that's just me. Maybe she doesn't even notice. I just know there's something I need to do and maybe it's not here but for now, I can't think of a better idea. OK, time for the Daily Three.

Daily Three

- *I'm lucky I have people who both love me and are able to help me, like Casta.*
- Catra is very understanding of all of this and I'm happy I have such a great wife.
- There are worst places to be stuck than Mystacor and I'm grateful I'm here.

She knew she was supposed to be totally honest in her Daily Three and she looked at number three for a moment. She wasn't entirely grateful to be there and she finally added on to it.

I'm grateful to be in Mystacor because maybe I'll get an answer but I wish I didn't have to be here. I miss Catra.

Adora looked at it and knew that was breaking a rule as well for the little exercise but she just shook her head and closed the journal then. She'd been keeping a journal since shortly after the Fall of Prime and rarely missed a day. She looked at the other leather bound volume beside it, where she'd been recording everything she could remember about She-Ra, and thought about how she'd be remembered. Her and Catra had created wills when they'd started taking care of Finn and had kept them up to date. Part of her will stipulated that her personal journals would all go to the Bright Moon Archive with access limited only to Finn and Catra for a period of twenty years past her death. Now, looking at the work she was doing on She-Ra with the intention of having it sent out to every kingdom and large town, she wondered if maybe she should change that.

A quiet beeping sounded from her data pad sitting on a table nearby and Adora sighed as she stood up. She went over and saw the reminder to meet Castaspella in a room down the hall for another round of tests. They'd made a little headway in the time she'd been there but Adora also suspected that some of the tests weren't strictly necessary, that the various sorcerers were using her as a chance to explore private interests. When Adora got to the room where she was to meet Castaspella, she blinked for a

moment in surprise. Normally, the room was dim with a few glowing crystals giving light but now it was lit up by regular light fixtures and looked like what it was, an old converted office. Castaspella sat by herself.

"Casta, am I late?" Adora said, looking down the hall in both directions as if she'd see the others that were supposed to be there.

"You know, you never ask if you're too early," Castaspella said.

Adora shrugged as she said, "Does that matter?"

"No," Castaspella said with a soft smile. "Sit down. We need to talk."

The face that Adora suddenly made had Castaspella give a gentle smile back as she said, "Nothing's wrong."

"Sorry. I've been in a mood this morning," Adora said as she shut the door and took a seat. "What's going on? I thought we were doing more tests today. The moons are supposed to line up in a certain way you said."

"We don't need to," Castaspella said. "Oh, we'll want to do some more but this alignment isn't important. I think we may have found a trace of Her."

Adora heard the uppercase H. The group she'd been working with hadn't said She-Ra's name and had a certain way of saying her. It took a moment though to realize what Castaspella had said.

"Wait, you found a trace? In me?" Adora said and her gut clenched as she thought about that. Castaspella shook her head.

"Not in you and it might not be here but we definitely think we found a trace of the runestone on the sword," Castaspella responded. "She's always been associated with that so we're thinking maybe that's her as well."

Adora nodded as her gut unclenched and wondered why she felt so relieved.

"Where?"

"It's not a where," Castaspella said. "Not like you think. Honestly, it's confusing even for me. I didn't do this work, Tong did."

Adora nodded. Tong was a short, squat woman who didn't talk much and wore dark glasses because she hated bright light but was considered the most brilliant theoretical sorcerer on Etheria. She wouldn't say a word for long stretches of time and half the time, when Adora had first met her, she thought the woman was asleep during the meetings they had but then she'd suggest

something that'd have everyone else stunned and shaking their heads and Adora had figured out she just didn't care about small talk at all.

"OK, I'm not remotely smart enough to ask Tong so could you give me an answer?" Adora replied. "What does this mean?"

"Honestly, I think it means we may be able to figure out if she does settle on someone. Maybe. I'm still trying to read what Tong wrote out as an explanation," Castaspella replied.

Adora nodded as she thought. "Uh-huh, I see."

Castaspella grinned. She'd watched Adora do something like that since she'd first met her and knew that she didn't really understand but didn't want to admit it just yet.

"I think we need a few weeks to process this. If you want, you can go home and we'd love to have you over for dinner tonight," Castaspella replied.

Adora was already on her feet, nodding but already thinking of what she needed to pack when she paused.

"Wait, I'd love to have dinner with you tonight but I already promised Angella that I'd go over this evening," Adora replied.

Castaspella's face went from happy to grim in a moment.

"I saw Micah this morning," she replied. "He's…"

Castaspella looked away and Adora stepped over to put a hand on her shoulder.

"Do you need help?"

Castaspella looked up at her and shook her head as she forced a smile onto her face.

"No. It's alright, I'm managing, I just feel so bad for Angella," Castaspella said. Adora had seen Castaspella do that almost since she first met her and knew that this was her trying to keep her feelings to herself.

"I'm here for you too if you ever need me," Adora said. Castaspella looked up at her and before she could say something more, Adora went on. "When you first met me, even though I had known Glimmer and Bow for hardly any time, you still treated me like you'd known me my whole life. You've never changed in that and that's one of many reasons why I've always thought of you as my Aunt Casta. I'm here for you."

Castaspella’s eyes overflowed as she leaned forward and Adora sat down beside her and put an arm around her as they both quietly cried.

Later that afternoon, Adora had already packed except for a few things, and let Catra know she would be coming home on the public skiff the next morning. Now, she was walking through Mystacor towards Angella’s room. She felt guilty not thinking of it as both Angella and Micah’s room but Micah just didn’t seem to be there anymore. Most of the time he sat quietly in a comfortable chair near the patio where he could see outside. He didn’t speak much and when he did it was confusing as he didn’t know what was going on. Now standing before the door, Adora took a deep breath and then knocked. Angella answered the door on Adora’s first knock and ushered her into the room.

“Thank you for having me,” Adora said, shocked to see Angella dressed in sweatpants and a sweater.

“I apologize for my attire,” Angella responded. “It’s hard to get up the energy these days to dress as I should.”

Adora smiled as she said, “Dress however you want. I’m not a fashion critic. It doesn’t matter to me.”

Angella gave a sad smile as she said, “It matters to me though and it bothers me that it doesn’t matter enough anymore.”

Adora didn’t know what to say. When her and Catra had started raising Finn, it was Angella they’d gone to a lot for help. Now Adora didn’t know who to go to for help in this and she was terrified of doing it wrong.

“Do you want to go get changed?” Adora offered. “I don’t mind.”

“No. Thank you but no. I’ve already been this way all day. It can wait,” Angella replied.

The two walked into the small sitting room where Micah was sitting in a chair. Adora looked at the man she remembered first meeting on Beast Island. He’d been strong and capable even if he’d been a little confused and not realized just what had been going on at first. Now she felt a little anger at the universe because the confusion he suffered from now was magnitudes larger than it had been then and it didn’t even have the decency to at least allow him to remain strong through it.

A nurse was quietly talking to him as she examined him. Adora looked at her in her dark blue robes and a lighter blue collar, giving full attention to Micah, and wondered what it was like to work at that job and to watch some people just slowly slip away, no matter how much magic or technology could be brought to bear on the situation. The woman finally patted Micah’s hand and stood up. She stepped back out of Micah’s line of sight and made a few entries on a data pad before nodding at Adora and Angella.

“I’ll be going now,” she said. “Adora is on the night shift.”

“Thank you, Oolby,” Angella said as Adora had a momentary moment of awkwardness at hearing her name attached to another person. She was just glad that trend had died off a long time ago and it didn’t happen as much as it used to. The nurse nodded and left the room as Adora stepped into Micah’s line of sight. She watched as he took a moment to register she was there and then waited as he focused on her.

“Hey, Micah. Good to see you,” Adora said, doing her best to keep a relaxed smile on her face. He gave a smile that was confused but warm.

“Hello,” he said, his voice weak. “Why aren’t you in your blue robes?”

“I’m not a nurse,” Adora said with a smile. “I’m here to visit you and Angella.”

Micah’s smile went from confused to joyful as Angella settled on a chair next to him. He shakily reached out to take Angella’s hand and she carefully laid her other hand on top of his.

“Hello, Angel,” he said, looking at her before turning back to Adora. “We’re going to move to Bright Moon soon. We’re talking about having a child.”

Adora’s smile stayed plastered on her face as she nodded.

“That sounds… good. I bet any child you have will be amazing.”

There was a long silence as Micah looked at her oddly.

“I… don’t…,” Micah said before lapsing back into silence.

“What is that, love?” Angella said.

Micah didn’t answer, just went back to staring out the window. After several minutes of silence, Angella stood up.

“I’m going to go and see about our meal. Could you keep Micah company?”

“Of course,” Adora said. Angella stood up, her back straight as she left the room. Adora sat down on a chair across from Micah and he looked up at her suspiciously.

“Who are you?” he said.

“I’m a friend of you and Angella. My name is Adora,” she responded. Every time he forgot her, she thought it wouldn’t hurt anymore but instead it felt harder every time.

“Are you part of the Rebellion?” he asked.

Adora nodded.

“I am,” she said. Micah went silent again and his face went slack as he settled back into the chair. Adora sat in silence when she heard conversation in the hall. She looked up to see Glimmer walking in with Angella. Glimmer walked over to kneel down beside her father.

“Hey, Dad,” Glimmer said. “How’re you doing?”

Micah looked at her, his face blank, before he turned his head a little and said, “Who are you? Are you with her?”

His hand rose shaking to point at Adora but Adora wasn’t looking at that. She was looking at the look on Glimmer’s face. She didn’t think she’d ever seen Glimmer look so utterly shattered or defeated. She tried to speak a few times as Adora quietly stood up and stepped behind her at the same time Angella did as well. Adora carefully lay a hand on her shoulder as Micah gave a little smile.

“Oh, are you two partners?” he replied.

Adora shook her head as she said, “We’re friends.”

Micah nodded as Glimmer said, “I’m… I’m your daughter. Glimmer.”

Micah looked at her and reached a hand out to her. Glimmer took it carefully as he said, “Of course you are.”

He gave a little smile before he lay his head back. His eyes slid close as he began to softly snore and tears slipped down Glimmer’s face. Adora knelt down beside her and carefully hugged her as Angella did the same. It took some time before Glimmer finally placed Micah’s hand on his lap and carefully tucked a blanket around him. Glimmer leaned over, kissing his forehead, a few tears dropping from her face to his as he muttered something indistinct in his sleep before settling back down. She stepped out into another room, her back straight, and the other two followed her. Adora was shocked at how Glimmer seemed to be holding it together. The she watched as Glimmer leaned against a wall as her shoulders started to heave in silent sorrow.

Nobody said anything. Nothing could be said. They simply were there for her.

Later that evening, after they’d had dinner with Angella and Micah and Glimmer had brought Adora home, Adora sat in her recliner in

her living room with Catra sitting in her lap and Melog perched on the back of the chair. Glimmer lay out on the couch while Bow gently stroked her hair.

"I just thought it'd be good to pick you up early," Glimmer said. "And it'd been a few days since I'd gone out to see Dad so I figure, why not, I'll surprise you both."

Glimmer sniffled a little as Bow carefully wiped away a tear.

"That's not good is it?" Catra said quietly. "What happened I mean."

Glimmer shook her head.

"He's never completely forgotten me before," she said and took a deep breath as she started softly crying again. "He probably doesn't have much longer."

Catra and Adora got up out of the chair and sat down beside the couch, Melog shrinking down even smaller as if to hide from something. Glimmer reached out and Catra took her hand as Adora gently took her shoulder.

"Have you told Cappe yet?" Adora said.

Glimmer shook her head.

"No. I will when we go home tonight."

"Should we maybe, I don't know, be there all the time?" Catra said.

Bow shook his head as he said, "No. I asked Angella that a while back. She said she wants things to be as normal as they can. She can't stand the thought of all of us hovering around, waiting for it to happen."

"It," Glimmer said with a little snort. "My father's death." She teleported to the kitchen and leaned against the counter for a moment. "This isn't fair."

She stared down at a bowl with some fruit in it as she started to cry again. The three started to come over to her when she suddenly balled her fists up and screamed at the top of her lungs. She turned on all three of them as she shouted, "This isn't fair damn it! I've already had to mourn him once in my life! Why do I have to do it again!? Why!?"

The four stood and looked at her in shock, none of them having any idea of what to say.

"It's just…," Adora started to say before Glimmer cut her off.

“Just the way of things? Just how it is? Is that what you were going to say?” Glimmer said, her voice full of sarcasm and pain. Adora just held her hand up a little in a hopeless manner and nodded a little. Glimmer slammed her hand down on the counter, the bowl jumping as tears streaked her face.

“I can harness power like almost no one else on this planet. I can teleport myself and huge amounts of people and stuff anywhere on the planet. I rule a kingdom and indirectly a planet but I can’t help my own father. I have to watch him wither like this,” she said, flicking her hand off to the side like she was dismissing something. Bow started towards her and Glimmer put her hand up to. “No. I can’t right now.”

“Starlight, please let me help you,” Bow said.

“How? Can you reverse this? Can you bring him back?”

“You know I can’t but I can help you through this.”

Glimmer sat down on the ground, her wings curling in around her like a shield as she shook her head.

“I don’t think I can do this,” she quietly said. Bow lay down on the ground, his head only a few feet from Glimmer’s feet as Adora sat

down on the couple of stairs coming down from the kitchen to the living room and Catra leaned up against the wall.

"You don't have to do anything right now," Bow whispered back. "Just rest."

"I can't," Glimmer whispered back.

Adora looked at her as she said, "You can."

Glimmer shook her head as Catra said, "Rest. Come and lay down on Ellie's bed. You don't have to sleep but at least get comfortable."

Glimmer looked at her for a moment before snorting a little as she said, "Mom used to say that to me all the time to get me to take a nap."

Catra nodded as she said, "She taught it to us when we first got Finn."

Glimmer put her head down with a sigh before she carefully got up. She held her hand out to Bow who took it gently and kissed the tips of her fingers. Adora got up and went to grab a few extra pillows as well as some bedding as Glimmer made her way down the hall. As Adora came back in she made the bed up quickly and Glimmer sighed as she sank into the bed and pulled an extra

pillow to her. Bow settled in front of her and she pulled close to him as Adora turned the lights off.

"Adora, I'm not staying overnight," Glimmer said but her voice was heavy, worn out from the rage and the sorrow.

"Catra's letting the castle know you're here. You take as long as you need. If we've gone to bed when you go home, just turn off the night light in the hall when you go," Adora said.

Glimmer looked at her, her eyes tired, and Adora could see she wanted to argue but she finally just nodded as she pulled Bow a little closer.

Adora walked past Catra, talking with the Bright Moon guard sergeant that was on duty that night, and continued on out to the patio. Melog padded along after her as she went across the patio and through the yard, and down a little slope to the fire pit. She stood beside the pit and looked down on it. It was clean, no ashes, and she tried to remember the last time they'd even lit a fire there. It'd been a common occurrence when Finn had lived there. They'd spent a lot of time down there as a family and a lot of serious conversations had taken place there.

Adora picked up a small stick of firewood. She turned it over in her hand before breaking it and smelling the wood. The fragrant smell brought back a dozen memories sitting around the fire pit and she carefully knelt down, got some more wood from the small pile, and made a small cone shape. She opened a small protected box and took out a pine cone dipped in wax and carefully put it

under the sticks before lighting it with a match. She stayed crouched down as she watched as the flame slowly caught on the pine cone and then started burning merrily.

"Thought I might find you down here," Catra said quietly behind her. Adore looked over her shoulder at Catra.

"I don't know why I came over here. I just thought… I don't know," Adora said. Catra nodded as she sat down on one of the chairs sitting around the pit.

"I know what you mean," Catra said. "I heard Bow softly singing to Glimmer, figured I'd come out here, leave them be for the moment."

They watched the little crackling fire, flames flickering and jumping towards the sky, as they both just took a moment to not think, to not try and worry about the next thing to say. After a little while, they saw a brief flash and heard a teleport as Capella came into the backyard.

"I'll get her," Catra said as she stood and walked up. A minute later, Capella was coming down to sit down with them as Catra told her that her parents were inside and needed a moment.

"What happened?" Capella said as she settled down on a chair and Melog lay their head in her lap. Adora almost didn't say but decided to go ahead and let her know.

“Your Mom came to pick me up from Mystacor early,” Adora said. “I was with your grandparents and… Micah… he forgot your mom.”

Capella put a hand over her eyes as she looked down.

“He doesn’t remember me anymore either,” she said quietly. “It came back every once in a while but ever since I got out to visit him after being kept in the castle for that month it just got worse fast. He remembered once but it’s like…”

Capella sniffed as a few tears streaked her face. Adora started to get up to go to her and Capella shook her head.

“I’m OK, Aunt Adora. I mean, I’m not but it’s natural. That’s what the healers say at least,” Capella said. “My Listener as well. Just a part of life, regular as breathing, it comes for us all. All of that bit.”

She clasped her hands together as she said it and faint sparkles formed in her hair before disappearing again. Adora silently picked up a few more sticks and set them on the small bed of coals that’d formed when the cone had fallen in on itself a few minutes before. The heat from the coals caused them to smoke for a split second before they burst into bright flame.

“That doesn’t mean you have to like it,” Catra said.

“I know,” Capella said. “And I don’t. I hate it. I keep finding excuses not to go and visit them and I find more than I want to say.”

“You’re going to regret that,” Adora said and Catra and Capella both looked at her in surprise. “What? It’s true. I know it hurts, Cappe, but try. If you need someone to lean on, you know we’re there for you.”

Capella sighed as she leaned back in her chair, pulling her coat around her against the chill in the night air that wasn’t really dispelled by the small fire. She suddenly sat back up as she looked at Adora with hope on her face.

“You. You can fix this,” Capella said suddenly.

“What? How?” Adora said and then suddenly realized she had a pretty good idea of what Capella was about to say.

“She-Ra can heal. Heal him,” Capella said with the force of utter belief in the truth she thought she was speaking.

“Cappe… I can’t,” Adora said.

Capella frowned as she looked at Adora.

"You pulled Catra back from the dead," Capella said, pointing at Catra as if trying to show proof of her words. "Why can't you heal this?"

Adora was shaking her head as she said, "I didn't raise her from the dead. That's a myth and it's a long story of what exactly happened that day but I can't because…"

Adora paused. She had actually had the conversation with Micah a few years before and he'd pointed out that magically tampering with a person's mind was not a good idea and had asked that it not be attempted. Adora didn't want to tell Capella that though, that Micah himself had known that he was going to suffer like he was at the moment. On top of that, she didn't want to tell Capella that she didn't even have the ability to try even if she had decided to go against his wishes.

"Because why? Are you scared?" Capella said in disbelief.

"No, but…," Adora finally decided to give her part of the reason. "It's his mind. Tampering with a person's mind is… you don't do that. It's not like there's not magic that allows that but no one does it. No one who isn't evil at least and doesn't care about the consequences."

"But you're She-Ra," Capella said. "You can do amazing things!"

Adora looked away as she said, “Not this.”

Capella deflated as she said, “I can’t believe you won’t even try.”

Adora looked back at her as she said, “It’s something we’ve discussed. It’s how I know about the mind magic. I want to be there for him but I just…”

Adora shrugged, her shoulders barely lifting as she felt the weight of all the expectations on her and shook her head.

“I’m sorry, Cappe.”

Capella pulled in on herself, pulling her legs up to her as she wrapped her arms around them.

“I should have known you’d have done it if you could have,” Capella muttered. Adora just nodded as the sticks burned down and it got darker. “Is that why you’ve been at Mystacor so much lately?”

Catra looked at Adora with a little glance that Adora knew meant Catra would come in with a change of topic if she wanted. Adora gave a little shake of her head as she said to Capella, “No. That’s

another project I have going on. That conversation about trying to help your grandfather was earlier.”

Capella nodded again but didn’t say anything as they listened to the crackle of the coals. After a long stretch of silence, Capella stood up from the chair.

“Can I stay in Finn’s room tonight?” Capella said.

“Of course,” Catra said. “Want me to make the bed up for you?”

Capella shook her head. “I’m a big girl. I know where you keep the sheets.”

Capella started to walk away, shuffling her feet as if she didn’t have the energy to even lift them, and Adora could feel a solid lump settle into her throat.

“Cappe?” Adora called out to her as she got to the top of the little hill. Capella stopped but didn’t turn around or say anything.

“I… I wish I could do so much more. I wish I could heal him for you,” Adora replied.

Capella looked over her shoulder as she said, “I know and I’m not mad at you but that’s not really any comfort. Good night.”

Adora watched her go. When she was gone, she put her face into her hands. Catra sat beside her in silence, her arm around her as Melog became large and curled around them both, as Adora wept at her helplessness in the face of the sorrow of the people who were the only real family she’d ever known.

Chapter End Notes

Chapter Summary: Adora is melancholy about the loss of She-Ra but when she finds out from Castaspella that the sorcerers have detected some faint hint of the runestone on the Sword of Protection, she's conflicted and has a gut reaction of worry that she might still be attached. Castaspella assures her she doesn't think that his the case but because they do seem to have detected it, they think that they will be able to find She-Ra if she returns to someone. Micah has declined further and forgets Glimmer.
End of Chapter Summary

I talk a little more about Glimmer's reaction below as well as my own experiences with Alzeheimers.

End Note
I don’t normally talk about myself in great detail because it’s not something I really want to do but I want to say that I’ve lost two family members to Alzheimers. This is what Micah has, or at least the fictional Etherian version, and Glimmer’s screaming is almost directly mine. It’s a nightmare of a disease and it’s not fair. When Adora makes the comment that it doesn't even have the decency to leave the person with some kind of strength, that's again me talking directly. It's been ten years since I've lost someone to this disease and

I'm still crying remembering. I almost backpedaled putting it in here so many times. I still worry that maybe I shouldn't have but like I said in the opening note, I hope I at least did it well.

Fic is often joked about as being therapy and when I first started writing it last year I laughed at that but I've done that in so many of my fics. This is another example and while it hurts, it has given me perspective. I'm sorry. I know it's hard to read. It was excruciating to write. I will say there won't be much more of this plotline. I cut this it down in the story. I can't write much more of it.

Normally, I try and end these by saying thank you for reading and I hope you enjoy this but it feels wrong to say that about this chapter. Instead I'll say please try and make sure you spend time with those you love and let them know they're loved.

Capella

Chapter Summary

Capella wakes up the next day at Catra and Adora's house.

Note: Brief discussion of Micah and his condition. Very mild but I did put a summary at the end just in case.

Chapter Notes

"Dreams are messages from the deep."
- Dune: Part One by Denis Villeneuve

Note: See chapter summary. Brief discussion of Micah, very mild but there is a summary at the end anyway.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Capella woke up and for a brief moment wasn't sure why she was lying in a bed with a tent over it. Then she remembered the night before that she'd come to her Aunt Adora and Aunt Catra's house and had ended up sleeping in Finn's old bedroom. It was early, so early it wasn't light out as she got up and debated putting on the same clothes she'd worn the night before. In the end, she decided to keep on the pajamas that Catra and Adora kept at the house for their frequent houseguests like her. She quietly walked down the hall, past Catra and Adora's room where they both slept and past the room where Elliepurr stayed when she was at the house and where her parents were both asleep at the moment.

Capella went on into the kitchen to see what was available for breakfast. She was looking through the well-stocked pantry when she heard a little noise. She looked around and saw Melog, shrunk down to a small size, looking at her.

“Hey there,” she whispered. “You want something to eat?”

Melog made a little chirping noise at her and she looked at them, waiting for more.

“I don’t know if that’s a yes or a no,” she whispered back.

“It’s a yes,” Catra said softly as she stepped around the corner, rubbing her eyes as she adjusted the loose sleep pants she wore. Capella jumped a little but just nodded. Catra came over to the pantry as Capella stepped out of the way.

“Usual, buddy?” Catra said as she grabbed a few things and got a large bowl. Melog chirped again and Catra shook her head. “I will later but thanks for asking.”

“I didn’t mean to wake you up,” Capella said, awkwardly standing in the kitchen, picking at the shorts she was wearing.

“I don’t know if you did or not. I’ve noticed over the last few years that I wake up pretty early without any effort. Just part of getting old I guess,” Catra said as she stepped to a counter and started putting stuff in the big bowl. “You want something?”

“I don’t know what I want,” she responded.

“I know the feeling,” Catra said. “Listen, about last night…”

Capella held her hand up as she said, “I know. I need to apologize.”

“No, you don’t,” Catra said. “If something was happening to Adora and I thought there was a chance someone could help her, I’d be way more aggressive than you were. Not that I’m saying you were but… you get what I’m saying.”

Capella nodded as Catra took a breath.

“All I’m saying, and I’m not going to explain why right now, is please, don’t bring up She-Ra around Adora, OK?” Catra said.

“Why not?” Capella said, confused.

“I said I wouldn’t explain. Just do it as a favor for me. Please,” Catra said.

Capella wanted to ask more but it was too early and she wasn’t sure what was going on and Catra looked uncomfortable and sad all at once as she set the bowl on the table as Melog jumped up on top and started eating.

"OK, I won't," Capella responded.

"Thanks. Like I said, I'll explain eventually but for now… just… don't mention it," Catra said and then paused as she watched Melog daintily take a bit of muffin out of the bowl. "You know what, let's get some breakfast ready for everyone. I have a feeling it's going to be an early morning."

Capella agreed and they started working on getting things together. Glimmer passed through the kitchen, her eyes barely open, and Catra greeted her warmly. It was friendly, inviting, and genuine but Catra also did it because she knew it annoyed Glimmer so early in the morning. Capella looked up, wondering how her mom would react, and was surprised there wasn't a reaction from her. Instead, she just stood in the middle of the dining area next to the kitchen, watching Capella and Catra getting stuff ready.

"Morning, Mom," Capella finally said.

Glimmer didn't say anything. She just walked over and grabbed Capella in a fierce hug. Capella wrapped her arms around her as Catra stepped around them without a word and stepped out of sight for a moment.

"Catra, I didn't mean to drive you out of your own kitchen," Glimmer said as she broke the hug.

Catra's head popped back around the corner as she said, "It's alright. Just giving you a moment. I hadn't started actually cooking yet."

"You alright, Mom?" Capella said.

"You heard?" Glimmer said.

"Yeah. The guard last night told me you were here since Aunt Catra called instead of you or Dad. Then Aunt Catra caught me before I came in. They told me what happened," Capella said.

"Sorry about that," Catra said as she leaned against the wall. "We should have let you do it."

Glimmer shook her head as she said, "No, it's alright. Thank you for that. It was hard enough last night."

"What do you need from me?" Capella said.

"Nothing, sweetheart," Glimmer said with a tired smile. "I'm supposed to be there for you."

"Well, that's just not a good answer, Mom," Capella said.

“It’s the one you’re getting for now,” Glimmer said as she gave Capella another short hug.

“Well if you’re going to be that way, I’m going to go out and hit the morning market. I think we need fresh donuts,” Capella said with a smile.

“The fruit lady said they’d have some mango in from the Kingdom of Snows soon,” Catra said. “See if any has shown up.”

“Mangos, donuts, anything else?” Capella said. After a short pause and no response, she nodded and went down to change real quick before she teleported out. She ended up just down the road from the market and walked through the darkness right before dawn. It was colder than normal for Bright Moon during that time of year but Capella wasn’t paying attention to it as she watched the early morning crowd going through the stalls. She waved at a few people she recognized as she stopped at the fruit stall first and got fresh mangos. She chatted a few minutes with the lady running the stand before she moved on, following her nose towards the bakery.

As usual, there was a small line waiting and Capella fell in at the end, holding her little bag of mangos. People came and went and the line went forward. Right before Capella was set to step through the doors into the small bakery, she felt a strong sense that someone was looking at her. She turned around, wondering if it was maybe Sert or someone else, not thinking that they would have just come up to her. It took her a moment before she

spotted someone standing back at a small cart with a roaster attached that was selling various roasted nuts.

It was a blonde woman looking at her and she seemed familiar. Capella was trying to figure it out when someone behind her said, "Hey, you're next."

Capella turned around and saw that it was indeed her turn.

"Sorry about that," she said with a smile as she went forward. It only took her a few minutes to get the fresh donuts and started back out the door. She was looking for the blonde woman again because something in her head said she should figure it out when she was distracted by Sert waving at her from the end of the bakery line. Capella made her way over to them.

"Whatcha doing down here this early?" Sert said.

"Getting donuts of course," Capella said, holding up the small box they were in.

"This is the place for it," Sert said with a nod at the little shop. "I'm glad I ran into you though. You free later today? We're talking about moving Wheatland up after the thing in Poview the other day and we could use your input on it. We want to move fast. We're thinking in just a couple of weeks."

“I think we can do it. I’ll be on the chat later and if not, I’m sure Gress can give you some good input on it,” Capella said.

“I’m sure he can,” Sert said. “Whether or not we all understand it without you there to help us parse it is another story.”

Capella rolled her eyes as she said, “He’s not that bad.”

“He quoted three philosophers I’ve never even heard of in our last big discussion,” Sert said. “Understand, I’m working on philosophy in school so that’s saying something.”

“Just keep poking him until he explains it in terms you understand. That’s what I do,” Capella said.

“You really don’t but no worries,” Sert said. “I’m going to go get some donuts of my own. See you later.”

Capella nodded and teleported back to the house. She walked into the little dining area beside the kitchen to Adora sprawled out in a chair, her hair pulled back. In her hand was a cup of what she called coffee and what others called caffeinated brown liquid when they were being generous. She wasn’t fully awake yet and her nose seemed to twitch for a moment that made Capella think of Catra before Adora said, “Donuts?”

“Yes, Aunt Adora, donuts,” Capella said as she sat them on the table in front of her as Adora leaned forward to grab the box. Glimmer teleported out of the kitchen, grabbed the box, and then teleported to the counter separating the two areas.

“Why did you do that?” Adora said, her hand still in mid-air.

“Because I’ve seen you eat an entire dozen, by yourself, in under a minute,” Glimmer said as she opened the box. “At least if I make you get up and walk over here the rest of us will have a chance.”

Adora let out a long sigh as she said, “I almost had them. I’ll miss it, the donut that got away.”

“You’re not hunting them,” Catra said with a shake of her head as she grabbed two, put them on a plate, and walked them over to Adora. She sat them down in front of her and kissed her on the forehead. “There.”

Adora yawned widely as she picked one up and Capella could have sworn that it simply disappeared.

“You’re going to choke if you eat that fast,” Capella said.

“You sound like your mom,” Adora said right before the next donut followed its predecessor.

“I never had to say that to her. She doesn’t eat like that,” Glimmer said.

Catra said from the kitchen, “It’s a Horde thing.”

“You gotta stop using that excuse,” Glimmer said with a roll of her eyes.

Adora gave a little grin as she said, “Naw. It’s still funny.”

Catra carried out a tray full of food with Melog draped around her shoulders as she said, “And trust me, we try to get the most humor out of that.”

Capella said, “Looks like we’re about ready. Want me to get Dad?”

Glimmer shook her head as she said, “No need. He should be out in a moment.”

True to her word, Bow came out of the hallway just a moment later. Capella went over to hug him as Adora looked at him, neatly dressed in the spare clothes he kept at their house and with a smile on his face.

“Bow, I’ve known you for decades now and I still have no idea how you look so chipper first thing,” Adora said as she adjusted her ratty robe a little and took a long drink off her coffee. Bow helped Catra get another tray to the table before sitting down as the rest got seated.

“I seem to remember you used to wake up bright and early every morning ready to face the day with a smile,” Bow said with a smile of his own as he got some toasted bagels and some fresh fruit.

Capella looked over at her Aunt Adora with a bit of a surprise. She’d stayed at their house many times and while Adora could and would get up early, ready to face the day with a smile was not one that Capella would ever apply to her. Adora just shook her head.

“Yeah, well, I did lots of silly things when I was young.”

“I know one of those silly things,” Glimmer said with a little grin on her face as she picked up a pitcher of juice and looked towards Catra.

“Do I need to remind you of your little description of a ballgown and…,” Catra shot back at her before she looked towards Capella and cleared her throat. “You know what I mean.”

“OK, I don’t,” Capella said. “So you better finish that sentence right now, Aunt Catra.”

“Absolutely not,” Catra said with a laugh when Melog perked up and looked towards the front door. Everyone turned at the same time as the door opened and Finn and Izzy walked into the living room. The two stopped as they looked back at the six all staring at them.

“Ummm… surprise?” Finn said with a widening grin.

Capella laughed as she said, “I’m guessing you didn’t tell them you were coming.”

“No,” Izzy said as she crossed the room with a small bag and Finn followed along. “I wanted it to be a surprise.”

Melog leapt off of Catra’s shoulder and took a few steps across the living room, growing large enough to knock Finn back onto the couch. Finn reached up to scratch at their head as they said, “Missed you too!”

Izzy smiled as she handed off the bag to Catra as Adora got up and hugged her. Finn finally made it into the kitchen, Melog hanging at their heels as everyone got up to hug the arrivals. As they got settled, Izzy explained she needed to be in Bright Moon for something and figured she’d show up extra early as a surprise for breakfast.

“Well, we were surprised,” Glimmer said. “What’s going on in Bright Moon that brings you here?”

Capella was wondering the same when Izzy said, “Visiting a chip factory that’s been supplying us with some of our parts for the heavy bot miners. It could have been a data pad conversation but I figured why not just come on down.”

Capella said, “Are you going to be here late enough that you can come have dinner with us tonight? If that’s OK, Mom.”

“I like how she doesn’t ask me,” Bow said with a laugh.

“Because she knows if Aunt Glimmer is alright with it, you’ll go right along,” Finn said with a mischievous grin.

“You know, you used to be more respectful,” Bow said with a fake serious look.

“No, they weren’t,” Adora and Catra both said in unison.

“Moms!” Finn said, laughing. Glimmer agreed with dinner and talk went around the table as everyone ate. Then Capella remembered running into Sert at the market and brought up the event getting moved.

“They said we shouldn’t wait too long,” Capella said. “We’re thinking of putting it on in just two weeks.”

Glimmer frowned as she said, “I don’t like that. You shouldn’t jump off half-planned.” Finn snorted as they reached for a strawberry and Glimmer looked at them. “I’m right!”

“I love you, Aunt Glimmer, and I agree with you, but you see, I’ve heard Best Friend Squad stories most of my life. Hearing absolutely any one of you four you say that just struck me as funny,” Finn replied.

Izzy carefully ran her hand over the side of her head as she listened and Capella rolled her eyes as she said, “Mom, we already had a lot of the planning done. We’re not going in blind.”

“Just remember the conversation we had the other day,” Glimmer said. “You need to let us know if it’s going to be a big deal.”

“And no running off without warning again,” Bow said as he pointed the last of his bagel at her.

Suddenly Glimmer eyes got wide as she said, “You better find out if it’s a big deal as soon as possible. Bow, we leave the planet that week.”

“Wait, that’s that week?” Bow said. “No. That’s a month from now.”

“No, it’s not,” Glimmer said. “Check your calendar if you don’t believe me.”

“Glimmer, I can keep an eye on her if you want,” Izzy said.

“Thanks, Izzy but if I need to I can always task a squad to watch her,” Glimmer said.

“Mom, we’ve talked about that. Don’t send a squad with me or even into the crowd,” Capella said. “It won’t help.”

“Honey, listen, if your Dad and I were going to be here, it’d be one thing but come on,” Glimmer said. “After Poview…”

“The one you all said I handled just fine?” Capella said.

Bow shifted uncomfortably as he said, “I didn’t say that.”

“Dad, come on,” Capella said. “I know you worry but I really did handle it fine. Aunt Catra, you seemed to think so for sure.”

“Guys, she did,” Catra said. “She’s got a honking huge dagger too.”

“That actually doesn’t make me feel better you know,” Bow responded as he tried not to look disapprovingly at Izzy.

“Your wife had a…,” Adora started to say before Bow cut her off.

“I know. She had an entire arsenal when she was Cappe’s age. She wasn’t my child though,” Bow said. “It’s not even the dagger, honestly.”

“It’s the thought of her going into danger, isn’t it?” Izzy said quietly. Bow nodded.

“Dad, I promise I’ll be careful,” Capella said. Catra got suddenly serious as she pointed at Capella.

“Don’t say you promise under this roof unless you mean it,” Catra said.

“I know what I’m saying,” Capella said. “I’ll be careful. I don’t think we’ll have problems. It’s in the afternoon and it’s going to wrap up right before dinner time so it’ll be light out. It’s going to be just a nice gathering. None of us want trouble and we really don’t want to give people the impression that clones mean

trouble. And Dad, Gress will be there. You think I'm going to risk my closest friend?"

Finn finally spoke up as they said, "Hey, what are you all worried about? She's the child of Glimmer and Bow, heir to Bright Moon, who's faced enemies and prevailed, both in combat and in wits. She's smart, she inspires those around her, and she's as solid as the bedrock that holds up her home. She's Capella, Princess of Bright Moon, and I think you all need to not undersell her. Cappe, you got this."

Everyone at the table looked at Finn after they made the pronouncement and then slowly nodded.

"Thanks, Finn," Capella said.

"Just call it like I see it," Finn said.

"And you saw an excuse for a monologue," Adora said.

"Mom, that's not a monologue. That's barely exposition," Finn said. "It's still true."

Bow sighed and Glimmer nodded as she said, "OK. We'll go on the trip and I won't send someone along. However, I am putting a squad on stand-by. Possibly several. If something goes wrong, they're coming to help."

“You do know Wheatland is its own political entity right?” Izzy said. “You’d be invading if you did that without their permission.”

“I can send guards to help the princess,” Glimmer said. “That’s not an invasion, that’s a bodyguard. I’ll happily argue it with them when I get back.”

“Mom, I suppose I can’t talk you out of this?” Capella said.

“No, you can’t,” Bow replied. “I agree with her.”

“Alright,” Capella said. “Just don’t have them in the town. I’m serious.”

“I won’t,” Glimmer said. Breakfast ended shortly afterwards and they all helped get everything cleared. Glimmer pulled Capella to the back porch for a minute.

“Mom, listen, I really will be careful,” Capella said as Glimmer slid the door shut.

“It’s not about that. It’s about Dad…,” Glimmer said as she stopped for a moment to catch her breath. “I’m going to be going to see him as often as I can. Can you do the same? Especially when I’m off planet.”

“Of course,” Capella said and felt a lump in her throat. “You know… he doesn’t… he doesn’t remember me though.”

Glimmer nodded and for a moment couldn’t respond.

“I was ready not to go anymore myself,” she said quietly. “But it’s not just for him, it’s for Mom. Also, I just feel like what if he could remember me, some way, somehow, but knew I had stopped coming… I couldn’t handle that. In the end though, he’s my Dad, I have to be there.”

“I’ll be there as well. I’ll be sure and go and see him regularly,” Capella said.

“Thanks,” Glimmer said and the two hugged each other tight.

Chapter End Notes

Chapter Summary: Capella wakes up at Catra and Adora's house. She has a brief conversation with them before going to the market in the early morning hours. She sees a blonde woman who she feels like she should recognize but it's not popping to mind. Then she meets Sert who tells her that they're going to move the protest at Wheatland up to just two weeks away. When she gets back, they have breakfast and are joined by Izzy and Finn, Izzy in town on Dryl business and Finn just coming along to spend time with family and friends. It ends with Glimmer asking Capella to please try and visit Micah and Angella as much as possible, especially during the time her and Bow are going to be off

planet.
End Chapter Summary

Not much to say on this one. When I first started this, I though, "I'm going to put quotes or lyrics up on each chapter!" I loved books that did that but I may have changed my tune if I knew just how long this was going to be. That being said, this was a chapter with a lyric from Hedwig and the Angry Inch and then I saw Dune and loved the opening line way more for this.

Thank you for reading!

Izzy

Chapter Summary

Izzy goes into Bright Moon to run a few errands,

Chapter Notes

"Dreams do come true, if only we wish hard enough. You can have anything in life if you will sacrifice everything else for it." - J.M. Barrie

Note: No Micah, no summary.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izzy leaned against a cabinet while Finn leaned back into her arms as Melog curled around Finn's feet and Catra caught them up a little on what Melog had told her about how the rebuilding of Krytis was coming along.

"I'll catch you all up in full at dinner tonight," Catra said. "So you're down to see a chip manufacturer?"

"No, she's down to see a chip manufacturer," Finn said with a thumb hooked back. "I'm down to see you all, Ellie, and Grandma. Hang out at the cafe too if I have some time, catch up with some of the old theater people."

"Noted," Catra said as she laughed. "Izzy, is there something wrong with the stuff? Seems odd you'd come down for something routine."

"Nothing is wrong. A few chips out of spec, nothing to freak out about. I just figured I'd come down and chat with the owners," Izzy replied. "I've read it's useful to go face to face with people occasionally so they have that connection."

"A more Izzy comment I can't imagine," Adora said as she lifted her third cup of coffee at her. Izzy nodded at her as Glimmer and Capella came back into the house.

"We're headed out now," Glimmer said. "If I'm not in the throne room soon the kingdom will collapse."

"No, it won't," Bow said. "But you'd think it would the way everyone runs around."

"I keep telling you, step down now," Catra said. "Cappe, you're ready to be queen, right?"

Izzy watched Capella's face go through five different emotions in under a second before she gave a strained laugh as she said, "No. No. Absolutely not."

Glimmer hugged her as she said, "No worries. I'm planning on keeping the job for a while longer."

The three teleported out and Izzy and Finn went on their way. As they walked down the road towards town, they passed the point

that was halfway between her grandmother's house and Catra and Adora's house. Finn stopped there as they said, "Ah, the amount of times we stood here."

"I remember," Izzy said as she pulled them close, remembering all the nights they'd stood there together, not wanting to go back home. "Did you ever think back then we'd end up together for good?"

Finn shrugged as they said, "I thought it was something special but I wasn't sure. I remember when I first told my moms about how I felt, I asked her if she thought it was serious. She said what did it matter? Either it lasted or it didn't but that didn't make it any less important at that moment."

Izzy leaned forward and kissed Finn before saying, "We've had some difficult times, that's for sure, but I would do it all again if it meant being here with you."

"It doesn't matter. Forever is each moment with you," Finn said, placing their head against Izzy's head.

Izzy grinned as she said, "Which play is that from?"

"It isn't," Finn said, their face serious. "It's exactly how I feel."

Izzy's face went soft as she said, "I love you, Finn of Dryl."

“And I love you, Izzy of Dryl,” Finn said before they kissed again and started back down the road. Finn broke off at the turn for Elliepurr’s house and Izzy went on through town. She walked down a side street to a small building that was just opening for the day. She sighed as she reached into her satchel and pulled out her tiara and got it on her head. Izzy muttered under her breath where only her AI, Pat, could hear it.

“Pat, record, scan, and report, please. Activate Handshake program as well.”

As she approached the door, she squared her shoulders up, and took confident strides taking deep breaths as she psyched herself up for what was to come. A person not much more than three and a half feet tall met her at the door with a smile as they said, “Can I help you?”

Izzy gave a professional smile, one she’d worked on, as she said in a level tone, “Certainly. I’m Princess Izzy of Dryl and I’d like to see Koal-id. Could you let him know I’m here and would like to speak with him please?”

“Nice to meet you, Princess Izzy, I’m Kinnick. He and I just got in but it shouldn’t be an issue. Come on in and get comfy,” they said as Izzy stepped in. The front waiting room was full of overstuffed couches and tables like a living room that had multiplied and pushed the walls out. She made her way over to a couch and sat on the edge of it. “I’ll go grab him. Need anything?”

“No, thank you,” Izzy responded.

She heard Pat’s quiet voice giving her status updates through the tiara. Izzy took a deep breath and let herself slip into what she thought of as neutral as she just took in the office, trying not to anticipate anything. She didn’t wait long before a short man, covered in grey fur with large ears and eyes, came out into the waiting room. He was only wearing pants with suspenders and he had his thumbs hooked into them. Izzy immediately picked up a sharp almost medicinal smell coming from him that reminded her of a certain tree that grew out in the Fright Zone and Salineas.

“Princess Izzy, hello!” Koal-id said with a broad smile. “What brings you in so early?”

“Hello,” Izzy said as she stood. “I just wanted to talk about the chips we received from you recently and I was already going to be in town so I thought I’d catch up in person.”

“Come on into my workspace,” he said as he gestured towards a door. They both went into a room where electronics, both in one piece and taken apart, covered a lot of the surfaces. What wasn’t taken up by electronics was covered with papers, take out containers, and little miscellaneous toys. Koal-id picked up a chair, titled it to dump out a frisbee, a stack of papers, and a small spring, before setting it back down and offering it to Izzy.

“Thanks,” Izzy said as she got settled.

“So, what’s up with the chips?” Koal-id said.

“They seem to have a flaw in them,” Izzy responded. Koal-id looked at her as he picked up a few leaves off a small tray on his desk and started chewing on them. The sharp smell Izzy noticed earlier filled the space as she went on. “It’s in every single one. Seemed a bit odd.”

Koal-id swallowed the leaves as he said, “You ordered several thousand. I find it hard to believe that every single one has a flaw.”

Izzy shrugged as she pulled out a single sheet of paper from her satchel. Harpi had helped the team that had examined the chips and he had created a single sheet summary out of the huge amount of information that the team had created.

“My aide made this,” she said as she set it on the desk. “I’ve reviewed it, and the information it was compiled from, and I have to say, it seems correct. Particularly this.”

Izzy had her hand on the paper still and tapped it with her index finger to indicate what she meant. It was a description of part of the architecture in the core of the chip that would allow outside access to anything it was installed in. Considering that most bots had some kind of communication with the planet wide network as well as any local network they were around, it was a flaw that would allow them to be controlled by anyone with the knowledge of the architecture change.

Izzy watched Koal-id as he picked up the paper and read it. The whole thing was couched in very bland language, nothing accusatory, but she could see Koal-id's eyes get a little larger.

"And this is in every chip you received from us?" Koal-id said as he looked up.

"Every chip," Izzy said, keeping her smile on her face as she nodded.

"It doesn't sound like it affects performance," Koal-id said as he pointed at a small chart near the bottom. "In fact, that looks like it specs out a bit higher on all parameters."

"It sure does, doesn't it?" Izzy said, nodding, letting her smile slip a little. "Would have been great to install that, it would have made the bots a bit better; we would have been thrilled if we hadn't checked them out first."

"OK, so what's the problem then?" Koal-id replied.

"First, I don't want that kind of flaw in my bots' architecture. Second, it's like you said, it sure seems weird that flaw is in every single one of the chips. Looks less like a flaw, more like something intentional," Izzy said.

“Now hold on,” Koal-id said. “Those were made by a high-speed fabricator. It’s possible it just turned them out very quickly.”

Izzy shrugged as the smile went completely off her face and she let a neutral expression take its place.

“Maybe.”

She sat there, doing a little mental exercise to keep herself calm, as she waited for Koal-id to respond. About thirty seconds went past before he spoke again.

“Are you really trying to imply that I did this!?”

“That you created these? You did. On a high-speed fabricator. You said so yourself,” Izzy responded.

“It’s a flaw! Like you said!” Koal-id said.

“True, I did say that. We wondered about that so we obtained another few thousand chips from you to test,” Izzy responded.

“What? No you didn’t,” Koal-id said, confused. “No one’s bought that many from us. You’ve been our largest order ever.”

“Yes, I did and I’m not telling you how. Here’s the report on those,” Izzy said as she pulled another sheet of paper out. “Not a single one had that flaw and their serial numbers were on both sides of the run you made for us. Funny thing is, the flaw just showed up in ours.”

Koal-id looked at the report for a moment before carefully setting it back down. He just sat in silence and Izzy could read the uncomfortable look on his face. She stared back at him with a blank face and then heard Pat quietly inform her that the Handshake program had completed. She broke the silence.

“You don’t seem to be trying to defend yourself so I’ll just say this. You’re going to refund us and we’re terminating our contract with you as well of course,” Izzy responded. She saw Koal-id flinch. They’d only ordered from him once, officially, but the contract was the largest his company had by a large margin and had been for continuing support and future purchases. She knew she’d just hit him hard by pulling it back. “Then I have one more request.”

“What?” he said, trying to keep his voice flat but his irritation still creeped in.

“You’re going to tell me if this was something you did on your own or if someone talked you into it,” she said, sitting back as she folded her hands and let her fingers slip up her sleeves a little.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about,” Koal-id said. “It’s a flaw.”

“A flaw that doesn’t show up in any of the other products,” Izzy responded.

“Yes,” Koal-id said. “Things happen.”

Izzy stared at him for a split second before smiling, a wide, warm smile that wouldn’t have fooled anyone who actually knew her, as she stood up.

“That’s good to hear at least,” Izzy said. “I expect the refund promptly. Thank you for your time.”

She turned on her heel and walked out of the office, not waiting for a response. She heard Koal-id curse and something bang off a wall after the door shut behind her. Kinnick was on the other side of the waiting room and doing their best not to look at Izzy as she walked out. Izzy didn’t look at them either. She could feel the awkwardness and she did her best not to show it. Kinnick was second in command at the factory and the decision would affect them as well. Besides, it was only polite after they’d given Snow-by the passwords to the main system that Pat had used to get in with the Handshake program and Izzy never betrayed an asset.

As she walked down the street, Pat chimed in.

“Bot Iota-Mark-23 is reporting damage to its limb and excessive power drain.”

“Tell it to go on back for repair,” Izzy said. “The rest should be more than enough for my envelope.”

She looked towards the bushes where she figured the myriad of small bots that followed her when she was out would hide. She couldn’t see them but if she wanted to, she could flip down the monocle and have Pat highlight their locations for her. She went on along though. They had their job and she knew they’d do it if they were needed. She walked on towards the town square. She’d told Finn she’d met them at the cafe for lunch but first she needed to check in on someone.

“Phone call on Koal-id line to number previously flagged,” Pat said.

“Nice to not be surprised,” Izzy said with a sigh. The number was someone she suspected of working for Aeron. She pulled a small pad of paper from her satchel and made a cryptic note that meant talk to Blu about it but wouldn’t make any sense to anyone else.

After a short walk, she came to the edge of the town square and walked into a small fabric store. The owner, a clone named Dasi, looked up from where he was stacking up some canvas.

“How can I help… oh! Brother Izzy!” he said with a smile.

“Brother Dasi, it’s good to see you,” Izzy said with a responding warm, genuine smile. Dasi walked over and surprised Izzy as he opened up his arms for a hug. The clones at Dryl were generally quiet and reserved for the most part and that was what she was used to but she still happily gave him the hug.

He went back to stocking fabric onto the shelves as he said, “What brings you into my shop?”

“I’m in town seeing family and decided to stop by,” Izzy replied. “How are you doing?”

Dasi’s ears flicked in cheerfulness, his face in relaxed passivity, as he said, “Not bad. Been pretty busy lately. Winter usually is around here, I’ve noticed. People want projects to do on the cold days.”

Izzy tried not to grin as she thought that what constituted a cold day in Bright Moon was at best a bit nippy.

“Understandable,” Izzy replied. “Well, I’m not going to take up a bunch of your time. Just let me know if you need anything.”

“You know, you don’t have to do that for me. I can go to Queen Glimmer,” Dasi said with another cheerful ear twitch.

“I know you can and I’m not saying you can’t but I’m your Brother. I just want you to know I’m there for you,” Izzy said, her hand going up to fiddle with a piece of hair that wasn’t there beside her ear.

Dasi stepped back over to her and put a hand on her shoulder.

“Brother Izzy, we all know how you feel and how hard you work for us. I know you’re there for me if I need it. You don’t have to always be dropping by if you don’t want to do so,” Dasi replied.

“I know I don’t. I like to do so,” Izzy said. “Besides, where else am I going to go to get the fabric I need?”

“There’s a perfectly good shop in Dava that’s closer to Dryl and you know it,” Dasi said as he squeezed her shoulder fondly. “But I won’t argue with you for obvious reasons.”

“The customer is always right?” Izzy said, a bit confused.

“Oh, absolutely not,” Dasi said with a vigorous shake of his head. “Terrible motto. I just don’t want to talk myself out of a sale.”

Izzy laughed as she made some orders for some of her brothers back in Dryl and chatted with Dasi for a little while longer. She left

the shop shortly afterwards and headed towards the community center, location of Finn's former theater in Bright Moon. She walked into it, looking around as memories of the place pushed towards the front of her mind.

Izzy remembered her first night there, scared of what people would think of her, scared of being alone all the time as well, and listening to the stage crew talk back and forth and mustering up the courage right before she left to suggest a change to something. When she came back, she found out they'd taken her suggestion and that gave her a little courage to suggest another and then another and soon she had friends and then she and Finn started talking more and more. Then a relationship, adventure, and discoveries.

Looking back, she could see the arc of her late teen years bending towards the crown of Dryl. It could have gone so many different ways, she knew there were so many different things she could have done instead, but she could see each little point, each choice, along the way that made her what she was now. She wondered what she would be in thirty years while a little dark voice in her head asked if she had that long. She knew very well the people she fought, who'd dance in the streets if she fell and who worked hard to give themselves the reason for that dance.

Izzy shook off thoughts of the past and concentrated on the present as she walked down a hall to a small study room and knocked on the door. A woman a few years younger than Izzy opened it up and looked at her in confusion. Izzy said, "I'm sorry, I was supposed to be meeting Schultz here for the dialogue project."

The woman smiled suddenly as she said, “Schultz couldn’t make it. He had to help his mother with something.”

Izzy groaned as she said, “It’s always something with him. Do you mind if I come in and work on it at least?”

The woman stood aside and held the door open as she said, “Not at all!”

Izzy stepped through and heard Pat whisper in her ear that they’d lost connection to all networks. The woman shut the door as Izzy went and sat down at one of the four chairs around a small table in the room. In the middle of the table sat a silver backpack covered in glitter. Izzy sat her satchel down next to it as the woman sat down across from Izzy.

“Rooms clean and protected,” Blu’s voice said, coming out of the woman.

“Figured,” Izzy responded.

“You should have gone on the stage. You’re good at that,” Blu said, nodding at the door to indicate their passphrase exchange.

“I live next to a theater and I’m married to its manager. It rubs off,” Izzy said. “I don’t have a bunch of time. What do you have for me?”

"Aeron's in Candila. We have no idea why but he's definitely there and has been since pretty much right before Seaweed," Blu responded as she twirled the long brown hair of the form she was wearing. "There's a small group of people there as well. Asked around in the towns and those that would talk said they were working on transforming the area around Mount Candila. The Spirit Ember was destroyed back during the war and they claim they can turn the area back into something habitable. I don't know how, the place is… unpleasant. It's pretty obvious it's a very anti-clone area though."

Izzy sat back in the chair as she thought.

"Why Candila though? I mean, if the Ember was still functional, I could see that but there's nothing there from what I know," Izzy said slowly.

"I don't know," Blu said.

Izzy shook her head as she said, "You have anybody in that area?"

"One and they don't know they work for me. When I say it's anti-clone, I'm not kidding," Blu said.

Izzy thought about what she was going to ask next. She didn't like what she might find out when she did ask it but she finally leaned

forward and folded her hands on the table in front of her as she looked Blu straight in another person's face.

"OK, I have to ask. Did you do that background on Skua?"

"I did. Aquaponic technician. One daughter. Used to have a partner but lost them right after the daughter was born. Guy went out on a search and rescue in the middle of winter and died when a blizzard caught him and the three people with him in the open. She doesn't have any politics as far as we can tell. She was hired by a company that is helping the communities down there around Candila. They want her to come down and set up an aquaponic's greenhouse for a town called Marasville. The company seems to actually do that, they've already got one setup at a town called Liberation, but they seem shady for lack of a better word," Blu said. There was a pause and Izzy was about to speak when Blu went on suddenly. "She's also engaged to your friend Artho so I kind of figured out why you wanted me to check her out."

Izzy's face went still as she said, "I would have wanted to check her out simply because of where she was going."

"You don't have to be cagey on this one. I understand," Blu said. "What do you want me to do?"

"I'm going to have someone else handle this but I've actually already talked with her at a party. Offered her help," Izzy said. "We need to be ready to offer as much as possible."

“You want some leverage on her?” Blu said.

Izzy shrugged as she said, “For what? Intimidation? Threats? I understand the carrot and stick method but people aren’t animals. They expect us to be threatening. I’d rather be helpful.”

Blu shrugged as she said, “Well, no problem. I’m headed up to Wheatland in a few. Rough things have been happening up there and Equal is going to be having a little get to know clones thing there soon.”

“Alright,” Izzy said. “Keep in touch.”

Blu picked up the backpack and reached inside. After a moment, Izzy heard Pat quietly say that they were reconnected to the Etherian network and Blu slung the backpack over her shoulder.

“I’m going to go on now. Tell Schultz I said hello,” Blu said in the woman’s voice again.

“I will. Thank you for your help,” Izzy responded politely. Blu left the room and Izzy leaned back in the chair and sat quietly for about ten minutes before she got up and left, walking towards the town square and over to the cafe. She waved at Finn sitting on the patio with Elliepurr.

“Done with that one meeting?” Finn said, looking around as they walked up to Izzy.

“I am. Thank you for understanding,” Izzy said as she gave them a kiss. Finn smiled as they laced their arm through hers and walked on over to the outdoor table. Izzy heard Pat confirming the integration of her and Finn’s bot envelope as well as the one that followed Elliepurr around.

“Hello, Ellie,” Izzy said as she sat down at the table. “How’re you doing?”

Elliepurr smiled as she ran her fingers over the Braille menu she had.

“I’m doing very well. Finn was just telling me all about the theater,” Elliepurr said as she made a decision and sat the menu down. “So why haven't you visited Nicoletta lately?”

Izzy shook her head as she said, “I’m going to see Grandma today. I had a few things to do first this morning.”

Elliepurr tapped her hand against the table as she said, “You could have done them after you visited her.”

Izzy smiled. The only time she’d known Elliepurr, Finn’s biological mother, to be reserved had been when they had found her in the

back of beyond in the Crimson Waste after having been abandoned there years before. After Finn had brought her back to Bright Moon, she'd gone through a lot of grief and anger but with the help of a Listener she'd managed. Now she was friendly but also not the least bit worried about being outspoken. Izzy found it refreshing. Usually.

"I know but she likes her mornings quiet and besides, she's taking care of June these days. I don't want to be in the way first thing," Izzy said, referring to a friend and former neighbor of her Grandmother.

Elliepurr shook her head but smiled as she said, "I'm just hearing excuses. Go see her."

"I will, Ellie," Izzy said as the waiter came up to the table. They ordered and got to talking about other things. Elliepurr talked about her latest hobby, trying to learn the piano, and told them the next time they visited, she'd have to play something for them. They talked, laughed, and ate and finally after a few hours went their separate ways with hugs and assurances they would see each other soon. As Izzy walked with Finn she knew when Elliepurr was a hundred meters away when she heard her bot envelope split from her and Finn's.

They spent an afternoon at her Grandma's house, playing cards with her and chatting with her and her friend June. June had declined in health and was in a wheelchair most of the time but she was still mentally sharp as can be as she gave all of them a good challenge at the various card games they played. Towards the end of the visit, Izzy asked June if she wanted one of the high-end wheelchairs that Dryl turned out.

“Tried one out already,” she said as she sat back and her wheelchair sighed back a little to hold her comfortably. “I know I probably shouldn’t speak ill of a Dryl product to you but this one is just fine. Too many bells and whistles on yours.”

“June, you’ve known me longer than just about anyone,” Izzy said with a grin. “You can certainly speak ill as you put it. At least now I know that maybe they went overboard on it.”

“Not surprised to be honest,” Grandmother said. “You always made the most intricate models. Not surprising you’d do the same there.”

“I actually don’t have anything to do with that part of Dryl manufacturing,” Izzy said. “That’s just how Dryl is sometimes.”

“Probably why you fit in so well there,” Grandmother said with a smile and a touch of Izzy’s hand. “I’m so happy that you found it.”

Izzy covered Grandma’s hand with her other hand and smiled back at her.

###

The day ended up at Bright Moon with dinner with Glimmer, Bow, and Capella. Catra and Adora showed up, Melog loping along beside them. Elliepurr and Grandma arrived with Izzy and Finn and Izzy grinned to see Grandmother in her finest dress and with the most formal of manners. She'd been to the castle multiple times, her own granddaughter was a princess, but she still reacted to it the same way every time.

Elliepurr in contrast was dressed in brightly clashing patterns and colors and had no problem cutting up with Capella. As to the clothes, she knew exactly what she had done and took great pleasure in it. She'd once told Finn that just because she was blind didn't mean she was going to dress drably. Finn had tried to explain matching patterns and colors and Elliepurr had just laughed, said she'd understood but that the way she thought of them in her head was what pleased her.

After dinner, everyone was standing around in one of the living rooms of Bright Moon and Izzy went over to talk with Capella. Izzy made small talk with her and slowly moved towards the balcony on the side of the room until it was just her and Capella standing at the railing. Izzy leaned against the railing as she watched everyone in the room, working hard to keep a regular expression on her face.

"I saw that you've got something coming up in Wheatland soon," Izzy said.

"We do. It's been moved up," Capella said.

“I know,” Izzy said and then Capella watched as her face lost some of its composure. She didn’t know why but Izzy looked suddenly younger. If Finn had been there, they would have been able to tell Capella that’s because the look on her face was the same she’d had when Finn had first met her. Scared, unsure, but still trying. Izzy put her hand up in her nervous tick as she ran her hand along the top of her ear, feeling the orange and yellow buzzed hair there.

Izzy took a deep breath as she said, “Listen. Something is going on. I don’t know what it is but things are getting unstable. You need to be aware of that.”

Capella’s face got serious as she said, “I know. I’m sure you heard about what went down in Poview.”

Izzy nodded.

“Why didn’t your protections help!?” Capella said, as anger bubbled to the surface. Izzy almost didn’t say something but went ahead and responded.

“I don’t want you to say anything but it’s because the people didn’t come close to Brother Ulip and Brother Hort’s home. I have protection there but the orchard doesn’t have it. I don’t know if the people who did that know that but it still worked out that way.”

Capella said, “Why not? They need it there as well.”

“They have it when they are there,” Izzy said. “And I’d appreciate it if you did not say anything about this.”

“But they took a big loss!”

Izzy hugged her arms close as she said, “They lost things, Cappe. All my brothers who got hit in Poview did and it sucks. The feelings of violation are very real but in the end, it’s just stuff. I will always, and I mean *always,* put my efforts into protecting people. The day you decide that stuff has the same level of concern, or even higher, than people is the day you have lost your way.”

Capella leaned back against the railing then and the two looked into the room where everyone was chatting.

“You’re right,” Capella said grudgingly. “I hate that they all have to feel that though.”

“I do as well,” Izzy said. “It’s why we have our arrangement.”

Capella just nodded as Glimmer came outside.

“What are you two doing looking so grim out here?” Glimmer said with a smile.

“Just talking, Mom,” Capella said.

“I was asking her questions about the whole Equal thing,” Izzy said. “The Clone Council is interested and we didn’t really know much about it.”

Capella did her best to keep the look off her face of shock at such a bold faced lie from Izzy but she managed to just nod.

“I was telling her about the Wheatland thing coming up.”

Glimmer’s smile slipped a little as she said, “I really wish I could be on planet for that.”

“Mom, it’ll be fine,” Capella said with a roll of her eyes.

“Well we’re not going over that right now. You two come on in. We’re going to play a quick board game before everyone leaves,” Glimmer replied.

###

Later that night, Izzy stared at the canvas tent over Finn's old bed at Catra and Adora's house as Finn came out of the bathroom and sat down at their old desk.

"You look thoughtful. Care to share?"

Izzy rolled over to look at Finn as she said, "Just worried."

"You're always worried," Finn said.

"OK, more worried than normal. That one person?" Izzy said and her face went a certain way. Finn immediately knew she was referring to Aeron. "He's off doing something I don't understand and I'm having a hard time figuring it out."

Finn nodded as they said, "Can you do anything about it right now?"

"No, I can't but that doesn't mean I'm not going to worry about it," Izzy said a bit irritably.

Finn came over and she scooted over, taking her blanket with her as Finn lay down and pulled another blanket over themself. She scooted back over to Finn and wrapped her arms around them.

“I know you’re going to worry about it. You think and you worry. Let’s try not to worry about it right this moment though. Breath with me?” Finn asked. Izzy nodded and the two of them took long, deep breaths together for about a minute. Izzy did her best to concentrate on the present moment, Finn in her arms, the quiet peacefulness of the house, and her breathing.

“Better?” Finn said when they finished. Izzy smiled at Finn and kissed them.

“Better,” she said and the two settled down and were soon asleep.

Chapter End Notes

While this chapter serves a few purposes, the biggest one is to feed the Fizzy shippers a little. :)

Aeron

Chapter Summary

Aeron sits in Candila and makes his decision.

Chapter Notes

"I really don't know what you mean / Seems like salvation comes only in our dreams / I feel my hatred grow all the more extreme" Terrible Lie by Nine Inch Nails

Note: No Micah, no summary.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Aeron sat inside what had once been the throne room of the Fire Princess. When he and Carl had arrived, right before the protest at Seaweed, there had been bits of old Horde bots scattered around the room. Now, weeks later, they were finally cleared away as Carl stood beside him and Aeron sat on a block of stone watching the small group of people in front of him. A few of the people were recording and a small drone hovered overhead as well, getting footage.

Aeron thought of all the things that had happened while they'd been in Candila. It had been hard to keep a hand on his network when he'd been so far removed but he'd managed. He'd been able to arrange many things. Some had already happened, some were ongoing, but some had yet to happen. Those in particular filled him with hope. It wasn't much longer before a few things happened in particular and while he was excited about them, he was also worried. He knew that if it went well, like he hoped, then things would start happening quickly. He and Carl had spent several late nights debating if it was a good idea, speeding up, when they were so used to going slowly and carefully.

Aeron hadn’t spent too much time worrying though as living in Candila had been a trial of its own. The area was more than just a desert. As Carl had pointed out, even the Crimson Waste had plants and animals. This area, scoured by magical fire centuries before, had nothing of the sort. Wells were as likely to dry up as keep flowing and food had to be brought in or grown in greenhouses. They had found a few green things growing near the entrance of the castle but they were weak and neither one of them had figured out how in the world they were managing to hang on. Even though the season was moving into winter, the days were hot enough to rival the Crimson Waste but the nights were so cold water would freeze shortly after nightfall.

Aeron had worried that people wouldn’t hang on in the towns around the area because of all this. Some hadn’t. Several small towns had started but didn’t stick it out and nothing remained but a few blocky buildings. The ones who had stayed though, Aeron counted as true believers and confidants, people willing to endure hardship for a belief. He knew he could send them back out into the rest of Etheria to help the cause. He thought of that often but right at that moment, some of those people stood before him and he listened to what they said to him before responding, clearly and slowly for the benefit of the recordings.

"Am I to understand that you wish me to accept this honor from you?"

One of the people stepped forward, a person dressed in heavy red canvas clothes. They stood straight and tall as they adjusted their coat a little.

“Yes. My name is Thorn and I represent the few towns that are within the border of this kingdom,” Thorn said. “We have seen that you have taken up residency here. None of us claim the title of the crown of Candila but we see that you are one who could. As under the Etherian Charter, we built our towns inside of a kingdom, we recognize that we are subject to anyone who makes the claim and fulfills the duties as set forth in the Charter. If you wish, we recognize you as our princess and reject our town's sovereignty in favor of the sovereignty of the Princess of Candila.”

Aeron kept the smile off his face. There were other things he had to do before the title was fully legitimate but he and Carl had read the Charter’s sections on princesses and what they were and how they were recognized and were sure this would work. It even had a section on previously unrecognized princesses joining the Princess Council. Aeron was quite confident he’d be recognized by them and allowed to sit on the Council and if they didn’t allow it, well, he had plans for that as well.

“I accept this title,” Aeron said, uttering words that had been rehearsed over and over until they flowed naturally from him. “I will lead you, protect you, judge you, and above all, be brave in my defense of you.”

Thorn turned around to someone behind them who gave them a tiara. It was fancy, with two large wings sweeping back along the sides and pointing up from the back. The whole thing was sculpted from bright red metal, with rubies inset all throughout it. Thorn stepped forward and held the tiara out to Aeron.

“Then accept the crown of Candila,” Thorn replied. “Hidden for centuries, it is decorated with bits of the Fire Ember itself and was

found among these ruins only weeks ago. It has revealed itself now because someone worthy of it, someone who'd rule this kingdom well and bring Mara's dream to fruition, has come forward. Accept this crown as a physical symbol of your title of Princess of Candila. Lead us! Lead us to the dream and to the future!"

Aeron managed to look humble and Carl managed not to snicker as he had before, instead bowing his head to look humble. The tiara had been made by Thorn. The tiara didn't matter for recognition by the Charter but Aeron wasn't doing this just for the Charter. The video they made now would go out when he approached the Princess Council to be accepted so that the whole planet could see. He fully understood that symbols and imagery powerfully shaped what others thought of as the truth and the tiara, and the legend they were building around it, was one such symbol. He reached out and took it from Thorn's hand and held it before him for a moment, frowning on the outside while laughing on the inside.

"I am full of trepidation at the task set before me but I have accepted and so…,"

Aeron stood up and held the tiara out in front of him as if inviting everyone to see and inspect it. Then he brought it up to his head and rested it there, where it fit perfectly.

"I am Aeron, Princess of Candila, and I am proud to be your ruler."

The crowd cheered as Aeron put his arm around Carl, both their faces somber until the filming came to a halt and only then did Aeron allow a huge smile to break across his face.

"Good work everyone! I'm proud of you all. We will see our dream sweep over this planet; the dream of Mara, a dream of protection for all of us and our children and their children to come. We will see it forward! Mara was right!"

The crowd cheered and shouted back at him, "Mara was right!"

Aeron leaned over from where he stood on the block of stone to Carl and kissed him.

"I love you. I'm glad you're by my side for this."

"I love you too."

Later that evening, they both sat curled up in their sleeping bags in a small chamber off what they thought of the throne room. A lantern cast light around the room as Carl fiddled around on his data pad, his coat hung around his shoulders.

"OK, we got confirmation that Wheatland is going to happen for sure and that it has been moved up. This works out really well for us too."

“How so?” Aeron said, putting down a book he’d been reading.

“The Queen and King will both be off planet when it happens,” Carl said with a grin.

Aeron sat up a little as he looked at him.

“Seriously?”

“I wouldn’t joke about this,” Carl responded. “Also, remember that thing we handed over to Iceson to work on?”

“That tracking thing we dug up out of that old pre-Prime Horde data dump?” Aeron said.

“The very one. It works,” Carl said. “Said she tested it out too.”

Aeron stared at the ceiling in silence for a moment before he said, “I feel like we need to take advantage of this moment. That plan we had on hold for Princess Capella? Is everything in place?”

“Except for those last minute things, yes,” Carl said. “You think we should go ahead with it?”

“Yes. What we had planned for Wheatland will be perfect cover for it and all of this is too good not to take advantage of,” Aeron said.

“Agreed. I’ll send out the orders now, Your Highness,” Carl said with a grin.

Aeron rolled his eyes but his smile was full of warmth and happiness.

“Finally. We can really get moving.”

Chapter End Notes

This is a short chapter so I figured I'd go ahead and post it because I know everyone was missing Aeron so much.

Various

Chapter Summary

Presented are a some short viewpoints from various characters in the story.

Chapter Notes

"Tomorrow we'll discover / What our God in Heaven has in store! / One more dawn / One more day / One day more!" One Day More from Les Miserables

Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Artho stood outside the small stone building that she, Skua, and Puffin had been given by the town for a home. She was bundled up in cold weather gear against the chill of the night as she looked up at the night sky of Etheria and thought about her friends. She missed them and the ache of missing them felt sharper than she expected because she had a feeling she wouldn't have many friends in Marasville. The town's people had been thrilled to see Skua, Artho thought, but they had just been polite to her. Not rude that she could put her finger on but she could tell they weren't really thrilled she was there. She'd run into that before, people disliking her because she was a princess or even occasionally because she was a Listener.

Artho heard Skua come out of the little house and come up behind Artho. Artho put her arm out and Skua, a blanket wrapped around her shoulders, leaned into her.

“You’ve been out here for a while,” she said, her voice quiet in the still night air. “You OK?”

“Just thinking,” Artho said. “Puffin go to sleep already?”

“Yeah. I told her you’d come in and check on her. She likes it when you do that,” Skua said and gave Artho’s hand a little pat. “So do I.”

Artho wanted to say she knew it was because Puffin had lost a parental figure at an early age and that she did it to help give her that structure and reassurance but that was her work mind thinking and giving justification to a deeper feeling. She did it because she loved that little girl and she wanted to be sure she was OK before Artho went to bed herself.

“And I like to do it,” Artho said, hugging Skua.

“I can’t believe that you grew up in Plumeria,” Skua said after a moment of quiet.

“Why so?” Artho said, looking down with a surprised look on her face.

“You stand around outside when it’s freezing like this,” Skua said. “You did it at our old place in the Snows too.”

Artho shrugged as she said, “Well, I did live in the Fright Zone too. That gets pretty cold in the winter.”

Skua shrugged, not saying it didn’t like the Kingdom of Snows did, and just said, “Still surprises me.” The two stood in silence for a little bit before Skua went on. “You seem a bit out of sorts though. What’s bothering you?”

Artho grinned at her as she said, “You shouldn’t notice my moods so much.”

Skua put a hand on Artho’s stomach with a smile as she said, “You’re my partner. It’s going to happen.”

Artho shrugged again as she said, “I’m missing my friends. I was thinking about all the times we spent outside at night chatting. I’m just worried that I won’t make friends here honestly but that’s probably just my anxiety about a new situation manifesting itself.”

“I don’t know, they seemed so friendly when we arrived,” Skua said. “I’m sure we’ll find some common interests.” Artho smiled at her as she leaned down to kiss her and then put her hands on the sides of her face. Skua squealed a little at Artho’s cold hands as she laughed and said, “Oh! Why!?”

“You’re so warm!” Artho said and kissed her again.

Skua sighed contently as she said, “Well stop standing outside getting cold. Come on inside.”

Artho nodded and they went inside, hand in hand.

###

“Let us have a moment of quiet to honor the Nameless Ones,” Hort said. He sat at the table in the dining room with his partner Ulip and their child Gress. The three sat silently and Hort thought about the brothers he’d had while still serving Horde Prime. He’d seen many die, tossed aside, in the conquest of one world or another. At the time, he’d believed it was the way things always were and should be. He only lived to serve Prime. Those who died did so in the glory of His name and thus did not need one.

Now, sitting at the table, looking at Gress dressed in some outlandish top that Gress had borrowed from Capella, he found it hard to imagine that he had ever believed such a thing. Hort knew that if he fell, Gress would remember him as would Ulip and many others. He refused to even think about if Gress fell and when the little thought snuck into his head, he shook his head as if to clear it and said a high-pitched word that meant, “This is over” in the language of their distant ancestors.

The three began to serve one another from the central bowl in the middle of the table. Tonight was soup, made by Gress from a recipe he said he’d learned at Bright Moon, and Hort found it a bit

odd. The bread though he found more than made up for it as he tore a piece off and set it on Gress' plate.

"Brother Gress, I cannot help but notice that you have packed an overnight bag," Ulip said as they began to eat. "Are you going to be staying over somewhere?"

"Yes, Brother Ulip," Gress replied. "Capella and I will be going to Wheatland soon for the meeting I informed you about. I wanted to get a head start."

"That's not for several more days," Hort replied. "Are you perhaps not getting ahead of yourself?"

"No. I am nervous and that gave me something to concentrate on," Gress said as he dipped his bread into the broth.

"Why are you nervous?" Hort said. "Do you worry something may happen?"

Gress did not answer at first and Hort began to feel restless as the little thought from earlier pushed at him. Gress finally looked at him and said, "I wish I could say that I think nothing shall come of this but you have taught me to never lie, especially to myself. We are going because there have been problems there as we have had here and there is an active group speaking out. We wish to show that town they have nothing to fear but…"

Hort watched Gress trail off as he looked down at the bowl of soup in front of him.

"But you fear," Hort said simply as Ulip scooted his chair over a little to put a hand on Gress' arm.

"I fear," Gress said looking back up.

"You do not have to do this," Ulip said. "Are you sure you're making the best decision? Have you examined it properly?"

"I have. It is a just cause, in defense of my brothers and I will not back down. I make this decision as an individual, free and unblinded," Gress said. Ulip gave a sad smile.

"And I believe you," Ulip said. "Be careful, please. You never know when you think you're seeing clearly but in fact are approaching something you never would have thought of."

"Of course," Gress said.

"Never doubt that we are here for you," Hort said. "We are your caretakers and we will always be there for you, no matter what happens."

"I know you are," Gress said and smiled. Hort and Ulip both moved their ears, while their faces remained more neutral. Hort thought about that as everyone helped clear up later. Gress had picked up many mannerisms from Capella. He thought for a moment if maybe he shouldn't be worried about that, about Gress losing something, but then thought about the past that Ulip and Hort came from and realized that they had passed on everything Gress needed from that. A smile was a lovely thing and he hoped he'd see it on Gress' face for a long time to come.

###

Prickly Pear sat out in the meadow in front of the Heart Blossom, meditating. She'd received an invitation to come to Wheatland from Capella and she didn't know what she was going to do. On the one hand, she wanted to. She knew it was the right thing but on the other she was worried about being a good princess for her kingdom. Perfuma was talking about stepping down soon and that would mean that Prickly Pear would take her place. Plumeria had tried to remain neutral when possible and she thought it was something she should carry on. She tried to just let her mind relax and not focus on thoughts but she kept thinking about how she should try and do something. She didn't know what though.

Finally she sighed and stood up and walked over to the Heart Blossom and placed her hand on it. She felt the energy run through her as she did, warm and inviting, and thought about her Mom and remembered when Perfuma had confided in her once that she was afraid of her power. That when she fought, it was easier to just let the magic flow and that sometimes she worried about losing control. Prickly Pear didn't know what that was like.

She'd never fought before, not like either one of her moms had fought. She wondered now in the darkness if she'd ever know and a little part of her seemed deeply interested in that idea. That part scared her and in that moment, she had an idea of what her Mom had meant.

###

Finn sat in their office at the theater as they wrapped up the few things they needed to do for the evening. They'd just come off a show a few days before and didn't have anything scheduled to start for a few more weeks. Most of the theater troupe had packed up and gone out on vacation and the theater was quiet. Every once in a while, Finn would hear a little click or some other random noise and grin as they thought of the various stories of ghosts in the theater. They loved the feeling, that the theater didn't ever truly feel empty, and even though they didn't truly believe in ghosts they wanted to just because of that.

They stood and stretched and shut off the lights in their office and walked slowly through the backstage area. A few little bots scurried around, doing whatever it was that bots in Dryl did. Finn knew a few of them were housekeeping and some were maintenance but there were a few that they could never figure out. They'd asked Izzy about them before and she'd looked at them for a moment before shrugging.

"Lot of those around," she'd said. "Entrapta made a lot of bots and honestly, I think some of them were just for the joy of making bots. They just exist."

Finn watched a few just running back and forth and smiled. Bots didn't feel emotion but who was Finn to deny them whatever it was they were doing? They were about to walk back to the troupe's dorm area when they thought they heard someone in the main theater. They took a detour and walked out onto the stage, where the ghost light illuminated the stage and the orchestra pit. Finn's eyes could see out into the dimness of the theater and they saw Izzy sitting in the back.

"Iz? You alright?" Finn said as they walked to the edge of the stage.

Izzy looked up with a tired smile.

"Yeah, I'm ok. Sorry. I didn't mean to bother you."

"You're never a bother, you know that," Finn said as they carefully dropped down into the orchestra pit from the edge of the stage and started walking towards her. "What brings you in here?"

"Just needed a quiet place," Izzy said. Finn didn't say anything else until they were sitting down next to her. The seat sensed their general body shape and adjusted to fit them as Finn took her hand, noticing her data pad sitting in her lap and a little ear piece on that linked to it, as they both leaned back and looked out at the empty theater.

"I still can't believe this is real sometimes," Finn said.

“I think that a lot about the stuff that’s happened to me since I met you,” Izzy said, squeezing Finn’s hand. Finn could see she was worried about something but didn’t press her. They just let her sit in the quiet of the theater. After a little while, she leaned over against them and Finn put their arm around her, hugging her close as she let out a long sigh.

###

Carl finished reading the packet before him finally. It was late at night and he’d been working on the packet of information they were going to submit to prove that Aeron had rightfully taken the crown of Candila. Aeron’s claim was supported by references to the various parts of the Etherian Charter referring to new princesses but the part that Carl particularly liked was where they used a survey that Adora herself had created based on old information that defined the boundaries of the kingdom. Carl liked that idea of being able to say, “Well, you yourself said it was right here. We’re just taking your word for it.”

He pushed back from the small desk that had been brought into the space they were using as a bedroom, picked up the small battery powered lamp, and went over to the small jug of water that sat beside the block of stone they’d been sleeping on. Aeron was sprawled out of his sleeping bag, his chest rising and falling slowly in his sleep as Carl took a long drink from the jug’s spout and then closed it back up, careful not to spill any. It still shocked him, the preciousness of water in this area, and he was glad they wouldn’t be in Candila much longer. He even dared to dream that they’d be in Bright Moon in not too long and then after that be able to have their pick of places to live.

Carl kicked off his boots and lay down on the pad next to Aeron, pulling a sleeping bag over himself as he turned off the lamp and sat it down beside the block. He ran over the upcoming plan for Wheatland and felt a solid lump sit in his stomach. He had known fear for years now, ever since they'd started this, but this was different. This wasn't slow and steady, this would be a leap forward and he could only hope that they wouldn't fall flat on their faces.

He rolled over in the darkness, just barely able to pick out Aeron's form and thought about when he'd first met him. Carl had never thought that his love would take him to here but he was glad it had. He lay a hand on Aeron's arm, careful not to wake him, as he thought about that. He knew love could change so many things and he hoped their love for each other and for Etheria would be able to bring about the change they dreamed about. As he drifted off to sleep, that dream was in his head and he couldn't help but smile.

Chapter End Notes

I love these little montages as we see what's going on with various characters. Thank you for reading!

Capella

Chapter Summary

Capella and Gress go to Wheatland for the next gathering.

Chapter Notes

"Eight miles high, about to fall / And no one there to catch you" Sign of the Southern Cross by Black Sabbath

Note: Brief description of Micah and family reactions in this story (a few paragraphs), summary at end

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Wheatland. It was a small town that had been under Horde control for years. Then after the Fall of Prime, they'd looked around, realized they were surrounded by rolling prairie, noticed they weren't actually inside the newly agreed upon kingdom boundaries for the Fright Zone, or any other kingdom for that matter, and ran with it. It, in this case, being grain farming. The town had grown a bit but the main focus of the town were the rolling grain fields and the huge grain storage bins on the edge of town, towering over anything else in the area, certainly helped drive that point home.

Capella stood outside the meeting hall they had rented and watched a fine drizzle falling from a gray sky, the grain elevators barely visible in the mist. People were coming into the event, hanging around and talking and visiting some booths, while a few speeches were given. Capella had been nervous from the start, something she'd briefly talked about with her Grandmother Angella the day before when she'd visited her.

She'd just seen Micah and he'd gone to lay down to rest. Capella had helped him, as he kept asking her why she wasn't dressed for her job as a nurse. Capella had just smiled until she got back into the living room and fell into a chair. Tears streaked her face as Angella sat down beside her.

"I'm sorry," Capella said.

"Don't be," Angella replied as she placed an arm around Capella. "I know I cry plenty as well."

"I know and I should be supporting you," Capella said. "Not weeping on your couch."

"He is dear to you as well. It's alright," Angella said as Capella looked over and saw tears in her eyes as well. Capella hugged her tight and she remembered that moment, that feeling of care and warmth, as she stood outside in Wheatland looking across the street at a small but growing crowd holding signs that weren't subtle about their dislike of clones.

She hoped Gress didn't see any of it. Not just because of the message but because he was already nervous and she didn't want anything that might make it worse.

“More showed up, huh? Kind of makes me wish the town hadn’t planted those trees,” Sert said, nodding at the broadleaf trees that kept the drizzle off the crowd.

“They’d bring umbrellas then,” Capella said, her voice flat.

“You’re a ball of light today,” Sert responded.

“I just watched a whole family, kids and all, join the crowd,” Capella said. “I’m not feeling real cheerful right now.”

“Right now you say, as if you haven’t been like this all day,” Sert said as they looked at the crowd.

Capella shrugged. She wasn’t sure why she was the way she was but it could be the conversation she’d had with the Bright Moon guard sergeant who’d been assigned by her mom to protect her. Sergeant Clo had spoken with her that morning over the data pad and tried to give her all kinds of advice for what to do if things went badly that day. Most focused around staying safe until her and her squad showed up. That had put Capella in a jittery frame of mind when she’d already been so, especially when Sergeant Clo had given her a special code phrase. Clo’s serious face rested in Capella’s mind as she remembered what she’d said after she’d made sure Capella had it memorized.

“I may have to send someone in after you who’s not in uniform or isn’t me,” Clo said. “This way you’ll be able to know they’re

authorized. Only my squad and you know that phrase so don't go with anyone who can't give it."

Capella had stayed the night in a little inn on the edge of town with Sert, Gress, Aden, and Laho. Everyone had seemed on edge, Sert making weird jokes, Gress silent as he dove into books, and Aden and Laho occasionally drifting off in the middle of a conversation. She had tried to chalk it up to the cramped room arrangement but she knew better. It'd been the worry about the upcoming event and the worry hadn't been relieved when they'd caught a glimpse of her dagger in her bag.

Now, standing on the front walk of the building, Capella felt weird with it strapped across her back with a beautiful blue coat over the whole thing, tailored to keep it from showing. When she'd gone to the Bright Moon tailor to have it made a few days before, she was sure they'd tell her no or give her a talking too but they'd just nodded, took measurements, and delivered it later that day. She'd almost not taken it with her though. It'd been a last minute decision to bring it and had put the dagger into her bag with the coat. Watching the crowd now, she hated that she felt a little better that she had it as she ran her hands over her green pants a little before she made herself stop.

"I don't like this," Capella said. "We didn't have that kind of thing at the other places. I wish we had Coalfire's group here."

"She was busy and besides you did have a crowd at Poview that one night," Sert said. "That came off just fine didn't it?"

“And I guess we managed at Poview the first time,” Capella said, nodding slowly.

“And at Seaweed and we did that one without even a fight,” Sert said.

“Hey, there wasn’t one at Poview the second time,” Capella said.

“True,” Sert said and went quiet as they watched a few more people join the crowd across the street. Capella took heart in that it seemed like for every person that joined that crowd, at least two or three seemed to be coming into their event.

“Well come back in,” Sert said. “You look like a freaking guard out here, the way you’re standing and staring at people. You and Gress are supposed to be the friendly face of this.”

“I know, I know,” Capella said as she followed Sert into the building. Inside the foyer, a few of the local businesses, clubs, and other social groups, both clone and otherwise, had set up tables and were talking about what they did as well as selling some stuff. She didn’t really recognize anyone but she knew that a lot of the Equal group people were in the main auditorium giving speeches and panels or sitting behind the curtain waiting their turn.

They made their way through the crowd and down a side hallway to a little unmarked door. Inside Capella smiled to see Gress sitting and talking with a few people. He looked up, his face

lighting up as he waved at her. She sat down beside him as he introduced her to the three clones, two caretakers to the third, he was talking with and then went on talking about some philosophical thing he was thinking about. The two caretakers looked a bit lost but polite but the younger clone, probably a few years younger than Gress, seemed fascinated and Capella thought maybe even a little star-struck.

"Sorry to cut you off, Gress, but I'm utterly lost," Capella said, jumping in when Gress stopped for a moment.

"Sorry, I do tend to ramble about this a bit," Gress responded. "Brothers, I hope you forgive me for taking up your time."

"Not at all, Brother Gress," one of the caretakers responded. "Brother Krist had heard you would be here and insisted that we allow him to come. At the risk of embarrassing him, he is very interested in you."

Capella turned and looked at Gress with a surprised look on her face as she said, "I didn't know you had a following, buddy."

Gress' ears went down a little as he blushed and the caretaker responded.

"A lot of our Brothers in Poview have spoken of his impassioned speech that drove them to action," he said. "We are all proud of him."

The younger clone finally spoke up, and Capella almost laughed at the awestruck voice that came out.

"Did you really stand fearlessly before a mob by yourself that night and face them down?"

Gress shook his head as he said, "No, Brother Krist. I simply held a data pad so everyone could see. I can also assure you that I was very much afraid but I stood with my Brothers and my best friend. They gave me the courage to do what I did."

Gress put an arm around Capella as he said best friend and gave her a hug. Capella hugged him back as she said, "Don't let him sell himself short. He stood there in plain sight with nothing but a data pad between him and that mob. Sure, we were there, but he was right out front, nothing but a thin layer of electronics as his shield. He's braver than he gives himself credit for."

Gress blushed harder as she said that and Krist clapped his hands together as he said, "I knew it!"

"Cappe, please," Gress said quietly.

"OK, OK, he's being humble," Capella said. "I'll lay off."

The two caretakers stood up then as one of them said, “We’re going to start heading home now. Thank you for everything you’re doing here.”

Gress just nodded but Capella said, “It’s worth it.”

As they started to step away, Krist stopped and turned around suddenly.

“Brother Gress?”

Gress looked towards him.

“Yes, Brother Krist?”

Krist was holding up a small data pad as he said, “May I have a picture with you and Princess Capella please?”

Capella smiled at Krist as she said, “I’m fine with it. Gress?”

Gress nodded with a shy smile and Krist handed his data pad to his caretaker and quickly came over. Capella stood up and scooted over a little so that Krist could stand in the middle. Capella almost laughed as she realized that Krist, even though younger than her and Gress by several years, was towering over her just like Gress

did and almost considered standing in the middle herself instead. As the caretaker lined up the shot, Capella said, “Make sure you at least get my head in the shot.”

The caretaker’s ears twitched with amusement as he said calmly, “I assure you, you are in the shot. Barely.”

Capella laughed and the picture was snapped. The caretaker showed them and she gave him her data pad address so he could send her a copy.

“Thank you for taking time for us,” he said.

“It’s why we’re here,” Gress responded. The three left, with Krist waving at them as they went out the door. Gress sat back down with a sigh.

“How come you didn’t tell me you were a big deal?” Capella said with a grin as she sat down next to him.

“Because of this reaction,” Gress said, pointing at her grin.

“Come on! You deserve that appreciation!” Capella said as Sert and Tropistar came over to sit down beside them.

“What appreciation?” Sert said.

“Those people who just left, the kid was thrilled to meet Gress,” Capella said as Gress blushed again and covered his face halfway with his hand. “He’s got a reputation in the clone community now!”

Tropistar, wrapped up in multiple layers of clothing including a scarf wrapped around the fin on his head, gave a toothy grin as he said, “I’d heard about that recently. You should be proud, dude! That’s pretty sweet!”

“I’m not doing this for personal glory,” Gress said.

“I know you’re not buddy but come on, you stood tall at Poview the first time while the rest of us were still trying to figure stuff out,” Tropistar said. “Then you did it again. You’re pretty awesome in my book.”

“The first time was because Cappe told me what to do. In fact, the second time was as well,” Gress said. “I just listened to her and trusted her.”

“Doesn’t matter,” Capella said. “You still did it and did it well. Come on. Be proud.”

Gress just shook his head, his face neutral, but Capella could see his ears perked up and she gave him a quick hug.

"There you go," Capella said.

Tropistar reached forward and squeezed Gress' shoulder.

"Alright, everyone, how about we go out and do what we came to do instead of sitting around in here?" Tropistar said.

"You sure?" Capella said. "You seem like you're hiding inside of all those clothes."

"Because it is *cold!* " he said, dramatically wrapping his arms around himself. "I'm used to warmth drenched beaches."

Sert snorted as they said, "You normally never leave your house except for these things."

"I have sand in my house and a skylight," Tropistar said, trying to exude affronted dignity. "That's a warmth drenched beach."

Gress patted the side of Tropistar's arm, his hand sinking into the outer layer of a wool sweater, as he said, "I agree. It sounds lovely."

Tropistar grinned as he said, “When this is all said and done, we should go there and relax.”

“Deal but you gotta come to Bright Moon and hang out sometime,” Capella replied.

“Can do,” Tropistar replied. “Now I’m going to head out to the crowd. See you all there.”

He headed on out, stooping a little so his fin would clear the doorframe, and Capella took a deep breath as she looked at the clock and realized her and Gress were going to go on stage soon to talk. Sert noticed and said, “You ready? You know what you’re going to talk about?”

“I thought we could talk about how we both met,” Gress said. “Then just talk about hanging out together I guess and our friendship. Maybe questions. I’m still not sure on this whole thing to be honest though.”

Sert nodded as she said, “It would have been nice to have more time.”

Capella shrugged as she said, “It’s the first time doing this. I think the day has been pretty good so far so even if we mess up, we’ll just do better next time.”

“That’s the spirit,” Sert said.

The three left the room and started roaming around. Sert ended up talking with some people she knew and Capella and Gress waved at Aden and Laho while they made the round of the various tables in the front. It was late afternoon and the place was crowded, Capella figuring that between the weather and really nothing going on in the town, it was a good place to come hang out. She looked at the clock again and realized they’d probably need to head back to get ready to go out on the stage when she heard some raised voices over the crowd. At first, she didn’t think anything of it but then the crowd went a little quiet and she felt her stomach drop as the voices got louder.

“And I said keep your damn hands off of me!” she heard someone’s voice yell.

“Gress, what is that?” she said. Gress was looking out over the crowd towards the source of the yelling and replied.

“It’s a few people standing in front of the baker's table,” Gress said, referring to one of the clones who’d set up a table. “They’re shouting at him and a few other people are coming to his defense.”

“We have to get this calmed down,” Capella said, her gut beginning to roll.

“Cappe, we should stay out if it,” he said, putting a hand on her shoulder. “Besides, there are plenty of people there right now. It looks like they’re getting the shouting people out.”

Capella could see the crowd shifting and could just barely see the small group leaving the building, all of them shouting and yelling the whole time about how the baker was a liar. A clone was in the small group ushering them politely out. A few people by the double doors were hauling them open to let them pass and as soon as they did the original person that Capella had heard yelling seemed to fall forward into the clone. They suddenly screamed and staggered backwards, clutching at their forehead.

“What!? Why did you do that!?" the person screamed, while the clone stopped. Capella could see the confusion on the clone’s face but it was subtle, their face looking just expressionless to most people. The clone held his hands up and said something that Capella couldn't hear.

“Is that blood?” Capella suddenly said as she saw a stream start running down the loud person’s face.

Gress nodded but couldn’t speak as he looked away from the sight. The person’s friends saw it and started yelling at the clone, asking what he’d done to their friend as they grabbed their friend and hurried out the door. The people on the door let it close and a silence went over the room for a moment before someone said, “What on Etheria was *that* all about?”

A few people chuckled and the crowd started talking again but Capella couldn't shake the feeling that something bigger was happening than just a little argument.

"Gress, stay here," she said as she got ready to teleport.

"Hang on," Gress said, grabbing her arm. "What are you about to go do?"

"Something is going on," Capella said. "I'm just going to go take a look."

"Don't," Gress said. "I'm sure it's not a big deal."

"He was bleeding," Capella said, gesturing at the door where the group had left. "There's no way he should be but he was. Something fishy is going on."

Capella could see the look on Gress' face, that he wanted to know more but also just wanted to let it go, write it off, and go on their way.

"Maybe send someone else," Gress said. "We have to be up for our talk in a minute."

“Gress, they can wait,” Capella said. Gress was about to say something else when a huge thud sounded at the front doors. Then several more in quick succession and then one of the windows shattered out as a chunk of cinder block flew through it. Then she heard the crowd screaming in anger outside as people inside started screaming in fear.

Capella felt everything slow down, like the world was just suddenly crystal clear, and she looked around, taking in the room. She didn’t realize this was from fear, that her body was getting her ready to either fight or flee and as the heir to Bright Moon, daughter of Glimmer, there was only one answer to such a question. She grabbed Gress, teleported him back to the auditorium and dropped him on the stage in front of the microphone, causing the person on the microphone at the time to scream.

“Give him the mike, now!” Capella yelled over the din of the crowd struggling to get into the auditorium as anger coursed through her and sparks started raining down from her hair. She heard the sounds of more shattering glass as the person dropped the microphone and ran for it. Gress fumbled it up off the ground, his eyes huge.

“Get them into the auditorium?” he said.

“No. Tell them to go for the exits,” Capella said. “Try to keep it orderly. I’ll be back for you.”

"Be careful," Gress said, putting his hand on the side of her face for a split second as she nodded and teleported out.

Capella appeared again in the front room and it was already chaos. The crowd inside had tried to keep the door shut but people were coming in through the windows and fights had broken out. The crowd from outside had broken down the poles of their signs and were using them as clubs while the people inside fought with whatever they could get their hands on. Capella thought about pulling the dagger at that point but she didn't think indiscriminately stabbing in tight quarters would be helpful. Then she saw a group of five descend on two clones cowering behind a table and start beating at them.

She teleported over and immediately punched one of the attackers in the back. He screamed and she took advantage of him arcing back to grab the top of his head and yank him backwards so he fell. She stepped forward, kicking the man as he hit the ground, and punched the next person in front of her in the side of their face. The person staggered backwards screaming curses and the rest stumbled backwards to see who was attacking them.

Capella was tempted to take the rest on but she managed to keep her head. She teleported next to the two clones and grabbed them both. She wasn't used to taking multiple people, had only done it a few times and it'd been a strain, but she figured now was as good a time as any to practice.

"Hang on!" she screamed and then teleported them to the stage. She could feel the pull on her as she did and popped next to Gress breathing heavy. She could hear his even voice, calling for

calm and asking people to head towards the exit but it didn't seem to be helping. Then she saw Sert stumbling up onto the stage.

"Gress, Cappe! Stop sending them to the exits! People are waiting outside for them! It's making it worse!"

Gress stopped and turned to Capella, his face terrified and his ears drooped low, as he waited to see what she would say.

"Has anyone called the guard!?" Capella shouted back at Sert.

"We have but we got cut off! None of the data pads seem to be connecting!" Sert shouted back.

"Get them into the auditorium, Gress," Capella said. "Sert! Go find out if the back door from the backstage is open!"

"I already know it isn't!" Sert said. "I was just there!"

"Wait one!" Capella said and teleported backstage. She saw three people leaning into the double doors, holding a table across them, as it boomed with someone bashing on it from the other side. A group of people were cowering around the room and they all turned to look at her, standing there for a moment, an angry grimace on her face as a shower of sparks fell around her.

“You three!” she said pointing at the people on the door as she stepped over to them. She had no idea who they were but they all nodded at her. She watched as they moved back a little as the door flexed again under the blows from outside. “Do not let them pass but you won’t have to hold long. We’re going out this way in just a few.”

“There’s a group waiting outside there,” one of the people, a large muscular woman, said. “They’re armed.”

Capella’s grin was feral and threatening as she reached behind her and drew out her dagger.

“So am I.”

“We’ll hold, Your Highness,” one of the others said with an answering grin full of fear and bravado. Capella nodded once and teleported back. People were streaming into the auditorium and Sert’s eyes went huge as she saw Capella with blade in hand.

“Go to the back, tell the three holding the door we’ll be on our way,” Capella said. Sert nodded and went running. Fights were taking place at the door and Capella saw people falling. She put her hand on Gress’ shoulder and he leaned down to her. She took the microphone and shut it off for a moment.

“We’re going to rush the back door,” Capella said. “Once we’re out, there’s that big field behind that we can spread out and run. They don’t have enough people to keep us from going across.”

Gress was about to say something when the sounds of screaming suddenly picked up an extra horrified noise and Capella turned to see smoke. Not much, but enough. She switched the microphone on and yelled, “This way! There’s a back door this way!”

She dropped the microphone, grabbed Gress with her free hand and teleported to the back. She slashed the rope holding the curtain up separating the backstage from the front and watched it fall.

“Go for the door, Gress. I’ll be right there,” Capella said. She waved at the crowd and shouted and they flowed towards her. She jumped to the door.

“Good job! Just a second longer!” she shouted at them. Sert was leaning against it, their eyes wide as Capella looked at the door for a moment. It was simply sheet metal, dimpled from the smashing outside. She looked at the blade for a moment and figured what she was thinking would work. She took the dagger in both hands and shoved it as hard as she could through the door right as it boomed again under an impact. She heard yelling outside, yanked the dagger back out with the idle thought wondering if she’d need to sharpen it after this, and then did it again. Then she saw the crowd was almost on them.

“Move!” she shouted.

Sert and the other three moved, dropping the table and Capella stepped forward and yanked the doors open. On the other side stood about ten people with sledgehammers and pry bars. Capella screamed defiant rage in their face and charged dagger point first at them, Gress right on her heels. Sert and the door guards were right with her as she charged forward and the ten dropped their weapons and fled. As they did she grabbed Gress and teleported them both into the middle of the field.

"Wave and shout to get their attention so they head this way," Capella said but Gress had already got the idea and was doing so. The crowd streamed across the field.

"I'll be right back!" Capella said before teleporting back into the building.

The place was in shambles and smoke drifted through the halls. She couldn't tell if the building was on fire or not but she went room to room, teleporting, to make sure no one was trapped. She saw people laying on the ground and made a mental note to try and come back for them. No one seemed to be in the building anymore, except for the injured, and the quiet was unnerving. As Capella quickly walked through the front hall to start checking the injured, she saw a town guard stepping in, his stun baton held up hesitatingly.

"Hold it right there," the guard said, his eyes wide, and she was surprised at how young he looked, not much older than herself.

Mom's going to be so mad about this, Capella thought as she walked forward quickly.

"I'm Princess Capella of Bright Moon and I need to speak to you right now!" she said as she managed to keep her voice from quavering.

He straightened up a little at the sound of command in her voice, not sure of what was going on, and she was almost to him when he suddenly staggered forward a little, his eyes going wide as he started to fall forward. Capella dropped her dagger as she grabbed him. She staggered under his weight but managed to get him to the ground without dropping him. That's when she saw the hole through the front of his jacket and the spreading red stain.

The guard looked up at her as she knelt down to him, his eyes horrified. He tried to say something but she never found out what he had to say. He coughed a few times and reached his hand up towards her and she took it as his eyes glazed over.

"Sil? I told you not to run forward, Sil! Where are…," Capella heard a voice say. She looked up to see a guard standing outside, his face full of horror that quickly got replaced by rage. "WHAT DID YOU DO!?"

"I didn't do anything!" Capella shouted back, her voice full of fear but the guard wasn't hearing it as he dropped his stun baton and drew his sword. Capella grabbed her dagger and started scuttling backwards into the front hall, fear screaming through her mind as she saw the guard coming into the room. She came to rest

against a barely moving person and realized there was no way she was going to fight this guy. She teleported back out into the field where people were milling around in confusion.

She found Gress and Sert standing together along with Tropistar and Aden and Laho. They all saw her appear but it was Gress who saw it first.

“Cappe! Why do you have blood on your shirt!?” he said as he rushed forward.

“It’s not mine,” she said as she sat down hard on the ground, looking down at the shirt. It wasn’t much, just a few spots, but it felt like an ocean. “We have to go.”

“What happened!?” Sert said and then they all heard the guards coming around the building and into the field. “What did you do!?”

“I didn’t do anything!” Capella screamed back.

Tropistar was leaning down as he said, “Listen, we’re going to be called ringleaders again. We have to go and we have to go now. We can make an argument from a safer place but now is not the time.”

Laho said, “I know someone who has a little house on the edge of town. They said we could use it if we needed.”

Capella sheathed her dagger, her shaking hands making it hard, and Gress helped her to her feet.

“Tell me where it is,” Capella said. “I’ll teleport us.”

Laho told her and she grabbed Gress and Sert and jumped them. She jumped back and grabbed Laho and Aden as Tropistar insisted on being the last and got them out as well. The last run, she was exhausted. She felt like falling down as all the emotions and physical strain fell on her and she barely got Tropistar there. The house was on a dirt road a little way out from town and surrounded by a field, the planted winter wheat showing a light green under the dark sky, and Capella sat down in the middle of the yard. She stared at the wide front porch of the small single story house and saw Gress, Aden, and Laho sitting on it but not Sert.

“Where’s Sert?”

“She went back to the inn to get our bags,” Laho said. “There was a small cargo vehicle here she took.”

Capella knew she should go after her. She knew that people would be going to the inn because it’s not like they had been secretive about checking in but she couldn’t bring up the energy to do so.

Instead she kept thinking of that guard collapsing in front of her. She'd never seen death before but the introduction was not one she'd forget. She lay down on the ground and pulled her legs to her as Gress came rushing across the yard to her. She started sobbing right before he got to her.

"It's alright, Cappe," he said as he got down beside her and pulled her close. "We're ok."

She tried to speak, to tell him what she'd seen, but she couldn't get it out.

"Come on, you don't have to talk," Gress replied.

Capella shook her head as she started to get up.

"No, you don't have to talk," Gress said. "I know, there's a lot to do, but you need to take a moment."

Capella managed to finally get out, "He's dead."

Everyone there heard her say it and the little conversation the other three were having stopped as they turned to look at her.

"What do you mean?" Tropistar said. "Who's dead?"

“A guard,” Capella said, gasping through her tears. “Something happened. He died right in front of me.”

Laho pulled out his data pad and began furiously typing.

“Capella, what happened?” he said.

“I don’t know!” she shouted. “I just went to the front, trying to see if anyone was left before helping the people that were down and he was there and suddenly he staggered and he fell and I caught him and…”

She started crying again as Laho started to say something and Gress said, “Leave her alone.”

They all sat down around her while she wept and after a little while, she began to run out of energy and the tears slowed.

“Let’s get you inside,” Gress said quietly to her. Capella nodded as he gently helped her up and across the yard. Once inside, he got Capella into the small living room and laid down on the couch. Gress whispered to her for a moment before going into the kitchen to get some water for her and she was half-asleep when she saw Laho follow Gress. She vaguely heard the conversation but she suddenly paid attention when she heard the word murder.

“What did you say, Laho?” Capella said as she sat up on the couch. Laho looked at her from the kitchen and she saw Gress’ angry face looking at Laho. “What’s going on?”

“It’s alright,” Gress said, not looking away from Laho. “Brother Laho was mistaken about something.”

“No, I’m not. It wasn’t me saying it,” Laho said.

Tropistar was looking at his data pad and looked up as he said, “Cappe, they’re saying you murdered a guard. Is that what you two are dancing around?”

Capella shook her head slowly as she tried to say something. Gress shot Tropistar a dirty look as well as he went in and handed Capella the water.

“She did no such thing,” Gress said as he sat down beside her.

“I’m not accusing her, Brother Gress,” Laho said as Aden leaned against the wall. “I am simply saying what is being repeated online. A lot. There is even a video.”

“I don’t care if there’s a dancing and singing troupe,” Gress spat back. “Cappe wouldn’t just murder someone!”

“Stop,” Capella whispered and Gress immediately looked at her. “Please.”

“Cappe…,” Tropistar started to say and Gress turned to him.

“She said stop. We’re done for now,” Gress said.

“Brother Gress, we need…,” Aden started to say and Gress jumped to his feet.

“We need to look after each other! Now is not the time for this!” Gress responded. Aden’s ears twitched a little and Gress went on. “Be uncomfortable. She is my friend and she needs rest. We can talk about this later.”

Gress turned and helped Capella up and into a sparsely furnished bedroom. She lay down on the bed and he put his hand on her shoulder for a moment. She muttered something, trying to ask him to pull the curtains on the window but she couldn’t get it out. She just stared out at the field stretching towards the horizon, low trees growing along the edge against the dirt road.

She didn’t realize she had fallen asleep but Gress was shaking her and she was suddenly awake, looking out the window again at darkness. She could see her face reflected in the glass from the single lamp lit in the room. For a moment, she didn’t recognize

herself. Her hair stuck every which way and she had dirt and grime smeared on her face. She sat up, groaning a little.

"What's going on?" she said.

Gress said, "Sert came back a little while ago. We need to leave. They're looking for you and locking the roads down."

"Gress, I probably need to turn myself in," Capella said. "I didn't do it. Running isn't going to look good."

"Cappe, there's people roaming the streets destroying buildings and burning down homes," Gress said. "If you get caught, they could very well kill you."

"That's ridiculous," Capella said.

"It's not," Gress said. "Every clone in town has left. The town council tried to meet and the mob overran the building and took over. We need to go."

"OK," Capella said, shaking her head. "This is absurd."

"I'm aware," Gress said. "We can talk about it safely somewhere else."

Capella got up and marveled at how little she ached. She felt like she should creak like an old door but she just felt a bit worn out still. She went into the front room to see Tropistar and Sert standing there.

"Where's Aden and Laho?" Capella said.

"They went into town to help the other clones and left with them. They said they'll be in touch and we can use this house for at least two days," Sert said.

"Gress, why didn't you go help?" Capella said.

"Because you're here," Gress said.

Capella was about to respond when there was a knock on the door. All of them looked at each other with fear on their faces and no one moved to answer it. Then the door handle turned and the door opened. A blonde woman that Capella felt like she should know stepped in, a small stun baton in her hand and several weapons strapped to her. Her clothes were dull gray and she looked around the room as she came in. Capella finally recognized her when she saw the badge on her lapel. It was several nested black crescent moons on a dark purple background.

“Ah, Princess Capella, we’re glad we finally found you,” the woman said.

“You! I saw you at Poview that night!” Capella said.

“And again in the market the other day,” the woman said. “The Queen would be quite irritated with me if she knew that but I’ve long argued that you should know about us. Introductions later though, now it’s time we were leaving. Come along, Sergeant Clo is holding the perimeter for us with her squad. You can go with her. My sisters and I have work to do here first.”

Capella saw a few other people on the porch, all dressed the same, standing quietly.

“I’m not going anywhere,” Capella said and fought to keep her hand from going to her dagger. Something about the woman’s calm and quiet demeanor scared Capella worse than the mayhem earlier in the day.

“I’m glad you’re at least being skeptical, Your Highness. Sergeant Clo didn’t think you would be but she did say I was to tell you, ‘The stars appeared and blessed us all,’” the woman said.

It was the phrase that Sergeant Clo had said she’d use to identify herself or anyone she sent to help Capella. Capella almost went with her then but it felt wrong and something the woman had said didn’t sit right with Capella.

“What do you mean by you and your sisters have work to do first?” Capella said, suspicion coming to full bloom.

“Nothing you need concern yourself with, Your Highness,” the woman said politely, looking at the others in the room. “Come along now please.”

“Cappe, what is this?” Sert said quietly beside her.

“She is royalty. Address her properly or shut your mouth,” the woman said evenly, looking at Sert.

Sert looked at Capella and said, “Get them out, don’t worry about me.”

Capella didn’t know what she meant at first but then Sert threw a lamp across the room at the woman. Capella suddenly understood and grabbed for Tropistar as she grabbed Gress. Tropistar though was already moving across the room at a run, roaring. The woman simply stepped to the side to avoid the lamp and another woman came in from the porch and met Tropistar’s charge with a stun baton. The discharge sounded less like a crackle and more like a thunderbolt. She didn’t wait and teleported Gress out. She appeared just outside the little house and saw through the windows the woman calmly step forward and jab her baton into Sert and drop her.

“I’m getting you to safety, Gress,” Capella shouted and grabbed him again and began to teleport. She didn’t go home. She went straight to Dryl and appeared in front of the welcome booth. The clone on duty that night looked up in surprise as she appeared with Gress.

“What was that!?” Gress shouted at her in fear.

“I don’t know! I don’t know! Get to Izzy! Tell her what’s going on!” Capella said.

“Don’t leave!” Gress said.

“I have to! I have to try and save them!” she replied. Gress grabbed for her but she darted sideways. “Love you, buddy. I’ll see you soon.”

She disappeared and began her run back to the house. She ended up in the air, hundreds of feet up and just below the clouds, as she remembered how she’d entered Poview. She saw five women walking out of the house and across the front yard, dressed in the dull gray clothes. What scared her to her bones though was seeing Sergeant Clo and her squad walking towards her from the road. She didn’t wait. She teleported into the front room. Tropistar lay on his side, not moving. She saw several stab wounds on him, his eyes were glazed over and she started to shake. Then she heard Sert moan next to her. She looked at them, saw their fur was wet, and knew it had to be blood.

Capella didn’t understand why she did what she did at that moment. She thought of Mermista, who’d become friendly with Sert, and that Salineas was a bit closer than Dryl by her teleport jumping. She even cursed herself a bit as she thought about why she didn't take Gress there instead but she didn’t waste too much time on that. She grabbed Sert then and heard someone shout outside. She didn’t wait, she teleported, headed for Salineas. When she got there, she appeared in front of the palace, causing the two guards who were half asleep to jump.

“She needs help right now!” Capella shouted at them. “She’s Mermista’s friend! MOVE DAMN IT!”

The two guards dropped their weapons and rushed over. Capella stepped back as another guard came out at that moment, looked at her, and started over to her.

“You’re Princess Capella aren’t you?” they said as they carefully lowered the trident they carried. It wasn’t quite a threat but it was enough.

“Nope,” Capella said and then teleported away. She didn’t go far. She didn’t even think when she did. Where she ended up was on the street where her favorite noodle cart normally set up. It was quiet at night and she looked around and darted over into an alley. She squatted down beside a few trash cans, ignoring the smell as she pulled out her data pad and started it up. She saw messages all over the place, people asking about what she’d done but one caught her attention. It was a message pushed out across the Etherian main data network with her photo and description.

“Princess Capella of Bright Moon is accused of murder of a Wheatland guard in the line of duty. All Etherian’s are asked to report on her whereabouts so she can be detained for trial and appropriate rehabilitation. All princesses and town officials are asked to make all effort to detain her. All others are asked to only report but do not approach. Message will repeat in five minutes.”

Chapter End Notes

Did someone order a bunch of falling shoes?

OK! We finally got to this one! If you've noticed me posting way faster than normal over the last week or so, this is why. I wanted this one posted. If I wrote in act structure, this would probably be considered the end of Act One.

A little story for you on the quote that started this chapter. I had just discovered this song when this fic was still very much in the early planning stages. I was thinking about the overall plot line and then I heard Dio hit that line (go listen to it if you want, it’s great) and my ears just stuck right up in interest. It felt so right for what I was thinking in this chapter. Cappe is on top. She’s been successful at Poview, twice, and did well at Seaweed. She’s eight miles high. Now the fall.

Summary
Capella and Gress have gone to Wheatland for a gathering/protest. She briefly remembers visiting Micah and Angella recently and how he thought she was a nurse. Her and Angella sit on a couch and grieve. The rest of the chapter is taken up with them in the meeting the hall they gathered in and a few people in the crowd starting an argument with a clone. As the people are being escorted out, one of them runs into a clone and staggers backwards with a bleeding forehead. There's a brief lull and then a crowd of anti-clone protestors attack the meeting hall. Everything gets wild, Gress and Capella manage to get people out the back door to

safety and Capella goes back inside to make sure no one is left behind and to help the injured.

As she's doing that, a guard comes in the front door. Capella goes up to him, as they've taken forever to arrive, identifies herself and then he suddenly jerks forward and starts to fall. Capella grabs him and realizes he's bleeding and he dies in her arms. Another guard shows up and sees it. Capella teleports to her friends, teleports them to safety, and has a small breakdown.

Aden and Laho leave to go help clones in town, as all the clones are fleeing as a mob is burning them out and destroying their homes. Capella wakes up from a short exhausted nap and goes out into the living room of the small isolated farmhouse they've gone to. Her, Sert, Gress, and Tropistar begin discussing what to do when there's a knock at the door. Then the door opens and the blonde woman Cappe has been seeing comes in wearing the rumored badge of Dark Moon, asks that Cappe go with her, and gives the proper secret phrase that Cappe's Bright Moon guards had given her to identify anyone that might need to come and get her.

Sert and Tropistar attack the blonde woman, Cappe teleports Gress to Dryl, comes back, and sees the blonde woman and her team outside and walking towards Cappe's Bright Moon guard. She goes inside, finds Tropistar laying on the ground, not moving, with glazed eyes and finds Sert barely alive, both of them with multiple stab wounds. Cappe teleports to Sert to Salineas, it being a bit closer and because Sert and Mermista have a budding friendship, drops her at the castle and then runs when a guard seems to be threatening to her. She ends up in an alley in Salineas, watching as an Etheria-wide message goes out that she's wanted for murder and should be detained by any town guard or princess and all others should report sightings of her.

Capella

Chapter Summary

Capella isn't sure what to do after Wheatland.

Chapter Notes

"A single thread hangs limply down / And I breathe not now, not now / And I find you all unwoven / Trying desperately to sew" The Rockrose and The Thistle by The Amazing Devil

Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Capella sat the data pad down and leaned her head back against the wall as she held her hand over her mouth and started crying again. She jumped when a Scorpioni woman came out into the alley with a bag of trash.

"You look like you're not having a good night," the woman said as she opened one of the cans and carefully set the bag in.

"I… um… no, I'm not," Capella managed to say as she grabbed her data pad and struggled up to her feet.

"No need to run," the woman said. "I'm Clawrene."

Capella noticed Clawrene, even though tall as most Scorpioni were, was stooped over a little in a bright patterned dress, her red

carapace mottled with what looked like a white film, and what felt in that moment to be the warmest smile Capella had seen before.

"I'm just going to move along," Capella said, desperately wiping at her eyes.

"You don't need to do that," Clawrene replied. "Why don't you come on in for a moment? You look like you could use a hot meal, maybe even a good place to sleep."

"I can't," Capella said. "It's nice of you to offer but I can't. I could be trouble for you, even just for talking to me."

Clawrene looked at her as she crossed her claws in front of her and said, "I survived the fall of the Scorpioni kingdom. Fled here with nothing. I lived through the invasion of this town by Lord Hordak's Horde and then lived through the occupation of Prime. I've lived a long time and I know trouble and sweetheart, you look like just a tiny bit compared to the rest."

Capella wanted to argue. She thought about teleporting back to Dryl but she suddenly realized she couldn't. Izzy would be bound to hold her if she did. Every place she thought of she realized she'd either be alone or going to someone who'd hold her. She finally tucked her data pad away and just nodded.

Clawrene led them both around the corner and up a narrow staircase to a small single room apartment. A plant grew in a

hanging basket in the window with a small table under it. Several small stained glass trinkets were attached to the window and caught the light from the road outside. Capella looked around and saw a rolled up mattress in the corner and a few comfy chairs placed around the room. She saw pictures of what she assumed were family on the wall by the door. What she smelled though was a warm stew on the stove that made her stomach growl. Clawrene looked at her with a grin as she said, "I heard that. Have a seat at the table."

"I'll help," Capella said.

"No, you sit down. Get your coat off and be comfy. I don't get guests a lot, let me be the host," Clawrene said as she stepped over to the kitchen. Capella nodded and almost took her coat off when she remembered her dagger.

Capella went to sit down instead as she said, "I'm chilly. I'll keep the coat on for now."

Clawrene looked over from the little counter that was the kitchen as she said, "It's Salineas. I know it's not cold. Whatever you're hiding, I'll just turn my back to put some stew in bowls and you can hide it while I do."

Capella started to say something but Clawrene turned her back and began to whistle. Capella shook her head and took off the coat, quickly undoing the clasps holding the sheath in place, and wrapped the coat around it before setting it on the ground beside

her. Clawrene gave a little grin as she turned around with a tray in both claws and walked over to the table.

"You're going to need a new shirt there," she said as she sat the tray down and nodded at the bloodstains, the guards and now Sert's as well, on Capella's shirt.

Capella felt her stomach plummet as she said, "It's… uh… juice stains."

Clawrene looked at her for a moment before nodding.

"Yep. Figured it was that. Seen a lot of juice stains in my day," she said as she sat the bowl in front of Capella. "No problem. I can find you a clean shirt after dinner because you shouldn't wear it in public. People get all bent out of shape over juice stains."

Capella looked at her as Clawrene calmly took a glass and filled it with water. She plucked a slice of lime out of a bowl on the tray and placed it in the glass before setting it in front of Capella.

"Eat," Clawrene said, gesturing at her. Capella just nodded and started eating. She found herself focused on the food and as her mind tried to bring up all the worries, she just kept slipping back to the warmth of the stew or the cool water with the faint taste of lime in it. She took a deep breath and then was startled when Clawrene spoke up again.

“You need a place to sleep tonight?”

“I should really get going when I’m done,” Capella said, looking up.

“You’ve been slumped down in your seat for ten minutes now,” Clawrene said. “I think you’re done.”

Capella looked at the empty bowl in front of her and realized she’d been asleep in the chair sitting up. Clawrene smiled gently at her.

“Whatever you’re running from, whatever you’re scared of, you don’t have to worry about that tonight,” she said. “Go roll the mattress out and get some rest and don’t worry about me. I sleep in my easy chair most nights anyway.”

Capella picked up her coat, being careful to keep her dagger hidden, and went over to unroll the mattress. Clawrene got up and rummaged around in a stand-alone closet and handed her an old nightgown, soft with age.

“Change in the bathroom and hand me your clothes. I’ll get them cleaned and get you a new shirt as well,” she said. Capella just nodded agreement, too tired to argue anymore. In the bathroom, when she put on the nightgown, it was large on her and she was reminded of playing dress up with her mom’s old dresses. She

stood in front of the mirror, not looking at herself as she fought back tears as well as fighting back the memories. When she finally came out of the bathroom she handed her clothes in a bundle to Clawrene before going over to the mattress again.

As she lay down, still holding her coat that she had refused to give up, she vaguely wondered if maybe she should be more suspicious. For all she knew, Clawrene was just humoring her and she'd wake up to guards. As she pulled a crocheted blanket over herself and fell asleep, that thought didn't really hold any fear for her though.

Capella woke with a start some hours later, early morning light streaming in through the window, the stained glass figures in the window bathing the table in colored light. Clawrene was sitting at the table, reading a book and picking at some fruit with a cup of coffee by the plate. She looked up when she heard Capella moving and smiled.

"It's still really early," she said softly. "Go on back to sleep if you want."

Capella shook her head as she said, "No, thank you. I've really bothered you enough. I need to get going."

"In my old nightgown? Listen, I sent your clothes out with my grandchild to be washed. I have another grandchild who's a tailor. He's going to come by in a few, get you some new clothes as well," she said. "Come and eat."

Capella wanted to argue but she knew she couldn't just go traipsing around Salineas in an oversized nightgown and anywhere she could think to teleport to would just see her taken into custody. As she stood and shuffled across the floor, pulling the nightgown up so she didn't trip, she wondered why she didn't just do that but something kept telling her to stay free, just for a bit longer. She sat down and poured herself some more water and put a few pieces of fruit and some toast onto her plate.

"Thank you. I really wish you wouldn't do all this for me," Capella said. Clawrene looked at her as she leaned back in the chair and set her book down.

"I told you, it's not a problem."

"Listen, I know you say that but what I'm involved in… I just don't want to get you in that," she said.

Clawrene looked at her for a long moment before she said, "You know, you never told me your name and I never asked because I figured if you wanted me to know, you'd say. But let's stop being coy, Princess. I know who you are and I've heard what trouble you may be in. I don't believe it. I know what a lie sounds like when it's twisted so hard it screams like the truth. The people that aligned themselves with Lord Hordak to overthrow the Last King, they were good at that."

Capella was silent, as she looked at the table. Clawrene leaned forward and quietly said, "I also know that when people get trapped by that twisted, screaming lie, you help them. If you're scared I'm going to turn you in, you don't need to worry."

"That might not be the worst thing," Capella said quietly. "Getting caught."

Capella jumped a little as Clawrene set her claw on Capella's arm.

"Do you really believe that or do you just feel like giving up?"

Capella looked up at her as she said, "Both, I think."

"What good will you do sitting in rehabilitation for something you didn't do?"

"What good am I doing now?" Capella said as tears began to course down her face. "I'm pretty sure one of my friends is dead. I don't know if the other one I brought here is still alive. There's two others I don't know about at all. Ever since I got involved, this has been getting worse and worse."

"And you think you're to blame?" Clawrene said as she sat back in her chair.

"I know I am," Capella said as she realized that Dark Moon had come to get her and her friends had ended up in the way. She covered her face as she began to sob. "If I hadn't been with them, the people who got them wouldn't have even been there."

Clawrene let Capella cry, her claw gently resting on her shoulder. Capella realized that the thing she had ridiculed, laughed at, and never thought was real was not only very real but that her mother had known about it the whole time.

How else would they know the code to identify themselves to you? a little voice said in her head. *Your mother lied to you. She might have some reason but she still lied to you and now people are dead because of it.*

Capella's tears slowed as she realized that and anger began to replace the tears. Clawrene nodded as she said, "And now you get angry. Before you go off though, you need to let that anger cool."

Capella wiped at her eyes as she said, "No, I don't."

"Yes, you do," Clawrene said firmly. "Take it from me, you'll never get what you need letting hot anger drive you. You want satisfaction of the wrongs against you and your friends? Then you need to think. Plan. What do you want?"

"The people who came for my friends," Capella said, her voice shaking with held back anger as little sparkles formed in her hair.

“How?” Clawrene said as she sipped at a cup of coffee.

Capella started to say something and then realized she didn’t know. She sat back, the rage still simmering as she tried to think.

“You have time to think this out. You can’t just go running out, knife in hand,” Clawrene said. “Your clothes won’t be back for a little bit from being cleaned and your other clothes won’t be here until this evening. Get a shower for now. I’m going to run out for now; got a few things to do.”

Clawrene stood up as Capella looked at her.

“Why are you doing this? Why are you helping me so much?”

“I told you already but I’ll state it plainly,” Clawrene said. “Because it’s easy to turn your back when the chance to do the right thing comes along and I refused to do that a long time ago. You understand this even if you don’t quite fully know it. You didn’t turn your back when you had the chance to do so, even when it didn’t go your way. Stay free. Fight back.”

Capella nodded her head and Clawrene put a claw on her shoulder again as she said, “You’re a good kid. Well, maybe a little old for that but still…”

Clawrene patted her shoulder and went on out the door. Capella got up and went to get cleaned up. The thought of what her mother had done to her, how she'd betrayed her, kept clanging around in her head and she did her best to force it out as she got showered. She went back out and sat down on the mattress and unwrapped her dagger from her coat and sat it beside her. As she took deep breaths she worked to shove her anger, fear, and sorrow down inside of her. She was going to take Clawrene's advice. She was going to think, plan, and be ready.

Capella picked up her data pad and immediately made sure that all the encryption was on it and up to date. She made sure that it was reporting her in a different location to the network before she logged into the data board. She immediately set herself to show as still away as she looked through the notes. Everyone was up in arms. While the group Capella knew weren't the only leaders in Equal, they'd been some of the more visible ones and having them disappear had everyone frantic.

Messages were flying back and forth and Capella could see that some people were having video conferences but she couldn't hop into them while they were active without people realizing she was on the board. Messages had piled up for her and she just shook her head as she realized that there was almost no real information. It was almost pure noise. She wasn't learning anything that she didn't already know.

Capella opened up her private messages. It was overflowing with messages but she saw several from Gress that simply said, "Where are you!?"

She almost called him right there but her hand hovered over the call button. Gress was in Dryl or at least had been. She couldn't think of a place more likely to be able to figure out where she was in a heartbeat than the biggest tech center on the entire planet. Then she realized that Izzy and her network would probably be out looking for her on behalf of the princesses as well. She disabled the call function as she thought.

Did she know about this as well? Capella thought as she sat cross-legged. *Why didn't she warn me? She told me things were getting unstable but… that's so VAGUE.*

She thought carefully about how to contact Gress and finally decided to send him a short message. It would be encrypted although it might still show where she was, even if no one could read it but Gress. She decided she needed to take the chance, if only to reassure Gress. She opened up a message and made sure it was as secure as she could make it.

Dear Gress,

I'm so sorry I didn't come back but it's bad. Mom lied to me. Dark Moon is real. I don't know who I can trust except you. Stay at Dryl. I trust Izzy to protect you and your caretakers and that's it. Me? I can't trust that she'd let me leave and I have to stay free. I have to find out what happened. Please don't try to reach out to me because it's not safe. I hope one day I'll be able to reach out again but for now I want you to stay safe. Know that you're a better friend than I could ever have hoped to have in my life and I cherish every moment we had together. I hope you know how much I love you.

Your Friend Squared,

Cappe

She sat back and wiped at her eyes as tears flowed down. She wanted to say she would see him soon but she didn't lie. She didn't know if she'd ever see him again. She just signed it and hit send and set the data pad down with a sigh. She leaned forward and let herself quietly cry for a minute before shoving the pain back down. As she did, a little thought popped into her head.

Capella wiped tears out of her eyes as she picked the data pad back up and checked the account she had access to at Flower Drone Systems. She was surprised to find that not only was it still active but there was a note waiting there, dated from late the night before. She hesitated to open it but curiosity got the better of her.

Your co-worker has caught me up to speed on your latest job but you need to check in soon please. I'll make sure the expense account stays full in case you need it. Stay safe.

Capella stared wide mouthed at the message. It had some name she didn't recognize that was listed as the head of the company but considering no one at the company would be sending her messages, as far as she knew she didn't even show up on the company message list, she could only assume it was from Izzy. She fell back onto the mattress as she thought.

Maybe there's still one princess I can trust. Maybe , Capella thought, although the request to check in made her uneasy.

Capella spent the rest of the morning thinking and planning. She missed Gress, not just for his ability to help her plan but also just for his comfort. She cried when she thought of that but she just shoved it back down and kept working. Clawrene came back a few hours later and Capella took the things she brought for lunch and went into the kitchen with them after throwing her coat over her dagger before Clawrene could see.

"Honey, you're a guest," Clawrene said as Capella began to assemble a tray for them.

"And a guest should show their appreciation for their host," Capella said with a little sad smile. "So sit down please."

Clawrene smiled at her as Capella worked and soon Capella was setting down the sandwiches along with the salad she'd assembled.

"You've been crying," Clawrene said. "You alright?"

"No, I'm not but I'm taking your advice. I've got plans," Capella said.

"Good to hear," Clawrene said.

The rest of the day was quiet. Capella even managed to take a nap at one point before waking to a knock on the door that had her leaping to her feet and then tumbling down when the nightgown she was still wearing tripped her. Clawrene shook her head as she went to the door, checked it, and then spent a few minutes speaking to one of her grandchildren before coming back inside.

"Here's those freshly laundered clothes," she said, handing Capella a package wrapped in butcher paper and tied with a little twine. Capella opened it to find her clothes cleaned and pressed, including the stained shirt made back to normal. "Now you can go get changed and put that knife back on that you think I haven't noticed."

Capella stopped as she was getting up, looking at her.

"I… I was just trying not to scare you," Capella said.

"I appreciate it but there's no need. Put it somewhere you can get to it easily if it'll make you feel better."

Capella nodded and picked it up and carried it into the bathroom with her where she got changed and came back out, the dagger in hand. She sat it on the table and sat down with Clawrene.

“My grandchild said that there’s been some blonde woman with a few silent friends asking around the neighborhood about you,” Clawrene said. “Friend?”

Capella felt her gut drop as she shook her head no.

“Didn’t think so. No one’s telling her anything. No one likes the look of her. Don’t worry about her.”

Capella looked down at the table as she quietly said, “I think she killed my friend.”

Clawrene looked at her for a long moment before putting her claw on Capella’s hand.

“She can have an accident if you want.”

Capella’s head snapped up with wide eyes.

“What!? No!”

Clawrene nodded as she said, “You’re a good person. Me though, I’d go for the accident.”

"No! Never mind the morality, she'd probably kill anyone who tried."

Clawrene just gave a little warm grandmotherly smile as she replied, "You overestimate her chances but it's your choice."

Capella just shook her head and said, "I'm going to move on as soon as I can now that I have my clothes."

"I did say that I had some more coming for you, right?"

"Yeah, but…"

"Really going to argue this one?"

Capella sighed and shook her head. "No, I guess not."

"For now you're safe and under cover. Besides, my grandchild, he's a great tailor," Clawrene said.

Capella spent the next few days at Clawrene's house. True to her word, her grandchild brought her a set of good clothes and a small satchel to carry her stuff in. He refused payment, simply saying, "Don't worry about it."

Those days were stressful, as Capella tried to figure out what to do, but also strangely calming. She never left the place and the small room felt close and comfortable. She had one of Clawrene's grandkids get her some theater makeup she was familiar with and the things to apply it and made a place for it in her bag. She heard from another grandkid that Sert was in Mermista's castle and expected to recover and she sighed a little in relief that they was at least alive, if in custody. In fact, with the various grandkids and such she met, she was beginning to realize that her presence in the neighborhood was known but was also a closely guarded secret.

Finally, as evening fell one day a week after Wheatland, she packed up the few things she had, strapped her dagger on her back, and put on her new coat over it. It was a beautiful green color cut in a style popular in Erelandia and becoming popular in Salineas. It was comfortable and most important, hid the dagger well.

"You know you can wait," Clawrene said.

"I know but I have to figure this out and I have things to do," Capella said.

Clawrene pulled her in close for a hug as she said, "If you ever need a place, we're here for you."

Capella hugged her tightly back as she said, “I know. I can’t thank you enough and I won’t forget this.”

Clawrene put her claws on Capella’s shoulder and looked at her for a moment.

“I’d say stay safe but I know that’s not possible.”

“How about I just get the job done,” Capella responded.

“That sounds good. To better times,” Clawrene said.

Capella wiped at her eyes a moment as she said, “To better times.”

Then she teleported out and was on her way.

Chapter End Notes

I love Clawrene. She kind of popped up and because of her I built up this whole headcanon on just what happened with the fall of Scorpia's grandfather and the overthrow of that kingdom. As in, I have enough of a headcanon that I could do an entire pre-Season One series about it I think. Will I? I have no clue. I've still got a long way to go on this series, another series that I haven't touched, and other stuff that I want to cover (like Catra and Adora taking care of Finn the first time they get sick) but it's definitely in the WIP list.

Izzy

Chapter Summary

> Izzy sits in Dryl, wondering what she can do to find Capella as she gets news that she has a visitor waiting for her.

Chapter Notes

> "There will be time, there will be time / To prepare a face to meet the faces that you meet; / There will be time to murder and create, / And time for all the works and days of hands / That lift and drop a question on your plate" The Love Song of J Alfred Prufrock (excerpt) by T.S. Eliot
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Still no activity on that account?” Izzy said, laying down on a couch in her office. Harpi shook his head.

“No, and before you ask, yes, the alert is still set for as soon as someone makes a withdrawal, Blu has not given any new information, and we haven’t had any luck locating her data pad.”

Izzy gave a thin smile as she said, “Am I getting that predictable?”

“Yes, but it is understandable since we’re all worried about her,” Harpi said. “Brother Gress is incredibly on edge. His caretakers are very worried about him.”

“I’m worried about him,” Izzy said. “At least he got that message from her, even if he won’t tell us what it was so at least we know she’s out there.”

Izzy didn’t say the thought that popped into her head of which was that it had been a week with no word or sign of her since. The memory of Aerie and Siggie seemed to hang over her like a ghost. Even though Capella hadn't been doing the same thing they had, it still felt the same because someone she’d gotten involved had gone missing. When she’d spoken to Finn about it, they’d tried to point out that Capella had been involved already but Izzy had just shook her head. The point for her was that she’d given Capella the means to get deeper involved and now she was missing.

“Queen Glimmer returns today,” Harpi said.

“I know,” Izzy said with a grimace. “I was hoping I’d have something to show.”

Harpi looked at Izzy for a long moment before he said, “Are you getting any sleep Brother Izzy?”

“I could ask you the same,” Izzy shot back.

“You could and I would say not enough,” Harpi responded.

“Then that’s my answer as well,” Izzy said. “I won’t have this be another… well, just another.”

“It’s ok to say their names,” Harpi said gently.

“No, it isn’t, not right now,” Izzy said.

Harpi looked at her for a long moment before just giving a twitch of his ears.

“Go and get some sleep,” Harpi said. “I’ll wake you if anything happens.”

“No, you go on and get some sleep,” Izzy said. “I’ve got things to do.”

“We both do. That doesn’t mean we’ve been doing them,” Harpi said.

Izzy started at Harpi before she replied, “Fine. Let’s both get a little rest. Have Pat wake us up in an hour?”

Harpi started to argue and then just nodded his head in acceptance.

“Alright.”

Izzy set an alarm on the AI and didn’t bother to even get off the couch. She just put a small pillow over her eyes, and rested an arm on the horns curving along her skull. She thought she wouldn’t be able to sleep but it felt like only moments before she heard Pat chiming and speaking to wake her. Izzy sat up, feeling groggy as she pawed at the data pad.

“I’m up, Pat,” Izzy said as she sat up. “Find Brother Harpi and wake him…”

Then she trailed off as she saw Harpi straightening up in the chair where he’d fallen asleep.

“Brother Harpi, you should have at least taken the other couch,” Izzy said as she rubbed her eyes.

“It seemed easier to just slump over here,” Harpi replied. Izzy gave a little snort at the joke as Pat spoke to her through the monocle headband she had on. All humor drained out of her as she listened.

“Glimmer’s here.”

“Impossible. Her shuttle doesn’t land for another few hours.”

“Impossible or not, Pat just told me she teleported to the courtyard. And I just got notification from the front gate attendant,” Izzy said as the notification beeped at her. “I better go down there.”

Harpi gestured at Izzy in ragged sweatpants and one of Finn’s hoodies as he said, “Maybe change first?”

“I’m not keeping her waiting,” Izzy said as she started walking. Harpi was right on her heels as she dropped her monocle for a quick review of notifications as she muttered into her headset and issued Pat a string of commands, thinking maybe she should maybe at least grab her tiara. As she did, another notification from the front gate came through and she realized that Glimmer being there, impossibly early, was not a good thing and she needed to face it immediately as she turned down one of the many tunnels in Dryl.

As she came out of the shortcut to the courtyard, she flipped up her monocle as she heard Glimmer say, “When!? When is she going to get here!?”

“Glimmer, I’m right here,” Izzy said as she walked towards her and then spoke to the clone standing beside Glimmer. “Thank you for your help, Brother Kevin.”

The clone nodded and almost ran back to the front gate as Glimmer turned to her and even though Izzy was tired and worn out, she could quite easily pick up on Glimmer's mood. It was fury.

" *Where is my daughter* !?"

"I don't know," Izzy said as calmly as she could and was about to say more when Glimmer cut her off.

"Oh, yes you do! Don't you dare try and lie to me! I've heard the rumors about what you do!" Glimmer said. "You recruited her didn't you!? You put a dagger in her hand and sent her off to fight!"

"Glimmer, I'm more than willing to talk about this but not out here," Izzy said, holding her hands out in supplication.

"No! I'm not playing your little game! Get her out here! Now! Or so help me Mara…," Glimmer said and Izzy saw a ball of light starting to grow in her hand.

Izzy's face went cold as she gave a little nod and dropped the monocle into place. Harpi heard little clicks as bots of all sizes began to quietly appear around the courtyard as Izzy said, "Are you really threatening me *here?"*

“You’re damn right I am!” Glimmer shouted back. Izzy looked at Glimmer and knew that she would have to strike the first blow. Izzy had no illusions about how it would play out if Glimmer did. She brought her hands up, one hand in a loose fist and the other with the fingers held in a certain way that she had hoped she’d never have to use for real. As she brought her hands up, several large bots on the parapet shifted to bring their blank faces to bear on Glimmer and a multitude of other bots started to move as well as the ball of light in Glimmer’s hand grew larger and a spell started to form in the other. For a second everything was still, the moment hanging like a crystal glass above a concrete floor. Then the moment broke.

“What are you two doing!?” Izzy heard a voice shout and her eyes flicked over to see Finn standing in the gate, out of breath as if they’d run all the way there. Glimmer shot a quick sideways glance at Finn as well before snapping her eyes back on Izzy.

“Aunt Glimmer! Drop that right now!” Finn said, striding across the courtyard.

“Finn, it’s alright,” Izzy said, getting ready to close her fist as she shifted the fingers on her other hand into a different configuration to avoid Finn and the bots began to move a little closer.

“Izzy, I’m talking to you as well! I see a bunch of bots poised to pounce! Send them on their way!” Finn said. “Both of you need to take a breath and talk this out!”

Glimmer remained crouched over as Finn stopped and stood between the two of them.

"You going to hit me too, Aunt Glimmer? Izzy, you think the bots are smart enough to avoid me entirely?"

Izzy almost said, yes, she was sure of that but she took a deep breath as Glimmer straightened up a little and the ball of light disappeared along with the spell.

"Iz, I still see bots," Finn said, looking at her, their ears laid back. Izzy almost said something about not wanting to send off her protection but instead she muttered to Pat the commands to stand down the bots before she unclenched her fist and let her other hand relax as the bots went on their way. Izzy watched Finn breathe a sigh of relief as their ears came back up a little. "Thank you, both of you. Now come on over to the theater. You can talk about this in my office."

"Finn, I'd rather just…," Glimmer started to say when Finn cut her off.

"Please, Aunt Glimmer, Izzy, my office," Finn said, looking at her, their tone gentle but their meaning firm. Glimmer scowled at Finn for a moment before she just nodded. Finn looked at Izzy and she nodded as well before telling Harpi she'd call him when they were done. He walked away, looking sideways at Glimmer the whole time.

As Glimmer and Izzy started walking they never took their eyes off each other as Finn walked between the two. When they got to the theater, people would start to approach Finn and then catch sight of the other two. At that point they would turn around and go the other way. Finally, they reached Finn's office and Finn opened the door as Glimmer teleported inside to the back wall while Izzy walked in and stood at the other side by the door.

"Do I need to be in here to referee?" Finn said, looking between the two

Izzy said, "Honestly, I'd prefer it if you weren't."

"I bet you would," Glimmer shot back.

"Not constructive. Work it out and I'm going to be sitting right out here in the hall," Finn said as they shut the door and Glimmer and Izzy stared at each other for a moment.

"OK," Izzy said as she sat down and clamped her hands to her knees as she looked at Glimmer. "Yes, I have an intelligence network. No, Capella didn't… doesn't work for me in the sense you're thinking. I gave her some funds to help her group. The dagger was not to arm her like you're thinking."

"I don't care. Where is she?" Glimmer spat out.

“I don’t know,” Izzy said as she looked away and Glimmer’s face softened a little at the defeated sound in Izzy’s voice and the tired look on her face. “We’ve been looking but… the last place we know for certain she was at was at Mermista’s castle in Salineas. She dropped a severely wounded person off and then teleported out again. No one’s seen her since.”

“No one’s reported they’ve seen her? At all?” Glimmer said, calmer but still with suspicion in her voice as she sat down at Finn’s desk.

“People are reporting they have but nothing has panned out,” Izzy said as she looked back at Glimmer. “Glimmer, I care about her as well. I want to see her safe.”

“Then why did you put her in that situation?” Glimmer said, her anger rising again.

“I didn’t. I didn’t even approach her until after the whole thing at Poview the first time,” Izzy replied. “I have done nothing but give her finances for what she was already doing.”

Glimmer looked away from Izzy and took a deep breath before continuing.

“What do you know?”

“Right now? A mob attacked the building they had their event at in Wheatland. It was supposed to look random but it had coordination behind it. Cappe helped rally the crowd and get them out the back then went back in to help those that had been injured.” Izzy saw a flash of pride in Glimmer’s eyes for a moment before it was replaced by anger again. “The town guard took forever to respond and when they did one of them died. His name was Sil. There’s a video shot from outside that looks like she attacked him. It looks pretty damning. He had a single wound, straight through his chest. It was narrow and lined with burns but it was enough. People are saying Capella used light-based magic to make a beam,” Izzy said, looking for a moment at Glimmer’s hands before continuing.

“After that she disappeared with a few of her friends, higher ups in Equal, and I know that she and her friends were attacked in that time frame. The last solid sighting of her was when she appeared in front of the palace in Salineas with one of the Equal leaders named Sert who had been badly injured. Stab wounds. She dropped them at the gates, told the guards to get help, and then teleported back out. That was the last credible sighting I have of her.”

Glimmer leaned forward, her hands gripped tight as she stared hard at Izzy. Izzy did her best to try and keep calm but she was a mix of emotions, none of them happy, and she was hoping Glimmer wouldn’t ask a certain question.

“Where’s Gress?”

There was the question.

“He’s with his caretakers,” Izzy said simply.

“Where are they?” Glimmer said. Izzy kept her mouth shut. They were in the hidden tunnel system in Dryl but she wasn’t about to tell anyone. After a brief pause, Glimmer leaned forward. “Izzy, where are they? I am going to talk with Gress.”

Izzy just shook her head.

“I’m not asking, Izzy, I’m telling. I am going to talk with him,” Glimmer said.

“I will ask him if he wishes to speak with you. If he says no, then no, you’re not,” Izzy said.

“Is he here in Dryl?” Glimmer said, standing to her feet at the desk.

“I told you what I’ll do,” Izzy said, her voice raising as she got to her feet as well. “That’s it.”

“Izzy!” Glimmer started to shout and then they both jumped as Finn pounded on the door to the office from outside.

"Keep it civil you two!" they heard Finn shout through the door. "If I can hear you, you're not doing that!"

Izzy shook her head as she sat back down, clasping her hands. Glimmer took her seat as well and there was quiet for a minute.

"I know she's not my daughter but I'm worried about her as well," Izzy said quietly. "But… Gress is traumatized. I'm not making it worse on him."

"Have you talked with him?" Glimmer said.

"Yes, briefly on the night it happened," Izzy said. She didn't want to mention what Gress had said, that Dark Moon had not only come for them but they had known the passphrase to get Capella to go with them. She didn't want to believe that Glimmer was capable of such a thing but at the same time she was afraid to be wrong and endanger more people. "He stated they had been at a house on the outskirts of town for a little bit, they were attacked, and then Capella teleported him out and then left, saying she'd be right back."

Glimmer stared at her for a moment before she pointed at Izzy.

"I know you take a promise just as seriously as Finn and their moms do. Promise me you don't have Cappe hidden here," Glimmer said.

Izzy took a deep breath and said, “I promise you that I don’t have her here and I’ll also say I promise I don’t know where she’s gone to. I also promise I’m doing my best to find her.”

Glimmer started at her for a moment before nodding and covering her face. Izzy saw a tear leak down her face as Glimmer took a deep breath.

“I’m… I wish I had more to give you. I’m trying my hardest to find her,” Izzy said quietly. “I really did not want this to happen.”

“I wish you had more to give me as well. Like my daughter,” Glimmer said, her voice tired before she pulled herself upright in the chair and looked at Izzy again. “Ask Gress for me, like you said you would.”

“I will,” Izzy said. “Are you going to stay? Do you want me to get you a room?”

Glimmer looked at her, tears on her face and anger in her eyes, as she said, “No, I won’t stay under your roof. If something happens to my daughter, I’m never going to forgive you for getting her tangled up in whatever happened. I may not anyway.”

Izzy wanted to remind Glimmer of what she had said earlier, that Capella had already been involved and she had just given her

assistance. Izzy knew though what kind of excuse that would sound like and honestly she knew if she was in Glimmer's shoes, she wouldn't want to hear anything like it either.

Izzy just nodded as she said, "I understand. I'll never forgive myself either."

Glimmer looked at her again before just shaking her head and teleporting out. Izzy sat back, tears flowing down her face as she looked at the ceiling. She heard the door open and Finn poked their head in.

"Can I come in?"

Izzy just nodded and Finn sat down on the couch beside her and pulled her close.

"Didn't go well, huh?"

"She blames me. I can't say I don't understand," Izzy said as she wiped her eyes. "I'll tell you more later."

Finn hugged her as they said, "I'm so terrified for Cappe. I wish she'd contact us somehow."

“I think she’s running scared,” Izzy said softly. “Hopefully she’ll contact someone soon and we’ll at least know she’s out there still.”

That thought, that she wasn’t, quieted them both and she heard Finn sniffle a little as they both sat. Izzy heard a little beep in her earpiece and heard Pat’s soft voice saying there was a priority alert. Her chest clenched as she spoke, not even bothering to subvocalize the command as she normally would.

“Go ahead, Pat.”

She listened for a moment, slowly sitting up as her eyes went wide.

“Pat, repeat that!?”

“What is it?” Finn said, their ears perked up and pointed towards her.

Izzy listened again as she turned to Finn and said, “Someone with Cappe’s access codes just accessed the financial account I gave her access to. Then they completely drained it.”

Chapter End Notes

> Glimmer and Izzy facing off in the courtyard of Dryl was something I was looking forward to as soon as I knew Cappe was going to go missing. Glimmer's fast, has magic, and has

been through plenty of fights. Izzy is in her domain though, with the full assistance of the Dryl bots and clones, and she definitely has anger issues. I can see multiple ways it would have played out, none of them good for either party involved. Victory for either one would have been of the Pyrrhic variety more than likely.

Also, for those of you wondering WHY I had Izzy give Cappe a dagger, this is part of the reason. Izzy did it more to deliver the note of being cautious but I did it more as a way to drive this wedge in.

Anyway, thank you for reading! I'm still moving right along and I recently broke 160,000 words on this and I'm not close to being done so we've still got a ways to go.

Capella

Chapter Summary

> Capella is out on a quest to figure out what has happened to her but she can't do it alone and she doesn't want to get Gress involved in any more danger. So who can she turn to for help?

Chapter Notes

> "Let me not then die ingloriously and without a struggle, but let me first do some great thing that shall be told among men hereafter." The Iliad by Homer
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Capella took a deep breath as she appeared in the empty land outside the Valley of the Lost. She remembered the last time she'd come to this place. She had been with Gress and she thought she was starting a new chapter of Equal there. She thought at that point the mercenaries she ended up meeting instead had been nerve-wracking. She almost missed that now and she really missed Gress. She hadn't communicated with him since her one message she'd sent out and she was pretty sure that was the longest she'd ever gone without speaking with him since they'd first met. She thought about her home then and had to shake her head as the tears really started to come.

Bright Moon is just a place; it isn't your home anymore. Not now and maybe never if you don't figure this out. Shove it down. Get yourself centered. First step, she thought to herself as she sniffled and rubbed at her eyes a little. She took a deep breath and pulled down an illusion over her face. She'd practiced a bit more in front of Clawrene's mirror and she felt like it was pretty good. An older

woman looked back at her from the mirror when she had it in place and while she couldn't change her height or her body shape, she knew the face was important and she was dressed like she was from Salineas. She was as confident as she could be that she'd pass without a glance to someone who had known her before. She took a deep breath and took one final jump into an alley.

Capella straightened her back and walked forward into the main road. She went along until she found the square she was looking for. On the other side was a bar she'd visited on the previous visit with Gress and she had to take a deep breath to keep both of her faces composed. She walked across the way and pushed the half-curtain aside that hung down where a door would normally be and took a moment to look around the room with its high ceiling to see if she spotted any of the people she was looking for. The room was pretty busy with an early evening crowd, people chatting, laughing, and good naturedly arguing but she didn't spot anyone.

Capella walked across the room, faking confidence as best as she could, towards the two empty seats at the bar, one on either side of a ragged looking blonde feline person. She took one to the left of him. Looking out of the corner of her eye to see if he looked at her she noticed that he just stared straight forward into the large mug in front of him. She had her attention on him and almost jumped when the bartender seemed to almost appear in front of her.

"Whatcha want?" she said as put her hands on the bar in front of Capella. Capella didn't know what to order, she suddenly realized. It's not like she was used to hanging around bars after all. She

almost ordered a fizzy drink and then realized that would probably be way out of the ordinary.

"Something cold," Capella said, doing her best to alter her voice to be a bit deeper and trying to be a little intimidating.

The bartender rolled her eyes as she said, "Come on, quit being cute and just order something."

Capella looked over the bottles on the back of the bar, trying to decide and then just shook her head.

"Orange fizzy drink?"

The bartender shrugged and said, "Sure."

She went down, reached under the bar and came back, popping the cap on a bottle and set it in front of Capella. Capella started to reach for a coin when she realized she didn't have any on her but the bartender just held up her hand and said, "Don't worry about it."

She was about to turn when Capella leaned forward and said, "Wait. I'm trying to find a person named Coalfire. I've met her here before. Is she around?"

The bartender turned around with a bored look as she said, “I have no idea who you're talking about.”

Capella nodded and the bartender went on. Capella sighed as she took a drink of her fizzy drink and tried to be too obvious as she looked out of the corner of her eyes. No one seemed to be paying her any mind. She wondered how she was going to do this. She had hoped to find Coalfire and see if she wanted to work for her or at least might know something. She also knew she had to tell Coalfire about Sert, her cousin, but wasn’t sure how she’d even bring that up. Then again, she wasn’t sure how she’d bring any of it up if she couldn’t find her.

Capella sat at the bar, slowly drinking her fizzy drink, for about half an hour. She was interrupted by the person sitting on her right slowly slumping over as he began to snore. He bumped into her and she carefully pushed him back the other way. The bartender came around and looked at him for a moment before picking up the mug and putting it back behind the bar. She gave him a shake.

“Ridor! Wake up! Go sleep somewhere else!”

The man’s ears perked up as he sat up on the stool, his eyes barely focusing as he looked around.

“Where’s my drink?” he said with a slur.

“Put it behind the bar. It’ll be here when you get back. Go on. Get something to eat and go sleep,” the bartender said. Ridor stood up with a shrug, weaving a little as he did, and shuffled towards the door. Capella kept trying to wonder why that name sounded so familiar when she saw Coalfire step in around Ridor as he left. She tried to hide her surprise by taking a sip of her drink as she watched Coalfire come up to the bar to where Ridor had just left. The bartender came over as Coalfire, still in her long dark yellow robes, face veil and head wrap, leaned over and ordered a few things.

When the bartender went on, Capella looked at Coalfire and said, “Excuse me. My name is Sareen and I understand that I can hire you for some work.”

Coalfire looked her up and down for a moment before saying, “I don’t know you.”

Capella hadn’t expected that. She thought fast.

“No, I know, I know,” she said. “Would you at least like to hear my offer?”

“Perhaps,” Coalfire said. “You do understand that the work I do is not cheap?”

“I expect to pay well for good work,” Capella said. “So yes, I do understand that.”

Coalfire looked her over again before shrugging and saying, "I have a private room here. That door over there. Go on over while I let the bartender know where to send my order."

Capella looked to a door on the other side of the room. Her hands wanted to shake as she realized it was the room where she'd first met Coalfire, and several other mercenaries that worked for her or with her, Capella had never been real clear on that, the first time she'd been there. It wasn't large and it didn't have any way out but the one door. She didn't have much choice though, she just nodded and started walking that way. She caught sight of a clone in the crowd that she recognized, named Half Ear, who was just sitting down at a table with a few other people. He worked for Coalfire and he didn't seem to be paying any attention to her so Capella just clenched her toes a little trying to stay calm.

The illusion is holding. Just keep it calm, Capella said as she opened the door.

A small battered wooden table with a few chairs around it sat in the middle of the room and Capella took a chair with her back to the wall and facing the door.

Appear calm, that's the trick. Appear to be what you want others to see, she thought and leaned back a little with her feet out before her and her ankles crossed. The back of the chair pushed against her hidden dagger a little and just served to ratchet up her nerves even more. Coalfire walked in a few minutes later, sipping at a strawberry fizzy drink through a straw that went up

under her veil. She sat down at another chair, her back to a wall with Capella and the door in plain view.

"OK, what do you need from me? Be succinct please, Sareen," Coalfire said calmly as she put her drink on the table.

"I need information that you may already know but I also need you to gather more as well," Capella said.

Coalfire looked at her for a long moment before she said, "You're going to have to be more specific. What *kind* of information do you need? What kind do you need me to gather?"

"You're aware of the issues surrounding clones?" Capella said.

Coalfire's eyes showed she had a sudden smile on her face as she said, "Of course. Are you?"

Capella kept her face as neutral as she could as she said, "I am. I need to know more."

"Smart person like you, probably knows more than I do," Coalfire said and Capella felt like she was being teased. "Why do you need poor old me out here in the Waste for? I bet you can find out all you want."

Capella shook her head as she said, “No. I don’t know much. I need you to find it out for me. What is your price?”

Coalfire said, “Straight to the point and not real subtle. Makes sense though. I guess your tutors at Bright Moon didn’t teach negotiating with the shady side, did they?”

Capella started to say something when she realized what Coalfire had said. She froze for a split second before she gave a haughty laugh. Even Capella thought it sounded fake and strained.

“I’m not from Bright Moon. I’m from Salineas if you must know,” Capella said.

“You’re Princess Capella of Bright Moon and I have to say you’ve gotten much better at illusions since you tried to bluff me with an illusory dagger,” Coalfire said. “Keep up the charade though and I’m going to assume you mean me ill. Are you really here to talk or do I walk out?”

Capella sat for a second and then pulled her hand down her face and dismissed the illusion.

“How did you know?” Capella said.

“I’m always teaching you lessons aren’t I? Calm down, I’m going to tell you. It was pretty good. Something about your voice

though had me wondering and then I saw your boots when I walked in. They have the Bright Moon symbol on the sole. That's when it clicked. Your voice was pretty good but once I had that put together, I just listened a little more. You still sound a bit like yourself when you're doing it," Coalfire said. Capella nodded and then froze as Coalfire went on. "You know there's some people offering money for you, right?"

Capella looked at her and slowly said, "No, I didn't know. I know people are looking for me."

"Yeah, these aren't the same people just looking for you. These people aren't looking to send you off to rehabilitation," Coalfire said. "What are you doing here? Honestly."

Capella held her hands together tightly as she leaned against the table.

"Exactly what I said. I want to engage you for information," Capella said. Then she took a deep breath. "I also wanted to tell you that Sert was badly injured in an attack that I think… um… my mother ordered."

Coalfire folded her hands together as she said, "I already knew about Sert but thank you for telling me. They're doing OK by the way. Mermista is looking after them although she's calling it custody and rehabilitation for the look of it because Wheatland is asking Mermista to send them Sert. Mermista told them to get bent. Exact words."

“I didn’t know that,” Capella said and felt a little relief enter her life. Then she remembered Tropistar, laying still on the floor of the house, and the relief disappeared. She shoved the pain back down and went on. “OK, what about my offer?”

Coalfire looked at her with curiosity for a moment before shrugging and going on.

“You sure about this? How are you going to pay me? If you think your mother is out there ordering people to try and kill your friends, you think she’s going to be fine with you using whatever account you have with Bright Moon to pay for stuff like this?”

Capella thought of Glimmer for a brief moment but the thought was full of anger and sadness and she just shook her head as she said, “I’m not using a Bright Moon account. I have a side account.”

“How secure is it?” Coalfire said.

“Secure enough,” Capella said.

Coalfire said, “Listen. I have an idea of what you’ve gotten twisted up in. There’s a reason I did that work for Sert for so cheap. I sympathize with your aims but you’re dangerously out of your

depth here. I mean, you came straight to me. Why not someone else?”

Capella didn’t want to say because she didn’t know anyone else who could do this but she had a feeling Coalfire already knew that so she just stayed quiet.

“Why don’t you just go on home? You’re the heir of Bright Moon. They’ll probably sweep this under the rug or you’ll just have to do some pro-forma bowing and scraping and you can go right back to your life. You don’t have to do whatever it is you think you’re trying to do,” Coalfire said.

“Maybe I don’t want it swept under the rug or go back to my life like it was because maybe I want to find out who is trying to set me up and why. Maybe I want to find out who keeps making my friend’s life hell as well as anyone like him. Maybe I want to find out why my own mother sent a squad to kill my friends!” Capella said, her voice raising and her fist slamming to the table as sparks shot off her hair.

“Maybe you need to grow up and realize you can’t solve the world’s problems. Go home, Princess,” Coalfire said, suddenly serious. Capella looked at her in surprise for a moment before she stood up and pulled her illusion back over her face.

“You could have just told me from the start you weren’t going to help me, instead of wasting my time,” Capella shot back.

“Sit down,” Coalfire said. “And take that thing off your face.”

Capella started towards the door and Coalfire went on. “I didn’t say I wasn’t going to help you.”

Capella stopped at the door before turning around.

“I’m not sitting down until we have an agreement.”

“You haven’t even told me what you want me to do. ‘Find information’ isn’t helpful,” Coalfire said, making little quote gestures with her hands.

Capella thought for a moment before she said, “I have a list.”

They both looked at each other before Coalfire gently said, “Would you like to show me that list or should I guess?”

Capella stepped over to the table and sat down. She pulled her data pad out and got her list on the screen and titled it so Coalfire could see it. Coalfire reached for the data pad and Capella pulled it back. Coalfire nodded as she said, “Good. Don’t ever let someone take it from you that you don’t trust.”

“Then why did you try?”

“To see if you knew at least that much,” Coalfire said as she looked at the short list and snorted. “You don’t ask for much do you?”

“It’s broad definitions,” Capella said.

“You’re basically looking to retain me long-term if you want all of that,” Coalfire said. “Item one is pretty easy but the rest? That’s a lot of work.”

“I understand. I’m not completely oblivious.”

“I agree to take on the first two jobs, pending payment of course. The rest, we’ll see.”

“I want first option on your services after the first two then,” Capella said. “I may not be able to wait.”

Coalfire waved her hand in the air a little as she said, “Maybe. How quickly are you expecting this?”

“As quickly as possible while not needlessly endangering yourself,” Capella said with a deep breath.

“I appreciate that last part. OK, I think we can do that. Ready to talk cost?”

Capella nodded and Coalfire mentioned a price. Capella tried to keep her eyes from getting larger but failed.

“Is that… um, is that for everything?”

“No. That’s for the first two and a retainer for your option on the others. That is also upfront,” Coalfire replied. “If you can’t pay upfront when you exercise the option later then I pass and your option expires.”

Capella sat back for a moment. It was much more than she was expecting but then again, she realized, it’s not like she really had an idea of what this kind of thing went for. She suddenly realized that because she didn’t have an idea if this was a fair price that Coalfire more than likely knew that and was probably taking advantage of the situation.

“This includes your whole team?” Capella said slowly. Coalfire nodded. Capella thought for a moment and said, “I don’t know. Seems a bit steep. How about a different price?”

“Are you asking or offering?”

“Offering. I’ll agree to thirty percent less and the option doesn’t expire if I can’t meet the funding at time of request,” Capella said. “I just have to wait until you’re available again.”

Coalfire laughed as she said, “You learn quickly. I like it. Make it twenty percent less than quoted, I agree to the option terms, and I’ll even throw in a five-day window to meet funding on future work. You have to pay today though for this.”

Capella wanted to argue, she felt like she should, but she just took a deep breath and said, “Give me one moment.”

Capella pulled up a note she’d made with the amount in the account at Flower Drone Systems. It was as she remembered. There was more than enough to cover what she had agreed to but she knew that a withdrawal of that amount would probably set off alarms with Izzy and set her on her trail even harder than she probably already was at the moment.

“You know, it’s not a good look to check your account in the middle of this,” Coalfire said with another laugh.

“I accept the terms as stated,” Capella said, ignoring the laughter. “How do you want the transfer?”

“That simple? OK, before we do this, I’m going to offer you some advice. It may cost you a little if you take it but I think you may want to hear it,” Coalfire said. Capella was a little leery but she

told her to go on. “You’ve already said it’s not Bright Moon but I can’t imagine you have the kind of fund that you’re talking about without it having some kind of string attached. Is it somewhere you fully, one hundred percent control the access to?”

“Why should I answer that?” Capella said.

“Because I’m going to make you an offer that I think you’ll want,” Coalfire said.

“Yes, I have reasons to believe it has strings attached,” Capella said. “But I’m confident in the ability to pay you safely.”

“For now,” Coalfire said. “I’m going to offer this. We can take as much money out of that account as you want and move it to an account you can control entirely. Untraceable as well.”

Capella sat back as she thought about it.

“How do I know you’re not just going to move the money somewhere else and run?”

“How do you know that I wasn’t going to do that with the payment you were going to give me?”

Capella shrugged as she said, "I guess I didn't. Still doesn't make this seem less odd."

"I'll explain what I'm going to do as we're doing it and you can check me each step of the way. I will have to involve one of my crew though," Coalfire replied.

"Explain it first. Then I'll decide," Capella said.

Coalfire gave a little nod that Capella felt like was one of approval before she started talking. She explained how she'd have her crew set up a shell company that'd have the money moved to it. Then she'd split it and move it to multiple other accounts. The money would dance back and forth for a little bit before settling down into a final shell company, one that Capella would control.

"It sounds legitimate but I have two questions," Capella said.

"Let me guess. 'How much' is one of them?" Coalfire replied.

Capella nodded as she said, "And why are you even bothering?"

"One, five percent of the total transferred, less the amount you were going to pay us anyway. That's the handling fee. We'll take that first payment out for services as well before it hits the final stop," Coalfire said. "As to why, like I said, I'm sympathetic to your goals. You're going to do this anyway, might as well give you a

better chance then you have at the moment. Besides, if you get yourself killed or caught or lose access to the account then I don't get a chance to make more money off of you."

Capella looked at her with a grimace as she said, "Just when I thought you were being kind."

"I am kind," Coalfire said. "I'm also in business and not one that runs by normal rules. Do you accept the deal?"

"No. Three and a half percent of the total transferred," Capella said.

"Five percent is non-negotiable," Coalfire said. "Tell you what though, I'll throw in a place to stay tonight, unless you already had something lined up."

Capella hadn't. She'd planned on teleporting somewhere else but she hadn't even thought that far yet because she hadn't even been sure how this would turn out. She started to open her mouth and saw Coalfire start to lean back and stopped.

"Alright, five percent and a place but throw in dinner at least," Capella said.

Coalfire laughed as she said, "That's fair. Let's get it done."

A tall woman named Alice came into the room shortly afterwards. Capella recognized her from the last time she'd been there and found out she was Coalfire's electronics specialist. As Alice and Coalfire discussed how they were going to make the transfer, Capella thought about her father and his love for building things and electronics. She then wondered if he had known about the squad and between that thought and the others, Capella had to turn away for a moment.

"Hey, you ready?" Capella heard and turned around, realizing it wasn't the first time Coalfire had tried to get her attention.

"Sorry. Distracted," Capella said.

"Don't do that!" Alice said. "Quick way to end your career."

Capella had no idea what she meant for a moment and then suddenly realized it when Alice made a slicing gesture across her throat.

"I'm paying attention now," Capella said. "What do you need?"

"Get logged into your account," Alice said as her long fingers began clattering away on a large foldable data pad. "Here's the account to send it to. Move as much as you want and tell me as

soon as you initiate the payment. Here's the company where it's going to end up."

Capella nodded and got into the Flower Drone Systems account again. There was more money there than the last time she'd checked and she stared at the large amount wondering just how much she should take.

All of it, she thought suddenly. *Take all of it. You may not get access again.*

Capella wrote the amount down on a scrap of paper and gave it to Alice before typing out the amount to transfer. The system asked for access codes and she entered them, her gut tightening as she waited for a notification telling her she was denied but it never came. She looked up at Alice as she hit the final confirmation button.

"Sent."

Alice nodded and looked for a long moment, comparing the amount on the scrap of paper to the screen, before saying, "Received. And here we go."

Capella sat back, trying to be calm but not having much luck as she waited. After about ten minutes, Alice looked up at her and said, "Go check the new account."

Capella opened it up, a little business listed as being in Erelandia named All Goods & Services, and for a moment her heart plummeted as she saw nothing there. Then she hit refresh and she saw it. She did a quick calculation and saw it was exactly what should have arrived.

"It's there," Capella said.

"Now, whoever you just pulled that from…," Coalfire started to say before Capella cut her off.

"I know they're probably going to be looking for it. I already had that assumption," Capella said.

"Good," Coalfire said as Alice burned the scrap of paper and then packed up.

"I'm heading on, Boss," she said.

"We have work starting immediately," Coalfire replied. "I'll probably need you later tonight."

"Of course," Alice said with a sigh and then a wink before she went on her way.

The room was silent as Capella looked at the amount in the new account and thought. It seemed a huge amount but she had no illusions that it would last long. She grimaced, closed the data pad down, and stuck it back in her bag.

"I believe I was promised a meal and a place to stay," Capella said, trying to sound confident.

Coalfire nodded as she said, "You were. You might want to bring that illusion back up before we walk out though."

Capella ran her hand down her face before squaring up her shoulders and following Coalfire out the door. She didn't know why but she half expected to see someone waiting for her outside. No one even looked up though as she walked with Coalfire to the exit.

The streets of the Valley of the Lost were lit by little lights here and there. Lamps over doorways, a string of flickering lights from some all-night food cart, a lantern sitting on a table where a few people sat and played some tile based game, and even a few guttering torches while overhead the night sky stood out brighter than Capella thought she'd ever seen before. Capella was constantly looking around and would have thought it was almost beautiful if she didn't keep catching glimpses of furtive figures in shadows going about their business or the occasional person leaning against a building watching them pass with more than a casual interest she felt.

After about ten minutes, Coalfire stepped onto a patio, separated from the road by a waist high adobe wall. As she opened the door, Capella followed along, looking about, as she went into the dim room, lit only by a single tiny light.

"Shut the door," Coalfire said as she picked up an oil lamp on the table.

"Why?" Capella said, standing to the side of the door. "Light the lamp first."

"Because I don't want anyone to be able to see in here. Now please, shut the door," Coalfire said.

Capella looked around but it was just a room with a big table and benches on either side. A few old chairs that looked like they had been scavenged from Hordak-era Horde equipment sat around an unlit fireplace and a small loft with a ladder leading up to it overlooked the room. She shut the door.

"Thank you," Coalfire said as she pulled a box of matches from her robes and lit the lamp. Its warm light made the room feel close and peaceful. "There's some mattresses and a few blankets up in the loft. You can sleep there tonight. Pull the ladder up after yourself if you like. I'll get dinner soon. First though, I can answer most of your first question you hired me for already."

Capella sat down on the bench beside the big table, took off her illusions, and sat her satchel down as Coalfire got comfortable in one of the chairs.

"So what I'm hearing is that I overpaid you for that," Capella said.

Coalfire laughed as she said, "Maybe. Honestly the others will be way harder. It'll even out." Capella sighed as she shook her head and Coalfire went on. "You want to know what happened in Wheatland and was it just spontaneous. No, it wasn't. It was very much planned. How much do you know about Wheatland and their politics?"

Capella said, "I know there was a very active anti-clone group there. That's why we went there."

"That group is kind of loose. They don't look organized and to be fair, that's not entirely just looks. They kind of aren't but there is a small tight knit group that could be considered the core of that group. They were smart enough to keep quiet, mostly, and just kind of acted as a catalyst, driving the group by what looked like consensus of the whole," Coalfire said. "Basically a clever sentence here when they met or talking with other people and saying, 'Boy, why don't we do this?' or 'Why do they get to get away with that!?' kind of thing."

"I get what you're saying. Behind the scenes kind of thing," Capella said.

“There’s probably ten of them at most,” Coalfire said. “Call themselves the Children of Mara. I heard there were a few people who got into an argument with a clone and claimed he attacked one of them, came out bleeding?”

Capella remembered that and nodded.

“They did,” Capella said. “One collided with a clone, looked like they ran into him and held his hand to their forehead and then blood started coming out. The clone didn’t do anything, just looked confused.”

“Well, that was them. They came out and said the clone had slapped them all around,” Coalfire said. “Several others from the inner group started shouting and grabbed cinder blocks… well, you were there. You know what went down.”

Capella clasped her hands together to keep them from shaking as she nodded her head.

“OK, so this Children of Mara instigated it,” Capella said. “Started the attack and the others went along.”

“Yes,” Coalfire said. “They’d been outside ramping everyone up all afternoon. It wasn’t hard. As far as I can tell, there wasn’t any concrete plan beyond attack.”

“There had to be. They killed a guard and pinned it on me!” Capella said.

Coalfire was shaking her head as she said, “I don’t think so. Most of them were around back or had moved into the rest of the town by the time that happened. There was another actor I think on scene. Probably several.”

“Wait? Actors? Like a play?”

Coalfire chuckled as she said, “No. In the sense of someone taking part. Someone killed the communication links in the area long enough to delay a call to the town guard. Someone also filmed your encounter with the guard. Which means, to me at least, they were set up for exactly that. They were ready for you. Have you seen the video yet by any chance?”

Capella shook her head. She knew it was circulating the data boards but didn’t want to see it.

“It’s well shot and framed while still looking shaky and like it’s just some bystander,” Coalfire said. “Those people? I don’t know who they are and I’d be surprised if it was this Children of Mara group.”

“Why?” Capella said.

"I don't know," Coalfire said. "I can't give you a definite answer. Clever to them is picking a fight and then running into someone. Not setting up a delicate dance of you, a guard, a delay in said guard arriving because of a very coordinated attack on the communications system… well, you get the idea. Not that The Children of Mara aren't clever enough to now be basically running the town now through the old city council."

Capella thought. Coordinated attack. Careful planning. The word had slid into her mind already.

Dark Moon, she thought. *Why set me up like that though?*

"I think I might have an idea who it was," Capella said.

"Well? Want to fill me in?" Coalfire said.

"No, not right now. I have to think a little more about it. For now though, do you know the leaders of the Children of Mara and where they might be?"

Coalfire leaned forward, looking hard at Capella, as she said, "Maybe. Why?"

"I hired you for information, not to ask what I was going to do with it," Capella said.

“Yeah, but if you run off and do something stupid, I don’t get more payment,” Coalfire said.

“Don’t worry about me. I’ll get my hands on robes like those or something, disguise myself well,” Capella replied, nodding at Coalfire’s clothes.

Coalfire shook her head as she said, “No, you won’t, not like these. They’re robes of my order.”

“Wait, what?” Capella said.

“I belong to a group of people who study magic with no limits. We were inspired by someone during the war,” Coalfire said.

“Who? Shadow Weaver?” Capella said, jokingly as she realized why the clothes looked familiar. Then she realized Coalfire wasn’t laughing. “Wait, you really are!?”

“This is why I didn’t want to say her name,” Coalfire replied. “I know, she did terrible things but her methods and ideas were some of the most unique to come out of Mystacor in over a generation. Besides, you shouldn't scoff too hard, you know she trained your own mother, right?”

Capella was about to argue the point when she froze in place at the mention of her mother. She shook herself and scowled.

"Doesn't surprise me. We're off track though. Do you know where these people are or not?"

Coalfire sighed as she said, "I do. They're not being real subtle about it. There's four of them staying in the town hall and getting the town council to issue edicts."

"Get me a run down on all four of those, please," Capella said. Coalfire paused for a moment and then nodded.

"I'll have it for you in the morning. Dinner should be here in a moment," Coalfire said, suddenly looking at the door.

"How do you…," Capella started to say before there was a knock on the door. "Did… did you use magic for that?"

Coalfire eyes showed she was grinning under her veil as she pointed at a small red light next to the door.

"Motion sensor," she said as she stood up and opened the door. Half Ear came in with a paper bag that was emitting delicious smells.

“We're really working for this princess?” Half Ear said as he sat the food on the table in front of Capella while looking at Coalfire.

“She’s our latest employer, yes,” Coalfire said.

“Figured you’d at least bring your little boyfriend,” Half Ear said as he reached into the bag, pulled out a sandwich and went to sit in a chair.

“He’s not my boyfriend. We’re friends,” Capella said, her voice holding an edge.

“Whatever,” Half Ear said. “I don’t care if you bring Gress around or not.”

“Really? If you’re going to treat the boss that way, go on,” Coalfire said.

“Just giving her a little good-natured teasing,” Half Ear said, acting wounded. “I apologize, Your Highness.”

Capella could hear the dripping sarcasm in the apology but just gave a tight smile as she remembered something from the first time they met. “No problem... Brother Half Ear.”

Half Ear stopped with the sandwich halfway to his mouth for a bite as he looked at her. She looked back, a little smirk on her face.

"Don't ever call me brother," he said as he leaned forward in his chair.

"Sorry. Just a little good-natured teasing," Capella said as she reached in and took a sandwich. "I apologize, Brot… sorry, Half Ear."

Half Ear took a bite of his sandwich, anger on his face but he couldn't very well show he was upset when he'd done the same to her.

"Whatever," he muttered around the sandwich. Capella ate her hot sandwich quietly, thinking of the meals at Clawrene's and doing her best not to sigh as she did.

After a little bit, Coalfire stood and stretched as she said, "I'm going to meditate. If you have to go out, leave a note. Half Ear, tell the rest of the crew to be ready in the morning. We got more to do."

"Sure thing," he said as he wrapped up the wrapping paper of the sandwich and shoved it in the bag. Coalfire went and sat in the corner as Capella finished her sandwich. She took her satchel and climbed up into the loft, pulling the ladder up after her as Half Ear

left. She thumped one of the rolled up mattresses and then unrolled it, being careful to look for bugs. She sat down on the edge of the mattress with a sigh. It was dim up in the loft and the wood planks making up the floor were a little uneven and let small slits of light filter up from below.

Capella looked up at the ceiling and thought about her room back in Bright Moon as tears streaked her face. It felt like an eternity since she'd seen it. She thought of the times she'd spent laughing and joking with Gress there and good moments with her parents. Thoughts of her parents made her think of what her mother had done and she covered her mouth to keep any noise from escaping as she shook with anger and tears. She felt like screaming until her throat was raw but knew she couldn't.

I'm never going to see home again, she thought as she fought to shove the pain down, to ignore it. After a little bit the tears slowed and she stopped shaking. She took her coat and dagger off, balling up the coat for a pillow and lay the dagger beside her so she could reach it immediately. She lay down as the slow tears wet her coat.

Do what is needed and maybe you'll get to have a future, if you're lucky, but home's gone. Accept it, she thought. She kept telling herself that home was gone over and over as she went to sleep, trying to convince herself that it was true.

Chapter End Notes

> Ridor! I swear, he turns up like a forgotten penny. Probably because I keep using this bar because I have a good idea of what it looks like and I love the ambiance. Anyway, Cappe is getting things done but as always we have to ask, at what cost?

I do have to say I got past 170,000 words on this story the other day and I'm currently on Chapter Forty-One. I'm not entirely sure how much more I have to go. I know where I'm at in the story, I'm just not sure how many more words I need to get through the chain to the end. We'll see! Thank you for reading and I can't wait for you to see the rest!

Gress

Chapter Summary

Capella drops Gress at Dryl and Gress waits for her. And waits. And waits. And...

Chapter Notes

"The roaring seas and many a dark range of mountains lie between us." The Illiad by Homer

Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Brother Gress!” Izzy shouted in surprise as she came running across the courtyard. Gress was still reaching out for Capella after she’d teleported away to go back to Wheatland for Sert and Tropistar. When he turned to look at Izzy, his face was stricken.

“What’s going on, Brother Gress?” Izzy said as she got up to him and put a hand on his arm. Gress looked down at her for a long moment.

“We were attacked by Dark Moon,” Gress said, his voice hollow sounding. “They came after us and tried to take Cappe with them.”

“Where’s Cappe?” Izzy said, looking around.

“She teleported back to where we were,” Gress said as tears silently fell from his eyes.

“She went back!?” Izzy said.

“There were others,” Gress said as he turned to watch where Capella had disappeared. “She wouldn’t leave them behind.”

The clone on attendant duty who’d called Izzy came back with a chair. As he got it open, Izzy said, “Brother Gress, there’s a chair here, sit down.”

Gress just nodded and slowly sat. He felt numb. He felt like the whole world was gripping him tight, forcing him forward at a run when all he wanted to do was sit and wait for Capella to come back.

“Are you alright?” Izzy said as she looked him.

Gress nodded as he said, “I wasn’t physically injured.”

“Do I need to get a Listener out here? Or do you want to go inside?” Izzy said gently.

Gress carefully shook his head.

"No. She'll be back in a moment. I know she will. I don't want to be away when she returns."

Izzy looked at the empty space he was staring at and said, "I understand. Can you tell me what happened?"

Gress gave her a brief rundown of the events of the day, ending with the Dark Moon guards coming into the house.

"They knew the passphrase that Izzy's Bright Moon guard was supposed to use," Gress said in a monotone. Izzy had put her arm around his shoulder and found them hard as rock from tension. "Only her Bright Moon guard squad were supposed to know that but they had said that if they had to, they'd pass it on to someone and it was a way to verify their authenticity. They knew it."

Gress went silent, still waiting for Capella and after a few minutes, Izzy said, "Brother Gress, I'm going to step over to the welcome booth. I'll be right back."

Gress only slightly twitched his ears in acknowledgement. As she walked away he could hear Izzy giving orders to her data pad and speaking with the gate attendant before coming back.

"Brother Gress, please come inside. I've told the attendant to have Cappe come in as soon as she returns, alright?"

Gress looked up at Izzy and she saw his eyes set in his decision as he said, “No, Brother Izzy. I will wait for her right here.”

Gress could feel Izzy’s eyes on him as he waited but he knew Cappe would be back soon. She had to be. He refused to believe otherwise. After about ten minutes, he heard a high speed skiff leave from somewhere close by and then he briefly saw it’s running lights as it shot off into the night. He didn’t give it any more thought though. Izzy tried to speak to him a few times and he gave short responses before lapsing into silence after a while.

As he sat and waited, the day's events kept trying to play again and again in his head but he kept forcing them away. He found his eyes falling on the front of The Beautiful Imperfection Theater and remembered the time he'd spent there with Capella. He remembered meeting an actor he’d idolized when he was a little younger and what a great night that had been. He remembered the head of the costume and makeup department helping Capella put makeup on him to transform his face.

When she gets back, after we’ve rested, I’d like to do that again, Gress thought as he wondered how much longer it'd be before she was back with the rest of the group.

Several hours passed. Gress finally took out his data pad and tried to send a few short messages to Capella but that only took a minute so mainly he just waited. Izzy came and went and at all times there was always one of his brothers there with him. Gress knew the castle was suddenly full of hustle and bustle but he didn’t give it much notice. Harpi sat down with him at one point

but didn’t try to speak unlike pretty much everyone else. He just kept watch with him with a hand on his shoulder and Gress didn’t realize how much he appreciated that until after he’d left and the next clone came to sit with him and tried to get him talking to take his mind off of things.

As the evening wore on, things quieted down and Gress began to wonder if she’d be back but he shook the thought away. He refused to think otherwise. She had to be and that was all he was willing to accept. Then the sound of the high speed skiff split the night as it returned and it came to rest on the road in front of him. Gress saw his caretakers jump off, large bags over their shoulders as they came running over to him. Ulip was the first one to reach him and pulled him up out of the chair and into a crushing hug.

“We thought we’d lost you,” he whispered as Hort caught up just a moment later and took them both into a hug. “Do you need assistance?”

Gress looked away from the spot he’d been watching to see the fear and concern on his caretaker’s faces and his solid demeanor cracked. He buried his face into Ulip’s shoulder as he began to weep.

“We’re here for you,” Hort whispered.

“She hasn’t come back,” Gress said between gasps for air. “Why isn’t she back?”

"We don't know," Ulip said. "We must go inside though. She will understand if you're not sitting here."

Gress shook his head and Hort gently laid his hand on the side of Gress' face.

"Yes, we must. Things are very bad. We must hide for now," Hort said.

Gress sagged for a moment as he listened to Hort and was about to agree when he looked back at the spot where he'd last seen Capella. Then anger surged through him as he thought about hiding.

"Cursed Prime and all His Light, no! Absolutely not! I will not hide! I have done nothing wrong! She is out there fighting and you expect me to hide!" Gress yelled as he pulled away from Hort and Ulip. "They came for us, Brother Hort! They tried to massacre us, Brother Ulip! I will not stand idly by while Cappe does what we should have done a long time ago! If they do not wish to listen to us then so be it but they will give us the respect due any sentient creature! Otherwise I call them vicious animals and I know what to do with a vicious animal that attacks!"

Hort and Ulip, as well as the few people standing around the gate, looked in horror at Gress. Izzy had come out to greet Hort and Ulip and was the one person in the group who didn't look horrified

at Gress' statement even though she fully understood why the others did.

"Brother Gress, do not say such things!" Harpi replied. "That… that is… do not!"

"Why shouldn't I!? Do I sound like Cursed Prime!?" Gress said, turning to look the people in their eyes. "Why does calling for us to defend ourselves in the face of an attack make me sound like Cursed Prime!? I have read The Great Reckoning, I know what the arguments are, I have read other philosophies! I am not reacting just from fear! To defend oneself is morally right and I do not hold with standing passively aside while a threat to our very existence comes for us! Why would saying such a thing make me like Cursed Prime!?"

Everyone was silent except Izzy who walked up to Gress.

"Brother Gress, I've just got word that Capella dropped Sert off in front of Mermista's castle and then teleported back out. Sert is very gravely wounded and the healers are not sure they will live through the night," Izzy said, exhaustion writ large across her face. "This was hours ago. If she was going to come back here, she would have by now so it stands to reason that she has stayed away for a very good reason. Now please, come in. People are looking for you, it's only a matter of time before they come here, and I do not want them to find you."

Gress seemed to deflate at the news and Hort put his arm around Gress. Gress put his hand up and rested it on Hort's hand. Ulip put

his arm around Gress as well.

"Let's go," Gress finally said and he felt like he was deflating as he said it. He let himself be led inside and they went down into the maze of Dryl with Izzy leading the way. As they walked into Entrapta's old lab and Gress saw the entrance to the second tunnel system standing open, he sighed.

"Ah, the old hometown," Gress said and the acid bitterness in his voice caused all three of the rest to look at him with worry in their eyes. Izzy closed the tunnel after them and Gress was briefly struck by how quiet it was inside. No one had been in, aside from the occasional maintenance run, since Izzy had settled all the clone children out on Etheria years before. Gress had never seen them empty like they were now and he remembered how much he'd loved running up and down the halls or playing in various rooms with his friends. Now the place just reminded him of the wider world that he'd lost.

Hort and Ulip quickly found a room near the entrance and they began to settle into it. Bunks were built into the walls and again Gress was struck by the difference. Where they had once stayed inside the secondary tunnel system had looked much like a house but this one was just a little room with basic accommodations. It hadn't been a place for families, it'd been for clones who needed to stay in the tunnels for maintenance or other upkeep and had never been a permanent living space for someone. Gress sat down on one of the bunks, fresh sheets having been fitted to it before they came in and stared at the wall for a moment before Hort spoke up.

"Do you want to talk about this?"

"No," Gress said as he looked away from them. "I stated what I felt and I meant every word. They feared Prime but he's gone and so they don't fear us, not like they did him. I think they need to learn to maybe fear us a little more."

"Don't you ever say that again."

Gress' head snapped around to look at Ulip, who'd just spoken. In all of Gress' life, he didn't think he'd ever heard Ulip speak with such venom in his voice.

"I just…," Gress started to say, his ears drooping a little. Ulip's ears were sitting straight and high and quivering slightly in his anger. His face was full of the anger and Gress watched as he fought to calm down.

"I know what you meant," Ulip said, taking a deep breath. "It is scary what we have had to live through. It is not right but I do not ever want you to say something like that ever again. I can't express just how much I am disappointed hearing that from you, Brother Gress. I know you know better. I believe you are saying it because you are scared and worried and things feel out of control but I will not see you become blind by light. We are all tired and worn out and so I do not want to speak of this more for now. I think we would only quarrel but we have not finished speaking of this for good."

Gress nodded, looking away so as to avoid looking at Ulip's face. As Gress lay down on the bed, he pulled a pillow tight to himself and watched as his caretakers turned off the main lights in the room. Soon only a few dim red lights that showed where the doors in the room were could be seen, their light slowly seeming to get brighter the longer Gress stared into the dark. He watched as Ulip and Hort got ready for bed, putting their luggage near the bunk they'd share, and as they took their shirts off, Gress suddenly spoke up as he saw their backs.

"I did not mean to disappoint you," he said quietly. Hort and Ulip both looked over to Gress and Ulip walked over and put a hand on Gress' leg.

"We are not disappointed in you," Ulip said softly. "We are proud of you more than can ever be said. I am disappointed in what you have said and I am sorry for speaking so harshly. We will speak again come morning but calmly. We love you."

Gress looked at Ulip's back again and saw the scars there from where the ports had been removed. The ports that had been part of the controls Prime had over them both. He remembered when he'd first learned of those umbilicals as a child and shuddered again in the knowledge of that horror and he started to softly cry.

"I'm sorry. I love you too. I do not want to be like Him," Gress said.

Hort same and knelt down.

“We know. We do not think that you did,” Hort said. “It is alright.”

Ulip gently move Gress over a little and lay down beside him. As he did, he began to sing a song that Gress remembered from when he was a child and Gress remembered the many times Ulip had done the same thing when Gress had been ill or scared as a child. Gress leaned into him as Ulip gently hugged him. Hort sat down on the floor beside them both and began to sing along and Gress soon fell asleep with both of their voices in his ears.

Gress woke early in the morning, a blanket over him, and saw that Hort and Ulip were asleep. After a quick shower, he sat down at a table with his data pad. He stayed away from the data board but answered some messages that had come in from a few friends in Poview. He didn’t say where he was, just that he was safe. He stared at the screen, trying to find motivation to do anything, and was not able to do anything. He was about to shut off his data pad and go back to bed when he saw a message pop up and his heart leaped to see Capella’s name on the header. He quickly opened it up and began to read. Then he began to scream at the top of his lungs a few moments later as Hort and Ulip fell over each other trying to get out of bed.

“Brother Gress! What’s happened!?” Hort said as he got to Gress.

“Cappe… Cappe…,” Gress said, holding the data pad against his chest as he began to weep uncontrollably.

“What has happened to her?” Hort said, pulling Gress close to him.

“She messaged me,” Gress finally managed to get out.

“That’s good though. Isn’t it?” Ulip said as he rubbed Gress’ back.

Gress just shook his head. He didn’t want to say how it sounded like Capella was consigning herself to never seeing him again. Even worse, how it sounded like she was consigning herself to possibly not even being alive much longer. Gress took a deep breath as he kept telling himself that at least it meant she was alive at the moment and somewhere safe enough to send a message. He held onto that thought like a life preserver as his crying slowed.

“What did she say?” Ulip asked.

“It is private,” Gress said, his voice flat.

Ulip and Hort shared a worried look but didn’t push him. They comforted him as best they could as the rest of the day went by with Gress waiting by the data pad, hoping to hear more but nothing came in. For a week, Izzy kept them up to date and people who knew his caretakers came to speak with them and spend time with them so they all didn't feel alone in the tunnels but Gress went from sadness to anger and it only grew as the week passed. He knew that if she’d only come to Dryl, she’d be

safe. Izzy would never turn her over to their enemies. He debated sending her a message in that regard but he realized that she might not believe him and he still wanted to respect what she'd requested.

To try and pass the time, Gress made a habit of logging into the data board incognito and reading the messages. It didn't help much. Everyone was confused and there was no good information. Tropistar was still missing, people had found out about Sert, Aden and Laho had checked in long enough to assure everyone they were safe but then had disappeared off the board, and Gress himself hadn't said a word. Then, one evening a week after Gress had arrived, Izzy knocked on their door. Hort invited her in as Gress and Ulip packed up the dishes to get sent back up to the kitchen.

"Brother Hort, Brother Ulip, and Brother Gress, I hope you are doing alright," Izzy said as she took a seat at the table.

"We are doing well, thank you, Brother Izzy," Hort replied as he sat down at the table with her. "It's very kind of you to do what you are doing."

"By your side, though the whole universe be against us, remember?" Izzy said, referring to what she'd said the day the clones had offered her the twin honor of the title of princess of Dryl and to be considered one of them. "I'm here to talk with Brother Gress."

Gress came over and sat down across the table from her but didn't say anything. Izzy looked at him and waited a moment to see if he'd start. When he didn't, she nodded and went on.

"Queen Glimmer returned to Etheria today and her first stop was here. She was not happy," Izzy replied. "Brother Gress, she wishes to speak with you. I have told her that this will be your choice. You do not have to and I will not try and make you."

Gress looked down at the table. He'd been thinking all week of what he could do and he'd had some ideas and this, while not quite what he'd thought, played into those ideas.

"I think I may speak to her," Gress said, slowly as an idea began to take shape.

Izzy said, "I can arrange a conversation over the data pad if that makes it easier."

"No," Gress said, placing his hands flat on the table. "I will speak to her."

"Are you sure?" Ulip said.

Gress looked at Ulip and said, "Yes. I have many things I wish to say and I will say them."

Izzy nodded. “If you’re ready, I’ll call, and set it up as soon as she’s available. I have a feeling that will be as soon as I tell her you’re willing to talk to her.”

“No. Not yet. This will be when I am ready,” Gress said after a thoughtful pause. “I will be quiet and sedate no longer. My voice will be heard by her and as many as I can reach.”

Chapter End Notes

> Originally, when Hort and Ulip are comforting Gress after he said he didn't want to be like Prime, I had Hort say something like, "We know and we don't think you ever could be like him."
>
> It got changed to what it currently is which is, "We do not think that you did," in reference to them assuring Gress that they didn't think that he was trying to be the next Prime. Part of that change was because I think a clone would never say, "No, you could NEVER be like him" because to a clone, especially one who lived through the Prime-era of their culture, anyone could be Prime. You'd just be working and then suddenly, bam, you're Prime. And of course he's gone and they realize that but I think that's got deeply into their culture and they've pulled that as a lesson, that no matter what, anyone can go too far and be something evil.
>
> And so a clone would never tell someone, "No, of course we don't think you could ever do that!" because they know better.
>
> Anyway, thank you for reading and I can't wait to hear your responses!

Aeron

Chapter Summary

Aeron and Carl watch the events at Wheatland unfold.

Note: No Micah, no summary

Chapter Notes

"In time we hate that which we often fear." - William Shakespeare, Antony and Cleopatra

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The night of the attack at Wheatland had been a long night for Aeron. He'd put many things into play and the risks that came from them he knew well. As the information came flowing back to him though, he began to realize just what he'd wrought. He and Carl sat in their room at Candila watching as the events unfolded and when the Children of Mara took city hall and put the council under their command they leapt to their feet and into each other's arms.

"They did it! I can't believe they did it!" Carl shouted in joy.

"You picked them. I never doubted it," Aeron said as he grabbed Carl's face and gave him a huge kiss. Carl kissed him back before breaking for a breath.

"Yes, you did," Carl laughed. "But that's alright. I did as well."

Aeron fell back into a foldable chair with a contented sigh as he looked at the holographic display set up on a broken stone block. Information flicked back and forth across it as they watched. He picked up a water bottle and took a long drink before resealing it. Carl sat down on the ground in front of him and leaned back against Aeron. They watched images and videos of clones fleeing the town.

"How many are leaving?" Aeron said, a smile on his face and a warm feeling in his heart.

Carl tapped at his data pad and looked back up at the display as he said, "Reports vary. I'd be surprised if there was one blankeye left in the town by daybreak though. The mob is being very thorough at burning them out."

Aeron's smile became a bit dreamy as he thought.

"A town free of them. It's the dream isn't it?"

"It is," Carl said with a contented sigh as he kept an eye on his data pad. "OK, there's the order from the town council. They're ordering the guard to focus on fighting the fires for the 'good of public safety' and to detain any clones for their own safety. That'll keep them busy."

"Hawk-kin really is doing their job well," Aeron said, referring to the head of the Children of Mara.

“Well, you sent a good advisor to talk to them,” Carl said.

“They're useful. The rest are overzealous but they could be useful when we’re reforming the government,” Aeron said. “Keep an eye on them.”

“Already marked,” Carl said. Aeron kept watching the display in silence as he gently played with Carl’s hair. After a little bit, Carl sighed.

“Not good news?” Aeron said.

“It looks like Capella and her little pet blankeye got away. She dropped him at Dryl and then went back to Wheatland,” Carl said. “Then she got Sert out as well but not before Sert was badly wounded. The other two blankeyes weren’t there but Tropistar is finished.”

“Not optimal but we can work with that. Release the video. Send an order down the chain to Hawk-kin to have the council put out a call for her to be detained,” Aeron said.

“Already did,” Carl said. “I’m sending the squad to Salineas. They say the tracker shows she hasn’t left there yet.”

Aeron grinned as he said, “Good. We can’t let her go to ground. If she doesn’t turn herself in by daybreak or get detained, put out the word on the shady side. A reward in the amount we agreed on, payable upon proof of her death. Start the rumor mills on the data board too. We can’t miss this chance to throw them into disarray.”

“You really think anyone will take a shot at her? Considering who she is?” Carl said.

Aeron thought about it for a moment before he said, “You may be right. OK, put out to have her turned over to the Wheatland authorities. If she just happens to resist…”

Aeron laughed as he left the rest unsaid. Carl shook his head with a smile as he typed on the data pad a little.

“We’ll have her soon,” Carl said with a smile as they watched the alert start to go out over the main Etherian network.

A week later though, neither was laughing or smiling.

“Where is she!?” Aeron shouted at Carl.

“How should I know!?” Carl shouted back. “She’s disappeared! The squad has been all over the neighborhood where it shows she teleported into last. No one knows anything and she hasn’t left, at

least not by teleport. She hasn't made contact with Bright Moon that we can tell either and she hasn't been on the data boards. She's just gone."

"We have to get her and get her soon. She is too smart and too persuasive to be left loose," Aeron said.

"You think I don't know that?" Carl said. "The only thing that's in our favor is she hasn't seemed to reach out to any of the princesses, even Her. Maybe she bought the Dark Moon thing."

"I can't play on that!" Aeron said and was about to go on when he saw Carl's face change to fear as he looked at his data pad. "What? What happened?"

"Queen Glimmer is back. She's been spotted at Dryl," Carl said.

"Damn it! She's going to get the whole damn princess council on this!" Aeron said, throwing a folding chair across the room. "We have to move up the timeline. Now!"

"Absolutely not! Too much hinges on you being inducted into the Princess Council! We don't have that yet!" Carl said.

"Then we need to do something! Anything! Right now!" Aeron said.

"No! That's how we got caught at Dryl! We are not flying off the handle!" Carl said.

Aeron started to shout back and then took a breath and shook his head as he started pacing the room.

“No, I’m sorry, you’re right,” Aeron said and was silent for a second before going on. “Do we have any towns that are wavering?”

Carl looked at his data pad and said, “A few but they’re not critical. We are also getting a complaint that Wheatland’s government is being undermined and they are demanding a review by the Independent Town Board.”

Aeron snorted as he said, “Just make sure we have the levers for the town council and contact our people on the board. In the meantime, we have to get on the Princess Council. How soon can we get ourselves seen?”

“I can put in the request right now,” Carl said and then stopped and looked at the ceiling. “No wait. Not yet. We might want to do so right now anyway but what we do is what you’re saying about the councils. We throw as many other complaints and such towards the review boards as our people can manage. Encourage others to do the same. We get that system cranking so it’s busy trying to deal with all the extra complaints and hopefully they don’t have time to be looking our way.”

Aeron’s smile returned as he said, “Sweetheart, that is a great idea and that is why we slow down. Do we have something in place?”

Carl rolled his eyes as he said, “I know that’s why we slow down, I’m the one who suggested it. But no, we don’t have something in place but that shouldn’t take long. I got a list of people we can trust to start it off. In fact, the first one I can think of is Tandini. He can put in a complaint that he was put out of his office improperly.”

Aeron thought for a moment before he said, “He’s got those people as well in place. We can use them for that. And Bryce. I think it’s time we get ready to use Bryce as well.”

Carl nodded as he typed.

“I had the same thought. We should have a little conversation with our friend eventually,” Carl said. “We never did get a good lever on him though. We’ll have to be careful how we approach him about this.”

“We didn’t get a lever? I’m pretty sure we did,” Aeron said. “Remember all that embezzlement of funds and equipment he’s been doing from his job? We’ll just threaten him with that if he balks.”

“He hasn’t… ah, I see,” Carl said as he saw Aeron’s knowing smile. “I’ll get the records ready then.”

“Then that’s the plan. Get those complaints in, start working on getting on the Princess Council quicker, and we’ll review the timeline after that,” Aeron said, taking a deep breath. “We’ll be alright.”

“We’ll have to face them eventually you know,” Carl said as Aeron went and picked up the chair he’d chucked across the room. “We may end up facing them when we go to the council.”

“I’m aware,” Aeron said as he folded the chair back up and set it in a corner as he went back to pacing. “I don’t think so though. I think we’ll at least get that far.”

“I want as far as Dryl,” Carl said, sudden hatred in his voice. “I want that. I need to see it burn.”

Aeron went over and rested his forehead against Carl’s as he said, “I do too. And we will soon have our excuse to do so. I swear it, sweetheart.”

Chapter End Notes

I've been tempted to develop a ship name for Aeron and Carl and I was just talking with my wife about it and she suggested Careon (pronounced carrion). I'm going with it. Anyway, this one is short and to the point which made

proofing easier which I needed. I hope you all enjoyed it and we return to Adora next chapter.

Adora

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra go to Wheatland to try and find Cappe.

Note: Very minor mention of Micah but not a conversation about his condition so no note

Chapter Notes

"We are not lonely, because we chose to be alone. We are not lost, because we chose to disappear." - Steven Wilson

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had spent more time in Mystacor lately than in her home she felt like and it was beginning to wear on her. So when she got word about Wheatland, she was almost happy for a chance to do something and immediately grabbed the nearest skiff she could find. She'd stopped long enough to get Catra and Melog and the three had shown up in the town the following morning. On the flight out, Catra had contacted Bright Moon while Adora flew. They didn't seem to know much but Catra wasn't so sure.

"I tried to find out if Cappe's guard were even still in town but Bright Moon is keeping their mouths shut," Catra said as they landed. "I think they know something they're not saying."

As they got off the skiff, Melog leaping off even before they were fully landed and started roaming wide for any danger, Adora said, "That makes sense. Something has happened with that whole, you know, Cappe being wanted thing, so they're going to keep quiet."

“To us though!?” Catra said.

Adora just shrugged as they started to walk along the streets. Smoke floated around them from burned out homes but no one was out trying to do something about the smoldering properties. When they knocked on people’s doors most didn’t even answer and the few who did promptly shut it in their face. They had talked on the way out that they were there to lend assistance to those who needed it as well as trying to find Capella or her Bright Moon guard. Nothing turned up though. Soon they were standing in front of the building where it’d all started as they quietly held each other's hands and Melog circled them nervously.

“It looks like the war all over again. It *feels* like the war all over again,” Catra said quietly, gently running her hand down Melog’s back as memories of burned out towns shoved their way to the surface from the long buried past. Adora felt Catra grip her hand tightly as she said it and Adora squeezed her hand back.

“I should have done something,” Adora muttered.

“You are doing something,” Catra said.

“Something that would have stopped this,” Adora said.

Before Catra could say something, Adora pushed on the door into the building and it fell a little, held on by only one hinge at the top. Melog jumped back as Catra looked through the door. They could both see where smoke had stained the walls and ceiling in places but it didn't seem that the building's structure had ever caught. The carpet was scorched in places though and as they started in to look around Adora used her foot to flip over a burned sign on the floor. A smiling loaf of bread, half its smile nothing but ash, looked up off the sign that announced good bread came from Wheatland's best grain and that such bread could be found at a bakery downtown.

"You think anyone is still in here?" Adora said quietly.

"One way to find out," Catra said and then cupped her hands around her mouth and shouted. "Cappe! Anyone! It's Catra and Adora! Come on out!"

Adora looked at her with a raised eyebrow.

"What? We're not trying to be sneaky," Catra said.

The silence that came back though was enough to give Adora goosebumps. As they walked into the backstage area and saw the busted up back door still hanging open and the collapsed curtain Catra suddenly froze in place. Adora froze as well as she saw Catra's ears start to twitch back and forth. Catra looked down at the stage they stood on and put a finger to her lips and pointed down. Adora nodded as Catra knelt down.

“Hey, whoever’s hiding under there, this is Princess Catra and Princess Adora up here,” Catra said in a low tone. “If you need help, tap the stage twice.”

After a brief pause Adora very clearly heard two thumps.

“Gotcha,” Catra said as she looked around a little. “I’ll open the trapdoor over here. You can come up.”

Catra spoke to Melog for a moment and they nodded and went loping out into the building. Catra fiddled with the trapdoor for a moment before getting it open and as she did Adora looked down and saw five frightened people looking up from the cramped space. Two clones and their child and two men holding each other close.

“You alright?” Adora said, trying to give a smile. One of the clones spoke up.

“We are not physically hurt,” he said. The others nodded in agreement.

“That’s good to hear,” Adora said as she looked around again. “This town is still a bit unstable. Do you have a safe space we can escort you to?”

One of the men gave a humorless laugh as he said, “No need, we’re already in it.”

Adora nodded as she looked around again as the breeze from outside carried the smell of smoke in with it.

“Understandable,” she said. “Listen, we have a skiff. We can get all of you out of town, take you back to Bright Moon if you want.”

There was a brief conversation between the four adults hiding before the clone who’d spoken before said, “We’re in agreement.”

As Melog returned, Catra put an arm around them and said, “I’m going to bring the skiff to the backdoor here. No reason we need to go parading down the street.”

“You sure you’ll be ok?” Adora said, her gut tightening up.

“I’ll be just fine,” Catra said, briefly touching Adora’s hand. “Back in a few.”

Adora nodded and watched her trot to the backdoor, look around, and then break into an easy run, Melog right on her heels. Adora turned and began helping everyone up from under the stage, as the child looked around, eyes wide with fear.

“We have been here since last night,” one of the clones said. “What has happened?”

Adora looked at the kid and hesitated. The clone noticed and said, “Brother Krist has already been scared enough. Not knowing does not bring ease in this case.”

Adora sighed but gave a quick brief of what had happened with the clones fleeing town.

“You’re probably the only ones in this whole town right now,” Adora ended with. Silence fell for a moment before the two men looked up. Adora followed their gaze and saw three people with stun batons standing quietly in the front door to the theater area. They had the badge of the town guard on but Adora would have bet her home that at least two of them hadn’t worn it very long.

“What are you doing here?” one of the guards said.

“Helping,” Adora said, stepping between them and the five people. “What are you doing?”

“You’re not allowed to be here,” what seemed to be the head guard of the three said. “I’m placing you all in custody. Please come this way.”

Adora looked at the three slowly before shaking her head as she said, “No.”

“You will comply,” the head guard said and Adora felt her fists close.

“No, I won’t,” Adora said.

“Listen, don’t think we won’t use force, because we will,” the head guard said as the three started to advance slowly through the wrecked room. “Make it easy on yourselves.”

Adora brought her fists up.

“I am Princess Adora of Bright Moon. These people are under my protection and I am taking them with me to Bright Moon.”

The three stopped for a moment and the head guard said, “You’re not in Bright Moon. You don’t have authority here.”

“I don’t care. You can’t have them.”

She saw two of the guards whispering to each other and eyeing her and she knew they were trying to decide if she was who she said she was. Adora knew most people knew her from the old

images of her from the war and with gray starting to streak through her blonde hair and the wrinkles on her face, it wasn't quite the same face anymore.

One of the other guards said, "Yeah, you're full of it or you'd be She-Ra. Take them."

The three stun batons snapped to life as the guards started forward again. Adora leaned down and picked up a chair leg off the floor, shook the broken pieces off it, and then slowly rolled her shoulders to get loose. Then she heard the skiff coming in behind her.

"Go towards the skiff, now," Adora said to the five behind her. They didn't argue and they started running. The guards shouted and started charging forward. Adora carefully aimed and threw the chair leg at the head guard, then turned and ran without bothering to see if she hit him or not.

Adora saw that Catra hadn't wasted time when she saw people come running out. She'd landed close to the door and was helping Krist over the side when Adora ran up as Melog jumped off and growled at the guards who were coming out the door.

"I think I just assaulted the town guard; get on the controls!" Adora shouted.

Catra looked at the back door at the three guards and Adora was shocked to hear her suddenly laugh and shiver ran down her spine because it was a laugh she hadn't heard in years. It was the laugh of Catra suddenly excited for a fight.

"No! No fight! Controls!"

"I know! I know!" Catra said, still laughing as she jumped back onto the skiff. Adora helped the last person up and then saw the guards were closing in on them. Adora turned around, fists up again as Melog jumped past her onto the skiff, when she felt three pairs of hands grab her under her arms and grabbed hold of her coat. They held on tight as the skiff lifted, taking her up with it, and skewed sideways as Catra yelled at her.

"What happened to no fight!? Get on the skiff!" Catra said.

"Set it down for a second then! I'm not climbing up backwards!" Adora shouted back.

Catra set down, further away, as Adora turned and clambered on with the help of the rest of the people on the skiff. Melog settled at Catra's feet as Catra gave a little condescending salute at the three guards who'd stopped running when they realized they wouldn't catch up and then the skiff jumped towards the sky and flew off.

Later when they arrived in Bright Moon, the two men went on after thanking Adora and Catra and assuring them they had friends in Bright Moon they could stay with. Adora and Catra took the two caretakers and their child in and got them settled in one of their spare rooms. They helped them get in touch with friends to assure them they were alright and Adora sat down at the table with the two caretakers, Hisen and Ecta, while Catra and Krist made dinner.

"Thank you for your help," Ecta said.

"You're welcome. I just wish I could have done more," Adora said. The three turned as they heard Krist giggle from the kitchen as Catra booped him gently on the head with a bunch of lettuce and Melog made a little answering chirping giggling noise.

"You invited us into your home after risking yourselves," Hisen said quietly. "You have done more than could be expected."

"No, I did exactly as should be expected of anyone," Adora replied. "Please know that you're more than welcome to stay here as long as you need."

"Thank you, that's not necessary," Hisen said. "We will be contacting Brother Izzy and arranging for transport to Dryl."

Adora nodded as she said, "I understand. The offer still stands if you need it."

Silence fell around the table as Adora listened to Catra teaching Krist some little song and for a moment, things were almost normal. Later that evening, after they'd eaten and the three had settled down to sleep, Adora sat in her office trying to find out more information. Izzy had been contacted and had promised to send people to help Hisen and Ecta. Adora had noticed that Izzy was distracted but hadn't said anything. She imagined Izzy had plenty going on and didn't need any unasked for advice from her mom-in-law on what she was doing.

"Figure anything out?" Catra said as she came into the room.

"No," Adora said. "No one's heard from Cappe still although her guard did show back up at Bright Moon and they looked like they'd been in a fight. They're not saying anything at the moment or they're not telling me which amounts to the same for now. Mermista said Cappe dropped one of her friends off in front of her castle last night. The friend had been really badly wounded and the guards said Cappe teleported right back out after she saw they were helping her friend. Scorpia and Perfuma both said they've been handling people running into the Fright Zone from Wheatland but haven't seen her in the crowd. No one seems to have heard from any of Cappe's other friends yet and you know she'd never leave Gress behind somewhere. Between the injured friend and the silence, I don't like what any of that implies."

"I don't either. You think she's maybe still in Salineas?" Catra said, looking at the large holographic display that Adora had up with a map of Etheria hovering over her desktop. There were two dots on it, one on Wheatland and one in Salineas, and Catra could see

Adora had multiple surveying programs up to analyze the location data when it came in.

"I think that's the last place she was seen but with her teleporting, who knows," Adora said. "My goal is this. Glimmer and Bow are going to be back in a week. We need to find Cappe by then so I'm going to send out a message to all the princesses to send me information. We need to know what happened and for me it starts with tracking where she's been spotted and trying to find a trend."

Adora sat and fiddled with a pen on her desk as Catra put her arm around her and looked at the map for a moment.

"You OK?" Catra said.

"No," Adora said after a pause. "Something that guard said bothered me. He said if it was me, I would have already been She-Ra. He's right. I absolutely would have and maybe that would have made it so much easier. Could have probably helped so many more people…"

As Adora trailed off, Catra knelt down in front of her and took Adora's hand in hers.

"Stop. Don't spiral like that. There are five people, three of them sleeping peacefully just down the hall, who you helped. It matters to them," Catra said. "You think they care that it wasn't her?"

Adora shrugged as she said, “It matters to me.”

“There isn’t much you can do about that unless something new happened while you were at Mystacor,” Catra said.

Adora leaned back in her chair with a sigh as she said, “No, there isn’t anything new. Honestly, the only reason I’m going back at all anymore is to help Angella with Micah.” Adora suddenly sat up. “Oh *Mara,* we’re going to have to tell Angella that Cappe is missing.”

“Let’s call her then,” Catra said. “I doubt she’s asleep.”

Adora was tempted to wait until she could go back and do it in person. She knew she was just stalling though and took a deep breath.

“OK. Stay with me?”

Catra nodded and sat on the desk beside her as Adora typed at the data pad. Angella answered after a long wait.

“Adora? It’s almost the middle of the night,” Angella said.

“I’m sorry, I know, but something has happened,” Adora said.

Angella sighed as she said, “Of course. Nothing good ever comes from a midnight call.”

“I don’t know how to say this but… Cappe has gone missing,” Adora said, a lump suddenly in her throat. “She was at Wheatland when it all went bad. We’ve been trying to find her all day but we haven’t had any luck. I’m sorry it took us so long to contact you.”

Angella’s picture suddenly changed and they were looking at the ceiling of her living room.

“Angella? Are you… hello? Are you ok?” Catra said.

“I’m here,” they heard her say, her voice strained.

“Have you heard from her?” Adora said.

“No,” Angella said. “Thank you for calling me.”

The call suddenly ended and Adora and Catra looked at each other.

“Did we lose her?” Adora said.

“She hung up,” Catra said. “I don’t blame her. It’s been one thing after another for her lately. I’d hang up as well.”

“I should have waited,” Adora said.

“No, we should have called earlier,” Catra said. “Doesn’t matter though. We did what was needed. Come to bed. You’re not going to be of any use if you’re exhausted.”

“I just need to send out that message,” Adora said.

“You have five minutes and then I take your data pad from you,” Catra said. Adora leaned forward and gave Catra a kiss.

“Thank you,” Adora said.

“You’re welcome. Now, the clock’s ticking,” Catra said as she stood up. Adora gave a weak smile and started typing. A few minutes later she went and lay down but sleep was a long time in coming.

The next few days were eventful. Wheatland lodged a complaint of Adora interfering with their internal working. Izzy sent a few clones to escort Hisen, Ecta, and Krist to Dryl. Most of the clones

that had left Wheatland had ended up going to Dryl as Izzy sent out people to get them. Reports of Capella came in from all over and Adora kept up a steady stream of information to Glimmer over the long range communications net but Adora felt helpless because it was a whole bunch of nothing she was sending on.

A week later, Adora looked up at her map that hung over her desk and saw the scattering of sightings. Nothing had panned out. Glimmer hadn't responded to her messages recently and Adora felt lost. She had finally managed to talk with the guard that had been at Wheatland and they'd told her they'd never seen Capella but had gotten into a fight with someone at a farmhouse out in the countryside where they suspected she had been. She read through the sighting information again and again but it was always something along the lines of, "I saw her! Had to be her! Looked just like her! She's six foot five and bald right?"

As Adora sighed and set down another report, she heard a surprised shout from the kitchen where Catra was cooking. Adora jumped to her feet and went running out to find Glimmer sitting on the step down into the living room, tears streaking her face, as Catra was sitting down with her back against Glimmer's back.

"Glimmer…," Adora said, carefully.

"Have you found anything new?" Glimmer said, reaching back to grab Catra's hand and squeeze.

Adora wanted to talk about the trails the other princesses were tracking and what was going on but she knew that wouldn't

matter. It was still a big fat zero. Adora's voice cracked as she said, "No."

Glimmer nodded as she started to lean back into Catra and then suddenly stood up and walked out into the living room, her wings twitching. Finally, she turned and looked at both of them.

"I went and talked to Izzy before this," Glimmer said. "She has an intelligence network and I figured out that Cappe's been working for her. Did you two know about that?"

"That Cappe has been working for her?" Catra said as she turned around to face Glimmer. "No. I've heard rumors about the intelligence network though but I never asked her."

Glimmer stared at them both and Adora felt uncomfortable under her gaze as she responded.

"No, I didn't know about it either. Catra told me about the network thing a while back but just that it was a rumor," Adora said. Glimmer stood with her arms crossed and Adora started across the room towards her. "We've been trying to find her…"

"Yeah, I get it. Got it from the messages," Glimmer said. "Izzy said the same thing. Trying to find her but she's not showing up is she?"

Glimmer sat on the back of the couch as she put her hand up to keep Adora from trying to hug her as tears slipped down her face. "You know, we'd just finally got back to some kind of normal after that whole mess from Poview. I was so excited to hear about how this new thing went but I screwed up didn't I? I shouldn't have given her any kind of validation for this. I should have taken her with me or forced her to stay home somehow."

"You know she would have…," Catra started to say.

"I don't care! I'm her mother! I'm supposed to keep her safe! And she's gone and Bow will be landing any minute now and I have to go back and tell him our daughter is gone! And the only reason I can have any hope whatsoever is I can still feel her connected to the Moonstone! But that doesn't mean she isn't hurt and scared or unconscious or even maybe just…"

Glimmer trailed off as she looked down and Adora could catch a glimpse of the horrors that were playing in Glimmer's mind from the look on her face. Adora started to reach out again and Glimmer's head snapped up.

"Don't comfort me; I don't deserve it. Help me find my daughter instead," Glimmer said.

Catra said, "Don't say that. Of course you deserve comfort and of course we'll help you find her. We're already trying."

Glimmer stood and stared Catra in the eyes, her face going hard even as tears continued streaking down.

"Have you tried? Really tried?"

"Of course we have," Adora said. "I can show you…"

"A map? Some sighting reports? If Finn went missing, is that what you'd do?" Glimmer said. "No, and you damn well know it."

"We're doing everything…," Catra started to say before Glimmer cut her off.

"No, you are not! You know there's more you can do! What do you need? You need the Bright Moon guard!? You have it! I'll make you both generals! You need weapons!? Done! Money, transport, anything that is within my power, you have it! I want you to help me tear this world apart until we find her! I know you both know how! If you were ever my friends, you'll do this for me!" Glimmer shouted, her hands shaking and tears coursing down her face.

Adora tried to think of what to say as Catra stepped forward, her face cold and serious.

"No," Catra said. "I won't do what you're asking."

“Yes, you will and you know why?” Glimmer said, her voice threatening as she wiped at her face. “Because you owe me. Did you forget that you didn’t end up on Beast Island after the war with Hordak and Entrapta because of me? That the very ground this house stands on is yours because of me? Everything you two have built your life on after the war came about because of me! You! Owe! Me!”

“Glimmer…,” Adora started to say.

“Unless you’re going to say, ‘We’ll start now’ I don’t want to hear it,” Glimmer shot back at her.

Catra replied, “I won’t burn the world for you.”

“Coward,” Glimmer said, pointing a shaking figure at Catra as her face lost its hardness and tears made fresh tracks down her face.

“No, I’m your friend and one who’ll tell you no,” Catra said. “Get Bow. Go home. Come see us tomorrow when you’ve calmed down and we’ll plan. We’ll find her but not that way.”

Glimmer took a step forward and for a split second Adora thought Glimmer was going to punch Catra but then she disappeared in a cloud of sparkles and Catra sat down on the floor.

“You ok? You know she’s just scared and angry,” Adora said as she knelt down next to her, her voice shaking a little. Catra looked up with a sad smile.

“She just screamed at both of us and your first thought is to make sure I’m alright.”

“Do you think we should go up to the castle tonight?” Adora said.

“No,” Catra said. “I think we do what we said and keep trying to find Cappe. She’ll be back and whatever her mood, I hope we can get her to understand we’re trying as hard as we can.”

Adora hugged Catra and Catra hugged her back before they got up and Catra went back to the kitchen. The food she had been cooking for dinner was smoking and she shook her head as she pulled the pan off the stove and set it in the sink. Adora leaned against the wall as she said, “Do you think she’s right? That we would do more if Finn had gone missing?”

Catra leaned against the sink and wiped at her eyes.

“I don’t know. I mean, I thought about that, you know, when they still lived here. What if someone hurt them or took them? It doesn’t matter though. I won’t be that Catra again.”

There was a silence in the kitchen, the two alone with their thoughts, when Catra suddenly slid down onto the floor.

"We should have gone with her to Wheatland," Catra said. "We should have been there when it went down."

Adora went over and sat down next to her.

"I know. We weren't though and we can't say what if. We have to work with what is. Breath with me."

Catra gave a sad smile at her as she nodded and the two took deep breaths, in and out, over and over, as they fought the thoughts in their head. After a little while, Adora whispered, "I'll make some sandwiches."

They went to bed early and woke up in the middle of the night to a knock on the front door. Adora looked at Catra who was sitting up with her hand on Melog. The two silently got out of bed, Melog draped around Catra's shoulders, as they walked towards the front door. Another knock came right before they got there and they heard muffled voices on the other side. Adora finally opened the door and Glimmer stood there with Bow.

The four stared at each other. It was obvious that Bow had been crying, as had Glimmer. No one said anything at first and it was Bow who finally spoke up.

“I wasn’t here earlier but I understand some things were said,” Bow said quietly.

Catra reached up and rested her hand on Melog as Adora said, “As much as I want to just pretend like there weren’t, yes, there were.”

“May I come into your house and talk about it? Please?” Glimmer said. Adora turned and looked at Catra who gave the briefest of head nods.

“Sure,” Adora said and moved out of the way. Glimmer and Bow came in and Catra gestured at the couch. Adora sat down in her easy chair as Catra remained standing. Again silence fell over the room, no one sure where to start. Finally, Glimmer spoke up.

“What I said… I’m sorry. That was cruel. You’re my friends. I’ve just been… no, it was cruel and I’m sorry,” Glimmer said, quietly wringing her hands. “I shouldn’t have done that.”

Catra nodded as she sat a hand on Adora’s shoulder.

“It was cruel and you’re right, you shouldn’t have,” Catra said. “I’m going to forgive you though.”

“It hurt,” Adora said. “Yes, I forgive you but that really hurt to hear.”

“I’ll try not to do it again,” Glimmer said and then shook her head as she reconsidered her words. “No. I won’t do it again at all.” She was quiet for a moment before going on. “I should probably say the same to Izzy.”

“What in the world did you do to Izzy?” Catra said, an eyebrow raised. Glimmer gave her a brief description about what happened and Catra shook her head. “I’m proud of Finn for defusing it like that but I can’t believe you really tried to threaten the Princess of Dryl in her own castle. I know she’s not magic but you two actually fighting would have been interesting in a running and screaming in horror kind of way.”

Bow hugged Glimmer as he said, “What do we do?”

Adora looked at Bow and saw a look of hopelessness on his face. She got up out of her chair and went over to sit down beside him and put her arm around him.

“We’re going to find her, I promise you,” Adora said. Catra sat down on the other side of the two.

“I promise as well,” Catra said. “One way or another, we’ll figure out where she is and what happened to her.”

Bow nodded, his face unwilling to believe in anything but desperately wanting to anyway, as he said, "Bring my little girl home. Please."

The four hugged each other tightly as Bow whispered again so low they could barely hear him, "Just bring her home."

Chapter End Notes

Not much to say on this one. I hope you enjoy it!

Capella

Chapter Summary

> Capella begins to make visits to try and learn what information she can.

Chapter Notes

> "You make this all go away / I'm down to just one thing / And I'm starting to scare myself" Something I Can Never Have by Nine Inch Nails
>
> Note #1: No Micah, no summary
>
> Note #2: A reminder that is rated Teen and so the language can get a little salty. This chapter is an example. Nothing awful, just definitely outside of my normal language.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Capella didn't watch the video that got passed around of her mother calling on her to come home. It was released the day after Glimmer had returned and while Capella felt the pull to watch it, she managed to talk herself out of it. Too many emotions fought within her and she had to fight them down, keep herself focused, or she'd fail and watching that video would have set anger, sorrow, longing, and love fighting in her and she didn't know what would win and didn't want to find out.

She was still in the Valley of the Lost, moving about under cover of her illusions, two days after the video had been released. Coalfire had brought her the information on the four heads of the Children of Mara and Capella had looked it over and slowly formulated a plan. She was still staying in the loft and Half Ear had come by a few times to tell Coalfire something and always took a moment to antagonize Capella a little if she was there.

“Why does he do that?” Capella said once after he’d left.

Coalfire had shrugged as she said, “He doesn’t like princesses. Never did find out why. I think it bothers him that you’re here.”

“Yeah, but I’m paying you,” Capella said. “I remember him saying he’d work for anyone who paid him. Is he something I need to worry about?”

Coalfire had shrugged a little when she heard Capella give that little bit of insight before saying, “Naw. He’s just a jackass.”

Now Capella was coming back from the market with a big container of noodles. She looked like one more person who lived in the Waste, wearing a heavy canvas coat and old t-shirt, baggy pants, and boots that didn’t have the Bright Moon emblem on them. She wore her dagger on her left hip openly but she’d learned that this didn’t even get her a second glance in the Waste. She considered it a final test before she went out that evening to try and do what she had planned and so far it was going well. As she cut through an alley to the next street, she suddenly stopped in the shadows as she heard a voice boom out.

“I didn’t ask you if you cared, I asked if you’d seen her.”

Capella edged up to the edge of the alley and saw her Aunt Huntara holding up a photo of Capella to a guy sitting behind a table full of mechanical parts.

"Naw, I haven't seen her. Although… you know I could be persuaded to remember…," he started to say with a little sly grin. Huntara leaned forward, her arm flexing as her fist hit the table.

"You wouldn't be trying to *scam* me would you?" she said with a big smile.

Capella didn't stand around to see what happened from there. She quietly went back down the alley and took another way. A few minutes later she was moving through a little market full of sellers with pottery and brass trinkets when she suddenly turned and took a huge interest in a brass censer. She pretended to be looking at the chain on the censer as her heart thumped hard in her chest as she looked out of the corner of her eye at the blonde woman she'd last seen in a farmhouse on the edge of Wheatland who was standing and talking to a stall owner. The woman was dressed in clothes that blended in but it was no mistaking who she was because her face was seared into Capella's mind.

"You interested?" said the owner of the little booth as they nodded at the censer. "I got a buddy who sells good incense for it. I can get you a discount if you need one."

Capella just shook her head as she quietly said, "Naw, sorry. Just curious. Thanks."

Capella was about to turn and go back the way she came when an old Horde cargo truck covered in graffiti parked, blocking the way in. The stall owners started shouting at the driver as two other guys hopped out and started unloading some boxes. Capella looked around for another exit. However, there was only one way.

You wanted to test it, Capella thought. *Now's the time.*

Taking a deep breath and trying to keep her face neutral, she wound her way through the little crowd, and walked behind the woman. As she did, she had to fight her hand to keep it from drifting towards her dagger for the comfort of it. While no one would look twice at her for carrying it, everyone would look at her if she made a move like she was going to draw it. As Capella passed, the woman didn't even look up as she continued to talk to the stall owner.

"Never mind who I am or who I'm asking for," the woman said. "You see her, you contact me. Don't cross me."

The stall owner looked bored as they listened to her and waved their hand a little in the air in a hurry it up gesture. Capella for a brief moment thought the woman was going to slap the hand out of the air but she just turned and walked to the next stall. Capella went around the corner into another street and it took everything she had not to start sprinting or teleport away. She took several random turns, keeping an eye over her shoulder the whole time, but no one followed her that she could tell and she was soon back in the little room. Alice and Coalfire looked up from where they sat at a table as Capella leaned back against the door.

“You alright?” Alice said as Capella dismissed her illusion.

“After I eat, I gotta get going,” Capella said as she went to the table and set the noodle container down. Alice got up and got two bowls, filled them up and put one in front of Capella and took the other herself. Coalfire almost never ate in front of Capella and she’d never gotten up the nerve to ask why.

“Why so fast?” Alice said as she inhaled the steam off the broth before grabbing some chopsticks and slurping up some noodles.

“My Aunt Huntara is in town asking around about me. More importantly, someone else is as well that I’ve… had a run in with,” Capella said, not wanting to give them more information than she felt they needed to know at the moment.

“You coming back?” Coalfire said.

“I have to. I’ll want to talk to you in person,” Capella said. “But I think maybe I need to find another place.”

“I can do that,” Alice said as she looked up from her noodles.

“For how much?” Capella said as she ate quickly, thinking of the things she needed to do.

“I’ll throw it in as a perk for the contract,” Alice said with a grin. “Slow down. You gotta chew your food.”

“I gotta get going is what I gotta do,” Capella said. “I don’t know if I was spotted and I was careful coming back but still… I don’t want to endanger anyone.”

Coalfire snorted as she said, “Says the person who hired us for dangerous intel work.”

“You know what I mean,” Capella said as she slurped up the last noodle and then drank off the broth. She stood up and went up into the loft. She thought of the places she planned on going as she got changed. She picked up a small duffel bag to go with her satchel and packed away her Crimson Waste clothes as she got changed into the clothes she’d arrived in. The boots she’d been wearing that day she kept on though. They were heavier and clunkier than the boots she’d worn in from Bright Moon but they also felt way more solid and she felt irrationally safer in them for some reason. She climbed back down with her two bags over her shoulder and Alice and Coalfire looked at her.

“You remember the passphrase?” Coalfire asked. Capella nodded and Coalfire sighed. “Listen, I like you and not just because you paid us a bunch of money. Be careful.”

“I’m going to do what needs doing. I’m not sure that’s careful,” Capella said. “I’ll try and return late tonight.”

“Don’t come back here,” Coalfire said. “Contact me before you return. Either through the data pad or I’ll be at the bar. Use the face you did the first time. The bartender knows to look for her.”

Capella nodded and stood for a moment, feeling awkward. She felt very lonely all of a sudden but before anyone could say anything else, she teleported out, headed for her first visit of the evening.

Her first visit went off without a hitch and then she teleported outside of Wheatland. She stood in a small line of trees along a field, listening to the wind whistle through them as she carefully packed away the robes she’d stolen on her first visit, the dark blue barely visible in the dark. She carefully looked around to make sure no one was around, having a brief memory of playing hide and seek in Catra and Adora’s backyard among the bushes, but all she saw was the shifting light of the night sky. She put her duffle bag and satchel down against a trunk and used her dagger to chop a few limbs off to cover them. As she shifted the sheath to hide it under her coat and sheathed the dagger she looked at the covered bags. She figured it was good enough for dark but it would still probably be noticeable as off in the daylight. However, she knew that if it took that long, she probably wasn’t coming back to them anyway.

With that thought, Capella had to take a few long deep breaths before she teleported the rest of the way into Wheatland. She appeared behind the little community center where it’d all started and saw it boarded up and covered in anti-clone graffiti. She shoved the grief away, wiping her eyes as she did, and reminded herself that she had a job to do and started walking. It was

already late as she walked down the dark streets. She saw the burned out buildings and noticed how the ones still standing were either dark, like the occupants were trying to keep hidden, or blazing with lights to try and make sure nothing had any shadow to hide in.

When she got to the main street of the town, all the businesses looked closed down, even the ones like the cafes that she'd expect to see open later. A few had shattered glass and busted doors on the front that no one had bothered to repair or board up and she had a sneaking suspicion those had been clone run businesses. At the corner of the two main streets through town stood the little city council building and it was well lit with a little crowd of people standing around outside. Capella took a deep breath.

Illusions in place, voice is practiced, here we go, she thought as she walked forward.

Capella kept her face serious as she walked up and the crowd gave her a look as she walked past them up the steps. She kept waiting for someone to say something but no one said a word as she went in. Right inside the door was a room that had been the city council chambers. Theater seats took up most of the room with a couple of big tables at the front and a holographic display behind it. The people in the room turned and looked at her as she came in. One woman who could have rivaled Huntara for size, came over to Capella.

"What are you doing here?" she said, her voice bored as she crossed her arms in front of her and Capella idly wondered how she didn't tear the tight t-shirt she was wearing.

“Name’s Sareen,” Capella said as she worked to keep her fake voice consistent. “I’m here to see Neral.”

“Are you know?” the woman said with a little smile. “And she knows this?”

Capella thought about trying to bluff but she needed to do this as quietly as possible and lying more than necessary wouldn’t help. She crossed her arms in front of herself, partly to keep her hands from shaking, and looked hard at the woman.

“No, she doesn’t as a matter of fact. Listen, I had a long trip down here from Erelandia, I’ve heard she’s the person to talk to if I want something from the council, and I’ve got a long trip tomorrow. Is she available or not?” Capella had a sudden insight and she went on. “If she can make time for me, I can make it worth everyone’s while.”

The woman looked at her with a mocking smile as she said, “I’m sure. Listen, have a seat there; I’ll see if Neral is available.”

Capella looked at the offered bench on the wall beside the front door and shrugged. She went over and sat down on the edge, making sure not to sit back in case she clacked her hidden sheath against the back of the bench, and waited as the woman went away through a door next to a little service counter built into the wall.

A few people eyed her but she just looked at them for a moment before looking away as if she was bored. Inside though, she was terrified and she kept her arms crossed and tried not to fidget as she waited. People wandered in and out of the room, some of them going through the door the woman had come through and others who chatted for a few minutes with the people hanging out before moving on.

After what seemed like an eternity, the woman came back out and said, “Sareen, get over here.”

Capella inwardly sighed a little as she stood up and followed the woman back through the door. She didn’t know what she expected when she went through the door but what she walked into was a small open office space with desks around the floor and a few offices along a wall. Filing cabinets sat up against one wall and a skylight was colored with the night time aurora. The woman didn’t say anything else but led Capella right up to an office.

A bored looking woman with the sides of her head shaved and wearing a jumpsuit sat behind a desk. Capella had to fight the urge to say hello to her and greet her by name. She’d seen the face in the information Coalfire had given her but planned to be as circumspect as she could manage.

“Doric here says you’re looking for Neral,” Neral said. “That your name is Sareen and you’re from Erelandia? That right?”

“That’s right,” Capella said, putting her hands on one of the wooden chairs in front of the desk. She was trying not to sweat as Doric moved behind her and leaned against the door frame.

“Why are you here and so late too?” Neral said.

“I’ll tell Neral,” Capella said.

“That’s me,” Neral said. “So just tell me.”

Capella had rehearsed what she was going to say so she managed to get it out without a hitch, even though the words she said felt awful in her mouth.

“I’m here because I hear you drove the clones out and you can get the town council to do what you want,” Capella said. “I want to build a business in a town without that kind of filth in it and I propose to cut you in on a part of the profits if you can get the town council to cut me some deals on both property and taxes. Say, five percent of my net income.”

Neral looked down at a data pad on the desk in front of her and slowly nodded.

“You know, this could have been a message to my data pad,” she said as she looked back up at Capella. “Maybe you wanted to

meet in person because of the huge dagger you have hidden on your back."

As she said that Capella felt Doric's hands drop onto both of Capella's shoulders and grip tight. Capella repressed the urge to show Doric just how solid her boots were. She still needed to talk with them.

"I'd heard it'd gotten dangerous on the road," Capella said. "I wasn't trying to hide anything."

"You know, that's funny because I can't find your name in Erelandia. So what about proof of your business? What about proof of who you are?" Neral said with a bored smile as she pushed her data pad away a little. Capella was about to speak with her cover plan when Neral's smile got less bored and scarier. "Wait, one last question. Is there anyone that's going to miss you?"

Capella felt herself get hurled towards the wall. If it had been anyone else, she would have smashed into the solid wall and been dazed long enough for Doric to do whatever it was she had planned. Capella didn't even think about it though, she just teleported and ended up behind Doric. Capella grabbed one of the wooden chairs as Doric was turning around and swung it overhand. It would have been a great move if Doric hadn't simply reached around and grabbed the chair with both hands and yanked it out of Capella's hand. Doric had a huge grin on her face as she swung the chair at Capella. Capella didn't hesitate and teleported out of the way and behind Neral.

As she did, she saw Neral grabbing for her data pad. Capella grabbed it first and then grabbed Neral by the hair and crouched down behind Neral. Doric turned with the chair and was about to throw it when Neral started shouting.

"Wait!"

"Good call," Capella said, trying to see over Neral's shoulder without exposing too much of herself.

"You're that princess," Neral said, her voice strained. Capella almost denied it then realized that would be pretty silly since she'd just spent the last few seconds teleporting around the room.

"Yeah, I am," Capella said. "All you had to do was answer a few questions and I would have been on my way but no, you had to go all wild on me."

As Capella spoke, Doric sat the chair down and calmly pulled a collapsible baton out of her pocket and snapped it open.

"Tell her to stop!" Capella said, trying but not entirely succeeding on keeping the panic out of her voice.

"You're a murderer," Neral said. "Everyone's looking for you; they're gonna put you in rehabilitation for years and years. That's assuming we don't get you first."

Doric was slowly starting to come around the desk and Capella yanked back harder on Neral's hair.

"If I'm a murderer, what makes you think you're safe?" Capella spat out as she tried to keep Neral between her and Doric. Neral was about to reply when Capella shoved her forward. Doric just shoved Neral to the side, sending her smashing into a bookcase and as she brought the baton down. Capella teleported to the outer room and saw the chair she'd been hiding behind break as the baton smashed the top of it. Neral was screaming curses as she got up out of the bookcase and pointed at Capella. Capella couldn't really hear what she said but she did manage to hear the words data pad and suddenly realized she still had Neral's data pad in her hand. People were running into the room and Capella looked around frantically for a moment as Doric came running out of the room yelling at people to grab Capella.

Capella decided this was the very definition of knowing when to cut losses and teleported out, taking Neral's data pad with her. Something in her though made her teleport to the front of the building where the small crowd was still hanging out, most of them looking back into the building to figure out what the fuss was about. She'd dropped her illusion as she appeared and when everyone turned around to stare gape jawed at Capella standing in the middle of the street, she yanked her dagger out of its sheath and pointed it at the crowd to dissuade anyone from trying to charge her.

"Look at me! I am Capella and don't think you've gotten away with any of this! I don't forget and *I don't forgive!"* she said, screaming the last bit. She wasn't sure why she did but it just

came bubbling out of her right before she teleported out. She appeared by her bags and quickly kicked the branches off as she sheathed her dagger and threw Neral's data pad into her satchel with her own. She was shaking and her stomach was a knot as she shouldered the bags.

Capella had one last stop before she got in contact with Coalfire again though. She spent a few minutes getting herself collected as she thought about her next stop. She wasn't sure how good an idea it was but she had remembered a promise from several years back the day before when she had been planning and she figured it was time to collect on that as she teleported away.

Capella's teleport finished a few hundred feet above a house she'd spent so much time in over the years. It was late but not so late that Catra and Adora would normally have gone to bed but she didn't see any lights on. As she fell through the sky, she spotted the flicker of a fire in their fire pit and two figures sitting around it. She teleported to the front of the house and stood in the bushes for a long moment, listening, before she went around the house and into the backyard.

Capella moved as silently as she could, keeping a constant eye out and straining her ears as she approached the slope down to the fire pit. She heard voices quietly talking and she froze when she heard them stop. She waited a long breath, wondering if she should move or just leave, when she heard Catra's voice clearly.

"Whoever's up there, come on down."

Capella couldn’t help but notice the voice sounded tired and again she almost left. Instead, she straightened up a little and walked to the edge of the little slope that went down into the fire pit. She wasn’t sure what reaction she had been expecting but the one she got was seeing her Aunt Catra and Aunt Adora sitting in frozen shock looking up at her. The three stared at each other for what felt like forever but it was only a few seconds before Adora stood up.

“Cappe?” she said, her voice full of hope.

Capella couldn’t answer. She just stared at them both and wondered how much they both knew about Dark Moon. She didn’t know where to start and she was suddenly realizing just how much danger she might be in from the two women. She took a step back, starting to change her mind, as Catra came to her feet.

“Please, wait,” she said. “Cappe? That is you, right?”

Capella slowly nodded her head. The two started to walk towards her and Capella held her hand up and finally found her voice.

“No! Both of you stay right where you’re at,” Capella replied, forcing her voice to be hard. The two stopped, confusion on their faces.

“We’re not going to hurt you; we’ve been really worried about you,” Adora said. “Are you alright? Come sit down.”

“Stop, I’m not staying,” Capella said. “I’m only here for a moment. Do you two remember the promise you made me at Finn’s theater when I was a kid?”

The two looked a little puzzled at each other for a moment before Catra’s ears twitched a little.

“Yeah, I think I know what you’re talking about,” Catra said.

“I’m here to see you fulfill it,” Capella said, her fists clenching as she shoved down all the emotions that were boiling up in her.

“I remember as well,” Adora said. “Listen, you look exhausted. Have you seen your parents? They’re worried about you.”

Capella backed up half a step as she shook her head.

“What are you going to do to fulfill your promise?”

Adora held her hand out as she said, “Cappe, we can talk about that in the morning. Come down here or let us come up there and we’ll help you.”

“There’s nothing to talk about in the morning. We can talk about it right now. Tell me what you’re going to do,” Capella said.

Catra started to take a step forward and Capella’s eyes snapped right to her. Catra stopped and held her hands up.

“Cappe, the promise was to give you what help we could. Right now, that help is helping you and getting you back home,” Catra said.

Capella’s eyes narrowed as she looked at them both.

“Gotcha. Sure,” Capella said and snorted. “So all that talk from you two about a promise being sacred was bullshit.”

“No, we said we’d do what we could to help. Right now, this is it,” Adora replied. Capella started to back away again and Adora held her hand out.

“Cappe, please, don’t!” Adora said.

“How long did you two know about it? I’ve thought about it and I can’t see Mom keeping it from either one of you!? How long!?” Capella shouted.

“What are you talking about?” Catra said.

“You know! Don’t act like you don’t!” Capella shouted at her.

Catra just slowly shook her head as she said, “I don’t, Cappe. I promise, I don’t.”

“Promise. I’ve seen how good your promises are,” Capella said, almost spitting the word promise back at the two. “Tell Mom I won’t forget what she did.”

Catra figured it out a split second sooner than Adora did but they both went running for her as she teleported. As Capella jumped, the sound of both of their voices screaming “Wait!” echoed in her ears.

Chapter End Notes

> OK, this chapter has some language in it that I don't normally put in a fic. However, when I started doing this series I knew that I wanted to step out of my comfort zone in many respects. So that meant things like outlining more so I could have multiple fics feeding into this one, the multiple shifting viewpoints in this fic, and of course, the imagery would be a bit different. Part of that was violence of course but part of it is the the language gets a bit more on the adult side (I am planning on one F-Bomb and no, I won't say who gets it yet). I know that I'm keeping it pretty tame for the most part but it's still outside my comfort zone. Anyway, all that for a few damns and a BS but there it is.

Anyway, I hope you're enjoying this and I wanted to say that I'm pretty close to hitting 200,000 words soon on this. Is that close to the end? I don't know just yet. We'll see.

Izzy

Chapter Summary

> Izzy gets notification of Capella's visit to Catra and Adora's house and has to figure out what her next move may be.

Chapter Notes

> "Every time I think I am out of the woods, I am back in the fire." - Robert Black
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izzy had gone to bed early and so she was sound asleep when Pat got the notification. Izzy immediately regretted the alarm she'd set for said notification when Pat set it off, screeching at high decibels from the speakers she had set up in her and Finn's bedroom as well as flicking her lights on and off a few times for good measure. She sat bolt upright in bed, shaking a little, as she screeched at Pat to shut off the speakers and keep the lights on. She turned to apologize to Finn only to start laughing as she saw them sitting beside her, their fur and tail fluffed out in alarm.

"I'm sorry, Finn," she said as she sputtered. Then she heard what Pat was saying and the laughter died. Capella had shown up at Catra and Adora's house. She grabbed the data pad off the nightstand as Finn looked over her shoulder as she typed. A low shot video of Capella standing in the backyard near the fire pit appeared and she saw several other videos were cued up from the various bots around the yard. They all had audio and as she looked at the timestamps, she realized it was only a few minutes old. She was reaching to make a call when she saw Capella teleport out in the video and Catra and Adora running in desperation up the slope to try and stop her.

“Cursed Prime,” Izzy muttered as Finn hugged her close.

“What was that?” Finn said.

“Bot network at your moms’ place,” Izzy said. “Cappe must have shown up there for some reason but something’s wrong.”

“We need to call Aunt Glimmer and Uncle Bow!” Finn said as they rolled over and grabbed their data pad.

“Finn! No! Not yet,” Izzy said, almost yelling at first before lowering her voice. Finn looked at her, ears folded down a little.

“Izzy, they’ve been worried sick about her,” Finn said. “If you’re still mad about how Glimmer acted…”

“No,” Izzy said. “No, it’s not that.” Izzy took a deep breath before continuing. “I haven’t told you but I don’t one hundred percent trust Glimmer right now and it has nothing to do with the other day. Let me listen to the audio first, OK?”

Finn looked at her and slowly nodded their head.

“OK,” Finn said. “But you better explain what you mean.”

Izzy promised she would and hit the audio on the video. She listened to the conversation, frowning as it went on, and when it was over, looked to see how much the bots had enhanced the audio. She sighed as she saw it had been very little so it was probably exactly as it was said. She ran it again from a different source.

“OK, you’ve watched it twice,” Finn said. “Something’s wrong with Cappe, it’s pretty obvious. She’s acting really strange.”

“No, she’s acting really scared,” Izzy said.

“Is that thing she said at the end about her mom… is that what you mean about not trusting Aunt Glimmer?” Finn said.

Izzy scooted back and leaned against the headboard of the bed as she sat Pat down to pick up her monocle headband. She carefully put it on and adjusted it as Finn watched as she did, knowing she was stalling, but let her get settled.

“Finn, I… how do I say this? Gress seemed to think Dark Moon was real when he arrived,” Izzy said. “Someone attacked them and knew the passphrase to verify that they were sent by Cappe’s Bright Moon guard. They also wore the emblem that’s supposedly been identified as the Dark Moon emblem. Now Cappe shows up

going on about something your moms may have known and that Cappe won't forget what Glimmer did."

Finn looked at her slowly shaking their head before saying, "Come on. That's… come on! That's… just… it's silly! Aunt Glimmer!? Dark Moon!? There's no way!"

"But do you see why I don't want to tell her I know Cappe was at your moms house?" Izzy said. "Besides, your moms are probably telling her right now."

"No, I don't really get it," Finn said. "Tell her!"

"Tell her what? 'I know your daughter was at Catra and Adora's house. How? Oh, secret network of bots around their house. Just like two more I have just down the road from there.' She's already leery of me. I don't see that improving the situation at all," Izzy said. Finn sat the data pad down and took Izzy's hand.

"Iz, come on," Finn said. "You know talking is what's needed here. Be upfront."

Izzy squeezed their hand as she said, "Something small, something personal, I'd agree with you. This is too big though. I can't be wrong on this. I have too many people I'm responsible for. If I thought it was the only way she'd find out that Cappe is at least mostly OK, I'd say fine, maybe I can figure it out. But no, I can't do it."

“I expect you want me to stay quiet about it as well,” Finn said sadly.

“Yes, but you know that’s just my request. It’s your call,” Izzy said.

Finn slowly shook their head as they thought and then both of their data pads beeped as messages came in. Finn picked their data pad back up and looked down as they gave a little mirthless chuckle.

“I guess I don’t have to wonder. You were right,” Finn said. Izzy looked at the message that had come from Catra to a wide distribution list of their friends and family. It didn’t say much, only that Capella had stopped by their house in a distraught state but didn’t seem physically hurt before she left again.

“I’m sorry. I don’t want to do this to you,” Izzy said sadly.

Finn gave a little smile as they said, “I know. I don’t blame you either. You made a promise to your brothers. You’re doing what you think is right. I understand… even if I don’t like it.”

“I’m going to get up,” Izzy said. “This is the first decent break we’ve had since she went missing. I’ve got work to do.”

Finn got up and walked around the bed to kiss her forehead.

"I love you," Finn said as they hugged her tightly.

"I love you too," Izzy said, hugging them back just as tightly.

Finn stayed up for a few minutes, getting her a few snacks in the kitchen before going back to bed. Izzy was chewing on a carrot and having Pat run some programs on the video to make some measurements of Capella. She was wondering if she'd be able to pin down her clothing when a call came in. She flinched a little when she saw that it was from Glimmer but she tapped the answer button anyway.

"I saw the message," Izzy said as Glimmer's tired face came on screen.

"What are you doing?" Glimmer responded.

"Trying to figure out how I can find out if it was actually her," Izzy said. Glimmer looked at her strangely and Izzy went on. "With illusion magic and people like Auncle DT running around, I need to be sure."

Glimmer gave a tired laugh as she said, "If DT pulled a stunt like this, Catra would kill them if I didn't reach them first." Izzy could see Glimmer realized how that sounded as her face got serious

again. “You know what I mean. Besides, she teleported out. It was her.”

Izzy said, “I understand. I’ll call Catra and Adora here in a few, talk with them, find out what was said.”

Izzy kept her face neutral as she saw a troubled cloud cross over Glimmer’s face before she sighed and said, “Adora said she was… troubled. Was demanding they repay some promise that she seemed to think they made to her.” Glimmer looked away for a second and wiped at her eyes before looking back. “What else are you going to do?”

Izzy said, “As soon as I talk with them, I’ll see if there’s something I can work from. I’ve already alerted a few people, they’ll be ready to move by the time I’ve talked with Catra and Adora if there’s anything I can use.”

“Find her, please” Glimmer said, her voice sad.

“I am giving it my all,” Izzy said. Glimmer looked at her for a moment longer and then the call cut. Izzy leaned back with a sigh as she saw Pat give confirmation on facial recognition, body build, and voice prints with high confidence. Izzy called Catra and Adora and spoke with them for half an hour, prying at details and asking questions. Towards the end of the call, Adora leaned in to the camera a little.

“Iz, we’ve never asked but… you have an intelligence network don’t you? That’s why you’re asking all these questions?” Adora said. Izzy almost denied it but finally just nodded her head.

“We know how to keep quiet,” Catra said. “Your bots are nice and unobtrusive as well.”

Izzy started to utter a denial before she just sighed and said, “I’m not spying on you. They’re there for your protection.”

“We appreciate it,” Adora said.

Izzy thought about what more she should say. Adora and Catra were close but at the same time she couldn’t help but remember that they had also been friends with Glimmer for decades and the words Capella had said, that there was no way they didn’t know, kept echoing in her head.

“Well, Ms. and Ms. Applesauce, I’ve got stuff to do and you two are up way past your bedtime,” Izzy said, trying to make a joke. Catra rolled her eyes at the old Applesauce joke and Adora gave a tired chuckle. They said their good-byes and hung up. Several hours later Izzy was drowsing in her office chair when Harpi came in.

“Brother Izzy?” he said quietly as he sat down by her. Izzy stretched and ran her hands through her hair, tucking it back under her horns, and looked at him.

“Brother Harpi, it’s…,” Izzy said with a pause as she pulled up a clock on Pat, “still way too early.”

“I received a message from Snow-by,” Harpi said. “Capella was spotted in Wheatland.”

Izzy sat up more as she rubbed at her eyes.

“When?”

“Earlier this evening,” Harpi said. “She showed up at the town hall under an illusion to try and talk with one of the Children of Mara. It’s not known what happened but it turned into a brief fight. She teleported out into the street, threatened everyone present, and then left.”

Izzy had Pat pull up a timeline and said, “What time?”

Harpi gave her one and Izzy put it on the timeline as she said, “She showed up at Catra and Adora’s house not long after that, had a weird conversation with them, and then teleported out.”

“Stress or something more?” Harpi said.

Izzy thought about it before shaking her head.

"I'm not sure. Because of the bots in the yard, I have video no one is really aware of yet. She's stressed but… no, I'm not a Listener, I don't want to make that kind of determination. I'd say she's stressed, maybe a little paranoid but not without reason," Izzy said. "What was she trying to do in Wheatland?"

"Snow-by was working on it," Harpi said and then looked down at his data pad. "And he just sent something."

Harpi sent it over to Izzy's data pad and she took a moment to read it.

"So she tried to pretend to be a business person from Erelandia, asked for Neral, and then got into a tussle," Izzy said, looking back up at Harpi. "What do you think she was trying to do?"

"I don't know," Harpi said. "But the illusion says she was trying to be subtle about it. Why do you think she chose Neral?"

"Actually, the better question is how she even knew about Neral," Izzy said. "Out of all the Children, she's the one that's furthest back in the shadows. I'd say she's the head of the group if they had such a thing. Between that and the money effectively disappearing, I think she's getting some help from the shady side."

“Who do you think?” Harpi said. Izzy thought for a moment before shrugging.

“I don’t know,” Izzy said. “And it’s not like I can guess based on proximity. She can teleport anywhere on the planet. For all I know she’s hiding in the mountains above Dryl. Has she ever been to Seaworthy that we know? Or the Hidden Grotto?”

Harpi said, “I know she’s been to Seaworthy but it was with her parents. I doubt she’s been to the Grotto. However, I do remember you telling a story that you’d heard from Finn about her going out to the Waste for an Equal thing.”

Izzy slowly nodded her head as she remembered the story.

“That’s right. Glimmer and Bow told Catra and Adora about it. You think she knows someone out there?”

Harpi’s ears twitched as he thought for a moment.

“Maybe but even if we’re not sure, it’s not like we have an abundance of leads to follow,” Harpi said.

“Great,” Izzy said with a sigh. “The Waste is like the number one place on the planet for shady side people. Who knows who she

contacted out there. Snow-by can't get there fast enough. Blu's still checking out that aquaponics group… I guess send out Clee. Tell them they're just poking around and to be super circumspect. Cappe's nervous. I don't want to spook her."

Harpi nodded at the name of one of the field agents and sent out the notifications for it.

"Maybe we should have another try at locating her data pad," Harpi said.

"We should," Izzy said. "I'm kicking myself for telling her to keep her encryption up to date."

"It may very well be keeping her safe right now from others," Harpi said. Izzy sighed as she nodded.

"I know but I'm scared for her. She's out there trying to meet with dangerous people that she probably got information on from *other* dangerous people and I just want to see her safely home," Izzy said.

"Around even more dangerous people?" Harpi said. Izzy looked at him and chuckled.

"Be fair. We're at least not those dangerous people she's probably with now."

“True,” Harpi said. “Do you have time to discuss the latest updates to The List?”

Izzy nodded as she sat up. The clones working on Entrapta and Hordak’s master research list was one of the things she enjoyed hearing about. She hadn’t had a chance to help with actual research in a long time but she enjoyed hearing about it and giving help where she could with her position. Besides, she needed a break and she realized that Harpi knew that as well and was offering it to her.

“Sounds like a good break. Thanks, Brother Harpi,” Izzy said.

Harpi just twitched his ears and smiled as he started talking.

Chapter End Notes

> Not much to say right now except I did pass 200,000 words on this the other day. I hope you're enjoying!

Gress

Chapter Summary

Gress gets word that Capella has been to visit people but not him. Now, Gress decides it's time to do something.

Chapter Notes

"Smoke, fire, it's all goin' up / Don't you know I ain't afraid to shed a little blood? / Smoke, fire, flares are goin' up, flares are goin' up"
White Flag by Bishop Briggs

Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She visited them but not me, Gress thought as he listened to Izzy tell him what had been happening. The feeling clenched at his heart, anger and sorrow all at once.

“So that’s what’s been going on,” Izzy said as she sat back in her chair. “I thought you should know.”

Gress sat very still as he looked at Izzy. He wasn’t sure what to say. He had been worried about her like the rest but now he was angry and he was doing his best to keep it down.

“Has Queen Glimmer asked about speaking with me recently?” Gress said, his tone even.

“No,” Izzy said. “She’s respecting your answer that it’ll be on your time table.”

“Then I need a favor from you, Brother Izzy,” Gress replied.

“What do you need?” Izzy responded. Gress had thought about this but he hadn’t been sure until just now.

“I will go back to Wheatland and speak and I’d like you to help me,” Gress said. “I was interrupted last time. Queen Glimmer is more than welcome to come and listen to me there. I believe I will say many things that will be of interest to her and she’ll be more than welcome to answer questions afterwards.”

Gress didn’t think he’d ever seen Izzy stunned before so it took him a moment to figure out why Izzy didn’t respond at first.

“Brother Gress…,” Izzy started to say and then stopped as she ran her hand up along her ear, as if tucking back a strand of hair. Her mouth opened a few times before she finally managed to go on. “What exactly are you looking to do?”

Gress felt good that she didn’t immediately say no and went on.

“I wish to take the stage as Cappe and I were supposed to do. I wish to speak,” Gress said. “I believe there will be a crowd who’d be interested in hearing what I have to say.”

Gress could see on Izzy’s face she believed there would be a crowd but not necessarily one who’d be interested in anything he had to say and then her face went still as she thought for a moment.

“Brother Gress, I won’t do that for you. There are many reasons but your safety is the highest one for me,” Izzy said.

“Brother Izzy, I’m sorry, I was not clear. I am going to go, with you or without you,” Gress said. “I ask you to help the way you helped Cappe. You will help fund me. I’d like you to come as well but that is your choice.”

Izzy gave a little shake of her head and a brief smile as she said, “I told her not to tell anyone but I should have known she’d tell you.”

“I am her friend,” Gress said and his voice had sorrow in it. “I am furious at her for not making contact with me but she is still my friend and we had a job to do that was interrupted. I will continue it.”

“I understand how you feel,” Izzy said. “It’s not safe for you to go to Wheatland though. If you must, maybe somewhere different...”

“It wasn’t safe the first time,” Gress said, cutting her off. “I’m still going.”

“Brother Gress, no. Speak here from Dryl instead,” Izzy said, starting to shake her head.

“Am I a prisoner here?” Gress said.

“Of course not,” Izzy said.

“Then you will either back me and I will go to Wheatland or you won’t back me and I will still go to Wheatland,” Gress said.

Izzy sat back in her chair, looking at Gress, and Gress looked at her. To some people, Gress would look composed but Izzy had spent enough time around clones to see the barely restrained nerves.

“You’re scared,” Izzy said.

“Of course,” Gress said. “I’d be a fool not to be. I’m still going.”

Izzy picked up her data pad and looked at it for a moment before setting it carefully back on her desk.

"You probably don't know this but Wheatland and several other towns have been flooding the Intergovernmental Review Panel with complaints of princess overreach in their internal matters," Izzy said.

"So you're not going to help because of politics," Gress said, his voice dropping in irritation.

"Didn't say that," Izzy replied. "But you're looking to involve ruling princesses, and the queen I might add, so you need to be aware of that and how it may affect the person you're trying to talk into something. That being said, I won't set foot in Wheatland. Wait a second, let me finish. The town council is under the sway of some scary people and other scary people are flocking to the town. I also don't want to give any excuse for more complaints. However, if you want to give a speech, would you be willing to give it close to Wheatland?"

Gress' head cocked sideways as he said, "You have an idea."

"I have an idea," Izzy said and muttered under her breath for a moment. A monitor turned on next to her desk and showed a map of the area around Wheatland. "See that line not too far from Wheatland off to the right there?" Gress looked and nodded. "That's the border of the Fright Zone. There's a tiny little town there called Base One just on the Fright Zone side."

Izzy went silent and sat back while Gress looked at it. Gress thought and then he nodded.

"You wish me to give a speech in Base One with the understanding that it's close enough to Wheatland that residents of same will be able to easily attend while still being inside the Fright Zone and thus inside a kingdom so there will be no arguments about interference with internal matters because I assume you will be able to get the agreement of the ruling princess for us to gather," Gress said.

Izzy gave a little grin as she said, "You got it. It's Scorpia's kingdom and while her and Perfuma want neutrality, I'm pretty sure they wouldn't object to this."

"No," Gress said. Izzy's grin disappeared.

"Brother Gress, this is the start of a good plan," Izzy replied. "Why no?"

"I won't play that game," Gress said. "I will go to Wheatland, I will have my say, and again, if the queen wishes to ask me questions, she'll go there and not to a location that is politically safe."

Izzy said, "I respect that. I can't go though and I don't know if Glimmer would either. I can see your face so let me explain. The

reason I can't go is because the Clone Council, even with everything that is going on, wants us to try and stay as out of it as possible. They do not want it to seem like Dryl, and the clones who live here, are becoming belligerent. That being said, you have my support."

Gress could see her grip the arms of her chair a little tighter as she said it.

"What is it, Brother Izzy? Why is supporting me so difficult?" Gress said.

Izzy was silent for a long breath before saying, "Because of things I can't tell you and one I can. I supported Cappe and now…"

As she trailed off, Gress nodded.

"I understand. I cannot say that nothing will happen to me but I can say that I'm tired of tiptoeing around and do not intend to go down easily or quietly," Gress said.

Izzy nodded as she said, "Brother Gress, I fully understand what you mean. Living hunched over, scared to do something… well, I understand more than you know. Please, be careful. I imagine you haven't told your caretakers this yet either."

“I have not. I will tell them today,” Gress said. “Do you wish for me to keep it hidden that you are backing me as well?”

Izzy paused and then nodded with a sigh.

“If you feel they should know, please don’t keep it from them but yes, I’d like it to be quiet.”

“You did not tell Cappe that.”

“I know,” Izzy said as she looked away. “I know.”

Gress waited a little bit longer but Izzy seemed to have said what she was going to say.

“Thank you, Brother Izzy,” Gress said as he stood up.

“Don’t thank me,” Izzy said, looking back at him. “I feel like I may have just doomed you.”

“I do not intend to be doomed,” Gress said as he stood and went towards the door.

He heard Izzy mutter sadly under her breath. Gress wasn't sure but he thought she said, "None of them do."

He paused at the door but she didn't say anything else and he went on.

Later, back in the tunnels, Gress held his data pad. He'd typed out a response to Capella several times since the day she'd sent her message to him but he'd never sent any of them, trying to follow what she'd said. He knew people worried about him, that Capella was looking out for him, but he was tired of that. He was tired of being careful.

Now, he looked at the message he'd typed out and thought. He was so angry at Capella. He knew she probably had her reasons for what she was doing but he felt like out of all the people on Etheria, she should be able to trust him. He also missed his friend and tears streaked his face as he looked at the message. Then he wiped the message out one more time before starting again.

Dear Cappe,

You saved me that night. Again. Then you left me here. You haven't said anything to me. Why couldn't you talk to me? Why couldn't you pull some daring teleport in to let me know you were all right? Why are you out there doing the work we started together by yourself? Are you even still doing that? I don't know. I've heard second hand and third hand of what you're doing. I'm sure you've thought this out and you think you're doing the right thing. I know that's what you do but I don't like it.

In what I can't help but think of as your good-bye message, you spoke of wanting me to stay in Dryl and stay safe. I respect that. However, I'm not going to do it. In a few days, I will return to Wheatland. We had a speaking engagement that got interrupted and I will deliver it. My voice will be heard, even if it is a single voice against a mob. I will not bow. I will not hide. I will be brave.

Cappe, I miss you more than I can say. You're still my friend plus, my friend squared, my best friend and we started this together but if things make it so we end it apart, then so be it. Yes, I'm angry with what you've done but I want you to understand this decision is not made out of anger at you, my friend. I hope to see you again one day but for now, I have work to do and so I state the following. I think you'll understand what it means.

Clear and unblinded by light, I, Gress of Poview of the generation of the First of the Free and Named, make this decision and I will not be swayed from my path, though Cursed Prime himself stand in my way.

Gress looked at the message and nodded. He addressed it to Capella and set a delay on it. Then he called Aden and Laho. Ten minutes later he finally got them to understand that he was serious as they both looked at him in shock.

"They'll kill you, Brother Gress," Laho said bluntly.

“They have already tried to do that,” Gress said.

“No one will show up in your defense,” Aden replied. “This is madness.”

“Then if no one shows up, I will stand alone before the mob. My bravery will be an example to others and shame those who did not show up,” Gress said.

“It will show them nothing of the sort,” Laho said. “They will just kill you.”

“After Seaweed, you said you would think of how to change their minds, Brother Laho. I have as well and this is what I will do,” Gress said. “I have called to get your assistance. We will get this done.”

“How!?” Laho said as Aden put an arm around him. “By our deaths!?

“No. I do not wish to die,” Gress said, “But I do not wish to hide either. Cappe is out there fighting. I will do it my way.”

Laho and Aden sat and looked at him and Laho began to shake his head.

“No, Brother Gress,” Laho said.

“Yes, Brother Gress,” Aden said at the same time. Laho looked at him in shock.

“But... Aden, no,” Laho said, his voice low. Gress blushed deeply to hear such an intimate way of speaking between the two and looked away. Laho looked at Aden in fear and Aden carefully put a hand on the side of his face.

“Brother Gress needs guidance. He has trusted us. I love you, Laho, but he is right,” Aden said, the last sentence a whisper before turning back to Gress. “I am with you.”

Tears slipped down Laho’s cheek as he looked back at Gress.

“I think it is madness still but I swore to Ad… Brother Aden that I would go where he went, grieve when he grieved, laugh when he laughed, and stand by him from now until we are gone so I will not stop doing so now. I am with you as well.”

Gress took a deep breath.

“Thank you for your trust. Now here is what I am thinking.”

Gress laid out a plan and Laho and Aden listened. They both started cautious but began to nod and relax as Gress went on.

"That's what I think we should do," Gress said. "We do not use the old board except for things we want to be public. Will we be ready to move on the timeline I mentioned?"

"We will," Laho said. "I will make one suggestion though." Gress nodded and Laho went on. "Do not meet in front of the building. We will meet in the field behind it. We can land a skiff there and speak from on top of it."

"You believe we will have to run again," Gress said.

"I believe we should have the option," Laho said.

"OK," Gress said. "That does sound like a plan. Get the few together you trust and remember, secure messages only. No more data boards."

The other two nodded and they talked for a little bit longer before they all signed off. Gress saw that his message to Capella had been sent while he had talked and sighed. He thought about her for a moment, wondered what she was doing, and then got onto the data board. He had already prepared a statement and posted it immediately upon entering it. It was simple.

Equal is about making sure all are treated equally. Nothing has changed. I will not back down. Stand with me for that which you know is right.

The board hadn't been very busy that he could see but within five minutes people were all of a sudden logging in and conversations flew fast and furious. He watched his board message box start to fill as he moved his mattress up against the wall and draped a sheet so that he had a backdrop. He was going to go on camera and didn't want everyone to see the distinct colors of Dryl's walls. Once he was settled and sure that he wouldn't immediately give away where he was, he began the call. He sat for a moment and watched people come streaming into the call, all muted as he waited. He began talking finally.

"I know I'm one of the first people out of what we call leaders to speak since the events at Wheatland. I can see all of you typing 'Where's Cappe?' and I'll say that I don't know. I haven't seen or heard from her since that night," Gress said and looked away for a moment as his throat closed up and his eyes filled. After a long pause he started speaking again. "I have reason to believe she is alive but I can't say more. I miss her so much but that is not why I'm here. I'm here to say that I was stopped from speaking at Wheatland. Cappe and I were going to talk about our friendship and what it's like for me as a clone on Etheria. I've had a lot of time to sit and think and I come to you to say this. I'm going back to Wheatland. It will be soon, in days, and I hope that I can see you there. I will not be silent. I will now answer questions."

Gress began to answer questions, barely getting to any of them, as people peppered him. As the call went on, Gress could see even more people coming in and Gress stated his original comment several times over the several hours he was on it.

Finally, he was exhausted and gave a little smile and looked up as he saw his caretakers coming into the room.

"I feel good for the first time since that evening," Gress said. "I will not be gone as long from the board again but for now, I must rest because I have much work ahead of me. Thank you and I'll see you all soon."

Gress cut the feed and logged out as Hort and Ulip looked at him.

"Brother Gress? What are you talking about?" Hort said carefully.

"I am returning to Wheatland in a few days," Gress said. "I intend to give a speech in replacement of the one I was interrupted in."

"No!" Ulip said, stepping forward.

Gress stood up off the bed and looked Ulip directly in his eyes.

"Yes," Gress said calmly. "You cannot stop me from doing this. If you think you're going to lock me in, I remind you that even as a child I knew how to leave this tunnel system without you or the other caretakers knowing."

“I am not going to lock you in,” Ulip said. “I will sit right beside you until you have come to your senses.”

“Caretakers, I love you both,” Gress said. “However, that will not stop me.”

“What if we say we’ll go with you?” Hort said.

“I hope you will,” Gress replied. Hort and Ulip looked at Gress, unsure of how to continue. “You didn’t expect that, did you?” They both shook their heads as Gress went on. “It is time for us to step up. We have tried being quiet. We have tried blending into the background but we have not been allowed to. I want you there with me if you’re willing.”

“It’s… you do not understand… I mean…,” Ulip said as Hort looked on.

“You think I don’t understand? Do you not see where we are?” Gress said as he gestured at the room. “You have wanted me to speak to a Listener since we got here. I have had to speak to one for years now. Do you really think I don’t understand the danger that is inherent in my actions?”

Ulip sat down at the little table in the room as Hort put a hand on his shoulder.

Hort sighed as he said, “Brother Gress, I think you are grieving, tired, and anxious because of your circumstance. Please consider what you are doing.”

“I have, I am, and I will,” Gress said. “I will be in Wheatland in just a few days either way. Come with me.”

Ulip shook his head but Hort looked down at him and slowly nodded his head. Ulip looked up and said, “Brother Hort… no. I do not want to add your name or his to the list of those we remember before our evening meal.”

“You have stood by me, even when neither of us had names,” Hort said. “I have loved you even when we were blinded by Prime’s Light, before I even understood what love for another meant. Come with me. Stand by me again. Stand with our child.”

Ulip reached his hand up to touch the side of Hort’s face as he silently mouthed Hort’s name. Tears began to streak Ulip’s face.

Hort knelt in front of him and took Ulip’s hand as he said, “Do not cry, my beloved. The future has not come to pass yet. We have not fallen. I am still here with you.”

Gress looked away as his two caretaker’s looked at each other and he knew at that moment, for them, they were the only two things in existence. Gress quietly walked to the bathroom and waited a

few minutes before he heard Hort call his name. Gress stuck his head out to see Ulip holding Hort tight.

"We have made the decision," Ulip said, his voice tired. "We will come with you to Wheatland. We will follow you. What is it you need from us?"

Gress nodded and came out and began to talk with them about what he had planned.

###

Gress and his caretakers flew out to the town of Base One the night before Gress planned to speak. They slipped into town and met Aden and Laho there. Introductions were made and they settled down in a little storefront in the town. Gress had considered renting a room but this seemed better and he hoped no one would notice they were even there.

There were some people in town that Gress knew from the data boards but he wasn't talking with them. He'd gone quiet that morning after telling everyone that he'd still be in Wheatland in the morning. Gress looked at his data pad one more time that night, hoping that Capella would respond to his message, but so far, nothing had happened.

When Gress woke, he expected his caretakers to argue that they shouldn't go but they simply made sure everything was packed

and they went to the skiff they'd brought with them, all five piling up onto it. Gress sat at the front, breathing deeply of the clear morning air and looking at the high clouds overhead. They'd had a minimal breakfast, none of them very hungry, and now they were just watching the clock as Gress looked at the data board and saw that people were already in Wheatland and reporting that the town guard was milling around the field as well as two groups of people, drawn up on either side. Hort looked over his shoulder and saw the image.

"It looks like battle lines," Hort said. Gress looked at him and Hort just shook his head.

"We will land in the middle," Gress said. "I will begin speaking quickly and hopefully I will be able to say what is needed. Brother Ulip, please give it a chance. Do not take off until the very last moment you possibly can. It may be ugly but…'

Gress trailed off and Ulip just gave the most imperceptible of ear twitches to acknowledge he'd heard Gress.

Finally, the moment came. The flight to Wheatland was short and they circled the field once and Gress could see that both sides were roughly the same side. He also couldn't help but notice that many on both sides were armed. Ulip brought them in for a landing and Gress immediately began to speak on the loudspeaker he had, doing his best to call for calm and to let him make his statement. He didn't get very far when a squad of the town guard began to march towards them. Gress stepped over and stood between Ulip and the controls.

“Give it a chance,” Gress replied. “Just let me speak.”

Ulip looked at the controls and then at Gress and then gave a sigh and a nod. Gress picked up the loudspeaker again and began to speak.

Chapter End Notes

> Gress out there facing people down to say the truth. I love him.
>
> Also, I went back and forth on that little bit of clone culture there about saying someone's name without putting Brother in front of it. It's both very intimate and very insulting depending on how it is done.
>
> Hope you're enjoying the story and thank you for reading!

Capella

Chapter Summary

> Capella goes back to the Crimson Waste, not sure what to do now but hoping that she can get something planned.

Chapter Notes

> "I wake up in the morning / And I raise my weary head / I've got an old coat for a pillow / And the earth was last night's bed / I don't know where I'm going / Only God knows where I've been" - Blaze of Glory by Bon Jovi
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Capella didn't teleport far from Catra and Adora's house. She jumped to the outer limit that she could on a single teleport and found herself sitting in the Whispering Woods. She stood for a moment, staring blankly at a gently glowing tree before she sat down, all her breath leaving her in a whoosh. She pulled her two bags close to her in a hug as tears streaked her face as she continued to stare forward.

I should have known they wouldn't help , Capella thought. *All those years hearing them going on about promises and how important they are… liars. Damn liars.*

Capella heard a rustling and looked up quickly, wondering what was coming through the brush. She was not expecting an elderly woman.

“Oh, dearie, are you lost?” Razz said as she looked at Capella. Capella jumped to her feet and looked around, wondering how Razz had found her when Capella wasn’t even entirely sure where she’d teleported. Razz looked around as well looking to see what Capella was looking for when Capella finally spoke up.

“I’m not lost,” Capella said, trying to keep her composure. “I’m just tired. Sitting and taking a break.”

“I didn’t think so,” Razz said. “You’ve been here before after all.”

Capella just shrugged. She hadn’t been as far as she could tell but she’d met Razz before when she’d gone hiking in the Woods with her dad when she’d visited her granddads. She knew how she could be.

“Uh… ok. I’m going to just… you know, be moving on in a moment,” Capella said.

“When you come back, bring berries,” Razz said with a smile.

Capella just slowly shook her head as she said, “I, uh, I won’t be able to bring berries. I’m probably not coming back here.”

“You’ll be back,” Razz said with a shrug as she began to shuffle into the brush again. “Bring berries.”

Capella watched her go and after a minute and nothing more happened, she sat back down, leaning against a tree. She shoved down the sorry and anger and got herself under control picking up her data pad. She called Coalfire who answered almost immediately.

"Please tell me you're not…," she said before trailing off and sighing in relief. "Oh, good. You're in the Whispering Woods."

"What? Yeah, I am," Capella said. "I was calling like you asked to find out where I should go."

"What's the passphrase?" Coalfire said. Capella told her and Coalfire nodded. "OK, meet me at the bar. Remember your disguise and do not go back to where you were staying. Someone kicked the door in while we were out and raided the place."

Capella's mouth was hanging open when she finally said, "Do you know who?"

"Some blonde and a few others," Coalfire said. "I've got a good image of them before they took out our security system. We're looking into it."

Capella gritted her teeth for a second before saying, "It's probably a member of Dark Moon. If it's who I think it is, she's the one who

led the group who attacked us right after Wheatland."

Coalfire looked at her for a long moment before she said, "Then I was right. I figured it had something to do with you. Luckily no one was there."

Capella almost didn't ask the question that leaped to the end of her tongue but she asked anyway, afraid of the answer.

"Do I still meet you at the bar?"

"Yeah, sure," Coalfire replied. "It's not like it's the first time I've had someone kick the door in somewhere I was staying. That was just a place. You coming back soon?"

Capella let out a breath she didn't know she was holding as she nodded.

"I'm going to come that way immediately," Capella replied.

"OK. Alice and I will be at the side room," Coalfire said. "Just come on in."

Capella nodded and said good-bye. She stood up again, getting herself ready, and then began to teleport again. She fit her illusion

to her face right before she teleported the last time into a little alley near the bar. Then she adjusted her bags and went walking out of the alley, standing tall and looking confident, even though she was still tied up in knots inside and felt the furthest thing from confidence.

As she entered the bar she saw it wasn't too crowded that night and Capella gave a little nod to the bartender as she walked up to the bar. The bartender didn't say anything, just opened an orange fizzy drink and put it in front of Capella and she almost burst out crying and laughing at the same time.

"Thank you," Capella said as she picked it up off the bar.

"It's on your room's tab this time," the bartender said with a little nod at the side room. Capella took a sip, trying not to shake as she did, and nodded at the bartender as she walked over to the room. She knocked once before entering. Coalfire and Alice looked up at her as she shut the door behind her and leaned back against it.

"Go bad?" Alice asked. Capella just nodded. "Sit down then. Drink your drink. Deep breaths."

Capella said, "I know, I know."

She still followed what Alice said. After a few minutes, Capella carefully sat her bags down and pulled out Neral's data pad.

Alice’s eyes locked on it as she said, “That’s not the one you normally have.”

“It’s not mine,” Capella replied. “I, um, kind of stole it from Neral.”

The reaction that Alice gave was not one Capella was expecting. Coalfire started laughing but Alice suddenly lunged over the table towards it. Capella jumped to her feet, knocking her chair over, as she yanked the data pad off the table and pulled her dagger. Alice stopped, sprawled across the table and staring at the edge of the dagger hanging over her face, as Coalfire stopped laughing.

“Cappe, I need that data pad,” Alice said slowly. “I don’t know if it’s tracking you or if it's recording us. I need to examine it.”

Capella looked at her for a moment, holding the data pad out of Alice’s reach, before saying, “Why didn’t you just say that?”

“Sorry. Overreacted,” Alice said. Capella wasn’t sure what to say but looked up at Coalfire for a second.

“Does she overreact like this often?”

“Why are you asking me like you can trust what I have to say?” Coalfire responded.

“Just give me an answer,” Capella said.

“Sometimes,” Coalfire said. Capella nodded before pulling the dagger back and holding the data pad out to Alice.

“Don’t make me regret this,” Capella said. Alice carefully took the data pad out of her hand and then got down and sat in her chair again.

“Sorry. We can get a lot of information off this I bet,” Alice responded. “Maybe even some stuff that can be sold.”

Capella started shaking her head as she sheathed her dagger.

“No. Not sold. Anything that’s on there is for me,” Capella said. Alice just shrugged as she began to work on it. Capella leaned forward and put her hand in front of the screen. “Alice. What did I say?”

“You’re getting gutsy,” Coalfire said. Capella ignored her and just stared at Alice.

“That it’s yours and not to sell it. I agree,” Alice said quietly.

“Thank you,” Capella said and sat back down, taking a cloth napkin and wiping up her spilled drink as she did.

“What happened out there?” Coalfire said and Capella gave her a brief rundown, leaving out her meeting with Razz. Coalfire leaned forward as she talked and listened intently. When she finished Coalfire just shook her head. “Not the brightest but you walked away from it and you got that data pad. Good work, I guess.”

Alice looked up as she said, “You’ve got a treasure trove here. I’m sure a lot of this will change pretty quickly but I know why the town council is going along with the Children of Mara. They’re holding their families hostage.”

Capella looked at her, eyes narrowing.

“They’re doing what?” she said, her voice going soft like a rock under cloth.

“Holding them hostage. They’ve moved them all into a little warehouse and they’ve got a few people staying there with the families,” Alice said. “At least that’s what this says.”

“Where is it?” Capella said.

“By the big grain elevators,” Alice said. “Hang on, what are you thinking?”

“I’m thinking that I’m going to help those people,” Capella responded.

“You’re thinking you’re going to get yourself killed,” Coalfire said. “Can I at least hear your plan?”

Capella started to say something but shut her mouth. Her first instinct had been to contact someone in charge but she knew she couldn't trust those in charge. The decision of what to do fell firmly on her, she realized. She was quiet as Alice continued to mess with the data pad. Coalfire watched, her eyes steady as she waited to hear what Capella would say.

Finally, Capella looked up and said, “I think I can maybe teleport three people at a time. I’d probably be exhausted when it was over but I could do it. How many people are we talking about here?”

Alice kept working as she said, “It didn’t have an exact count.”

Capella sighed as Coalfire said, “You can make an approximation. There’s seven members of the council. If each has at least one partner, then you’re looking at a minimum of seven. Some have children though so you’re looking at probably double that at least.”

Capella thumped her hand on the table as she said, “And I can’t count on getting them all and it being quiet without someone noticing.”

“I think you’re overthinking it though,” Coalfire said. “What are you worried about running into?”

“Well, the guards,” Capella said.

“How many are there?” Coalfire asked.

Capella started to say she didn’t know when she started to grin.

“If there’s not that many, I just have to move the guards,” Capella said.

“Exactly,” Coalfire said. “Alice? You got a count?”

Alice tapped for a moment and then said, “It says five. If I was doing it, it’d be one with the families and two groups of two out on the edge.”

“So take the two groups and then the one,” Capella said and then saw both Alice and Coalfire shaking their heads. “OK, why not?”

“You can teleport. Start in the center,” Coalfire said. “Then the families can barricade themselves in just in case it goes bad.”

“OK, then grab, teleport them away, come back, find the rest, let the families know they’re safe,” Capella said before stopping for a moment and shaking her head. “No. Not safe. They won’t have much time to get out before someone comes in looking or the people I took away call in.”

“That’s true,” Alice said. “We could always drive a truck up after you’ve done your thing, haul them away somewhere else.”

Capella looked up, confused, and pulled her illusion off.

“What do you mean we?”

“I figured at least I could go along,” Alice said. “Give you a little backup.”

“For how much?” Capella said.

“Let me sell something off this data pad, we’ll be even,” Alice responded.

“No,” Capella said. “I have no idea how much you could make off whatever is there and I don’t want it widely known that I might have got something very important.”

Alice frowned as Coalfire chuckled.

“She’s picking this up pretty quick,” Alice said, looking at Coalfire.

“Don’t blame me,” Coalfire said. “Besides, she needs to pick it up quickly. She’s in a tough classroom.”

The phrase made Capella think of her tutor, Raskin, at Bright Moon and how she loved to catch them by surprise and cause their blue feathered crest to stick up. The thought caught her off guard and she looked down to compose herself.

“You alright?” Alice said.

“Yeah,” Capella said, taking a breath. She knew she had to get off the subject of her. “Tell you what, you can sell something but I get to see what it is beforehand and I get sixty percent of the proceeds.”

“Oh, come on!” Alice said. “I’m the one that cracked it!”

“And I’m the one that snatched it,” Capella responded. “Take it or leave it.”

Alice grinned and said, “OK, deal.”

“I’ll get the truck,” Coalfire said. “Alice, you drive unless we can figure something else out. I’ll be Cappe’s backup.”

“Hang on,” Capella said. “Now you’re going too? What am I going to have to pay you?”

Coalfire shrugged as she replied, “Nothing. Remember how you said you overpaid for that first bit of info? Consider this me squaring it up.”

“No, that doesn’t sound right,” Capella said. “You threw in a place to stay for the night and then ended up housing me for longer than that. I made the deal already.”

“Listen, just take it, alright?” Coalfire said. “I gave you the reason.”

Capella looked at her for a long moment but the eyes peeking over the veil didn’t give anything away. Capella finally just nodded and accepted it. She pulled the illusion back on her face as she said, “Do you have a place for me to stay tonight? I’m exhausted.”

“Yeah, we got you covered,” Alice said. “Let’s head that way.”

As they walked down one of the winding roads in the Valley of the Lost, each person was silent. Capella almost missed the blonde woman leaning up against the wall at one of the intersections at first. She was very still and blended into the shadows but Capella noticed her a split second before she stood up.

“Coalfire,” the woman said with a tip of her head as she stepped out in front of them. “I’ve been looking for you.”

The three stopped in the middle of the road and Capella felt sweat slip down her sides even in the cold of the desert night as she tried to imitate the calm stance of Coalfire and Alice.

“I don’t know you,” Coalfire said calmly. Capella noticed three more people walking out behind them. “Let us pass please.”

“I know you don’t know me but I know you and I know you know someone I’m looking for,” the woman replied. “It’s very important that I find her and I won’t stop until I find her. Make it easy.”

Coalfire gave a minimal shrug, her robes rising just a fraction of an inch, as she said, “Make it worth my while.”

Capella did her best not to suddenly stare at Coalfire in horror.

Is everyone going to betray me? Capella thought. The only thing that kept her in place was knowing Coalfire was tricky and she'd had plenty of time to turn on her already without doing so and so she took a deep breath and waited.

"You'll have the gratitude of the Queen of Bright Moon," the woman replied. "And a large favor."

"Favors have a tendency to disappear," Coalfire replied. "Money. Pay me."

The woman shrugged as she made a gesture at her friends and said, "You should have taken the favor."

Coalfire said, "You should have left my cousin alone."

Capella watched as Coalfire flicked her hand towards the woman like she was shooing a fly away. Capella caught a glimpse of what looked like a glowing red tendril flash from Coalfire's fingers and snap into the woman's forehead. The scream that followed from the woman was a deep, visceral scream of abject horror that raised the hairs along Capella's arms and neck as she watched the woman start to collapse. She didn't have much time to dwell on it though because the three women behind them came rushing forward.

Capella turned, saw a woman close to her, and took a step forward to slam the heel of her hand into the woman's sternum. For a split second, Capella thought she'd broken her wrist as the impact jarred back through her arm. The woman was obviously wearing some kind of armor under her shirt but the strike put the woman off balance enough that Capella was able to step sideways, hook the woman's ankle, and then shove her down. The woman hit the ground with a thud and Capella was already scanning for the next target as she stepped back to try and keep the woman on the ground in view. As she did, a bright arc of electricity shot past her and grounded out in another woman who'd been drawing a sword. Electricity shot off of the metal and the woman took a jerky step backwards before her legs collapsed under her and she lay on the ground twitching.

Capella looked around and before it'd even felt like it'd started, she suddenly realized that it was already over. The third woman sat on the ground, a dull smile on her face with her eyes unfocused. The blonde woman had stopped screaming in the few seconds the fight had lasted and was moaning from where she lay on the ground, gripping her head and rocking back and forth. Alice stepped up beside Capella holding a small box with a pointed crystal coming out the front of it and pointed it at the woman Capella had knocked down who had got her breath back and was starting to stand.

"You can just stay right there unless you want to get a bolt as well," Alice said. The woman looked up at the face Capella was wearing and Alice and lay back down on the ground.

"Who are you?" Capella said, disguising her voice.

“You don’t know who you’ve messed with,” the woman said. “We’re Dark Moon.”

Coalfire stepped up and looked at Capella with a raised eyebrow. Capella ignored her.

“You’re looking for Princess Capella?”

“Yes, and we know she’s been with you,” the woman said. “You better tell us where she is or you’re going to have all kinds of problems.”

“Lady, considering we just wiped you all out in a few seconds, I’d say you have the problems,” Alice said.

“You got lucky,” the woman spat out.

Capella squatted down and looked the woman in the eye.

“You tell Queen Glimmer,” Capella said, almost spitting out her mother’s name, “that she had better call off this search if she has any hope of ever talking with her daughter again.”

“Oh, it’s threats?” the woman said. “We’re sworn to protect her. We’ll come for all of you, in numbers you can’t fight.”

“You’re sworn to protect her?” Capella said and dropped her illusion, to Coalfire’s sudden enormous eye roll. “Here I am. As the Princess of Bright Moon, I order you to back down.”

The woman looked in shock for a moment before saying, “We don’t answer to you and we’re sworn to protect you even from yourself, Your Highness. Your little friends will just get hurt if you don’t come with us. Just like the last ones did.”

Capella’s hand flew back towards her dagger and Coalfire was suddenly by her side pulling her back.

“Nope, nope, nope,” Coalfire said. “You’re not stabbing someone in the middle of the street. That’s what alleys are for.”

Capella heard the last bit as a joke and managed to shake her sudden intense anger out of her head. Coalfire leaned in close to Capella as she calmed down and whispered, “Put your illusion back up *this instance* before more people see you!”

Capella looked at Coalfire in the eyes before nodding and pulling the illusion back down.

“We’ll still find you, Your…,” the woman started to say and then a crack of electricity sounded as Alice discharged her weapon again. The woman jerked a few times and then was still except for her slow but steady breathing.

“I believe it’s time to go,” Coalfire said. Capella nodded and they quickly left the area.

Capella had been shaking since they’d walked away as the adrenaline drained out of her but she followed the other two and ten minutes later they were winding their way down a dim alley so narrow they could touch both sides with their hands. Coalfire ducked into a little side alley that ran for only a dozen feet before ending at a door. As she let them in they all breathed a sigh of relief.

“You got a good reason for revealing yourself like that?” Coalfire said as she turned on a small battery powered lamp, lighting the tiny room with a few cots in it, and Capella realized Coalfire was angry.

“I was trying to see what she’d do,” Capella said.

“If she works for your mother, now they know for certain you’re here. More importantly, they know for certain you’re with us,” Coalfire said, pointing between Alice and herself. “Not to mention that they know you can disguise yourself now as well. Do you see the problem?”

Capella sagged backwards into a wall and slowly nodded.

"I'm sorry. I do," Capella replied. "What do you want me to do?"

"Damn it!" Coalfire muttered as she turned away from Capella. Alice unfolded a chair and sat down, her face calm.

Coalfire looked at Alice and said, "Stop it. Get that look off your face right now."

"It's just my face," Alice said. "It's not any special look."

"Yes, it is," Coalfire said.

"Why is it such a big deal?" Alice said.

"Don't," Coalfire said, pointing at Alice as Capella looked between the two, trying to figure out what was going on.

"Just do it," Alice said. "Come on. We've talked about it enough and this just forces your hand."

Capella started to stand up, thinking maybe it was time to teleport, when Coalfire turned to her.

"I have to ask you a question," Coalfire said with irritation in her voice.

"What?" Capella said, drawing out the word. She watched Coalfire's eyes, usually so steady, flick back and forth as if looking for a way out of something.

"Can we go with you?" Coalfire finally said.

"What? Yeah, you already were," Capella said, shaking her head as she tried to figure out what she was trying to say. Alice looked down, shaking her head, a smile playing across her lips as Capella watched Coalfire. "Am I missing something?"

"Come on, spit it out," Alice said.

"Maybe you should do this," Coalfire shot back at her.

"OK, will someone say something because I am not having a good night and this is not helping in the least," Capella said.

“Maybe go with you was the wrong way to put it,” Coalfire said. “Do you want to join us?”

Capella looked at Coalfire as she slowly said, “What do you mean?”

“What I said,” Coalfire said. “You won’t be our employer. We won’t be your employed. We’re going to work together.”

“I’m not looking for that kind of work,” Capella said.

Alice started laughing as she said, “She’s trying to say she wants to join your mission, cause, quest, whatever it is you're doing. So do I. I think we got a couple more but even if they don’t join up, we can still hire them if we need them.”

“What!? Why!?” Capella said.

“Remember when I said that I worked for Sert cheap because I was sympathetic towards your goals?” Coalfire said.

“Yeah,” Capella said, nodding.

“Well, I got to thinking. Here’s this princess, no idea what she’s doing, out trying to do the right thing even while all sides are

trying to catch her and I realized, I sympathize and I can't just stand aside looking to grub some money off that. Then I realized you could be terrifying if you just had some people with you and some training with your magic," Coalfire said.

Capella slid down to the floor, her bags spreading out around her, as she looked at them both.

"Are you messing with me?" she said in a quiet voice.

"Nope," Coalfire said. "We're throwing in with you. What do you say?"

Capella lowered her head onto her crossed arms as tears streaked her face. She stared through her knees at the floor and noticed that the old wood planking that made up the floor had little bits of red sand ground into the grain. She thought about what Coalfire had said, that if she just had some people with her, and tried not to start sobbing. She knew that she'd had people with her already. That one of them was dead because of her and one was still recovering from horrific injuries. She hugged her knees tighter as she fought to keep herself contained.

"Great, we broke her," Alice said.

"Hey, Cappe, you there?" Coalfire said.

Capella looked up, eyes red, as she said, “I don’t want to get more people hurt.”

Coalfire nodded as she said, “Listen, I understand that but one, we’re already involved. Two, with no disrespect to my cousin or those you lost already, I think you just saw that we are more than capable of taking care of ourselves.”

Capella looked at Coalfire and she remembered the screaming of the blonde woman.

“What… what did you do to that woman?”

“Which one?” Coalfire said.

“You know what I’m talking about. You left her screaming on the ground with a flick of your finger,” Capella said.

Coalfire sighed as she said, “You don’t want to know.”

“If I didn’t, I wouldn’t ask,” Capella said.

“I tweaked her mind just a little,” Coalfire said. “Turned up the part that experiences anxiety and fear but it’s completely temporary.”

Capella's eyes were wide as she listened. Every sorcerer she knew had a strict rule about never, ever messing with another's mind.

Well, almost every sorcerer, Capella thought as she looked at Coalfire.

"That's… horrible," Capella said.

"That's necessary," Coalfire said. "As I said, it's only temporary. I won't do permanent. There's too many things that can go wrong."

"That's still terrible!" Capella said.

"As opposed to what? Breaking a bone with a punch? Slashing them open with the edge of a blade? Shocking them into unconsciousness?" Coalfire said.

Capella had started shaking her head but then she slowly stopped as she thought about it. She still felt like it was wrong but she saw Coalfire's point.

"I don't like it," Capella finally said.

“You don’t have to,” Coalfire replied. “Does this mean you’re not going to accept our help?”

Capella shook her head as she said, “No. I’m going to accept it but that doesn't mean I like you doing that.”

“Again, you don’t have to,” Coalfire said. “I don’t like the violence of the blade but I accept it.”

Capella sighed as she sat back against the wall and said, “Alright. We’re a team then.”

Alice shrugged as she said, “Glad you two worked that out. Now we need to talk about a few things. First, this is just a little hideaway. We can’t stay here past tonight. Second, what are the plans going forward and third, who’s the person with the final say?”

Capella clasped her hands together in front of her as she said, “We never had a person with a final say with my other group.”

“Sure you did,” Alice said. “You might not have thought you did but there was probably someone who always had the last say on how things would go. Everyone might have thrown in their ideas but in the end, they probably looked towards someone.”

Capella's mouth opened and then closed as she remembered Seaweed and Sert deferring to her.

"You're going to say it's you aren't you?" Coalfire said with a laugh.

Capella nodded nervously as she said, "I didn't think so but yeah, I guess it was."

Coalfire said, "Get that look off your face, I'm not going to fight you on it. I'd look silly considering I just asked to join you. Alice, you good?"

"Fine with me," Alice said. "Half Ear will blow a gasket but Dio will be fine with it."

"Who's Dio?" Capella said. "I don't think I've met them."

"She was there the first time you came to meet us. When Sert sent you," Alice said. "You'll recognize her."

Capella said, "Is that everyone?"

"Probably. There's others but I don't trust them enough to ask them the more I think about it," Coalfire said. "Did you want

more?”

Capella shook her head as she said, “I’m not sure I want this but you’re right, I need someone and honestly, I’ve already got you involved as you said.”

Coalfire shrugged as she said, “As speeches go, that was less than stellar. It’s fine. We’re not here for speeches. We’re here to accomplish something. Let’s plan.”

Capella shook her head but took the straps of her bag off and set them beside her. They spent an hour talking out what they would do to help the families being held captive. As they did, she could feel a lump of anxiety that always seemed to be with her now growing and she did her best to ignore it. Finally, they got the cots out, everyone settled down for the evening and Capella, her head on one of her bags as she pulled a coat around her, stared out into the dark room.

Capella tried not to toss and turn as she fought a lump in her throat as she thought about her family. She missed them, even though she knew that they had betrayed her, and she thought, not for the first time, of going to them anyway. She wondered what it would be like. She figured her Dad would grab her in his arms and hold her tight. Her Mom would chew her out but would hug her as well.

Things wouldn’t be that bad, Capella thought as she hugged herself tight. *It really wouldn’t.*

Then she remembered Sert bleeding, Tropistar lying motionless on the floor, and Gress' horrified face and she shoved the thought away.

They did that. Don't forget that, Capella thought as she pulled her coat tighter around herself. She fought down the feelings of loneliness as she did her best to not think about it anymore and go to sleep. Sleep took a long time though.

The next day, the three quietly moved through town to another location. Capella met Dio again, a bulky short woman with a loud voice, five o' clock shadow, and a bald head except for a single long braid coming from the left side of her skull.

"So you're the new head of this whole thing, huh?" she said as she thumped the table they were sitting at.

"I think of it as a new thing but yeah, if you're alright with it," Capella said.

Dio grinned as she said, "Come on. You gotta get tougher with your responses! That's the most Bright Moon response ever."

Capella looked down, uncomfortable at the thought of Bright Moon, and Dio laughed, thinking it was her being awkward, as she said, "So is that!"

Capella's head shot up, her face serious, as she said, "I guess I don't care if you like it or not because that's how it's going to be."

Dio stopped for a moment and then laughed even harder as she saw Capella give a little grin, trying to play it off.

"OK, so you can do that," she replied, running her hand over her bald skull. "Naw, I've got no problems with it. Glad to be doing something worthwhile for once. Should be a novel experience."

Capella filled Dio in on the plans for Wheatland and told her what her part in it would be that they'd determined the night before. Dio slowly nodded and then when they were done simply said, "Sounds good. I'll leave now."

Dio said good-bye and was out the door. The next meeting, with Half Ear, didn't go quite as well.

"What do you mean she's in charge!?" Half Ear shouted when Coalfire told him. "She's some princess that got herself in over her head and you expect me to take orders from her!?"

"Then quit. We might have some work for you but you don't have to go along with it. You were alright with it when we discussed this the other day," Coalfire said. "And could you stop yelling?"

“Because I thought she’d just be a part of the group!” Half Ear said, his volume coming down a little. “Honestly, I didn’t think she’d even last this long anyway!”

“Gee, thanks,” Capella said.

“Don’t,” Half Ear said. He stared at her for a moment. His green pupiless eyes should have reminded her of Gress but she’d never seen hate in Gress’ eyes like she saw now.

“Listen, you don’t have to be around me,” Capella said. “I don’t want to be around you either. But I have work to do and it’s going to get done. Are you in or out?”

Half Ear tried to stare her down and finally spat out, “Fine, I’m in. What do I have to do?”

“Right now, nothing,” Capella said. “But be ready in the next few days. You’ll be needed then.”

Half Ear turned and stalked out of the room, slamming the door behind him. Capella looked at Coalfire.

“I’m beginning to doubt him,” Capella said.

“He’s hot tempered. Has been as long as I’ve known him and like I said, not a fan of princesses. It’s alright,” Coalfire said. “He’s steady.”

“I hope so,” Capella said, doubtfully.

Chapter End Notes

Not much to say except thank you for reading!

Capella

Chapter Summary

> Capella is getting ready to go in and rescue people when she suddenly realizes Gress is headed towards Wheatland as well.

Chapter Notes

> "Cease being intimidated by the argument that a right action is impossible because it does not yield maximum profits, or that a wrong action is to be condoned because it pays."
> — Aldo Leopold, A Sand County Almanac
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

An hour had passed after Capella had watched Half Ear slam out of the room at the announcement that she was in charge. As she worked quietly on her data pad, Coalfire and Alice had both left for a little bit, letting her know they'd notify her before returning so she wouldn't be surprised. It had occurred to Capella as well that it was so she would know that anyone coming in without an announcement was hostile and as she thought about that, she saw a message pop up. She knew who it was from almost immediately since she'd blocked just about anyone else from her past that it could be and debated opening. Finally, she did and after she read Gress' brief message, tears were falling down her face as she was quickly reaching out to call him when her hand froze above the icon for the call.

Wait… why, after last night, is he all of a sudden messaging you now? she thought. *It's a trap.*

Capella read it over again carefully and then thought a little before reading his other messages he'd sent before.

Context seems different, she thought. *This isn't normal.*

She checked the encryption on it and saw it was done with Gress' key. She thought about it some more and then shook her head.

There's no way he'd do something that stupid, Capella thought. *This is trying to get me to react so I'll come out in the open.*

She almost deleted the message right then but something kept her from doing it. She read it again, thinking about Gress and finally archived it and did her best to ignore the lump in her throat at the thought of her friend. She started a reply several times but each time she stopped herself and finally she managed to shove down her loneliness and move on to something else.

The next few days were taken up with moving around as the group got ready to move out of the Valley of the Lost. Capella had offered to teleport the whole group that was needed out to where they'd be by Wheatland but Coalfire had turned her down.

"Never mind I'm leery about other people's magic, we're moving base," Coalfire said. "We got a lot of stuff to bring with us."

Capella thought about it but she knew she wouldn't be able to haul a bunch of equipment with them and finally just sighed and nodded. Then two days before they had planned the rescue, Alice looked up from where she'd been fiddling with her data pad.

"Did you know someone is going to throw another rally in Wheatland coming up? Looks like the day after we're planning on being there."

Capella had been trying to meditate in the corner when she looked over at Alice.

"What do you mean? Who?"

"I think it's that guy you came with the first time you met us," Alice said. "Says he's going to give the speech he was supposed to have given before he was interrupted."

Capella scrambled to her feet and ran over to Alice.

"Show me."

Alice turned her data pad and Capella saw the notice. Her heart dropped.

“He cannot seriously be that stupid!” she shouted. Coalfire stuck her head around the corner from where she had been talking with Dio over her data pad.

“Who can’t be stupid?” Coalfire said.

“Gress! He sent me a message a few days ago saying he was going to do this but I thought it was a trick to get me to show myself!” Capella said. “I gotta go see him right now.”

Coalfire got up and came out to the room where Capella and Alice sat as she said, “It still could be that you know. Doesn’t have to be coerced. Maybe someone put the idea in his head with the idea that you’d come running. He might not even realize that’s what’s being done.”

Capella shook her head as she said, “No, he’s smart. He wouldn’t fall for that.”

“First, you just made the comment that he couldn’t possibly be that stupid but this would seem to indicate he most certainly is. Second, you’re smart as well and while you’ve gotten more clever about this kind of thing, part of it is because you’ve had us helping you along,” Coalfire said. “I doubt wherever he’s staying now that he’s getting that kind of consideration and help.”

Capella shook her head slowly as she said, “He’s at Dryl. Izzy wouldn’t endanger him like that.”

“Why not?” Coalfire said. “How sure can you be? Besides, how do you know he’s still at Dryl? How do you know that the Queen hasn’t taken him?”

Capella’s eyes went wide and then narrowed.

“She… no…,” Capella said.

“Yes, she would. If she would try and kill my cousin just because she was close to you she would do that,” Coalfire replied.

Capella turned her back on Coalfire and stared at the door for a long moment thinking.

“We’re moving the timeline for the rescue,” Capella said.

“What? What do you mean?” Alice said.

Capella turned around as she replied, “I mean we were going to go in late at night but if this is really going to happen then they’ll be looking towards Gress. He’s bound to draw a crowd. We have to time it carefully though because once they’re out, I’m going for Gress and saving him. So this means the goals are now pull the families out, get them on their way, and then get Gress and do it in a time frame that keeps anything from happening to him.”

“Come on,” Coalfire said. “Just yank the families out on the original timeline. We’ll go for him later.”

Capella said, “No. You all said you were worried about there being people there we’re not expecting. This is a way to minimize that.”

“She’s right,” Alice said.

“It makes everything way more complicated,” Coalfire said. “Now we can move or not whenever, now we have to move based on someone else.”

“I’m familiar with the idea that you make your opponent react to you instead of the other way around but this is still the same. They still will be reacting to us, we’re just picking a different time,” Capella said. “We just wait until the best moment that day, as close to his speech as possible, to move.”

“Are you set on this?” Coalfire said.

“Yes,” Capella said, crossing her arms and then remembered what Dio had said and put a little more iron in her voice. “We’re going to do this and while I want to hear ways to improve it, I don’t want to hear a flat refusal.”

Alice didn’t seem to mind but Coalfire’s eyes bored into Capella’s eyes for a moment before she gave a little shoulder shrug.

“OK,” Coalfire replied.

They left the day before the speech and flew out as night was falling. As the light faded, Capella looked down to see a monument to Mara that had been built at the crash site of her ship. It was a large block with a short story of who Mara was carved into it and she saw little lights flickering around the base of it.

“What are those?” Capella said to Alice as she flew.

“Candles left by pilgrims to the monument,” Alice said and something in her voice made Capella look back at her.

“What’s wrong? That sounds nice,” Capella said. “They remember her.”

“See here’s the thing. Even after it was put up, it didn’t get those. That’s essentially the heart of the Waste down there. Not a lot of people came out except by tour,” Alice said. “The people coming out and leaving those? They think Mara wanted us to stay hidden in Despondos forever. They think the clones are a punishment for us leaving it. Recently they’ve started defacing the monument with their version of the story.”

Capella watched over the side as the monument slid out of sight and then looked back at Alice.

"You mean… those are the people who we're fighting," Capella said. Alice just nodded. Capella remembered when she'd learned about Mara from her Aunt Adora. She remembered how Adora's voice had been soft and low as she'd talked about how Mara had sacrificed herself to try and keep herself and the planet from being used as a weapon against the universe. Capella knew that Mara had done what she had done to protect the universe, not turn away from it.

As she thought about that moment, she thought of her mother who'd hugged her tightly as Capella listened to the story. Capella looked forward into the night as they flew towards their first stop, thinking about her lost family and as she did the tears that streamed out of her eyes were whipped away by the wind of their flight.

The trip took all night but morning found them in a little town in the Fright Zone that Capella had never heard of before they had started making their plans. It was called Base One and Dio was waiting for them in the early morning light on top of an old multi-story factory.

"Took you long enough," she said with a grin as the three climbed down off the skiff.

Capella was wiping at her face, tired after being up all night, as she said, “Just show us where we’re sleeping.”

“The luxury awaits,” Dio replied with a grin as she started walking.

Dio led them a set of stairs that led to a wide open concrete floor that took up almost the entire top story of the building. The windows were dirty and couldn’t really be seen through but enough daylight streamed in through the windows to make the area bright. That didn’t put Capella off any as she lay down on a camping pad that was set in a corner, threw an arm over her eyes, and was soon asleep.

Capella was the first one up when the light coming through the window next to her warmed her up enough to make it uncomfortable. She was still dressed like she was in the Waste, heavy canvas clothes with her hair pulled back and tied off with some string and she grabbed her bags and went in search of a bathroom. She found a small bathroom that looked like it had been pulled right out of the old Fright Zone and planted in the building. The best she could say for it was that it was functional.

After she’d changed and got ready, Capella stared into the small mirror over a sink. She felt like she wouldn't recognize the person staring back at her but it was her face all the same. She stared at her eyes, wondering if they looked different and she just couldn’t tell. She finally looked away when her hands started to hurt and she realized she was gripping the edge of the sink hard enough to leave a line along her fingers from the edge. She rubbed her hands together to get the pain in them to go away and then

adjusted her dagger on her belt, picked up her bags, and went back out. As she did, she almost ran into Coalfire.

"Wondered where you were," Coalfire said with a nod.

"Enjoying the luxurious bathroom a la Hordak's Horde," Capella said with a nod back.

Coalfire laughed as she said, "I have a feeling I know what you're talking about. Not surprising. This whole town was an outer supply depot for that era's Horde. I'll see what it's like but afterwards I need to talk to you before we head out if you don't mind."

Capella looked at Coalfire a little odd and just agreed. Ten minutes later, Coalfire came out and led her over to a corner and said, "Listen, I think you're doing fine with your illusions but do you want to get better at it?"

"Like in what way?" Capella said.

"You always make that hand gesture when you put it on or take it off," Coalfire said. "Why?"

Capella shrugged as she said, "Don't know. Just something I did when I was teaching myself."

“I think you can learn to do it with much more subtlety,” Coalfire replied.

Capella tilted her head a little to the side as if she didn’t quite know what she’d heard.

“Every sorcerer I’ve seen work uses hand gestures,” Capella said. “Even you.”

“Illusion is slightly different,” Coalfire said. “I don’t think you could get away with no gesture but I think we can get it down to really small finger movements. That’s not all. I want to help you refine your illusions and how you use them. In fact, I have an idea on how you can use them on this thing coming up.”

“Like what?” Capella said. She couldn't help but remember the woman laying in the road screaming after a small hand gesture from Coalfire but as she described a few things, Capella went from being a little leery to nodding along.

“OK, let’s practice,” Capella said.

A few hours later, Alice came over to them and said, “Dio is off with the truck. We have a time for when your friend is speaking and a place. It’s early in the morning. People are already starting to filter into Wheatland and they’re not happy. This may be ugly.”

Capella let the illusion she'd been concentrating on dissolve as she nodded.

"OK, early morning is good," Capella said. "Guards tired because it's early, wanting breakfast, and not paying attention."

"Or they've already switched out and it's a fresh guard with sharp minds," Coalfire said.

"Either way, I think we can handle this," Capella said and again brought up the illusion they'd been practicing with a minimal movement. It shimmered between her and Coalfire and Coalfire's eyes looked pleased.

"I think our odds have gone up, yes," Coalfire replied.

They caught a few hours of sleep and then flew out when it was still dark. Alice set the skiff down behind a small stand of trees on the outskirts of Wheatland and got her data pad as Capella sat on the edge of the skiff, trying to breath slowly. Finally, Alice looked up.

"Dio's checked in. She's parked down the street from the warehouse with the truck. Says no one has noticed her," Alice said. "Not likely to either is what she's saying. Says the whole area looks deserted."

Alice handed over headsets for Capella and Coalfire. Capella's hand shook a little as she took it from Alice, who pretended not to notice. Coalfire turned her back as she fitted the earpiece in and then they all did a quick check to make sure they were working.

"Now remember, Cappe, stay off the line and if you do call over it, keep it to a minimum," Alice said. Capella nodded and they watched the clock drift towards their jump off point. When the time hit, Capella reached out and took Coalfire's hand and they teleported and appeared in the back of the big cargo truck that Dio was sitting in. Dio looked over the front seat into the covered cargo area.

"That will take some getting used to," she said as she took a sip of water.

"Everything still clear?" Capella said quietly. Dio shrugged as she took another sip.

"Yep. The fun about to start?"

Capella wanted to say there was nothing fun about any of this. She was doing her best not to let the tension get the best of her but it was a near thing and she just nodded her head.

“Deep breath,” Dio said in a quiet voice so unlike her usual boisterous self that it caught Capella by surprise. Capella just gave a thumbs up and then grabbed Coalfire and teleported again. This time she was above the warehouse, falling through the air. It was part of the plan and she felt a little satisfaction at hearing Coalfire suck her breath in as they started to fall. The wind noise grew loud as they both looked around as they fell for a few seconds and then teleported back to the truck.

“Welcome back,” Dio said with a nod.

“Two on the front, two on the back,” Capella said.

“I saw them and I think two more walking around,” Coalfire said. “We’ll call it front, back, walking, and inner. Can you manage it?”

Capella nodded as she closed her eyes to try and visualize the inside of the building. As she did, she hoped the floorplans that Alice had got were accurate and up to date. They had shown an office space in the middle of the warehouse floor, mostly open floor space, and they all figured that was where the families were being held because it also held the bathrooms for the building.

“Comms, give me a go,” Capella said, speaking to Alice. Alice responded back with a single press of her microphone button. Capella heard the click it caused and then looked at Dio. “Ready?”

Dio gave her a thumbs up and Capella took a deep breath and placed her hand on Coalfire's shoulder. Coalfire nodded at her and Capella let the breath out.

"OK, here we go," Capella said and teleported.

They appeared in the middle of a room with all the lights out except for a small red light lamp on a desk by a door. Capella saw people sleeping fitfully on cots and it took her a moment to see that no one was at the desk and Capella couldn't see anyone else awake in the room. One side of the room had offices with glass walls and a small door and the other were floor to ceiling windows looking out onto empty warehouse space. Capella looked at Coalfire in the dim light with a confused look on her face. She didn't feel any better that Coalfire's eyes looked just as confused as Coalfire shrugged at Capella.

Capella was about to ask what they should do when they heard a door open and light came into the room from it for a split second before it was turned off. Capella turned and in the dimness saw two people holding hands, having stepped out of what she assumed was a bathroom.

"Who is that?" Capella heard one of them say but she was already moving. She teleported over beside them, grabbed them both, and teleported away with each of them. She appeared about five feet above a random field outside town and let them go before teleporting a handful of yards away. She could hear them shouting as they tumbled to the ground.

“Inner group out,” Capella said as she keyed her microphone. “Coming back.”

She heard Coalfire’s calm voice in her ear calming saying it was clear and teleported again. She was back in the room as people began to wake up. Coalfire was going around telling them it was alright and to stay quiet for the moment.

“Is there enough room in the truck?” Capella whispered to Coalfire. Coalfire looked around, taking a count in her head before she slowly nodded.

“It’ll be cramped,” Coalfire said.

“I’m going for the walking group now,” Capella said. She again teleported and was above the building, falling, just long enough to get a bead on the duo walking around the building. She gave a grateful nod as she saw the two walking were out of sight of the front and back groups and again she teleported, grabbed them both from behind, and then teleported them out to another random field and left them. She returned, grabbed the two at the back, and right before she was about to teleport back, she heard Coalfire give the order to Dio to bring the truck up. Then Capella heard the words she was worrying about.

“I’ve got two coming in the front,” Coalfire said. Capella had no idea how she managed to stay calm but teleported to the front of the building anyway. Before she went in, she put up the illusion they’d practiced. She didn’t try to keep her hands still as they’d practiced, she just gestured and got it in place. It was nothing

fancy but it was also clever in its simplicity. All it did was make two large squares, one in front of her and one behind her. The one in front mirrored what the one behind her saw, like a camera, and in essence making her invisible since it wasn't projecting her. It still had a shimmer but they hoped it'd be enough for cover.

Capella came in through the front door just in time to hear the two guards shouting for help. One turned and Capella saw their face wrinkle up in confusion at what looked like a heat mirage in the cold warehouse coming up fast on them. She was about to teleport to them when the stun baton the person was carrying snapped into life and Capella halted. She didn't want to get tagged with it trying to grab either one. The other guard snapped her baton to life and the two went back to back.

"Stop right there! Don't make us… uhhh… we'll… we'll kill the families!" the woman said, her voice shaky.

"Wrong answer," Capella said as she dropped her illusion and drew her dagger, only feet away from the two. The woman stabbed forward with the baton and Capella reacted without thinking. She stepped to the side, used her left hand to reach forward and bat the woman's wrist to the side and then flicked the dagger towards the woman's forehead. Capella didn't even try to strike her but the blade coming near the woman's face caused her to stumble backwards and put her and her partner off balance. Capella took advantage, stepped inside her guard and tripped her and then slammed the hilt of the dagger into the other person's lower back. They both went down and Capella teleported out of the way and to the side.

“Stay! Down!” she said, her voice shockingly loud as she pointed the dagger at them both. The two looked up at her and then quickly nodded and shoved the baton’s away without being asked. She heard Dio confirm she was outside and Coalfire immediately started filing the families out. She watched them go, some holding small children or leading children not yet teenagers, and she could feel anger rising up in her at the thought of what they had been through. Sparks formed in her hair and she started walking towards the two on the ground.

“Remember me?” she said. The two both nodded. “You think it’s fine to hold people hostage? To threaten helpless people?”

The two didn’t do anything besides stare at her in fear as Capella got a little closer, not sure what she was going to do. Then she heard Coalfire shouting.

“Hey! We are *leaving!”*

Capella’s eyes snapped up and she realized that Coalfire had been trying to get her attention and just nodded at her.

“You got lucky,” Capella said and then sheathed her dagger and went after Coalfire.

“That was the third time I had to yell at you! Pay attention!” Coalfire snapped at her as they jogged towards the truck. Capella just nodded as they got on the truck as it started driving.

Capella was sure they would have to fight their way out of town as she climbed in the back but the early morning streets were still mostly empty. There were around twenty people squished in the back and she began to realize it wasn't just the families but the town council as well. They all stared at her and she could tell they couldn't quite believe what had happened.

"Where are you taking us?" one woman said, looking warily at Capella.

"Base One," Capella said, not sure what else to say.

"So Bright Moon finally heard about our problems?" the woman said.

"I'm not doing this for them," Capella said and realized she'd almost spat the word them out.

"You're Princess Capella aren't you?" another person said.

Capella thought about lying but finally just replied, "Yes."

"And you're not with Bright Moon?" they replied, obviously confused.

“No,” Capella said and realized they had probably been held since the day she had gone on the run.

“Did you… um…,” the original woman started to stammer out.

“Did I what?” Capella said and realized she was getting snappy.

“That guard at your rally… did you…,” the woman started to say when Capella cut her off.

“No, and I don’t want to talk about it,” Capella said. “I’m going to go to the front in just a second but here’s what’s happening. When we get to Base One, we’re going to park in an old warehouse. We’ll notify the local government what’s going on and then we’re going to leave. What you do after that is up to you. Any questions?”

The crowd was quiet until finally someone from the back said, “If you’re not with Bright Moon, who got you to do this?”

“No one,” Capella said. “I chose to do it.”

Capella teleported to the front between Coalfire and Dio as the truck rocked along. She heard a skiff go overhead and looked out

the window to see Alice going on ahead of them. She leaned back into the seat with a sigh.

"They doing alright?" Dio said. Capella nodded.

"I guess. No one's freaking out at least."

"That'll come later probably," Dio said. "Listeners have got a lot of work in the back there."

They rode in silence for a little while and Capella finally looked at Coalfire.

"I'm sorry I didn't hear you in there earlier," she said.

Coalfire looked at her for a moment before shaking her head, "It's alright. It turned out OK. Just be more attentive next time. That's how things go wrong."

"I think you all did pretty good," Dio said. "What's a mission without some little hitch?"

"Could you not?" Coalfire said with a flinch. "We're not done yet."

Dio just laughed as they drove on. Not long after, they were coming into Base One. Capella heard a skiff fly overhead as they came into town, heading towards Wheatland, but she couldn't see who it was as they pulled into the warehouse. She looked at the time and realized that Gress was supposed to be in Wheatland soon.

"I'm headed back," Capella said. "I'll meet you at the new place soon and yes, I'll call ahead. You sure Half Ear will have a place for us set up?"

"You've lost your mind," Coalfire said as she shook her head and ignored the question about Half Ear. "Be careful. We'll bring your stuff with us. "

Capella hopped down out of the truck and walked around the back to see the people looking around.

"This is it," Capella said. "Good luck."

She felt good to see a few of the people give a little wave at her, as well as some thank yous, and then she teleported out. She appeared on the roof of the meeting hall back in Wheatland and saw the two crowds formed up on either side of the field and the town guard off to the side. She had arrived right as Gress settled onto the grass in the skiff and she was shocked to see Aden, Laho, Hort, and Ulip with him. She quickly put on an illusion as she heard him begin to speak, calling for calm, as she teleported off to the side before walking out onto the field. As she did, she saw the town guard starting towards the skiff and Gress saying

something to Ulip before getting back on the loudspeaker in his hand.

The guard stopped for a moment as he began to talk about how he wanted calm and peace and he didn't get much further before one of the crowds started chanting, "Blankeyes leave!"

Capella gritted her teeth as she saw Gress look around the crowd for a moment before bringing the loudspeaker back up.

"Why? What have we done? Is not the beauty of Etheria in the love we show each other? Is it not love that saved the universe?"

Capella heard someone shout something that sounded like, "Yeah, from you!"

The guards started moving forward again and she saw both sides starting to move as well and realized this was probably the time to move. She teleported up onto the skiff, dropped her illusion, and turned to see Gress looking wide-eyed in shock at her.

"Cappe!?"

She didn't say anything but started to reach for him, ready to teleport him out when he stepped out of her reach.

“Don’t you try and jump me out! I am not done!” Gress said to her, his voice high and angry.

“Gress! This is getting ugly! Come on! I can take you somewhere safe!”

“Why should I!? You haven’t been somewhere safe from what I’ve heard!” Gress said. “And I had to hear that from others! Not from you!”

“Now is not the time!” Capella said, looking around at the crowds.

“You do not get to make that call for me,” Gress said and turned to begin speaking again. Capella started to reach for him again and he spun on her. “If you want to help so badly then keep them at bay so I can say what I have come to say! Stop trying to teleport me out!”

Capella heard part of the crowd, the part she assumed was on their side, start shouting out her and Gress’ names. She heard the town guard calling out for her to give up and turn herself in. She looked at Gress’ face, more dead set on the decision than she’d ever seen from him, and just sighed and nodded.

Gress began to speak, having to shout to be heard over the crowd now, and Capella jumped down to the ground. The town guard started to advance on her and she looked at them and just shook her head. They suddenly stopped. She could see them thinking

and she shouted at them, “I’m not the one you should be looking for! Go ask your town council what their orders for you are!”

She wasn’t sure if they heard her but she did hear the opposing crowd began to shout at the guard that Capella was a murderer and why weren’t they trying to get her. She was so intent on watching the crowd, edging up to the skiff, trying to decide if she was going to pour out magic on them or just attack, that she never really heard what Gress had to say. She was reminded of watching a magician slowly pushing needles through a balloon, the tension rising as the audience waits for the balloon to pop.

Then she felt someone tap her shoulder and almost jumped out of her skin as she heard Gress say right above her, “We’re leaving, Cappe. Please come with us.”

Capella looked up at him, his face unreadable, and just nodded. She teleported up as Gress told Ulip to lift. Then she felt the balloon pop. When it became obvious they were leaving, the town guard rushed them. The opposing crowd rushed them. The anti-clone group rushed the other two groups and the engine of the skiff screamed as it shot into the sky.

“Where are we going!?” Capella shouted as they leveled off.

“To Base One,” Ulip said.

“We’ll see you there,” Capella said as she grabbed Gress and teleported.

The two of them appeared in a field in the middle of nowhere as Gress looked wildly around before looking back at her. Capella was about to say something when he shouted at her.

“Why did you do that!? You had no right to do that!”

“Gress, I’m sorry, I had to…,” Capella started to say.

“No, you didn’t! I told you not to teleport me! You disappear for weeks, I don’t hear from you, you don’t answer my message, and then you just show up!? That’s not alright, Cappe! This isn't alright! You think I wanted to be cooped up in Dryl this whole time, terrified about what’s going on, and then just not hear from you!? What is going on!?”

Capella stepped back a little, as a few tears started to fall. She quickly wiped them away as she said, “I put you at Dryl so you could stay safe! They killed Tropistar! They tried to kill Sert! I’ve been trying to find out what is going on and it hasn’t been easy! I never know who to trust at all! My own mother turned on me! You think I want to do this!? You think I want to go through this!?”

“How would I know!? You never talked to me! You sent a message that read like a farewell! I’ve been trying to ignore the little voice that said you may be dead until I heard you showed up in

Wheatland and at your aunts' house on the same night!" Gress shot back.

Capella turned her back on him and looked off at the horizon and a few bare trees sticking out against the clear sky. Capella heard a tapping noise and turned around to see Gress with his data pad out.

"Who are you messaging?" Capella said and Gress looked up at the sound of distrust in her voice.

"My caretakers, to let them know I'm alright," Gress replied.

"Don't," Capella said, backing up half a step.

"Do you really not trust me?" Gress said and she cringed at the pain in his voice.

"I just… I don't know. I know my mother betrayed me and she's friends with powerful people. How do I know they're not leaning on you to try and catch me?" Capella said.

"How do I know you haven't turned on me?" Gress said quietly.

The two stared over the open ground that seperated one from the other for a long minute.

"Gress… I would… I would never do that," Capella said as she looked him in the eyes.

"Then why do you think I would?" Gress said.

Capella raised her hand a little as she said, "I… I don't know. I know that Izzy is probably the most trustworthy of them but she's still a princess and I did kind of rob her and I know she'd protect you but me? I don't know."

Gress shook his head as he said, "Cappe, you're a princess and… wait, what do you mean you robbed her?"

"I made contact with someone who was able to get all the money out of that account I was using and into an account I control," Capella said.

"Who helped you do that?" Gress said.

"Don't worry about it," Capella said, looking away.

“You don’t trust me to talk to me but you trust someone else to do that?” Gress replied.

“It’s not that I trust them…,” Capella said and then trailed off. It was hard to say that when she realized she did trust Coalfire. She hung her head as the realization came.

“Take me back, Cappe,” Gress said, his voice hard.

“Gress, wait…,” Capella started to say and Gress cut her off.

“No! Take me back! Now!” Gress said.

Capella started to cry again and didn’t bother to stop it. Gress just turned away from her.

“Don’t,” Gress said. “I thought we were friends. Just take me back to my caretakers.”

“We are,” Capella said. “Are we?”

Gress said was quiet for a moment before he spoke.

“I don’t know if we are anymore. Friends squared? Remember? What does that mean if you don’t trust me?”

Capella looked at him and then said, “When I teleported out that night from Dryl, I went back to Wheatland. I found Sert horribly injured and Tropistar dead. The Dark Moon people were walking out to meet what looked like my Bright Moon guard. I got Sert out and to Salineas. I hid in Salineas with… I hid there for a while. Then I went out to the Waste and I made contact with someone on the shady side to help me. They’re getting me information. We’re trying to work this out.”

Gress turned around and looked at her.

“Why won’t you tell me who?”

“Gress, I… I trust you, you’re my friend but I’m so scared,” she said as she wrapped her arms around herself. “I got you involved in this and now look at where it’s all gone! I don’t want you involved any more than you already are! Do… do you understand?”

Gress looked at her and hung his head with a sigh.

“Remember when we both said we would be done when the other was done?”

Capella thought and then said, “Yes.”

Gress looked up at her as he said, “Are you done?”

Capella slowly said, “Are you?”

“Answer my question, Cappe,” Gress said quietly.

“No,” she replied back, just as quietly.

“Then neither am I,” Gress said and then looked at the sky, turned, and started walking.

“Where are you going!?” Capella said as she ran over to him.

“I’m going back to Base One,” Gress said. “I’ve got a long walk so I better get started.”

“You can’t do that!” Capella said.

Gress turned on her, causing her to stumble a little as he came to a stop.

“Am I your prisoner?”

“No! I would never do that to you!” Capella said.

“Then since you refuse to teleport me back, I have some walking to do,” Gress said and started walking again. Capella watched him get a little way from her and then shouted at him.

“Wait! Please!”

Gress turned and looked at her.

“Cappe, I have a long way to go. I don’t have time for this,” Gress said as he started walking again. Capella teleported out in front of him and held her hands up to him.

“Why? Why are you doing this!? You’re going to get hurt or even killed!” Capella said.

“Why do you willingly take on that responsibility for yourself but you’re not willing to let me take it on for myself?” Gress said as he kept walking, stepping around her.

Capella walked along beside him as she said, “Because I would never forgive myself if something happened to you.”

Gress looked down at her as he said, “Why do you think I’d feel any better if something were to happen to you? Do you think I want that for you?”

“Of course not!” Capella said. “It’s just… uh…”

Capella lapsed into silence as she stopped and Gress trudged along through the field ahead of her. She finally teleported out in front of him.

“What do you want me to do!?” Capella said. Gress came to a stop in front of her as he looked at her.

“I want my friend back. I want her to trust me like I trust her,” Gress replied. “Did you hear my speech at all?”

Capella shook her head as she said, “Not really. I was too busy watching the crowd.”

“I said that we have been failed by those that were supposed to protect us,” Gress said. “That all I wanted was to live in peace on Etheria but that it has been taken from me for almost my entire life. That I live in fear every day but that I would not cower any longer. That I call on all those who are brave and good to not be

silent and to demand that we be allow to live in peace. I called on those who call themselves our leaders, princesses, queens, town leaders, and in our communities, to lead the way to what is right or to get out of the way and let us lead."

Capella stood there in surprise, the stern look on Gress' face one she wasn't used to seeing.

"You… you said all that?"

"A little more involved but yes," Gress said. "I had intended it to be longer but circumstances forced me to be more succinct. Cappe, I say that to say this. You failed me. You should have trusted me. You should have kept in contact and before you say it, you should have found a way. You didn't fail to protect me but you did fail to consider me."

Capella looked at Gress and then nodded her head as she wiped at tears forming. She noticed Gress' eyes were brimming as well.

"What are you going to do next?" Capella said.

"Why does it matter to you?" Gress said.

Capella said, "Because if I can coordinate with you, I want to."

“Cappe…,” Gress started to say and she cut him off.

“If we’re not friends anymore, I understand. I’m sorry. I should have talked with you but I didn’t and I can’t take that back but I can keep you in the loop going forward. I’ll teleport you back right now but I just… I miss my friend,” Capella said as she looked down. “I hope… I hope we can…”

Capella went quiet, not being able to articulate it further. It was silent except for the wind over the field. She watched as a little dust blew past her feet.

“Cappe?” Gress said finally.

“Yes?” Capella said, not looking up and then jumped when she felt Gress’ arms wrap around her. For a moment she didn’t know what to do and then her arms wrapped around him and the two hugged each other tight, crying quietly. Neither really knew how long they stood there but they finally stepped apart, wiping at their eyes.

“I forgive you but don’t you ever do something like that to me again,” Gress said.

“I won’t and I’m sorry I ever did,” Capella said.

“Let’s plan,” Gress said.

Chapter End Notes

So, this almost got the lyrics from You Should See Me In A Crown by Billie Eilish but I think that might get saved for another chapter. I remember writing this chapter, and the one after it, and thinking that when it was time to be posting it that I'd probably be close to wrapping up because surely I didn't have that much longer to go on this one did I? Wrong! I've got seventy thousand words more after this chapter and I'm still writing. That being said, I am moving into the endgame I believe. It's weird to think that I've been writing this since late June of last year and I'm still going. Here's to the story, the writing, the editing, and most importantly to all of you who read it. Thank you.

Data Board

Chapter Summary

Just a little glimpse at an Etherian Data Board.

If you're reading this as I'm posting, please be aware that I've posted another chapter before this today and be sure you read that one first!

Chapter Notes

"A lie can run round the world before the truth has got its boots on."
— Terry Pratchett, The Truth

Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Welcome to the Equal Data Board! Please review the data board rules if this is your first time!

{Click into chat: Main}

FiendishFlower476: "I don't care what anyone says, Cappe and Gress planned that! There's no way it was pulled off separately! They're my heroes!"

DelightfulDeDe: "I just can't believe they managed to yank the whole council and their families out from under their noses!"

EqualasEqual: "Well she's facing kidnapping charges now. They're saying she dragged a bunch of people out to the fields and left them there."

FiendishFlower476: "Kidnappers themselves I bet. Probably lying about it anyway. I don't believe she did that murder and I don't believe them about this."

EqualasEqual: "Well I think she was lying about the whole Dark Moon thing if she pulled off a raid like that. Probably trained with them. You're all suckers to believe anything she says!"

DelightfulDeDe: "Says the person who believes there's a hidden race of cat people on the planet."

EqualasEqual: "Hey! That could really exist! There's evidence…"

{Click into chat: Wheatland Fallout}

BrotherPrimeWasATool: "Brother Gress is right! The strength of his conviction is inspiring! Our leaders have failed us and we should step up and do what's right. People did during the Fall of Prime and we can do the same now!"

OrcaTastic: "Easy for you to say, you're in the Kingdom of Snows. All this is happening down here."

BrotherPrimeWasATool: "You don't think we have the same problems up here? Just because I'm a spacebat in multiple layers of clothes doesn't mean people don't still hassle me."

OrcaTastic: "Listen, I was at Seaweed. It was tense!"

BrotherPrimeWasATool: " What's your point? I was at Poview the first time. I saw Cappe give her speech. I saw her and Brother Gress charge the line. That was more tense than Seaweed!"

SeaHawksInflammableNightmare: "You're getting off the point. We shouldn't be arguing about who was where. We're all here for important reasons, not to show off who had it worse. I'll say this though. The princesses and the queen may be doing something but they're not moving fast enough. The only princess I've seen do something just freed a bunch of people being held captive. Cappe is the only princess that's valid to me."

AllPurposeChocoChip: "I agree! Forget the princess part. She's a queen to me and honestly her and Gress are the only ones I'll ever recognize. Queen Capella and Queen Gress forever!"

OrcaTastic: "Now hang on, the ruling princesses are working at it. That's unfair."

BrotherPrimeWasATool: "So is having to put up with this bull just because of something my caretakers theoretically did under the rule of a maniacal jackass. I'm with AllPurpose. Queen Capella and Queen Brother Gress!"

{Click into chat: Cappe Sightings}

BrightMoonBrigand23: "All I'm saying is that maybe we shouldn't be so quick to laud Cappe. I heard she dropped Sert on the steps of Princess Mermista's castle and Sert was all torn up. Then she immediately left. That doesn't sound like someone trying to be helpful. That sounds like a not so veiled threat."

DataBoardUser#96547: "tHaT sOuNds liKe a NOT sO vEilED tHreAT. That's bull. Cappe and Sert were good friends. Why would she do that to her good friend!?"

BrightMoonBrigand23: "It's just that horrible things keep happening and she always seems to be involved in some way. Maybe she needs to come forward and let herself be put into rehabilitation. She can give her justification then."

DataBoardUser#96547: "Maybe you should shut your mouth. She's out there doing the right thing and you want her to go and sit in a room somewhere."

FrigidBeesAndFlowers: "You two, this part of the board is for talking about sightings of Cappe. You're off topic. As the admin for

this chat, I'll boot you both for twelve hours without warning if you don't stay OT."

DataBoardUser#96547: "You're just friends with BrightMoonBrigand23 so of course you come in when I'm making a point."

{User *DataBoardUser#96547* temp banned for 12 hours by board admin *FrigidBeesAndFlowers* }

BrightMoonBrigand23: "Thanks! They were just salty because they couldn't form a cognisant argument against me."

{User *BrightMoonBrigand23* temp banned for 12 hours by board admin *FrigidBeesAndFlowers* }

FrigidBeesAndFlowers: "Anyone else? We going to keep it on Cappe sightings now?"

{Click into chat: Main}

FiendishFlower476: "I just saw what BrotherPrimeWasATool said! It's what I've been saying and they put it perfectly! Queen Cappe! Queen Gress! The only two who are valid to me!"

OrcaTastic: "I can't believe you're saying this! No! That's the whole point of the Etherian Charter is to keep things like this from turning into chaos! You're trying to argue for chaos!"

LongLowSong : "I can't believe how blind you are, OrcaTastic. It's already chaos or close enough to it. The Intergovernmental Review Panel is getting all kinds of complaints. The Independent Town Board is overflowing with complaints as well. There is no way it'll get worked out. Fiendish is right. Brother Gress and Cappe are amazing."

MarasLeftHangnail: "I think you're all getting too hard on Orca. They're right. This isn't worse than the war and the Etherian Charter was written by people who'd lived though it. They know how to handle it."

EqualasEqual: "You're all being suckered. There's someone yanking the chains behind the scenes and you're all just dancing to the tune!"

DelightfulDeDe: "I'm with Fiendish and BrotherP and all I have to add is this. Long live the Queen and I don't mean the one in Bright Moon!"

{Log Off: Equal Data Board}

Chapter End Notes

Hail to the Queen!

Izzy

Chapter Summary

> Izzy receives a summon from Glimmer to come to Bright Moon for a Princess Council.

Chapter Notes

> "Sing, O muse, of the rage of Achilles, son of Peleus, that brought countless ills upon the Achaeans." - The Iliad by Homer
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izzy still wasn't sure what she was going to do. Snow-by had been out of contact for several weeks. She hadn't worried at first because he had a very irregular check in schedule unless he was working something big and he hadn't been. He'd just been hanging around Poview, getting information and while that wasn't incredibly dangerous, it wasn't entirely safe either. Now though, it was getting long enough that it was beginning to get worrisome. She'd sent Blu in after him and her gut was in knots as she wondered if it was going to be another person she'd doomed.

As she got dressed in her in-laws' old bedroom in Bright Moon, she remembered the time just a couple of weeks back when Gress had gone off to Wheatland. He'd returned to Dryl with his caretakers, as well as Aden and Laho, the day after his speech and she'd been waiting as they landed.

"Brother Gress, I heard Capella was in Wheatland. What's going on?" Izzy said as Gress climbed down.

Gress had looked at her and Izzy didn't recognize the look on his face before he turned and picked up his bag from a cargo hatch on the skiff before turning back to her.

"Cappe is fine," Gress said and then started to walk past her towards the castle.

"Hang on!" Izzy said as she turned and began walking with him. "She shows up out of nowhere, rescues a bunch of people, holds off a bunch more so you can have your speech, and then flies out with you and the best you can tell me is that she's *fine?"*

Gress stopped and looked at Izzy before nodding.

"Yes, that's correct."

Izzy stared at him in shock. Gress nodded again and started walking. Izzy got out in front of Gress again and started walking backwards when he didn't break stride.

"Brother Gress, please, what's going on? Have you been in contact with her before this? You know her parents are scared for her, the rest of us are worried sick, and if you don't know, she's being hunted by some very scary people," Izzy said. "Please help me figure it out."

“No,” Gress said.

“Why are you acting like this!?” Izzy replied.

Gress stopped at the threshold of an entry. He looked forward for a long breath before turning to Izzy.

“Brother Izzy, I trust you. I know that you wish to do the right thing and that you fight hard for that thing. I trust that you have Capella’s best interest at heart,” Gress said. He paused before going on. “Cappe, however, does not believe that. I will only tell you that I have spoken with her, she is in good health, and she is not going to quietly come in and give up and I only tell you that because she said it was alright to do so. If you do not wish me to be here anymore because of this, I understand.”

Izzy let out a long sigh as she said, “Brother Gress, Dryl is open to anyone, you know that and I would never deny that to you, no matter what you withhold from me. I won’t ask you to betray your friend if you believe she is unblinded.”

Gress looked at her, his face relaxing a little, as he said, “She is and thank you for understanding, Brother Izzy.”

He walked on into the castle and Izzy leaned up against a wall as Harpi came up to her.

“Glimmer is asking that you call her immediately,” Harpi replied.

“I already told her what I’d heard about Cappe yesterday,” Izzy said, staring up at a small bot crawling along the ceiling. “Did she say what it was about?”

“She’s calling a council. With the various boards and councils getting hit with all the petitions and actions, she says that the Princess Council needs to meet and discuss how to help clear the backlog,” Harpi replied. “The Princess Council itself has many to work through as well.”

Izzy said with a groan. “This couldn’t come at a worse time.”

“I’ve assumed she’ll call you and the others to Bright Moon,” Harpi said.

Izzy said, “More than likely. At least I’ll get to see Grandma. I need to take some time to go see Emma as well. It’s been way too long. You should stay here, take a break. No reason you have to come along. Anything I need from you, I can do remotely.”

“Except for the chance to see Brother Dasi,” Harpi said with a rare smile.

“Are you two…,” Izzy started to say before stopping. “Sorry, I don’t want to pry.”

“I know what you were going to ask,” Harpi said. “The answer is maybe.”

Izzy let a tired smile flicker on her face as she said, “It’s good to hear and I’m happy for you. OK, I’m going to make that call now.”

Harpi had been right. Glimmer told Izzy that the Princess Council would meet in Bright Moon to discuss the issues. The call was short, polite, and cold, like every call that went on between Glimmer and Izzy recently. Izzy spent the next couple of days taking a moment to interview Gress’ caretakers as well as Aden and Laho who’d come in with them. She didn’t learn much beyond what she already knew.

The rest of the time was putting the day to day operations of Dryl into the hand of the Clone Council. They’d run Dryl in the years when Entrapta had been gone out among the stars with Hordak and Izzy had asked them one time if they wanted to keep doing so but they’d been very insistent that she keep the duties. Besides, she felt like it was a bit off to just give up the duties she’d set out to claim for herself.

When the morning came to leave for Bright Moon, she noticed she was alone in bed. Finn was gone and for a moment Izzy felt panic clamp down before she heard them in the next room. She sighed as she got up and padded in there to see Finn putting a bag down next to hers.

“Are you going along?” Izzy said, her heart leaping. She hadn’t asked them because after all the years they’d been together, she still worried about pulling them away from their theater and Finn hadn’t said anything about it and so she’d resigned herself to being away from them the whole time.

“At least for a little while,” Finn said. “I shuffled my schedule, tossed a few responsibilities on Caladium and Mel, and threw my toothbrush in a bag. I’m ready to roll.”

Izzy went over and gave them a kiss as she said, “Well, I’m not. Could you make breakfast while I get ready?”

“Already in the process of it. Should be done soon,” Finn said, kissing her back.

“How did I get so lucky?” Izzy said with a little smile as she left the room to get ready.

“You showed up to the old theater!” Finn shouted back at her with a laugh as she headed towards the shower. Izzy just shook her head with the same little smile as she got ready.

Thirty minutes later, Finn walked into the room while Izzy was strapping the last knife to her left forearm. It was a long thin knife that had been brandished and then thrown in anger at her by Aeron years before and she’d promised him that one day, she’d return it to him if he didn’t change the path he’d been on. It was

always the first one off when she removed her weapons at night and the last one on in the morning.

"The Vengeance Dagger is on so you must be about ready," Finn said, giving their name for it as they leaned against the doorway. Izzy shook her head as she turned around.

"It's not vengeance or anything like it. I'm just holding on to someone's property until I get a chance to return it to him," Izzy said as she rolled her long sleeve down over it. Finn didn't say anything because they knew exactly how she wanted to return it. Izzy knew it bothered them, Finn was a strict pacifist and she loved them for it but she took a different view on such matters though and it could occasionally start an argument. Not that day though.

"Well breakfast is waiting," Finn said with a soft smile as they watched Izzy finish tying her hair back. Izzy walked across the room and gave Finn a little hug as they walked towards the kitchen.

That evening Izzy and Finn were sitting around the table at Catra and Adora's house. Izzy was set to check in at the castle the next day. Melog was sprawled out on the couch in the living room, their head resting on the arm of the couch as they watched the four sit around the dinner table. Izzy sat next to Adora as they both looked at the agenda for the upcoming council while Finn played cards with Catra.

“This… are all of these real?” Adora said as she looked at the list of petitions to the council

“I’ve looked through a random selection of them and based off that sample I think we could conceivably get rid of some of them as groundless,” Izzy said. “This will still take a long time to work through.”

“How long?” Catra said as she lay a card down and began to grin at Finn.

“At least a week but really, probably twice that,” Izzy said with a sigh. She watched Finn look at Catra with a solemn face as they calmly laid down their whole hand. Catra looked down at the cards, her face full of surprise, as Finn calmly raked in the beans they had been playing for while turning to look at Izzy.

“I’ll probably have to go home after a week but I can try and stretch it out longer,” Finn said.

“No, don’t do that,” Izzy said. “It’s not like you’re going to get to spend a lot of time with me while this is going on.”

“And I’ll be teaching and Adora is going to be up there the whole time,” Catra said.

“Mother, don’t you have to be there as well?” Finn said.

“I don’t go to these big long ones anymore. I show up only for the big votes,” Catra said. “Adora has my proxy otherwise. She enjoys this stuff way more than I do.”

Adora rolled her eyes as she sat back.

“It’s not that I enjoy it more, it’s that I’m better at enduring it then your mother is,” Adora said. “And when she gets bored it gets… interesting.”

“Is this the table thing?” Izzy said. The two looked at her as Catra started laughing.

“What? What table thing?” Finn said.

“I heard from someone,” Izzy said, not mentioning it was from Scorpia at a party, “that during one of the meetings years ago, Catra got bored, climbed up on the table and curled up in front of Adora and went to sleep.”

“And she did it on top of my data pad,” Adora said as she laughed along with Catra. “We recessed for the rest of the day. I thought Glimmer was going to be furious but she started laughing as soon as we were in private.”

Everyone at the table went quiet for a moment as they all thought of Glimmer and by extension, Capella. Catra sighed a little as she pushed a dried bean back and forth on the table, watching it intently, as she slowly said, "So… speaking of Glimmer… anything new on Cappe?"

"You probably heard her and Brother Gress disappeared for a bit right?" Izzy said and Catra and Adora both nodded. "Gress said she was doing alright but other than that, nothing. We haven't heard word one from her. I've heard she's been spotted in some towns, occasionally with someone, but I don't know how much I can trust those reports."

"Why do you think Gress won't say more?" Catra said.

"I don't have to wonder," Izzy replied. "He flat out told me. He said she doesn't trust me and by extension, I'm assuming doesn't trust the rest of us."

Izzy didn't mention she knew that Gress was certain that Dark Moon was real and by extension Capella must believe the same.

Which means she thinks her own mother sent a hit squad out after her friends, Izzy said. *And every princess who's close to Glimmer is guilty by association.*

She'd looked into the rumors again after Gress had told her that on the night he'd first shown up in Dryl and while there were even

more rumors, some of them bordering on the believable, she still couldn't find solid information to tie it back to Bright Moon. But that fear was there for Capella and Gress and she completely understood. She looked back down at the list of all the petitions to the Princess Council and thought about how this and all the other petitions weighing down on the other boards and councils was a good way to tie things up. Then she froze as a thought occurred to her.

Harpi has said at least some of the additional petitions are probably from Aeron and his people. He's trying to sow chaos and what better way than to distract the Queen herself by losing her daughter? Izzy thought.

"I know that look," Finn said with a grin. "Can you share this thought?"

Izzy snapped out of it and shook her head. She grabbed her data pad and walked out into the backyard to send a few orders out. She still wasn't sure how they would have got the passphrase but she had a feeling that the Bright Moon guard wasn't as secure as everyone assumed. Then her blood ran cold with a single thought.

What if the point of this is to get us all in one place?

She stood in the yard thinking long and hard about it but ultimately never said anything. It had to be done and the last army that had managed to overrun Bright Moon had been Prime and that had been way bigger than anything Aeron could bring to bear.

Three days later during yet another long day of pouring over the petitions and everyone trying their best to give good answers to them, Izzy wondered again if it wasn't a way to get them in one place. However, now she thought it was to kill them all through sheer boredom.

She watched Prickly Pear, who had been installed as the new princess of Plumeria the day before the meeting, sit fitfully beside her mother, Scorpia. Perfuma was in Bright Moon but was spending most of her time with her and Scorpia's children exploring the Whispering Woods. Prickly Pear had been extremely formal for her first meeting but the second one had dragged on for over twelve hours and Izzy had found it slightly amusing to watch her go from formal to confused to relaxed and then finally to just plain done with it all.

That had also been the first night Izzy had spent in Catra and Adora's old room in Bright Moon. She and Adora had been too tired to walk back to Adora's house, and Izzy remembered looking at the big mural in the room of a high ledge in the Fright Zone covered in greenery while Adora walked out of the bathroom wrapped in a robe way nicer than the one she used at home.

"You look contemplative," Adora said as she wrapped her hair up in a towel.

Izzy looked over her shoulder at her as she said, "Not really. Just tired. I miss Finn as well."

Adora gave a smile as she came to stand by Izzy and stare at the mural with her. She got very quiet for a moment and Izzy watched as Adora's face became somber.

"So much has changed," Adora said softly.

"Since that was painted?" Izzy replied.

"That too," Adora said. "Things seem so odd lately, I just…"

Adora trailed off and seemed to pull in on herself a little.

"Is it because you don't have She-Ra anymore?" Izzy said softly and Adora turned suddenly to look at her.

"Finn told you?" Adora said.

"Sorry, yes, they did," Izzy replied.

Adora's shoulders sagged a little as she said, "Don't be sorry, I didn't expect them to keep it secret from you."

Izzy sat down into a huge beanbag chair as she said, “Do you need to talk about it?”

Adora leaned against a pillar in the room as she said, “You know, it’ll never not be odd to hear that from someone I watched grow up.”

Izzy gave a small smile as she said, “You didn’t watch me grow up. You met me when I was almost an adult.”

Adora looked at her with a gentle smile as she said, “Yes, I did; from shy little Izzy to princess of her own kingdom Izzy.”

Izzy gave a little head bob in agreement before she said, “Do you need to talk about it though?”

“No, not really,” Adora said and then went on. “I’ve got better about it. Things like this worry me though. What if I’m needed?”

Izzy got a concerned look on her face as she said, “You mean in your role at the top of the Etherian Charter?”

Adora shook her head as she said, “Not what I meant but Mara, yes, can you imagine what would happen if something got all the way up there and then I couldn’t summon her?”

“At least it’s never happened before,” Izzy said and then flinched as she said it. Adora saw it and grinned.

“You have grown,” Adora said. “You’re aware of the danger of that statement.”

“Don’t I know it,” Izzy said in a flat tone of voice.

“I’m just planning on taking it as it comes,” Adora said.

“There’s a lot of that going around,” Izzy said, thinking of Bow and his eyes. He’d been there for every meeting but he’d hardly been involved. He’d just seemed to be staring off into space half the time. Izzy had heard from Spinnerella that he’d hardly been sleeping.

“Catra and I have been trying to help them both,” Adora said, thinking of the same thing, “and I don’t know how much it’s helping. They’re seeing Listeners but… I’m scared for both of them.”

Izzy said, “I am too. Bow’s never said anything to me but Glimmer, well, I don’t think she’s ever going to forgive me and I can’t say I blame her.”

Adora paused for a moment before saying, “Can I ask what Cappe was doing for you?”

Izzy looked up at Adora and for a moment didn't say anything before going on.

"She wasn't doing anything for me directly. I had made some money available to her so she could better fund what she was already doing."

Adora said, "Are you OK?"

Izzy shook her head as she said, "No, I'm not. She's…"

Izzy trailed off, almost saying she wasn't the first that Izzy had lost but she didn't want to voice it. Adora didn't push her and soon the two were going to sleep.

Over the coming weeks, they worked and slowly chipped away at the workload. However, there was a wrinkle that kept interrupting them and that was news coming in of Capella. It seemed like the weeks of no one seeing her were suddenly reversed. Now credible reports seemed to come in from far and wide. She was seen in this town talking with someone. She was in that town running out a group who were anti-clone. She'd been seen attacking another group. Graffiti proclaiming her queen was popping up here and there as well. Glimmer would occasionally come to Izzy and speak with her about the sightings and Izzy would be as upfront with Glimmer as she could. When Izzy went to contact Snow-by to see if he'd heard anything and he didn't respond, she knew something was going on there as well.

Then one morning, Adora came into the bedroom, holding two scrolls, as Izzy was strapping on her last knife. Adora was used to the amount of weaponry Izzy wore now but she'd been a little horrified the first night they'd shared the room and watched Izzy stack various weapons up on her nightstand.

"What's that you have there?" Izzy said as she got her sleeve rolled down and took a look at herself in the mirror to make sure nothing showed.

"I don't know; haven't read it yet," Adora said as she held one out. "This one's yours. One of the guards handed it to me on my way back."

Izzy stepped over and immediately broke the seal on it and rolled it out as she began to read out loud.

"Attention all and pay heed: The Council of Free Towns announces the recognition of a new princess and calls upon the Princess Council, headed by her honorable majesty Queen Glimmer, to admit this princess to their ranks to serve with the kingdom and Etheria," Izzy said and trailed off as she read the rest, full of equally grandiose but ultimately empty jargon. The only thing was a date of petition that was the same day. She looked up at Adora. "I've never heard of The Council of Free Towns, have you?"

"No," Adora said as she broke the seal on her scroll and scanned over it. "Has your… um, network?"

Izzy frowned as she shook her head.

"Not that I've heard. Hang on just a moment," she said as she grabbed her tiara, put it on, and flipped down the monocle. "Morning, Pat. Retrieve all information from internal DB pertaining to The Council of Free Towns or anything similar, please."

After she said it, she saw Adora grinning.

"What?"

"Nothing. You just reminded me of Entrapta with how you talk to AI and bots," Adora said. Izzy was going to say something when Pat came back and told her there wasn't anything. Izzy set up an alert to be notified of anything as she rolled her scroll back up.

"Pat hasn't heard anything," Izzy said as she stood and tapped at her satchel on the table.

"Well, we'll hear soon enough," Adora replied as she held up the scroll. "Looks like we'll get whoever it is today."

"I saw that," Izzy said, her chest tightening with nerves. Something felt off about the whole thing.

"Well let's get the day started. I'm going to move for a recess for a few days at the end of today, we all need to take a break," Adora said as she picked up a huge coffee mug that was covered in scrapes and dents. Izzy just nodded and the two went walking down the hall. She had given Harpi the morning off as his romance was starting to bloom with Dasi and she didn't want to get in the way of that.

The other princesses were all talking about the scrolls, each having received one, when Izzy and Adora walked into the council room. Even Bow, sitting at the table, looked more present than he had in days. Huntara was laughing as she said something to Netossa about how if they were going to have a new princess, it was going to be getting awfully crowded in the room. Prickly Pear was reading something from a stack of papers in front of her. As Adora and Izzy took their seats, Glimmer brought the room to order.

"OK, we've all seen the scrolls. That's going to be our first order of business today. There's an emissary from whoever this is waiting outside in the hall with a stack of paperwork that says what's going on so let's go ahead and get to it alright?" Glimmer said. There was a general murmur of consent around the table and Glimmer called the person in.

A person dressed in heavy canvas clothes came in, standing tall and straight, holding a bundle of papers. The noise from Izzy's tiara got her attention and she gave a little head shake to drop her monocle into place. The person had a faint red outline around them and Pat was alerting her that this person matched someone

suspected of being within Aeron's inner circle. Suddenly the reason for Aeron being at Candila was crystal clear.

No, no, no, no, no, she thought over and over as the person began to speak and she almost leaped out of her chair but held herself steady.

"My name is Thorn and I am here as a representative of the Kingdom of Candila," Thorn announced. "I have been given the honor of delivering the bonafides of our new princess to her majesty, Queen Glimmer."

Thorn stepped forward and set the paperwork on the table within reach of Glimmer and then stepped back. Glimmer looked down at the paperwork and then back up at Thorn as they went on.

"With that done, I present to you his highness, Princess Aeron!" Thorn said as they raised their voice until it boomed around the room. "Long may he reign!"

Everyone was looking at Izzy because they all knew the history between her and Aeron and so no one except Izzy was looking at the door as Aeron stepped into the council room. He was grinning wide and it stuttered a little when he realized only Izzy was looking at him. For a split second there was anger, then wicked glee at Izzy's face, and then back to the triumphal grin he had been wearing.

“Greetings to the Princess Council,” Aeron said, not shouting but still projecting his voice so it filled the room. “I am here to take my place among you as your equal.”

Izzy started to stand and Adora reached over and put a hand on her shoulder as Glimmer stood instead.

“We have not had a chance to review your petition,” Glimmer said, her voice flat. “We also do not recognize the authority of The Council of Free Towns that announced this to us this morning. While that need not be an impediment to your eventual ascension to the title you claim, the Princess Council will need to discuss this first.”

Aeron stepped into the room and Izzy got her first look at Carl in years as well as he came in behind Aeron. She rested her right hand on her left forearm and felt the knife there and began to calm her breathing.

“I understand and I have brought Carl, my husband, to help during these discussions. He will not claim princess status himself but he has been a great help in preparing my petition,” Aeron said. “I have other staff as well that will require housing during these discussions.”

“What indication do you have that I would allow you to participate in these discussions?” Glimmer replied.

“The Etherian Charter gives me the right to state my case and have it argued,” Aeron said. “Or was that only empty promises when you wrote it and you only accept those that you have pre-approved?”

Aeron made full eye contact with Izzy for a split second before looking back to Glimmer.

“He’s right,” Izzy finally managed to say. “He does have the right to sit in on the proceedings.”

Again, everyone in the room looked at Izzy, this time in surprise. Izzy was breathing slowly and deeply, shoving down her raging emotions, as she went on.

“He and I have deep history, I admit, but he has served his rehabilitation with Princess Huntara,” Izzy said as she carefully took Adora’s hand off her shoulder and stood up, methodically reminding herself to make eye contact with each person at the table. “If he has finally received the princess title that he craved so much when he and I knew each other so many years ago, then I for one am glad he has made good on his goals and wishes, no doubt helped by the rehabilitation.”

Aeron looked surprised at first as he listened and then his eyes narrowed as she continued on.

“So, with your permission Queen Glimmer, I invite him to sit at the table with us as we review his petition to take on the title of Candila, so long lost to this table,” Izzy said, finally ending staring directly at Aeron. There was silence in the room as Aeron and Izzy stared at each other.

“Thank you for that,” Glimmer said, her voice cold as she looked at Izzy before turning back to Aeron and gesturing at the empty chair of the Fire Princess. “Very well, Aeron, please sit.”

Izzy pushed her chair back and began to walk towards him as the room started to mutter as most of them began to stand. Aeron froze as Izzy stopped next to the Fire Princess chair. He was only a few steps in front of her and she felt calm and centered.

“Aeron, last we talked face to face, it was unpleasant,” Izzy replied and everyone could hear something in her voice they couldn’t place. “I wish to be the first to greet you now and hopefully we can put an end to this enmity between us.”

Aeron looked at her and she could see him calculating but she just kept her face neutral as she pulled the chair out. Carl stood behind him and Izzy could see him shift up onto the balls of his feet. Izzy just stood there and gestured at the chair.

“Your chair,” she said as she took a step backwards. He finally nodded at her and let his smile grow as he went to sit down, never taking his eyes off of her.

“Thank you, Princess Izzy,” Aeron said as he began to sit.

“You’re welcome,” she said. She turned and took two steps as her right hand drifted up to her left sleeve.

“Oh, I forgot something,” she said, sounding almost absentminded as she began to turn again. “Your knife.”

Izzy had managed to keep herself loose, against all the tension she felt, and the turn was smooth and appeared effortless. She drew the long, thin knife as she was vaguely aware of people starting to shout and flicked it side hand at Aeron. She saw the blade fly true and slam into his chest as she reached around with the same hand and drew the big curved dagger hidden in the small of her back. She began to step forward, calculating the slash, when she felt herself get grabbed by a vine around her waist and pulled backwards.

Izzy slashed back at the vine and felt it part as she watched Aeron pull the dagger out of his chest. She suddenly realized he was wearing body armor of some kind and she absorbed that knowledge and started looking for open places to strike. She moved, almost bouncing on the balls of her feet as she weaved forward towards him, and Aeron was jumping to his feet as she flicked the dagger at his throat. He shoved his arm in the way and she felt the blade slide along the armor as he shoved it sideways and away from him, stabbing in towards her belly as he did so. She dodged sideways to the left and as she did, she snapped her right hand back around from where it’d been deflected and dragged the blade across Aeron’s chest. The two stepped away for a split second and Izzy took the break to yank a stun rod out of its sheath on her right arm.

Izzy was vaguely aware of the room in an uproar as she turned the stun rod on and snapped it down at Aeron. She was hoping he'd think it was a regular baton and try to catch it on his armor but he jumped backwards and kicked the chair he'd been sitting in at Izzy as Carl came rushing around the other side, fists balled up. Izzy sidestepped the chair, jabbed the baton into Carl's leg, dropping him to the ground screaming, and then kicked him hard with the heel of her boot to his knee, sending the screaming up an octave.

As Izzy prepared to move on Aeron again, she felt herself get wrapped up in vines as her and Aeron got separated by an ice wall. She tried to scream at the others to let her finish it but all that came out of her mouth was a guttural yell as she was dragged back. She saw Netossa advancing on Aeron as he stood on the other side of the ice wall, standing upright and calm. She could vaguely see his face and she screamed again in anger at his smug smile as she was pulled out of the room.

Chapter End Notes

Izzy is definitely quiet, calculating, and careful but then again, occasional, she most certainly isn't.

Bow

Chapter Summary

> Bow has been fighting to come to terms with how things are happening and after the council decides it's time he does something.
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary

Chapter Notes

> "'Cause here's the thing/To know how it ends/And still begin to sing it again/As if it might turn out this time/I learned that from a friend of mine"
> - Road to Hell (Reprise), Hadestown

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bow had watched the fight between Aeron and Izzy start with shock but his first reflex had been to go for an arrow, his mind telling him to reach just left of center and feel for the arrow with three notches and a dot that indicated a net. His fingers closed on empty air as he suddenly remembered that he hadn't worn his quiver or carried his bow as part of day to day life for years. The fight was over in seconds though and Izzy was pulled from the room by Prickly Pear with Adora helping. Izzy was still screaming incoherently as she struggled to get out of the vines that Prickly Pear had wrapped her up in when she went out the door.

"Go do what's needed with Izzy," Bow said to Glimmer. "I've got this room here."

Glimmer nodded and teleported out as Bow stood and held his hands up. Everyone stilled when he did so and turned to look at

him, the silence cut only by the screams from Carl on the floor and the more muffled yelling from Izzy outside.

"Someone help that man on the floor please," Bow said. "Aeron, do you need assistance?"

Aeron was already making his way around the ice wall to Carl, kneeling down beside him, and didn't respond. Several of the Bright Moon guards were pulling medical kits out of their robes as they kneeled down with Aeron; it was only a few seconds before Carl was silent as the painkillers kicked in.

"We're taking him to the infirmary," one of the guards said as someone brought a stretcher into the room and started loading him up. Aeron stood up as the guards lifted the stretcher, his clothes shredded from multiple slashes and Bow couldn't help but notice that Izzy's dagger had actually managed to carve into the armor Aeron was wearing. As Aeron carefully sat the knife Izzy had thrown at him on the table, his face was full of fury as he turned to Bow.

"I thought there'd be some arguments about my claim but I did not expect to be *attacked!"*

"I apologize," Bow replied and felt the distaste of the next words. "Izzy does not represent the will of the council."

“I expect her to be handed over to me so that she can begin to serve rehabilitation in my kingdom,” Aeron said haughtily.

“You haven’t been appointed princess yet,” Huntara said as she leaned back in her chair. “I think you’re just mad because she took you to the cleaners. If you hadn’t been hiding behind that armor, you’d be in pieces right now, buddy.”

“I don’t have to listen to your bleating anymore,” Aeron shot back at her and looked around the table. “I know the Charter. My claim is solid. I expect to have it accepted and then I expect you to hand her over to me.”

“Now, that’s not how things are done,” Scorpia said, sitting back down.

“Are you arguing for her?” Aeron said to her.

“The Fright Zone is neutral but that doesn’t mean we don’t follow the rules as set down in the Charter,” Scorpia said.

Bow started around the table as he said, “Listen, even if we wanted to, we can’t go back into Council to discuss this right now. We’re missing the queen and several princesses that we need for a full council.”

“Any excuse to deny me...,” Aeron started to say before Bow cut him off.

“Your husband is on his way to the infirmary with a serious injury! Are you just going to stand here and demand some conversation on your claim right now!? Do you not care about him!?” Bow said, pointing towards the door that Carl had been hauled out.

“Do not presume to tell me how I feel about my husband!” Aeron said. “He worked on this just as hard as I did and he would want this!”

“Well I’m sorry but I’m going to have to force you to go be by his side,” Bow said. “Acting in the queen’s name, I call this meeting recessed indefinitely. You may speak with the guard about getting lodging if you still require it, sir.”

Bow turned away from Aeron and stalked out of the room, ignoring Aeron’s shouting after him. He went directly back to his room and leaned against the wall inside for a moment before walking over to a small side table. He looked down at the picture there of him, Glimmer, and Capella. It was some remote beach they’d gone to for a family trip. He could still hear Capella’s voice laughing as she splashed in the water as he and Glimmer held each other’s hands on the shore. He wondered where she was that day, what she was doing, and if he’d get to see her again. He rested his hand in front of the picture, afraid to touch it, afraid it’d make it disappear if he touched it just like Capella seemed to have.

As he looked at it, he heard a knock at the door and went to answer it, not bothering to wipe away the tears.

"Yes?" he said as he opened it. One of the guards named Demona, fresh out of cadet training, stood at rigid attention.

"Your majesty, people are inquiring after you in the council chamber," she said, eyes forward.

Bow sighed as he realized he had gone stomping out when he should have stayed behind and dealt with the fall out while Glimmer dealt with Izzy.

"Certainly, yes, I'm sorry, please tell them I'll be on the way immediately, Guard Demona," Bow replied. The guard started to turn and Bow suddenly stopped her.

"Yes, Your Majesty?" she replied.

"Never mind, I'll go with you," Bow said and began to walk with her. There was a moment of silence before Demona spoke up.

"Your Majesty?"

"You can just call me Bow," he replied.

“Sorry. Um… Bow?” she said tentatively.

“Demona, you have something on your mind, please share it,” Bow said, stopping in the middle of the hall.

She stood awkwardly dressed in the flowing ceremonial robes of a Bright Moon guard on duty in the castle and fiddled with the halberd of her position.

“I just wanted to say that… that I was part of Sergeant Clo’s detachment at Wheatland,” she said, looking down at the floor. “I’m sorry I wasn’t able to protect your daughter, Your Majesty. I met her once. She was…”

She trailed off as she felt Bow’s stare on her. She looked up to see a strange look on his face she couldn’t place. If she had to pick a name for it, she’d call it sorrowful anger.

“Cappe isn’t a was, she is very much an is, Demona. As to your apology, I know you were there because I’ve heard Sergeant Clo’s description of that day. I’ve read what’s been reported about Wheatland from many sources and you have no idea how much I want to blame what happened that day on you or Sergeant Clo or one of the others in your squad but the blame doesn’t sit with you,” Bow said, his face never changing. “The blame is squarely mine and it goes back much longer than you’ve been here at Bright Moon. I have duties to attend to now.”

Bow began walking forward again, not looking back, as Demona fell in behind him. She stayed by his side as he walked back into the Council room. Aeron had left but all the other princesses had questions and suggestions. If he noticed their looks of worry at him when they thought he wasn't looking, he gave no notice, as he quickly sorted the situation out and sent each of them on their way with something to do and an artificial smile from him. He checked in on the condition of Carl through his data pad before leaving the Council room.

Demona was still on his heels as Bow headed towards Catra and Adora's old room. He wasn't sure that's where they would have taken Izzy but he figured that was the first place to check. When he got to the door, he saw multiple guards on it and figured he'd made the correct decision. He noticed Demona was still with him and didn't say anything to her as she took up position beside her fellow guard corps members.

"May I go in?" Bow asked and one of the guards knocked on the door.

Glimmer answered, looking angry and frazzled, giving Bow a brief smile before going back to her previous look.

"I put us into recess," Bow said as he walked with her into the room. Prickly Pear sat in the corner nervously chewing on the side of her finger as she tried to stay out of view of Izzy who had only calmed down enough to at least sit down and not try rushing out the door. Bow noticed a small pile of weapons sitting on a table. Knives, batons, spikes, and coiled wire were what he noticed right

off the bat before turning back to Glimmer. Catra had come into the room at some point and sat next to Adora on another couch as Bow began to speak.

"The guard took Carl to the infirmary. From what I could see, you did serious injury to him, Izzy," Bow said quietly. Izzy didn't respond but Bow could see the look on her face that said she had intended much worse than just serious injury.

"What about Aeron?" Adora asked.

"He wanted us all to come back and confirm his claim," Bow said and they all heard the distaste in his voice.

"Because he doesn't care about him," Izzy finally said. "He only cares about his ambition."

"I assume you do have an explanation for that?" Glimmer said in a tired voice.

"He's a foe and I let my temper get the better of me," Izzy said.

"You had to be dragged literally kicking and screaming out of the room. His husband is currently sedated while healers rebuild his knee and Aeron looks like… well, like someone slashed him with a dagger multiple times," Bow replied as he put his hand on his

forehead with a sigh. “That’s a bit more than your temper getting the better of you.”

“Be fair, she has one heck of a temper,” Catra said from where she was sprawled out on the couch. Glimmer shot her a look and Catra nodded and made a zipping motion across her lips.

“Give me one reason why I shouldn’t be putting you into rehabilitation right now,” Glimmer said, staring hard at Izzy.

“Because I’m a princess and to do that you need a full vote of the council,” Izzy said mechanically, staring straight ahead.

Bow sat down in a chair in front of Izzy as he said, “I know we don’t get along anymore and I hate that. I know you and Glimmer faced off when we first got back after Wheatland but Izzy, please, we need to work together. I still respect you.”

Izzy looked at Bow and then with a sigh said, “No, we’re not getting along and I know why but yes, I respect you and Glimmer still. This isn’t just some old grudge from years back but something very real and present. I can’t prove it beyond a shadow of a doubt but he’s responsible for a lot of things that have happened lately… including Wheatland.”

Glimmer looked away in anger as Bow leaned forward, his face contorting between anger and grief, before he finally said, “What do you mean?”

"Listen, you want to blame me for Cappe disappearing, I'm fine with that; I understand. However, that… man is responsible for death and destruction across this planet," Izzy said, beginning to get heated. "If I hadn't been stopped, I wouldn't have necessarily put an end to all that but I would have put an end to him and his ability to cause more than his share. If those two had done this, would you be questioning it?"

Izzy pointed at Catra and Adora as she spoke the last sentence and Glimmer spoke up.

"No, because I trust them. I've known them for decades and I know they'd have a good reason," Glimmer said.

"Glimmer, that's not fair," Prickly Pear spoke up and everyone looked at her in surprise as she shrunk back a little.

"Glimmer, I trust Izzy," Catra said, standing up as Prickly Pear let out a silent sigh of relief that no one was looking at her.

Adora stood as well as she said, "So do I."

Bow looked at Izzy. Ever since he'd seen the reports she gave, he'd felt like something was missing, like she wasn't quite saying all that she could. It wasn't that he thought she was hiding Capella from them but it was if she didn't wholly trust them.

“Izzy, you’ve been holding something back from us and have been ever since after Cappe went missing,” Bow said. “What is it?”

Izzy looked away from them all and Bow moved over to sit down beside Izzy. Izzy scooted away a little without looking at him.

“Izzy, I’ve known you a long time now,” Bow said softly as he did his best not to cry. “I care only about seeing my daughter again and getting her out of danger. What are you holding back?”

Izzy looked down and Bow watched as her shoulders sagged.

“OK, there’s solid rumors that a Dark Moon hit squad went in to retrieve Cappe from Wheatland. Someone is still missing from that group and presumed dead. Sert was horribly injured. They’re the one she brought injured into Salienas,” Izzy said, still not looking at anyone. “It’s also why Brother Gress won’t speak directly to you. Cappe doesn’t trust any of us and he feels the same way.”

Glimmer looked down at the table. Bow got up as she began to cry and Catra quietly walked over as well and hugged her tight as she began to cry in earnest. Izzy stood up, uncomfortable, as Adora followed Catra and Prickly Pear came over to stand beside Izzy.

“I’m… I’m sorry. That’s what I’ve been holding back,” Izzy said. “Some of the rumors are…”

Izzy trailed off and looked down at the ground, shrugging off the hand that Prickly Pear sat on her shoulder.

“Do you believe them, these rumors?” Bow said and Izzy jumped at the sudden question.

“I don’t know,” Izzy said, looking up. “I’ve been trying to be cautious and so much is muddled… I didn’t want to be wrong.”

Bow moved back as Glimmer stood up and moved his hand off of her and pushed past Catra and Adora as she walked up to Izzy.

“Have you spoken with her?” Glimmer said. “This damn Dark Moon thing… you’ve been talking with her haven’t you?”

Izzy shook her head.

“No, I haven’t,” Izzy said.

Bow walked over to stand beside Glimmer and Izzy stood her ground, looking at Bow as they both stopped right in front of her.

“How do I know you’re not lying to us?” he said, his tone more of a quiet thought than any kind of accusation.

“You don’t,” Izzy said. “Use magic if you must. I consent to it.”

Glimmer looked at her and stepped back, drawing a truth spell in front of her as she did. Bow turned to her and shook his head.

“No,” Bow said, his shoulders sagging. “This doesn’t change if we don’t trust each other. Catra and Adora, do you really trust her?”

Adora walked over and put an arm around Izzy.

“We do,” Adora replied. Catra nodded from where she was standing.

Bow looked down, the silence in the room hanging heavy.

“Why did you do it?” Bow said finally.

“Because of what I said,” Izzy said. “He’s a terrible person and if he were gone, the world would improve.”

Bow looked up at her, his eyes wet with tears as he said, “Not that. Why did you get Cappe involved?”

Izzy looked down.

“Oh.”

It was quiet for a moment before she went on.

“Because she was already involved,” Izzy said. “I thought she would be able to use the money I offered to do better work.”

“For you,” Glimmer said, her voice sharp.

“Yes, for me,” Izzy said as she looked up, her eyes tired. “I could point out that she was already involved but yes, I definitely helped her stay involved.”

“And if I’m being honest, we got her involved in the first place,” Bow said, his voice almost not audible. Glimmer looked over at him, anger on her face, as he went on. “We did, Starlight. I remember you talking to me about her getting involved with something other than that data board stuff she had been doing with Gress and we both thought Equal was a good group for her.”

Glimmer said, “But I didn’t intend for her to do this!”

“Of course not,” Bow said. “But it’s what’s happened.”

Glimmer’s face fell as Bow stepped over and put his arms around her and pulled her in close. He whispered in her ear quietly, so that no one else could hear, “I love you and blaming Izzy won’t fix this.”

Glimmer nodded as she buried her head in his chest. They stood that way for a few minutes, the other four in the room going to the other side of the room to give them a little privacy. When they came back over, Izzy stood up and was the first to speak.

“OK, even if you hate me, I hope you understand I’m not going to leave Cappe hanging. I’m going to get her home,” Izzy replied.

Bow put a hand on her shoulder as he said, “Izzy… I don’t hate you and… well… Capella is moving around, going from town to town… if she… well, if she wanted to come home, she would have already.”

Glimmer looked away as he said it. Bow patted Izzy’s shoulder as tears ran down his face before turning away and sitting down with Glimmer.

"OK, I think you're right," Catra said, her voice tired. "I think that's something we all need to realize and face. She's staying away for her own reasons."

Bow nodded as he said, "I agree."

Into the moment, Prickly Pear spoke up.

"Do you think… maybe Plumeria, could, I don't know… help in some way?"

The others looked at her as Izzy said, "You could have helped by waiting to drag me out of the council room."

"Izzy, stop," Bow said, looking at her. Izzy didn't say anything else as Bow turned to Prickly Pear. "Listen, I want to know what you're thinking but don't you think you should ask your Mom before you commit to something?"

Prickly Pear opened her mouth, was about to say something, and then stopped. She raised her hand as if trying to think of something to say before suddenly straightening her shoulders.

"No, I do not have to ask her. She abdicated the title and I am the princess of Plumeria. I do not approve of the violence but I commit the resources of my kingdom to helping Capella and getting her home," Prickly Pear said, pausing a moment before

going on, her voice a bit less confident. “Maybe we'll keep that quiet for now though.”

Bow gave her a smile as he said, “I understand.”

Izzy looked between everyone as she said, “I’m already helping do this so I won’t have much to say beyond I’ll give you assistance P-Pear. Assuming I don’t end up sitting in rehabilitation.”

Bow put his arm around Glimmer as she said, “We’ll talk about that. For now… please, help us talk with our daughter again. Please.”

Izzy nodded and they began talking. Finn joined the group about half an hour later, running into the room and grabbing Izzy in a hug. They all watched as Finn and her stepped to the side for a whispered conversation that was obviously them arguing, Finn’s tail lashing back and forth as they talked, before they finally seemed to settle something and come back.

“Finn’s unhappy with me,” Izzy said as the two sat down, hand in hand. “But we’re ready to go on.”

After a long conversation, Glimmer and Bow left the room, everyone agreeing that Izzy would stay under custody of Bright Moon until such a time as they could discuss what charges would

be brought. Catra and Adora went back to their home and Prickly Pear stayed behind to talk with Izzy.

Demona followed along behind Bow and Glimmer as they walked through the halls, quietly holding hands. Bow turned for a moment to Demona and said, "Demona, thank you for your words earlier."

"I meant them," she responded.

"I know. Thank you for your help today but you can go on now," Bow said with a tired smile. "I'd like some quiet time with my wife please."

Demona nodded and went on as Bow put his arm around Glimmer and the two walked into Capella's room. They both quietly made their way to a small nook carved into the wall and Bow sat down with Glimmer arranging her wings as she lay her head in his lap. Bow began to gently play with her hair as they both looked out at the room in silence.

"You really think she's staying away on purpose?" Glimmer said.

"Yes," Bow said, his voice breaking. He swallowed the lump in his throat. "She's been seen by herself. She's obviously teleporting around places. She could have returned or sent us a message. This is her choice."

There was a long silence again as Glimmer hugged his leg and they both looked at the room, untouched since Capella had left. Some clothes still sat on the couch where she'd packed and some books and games sat scattered on a table.

"Why do we do this? Why do we keep coming in here?" Glimmer said softly.

"I don't know," Bow said. "I just like remembering her here."

Glimmer shook her head a little as she gave a little laugh and said, "She'd be irritated we were just sitting around in her room." The laugh disappeared as she got serious. "I'm talking like she's…"

Bow put his hand on her arm as the silence fell again. After a few minutes, he got up, gently moving Glimmer as he began to walk slowly around the room. They'd never touched anything before, leaving it alone so they could see if anything had been moved, hoping for a sign that she'd returned long enough to grab some clothes or rest there. Bow stood before the couch, looking at a long purple shirt wadded up on top of some tights. He reached down, his hand stopping just an inch above the shirt before finally picking it up.

"What are you doing?" Glimmer asked.

“Cleaning up,” Bow said, tears in his eyes as he picked up a hangar sitting on the couch and slipped the shirt onto it.

“We’re not taking her stuff out of here!” Glimmer said as she stood up.

“No, that’s not what I meant,” Bow said as he hung up a few more clothes and put a few others into a hamper. “I’m tidying up so when she comes home, her space won’t be chaotic. She’s going to need a lot of healing I think. I can make sure her space is clear.”

Glimmer hugged herself as she said, “You… you really believe she’s going to come back?”

“With all my heart,” Bow said as he looked at the floor, his voice timid, before he looked up at her and he forced conviction into his voice. “I have to believe it or I can’t go on.”

Glimmer came across the floor to him and they hugged tightly, tears flowing, before they each began to slowly tidy up the room in desperate hope that they weren’t just wasting time.

Chapter End Notes

> Trust Bow, the emotional heart of the Best Friends Squad, to strike right to the heart of things.

Capella

Chapter Summary

> Capella prepares for visiting Candila and in the process, has something happen that makes her starting thinking a little harder about her situation.

Chapter Notes

> "If you could sit with me upon the shore to-day,/And hold my hand in yours as in the days of old,/I think I should not mind the chill baptismal spray,/Nor find my hand and heart and all the world so cold." - Longing by Paul Laurence Dunbar
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“This is ridiculous!”

“For the last time, if you don’t like it, go back to the Waste!”

Capella could hear the argument between Half-Ear and Coalfire from down the hall as she walked into the small living room. A little bit of sea breeze slipped into the room through the shuttered windows as she paused for a moment before going into the room, to make sure nothing was there to surprise her. She was much more cautious lately since she’d just managed to get the bandage off her arm from the last surprise.

She’d simply been trying to have a conversation with one of the Children of Mara and they’d had a dagger she wasn't expecting.

Ever since Wheatland had managed to go back to its regular town council, the group had fallen apart. Capella though had stayed on the heels of the leaders as they ran because Coalfire had thought there was a link to someone who'd been pulling their strings. With Gress helping by searching for them over data boards and helping her with strategy, they'd had success. Now walking into the living room, she saw Half-Ear turn and look at her, his whole face contorted in anger.

"What are you griping about now?" Capella said as she leaned back into the wall.

"Screw off, this isn't between you and me," Half-Ear replied.

"I could say the same to you," Capella said, crossing her arms in front of her. "You stick around but all you do is complain. Be useful for once. Shut your mouth."

Half-Ear stood up out of the chair he'd been sitting in as he took a step towards her. Capella raised an eyebrow, keeping a calm demeanor over the anxiety that was her constant companion now.

"You know, you haven't been around this business that long to justify being that cocky," Half-Ear said, taking another step. "Keep flashing that scar and you'll get another."

Capella hadn’t realized when she crossed her arms that the scar starting at her left wrist and going back to her elbow was visible. She was used to wearing a long heavy coat now when she was out but she hadn’t been wearing it when she’d come back from where she’d just been on her own. She just shrugged though and let her left hand drop to her dagger, determined not to back down.

“Looking to become known as Quarter-Ear instead?” Capella said and forced a cold smile.

Capella watched his scowl on his face deepen as he stared hard at her and Coalfire leaned back in her chair as she watched the two. Capella had noticed that lately Coalfire hadn’t been getting involved as much in the little arguments that always seemed to happen between her and Half-Ear. Capella did her best to look casual as she cocked her head to one side and waited, her heart thumping. Finally, Half-Ear turned and left the room, shooting her poisonous looks over his shoulder. Only after he’d left did Coalfire speak up.

“Your little private trip go alright?”

“Yeah, no problems,” Capella said as she sat down, making sure she could see both doors into the space. She felt exhausted but kept herself sitting upright so as not to show it as Coalfire had emphasized.

“You know, it does look a little weird when you disappear for half a day or longer like that with no explanation,” Coalfire said.

“Is that what the argument was about?” Capella replied.

“That was in the argument but the argument was more just Half-Ear being Half-Ear,” Coalfire said.

“Why do you even bother with him?” she asked.

“Because he is an excellent fighter,” Coalfire said. “Not real great at strategy though.”

“Well we haven’t had a lot of fighting in this,” Capella said and she watched as Coalfire shifted her gaze to Capella’s left arm. “OK, you can stop staring at that now.”

“Fine, I’ll change the subject. Are you going to tell me what you’re up to when you leave like that?” Coalfire said.

“I’m fulfilling a promise,” Capella said, shifting a little in her seat. “That’s all I’m going to say.”

Coalfire said, “As you’ve said before. Well, you can have a private life.”

“Yes, I can,” Capella replied. “Now I think our next move is to find out where Neral has disappeared to and do some more training if you can.”

Coalfire nodded as she said, “Yes, I can train you more. You’re doing well with the illusion magic these days. As to Neral, that package you sent to from Gress said he followed up on that tip Kirken gave us,” referring to the Children of Mara person who’d cut Capella’s arm open, “and figures that what he meant by ‘went home’ was referring to a cluster of small towns out by Mount Candila.”

Capella leaned forward a little as she said, “That’s not the first time we’ve heard of that place have we?”

Coalfire shook her head as she said, “It’s not. Gress’ report said he is deep into some of those data boards and a lot of them are referring to that place. Talking about how the dream is being built out there or something.”

“What dream? This Mara thing we keep hearing about?” Capella said.

“Must be,” Coalfire said.

Capella sat back and idly ran her finger up and down the healing tissue on her arm as she thought. She’d just had it butterfly bandaged, glued, and then taped gauze over it all instead of

trying to do stitches and what had been pink when it first knitted together had begun to darken towards her natural skin color and a thought crossed her mind as she wondered what it would look like when it healed. She remembered a lot of the older people she knew when she'd lived at Bright Moon had scars of one kind or another. She remembered her Mom and Dad had a few but nothing like Adora who had them crisscrossing her body. She realized she was doing something similar to how those people had got their scars and that the one on her arm was probably the start of a collection.

"Don't pick at that, it won't heal right," Coalfire said.

"I'm not picking at it and it's already healed up for the most part," Capella said as she stopped messing with it. "You think the person Kirken referenced has something to do with that place?"

"Maybe? It's not like we're getting much further. I think unless we run Neral or one of the other inner four of the Children down, we're at a dead end for now," Coalfire replied as she held up her data pad. "Now you can focus on this next thing."

"What's that?" Capella said.

"Just sent it to your data pad," Coalfire said. Capella pulled out her data pad and took a look. She read for a moment before she suddenly looked up in surprise.

"You finally figured out who she is!?" she replied, looking back down at the picture of the blonde woman who'd attacked Sert and Tropistar and then tried to attack her in the Valley of the Lost. She read the brief description that was on the file Coalfire had sent while she told her what it said.

"Yep. Her name is Iceson. Spent time around the Hidden Grotto as a mercenary," Coalfire said. "Worked for several heavy hitters such as Orca, Kang the Slow, and Sally. Then she dropped off the radar not too long ago."

"This says she dropped out of sight about the same time as the Dark Moon rumors were really kicking off," Capella said as she sat back. "So it sounds like Dark Moon isn't that old."

"No, it's not," Coalfire said. "I'd guess the Queen formed them when she saw a threat to her power rising. It wouldn't be hard for her. She knows people who've organized and trained both armies and small squads before after all."

Capella went silent as she looked at the picture of the blonde woman and listened to Coalfire's fingers slowly drumming on the table as Capella thought. She knew that Catra had almost destroyed the Princess Alliance multiple times during the war and Adora was a brilliant strategist from what she'd heard and they'd both run small unit operations during the war as well. Putting together something like this would have been easy for them. She wanted to think there was no way, that it was out of character for all of them, but she had the proof of her own eyes to show that it had been formed and she kept thinking that she knew that the Best Friend Squad were loyal to each other. Capella was tired and

was wondering if they'd really do that when she had a thought drift into her head.

It's not a matter of if they would after all since they obviously already did.

"You really can't trust anyone can you?" Capella said as she turned off her data pad with a sigh.

"Well, not quite that bad. I mean you trust us and we trust you, but yeah, never fully commit or people will surprise you in the worst way," Coalfire replied. "I'm having Alice chase down the other members we've seen but I think it'll be the same thing. Mercenaries who've dropped out of sight about the same time. I'd say Iceson there is probably the main leader. She sure acted like it."

Capella nodded, remembering her tone of command back in Wheatland and again when they met on the streets of the Valley of the Lost, as she replied, "I wonder what the main Bright Moon guard thinks of it all."

"Well, if I was looking to split them up, it's definitely something to figure out. The Guard probably isn't very happy about it but they obviously work together. Probably why they went without outside help instead of from the Guard itself at first. Once they see that it's going to happen with or without them, they're more likely to fall into line. Besides, they're loyal to the queen. They'll follow orders," Coalfire said with a little dismissive wave of her hand. "I

would say that answers at least one of your original questions you first hired us for.”

Capella frowned. She felt like she was missing something but she was tired and she ran a hand over her forehead as she said, “True. How old is Dark Moon and who are the members was the question. You got both there. Bonuses all around.”

Coalfire raised an eyebrow at the exhausted tone in Capella’s voice.

“Careful there, you shouldn't give that much away,” Coalfire said and Capella looked up at her as she ran a hand over her bald head. Coalfire had suggested keeping it shaved to make hair illusions easier.

“I know,” Capella said. They’d had many conversations during their training about keeping her emotions in check and out of sight. “It’s been a long day.”

“I know what you mean. No problem. I do appreciate you bringing us here,” Coalfire said.

“Did you finally get in to see Sert?” Capella said, feeling a little bit of energy at the thought of finding out about her friend.

“I did,” Coalfire said. “They’re doing much better but still have problems talking.”

Capella shuddered, knowing why Sert would have issues speaking. The image had been seared into her mind. She hadn’t been into Mermista’s castle to see Sert but when they’d moved to Salineas a week back, Coalfire had started the process to go in and see her and had found out the extent of her cousin’s injuries.

“I still can’t believe it was that bad and she lived,” Capella said softly.

“It was a close thing from what the healers told me and it looks it. Sert is getting control of their arms again but the stab wounds caused a lot of nerve damage that probably won’t ever heal back to what it was. The throat wound is the one that’ll probably fully heal is the wild part considering it was the most potentially lethal of their wounds,” Coalfire said. “Sert knows you brought them in by the way, although they don’t remember it. I didn’t say I was with you but they said they hope you know how grateful they are one day.”

Capella sat back, keeping her face neutral as she tried not to remember that night, holding Sert as she teleported again and again to Salineas and hoping she’d be fast enough. She wished she could go see Sert and tell them how happy she was that Sert made it and how bad she felt for ever putting them in such a position. Instead, she shoved the feelings down and just gave a little head nod at Coalfire.

“Thank you for letting me know.”

There was a knock at the door and they both turned to look at it, Capella’s face suddenly shifting as she dropped an illusion over herself with a little twist of her wrist.

“I’ll get it,” she said in a voice she’d practiced for hours to make sure it was as different from her own as she could make it. She could keep it, and several others, up for hours without shifting out of it and she felt a little odd when she found herself shifting to one of them sometimes without even trying.

When she got to the door, she almost didn’t open it as she looked through the peephole. Standing on the other side was Mermista, looking bored as she waited for someone to answer. Capella turned to Coalfire, gave her a hand sign that meant, “Get ready” and then cracked the door open.

“What?”

“Aren’t you friendly?” Mermista said, looking at the tired face Capella was projecting. “I’m looking for someone who came by my place earlier today. I have something for her.”

“Who?” Capella said as Coalfire quietly moved up behind her and gave a tap on her shoulder to indicate she’d talk with her.

“Maybe she doesn’t want me to say her name, you think of that?” Mermista said with a sigh. Capella just stood in the doorway, feeling her heart thumping, before finally moving to the side as Coalfire took her place.

“Princess Mermista, what can I do for you?” Coalfire said as Capella stepped back a few steps. Mermista watched her for a moment before looking at Coalfire.

“Your cousin wanted me to deliver a message,” Mermista said and Capella could tell she was clearly irritated about having to do it. “They said to tell you, ‘Stars stay in their homes.’”

“What?” Coalfire said, her eyebrow arching up in confusion.

“Hey, I said what they said,” Mermista said as she deftly stepped inside and looked around. Capella desperately tried to look nonchalant as Mermista looked at her again. “Nice knife.”

Capella didn’t trust her voice and just shrugged, unconsciously mimicking a movement she’d seen Mermista do a hundred times before.

“What’d you say your name was?” Mermista said, looking at Capella.

“I didn’t,” Capella shot back.

“You know her cousin?” Mermista replied.

“Why’re you interrogating me?” Capella said, sounding tough even as her heart felt like it was going to burst from how fast it was beating.

“Whoa! Just making conversation,” Mermista replied, holding her hands up.

“Don’t,” Capella said and turned on her heels and left the room. Coalfire came in a few minutes later to find Capella walking around her small room one last time, making sure nothing was missed, with her few bags slung over her shoulder.

“Ah, I see you’re in the same frame of mind as I,” Coalfire responded.

“I can’t believe you gave her the address here,” Capella replied, not with anger, just with a tired resignation.

“I didn’t,” Coalfire said. “I gave it to Sert but I think they’re good friends now.”

Capella leaned back against a chest of drawers as she said, “Lesson learned on that one I guess. Listen, I think we need to go

out to this place by Candila. Let Alice know we're moving and go to the secondary rendezvous here. Let Dio know we need her to book passage out tonight to Plumeria. I'll meet you in two hours, I have something I need to do before we leave town."

"What about Half-Ear?" Coalfire said and Capella could see that she was grinning under her veil by the look of her eyes.

"I guess let him know as well," Capella said.

"Can I ask where you're going?" Coalfire said as Capella put her coat on and shifted her dagger so it was concealed.

"You can ask," Capella said, gave her a nod, and then teleported out.

She appeared in an alley off a street where a kebab cart sat, people waiting in line to get some early dinner. She looked around a little, getting oriented, and then walked out into the street, acting like just another person coming and going all while looking out the corner of her eye to be sure no one was taking notice of her. She passed a tailor shop where a Scorpioni was chatting with someone and then another block down she saw a narrow staircase going up the side of a building and a window with small stained glass ornaments hanging in it and a large potted plant hanging inside.

Capella shifted her bags a little as she walked along, taking special care to be sure she wasn't being followed before finally cutting across the road and walking up the staircase. From inside, she could hear music softly playing and she knocked once and waited. She heard someone walking and then quiet for a moment before the door opened.

"Hello," Clawrene said, looking at her with politeness but no particular recognition. "Can I help you?"

Capella could see past her to her cozy room, dinner on the stove, and she had to peel her eyes back as she reached into her jacket and pulled out a small drawstring bag heavy with coins and held it out to the woman.

"Yes, you can," Capella said in one of her voices. "I've been asked to deliver this to you."

Clawrene looked at the bag with a raised eyebrow but didn't move to take it at first. Finally, she reached out and took it from Capella and carefully opened the bag to see the glint of coins inside.

"That's a lot of money," Clawrene said as she pulled the drawstring closed and made the bag disappear. She looked extra hard at Capella before nodding. "Any particular reason I'm honored with this gift?"

“The person didn’t say,” Capella said. “The only message was thank you… and that she’s still refusing to turn away just because a lie screams like the truth.”

“You’re welcome,” Clawrene said with a nod and set her claw on Capella’s shoulder. “Tell her this wasn’t necessary but thank you, good luck, and to avoid juice stains. We’re all proud of her around here.”

Capella felt her cheeks flush hot as she stammered for a moment.

“Um… if I… you know... see the person again, I will,” Capella said.

Capella sagged a little as Clawrene patted her shoulder again before Capella nodded and walked away, fighting the urge to go back and go into the apartment to spend a quiet evening with Clawrene again, telling her what had been going on. She knew she couldn’t though. Clawrene’s home had been a cocoon that she had pulled her way out of and couldn’t return to anymore.

Maybe one day, a little voice said inside, a voice Capella thought of as treacherous since she felt that it tried to distract her. She took a deep breath as she walked to push the thought out as she turned down an alley, gave a quick look around, and then teleported close to the docks.

Capella walked through the crowd of sailors, some coming ashore, some getting ready to go back out, and felt comfort as just another mote of humanity carrying some bags in the crowd. She walked up a broad ramp to the second floor of a low building overlooking the docks and let herself in with the combination to the door. The room was old office space with a balcony overlooking the dock area and she realized she was the first person there as she sat her bags down, making sure she threaded her satchel's shoulder strap through all the rest of them so she could grab them all at a run if needed, and stretched as she made a circuit around the room checking the closets and bathroom to be sure no one was hiding. When she felt it was secure, she settled down into a chair behind a desk at the back and propped her feet up as she pulled up her data pad.

A few messages were waiting from Gress and Capella started answering them. She felt bad for him, still hiding under Dryl, but after their long talk she felt happy that she had him back in her life. She hadn't realized just how much she missed her friend and while the messages were mostly about things she'd asked him to research and there was one message that they had kept going as they played chess through notation and chatted. She had asked him to check up on the towns by Candila and sent him what Sert had sent to them when about stars staying in their homes, hoping he might have some clue, and now she was thinking through the latest chess move he'd sent when she saw a message come through marked as urgent.

She opened it up to see, "Izzy attacked some guy with a knife and broke another guy's leg at the latest Princess Council!" She sat up in her chair and typed out a response and waited for a return message. She wished they could use a chat feature or talk over the video but they'd decided that it was more secure through text.

Start of Message Chain

Capella: What do you mean she attacked some guy!? What's going on!?

Gress: A man named Aeron petitioned to be recognized as the princess of Candila. I guess he and Izzy have some kind of history from what I'm hearing and she attacked him without warning. His husband stepped in and she stunned him then broke his knee!

Capella: I can't believe Izzy would do that! She's so quiet! I think I remember hearing about this guy back when Izzy first became princess but I was just a kid, I don't really remember much. Why do you think she would do that?

Gress: I don't know. She's being held in Bright Moon right now until they can figure out what to do. I'm looking into this Aeron guy though. He's from Candila and we keep running into that with the Children thing.

Capella: Maybe that's why Izzy attacked him. Maybe he's some dupe for someone out in Candila and she was trying to get him and have his handler come forward.

Gress: OK, I looked him up. I guess he tried to attack Izzy back when she first claimed the title of Dryl. He was one of the people

who went after Entrapta's Prize and was well known on data boards as some kind of maker along with his husband, Carl. They both went off to rehabilitation in the Crimson Waste and finished that not too long ago. Cappe, I think we need to check him out.

Capella: OK, I gotta go but see what you can put together. I gotta get my crew ready. Stay safe.

Gress: I'll have something ready for you in a few hours I think. Stay safe.

End of Message Chain

Capella tucked her data pad away and looked up at Alice who had entered the room while she was shooting messages back and forth with Gress.

"You looked busy," Alice said with a smile.

"Did you hear about what happened with the Princess of Dryl?" Capella said, using Izzy's title. She'd stopped referring to the princesses by name as Coalfire said it was a bit of a giveaway of who she was since it sounded so familiar.

Alice nodded as she said, "You mean trying to carve a guy up in the middle of a Princess Council meeting? Yeah, I heard."

“I think he might be part of what we’re looking into,” Capella replied.

“Because of the Candila thing I’m guessing?” Alice said as she pulled up her data pad and started tapping away on it.

“That’s the idea,” Capella said. “That’s where I think we need to go next. Well, I think that’s where I need to go next. We’re already headed to Plumeria. The rest of you can find a place there somewhere and wait for me to get back.”

Alice looked up from the data pad as she replied, “I’m sorry, did you just say you want to go out there by yourself?”

“What? I go do stuff all the time by myself,” Capella said.

“Well, yeah, but this sounds like it might be a bit more intense,” Alice said. “I mean all these people we’re investigating call it home and are talking about it being the dream in uppercase letters. I think you don’t want to go poking around there by yourself.”

“May I remind you that I can teleport out if things go wrong?” Capella said. Alice looked down at her arm and Capella sighed. “Really? That wasn’t going wrong. That was just a hitch.”

“A hitch that I had to patch up with Dio,” Alice said. “You still owe me for the shirt you bled all over.”

“We got what we needed to know from the guy didn’t we?” Capella said.

Alice tilted her head forward a little and looked at Capella with a raised eyebrow.

“After you dropped the guy from a thousand feet up,” Alice said.

Capella flushed hot as she looked away, ashamed at what she’d done in a flash of anger when she’d been sliced open. She cleared her throat and shoved the shame down as she put on a casual look and said, “I’ve told you I wasn’t going to actually let him drop all the way. He was more than willing to talk afterwards.”

Alice looked at her with the same look and just shook her head before going on.

“Listen, we’ve agreed we’re following your lead here with input from us so if you want to do that, it’s my job to offer input,” Alice said. “Don’t do it. Let one of us go in instead.”

Capella sat back as she shook her head.

“No, I think I need to do this. I can go in under cover, act like I’m exploring the area or something,” Capella replied.

“Listen, this is a really bad idea,” Alice said as Dio walked into the room and dropped her bag with a thud.

“What’s a bad idea?” Dio said as she dropped into a chair.

“Cappe wants to go to the towns around Candila,” Alice said. Dio looked between the two with a look of mild bewilderment before shrugging.

“Isn’t that some mountain out in the middle of nowhere? What’s the point?” Dio asked.

“It’s the place we keep hearing people talk about that the Children of Mara and those like them are going to! Don’t you listen when we do briefs!?” Alice said.

“No,” Dio said as she scratched at her cheek. “I don’t care. I get a paycheck, I drive and pilot a variety of interesting vehicles, and occasionally I get to throw a punch. That satisfies me.”

Alice buried her face in her hand as she said, “Really?”

“I have never been shy about this,” Dio said with a grin before looking at Capella. “I say that you go for it. You’ve done stupider things. I got to patch you up after one of them.”

“OK, enough about that, I won’t get that close again without searching them better,” Capella said with a roll of her eyes.

“Anyway, I gotta ask, did you all hear that the Princess of Dryl tried to filet some guy!?” Dio said with a huge grin.

“That’s actually why we were talking about Candila,” Capella replied. “He’s from there.”

Dio raised a hand at Alice as she said, “See!? It’s like destiny or something!”

“It’s us sitting around in Plumeria while she goes in there with no kind of backup,” Alice said.

“I can’t wait,” Dio said, sitting up with a huge grin on her face and Alice sighed.

“How could I forget the combination of you and Plumeria?” Alice replied with a long-suffering sigh.

“What about Plumeria?” Capella said.

“They have the best parties to meet people,” Dio said with an eyebrow waggle.

“We’ll be working,” Alice said.

“Not for the whole time,” Dio said, turning the eyebrow waggle on Alice. Alice cracked a grin as she shook her head.

Shortly afterwards, Half-Ear and Coalfire showed up. Capella filled them in, had the expected back and forth, and then they all grabbed their things and started out after she took a moment to use her stage makeup to hide the scar.

“I’ve booked us passage on a boat,” Dio said. “It’ll take us into Bright Moon and then I’ve got us a private skiff up into Plumeria.”

Capella, behind her illusion, said, “Bright Moon? Really?”

“We were bound to have to go through eventually,” Coalfire said. “Just keep calm.”

“What’s the name of the ship?” Half-Ear said, walking as far from Capella as he could.

“The Chitinous Oak,” Dio said and then nodded as they walked down the docks towards a two masted ship. “It’s right there.”

Capella almost tripped over her own feet when she looked up and saw Oak and Chitin standing at the railing waving at Dio. She stopped for a moment as if to hitch up her bags and Coalfire fell in beside her as the rest kept walking.

“What’s wrong?” Coalfire said quietly.

Capella started walking again, knowing that just standing on the dock would look suspicious, and as she fought to keep her face neutral said, “The one on the left is the child of Princess Perfuma and Princess Scorpia. She’s known me since I was born.”

Coalfire nodded sagely as if Capella had said something deeply important as she replied, “Stick to your cabin. Pretend you have seasickness.”

“I’m certainly feeling sick,” Capella said and was very happy that she had her dagger hidden at the moment. She made a note to change the grip or something so it wasn’t so distinct.

“Welcome aboard The Chitinous Oak! I’m Oak and this is my partner Chitin. You’re the last ones on board and we’ll be setting

off as soon as we can," Oak shouted cheerfully as they made their way up the gangplank.

"I'm Kai-Es," Coalfire said.

Capella in her imitation voice said, "I'm Ptarmigan."

"Ptarmigan? Are you from the Kingdom of Snows?" Chitin said casually.

"No," Capella said and when she realized she was being too abrupt went on. "One of my parents grew up there but moved to Erelandia before I was born."

"Lots of that around," Chitin replied. "If you want, go ahead and get your stuff stowed. You're aft by our quarters. If you want to watch us leave the harbor, just stay off the bridge, please."

"That's where the wheel is," Oak said with a grin.

"Thank you," Coalfire said. "We'll go ahead and get settled now."

Oak and Chitin gave them a nod as they walked on their way and Capella managed to keep in a sigh of relief as they made their

way to the cabins. One of the crew pointed it out and Capella entered the cramped room with a single bunk and shut the door.

OK, I can do this. It can't get any… no don't even complete that in your head, Capella thought.

A day out of harbor, it got worse. Capella had managed to stay down in her cabin, reading on her data pad when she heard a flurry of activity. She looked up at the deck over her head wondering what it was when she heard Cowrie's voice sound out.

"Permission to come aboard!"

"No, no, no, no," Capella whispered as she wondered if she should teleport out right away or wait and see as she heard Oak respond back with permission.

Mermista must have recognized me and they're hoping having me in the middle of the ocean is the best way to keep me in place, Capella thought as she threw the few things she had unpacked into her bags, threw on an illusion, and got ready to run. She listened, heart pounding, waiting for the knock on the door. After twenty minutes had passed, she realized that nothing was happening except for an increase in cheerful shouting between the two crews. She jumped and almost ripped her dagger out of its sheath hidden on her back when she heard a knock at the door. Then she relaxed a little when she heard Coalfire's voice.

“Hey, Ptarmigan, you want to come out? Bit of a party going on,” Coalfire said. Capella stepped to the door and cracked it, peaking out for a moment.

“I… um, not feeling real well,” she said. Coalfire gave a little thumbs up to indicate it was alright as she responded.

“No problem. I’ll let everyone know,” Coalfire said and gave a little wink. Before she could turn away, Capella suddenly realized she couldn’t just sit there or risk looking weird and drawing attention.

“No, wait,” Capella said and looked at her stuff sitting on the bunk before sighing. “I think I’m feeling better.”

“You sure?” Coalfire said.

“Yes,” Capella said with a nod and adjusted her coat as she took deep breaths to calm herself. She looked in the small mirror to make sure the face she had on was the face that she’d said was Ptarmigan and then opened the door and stepped out.

“You sure you’re feeling OK to get out?” Coalfire said.

“I need to or it’ll look weird,” Capella said quietly and then responded. “Maybe getting some fresh air will help.”

They both walked out onto the deck into a bunch of crew members laughing and talking. She knew that a lot of them had once served on Cowrie's crew, including Chitin, and when Oak and Chitin had got their own ship a decent amount had gone with them. What she wasn't expecting though was to see crew tossing sea bags back and forth between ships as some went from one to another.

Dio walked up, a mug in hand, with a grin as she said, "We really have to party with these crews if we're ever in a port at the same time. I've heard a few stories in the short time since they boarded to know they really know how to cut loose."

Capella kept her face neutral as she said, "Sure, we have to do that at some point."

Dio elbowed her as she winked and said, "Maybe you could loosen up."

"No," Capella responded. She noticed Half-Ear sitting by himself up at the bow of the ship, watching everyone with an appraising eye. "What's he doing?"

"Being almost as big a party-pooper as you," Dio said before taking a big drink. "He just grunts any time someone tries to go up to him."

Capella took her eyes off of him and gave a brief glance up to the bridge where Cowrie, Chitin, and Oak were leaning back against the railing laughing and chatting. She felt a deep pain of loneliness as she thought about all the times she'd talked with them at parties and gatherings over the years and thought about going up there and saying hello for a split second.

You're not Cappe, you're Ptarmigan, and if you were Cappe to them, it wouldn't be a lively meeting in the middle of the ocean, it'd be running and screaming as they tried to catch you for the Queen. You're not a part of their world anymore, she reminded herself. She grabbed the mug away from Dio and took a long drink off of it, expecting to feel the burn of alcohol and being surprised that it was just water.

"Hey, if you're thirsty, they got mugs back there," Dio said as she took the mug back from her.

"Sorry, feeling a bit seasick," Capella responded.

"You need to go back to your bunk?" Coalfire said. Capella was about to respond when Oak approached the railing and gave a loud shout for attention. Everyone went quiet as they turned to look at her.

"Alright, I have to say that I'm sure you all remember Izzy! You all know what she did in The Arsonist Mermaid so long ago and we've all heard what she did at the Princess Council the other day! She's brave, loyal, and smart! I don't know her reason for the attack but I trust her with my life and so I support her! So out

here where there are no kingdoms but the ones we make with each other on these decks we say to Izzy!" Oak shouted out with a mug held high.

"To Izzy!" everyone on board shouted out with cheers and laughter as they took a drink. Capella shouted it out as well, feeling uncomfortable, not realizing just how uncomfortable she was about to be. As the cheers and whoops settled down, Cowrie jumped up on the railing of the bridge and stood, slowly rocking with the boat and showing no signs of falling, as she looked down at everyone. She removed her broad brimmed hat and held it in front of her.

"Now as Oak said, we are in no kingdom but the one we've made on these decks and answer to no one but our fellow crew members. With that, I want to have a moment to honor Capella, our Queen of Shadows and Smoke," Cowrie said as Capella watched in surprise as the crew removed their hats. "We miss her, we wish we knew why she won't come forward, but we know that she's fighting a fight for those who can't and so we honor her. To our queen."

Capella managed to keep her mouth shut but her eyes were wide as she watched the crew wait in silence for a short moment before Cowrie drew her saber, held it high, and shouted out, "To Queen Cappe!"

The assembled crews on both ships shouted back, "To Queen Cappe!"

Capella almost dropped her illusion then and there except Coalfire gently touched her arm and gave a minimal shake of her eyes to indicate that she didn't trust the situation. After the cheer, the group started mingling again and Capella did her best not to stare up at the three on the bridge. She watched as a few people went below deck and made her excuses to retreat quickly to her cabin. Once inside, she shut the door and latched it and leaned against it, trying to still her thumping heart. Her hands were shaking and tears were streaking her face when she heard a quiet knock on the door. Making sure her illusion was still in place, she unlatched it and cracked it open to see Coalfire standing there.

"May I come in?" she said. Capella nodded as she shoved her feelings down and sat back on the bunk, the most comfortable way to get more than one person into the room. Coalfire held up her finger and made an intricate gesture and Capella heard the noise of the ship deaden a little.

"You think that was a ploy?" Capella whispered as she leaned forward.

Coalfire nodded as she replied, "Possibly. I think Mermista may have spotted you and put out word to the captains she knows, and she knows a lot, to try and get you to reveal yourself."

Capella nodded, fighting the feeling that it didn't feel like a ploy, as she said, "That's what I thought as well. Caught me off guard though."

“I know,” Coalfire said. “Me as well. It was that Queen of Shadows and Smoke thing that tipped me off. Seemed too trite.”

Capella gave a half-hearted chuckle as she said, “I know, right?”

“Keep an eye open, we still have a little ways to go,” Coalfire replied. “I’ll come by later, help you train some more with your illusions.”

“Thanks,” Capella said. “I really do appreciate what you do for me.”

“Gotta protect the paycheck,” Coalfire said with a chuckle and Capella gave a fake grin back to her. Coalfire left shortly thereafter and Capella sat on her bunk with her arms around her legs, listening to the crews laughing and talking, forcing down the feeling of loneliness she felt. She kept thinking about the moment of quiet and the crowd shouting out her name as queen and she couldn’t help but think it didn’t feel like a ploy, that it had felt genuine. She fell asleep with her illusion still on, the boat rocking her to sleep as the illusion slowly disappeared as she drifted off, her face under it tired and sad as her breathing slowed into deep sleep.

Later, after they made dock in Bright Moon, neither Oak or Chitin said anything to them beyond wishing them well as they disembarked. They walked up a small hill to where a skiff waited and Capella looked at the castle for a long moment before getting on board the skiff. As Dio flew them away, headed for Plumeria, Capella wanted to turn and look some more and see if it matched

her memory. In the end she didn’t because she knew it would rot at her resolve. Instead she looked towards the horizon as they flew on as she thought of Cowrie, Oak, and Chitin and a little thought ran around in her head.

Maybe, just maybe, there are more people I can trust.

Chapter End Notes

When I first started thinking about where this was going, and realized people were going to hail Cappe as their "queen" I knew I needed a name they would call her. It was about that time I heard something about a shadow cabinet in government again. For those that don't know, a shadow cabinet is the coolest name for a government group that has the most boring explanation. To borrow an explanation from Wikipedia: "It consists of a senior group of opposition spokespeople who, under the leadership of the Leader of the Opposition, form an alternative cabinet to that of the government, and whose members shadow or mirror the positions of each individual member of the Cabinet. It is the shadow cabinet's responsibility to scrutinize the policies and actions of the government, as well as to offer alternative policies."

So yeah, I decided right then and there that Cappe was going to be hailed as the Queen of Shadows and Smoke.

Aeron

Chapter Summary

Aeron reacts and plans after being attacked by Izzy.

Chapter Notes

"Oh, but you must travel through those woods again and again... said a shadow at the window... and you must be lucky to avoid the wolf every time... But the wolf... the wolf only needs enough luck to find you once." — Emily Carroll, Through the Woods

Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Aeron sat beside a bed in Bright Moon the following day of the attack, carefully running his thumb over the top of Carl's hand. Carl was still under observation by the healers as Izzy's stun baton had caused an irregular heartbeat for a moment and the healers wanted to keep an eye on it. They'd said it was probably congenital and shouldn't be a problem as long as he didn't get shocked again.

"People think those stun batons are 'harmless' you know. Just a buzz and a person goes down for a little while but they still have that risk," the healer had said when she'd filled Aeron in on what Carl's status had been. Aeron had managed to keep his anger in check and thanked the healer warmly for her and her team's help.

Now, Aeron sat with Carl as he drifted in and out of sleep from the painkillers they'd given him after the reconstruction of his

knee. Carl stirred a little from under the haze and looked up at Aeron with a tired smile.

"You can go and get some sleep," Carl said, his voice a little slurred but strong.

"And give Her a chance to get at you with a bot?" Aeron said, leaning down to kiss Carl's forehead. "No. The chair isn't uncomfortable. Much better than our slab back home."

"Home," Carl said with a little sigh as he leaned back in the bed. "At the very least get someone from our entourage to come and watch while you rest. We trust them with enough. You can trust them to sit with me while I'm drifting in and out."

"OK, I'll get Entary. He's at the door," Aeron said, referring to a new person they'd brought into the inner circle in just the last few weeks.

"Well get him in here and get someone else for the door and you go lay down," Carl said. Aeron started to argue and Carl lifted his hand up off the bed and laid a finger on his lips. "Yes. We have a lot of work to do. You need to be rested and I can't rest knowing you're not taking care of yourself."

Aeron's eyes softened as he looked at him.

“OK. I love you.”

“I love you too. Now stop stalling,” Carl said with a little nod at the door. Aeron nodded as went to the door and stuck his head out for a moment before coming back in with Entary at his heels. Entary was the name they knew him by at least. If Izzy had seen him though, she’d not have to wonder anymore where Snow-by had gone.

“OK, you stay here in the room and keep an eye on him,” Aeron said. “He needs sleep. If any bots or the like come in, destroy them. Keep an eye on the healers as well although I don’t think they’d do anything.”

“Doesn’t hurt to be careful though,” Snow-by said with a nod.

“No, it doesn’t,” Aeron said, clapping his hand on his shoulder. “I’ll be back in a few hours.”

“Full sleep,” Carl said sleepily from the bed.

“I’m going to put something into play first,” Aeron said with a smile as he kneeled down beside Carl and took his hand.

Carl pointed a finger at him from the hand Aeron was holding as he said with a little smile, “It better not take long.”

"Just a call," Aeron said. "Don't think it'll even be a long one."

"OK," Carl said as he closed his eyes with a sigh as Aeron kissed Carl's knuckles and then sat the hand back down.

"Don't let me down," Aeron said to Snow-by.

"I won't. Mara was right," Snow-by said back.

"Mara was right," Aeron said, clapping him on the shoulder again before walking out.

Aeron went one door down to the room he'd been assigned. It wasn't a large room and he had a feeling that he was being subtly snubbed in some way but it still had plenty of amenities. He noticed the Bright Moon guards at either end of the side corridor the rooms were on and he knew they were there to spy on him although the official reason when he'd asked about it was security. Several of his people sat in the hall, watching the guards mostly, and he waved at them as he went into the room.

Once in with the door shut, he checked the little tell-tales he'd left around the room to see if anyone had been inside. He found that several had been disturbed but it had only been in the bathroom and he assumed some kind of cleaning staff had been in. The locked cases that the electronics were in sat undisturbed.

Aeron opened up one of the cases and ran a program on the system inside. He waited as it checked for broadcast devices or nearby bots and when it came back a minute later as clear he nodded his head. Then he picked up another case, opened it, and ran a similar test. When it showed as clear he looked around before finally pulling his data pad out and starting it up. The usual messages waited for him from various people and he made a note of those that shouldn't be bothering him but did and those that probably should be checking in but hadn't before moving on to actually reading what he considered important. The first one he read was from Iceson.

Target has left Salineas. Picked up her signal from somewhere inside Plumeria. Am relocating. MWR

Aeron sat back and thought for a moment. Iceson had been tracking Capella since she'd first tried to pick her up in Wheatland, stopping only for occasional side jobs with her team. Something had happened out in the Crimson Waste that she didn't really talk about. Aeron knew her team had got into a dust up and seen Capella and ever since then, Iceson had been even colder than her name suggested. Aeron figured she was angry about being beat but he didn't hold that against her.

If anything, he liked it. Aeron figured the extra little edge from making it personal would help her get done what needed to be done. He saw a message drop into the queue on his data pad for handling the various complaints that were being sent out to the various boards. The heading said something about princess overreach in some town he didn't even know and he had an idea that made him grin. He hit reply on her message.

Proceed as planned but do not approach target for any reason. Continue to track and monitor only. Notify the Squad to begin to move on their target. Instructions to follow. MWR

Aeron thought for a moment longer and then hit send on the message. Then he pulled up Tandini, wondering if he should make a call instead. He always felt better when he could speak to someone face-to-face or at least screen-to-screen but text was more secure. Besides, he had a call to make later and it'd be best if he only had one going out. As he typed he thought about how Carl was better at text than he was and he felt a pang thinking about Carl laid up in bed with the pang sharpened with anger towards Izzy.

Well, that'll be taken care of very soon, Aeron thought as he started typing out a message to Tandini. He grinned as he thought of the ex-mayor. He'd turned out to be much more adept at getting people lined up for their network and keeping them in line than he had ever been at being a mayor. From the outside, he seemed to run a quiet business, keeping out of the public eye, all the while he was running multiple agents of Aeron's network. He'd even been the one to recommend Entary as help and Aeron had to admit, Entary was turning out to be helpful. Aeron was thinking of that as he typed and reminded himself he needed to reward Tandini in some way.

T,

Start the second pressure campaign we discussed immediately.

MWR,

A

Aeron hit send. There were already complaints about princess overreach but Tandini had set up a campaign that would not just be official complaints but public opinion work as well. Talks of the princesses doing too much, talks of the princesses doing too little, and of course talk of princesses stepping over the line one too many times, with the attack on Aeron and Carl being a prime example as well as all the rumors that swirled around Princess Capella. She'd been both a thorn in his side with her pursuit of the Children of Mara group but also a minor blessing in how it allowed him to use her activities, and of course blaming completely made up activities on her, in his propaganda.

Aeron closed the data pad after answering some more messages and started to set it on the table next to him before suddenly stopping himself and shaking his head like he couldn't believe he'd almost done something so stupid. Then he set it on one of the cases they'd brought with them. He sat back in the chair and took a deep breath, filling his chest with air, before slowly letting it out as he began to clear his mind. He'd known about mediation and occasionally used it but he'd really leaned into it in rehabilitation and found that he felt much better and clearer if he did it every day.

Now though, he couldn't get himself to relax. He kept hearing the noise of Carl's knee as Izzy stamped on it, he kept seeing the sharp edge of her dagger as she thrust it for his throat, and he couldn't get over the feeling of the edge dragging across his armor, knowing that less than half an inch of material had saved

him. The whole thing had caught him by surprise and he couldn't believe he'd fallen for her little ruse but he'd been so caught up in the little back and forth of the Council that he had thought for a moment she was going to try and play out some kind of bureaucratic game. He knew he'd remember the thump of the dagger impacting the armor over his heart until the day he died.

Finally, after ten minutes of not being able to let go and mediate, he sat up and grabbed another data pad out of one of the cases. He felt cranky as he knew this next part would have to be a call and not one he wanted to make feeling out of sorts. Carl had prepped the way only a few days before, since they figured they'd make the move anyway, and now that it was there, Aeron couldn't figure out why he felt hesitant about it.

It's because Carl isn't here for this, he suddenly thought to himself. *He should see this.*

He sighed, got into a closet, turned on a few devices to make sure he wasn't being heard, and made the call. The call was answered almost immediately.

"Seraph, thank Mara you're calling," Bryce said. "I have had the worst day and I could use a kind ear."

"Really? What's going on?" Aeron said as he sat down on a small built-in bench in the closet.

“I got these papers delivered to my house yesterday,” Bryce said, holding up an envelope. “It says… well, it doesn’t matter what it says, it’s not true! I’ve been holed up here in my house ever since, even called in sick, trying to figure this out!”

Aeron cocked his head sideways a little as if confused, knowing full well what the papers said, as he replied, “Well, what does it say? Can’t be that bad.”

Bryce leaned into the camera as he said quietly and urgently, “It says I’ve been skimming money at the water works and selling off supplies! Some of them listed are important, replacement parts for critical systems! Do you know what kind of trouble I could get into if this got out!?”

Aeron nodded as he said, “I can imagine. You’re not, are you?”

“No! I would never do something like that! Well, that one time you needed that money but that was nothing! I covered it out of my own pocket a week later when I got paid! Besides, it’s one thing to pad an invoice but to mess with safety like that!? We pull superheated steam up for some of these works! That’d kill if something went wrong!” Bryce responded.

“Hey, take a breath, buddy,” Aeron said, Bryce not picking up the predatory tone that Aeron said the word buddy in. “What else was in there? What else did it say?”

“Just that someone would be getting in contact with me soon to discuss it,” Bryce said, taking a deep breath.

“Have they?” Aeron said, enjoying the barely controlled panic on Bryce’s face.

“Have they what?” Bryce said.

“Contacted you,” Aeron said.

Bryce shook his head as he said, “No! That’s what’s freaking me out!”

“You sure they haven’t?” Aeron said, fighting to keep the smile off his face.

“Yes! I’m sure!” Bryce said and then watched as Aeron finally let a cold smile slip over his face. “Why are you smiling like that?”

Aeron enjoyed the moment of dawning horror on Bryce’s face as he said, “Well, you know, just happy to help out in your moment of need.”

“Did you send this!?” Bryce said, trying to sound indignant. “What kind of joke is that!?”

“Yes, I did and who said it was a joke?” Aeron said, leaning in, his voice almost a purr. “Don’t worry though. Your little indiscretion will just be between you and I if you listen to what I have to say.”

“I didn’t do this!” Bryce shouted, waving the papers at the camera.

“Yell at me again and find out what happens,” Aeron said, his tone going flat and his face going still except for his eyes. His eyes though, they held a promise of horrors. Bryce went pale as he froze and Aeron went on. “Now, I have something I need you to do.”

Bryce started to shake his head slowly and Aeron gave him the cold smile again.

“Before you refuse, know that I am more than willing to make what is in those papers public and more like them. The money, meh, people won’t care as much about that I think but the needless endangerment of lives by selling off replacements for key protection systems? I think people will care about that. I’ll make *sure* people care about that,” Aeron said, trying not to laugh at Bryce as his camera started to shake. “You’ve already had a little brush with the princesses. You think it’ll be easier this time or harder? Maybe they won’t even bother with rehabilitation this time. Maybe you’ll just have, shall we say, a little accident. You live in the Kingdom of Snows. It’s winter. Lots of accidents happen. I promise you, the princesses make it happen all the time. You know who else does? I do. One of us will get you if you refuse me.”

Bryce was shaking so hard now that Aeron could barely see him.

"Why are you doing this?" Bryce said as he sat the data pad down on a table and hugged himself tight. "I thought we were friends."

"You're not my friend," Aeron said. "You're a tool and you better be a good tool or you'll get broken and thrown away. Are you ready to hear what I need my little tool to do?"

Aeron watched as tears began to run down Bryce's face and knew he was broken, that he was ready to hear what Aeron needed. The rush of that knowledge brought a warm smile to his face as he watched Bryce slowly nod.

"Good, now listen closely," Aeron replied and then told him exactly what he was to do. Bryce listened, not sure he had heard correctly. Aeron knew that it didn't sound bad but that was fine. He meant for it not to sound bad.

"That's… that's it?" Bryce said.

"That's it. Someone will come by soon to give you what you'll need. Do this one thing and all of that," Aeron said, gesturing at the papers that Bryce had tossed on the table, "will go away. You won't have to worry about it again."

Aeron didn't mention that it was because he would have Bryce in a much tighter corner then but if Bryce didn't see that, Aeron saw no reason to bring it up. Bryce looked down, wiping his eyes as he fought to get some kind of dignity and nodded.

"Fine, I'll do it," Bryce whispered.

"I'm sorry, I didn't hear you," Aeron said. "Speak up."

Bryce looked up, a little bit of anger peeking through as he said, "I said I'll do it."

"There you go," Aeron said. "Show a little spine. A tool is only as useful as its strength and there's no shame in being a tool. They're necessary and do amazing work and you'll understand one day just how useful you've been. Just remember though, you're replaceable and when a tool breaks… it hurts. Understood?"

"Yes," Bryce said, the anger gone from his voice as he sounded lost and helpless.

"Good. Someone will be in touch," Aeron said and cut the call. He leaned back, feeling the rush of the call and taking a moment to relish in the triumph over Bryce's will. He thought of Izzy and grinned bigger as he began to stand up in the closet.

I told her I'd make her regret it if she didn't kill me and she's failed to do so twice now, Aeron thought. *Time for her to really start regretting it.*

As he walked around the room, he picked up a small screwdriver, cracked the data pad's case open, and dropped the whole thing into a pitcher of water. Later he'd take out its internal memory and melt it with a blowtorch. As he got ready to pick up his own data pad, he heard a knock at the door and froze for a moment. His eyes shot around, making sure the various scramblers and such were on, before he went to the door and looked out the peephole. Glimmer stood there, her back straight and her face serious. He took a little comfort that she didn't seem to have brought any additional guards along. Before he answered the door though, he took his shirt off and threw it across the room.

"Hello?" Aeron said as he cracked the door open.

"Do you have a moment to speak with me?" Glimmer said, her voice formal and tight.

"Yes, I do. Give me a moment. I need to put a shirt on and we can walk and talk," Aeron said.

"Very well," Glimmer replied. Aeron shut the door and moved around the room, shutting things down and closing up cases, making sure the tell-tales were put back in place. Finally he put on his shirt and grabbed his data pad and went back to the door. He expected Glimmer to say something but the queen just looked at him as he shut the door.

“Shall we?” Glimmer replied and held her arm out as she began to walk. Aeron walked along beside her in silence for a minute, wondering what this was about but not willing to break the silence. They turned and went out a door into a beautiful garden, the evergreen bushes giving some green color to the brown winter grass. Glimmer stopped in the middle of the lawn and looked up at the mountain soaring overhead. Aeron looked up as well, glancing left and right as he tried to figure out what was going on.

“First, I must ask for you to please turn down whatever electronic counter-measures are being used in your rooms,” Glimmer suddenly said, not taking her eyes off the peak.

Aeron, startled that she’d just come out and say something like that turned and said, “I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

Glimmer took her eyes off the peak and looked up at Aeron and he felt a chill in his blood at her look.

“I am not a fool so don’t treat me as such,” Glimmer said. “If you wish to protect your communications, I understand, but you have your rigs turned up so high that you’re interfering with our own communications. I’m asking you politely because I’m giving you the benefit of the doubt that it’s unintentional.”

Aeron looked down into her eyes, hard as rock, and remembered the stories he’d heard of her wiping out whole Horde platoons by

herself.

And that was as a teenager, he thought as he made a decision.

"Certainly, Your Majesty. I apologize. I did not take you for a fool but am simply used to being protective of my capabilities in this area. Seeing that I apparently have an enemy who is one of the most technologically sophisticated people on the planet, I think you can understand why I am this way," Aeron said. "I'll instruct my techs to turn them down. Please let me know if there is any additional problem."

Glimmer looked at him and didn't say anything else but started walking again. Aeron watched her take a few steps and suddenly realized she must expect him to follow along. His anger spiked a little at being treated like a subordinate but he caught up and walked along.

"Speaking of enemies…," Aeron started to say and Glimmer cut him off.

"We're holding Princess Izzy here at Bright Moon as we work to get the Council back in session," Glimmer replied. "When that happens, we'll also debate your status after we debate hers."

"I expect her to be turned over to me for rehabilitation," Aeron said. There was no reaction as they continued to walk.

What is her game? Aeron thought as they came to a stop at a railing overlooking a small field below. They stood and looked again before Glimmer spoke again.

"Princess Izzy will not be turned over to you," Glimmer said. "If the Council decides her actions require her to enter rehabilitation, she will do it here in Bright Moon, where she committed her actions."

Aeron looked at Glimmer's face in surprise before anger took over.

"Absolutely not!" Aeron said. "I know the Charter! She attacked a princess and so she must go to the princess' kingdom to serve her rehabilitation! Don't you try and protect her by putting her here! I'll take this up to the High Council of Etheria for judgment if I must!"

Aeron was shocked to see Glimmer nodding along like she agreed with him.

"You are absolutely correct," Glimmer said. "If a princess attacks another princess, if the Council finds that it was not justified, then that princess does go to the other's kingdom for rehabilitation if the wronged princess wishes it so."

“And I do!” Aeron said hotly.

“Ah, I see your confusion,” Glimmer said and Aeron wanted to smack her with the tone she was using but he knew that to do so would be the very definition of a poorly thought out idea. “You keep calling yourself a princess. You’re not. Not until the Council confirms you as one. The King and I have reviewed your documents and I have every belief you will be confirmed.”

“Then why would she not go with me!?” Aeron said, stepping forward towards her. Glimmer looked down at his feet and then up to his face and Aeron had a distinct feeling of being measured for a coffin and probably not a very large one either judging by the look she gave him. He stepped back and Glimmer went on.

“Because the Council will judge her case first,” Glimmer said. “When it is done, you will still just be a regular citizen of Etheria and thus, she goes to Bright Moon. Only after we do that will we look at your claim to the title of Candila and whether or not you will be a princess.”

Aeron stared at her in surprise as he realized what she’d done before he suddenly spit out, “That’s just procedural nonsense! Put my petition first! It should be first anyway as it happened before the attack!”

Glimmer gave a tight smile as she said, “You’ve read the Etherian Charter so you should know, it is all about procedure. The procedure for the Princess Council is that the Queen decides the agenda and what goes on it unless I delegate that duty. Of

course, I’m expected to hold some things more important than others, to keep me from padding out the agenda with nonsense and keeping real work from being done. So I’m clear there as well because an Etherian citizen claiming they were subjected to violence by a princess without cause takes it straight to the top of the agenda, even over a person claiming princess status. Even if it didn’t, even if we heard your case first, you weren’t a princess when she attacked you so it still wouldn’t matter.”

“How dare you deny me justice!” Aeron said.

“Deny? She’ll be tried, just like you want. However, I feel you mean vengeance instead of justice since the only thing that will be different is where she might serve her rehabilitation. So yes, I deny you that because it’s not about vengeance, as you should know,” Glimmer said, stepping forward. Aeron surprised himself by stepping back an equal distance and forced himself not to take another step back.

“I do not accept this,” Aeron said. “I can still take this before the High Council!”

“Yes, you can,” Glimmer said with a shrug. “That’s your decision to make. We should be getting back into session in a few days. You’ll be notified appropriately when you’re needed. I hope your husband, Carl, is doing well.”

“He’s doing fine,” Aeron said through gritted teeth at her nonchalance.

“That’s good to hear,” Glimmer replied. “Thank you for your time.”

Aeron watched as she disappeared in a burst of sparkles. He had a brief daydream walking back to his room about telling Glimmer, after she was defeated, about defeating her daughter and killing her. That is if he ever caught up with her but he was sure she couldn’t run forever, not with them tracking her. Then he shook his head to clear the daydream.

She’s right. It’s not about vengeance. It’s about justice, Aeron thought. *And every single one of them will face the justice they deny to real Etherians.*

Aeron walked back into his room and had a brief moment of checking the tell-tales but nothing had been touched. He considered for a brief moment turning up all the electronic counter-measures even higher, out of spite, but knew he had to tread carefully. His foes were strong and dangerous and he needed to move carefully to knock them down.

As he picked up his data pad, he looked at a message from someone he had working at Mystacor. He was a little surprised to see it. He rarely needed anything done there and the person who was there wasn’t very important and so she rarely sent anything to him but he opened it just from the sheer novelty of it. As he read it, his eyebrows jumped up. He read it again.

I don’t know if you have any reason to know this but you told me to let you know about anything that seemed odd. This seemed odd. Princess Adora has been staying here off and on for months now. I kind of wondered why but had a hard time finding out as the project she was involved with was secretive. Well, I found out. She’s no longer the vessel for She-Ra and they’re trying to get She-Ra back to her. I don’t know if this is any help to you but it definitely was odd so I’m passing it along.

He stared out the window as a huge smile formed on his face. He knew exactly how he was going to use this.

Chapter End Notes

You know, I've written a lot from this guy's perspective and I feel like I have a pretty good grasp on his character. However, when I was doing the interaction between him and Bryce, I really feel like I caught his character. If I had to introduce someone to the character and only had one thing I could show, I would probably do that one. I feel like it just shows exactly who he is as a person.

Emma

Chapter Summary

> Emma goes on a walk through her greenhouse at night as she ponders her life.

Chapter Notes

> "Any moment might be our last. Everything is more beautiful because we're doomed. You will never be lovelier than you are now. We will never be here again." The Iliad by Homer
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Emma stared at the ceiling of her bedroom, her arm out across the empty space on the bed beside her. She rolled over as she looked at the space before sighing and getting up. She couldn't sleep and while she would prefer to think that it had to do with Izzy's troubles, she'd talked with Izzy and Izzy had reassured her that it was alright. So while Emma was still worried about her, it wasn't what was keeping her up at night.

She walked through her living room, stopping for a moment to check her plants almost as a reflex, on the way to the kitchen. She stood in front of the refrigerator for a long moment, staring in thinking about what she wanted to eat. Nothing presented itself, even though it was full, and she shut the door. Then she went back into the living room and sat down in her chair, picked up a few books that didn't hold her attention for more than a page or so before she finally put them back down with another sigh. She'd worked hard to make a life for herself here, a little snug home for herself, and she loved it. However, recently, the place felt empty when she was by herself. She knew why, even if she wasn't really fully admitting it to herself just yet. Finally she just shook her

head, got dressed in her coveralls, and went out into the castle for a walk.

Emma had intended to just walk around a little but her feet directed her down to the greenhouses. She walked down the large stone hallway past doors large enough for massive trucks to get into them, each door with a number painted on it. She stopped in front of #11 and remembered the first time she'd seen it when she'd gone there as part of her rehabilitation. She'd thought it was punishment at first, working in the aquaponics rooms, but she'd quickly grown to love it. Now, years later, she got to run #11 aquaponics greenhouse.

She stepped into the regular sized door beside the huge truck entrance and waved at the three people sitting around inside the small storage room playing cards. Four was the normal number for the third shift but Emma knew one had taken off work to go see family. It didn't matter, their only job was to monitor the equipment remotely, fix any issues that came up, and call for help if they couldn't and three could do it just as easily as four. The running joke was the only reason there were even four people on the third shift was to make it easier to form card games.

"Hey, Boss," one of them said as they shuffled a deck of cards. "Want in?"

"Naw," Emma said. "Just going to check that new pump."

One of the others leaned back, poked at a screen to pull up the diagnostics, and then rapped the side of it with her knuckles.

"Doing just fine," she said. “See?”

"I know. It's really just an excuse to get out of my place for a little bit," Emma said. The three shrugged as the dealer started handing out cards. Emma watched for a moment before she went out a second door and into the warm, muggy air of the greenhouse. She took a long deep breath of the air, redolent with the smell of fishes that swam in trenches under the racks of plants, twice as high as the average person, and the smell of the growing plants.

As she did, she once again marveled at the change in her. This never would have been satisfying to her younger self. She’d found purpose for herself in this greenhouse and as she touched the left breast pocket of her coveralls where a picture of her and Izzy sitting together at the gates of Dryl always resided, she realized she’d found redemption as well.

Emma didn't bother with the lights; the few left on for safety were enough as she slowly made her way towards the new pump, checking little things along the way. The pump was the reason she’d thought to visit as she’d walked down the tunnel to the greenhouse but she knew the real reason was a bit more complex.

She’d lived alone ever since she’d ended her marriage to Bryce. It’d been the first time she’d been on her own, ever. She’d lived with her mother, briefly lived with roommates, and then married Bryce. After the debacle that was Bryce trying to get Izzy to come back and live with them, she’d gone to the Kingdom of Snows and

been given her own private room for rehabilitation. She remembered those first quiet moments and what a nightmare they had been for her and she always wondered if it had been intentional by the Listeners in charge of her rehabilitation so she'd feel the need to talk. She'd never asked but as it'd gone on, she'd begun to tolerate it and then found that she loved it and until recently, couldn't have imagined it any other way. She'd had parties and made friends but in the end, she loved the quiet solitude of her home. Then she'd met Reave.

It'd been nothing at first. They'd met at one of Emma's parties. She'd just moved to the area and someone had brought her along and Emma, using what she thought of as her host mode, had chatted with her through the evening making sure she felt included and met other people. Emma smiled at the memory of Reave shaking her hand at the end of the night and thanking her for a great evening.

What followed had been natural, easy, unlike every other relationship Emma had ever had. Her prior conception of love had always been a fight for her, leaving her exhausted. When she'd finally realized how she'd felt about Reave, the first thing she'd experienced was fear because she didn't want to go through that with Reave. She'd talked with her Listener who'd gently guided her and advised her to just keep going along the path she was on.

"You gotta remember, your trauma in your past is going to try and shape your future. That's not good or bad but how you allow it to shape your life can be. So ask yourself, is this response because you think Reave will be like your former relationships and your trauma is rightly warning you away or do you think that maybe

your trauma isn’t a good advisor in this situation?” her Listener had asked.

Emma stood next to a plant rack and gave a little sniff of the water, full of nutrients from the fish tanks, running down through the rack. She didn’t smell anything out of the ordinary and went moving along. She’d remembered the advice and how she’d thought long and hard about why she was scared. She’d approached Reave and told her she wanted to date, that she hoped she did as well, but she wanted to be slow about it. Reave had grinned and simply said, “I wondered when we were going to have this conversation.”

That conversation had ended with a kiss and Emma had floated on air for days afterwards, feeling silly at her age for doing so but not caring all the same. Slow didn’t last long. Reave started staying at Emma's place several nights a week and at first Emma had thought it’d be awkward, sharing her space with someone else like that again, but like almost everything else in the relationship she’d found it had been as easy as breathing. Now, on the nights Reave wasn’t there, she felt lonely and out of sorts. Because of that, the third shift crew was seeing a lot more of their boss as she found reasons to wander through the greenhouse at night and keep her mind occupied.

I need to stop lying to myself and admit this is serious. I should have her meet Izzy, Emma thought to herself as she walked towards the center aisle. As if the thought had summoned some avatar of her daughter, she saw a little bot sitting on the corner of a shelf, tucked into itself as it recharged. The logo of Dryl on its back, a tiny cupcake, made her smile almost every time she saw one.

Emma walked a little further, patting the side of the gazebo that sat in the middle of the greenhouse as she went through, and was soon kneeling down in front of the pump. She listened to it, watched the water flow gauges, and put a hand on it to make sure it wasn't running hot. Everything was in order but she hadn’t expected otherwise. She sat down next to the pump, leaned back against the rack, and just listened to the little noises of the greenhouse at night. It was quiet in the room, with little sounds like the water flowing through the racks, the occasional splash of a fish, and the hum of the HVAC system that kept the room at a regular temperature and humidity filling the silence. Some sound pulled at the edge of her mind though and it took her a moment to realize there was a little metallic clanking noise that kept sounding nearby. She listened for a moment and realized it sounded fairly rhythmic and Emma frowned as she got up.

The noise made her think of an equipment malfunction. She remembered one such malfunction that had left part of the floor flooded with reeking water from the fish troughs and almost started a fire. She started walking towards the noise, reaching up to her collar to hit the call switch on her radio and then gave a little shake of her head and a chuckle at the reflex as she realized she didn’t have a radio on because she wasn’t actually on shift.

I’ll just see what it is and then go get the crew if it hasn’t shown up on the monitor yet, she thought as she went along. It didn’t take long to find the issue.

Emma came around a corner and saw a line of small bots up against the supports of one of the racks. One of them near the center was tapping against it. They looked like small crabs and

each one had a claw around the supports. Emma walked towards the one making the noise wondering why the pruning bots were out.

“You need some maintenance, little friend?” she said with a smile as she got closer and then felt some confusion as she looked closely at the bots. The Kingdom of Snows got all of their bots from Dryl. These bots though didn’t have the cupcake logo which meant they weren’t Dryl bots.

It was about the time Emma had the realization that she heard a humming noise and the rack supports clasped between the claws of the bots started glowing red. Then the rack started leaning. She wasn’t sure what was going on but she knew the racks, and all the plants and equipment to grow them, were an immense weight and so she started running for the main aisle. She was almost there when one of the hydroponic tanks slid off the rack. She saw it coming but had no chance to dodge as it slammed into her with a horrible force. The scream that tried to come out couldn’t even happen as her breath was driven from her and she felt something break inside.

She hit the ground with the tank on top of her, everything fading to black but not so fast that she didn’t see the rack, and all the other tanks on it, falling towards her.

Chapter End Notes

> I believe my wife's exact words when I read this chapter to her were, "You *&%$$^&!"
>
> Anyway, I won't make you wait long for the next one. I'll probably post the next chapter in the next few days. I'm coming close to finishing the writing of the whole story soon

and so I'm going to start posting a little faster (assuming I don't suddenly realize I need more chapters but I don't think so).

Izzy

Chapter Summary

> Izzy is now in the Kingdom of Snows wondering just what to do now.

Chapter Notes

> "If you can force your heart and nerve and sinew / To serve your turn long after they are gone, / And so hold on when there is nothing in you / Except the Will which says to them: Hold on!" If (excerpt) by Rudyard Kipling
>
> Note: Brief mention of Micah, brief summary at end

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izzy stood in Emma's apartment, her heavy parka opened in the warmth, as she held a large photo. It was Izzy's official coronation photo and it held pride of place on the small table beside the front door. Thoughts rolled through Izzy as she thought of Emma and fought back tears.

She was so proud when I took the title and it's because of it that this happened, Izzy thought to herself as she sat it back down. Then she shook her head sharply. *No. Not was proud. Still is. Still is proud. She's not gone yet.*

Izzy had been twiddling her thumbs in Bright Moon as they'd got ready to start the Princess Council back up. Glimmer had explained what her plan was and Izzy had been ready to go along with it. Then a few days after the whole incident, Frosta had come into Izzy's room in the middle of the night, telling her about the accident. Izzy had been getting ready to go, Harpi had been lining

up fast transportation, when Glimmer had come in and transported them all.

Izzy had gone straight to the hospital room. She remembered looking down at Emma, unconscious and covered in medical equipment and bandages as Izzy tried to talk with the healers. They kept saying things like they were hopeful and things seemed stable but Izzy couldn't help but feel like it was a lost cause. Emma had looked so small and insignificant among all the trappings of the healers that she had to fight to keep that image from overriding the other images that Izzy had of Emma in her head.

Izzy had held it together though, kissing Emma's hand before she walked out into the hall with Finn. She'd heard Finn start to say something to her but she never found out what they were going to say to her because she broke down in tears. Finn had said nothing and just pulled her into their arms.

Afterwards, she'd gone right down to the greenhouse, stuffing her pain down, and seen the heat blackened rack supports. The greenhouse staff were all trying to figure out how it'd happened and kept apologizing to her for the accident but Izzy knew as soon as she saw it that it was not an accident. She could see multiple ways to make it happen and had made notes with Pat as she walked around and sent things to Harpi, back in their rooms, to look up. Then she went on to Emma's home. She'd dreaded that part but she'd felt pulled to do so.

Now, standing in Emma's space, she wasn't sure what she had expected to gain. She sighed and then looked up as there was a

gentle knock at the door. Izzy's hand fell to a weapon as Finn came out of Emma's bedroom. Finn gave her a strange look.

"Iz, did you…," Finn started to say before she shook her head and held up a hand for quiet.

The knock came again and she carefully went over to the door and stood to the side.

"Hello?" she said.

"Izzy, open up, it's me."

Izzy turned on the little camera that sat above the door and saw Frosta. She unlocked it and kept her body behind it as she carefully opened it, looking up and down the hallway before opening it all the way.

"Sorry," Izzy said as she got out of the way to let Frosta in and then shut the door behind her.

Frosta shook her head as she came in and said, "No need. I understand. Are you alright?"

Izzy just shrugged as she said, "I've been looking around."

“Don’t think it was an accident do you?” Frosta said.

“Do you?” Izzy said.

“No,” Frosta said. “But I admit I'm not the most reliable person for that because I tend to look towards the dramatic. Curse of the writer and all that jazz.”

Finn sat on the edge of a chair as they looked back and forth between the two.

“Why do you think it wasn’t? The crew seemed to think it was one,” Finn replied.

“And I’ll probably be talking with them in more detail but the big giveaway was that the rack supports were heated up in some way,” Izzy said. “The greenhouse crew is saying they think some of the welding bots got confused but that many? All at once? When no one was really working and right when Emma went in? The logs also say none of those welding bots had left their charging stations.”

“How do you know that?” Frosta said. “I hadn’t even heard that yet.”

Izzy put her hand on her data pad in her shoulder bag as she said, “They’re Dryl made bots. How do you think?”

“But why Emma?” Finn said.

Izzy looked at Finn and Finn sighed as they said, “OK, but still. It seems… I don’t know, so over the top.”

“It is but it’s subtle in its own way,” Izzy replied in a voice Finn knew. It was Izzy trying to work out a problem. “Even if we figure out which bots were used, we’ll have a hard time figuring out who put in the programming. The logs showing clean, that’s another bit of tampering too, maybe, that we can run down. The problem is we might not find anything.”

“You’ve got my kingdom's support,” Frosta said. “You let me know what you need, we’ll provide it.”

“I’ve got a list going,” Izzy said, her voice serious, and then stopped as she noticed another photo on the table by the door. This one was Izzy and Emma sitting below the clock tower in the town square of Dava, both holding flavored shaved ice and grinning. Izzy stepped over and picked it up.

“I remember this day,” she said quietly. Finn got up and went over to put an arm around her as she went on, no longer all business. “It was only a month after I’d taken the title. She’d come to spend the weekend and we’d traveled around a little. I think this is one

of the first times I really felt comfortable around her. Brother Priz took the photo. We hadn't wanted him to but he'd insisted. Said we'd appreciate it." Tears slipped down her face as she held it to her chest. "He wasn't wrong."

"Iz, sweetheart, you need to rest," Finn said as they kissed the side of her head right below one of her horns. "You've been up way too long."

"I need to find out who did this," Izzy said, her voice going hard, as she sat the photo down and wiped at her tears.

"And you will but after you've rested," Finn said, softly, gently.

Izzy was about to say that she had no intention of doing that when there was another knock at the door. The three looked at each other. Frosta just shrugged.

"Finn, go to the bedroom," Izzy whispered.

"I'll just step over here," Finn whispered back. Izzy was about to argue when there was another knock at the door. Frosta gestured at her to go answer it and she realized that Frosta was more than capable of protecting Finn.

As Izzy walked to the door she shrugged off her parka and hung it over her left arm. She turned on the little camera again and saw

an older woman with black hair shot through with gray, carrying a large colorful shoulder bag and dressed in overalls like the greenhouse crew wore. She was carrying a plant and looked nervous. Izzy carefully cracked the door.

"Uh… hello," the woman said. "You must be Emma's daughter, Izzy. I'm Reave, her… well, girlfriend feels silly to say at my age but that."

Izzy nodded as she opened the door a little more.

"She'd mentioned you," Izzy said. Emma had just called her a friend but Izzy had figured it was more. Normally she'd be pleased to be right but now she was just leery.

"I'm sorry, I know it's a bad time but I just… I've been to see her and I thought maybe she'd like a plant when she came back," Reave said as she held the plant up. "It'll be fine until she gets back. It doesn't require much care."

"Thank you, I know she'd appreciate it. Would you like to put it on the entry table?" Izzy said as she stepped back and swung the door wide, positioning herself partly behind the door with her heavy coat shielding her other side.

The woman gave a tired smile as she nodded and started in.

“I’m sorry we’re meeting under such circumstances,” Reave said as she went in and Izzy shut the door. Izzy knew something was up and when she looked across the room at Finn, who was watching Reave, she saw a puzzled look on Finn’s face. Izzy flicked her eyes back to Reave and saw her bag and how the straps cut into the woman’s shoulder from the weight of whatever was inside. Izzy’s right hand went behind her back to grasp her curved dagger that rested in the small of her back.

“Of course,” Izzy responded to Reave as Reave sat the plant down. Reave sighed as she did and a different voice came out of her.

Capella’s voice said from the face, “I just needed a way in to talk with you without causing a huge fuss. I’m not here to hurt you.”

“Drop the illusion. Now,” Izzy said as she drew the dagger. Capella’s hand twitched and the illusion wavered and disappeared. The hair went from streaked with gray and long to bald. The most significant part though that Izzy noticed was how hard Capella’s face and eyes looked.

“Cappe!” Finn said as they started across the room to her.

“No!” Izzy snapped, dropping her coat as she held her hand out and Finn stopped. “How do I know it’s you?”

“You’ve bribed me with cookies twice in my life. Once with real cookies and once with metaphorical cookies,” Capella responded after a moment of thought

“Where did I tell you about the metaphorical cookies and who was with me?” Izzy said.

“It was in the Bright Moon gardens, specifically in the greenhouse,” Capella said and Izzy watched a shadow of sadness wash across her face before her face returned to neutral. “And Harpi was with you.”

Izzy sighed as she lowered her dagger slowly.

“Sorry. I just…”

She trailed off as Capella nodded.

“Don’t apologize. I understand.”

Finn came across the room at almost a sprint and grabbed Capella in a hug, startling her. Again, Izzy watched her face show surprise, then a shocking amount of sorrow, before it all disappeared again to the hardened neutral face as she put an arm around Finn to hug them. Izzy couldn’t help but notice it wasn’t her dominant hand.

“We’ve been worried about you!” Finn said as they hugged her.

Capella hugged Finn back briefly as she said, “I’m sorry. I have to figure out what’s going on.”

“You know, I’m supposed to detain you on sight, Cappe,” Frosta said with a grin as she leaned against the wall. “Technically so are you, Izzy.”

“Aunt Frosta, don’t you dare,” Finn said, stepping in front of Capella and Izzy watched Capella’s dominant hand start to creep to the front of her coveralls. Frosta continued to grin as she pulled some dark glasses out and slid them on.

“Look at that. I can’t see her,” Frosta said.

“Do you carry those around with you just so you can do that?” Izzy said.

“No. They have other uses as well,” Frosta said as she took them back off and put them back inside her parka.

“Listen, I don’t have time for this. Frosta, just stay over there. I have to get moving again and I have things to tell you,” Capella said, her voice steady, as she reached into the bag on her

shoulder and pulled out a crab bot. She stepped into the living room and set it down on the coffee table, tossing the bag to the side before retreating back into the entry hall. “That’s one of the bots that did the attack.”

Izzy was already over to it and couldn’t help but notice the stab mark through its top carapace. She looked at Capella with a raised eyebrow.

“It was stuck in a vent trying to escape and when I found it, it attacked me,” Capella said.

Izzy carefully poked at it as she said, “This isn’t a Dryl bot but it sure looks like the pruning bot. Except for that.” She pointed at one of the claws that was larger than the other. As she carefully opened it up, she said, “Looks like an induction heating tool for welding.”

“Don’t bother trying to figure it out from a busted bot,” Capella said. “When I heard about this, I thought I could get out here and figure things out quicker. I was right. I didn’t just find the bot; I found the person who did it.”

Izzy stopped poking at the bot suddenly and looked up.

“How do you know it’s the right person?” Izzy said.

Capella shrugged as she said, "I followed another bot back to where he was hiding. He was kind enough to tell me. Well, kind enough after I gave him some incentive to do so."

Finn looked at her in shock as they said, "Cappe! Tell me you didn't torture this person!"

"Fine, if it makes you feel better, Finn, I didn't torture this person," Capella said in a cold voice.

"Cappe…," Finn started to say when she cut him off.

"Enough, Finn. You don't know what's going on out there and I don't want to hear it right now. Like I said, I have a lot to tell you and I need to get going," Capella said.

"You don't have to," Izzy said softly and Capella gave a little snort.

"I do because I'm not stupid. I saw you were staying at Bright Moon after your little dust-up," Capella said. "Don't. Go back to Dryl and keep yourself and Finn safe."

"Cappe, we really need to have a long…," Izzy started to say.

“Stop, I don’t want to hear it!” Capella said, shaking her head. “Now let me say what I have to say, alright!? Or do you just want me to leave?”

Izzy held her hands up, feeling helpless, as she shook her head.

“This guy is tied up in an unused closet,” Capella said as she took out a casually folded sheet of paper that looked torn out of a notebook and put it in front of the pictures in the entry hall. “Here's the directions. He was pretty eager to talk when I cornered him so I think you’ll find out some interesting things. He’s got a bag with him. Mostly clothes but there were some invoices and what looked like other accounting stuff in there as well. Figured you’d want to see them so I left them as well.”

Capella stood there for a moment and Izzy could tell there was more so she stayed quiet and let her think. Capella finally shrugged her shoulders and reached into her coveralls again. This time the paper she took out was a piece of beautiful paper with subtle pink sparkles in it, wrapped with a purple ribbon, and sealed with some purple wax with more sparkles in it. The wax itself had an impression in it that Izzy couldn’t quite make out but Finn looked down and then up again at Capella in surprise.

“Cappe, what is that?” Finn said. “That looks…”

“Like an official document? It is,” Capella said and Izzy wondered what Capella was about to reveal. “Or as close as I could make it. I don’t have my signet with me. It’s locked up at Bright Moon but I did some studying. My thumbprint should suffice.”

Capella held the document out to Finn and Finn shook their head as they put their hands behind themself and stepped back.

"I love you too much to take what I think that is," Finn said. Capella pursed her lips and let out a puff of air in irritation that reminded Izzy so much of the young Capella she'd met so many years back that it ached.

"Fine. I don't have to hand deliver it but I figured I would be here so why not," Capella said as she tossed it down next to the directions and Izzy saw a flash of scar tissue on top of her wrist before the coveralls dropped over it again.

"What is it?" Frosta said.

"My abdication," Capella said and her voice became monotone as she looked at each one and went on. "Of my own free will, I, Capella of Bright Moon, renounce the title of the Princess of Bright Moon and any claim to the throne of Bright Moon, by either birthright or assignment, from this day forward. In doing so I recognize I give up all privileges and duties I may have or can claim from said title under both the Etherian Charter or any other binding law on Etheria." Capella stopped, her hand resting on the table beside her clenched into a fist before continuing. "The document is properly witnessed by several citizens of Etheria, signed by my own hand, sealed with my imprint and all done so free of any unlawful duress. It is done. Long live the Queen."

Izzy was familiar with what was required for abdication and knew the last sentence was traditional but Capella spat it out of her mouth like it was poison on her tongue, a bright shower of sparks flying from her hair for a split second. Frosta stood up, her face shocked and Finn had covered their mouth as they went on. Izzy started to take a step forward and froze as Capella's eyes snapped to her. Izzy stopped and gestured with her hand like she was trying to calm a dangerous person.

"Cappe, you don't have to do this," Finn said.

"I've seen the things people are saying about me and what I'm doing. I know what kind of pressure that's probably putting on all of you and honestly, maybe… people will stop chasing after me so much if I'm not the heir to Bright Moon anymore. I make this decision free and unblinded," Capella said, her voice low but controlled and her face neutral. Her eyes blazed though as she went on. "Mom will be mad maybe but when haven't I been a disappointment to her?"

Frosta shook her head as she said, "You're not a disappointment to your…"

"I didn't ask for your opinion, Princess Frosta," Capella shot back. "Don't think you can weasel out of this by burning the document either. I'll be sending out a broadcast announcing my abdication here shortly and I'll make sure to tell everyone that Princess Frosta, Princess Izzy, and Princess Finn were witnesses to it."

“Cappe…,” Finn started to say as they stepped forward to her and Capella teleported back and appeared with her back to the front door.

“No! Stop! I’ve made this decision! You can’t talk me out of it! I will solve who is behind this! I will find out what is going on and Mara help anyone who gets in my way!” Capella shouted out suddenly and her shoulders suddenly sagged. “Just forget about me.”

“That’ll never happen. We love you. You’ll always have a place at my theater,” Finn said, shaking their head.

“And in Dryl,” Izzy said.

“And here,” Frosta said.

Capella looked at the three of them for a long moment, longing in her eyes, before she suddenly straightened up and disappeared without another word. The three stood in the sudden thundering silence as Izzy slowly went over and stood over the document. Finn sat on the arm of a chair as Frosta looked away with tears in her eyes.

“It certainly looks official,” Izzy said, her voice cracking with emotion. “I can’t believe she really did that.”

“We can just deny it,” Frosta said. Izzy began slowly nodding her head.

“She’s obviously distraught. Something’s up,” Izzy replied.

“No, we don’t do anything like that. We deliver it like she obviously wanted us to,” Finn replied. “You don’t see it do you?” Frosta and Izzy looked at Finn confused. “She hasn’t really trusted anyone that we know, except for Gress, since she disappeared weeks, no, months ago. Then she turned up for this. Turned over the bot, told us about the person she caught, and then trusted us enough to deliver her abdication. Couldn’t you tell how conflicted she felt? Especially at the end. She didn’t leave in anger; she left before her resolve broke. If I had to guess, she’s trying to see if we’ll follow through on this.”

“She’s testing to see if we’re trustworthy,” Izzy said. Finn nodded their head. Frosta sighed as she stepped around Izzy and picked up the sealed document.

“Since she did it here, I’ll open it in council and have it recorded in,” Frosta said, her voice hoarse. “I’m going to go call Glimmer right now as well, so be prepared for a visitor.”

Izzy nodded as she picked up the other piece of paper and said, “I’m going to go see what’s going on with this.”

The three stood in silence for a moment before coming together in a big hug. They swayed there for a long moment before they broke apart and went on. Izzy followed the directions down into a part of the warehouse that supplied the greenhouses. It was huge, filled with equipment, supplies, and bots moving every which way. Finn followed right on her heels as she walked to a little room near the back. Izzy stood in front of the door and turned to Finn.

"Stand back. I don't know if whoever this is has gotten free," Izzy said softly.

"Then maybe we should get more people," Finn said quietly.

"No, I'll be alright. I just don't want to worry about you," Izzy said. Finn touched their forehead to her's and then stepped back by one of the racks as Izzy walked up to the door. She opened it, standing to the side, and then looked inside. Finn saw her face go from leery to shocked to furious in the space of a second.

"You!" Izzy screamed and something about her tone brought Finn running forward as Izzy went into the room, a low growl escaping her lips. Finn saw Bryce, tied up in the corner next to a small rack of bots and a duffel bag. He had a rag tied in his mouth and his eyes were full of terror as Izzy started towards him.

"Iz, hang on!" Finn said, scuttling to get between her and Bryce.

“Finn, get out of my way!” Izzy shouted at them as Finn held their hands up.

“No! Wait! He’s helpless! You don’t want to be that person!” Finn said, moving to keep in front of her as she tried to maneuver around them.

“Oh yes, I do!” Izzy replied.

Finn stepped back and stood right over Bryce as they said, “Iz, no! I won’t let you hurt him! He’s tied up, it’s not right!”

Izzy stood there, vibrating with fury, staring Finn down before taking a long deep breath.

“Go get Frosta’s guards,” Izzy said. “They can take him to a secure room so we can talk.”

“No, I’m not leaving you alone here with him. I love you too much to let you do what you’re obviously thinking,” Finn said, shaking their head.

Izzy took several more deep breaths as she took a step back before finally saying, “I won’t hurt him, Finn. I won’t even touch him. I promise.”

Finn stood there, looking at her and Izzy could tell they wanted to believe a promise from her but they were worried as well. Finally Finn slowly nodded their head.

"You promise," Finn said, not so much repeating it for her but for themself. "OK, I'll go get the guards. I love you."

"I love you too, Finn. And you can trust my promise," Izzy said, crossing her arms and holding herself tight.

Finn stepped away from Bryce and started for the door, watching Izzy, as they said, "I know I can."

Izzy couldn't help but notice that Finn watched her until they were out the door. She didn't blame them though because she knew how hard a promise was to believe sometimes. She turned and looked at Bryce, his face terrified and his body shaking, and fought down the thoughts that came into her head.

"You have no idea how lucky you are," Izzy said with a growl in her voice as she stepped over to the bots and looked them over. Each one was a duplicate of a Dryl pruning bot that was used in the greenhouse but with the replaced induction welding claw. She could see little differences here and there such as in a weld or how a joint functioned but she knew at a distance, they'd look like just another Dryl bot going about their work. She took a brief look at the papers in his bag, saw they were financial documents as Capella had said, and turned back to Bryce as she squatted down in front of him.

“I’m not taking your gag off because you’re going to say something that’s going to make me want to kill you and I’m keeping my promise to Finn,” Izzy said. “But we’re going to have a really long talk later where people can keep an eye on me and keep me from doing the awful things I want to do to you right now. Just so you know, Emma is still alive. Mara help you if she doesn’t make it because I’m pretty sure I’ll break that promise to send you right after her.”

Izzy watched his face as he started trying to shake his head and say something but it was garbled. She almost took the gag out to hear what he had to say but shook her head at the last second.

“You’ll have plenty of time to talk later,” Izzy said and was grateful to hear running feet outside as Finn arrived with some guards. As they entered the room she stood up and said, “I’m Princess Izzy of Dryl. Please take custody of this man and take him to a secure room. Make sure he is treated decently, and I will be along shortly to discuss some matters with him.”

The guards nodded and went up to him, cutting the plastic rope that held him, and helping him to his feet as they took the gag out. He started to say something but stopped as Izzy gave him a look that silenced him. After the guards had taken him out of the room, she sat down where he’d been tied up and put her head onto her knees and cried as Finn knelt in front of her and hugged her the best they could.

“I didn’t touch him,” Izzy said as Finn held her.

“I know you didn’t because you promised me you wouldn’t,” Finn said. “Now come on. You’re going to get that rest I wanted you to get earlier.”

Izzy finally nodded as they both got up and went to their rooms. As they walked in, Glimmer was standing in the room waiting.

“Izzy…,” Glimmer started to say.

“Aunt Glimmer, Izzy is exhausted. Please speak with me,” Finn said. “I was there for the whole thing as well.”

Glimmer looked at Izzy for a moment and then Finn.

“Finn, you need to think better of me,” Glimmer said and her voice was soft towards the both of them for the first time Finn could remember since the whole mess had started. They also noticed she’d been crying. “I was going to say, Izzy, I’m sorry to hear about Emma and I hope she gets better soon.”

Finn hung their head for a moment before nodding and saying, “I’m sorry. I should think better of you. She’s still exhausted though.”

“Finn, I can spare a moment for Glimmer,” Izzy said, patting Finn’s hand.

Glimmer sat down on a couch as she said, “Frosta told me about the abdication. I’ll… I’ll have it recorded with the Archives when I get back to Bright Moon. I don’t want to hear about that.” Glimmer looked at the floor, her hands clenched together as she went on. “How did my little girl look? Is she… does she look well?”

Finn and Izzy looked at each other before Izzy looked back to Glimmer and said, “She’s not… she’s not the Cappe I remember. She’s very brusque and very conflicted I think.”

Glimmer nodded as the tears dropped from her eyes as Finn stood and went over to sit down beside her. Glimmer held an arm out and Finn slid in and hugged her close. Finn looked up at Izzy and Izzy came over and stood in front of Glimmer. Glimmer looked up at her and then just nodded. Izzy sat down on the other side of her and hugged her as well.

“She’s been injured,” Izzy said quietly and Glimmer’s head snapped up. “I saw a scar on top of her wrist. It’s healed but it’s recent. I didn’t get a chance to ask. She was incredibly jumpy.”

Glimmer wiped at her eyes as she said, “I shouldn’t be surprised. I’ve heard some pretty outlandish stories about what she’s been doing. I mean, some of them have to be fake but some…”

Izzy nodded as she said, "I've heard the same. It's that same deal I think. She's chasing down that Children of Mara group. She's done really well at breaking them up too."

Izzy saw a momentary flash of pride in Glimmer's eyes before it was replaced again with her pain.

"I wish I knew how to get her to at least come and talk with me," Glimmer said.

"I'll talk to Gress again," Izzy said. "See if he'll pass on a message if you want."

Glimmer grimaced as she said, "Gress. You know, I hate him a little for being able to talk to her while I can't."

"I figured it'd be for all those messages and recorded speeches he's doing about how the powers-that-be are failing the clones," Finn said, trying to be upbeat.

"No, I'll never be mad at someone for that," Glimmer said with a shake of her head. "Mom once told me that if someone said something about me that made me mad, I needed to think about why I was mad. If it wasn't true, why was I mad? It wasn't true. If it was true, then why was I mad? It was something that I had done or was and if it made me mad, I should change it. Course, I didn't really get that until long after I was grown but I do get it."

“How is she? Your mother?” Izzy asked.

“Hanging on,” Glimmer said. “Dad… we don’t think it’ll be much longer now.” Finn hugged her tighter as Glimmer went on in a quieter voice. “Is it wrong that I’m hoping for it now?”

“No,” Finn said. “You just want it to be done and for him not to be hurting anymore.”

“I want a lot of things to just be done,” Glimmer said.

“I understand,” Izzy said. They sat in silence for a few minutes, Izzy handing Glimmer some tissues, before Glimmer finally stood.

“I heard you caught someone,” Glimmer said, trying to take her mind off her problems.

“No, Cappe caught someone,” Izzy said and she once again saw the pride flash through Glimmer’s eyes. “It’s Bryce.”

“Bryce? Wait, your… Bryce?” Glimmer said, cutting herself off from saying father at the last second.

“Thank you for that pause because he’s not my anything,” Izzy said. “But, yes, him. I’m going to go and speak with him soon.”

“Not before you’ve rested,” Finn said, placing a hand on her hand. Izzy took Finn’s hand and squeezed it.

“I can go and have a talk with him,” Glimmer said.

“No, I need to do it,” Izzy said standing up.

Finn stood with her, sighing as they said, “You’re going to go do it right now aren’t you?”

“Yeah, I guess I am. I’ll rest when I get back,” Izzy said.

“I’m going to go to Bright Moon,” Glimmer said. “Aeron is pitching a fit that we haven’t had either your trial or his recognition yet. Said he’s going to file a complaint with the High Council of Etheria if we don’t move soon.”

Izzy’s face went hard at the mention of Aeron.

“Let him stew.”

“Plan on it,” Glimmer said before stepping forward and holding her arms open to Izzy. Izzy stared at her in surprise for a moment before stepping into the embrace. Glimmer held an arm out to Finn and they stepped in as well. The three hugged each other tight.

“I know you’re trying,” Glimmer whispered to them both. “Thank you for not giving up just because of my attitude.”

“It’s completely understandable,” Izzy whispered back. “One way or another, we’ll figure it out.”

Glimmer gave them one last tight hug and then disappeared. Izzy looked for her satchel to grab and put it back on before she realized she’d never actually taken it off.

“Iz, you need…,” Finn started to say.

Izzy put her hand to the side of their face with a tired smile.

“I know, Finn. Trust me, I know,” she said. “But I need to find out what’s going on and if I lay down, I’m not going to rest anyway.”

Finn sighed, their ears laying back a little in resignation as they nodded. They took her hand and gave a small kiss to the back of it before letting it go.

“OK, let’s go,” Finn said.

The walk through the castle to where they were holding Bryce seemed to take no time at all to Izzy. She was so busy wrapped up in what she was going to say that she didn’t pay much attention to their route. Suddenly she was standing before a nondescript door with two guards sitting outside of it. One of the guards got to their feet as Izzy approached with Finn.

“Princess Izzy, Princess Frosta told us to expect you. Are you here to talk with him?”

“I am,” Izzy replied. “Is he ready to speak?”

“Wouldn’t shut up since we put him in there,” the other guard said with a shake of her head. “Anyone goes in, he starts talking. Getting him to shut up will be the hard part.”

“OK, I’m going to go on in then,” Izzy said. Finn put a hand on her shoulder as she started to step forward.

“I still hold you to your promise from earlier,” Finn said quietly.

“I know you do,” Izzy said as she gave a small smile. “Thank you for reminding me though.”

“Leave your hardware out here then?” Finn said.

“No,” Izzy said and leaned in to give them a kiss. “All the way to the end?”

Finn sighed and nodded their head.

“All the way,” Finn said and Izzy stepped forward, opened the door, and walked in.

Bryce looked up from the small couch he was sitting on. There was a table with four chairs around it and a few well stuffed chairs by the couch. He scurried to his feet as Izzy looked at him. The two stared at each other, neither sure where to start. It was Bryce that finally said something.

“I wasn’t told that Emma was a target,” Bryce said.

“Don’t you say her name,” Izzy snapped back at him and Bryce cowered back a little. “I’m here to talk to you about what’s going on. Sit down.”

Izzy pointed at the table and Bryce quickly made his way over and sat down. Izzy remained standing as she went to the other side and pulled out Pat.

“Pat, play back last three minutes of recording,” Izzy said as she looked at her monocle. “Stop. Mark as beginning of new archive recording, ‘Bryce Discussion - Part One of unknown.’ Archive until I tell you to stop please.”

She listened for a moment and then nodded and sat Pat on the table.

“That’s my AI,” Izzy said. “They’ll record this and keep me honest.”

“I’ll tell you whatever you want to know,” Bryce said and Izzy was struck at the complete difference from the man she knew as her violent, abusive father to what seemed like a shattered wreck of a man before her. She had dreamed of a moment like this before, of seeing him laid low and miserable. Now that it had happened, she felt the emptiness of it.

“Fine,” Izzy said, looking down at him. “You said that you were told she wasn’t a target. What were you told you were going to do?”

“I was told to monitor the bots and that they were going to do some sabotage,” Bryce said. “I was told no one would be hurt.”

“Oh, just some bots running around breaking stuff. No danger there,” Izzy said sarcastically.

“I… I, um, said something similar,” Bryce said. “The guy who came with me assured me that they were smart enough to avoid people and systems that would hurt people.”

“Your concern for not hurting people is noted,” Izzy said dryly. “Do you know what happened?”

Bryce shook his head as he said, “I know what you said. That… she got hurt.”

“Your bots burned out the supports to an aquaculture rack and dropped hundreds of pounds of equipment on top of her,” Izzy said. “She’s been in a coma ever since. Who was with you and where are they now?”

“It was some guy who called himself Hange,” Bryce replied. “He came to my house and came with me here. We had the bots with us and he was able to get me into that room and gave me instructions. Then he left.”

“Why didn’t you just leave yourself then?” Izzy said, sitting down at the table because she knew she wanted to pace and if she paced, she’d end up too close to Bryce and she didn’t want to test her temper.

Bryce looked away as he said, “I just didn’t.”

“You had some financial documents in your duffle bag,” Izzy said and Bryce looked back at her. “Does it have something to do with those?”

Bryce ran his hands down his horns as he looked back at Izzy.

“They said they’d release them if I didn’t go along,” Bryce said.

“I haven’t looked at them,” Izzy said. “The person who told me where to find you said she’d looked at them.”

“Who was she?” Bryce said. “Does she work for you, Iz?”

Izzy’s temper flared for a moment before she looked away as she said, “Don’t call me Iz and we’re not here to talk about her.” She looked back to Bryce and leaned forward. “Describe this Hange person to me instead.”

“Sea elf but real tall,” Bryce said. “Blue-green hair with blue skin.”

Izzy nodded and under her breath told Pat to send out a notification to the network.

"I'll have someone come in later, see if you can't make a better description but we're getting somewhere," Izzy said.

"Iz, I have to…," Bryce started to say and Izzy shot to her feet.

Bryce shoved back in the chair, his eyes wide as Izzy said, "Don't. Call. Me. Iz. If you have to use a name so badly then call me by my title but otherwise, don't."

Bryce quickly nodded as he said, "I'm sorry."

"And don't bother with sorry either. Your sorry stopped being real to me shortly after I stopped wearing diapers," Izzy said. "Did Hange say if he worked for someone? Did he just pick you randomly? Talk about that. Now."

Bryce started slowly shaking his head and Izzy leaned forward as her fingers clenched the edge of the table.

"Yes, Bryce, yes, you're going to tell me about that. The guards said you were real damn chatty so now's the time to be chatty. He worked for someone didn't he?" Izzy said.

“I… I don’t know,” Bryce said. Izzy looked at him and Bryce looked back at her, trying to keep his eyes on her eyes.

“You’re lying to me,” Izzy said.

“I don’t know,” Bryce said, his voice a little stronger.

Izzy looked at him and the thought of Emma laying still in the bed flashed through her head. Instead of the urge to leap across the table at him she expected, she instead felt just tired, and sat down in the chair again.

“Fine, you don’t know,” Izzy said, her voice monotone. “Shouldn’t be surprised because you’re still trying to just look out for yourself. We’re done. I’ll turn the recording over to Frosta. She’ll be making the determination of your rehabilitation. I won’t be involved.”

Izzy stood up, feeling stupid for even getting involved as she picked up Pat and put the data pad in her satchel. She was almost to the door when she heard Bryce speak.

“Princess… wait,” he said. Izzy stood at the door and didn’t turn around.

“I met a guy and his husband some months back at the inn that’s in my town. Said their names were Seraph and Nettie,” Bryce said

quietly. “We hung out a couple of times, they were really kind and fun to hang around. I did something that’s maybe a little shady to get them a little money but figured it wasn’t that big a deal since I paid it all back anyway. Then a few days ago, I got a package. It was full of documents that said I had been embezzling parts and funds from the water works where I’m employed. Then Seraph called the next day. He wasn’t kind anymore. Told me I’d do this or he’d make it public. It was all fake but… I didn’t want to run the risk.”

Izzy turned around, the words “a guy and his husband,” ringing in her head. She almost blurted out what Aeron and Carl looked like but she instead managed to say, “I’m still recording. Describe the guy who called you.”

Izzy listened as Bryce described Aeron. Her hands shook as she pulled Pat back out and quickly tapped away at it, pulling up the latest picture she had of Aeron, from the day he came into the Princess Council. Then she pulled up three other random photos that were roughly alike and had Pat trim out the backgrounds and put them side-by-side with numbers below them. She stepped over to the table and held the data pad so Bryce could see it.

“Is the person you’re calling Seraph one of these people?” she said.

Bryce looked at it and then said, “He’s number three.”

Izzy turned it around and looked. Aeron stared back at her from the number three position.

“Is he someone you know?” Bryce said.

Izzy looked back at him as she said, “His name isn’t Seraph, it’s Aeron and he would have killed you more than likely when you were finished. Him or that Hange person you’re talking about.”

“But he said that if I did what he asked...,” Bryce started to say and Izzy could see him realize just how stupid what he was about to say sounded.

“Even if he let you live, you never would have gotten out from under him,” Izzy said. “You’re actually lucky we caught you instead.”

“He said that the princesses make accidents happen all the time,” Bryce said, looking at Izzy with a hopeless look.

“No, they don’t,” Izzy said as she had a sudden hypothesis about Dark Moon. “I bet he wanted you to think that. I’m your enemy but I and the princesses are sure safer than your supposed allies. Keep that in mind. I have things I have to do now.”

Izzy had Pat save the lineup they’d created and put it back in her satchel as she headed for the door.

“Princess?” Bryce said and Izzy threw her head back in annoyance as she turned around.

“What?”

“I… I really am sorry,” Bryce said.

“I really don’t care,” Izzy said. “You’ve been dead to me for years now. You’re going to go through rehabilitation again. You’re going to get a second chance, again, but that doesn’t mean you get a second chance from me.”

Izzy turned and went out the door. She must have come out with a little more force than she expected because the guards and Finn jumped to their feet.

“Nothing’s wrong,” she said and was a bit surprised she didn’t feel like crying. Then she realized it was like she had said. Bryce, the man she’d once called dad, was dead to her. The person in that room was as much a stranger as the Hange person was to her.

“You alright?” Finn said.

“I didn’t touch him,” Izzy said.

“I know you didn’t,” Finn said.

“Now I’m going to see Mom,” Izzy said, as she stopped the recording and then dropped all the information to Frosta before she started walking. “I’ll rest in her room.”

Finn nodded and walked along with her, holding her hand. It wasn’t long before Izzy was walking past the guards that Frosta had put on Emma’s room. A healer sat by the bed, checking Emma’s vitals, and Izzy once again was surprised by how small Emma looked wrapped in blankets and all the medical equipment.

“You must be Izzy and Finn. I’m Healer Pyet,” Pyet said as she stood up. Izzy nodded mutely as she looked down at Emma. There were all kinds of emotions fighting in her at the moment and she didn’t trust herself to open her mouth. “Are you able to hear information right now about her condition?”

Izzy sat down beside Emma and gently touched her hand for a moment, taking some comfort in the warmth of it.

“I am,” she managed to say. Pyet came around the bed and knelt down by Izzy.

“OK, I have several things to tell you. First, we believe she will recover. We’ve managed to fix her lungs and set all the bones. There’s significant soft tissue trauma as well but that’s the least of our worries. Next, we’ve been doing scans of her brain since she

was brought in," Pyet said as she looked at her data pad for a moment. "We were worried about brain damage and while it does look like there is a little, we think she'll recover with appropriate rehabilitation. The final thing though is it appears her spine was damaged and we are not going to be able to reconstruct it. She won't walk with her own legs again but with appropriate prosthesis she will walk. I think you're familiar with those."

Izzy shook her head as she wiped at her eyes and Finn squeezed her shoulder as she said, "No, but I will be."

Pyet gave a comforting smile as she looked at the chart on her data pad again for a moment.

"Now, we were waiting for you for this next step. We'd like to try and bring her up out of the coma," Pyet said and Izzy looked surprised.

"Like, right now?" Izzy said.

Pyet nodded as she said, "We think she's ready to come up and we wanted you and your partner here if possible. It helps orient her if someone she recognizes is present. I'll warn you though, it's not like you see in plays. She won't just blink her eyes and be present. Expect lots of confusion, mood changes, and possibly even convulsions. If you don't think you want to see that, I understand. "

Izzy looked at Finn. Finn, grim faced as they took her hand, nodded at her.

"We'll both be here," she said.

"OK, my team will be here in a few minutes," Pyet responded. "When she starts to come up, I want you to start speaking with her. It can be about anything except the thing that put her here. If you need to stop for any reason, I want you," Pyet said pointing at Finn, "to jump in and keep the talking going. Can you do that?"

"Yes," Finn said and Izzy nodded.

"If it looks like there's a problem, we'll put her back under and we'll talk about it afterwards," Pyet said as a few people came into the room and started working. Pyet turned to them and started talking quickly and clearly as one of the other people injected something into the IV. Izzy saw that they had removed the tube going down Emma's throat and clenched Finn's hand.

"Here we go," Pyet said, nodding at Izzy as the rest of the team stepped back and waited.

"Hey, Emma, it's Izzy," she said, feeling silly. "You've been hurt but that's alright, you're getting taken care of. Finn and I are both here. I just… I hope you're hearing me. It feels weird talking to you like this." Izzy took a deep breath as she went on. "You know,

I never would have thought I'd be like this, worried about you like this, because of how we used to be but I think of you not being in my life now and it scares me so badly."

Izzy choked on her words and tried to speak but couldn't. She looked at Finn and they hugged her tight as they began to talk.

"Hey, Emma, Finn here. I don't know what I'm supposed to say and you know me, that's a rare moment. Come on up here and talk with us I guess. You can choose the subject, whatever you want," Finn said and Izzy reached up and squeezed their hand tight as they both saw her eyes start to flutter and she started to move on the bed.

"Yeah, Emma, that's a great idea. Pick a subject," Izzy said and gave a choked laugh. "Mara knows that I've subjected you to enough data dumps, it's your turn."

Emma's eyes opened and one of the healers quietly stepped over to look at the pupils as Emma started to shift around on the bed, slowly at first and then violently. Izzy looked up at Pyet where she stood off in a corner. Pyet looked up from her data pad and made a motion indicating to keep going.

"Emma, it's alright, you're in a hospital but you don't have to worry, they're taking care of you. Can you… can you please come on back to us?" Izzy said as she took Emma's hand and gave it a soft squeeze. Emma's eyes snapped over to Izzy and she seemed to calm down a little but she didn't seem to be seeing anything

really as Emma’s eyes seemed to fight to focus. “Come on, Mom, come on back to me. Please.”

Emma shook her head, blinked, and tried to say something but her voice was a raspy croak that made no sense. Izzy felt like she was trying to say something to her and leaned in.

“What was that? I’m right here, try to say that again if you can,” Izzy said, gently squeezing Emma’s hand again. She was surprised as Emma clamped down on her hand but Izzy didn’t pull back. “Yes, that’s me. That’s me holding your hand, Mom. What were you trying to say?”

Emma tried to sit up but couldn’t manage and Izzy said, “It’s alright, just stay laying back. Can you hear me?”

Emma looked at her and Izzy felt like she was finally seeing her and then Emma croaked out, “No… not mom…”

Izzy almost sobbed in relief as she nodded and gently squeezed Emma’s hand again. “Yes. Yes, you are mom. You’re Mom, I’m not giving you the choice this time.”

Emma gave a crooked smile as she tried to sit up again but couldn’t quite make it as Izzy gave Emma's hand a gentle kiss, and held it to her heart.

“It’s alright, don’t try and sit up,” Izzy said as the healers began to check Emma again and Izzy saw Pyet smile as she looked up from her data pad. Izzy could feel Finn’s arms around her as she leaned forward. “I love you, Mom.”

Emma gave a crooked smile again as she lay back and croaked out, a little clearer this time, “Love you.”

And that’s when Izzy knew that no matter what, with all the horror going on across the world, with all the weight of responsibility on her shoulders, at least this was good.

Chapter End Notes

> Alright! That was a long one! I remember when I first wrote this, I almost didn't have Emma make it but I'm glad I kept her alive because that scene at the end puts tears in my eyes every time.
>
> Summary: Izzy briefly asked Glimmer how Micah is doing and Glimmer responds that she feels bad she just wishes it would be over with. The rest of the chapter is Cappe catching Bryce, telling Izzy, Finn, and Frosta about it and abdicating her position as the heir of Bright Moon. The Izzy briefly talks with Bryce before going to see Emma as she comes out of her coma. Izzy tells her that she's going to call her Mom from now on and Emma doesn't get a choice in it.

Capella

Chapter Summary

Capella faces Izzy, Finn, and Frosta.

Chapter Notes

"Now those memories come back to haunt me/ They haunt me like a curse / Is a dream a lie if it don't come true / Or is it something worse" The River by Bruce Springsteen

Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Capella walked down the hall, hoping she didn't run into anyone who actually knew Reave or worse, Reave herself. The bag she was carrying cut into her shoulder and as it shifted a little with her stride, she was once again surprised at just how heavy a little bot could be. She shook the image of the claw snipping at her face as she looked into the vent it had gone into and was just happy she'd already had her dagger in her hand to skewer it with.

Now, standing in front of the door to Emma's apartment, she wondered if what she was about to do was a good idea. When she'd heard the complaints about her flying around and seen the discussion about the problems, she'd been so sure about the abdication. It wasn't like she was ever going to really be a princess again in the sense of what she had been so to her, it seemed no problem at the time, and there was no way she wanted to inherit the throne of Bright Moon either. Gress had been hesitant about it even while he'd helped her dig up the information on how it worked. He'd tried to talk her out of it at

least twice. Coalfire, however, had nodded with acceptance almost immediately when she'd brought it up.

"That's not a bad idea. Good solution to that question I asked the other day," Coalfire had said when Capella had asked her. "Lot of people after you and I think a lot of them are just because you're the heir to Bright Moon. Can't have you running around out here like you are, both embarrassing the crown and risking the succession after all, so if you abdicate I bet that'll take the heat off you."

"I don't know," Capella said. "It might get Dark Moon off my case but then again, it might put them on me even harder."

"Naw, it's obvious the Queen just wants her good little heir back," Coalfire said, shaking her head. "Do this and I bet they'll go away."

Capella had sat and thought about it before finally saying, "You think so?"

"I'd put good money on it," Coalfire said and even though Capella hadn't realized it at the time, that had settled it for her.

This is the final cut, Capella thought, standing in front of the door. *The old life falls away and I'm what I am, Capella of nowhere in particular.*

She'd bought some good paper and sealing wax. She'd written out the abdication based on a copy of Angella's when she'd formally given up the throne after she'd returned so as to avoid conflict with Glimmer. Her's hadn't gone as far as Capella's was doing however. She made sure to include severing any connection to her title and then signed it in front of some witnesses who she'd then paid to keep quiet about it until necessary. Alice had melted the sealing wax and put it on the document for her and then Capella had pushed her thumb carefully into it, being sure that her print was clear and legible.

"There, sealed," Capella had said with a nod. Alice had looked at her a little oddly, Dio had just raised her mug at her, and Coalfire had placed a hand on her shoulder and squeezed it in a brief gesture of comfort.

Capella had kept a casual attitude when she'd sealed it. However, that was laid over a core of her that was screaming and crying. She knew it was the best idea to do this but it was just one more loss, one more thing she was stepping away from.

Now as she knocked at the door to Emma's apartment she felt herself settle into composure. Reave's features, that had taken a little bit of hanging around the greenhouses to see, were sad but not overly so. There was a brief pause and when no one came, she knocked again.

What if no one's here? Oh Mara, what if Reaves inside!? she thought and then the door opened a little and she saw Izzy looking out at her. *Here we go.*

"Uh… hello," Capella said with the voice she'd practiced. "You must be Emma's daughter, Izzy. I'm Reave, her… well, girlfriend feels silly to say at my age but that."

Izzy opened the door a little more and said how Emma had mentioned her before and Capella fought to keep herself calm. She thought that Reave had never met Izzy from what she'd heard but what if she had since Izzy had arrived? What if this was a trap to get her inside? Capella knew she had to keep going though.

"I'm sorry, I know it's a bad time but I just… I've been to see her and I thought maybe she'd like a plant when she came back," Capella said and held up the plant she was carrying as if that was some kind of proof of who she was. "It'll be fine until she gets back. It doesn't require much care."

Capella gave a little internal sigh of relief as Izzy stepped back and opened the door and offered for her to go ahead and put the plant on the table in the hallway. Capella entered and couldn't help but notice that Izzy kept her heavy coat between her and "Reave" or that she was partially hidden behind the door, like she was expecting an attack. As she stepped in, she saw Frosta and Finn and gave a silent wish that neither would recognize her just yet. She shoved down the urge to hug them both, especially Finn. She'd loved Finn ever since she could remember and it hurt not to say hello.

As she went in, apologizing to Izzy for meeting her under such circumstances and setting the plant down, she noticed that Izzy's

hand was drifting towards the small of her back. She heard Izzy say, “Of course.”

She’s figured it out or always knew, Capella said but noticed that Frosta wasn’t moving in any threatening way and Finn was still just looking at her like they were trying to figure something out. *You were going to reveal yourself anyway, see if she could be trusted. Guess you’re doing it sooner rather than later.*

Capella dropped the voice as she said, “I just needed a way in to talk with you without causing a huge fuss. I’m not here to hurt you.”

Capella didn’t even flinch as Izzy drew a curved dagger. Capella’s dagger was essentially out of reach inside her coveralls but the brass knuckles she’d picked up recently were in a pocket within easy reach.

That’s not why you’re here, Capella said and dropped her illusion at Izzy’s insistence as she took in the room. She almost jumped though as Finn shouted out her name and started to come across the room. She had to fight to keep from going right over to Finn. *Not enemies maybe but not friends. Be careful.*

It was something Coalfire had said to her when she’d talked about how she was going to deliver the abdication and even though she didn’t like it, she had to admit it was good advice after she’d thought about it.

“No!” Izzy snapped out, warning Finn away. Capella almost teleported away right then at the tone in Izzy’s voice. It was one of fear for Finn but at the same time, one of terror for anyone who might hurt Finn. “How do I know it’s you?”

Capella had thought about how to prove herself and she knew exactly what to say. However, she paused, the memories of better times, times she didn’t have to have categories like not enemies but not friends for people. Finally she answered.

“You’ve bribed me with cookies twice in my life. Once with real cookies and once with metaphorical cookies,” Capella responded.

“Where did I tell you about the metaphorical cookies and who was with me?” Izzy said.

“It was in the Bright Moon gardens, specifically in the greenhouse,” Capella said and felt a wave of sadness wash through her. She remembered being there with her father, her mother, or Gress many different times. She’d had serious talks there, silly talks there, fun talks there, and sometimes just watching the stars from there with the people she had loved. She kept the sadness off her face though, so she thought, and went on. “And Harpi was with you.”

“Sorry. I just…,” Izzy started to say as she trailed off and lowered her dagger. Capella fully understood her defensiveness though.

“Don’t apologize. I understand,” Capella responded, keeping an eye on Izzy and was surprised when she heard Finn moving across the room and then grabbed her up in a hug. She didn’t even think about teleporting away at that moment. If Finn had told her at that moment that she was captured and it had all been a ruse, she would have cried and accepted it without question, just so she wouldn’t have to stop hugging her oldest friend. All of that flashed through her followed immediately by her forcing the feelings down as she heard Finn talk about how they’d all been worried about her. She carefully made sure to put her non-dominant arm around Finn in a hug, keeping the other free in case this was a ruse.

“I’m sorry. I have to figure out what’s going on,” Capella said to Finn as she stepped away from the hug.

“You know, I’m supposed to detain you on sight, Cappe,” Frosta said as she leaned against a wall with what Capella thought of as a calculating smile. “Technically so are you, Izzy.”

Capella was getting ready to teleport, her hand creeping towards the hidden brass knuckles, when Finn suddenly moved between her and Frosta.

“Aunt Frosta, don’t you dare,” Finn said. Capella managed to hide her shock that Finn would do such a thing when she saw Frosta pull out dark glasses and put them on and declare she didn’t see Capella. Capella listened to Izzy and Frosta joke back and forth for a moment and again felt the urge to just stay with them.

Maybe they aren't so bad, Cappe thought and then shoved that thought down. *No. Stay on task. You've got too much to do and you need to get out of here just in case they've signaled for someone.*

"Listen, I don't have time for this. Frosta, just stay over there. I have to get moving again and I have things to tell you," Capella said, forcing her voice into all business as she pulled out the crab bot and put it on the table. She tossed the bag to the side, something she'd nabbed out of a supply closet somewhere in the greenhouses. "That's one of the bots that did the attack."

Capella watched Izzy, all interest on the bot for the moment, go over and look at the bot and notice the stab mark in it. She looked back at Capella with a raised eyebrow.

"It was stuck in a vent trying to escape and when I found it, it attacked me," Capella said, her voice neutral but her heart thumping quicker at the fresh memory. Capella watched Izzy poke at it and talk about how it wasn't a Dryl bot and then dropped her next bit of information.

"Don't bother trying to figure it out from a busted bot," Capella said. "When I heard about this, I thought I could get out here and figure things out quicker. I was right. I didn't just find the bot; I found the person who did it."

"How do you know it's the right person?" Izzy said.

Capella remembered following the vent to the supply room and then to a small room with a man in it. She'd expected a fight. What she'd got was a man who'd tried to run and when she'd stuck her arm out sideways and caught him in the throat, knocking him down, he'd turned into a crying mess instead who'd started talking almost immediately. She knew she needed to keep her cards close to her chest though and just give basic information, as she'd learned the hard way.

"I followed another bot back where he was hiding. He was kind enough to tell me," Capella said with a shrug. "Well, kind enough after I gave him some incentive to do so."

The last bit seemed a bit much to her but she'd learned also to keep an intimidating presence. It's not that he'd needed any incentive to talk after all. She realized though how it'd sounded when she saw Finn's shocked face.

"Cappe! Tell me you didn't torture this person!"

Capella almost said of course she didn't but she didn't want to back down, even to Finn.

"Fine, if it makes you feel better, Finn, I didn't torture this person," Capella said in the best cold voice she could manage. Finn started to say her name and she cut them off.

“Enough, Finn,” Capella said and felt the frustration of her life come out. “You don’t know what’s going on out there and I don’t want to hear it right now. Like I said, I have a lot to tell you and I need to get going.”

“You don’t have to,” Izzy said softly and Capella gave a little faked snort because if she reacted like she wanted to at that moment, she’d cry instead and agree to stay. She put up more bravado and responded.

“I do because I’m not stupid,” Capella said and then thought of what she’d heard about Izzy and felt anger at her mother flare up. “I saw you were staying at Bright Moon after your little dust-up. Don’t. Go back to Dryl and keep yourself and Finn safe.”

“Cappe, we really need to have a long…,” Izzy started to say and Capella leaned into her anger.

“Stop, I don’t want to hear it! Now let me say what I have to say, alright!? Or do you just want me to leave?”

Izzy held her hands up and shook her head and Capella felt awful but she had to move on so she went on.

“This guy is tied up in an unused closet,” Capella said as she put her hand into her coveralls and grabbed the piece of paper she’d written the location down on. She managed to keep her hands steady as she set the paper in front of a picture of Izzy and Emma

in front of a clocktower somewhere. She looked away quickly as she said, “There’s the directions. He was pretty eager to talk when I cornered him so I think you’ll find out some interesting things. He’s got a bag with him. Mostly clothes but there were some invoices and what looked like other accounting stuff in there as well. Figured you’d want to see them so I left them."

Capella didn’t mention she’d taken some time to scan some of them and send them on to Alice but she didn’t think they’d needed to know that. Besides, she didn’t want to reveal who she was working with at all. Now she stood there realizing she only had one more thing she needed to do. Abdicate. She did her best to remain calm and stolid. She knew it was the best thing to do, she’d thought about it a lot after all, but now that the moment was there, she still wasn’t sure. Finally she just shrugged her shoulders and reached into the inner pocket in her coveralls again. Her fingers touched the fine paper that she’d bought in Bright Moon and she pulled the document out, forcing her hands to stay still and not shake.

“Cappe, what is that?” Finn said. “That looks…”

Capella said, “Like an official document? It is,” Capella said as she saw Izzy trying to peer closer. She held it out to Finn as she went on. “Or as close as I could make it. I don’t have my signet with me. It’s locked up in Bright Moon but I did some studying. My thumbprint should suffice.”

The image of her signet sitting in Bow’s safe next to his and Glimmer’s signets flashed through her mind and she forced herself to stay in the moment before she thought about the first time that her parents had shown her the one for her and what it meant.

She'd done enough brooding on that lately and she had to get through this. Then Finn stepped away with their hands behind themself.

"I love you too much to take what I think that is," Finn said to her.

Capella hadn't really counted on that. She figured she'd at least get Finn curious enough to take it from her hand. She puffed out a little breath of irritation and tossed the document next to the directions she'd already given them.

"Fine. I don't have to hand deliver it but I figured I would be here so why not," Capella said.

"What is it?" Frosta said.

"My abdication," Capella said and forced herself to remain calm. She began to speak what she'd practiced over and over. She could feel her voice became monotone but the words mattered, not in how she delivered them.

"Of my own free will, I, Capella of Bright Moon, renounce the title of the Princess of Bright Moon and any claim to the throne of Bright Moon, by either birthright or assignment, from this day forward. In doing so I recognize I give up all privileges and duties I may have or claim from said title under both the Etherian Charter or any other binding law on Etheria." Capella stopped, her

hand resting on the table beside her clenched into a fist before continuing. “The document is properly witnessed by several citizens of Etheria, signed by my own hand, and sealed with my imprint and done so free of unlawful duress. It is done. Long live the Queen.”

She’d managed to keep it together through the whole thing, her hand clenched in a fist to keep it from shaking as she recited. At the end though, she thought of why she was having to do this, why she was constantly fighting and ducking and hiding, and her emotions came out in her voice so strong she was surprised she didn’t catch fire from the anger. She saw Finn shocked into silence with a hand over their mouth, Frosta standing up with her eyes wide and mouth open, and Izzy started to take a step forward. Capella didn’t know if it was to say something or if it was involuntary but her eyes snapped towards Izzy and she stopped moving, her hands coming up as if to shield herself.

“Cappe, you don’t have to do this,” Capella heard Finn say. She was managing to keep herself under control, keeping her emotions in check, as she responded.

“I’ve seen the things people are saying about me and what I’m doing. I know what kind of pressure that’s probably putting on all of you and honestly, maybe… people will stop chasing after me so much if I’m not the heir to Bright Moon anymore. I make this decision free and unblinded,” Capella said, voicing what she’d been thinking when she’d made the decision, the last sentence being exactly what she’d said to Gress when he’d asked her if she was sure of what she was doing.

Then she thought of being the heir and Bright Moon and she felt anger pulse through her. She kept her outer composure except for her eyes. She knew her feelings were visible in her eyes as she said, "Mom will be mad but when haven't I been a disappointment to her?"

She watched Frosta shake her head as she said, "You're not a disappointment to your…"

"I didn't ask for your opinion, Princess Frosta," Capella shot back, fighting to keep herself from shouting. "Don't think you can weasel out of this by burning the document either. I'll be sending out a broadcast announcing my abdication here shortly and I'll make sure to tell everyone that Princess Frosta, Princess Izzy, and Princess Finn were witnesses to it."

"Cappe…," Finn started to say as they stepped forward to her. Capella saw them coming and wanted to step forward to meet them so badly she felt her stomach shaking. She knew exactly what she had to do though and she couldn't let herself fail in her duty. She teleported, just a few feet back, and stuck her back against the door.

"No! Stop! I've made this decision! You can't talk me out of it! I will solve who is behind this! I will find out what is going on and Mara help anyone who gets in my way!" Capella shouted out suddenly, doing everything she could to put her conviction into her voice. Then she looked at the three standing in the room and her shoulders suddenly sagged as she went on. "Just forget about me."

“Never. We love you. You’ll always have a place at my theater,” Finn said, shaking their head, and Capella knew Finn was telling her the truth.

“And in Dryl,” Izzy said and Capella wanted to believe her.

“And here,” Frosta said and Capella knew her Aunt Frosta wasn’t bluffing.

Capella looked at Frosta, thinking of playing in the snow with her as a child. She looked at Finn and thought of running around their theater with them as Finn showed her wonders. She looked at Izzy and thought about how Izzy had always treated her as an equal, never talking down to her. For a split second, she almost stepped forward and tore the document up. For a split second, she was ready to let it all go and let her guard down. For a split second, these things were so strong in her head it felt like they’d already happened.

I can’t, I can’t, I can’t, I can’t, Capella thought and with that in her head, she straightened her back, and teleported out.

Chapter End Notes

Nothing to say on this one except thank you for reading!

FYI, I will probably start posting chapters faster soon. I'm pretty close to the end.

Capella

Chapter Summary

Capella has newly abdicated and isn't sure what to do now.

Chapter Notes

"Oh lady, luck has led you here / And they're so twisted up / They'll twist you up, I fear" Wicked Little Town by Hedwig and the Angry Inch

Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Capella appeared in a small unused office off one of the main kitchens from her teleport. She had found the office when she'd teleported in, having learned that in large buildings, kitchens usually had a high degree of foot traffic and no one paid a lot of attention to others since they were busy paying attention to their own work. She was shaking as she made sure the door was still locked and pulled a small bag from where she'd stashed it under a desk. She quickly changed clothes, forcing herself to think slowly on what she had to do next and not dwell on what she had just done.

OK, clothes stashed… check the area to make sure you haven't left anything behind… make sure the dagger is well hidden… new illusion up… back straight… let's go, Capella thought to herself as she moved around the office and then out the door. With the illusion in place, she felt a little more detached from what had just happened. Working to think of herself as another person and keep her faked mannerisms in place helped calm her as she walked.

Capella wanted to teleport but she had started waiting to teleport out after something. If someone saw a person walk off, even if something had happened, they just saw a person walking off and Capella wasn't likely to use that facial illusion again so it just became a wild goose chase if anyone made a connection. However, if they saw that person disappear in a flash of purple sparkles, then they knew that was Capella or so she figured. Even if they saw that person go around a corner, the flash was still visible so she tried to be discreet and that's how she found herself standing next to a box when she heard someone say that Frosta was announcing an abdication and that Glimmer was on the way.

Capella knew she should have expected that and cursed herself for not thinking of it. She looked at the small box, saw the word cherries in the text on it, and grabbed it and started walking a little quicker with a determined stride like she had to get the box somewhere as soon as possible. People stepped out of her way and she took a corner and found herself in an empty banquet hall. She looked over her shoulder as the door to the kitchen shut behind her, the noise of it disappearing as the soundproof doors cut it off. She looked around, made sure no one was there, and then teleported.

Capella was a little unhappy with herself as she teleported for the first jumps because she hadn't put on heavy enough clothes and so the cold of the Kingdom of Snows seeped into her as she went. It wasn't long though before she was teleporting into the Whispering Woods and the cool of the winter evening was shockingly warm after the Kingdom of Snows. She took one last final teleport and stopped to look around. She wasn't where she thought she had been teleporting to and she couldn't figure out why she thought it looked familiar.

"There you are and I said berries, not cherries," Capella heard a voice say and almost teleported again when she saw Razz looking at her through her thick glasses. Then Capella realized she was still carrying the box of cherries. "Why do you have gauze on your face, Cappe?"

Capella looked at Razz, surprised for a moment that Razz could see through the spell but she went ahead and dismissed the spell. She was beginning to recognize the spot and was remembering now that Razz had said that Capella would be back there.

"Uh, sorry, cherries was what I could get my hands on," Capella said as she held the box out to Razz. Razz sniffed at the cherries as if in disdain but finally took the box from Capella and opened it up.

"You still have that gauze on your face," Razz said as she opened the box. Then her eyes lit up as she looked inside. "Oh, you brought glacier cherries! Why didn't you say so? Berries and she brings me glacier cherries… good decisions, good decisions."

Capella wondered what Razz was talking about with the gauze but she knew the spell was gone. Then when she heard Razz mention the cherries, she felt her stomach clench a little. Glacier cherries were fairly uncommon, even in the Kingdom of Snows, and the small box was not cheap.

I hope I didn't just get some poor kitchen worker in trouble for losing it, Capella thought as Razz tossed one in her mouth. Razz laughed as she held it in her mouth and blew out a fog of

condensed moisture from her breath from the cold of the cherry. Capella had to give a little smile as Razz's joy in the moment was contagious.

"Eat one," Razz said and held the box out to Capella. Capella took one out and looked at the bright red fruit with a blue undertone to it. She popped it into her mouth and the sweetness and cold of the fruit burst forth as she bit into it. A memory drifted up as she remembered sitting with her parents out in the gardens at Bright Moon during the heat of a Bright Moon summer evening, eating glacier cherries from a wooden bowl. They had done the same thing Razz had, holding the cherry in their mouth to blow out their condensed breath, and laughed as they did so. She could remember the wood grain of the bowl, the metal lattice work of the table, but most of all, she remembered the smiling faces of her mother and father.

Capella fought to clear the thought from her mind as she chewed and managed to repress the memory only for it to be replaced by another of a cherry flambe that Catra had made with glacier cherries and regular cherries at a birthday party for her. Catra had cooked them both together and the glacier cherries had offset the heat of the rest of the dish like ice cream normally would. She remembered laughing with Gress and Prickly Pear as they sat around the table eating the dessert. She felt like she could hear Bow's voice clear as day from the party as he told a joke and then Adora's laugh.

"Mara, why are you crying?" Razz said as she appeared into Capella's field of view and Capella realized she was looking down as tears fell from her eyes.

“I’m Capella, Razz,” Capella replied as she swallowed the cherry and wiped her eyes. “And I’m not crying. I’m alright.”

Capella felt Razz pat her on the arm as she said, “Yes you are. Come with me.”

Capella shook her head as she stepped back.

“No, I have to get going, really. Enjoy the cherries.”

“Nonsense, follow along,” Razz said as she tucked the box under her arm and started walking.

Capella couldn’t figure out why she followed instead of leaving. Maybe it was the kindness Razz showed. It was open and unguarded and she wasn’t used to that anymore. She counted Alice and Dio as friends but it was a sharp friendship and she had to always be thinking. Coalfire she could confide in but Coalfire was also always giving her advice on how to be careful and guard herself. With that and the teaching she did of magic to Capella, she still counted Coalfire as a friend but it was more like a friendly mentor than a true friend. Gress was someone she could trust but she hadn’t seen him since the day back at Wheatland and just talked through messages. So she followed Razz, listening to Razz patter along, speaking to people and places that Capella couldn’t see.

Razz walked into her little home in the woods and Capella followed her in, looking around. She'd never seen it before, although she'd heard Adora describe it before, and she felt like she could just sit down in there and stay forever. Razz began puttering around and soon handed Capella a steaming mug. She took a deep breath and smelled tea, cinnamon, cardamom, and ginger along with other spices she couldn't quite place.

"Drink it, don't smell it," Razz said with a laugh and Capella realized she'd just been sitting there lost in the scent. She took a sip and for a moment she felt tension she wasn't even aware of seeping out of her. Capella let out a long sigh as she leaned back against the wall.

"Thank you," Capella said but Razz didn't seem to hear her as she took the cherries out of the box they were in and placed them in a pottery bowl shaped like a bird.

"Of course, of course," Razz said absentmindedly as she settled into a chair. She looked at the door and said, "Swift Wind, what are you doing here? Why aren't you with Adora?"

Capella almost jumped to her feet as she looked towards the door but she didn't see Swift Wind. She carefully looked, wondering if perhaps the horse was outside but she still saw nothing as Razz went on.

"Oh, they're still fighting? Don't worry, they'll figure it out eventually," Razz responded.

Bow had tried to explain to Capella once what he thought was going on with her. He thought she existed in multiple time frames at once and Capella wondered when Razz was talking to at the moment.

Capella felt slightly spooked as Razz looked beside her at something that wasn't there in her timeframe as Razz said, "The little one doesn't look like either of you. Finn? That's a good name." Razz looked towards the door as if someone was standing there as she went on. "Why didn't they bring their partner? What do you mean they're only six? Nonsense. Are you sure?"

Razz nodded and kept looking at the door as Capella carefully drained her drink.

"Izzy? You're a princess? I don't think I've seen you before," Razz said as she got up and walked past Capella and circled a spot in the floor, looking up and down. "New princess you say? Didn't know they could make them. Finn, why are you laughing?"

Capella quietly sat her mug down, getting ready to quietly leave, when Razz's eyes suddenly focused on her.

"Don't leave that there," she said. "Here, I can put it up for you."

Capella jumped a little at the sudden attention and held the mug out.

"I really must be going," Capella said, against all her internal desire to stay right where she was, even if she felt a little confused. Razz didn't seem to pay any attention to her as she sat the mug down on a counter and Capella quietly went towards the door. Capella thought she heard Razz say something and looked at her. Razz stood in the middle of the room and was staring hard at Capella, tears streaking her face.

"Razz, are you ok?" Capella said as she turned all the way around. The tears came to a stop and Razz smiled as if nothing had happened.

"Of course! Razz has glacier cherries," Razz responded. "You go on your way now. Razz has things to do."

Razz made a shooing motion and Capella stepped out into the yard as she heard Razz start to hum to herself. She stood there for a long moment, not sure what to do, before finally taking out her data pad and calling Alice.

"Hey there. Coalfire was starting to get twitchy," Alice said, her feet up in a portable domed building where they were all staying in Plumeria. Capella heard Coalfire say something in the background that she couldn't make out but that made Alice grin. "Anyway, we saw you made your abdication. Princess Frosta announced it. You headed back?"

Capella looked over at Razz's little home and then back at the data pad.

"Yeah, I'm on my way," she responded.

Shortly afterwards, she was walking into the little domed building with an illusion back up on her face. Alice didn't even look up from where she was sitting in a moon chair. Capella made sure the door was shut and sat down on a low couch made from flat wood panels cleverly notched together. Capella had seen a Plumerian pull a similar one apart in about a minute or so and have it packed and ready to go. The futon mattress on top of it made it comfortable and she'd been sleeping there while they were in Plumeria.

Not that she'd been sleeping much though. They'd got a place near the Heart Blossom and the day after they'd settled in, Prickly Pear had returned from Bright Moon to set up shop there to help people in her new role as princess. Perfuma and Scorpia had been in and out with their large family and Capella worried about running into someone who knew her so she'd been keeping her illusion up almost the whole time.

"Where's Coalfire?" Capella said as she leaned back with a sigh.

"Just left," Alice said. "Dio's at another party and Half Ear is sulking somewhere. We still sending out that video? "

Capella thought for a moment and then said, “No. We may need to do some other kind if you’re saying they’re admitting to it. We’ll see what the boards say. If people are in doubt of it, then I’ll release one.”

Alice shrugged, still not looking up as she kept working. Capella wanted to talk with her, tell her what she was feeling at the moment, but she remembered what Coalfire had told her before, that she had to give the illusion of toughness even if she didn’t have it fully yet. Capella knew she couldn’t go on about how she felt both relieved she was no longer a princess but also saddened that it was just one more thing from her old life she’d lost in the long process she had been enduring.

Capella flipped around on her data pad for a little while. She’d been planning to go to Marasville for awhile but she kept finding a reason to not do so. She fiddled with that a little bit, looking up maps and ways to travel and things she might want to bring along but nothing really kept her attention long. Coalfire came in about the time she was heaving another sigh.

“For someone who managed to cut another tie holding them back, you seem pretty moody,” Coalfire said as she settled in a little folding chair by Capella.

“She’s been sighing like that since she got back,” Alice responded without looking up.

“I’m just bored,” Capella lied.

“I can imagine,” Coalfire said. “We’ve kind of stepped back our operation against the Children of Mara after all.”

“I’m going out to Marasville sometime soon,” Capella said. “Just got to think it through a little more since I’ll be dangling out there on my own.”

“You know we can still go,” Alice said without looking up. “We just don’t have to travel with you.”

“No, no,” Capella said, shaking her head. “Better if I teleport in and out. They’ll be more confused if they go looking for me.”

“More like they’ll be more likely to figure out exactly who it was,” Coalfire said. “It’s not a good idea for you to be out there running around on your own. You could get hurt. You know there’s a price circulating for you, right?”

“Yes, I know. You keep bringing it up,” Capella said, her anger starting to rise. She shoved it back down. It wouldn’t help her and as Coalfire had pointed out, the sparkles that came with it sometimes were a dead giveaway of her identity.

“Just trying to keep you safe,” Coalfire said and the way she said it grated right down Capella’s spine.

“Yeah, don’t I know it,” Capella said, hopping to her feet.

“Hey, easy there,” Coalfire said. “Take a breath. I’m your friend, remember? We both are.”

Coalfire nodded towards Alice and Capella started to say something but just shut her mouth and left the room, trying her best not to stomp. It was almost second nature for her now to bring up the illusion whenever she left a room and she had it up before she even had her hand on the door and then she was out and walking through the night.

The trees towered over her as she walked down a wide dirt path that wound its way around, and in a few cases through, the trunks of the trees. Capella could see little colored lights out in the forest and she knew that some of them were the portable dwellings of Plumerians formed up in little clusters with their friends and family but some of them were little lights of the forest and it bothered her for some reason she couldn't place that she couldn’t always tell them apart. As she walked, she found herself playing an old game her tutor, Raskin, had taught her. She picked a color and then began to watch for it in the landscape and followed where she saw it.

As she walked, it made her think about her old life, her gone life, and she almost stopped at first but the practice was strangely relaxing. She wandered through the little paths of the forest, watching the twinkling lights in the darkness, following colors on trees, trunks, rocks, and the little lights and after walking for about half an hour, she came to a spot in the path where it joined

with two others in a little circular area. A little fountain in the center where the paths all converged, surrounded by jumbled stone and made to look like a natural pool, burbled away and a little twisting tripod that looked like three branches had conveniently fell over the pool held a small lantern that dimly lit the area. Next to the path, in one enormous tree, someone had created a bench among its outstretched roots.

Capella sat down on the polished living wood of the bench and stared at the fountain splashing away in the darkness. The light didn't do much except accentuate the shadows that Capella was sitting in and she took a moment to try and figure out how she felt. The only feeling she could dig up was tired. She was staring at her hands, thinking about not much in particular, when she heard footsteps on the path. She didn't even bother to look up, too tired to deal with someone, and besides she knew her disguise was firmly in place. Then a voice spoke and she had to use every ounce of control to keep from jumping to her feet.

"I didn't see you sitting there for a moment," Prickly Pear remarked. "Are you OK?"

Capella looked up to see her friend standing by the fountain, her light blonde hair tied back. At first Capella didn't notice the shadows under her eyes, figuring they were just from the dim light but they were definitely there.

"I'm fine," Capella said, immediately shifting to one of her voices she'd practiced. "Just having a little walk."

Prickly Pear nodded but didn't make any move to go on her way and Capella carefully looked around into the trees to make sure no one was hiding in ambush.

Am I going to run into everyone today? Is this some twisted mind game? Capella thought. After a little bit of quiet, Capella spoke up again.

"Um… are you… are you OK?"

Prickly Pear just kind of shrugged, not really looking at Capella, and Capella was struck by how withdrawn the woman she'd always known as bubbly and outgoing seemed. Thinking back to just a moment before, Capella realized Prickly Pear asking if she was alright seemed almost rote, not really sincere.

How would just some random person react? Capella thought.

"Hard taking over from your mom?" Capella said and only just managed to keep her voice level.

Prickly Pear looked over at her as she said, "It kind of is, yeah."

"I'm visiting," Capella said. "I'm from Erelandia originally and I have to say, you seem to be running a pretty good kingdom here."

Prickly Pear gave a polite smile as she said, “Thank you.”

The two lapsed into silence again and Capella wondered just how long before she could leave when Prickly Pear said, “Can I ask you a question?”

“Sure,” Capella responded.

“Have you ever had to do something that you knew was right but you were afraid?” Prickly Pear said. “Maybe not afraid but… you get what I’m saying, right?”

Capella looked at her for a long moment, trying to figure out what she was trying to say, before she finally said, “Yeah, of course. I mean, probably not like you, I just work for a candy company. There’s not a lot of hard moral choices with gummy candy but sure, I know what you’re saying. I’ve been there.”

“What did you do?” Prickly Pear said.

Capella faked a nonchalant shrug as she said, “The best I could do. Brave, strong, you know how the song goes.”

Prickly Pear scowled a little before catching herself and getting her face neutral again.

“That song…,” Prickly Pear said before cutting herself off.

“What’s wrong?” Capella said, suddenly interested in what seemed so unlike Prickly Pear.

“Nothing,” Prickly Pear said as she shut herself off.

“I thought Plumerians were supposed to be talkative,” Capella found herself teasing.

Prickly Pear looked at Capella and for a brief moment Capella caught a glance of anger and Capella held her hands up.

“Sorry, just trying to be funny,” she replied.

“I know it’s a good song but I hate trying to live up to that,” Prickly Pear said. “Trying to live in a parent’s shadow… two of them in fact. I love my mothers but ever since I knew I was going to take this title, I’ve been wondering if I was going to live up to it. Having to sit back and… sorry, I didn’t mean to dump like that without asking if you were ready to receive it.”

A little voice was shouting at Capella to see what in the world Prickly Pear was talking about. Capella leaned forward a little as she said, “No, it’s alright. I’m ready to receive it. What’s going on?”

“I just… listen, what’s your name?” Prickly Pear said as she came over to the bench. Capella scooted over, nervous as Prickly Pear sat down beside her but hiding it well, as she answered.

“Hodge,” she said.

Prickly Pear nodded as she said, “Nice to meet you, Hodge. I’m Prickly Pear. I guess you knew that but…”

Capella nodded as she said, “It’s nice to formally meet you.”

Prickly Pear shrugged as she began to nervously twine together several thin vines from the tips of her fingers. Capella didn’t think anything of it but suddenly remembered she was supposed to be meeting her for the first time and gave a little gasp.

“Oh, wow, that’s pretty cool,” Capella said, nodding at the vines.

Prickly Pear looked up at her and then down at her hands before blushing a little and waving them away.

“Sorry, I didn’t even realize I was doing that,” she said. “It’s what I do when I’m nervous.”

“Well, is there something you wanted to tell me?” Capella said.

Prickly Pear looked around the little area for a moment as if making sure no one was around before leaning towards Capella.

“Can you keep a secret?” Prickly Pear said.

Capella, behind her illusion and with a faked voice, said, “I think I can.”

Prickly Pear nodded as she said, “You heard about what happened in the Princess Council the other day?”

Capella said, “Do you mean that thing with, you know, the Princess of Dryl?”

She had only remembered to not say Izzy’s name, as she would have said it as Iz, at the last second but Prickly Pear didn’t notice as she nodded.

“Do you know anything about the whole clone issue and the attacks and all that?” Prickly Pear said.

“A bit. I know Erelandia tried some stupid stuff around it a little while ago but they backed off,” Capella said as she sat her left

hand down out of sight and dug her thumbnail into the side of her hand to keep her face steady as she went on. “Heard about that mess out at Wheatland of course.”

Prickly Pear held her hands in her lap and gently smoothed out her skirt as she said, “Yeah, that.”

They sat quietly, both of them not looking at the other as they watched the water in the fountain jet up and then splash down into the little pool.

“Does that not ever freeze?” Capella said, just to break the awkward quiet.

Prickly Pear shook her head as she said, “It doesn’t get cold enough here normally to freeze moving water.” She sighed as she went on. “I guess this is the secret part. I don’t know why I’m going to tell you this but I gotta tell someone.”

“Hey, you don’t have to,” Capella said, her voice almost slipping into her normal voice as she looked at Prickly Pear. “If it makes you… you know, uncomfortable. We can just hang out.”

Prickly Pear looked at her with a sad smile.

“I appreciate you speaking from the heart and trying to keep me from facing an uncomfortable moment but I have to speak,”

Prickly Pear said. “You’ve heard that the crown princess has… well, she’s not the princess anymore but what I’m trying to say is, you know she’s kind of disappeared?”

Capella’s heart started thumping as her stomach clenched. She did her best not to look around, knowing how suspicious that would look and just said, “Yeah, I heard but what do you mean she’s not a princess anymore?”

Prickly Pear looked away from Capella and blinked hard a few times as she said, “She abdicated today. I guess you haven’t heard about it.”

Capella did her best to look shocked as she said, “I hadn’t! Is that the secret?”

Prickly Pear shook her head as she said, “No. My Aunt Frosta announced it to everyone. I guess Cappe showed up there long enough to do that.”

Capella slowly nodded as she said, “That’s… wow. That’s just surprising.”

Prickly Pear raised a hand for a moment as if to say something and then just shrugged and said, “It was but I guess it’s what she thought was right but the secret is something else.”

Again it was quiet and Capella wanted to reach out and put her hand on Prickly Pear's hand and tell her it would be alright but she held back. She didn't want to make contact with her because she knew she couldn't handle it. She still remembered Finn hugging her earlier and how she almost gave up right then and there. She had to remember that Marasville was still in her future and whatever lay beyond that.

Finally Prickly Pear went on as she said, "I guess this is the secret. My kingdom is neutral in all of that mess. Neutrality is something Mom decided with Mom back when they first got together, that their two kingdoms would be neutral and open to all. A little while ago someone, a clone I met, told me that there is a point where our neutrality ends up just helping those who hate him and wanted to know when it would change."

Prickly Pear again went quiet and stared off into the darkness and the little twinkling lights as Capella tried to keep herself composed. She remembered that moment. It had been at her birthday party at her Aunt Adora and Aunt Catra's house and it had been Laho that had said it. She remembered that evening, when she'd got her dagger, when the world had seemed like nothing bad could happen after the victory at Seaweed, and when she had friends around her.

"That's your secret? That you worry about how your neutrality will fare in the face of this?" Capella said, trying to keep the disappointment out of her voice.

Prickly Pear looked at her and for a brief moment green flashed across her eyes and Capella's breath caught in shock at the look on Prickly Pear's face before she managed to calm down.

“No. The secret is I want to take the kingdom, my kingdom, out of our neutral stance,” Prickly Pear said. “In a way, I already have but not in a public way. I want to live what I feel is the truth I see within myself. That neutrality matters for keeping peace but the peace is gone and at this point, I’m beginning to think that staying silent simply gives those who would stomp on others our unspoken approval.”

Capella’s eyes widened as Prickly Pear ran her hand back through her hair, flowers and thorns sprouting from it and breaking the tie that held it back.

“I want to fight, Hodge. I’ve spoken with… well, others, and they feel the same way. Cappe was the youngest of us and she stepped out to do what had to be done. I miss her more than I can say and I think she’s not making the best choices but I firmly believe she’s following her heart,” Prickly Pear said. “I want to follow my heart as well.”

Capella didn’t know what to say and she watched as Prickly Pear seemed to deflate a little when Capella didn’t speak.

“Sorry, I didn’t mean to freak you out,” Prickly Pear said.

Capella’s mind was running a mile a minute. She felt like it was a trap. She felt like Prickly Pear was being sincere. She thought about what to say and couldn’t come up with anything for a moment as she ran through a bunch of options. Finally she said,

“You didn’t freak me out. I’m just shocked you’d confide that in me.”

Prickly Pear said, “Mom has told me before that life is like a flowing river and it takes us where it wants you to go. You can control where you’re going, mostly, but sometimes that river takes us into the path of someone and that’s for a reason. When I walked here tonight and saw you sitting there, I just had a feeling that maybe I should tell you. I wasn’t sure why but… well, I did.”

“Thank you for trusting me with this,” Capella said. “For what it’s worth, I think you’re making the right choice.”

Prickly Pear smiled as she said, “Thank you, Hodge. I thought so but it’s good to have it affirmed.”

Capella stood up as she said, “Listen, thank you for this but I do have to go. I promise, I’m not running off because of what you said.”

Prickly Pear nodded as she stood and said, “Of course. I understand.”

She began to step forward with her arms wide and Capella took a step backwards.

“Oh, I’m sorry. I forgot not everyone is as huggy as we Plumerians,” Prickly Pear said. “I should have asked first.”

“It’s alright,” Capella said, just wanting to get out of there before she did something stupid and blew her cover. “How about a handshake? Split the difference?”

Prickly Pear smiled as she nodded and held out her hand. Capella took her hand and gave it a shake, looking straight into Prickly Pear’s eyes and happy that she’d be away soon.

“Have a good evening,” Capella said with a smile, one that felt real for once. “It was good to meet you.”

“I feel the same. Thanks for listening,” Prickly Pear said.

Capella let go of Prickly Pear’s hand and was starting to walk away when Prickly Pear spoke up again.

“I’m over by the Heart Blossom if you ever want to come hang out,” Prickly Pear said.

Capella stopped right at the edge of the lamp light, half in and out of shadow, as she looked down the path that would lead her back to where she was staying. The words “Hang out” echoed in her head and she thought of the time she’d spent with Prickly Pear growing up. Games and pranks, and even stupid, pointless

adventures like the time they'd explored a cave together and Capella had gotten her trapped in that cave. She'd then managed to rescue Prickly Pear at the same time but it had still been stupid. They'd always talked and while they'd never been as close friends as her and Gress, she was a friend.

I have something I have to do though, Capella thought as she began to take a step forward and then suddenly turned around.

"Can I ask you something?" Capella said.

"Sure," Prickly Pear said.

"Why were you out here again?" Capella said.

"Just walking. I know it's kind of late but I find the night woods very relaxing," Prickly Pear said.

Capella looked around one last time and then took a deep breath.

"I'm going to trust you with a secret as well," she said and then twitched the tip of her little finger, dropping her illusion. At first Prickly Pear didn't get it and then suddenly realized what she was looking at and gasped, covering her mouth.

“Cappe?” she said, barely above a whisper and Capella watched as tears formed in her eyes.

“Uh… yeah, it’s me,” Capella said, shifting uncomfortably as she kept flicking her eyes around to be sure no one else was around.

Prickly Pear took a hesitant step forward before stopping and saying, “It’s really you?”

“Yeah, it’s me. I’ll prove it. We went to the Half-Moon Cave without telling anyone and I rescued you after getting you stuck in it,” Capella said. “You grew a thin little vine through the rocks you slipped under and I pulled you out that way.”

“No, I wasn’t asking you to prove it,” Prickly Pear said as she started to walk forward and then stopped again. “I just… I’ve had dreams where you show up again and I’m always so sad when they’re just dreams.”

“It’s not a dream, P-Pear,” Capella said, her heart thumping so hard, as she waited for something bad to happen. Prickly Pear took a few more tentative steps forward and Capella took one back and then suddenly Prickly Pear had her in a tight hug and Capella was hugging her back as they both cried.

A few minutes later, Capella and Prickly Pear had stepped into the woods to be out of sight. A tight screen of trees shielded them from view of the trail as Capella sank down into a comfortable

chair that Prickly Pear made from woven willow. Prickly Pear sat right across from her, Capella's hand still in her hand and suddenly Prickly Pear gave a little laugh.

"What's so funny?" Capella said, her nerves jumping as she looked around again.

"You waiting for me in the shadows," Prickly Pear said. "Very clever of you. You really are what they're saying about you."

"I wasn't waiting for you," Capella said. "I was feeling out of sorts and went for a walk. This really was a coincidence; the only reason I was waiting in the shadows was because that lantern isn't bright enough to light the bench well. Wait… what are they saying about me?"

"Oh, I guess you might not have heard," Prickly Pear said. "They're calling you the Queen of Shadows and Smoke because of how you kind of appear and disappear from places."

Capella remembered Cowrie saying that on the ship and sat back a little in the chair.

"Who started that?" Capella said, carefully looking at Prickly Pear to watch her reaction.

“I don’t know,” Prickly Pear responded. “Cowrie was talking about it the last time we got together.”

Capella hung her head a little as she nodded, trying not to think too hard about all the little get-togethers she used to attend.

“Did she say where she’s hearing it from?”

“No, just that she’d heard it,” Prickly Pear said. “Why are you asking though?”

Capella looked up at her and said, “I heard it the other day. I’m not sure where it’s coming from and honestly, I think someone might be trying to trick me with it.”

“I don’t think anyone is trying to trick you,” Prickly Pear replied. “I think people are just impressed with what you’re doing and wanted to give you a name.”

Capella shook her head and looked around again with a little wry smile as she thought about how she used to be naive like Prickly Pear still was.

“No, something I’m figuring out is that people usually have a hidden angle that you have to figure out. Especially when they want something from you,” Capella said.

“No, that’s not right,” Prickly Pear said. “Most people are kind.”

Capella thought of her mother and Dark Moon and scowled, taking her hand out of Prickly Pear’s hand as she said, “No, they aren’t. They might give that kind of front, keep it up for years even, but they aren’t. You can’t trust anyone fully.”

Prickly Pear's face fell as she said, “Cappe, that’s not true. You can trust me. You did trust me! You let me know it was you and now here we are, talking.”

Capella crossed her arms as she shook her head and said, “Well, that might be a mistake. I guess I’ll see if that little bit of trust is going to bite me or not.”

“If you feel that way, why did you stop and reveal yourself? I didn’t know who you were, you could have just kept walking,” Prickly Pear said. “I think you’re lonely and you want to reach out to someone.”

Capella fought down her anger as she said, “You’re not a Listener so stop trying to talk like one. You don’t know what I’ve gone through, what I’ve learned.”

“You’re right, I’m not a Listener, I’m your friend and if you’ve gone through something then tell me about it. Talk it out with me,”

Prickly Pear said.

Capella gave a little humorless laugh as she said, “You wouldn’t understand.”

“Of course I wouldn’t because you won’t share it. This isn’t like you, Cappe. You never held back your feelings before,” Prickly Pear said.

Capella started to say something and then held back, not wanting to reveal her problems.

“It is me and you just have to accept it,” Capella said and started to stand up. Prickly Pear sighed and sat back.

“And so you run away again to hide while the rest of us deal with the fallout.”

Capella looked at Prickly Pear, the sheer weariness and irritation in her voice shocking Capella. It was so out of character for Prickly Pear and Capella wasn’t sure what to say. Then the anger came, the sparkles fell from her hair, and she started talking.

“Hide!?” Capella said. “Do you have any idea what I’ve been dealing with? I’ve been dealing with not only the fallout of being accused of a murder I didn’t do but every other thing that my enemies can get thrown at me! Do you have any idea how many

towns I’m currently wanted in!? Some of them I’ve never even stepped foot into but they say I’ve done all kinds of mayhem! You think I don’t know what kind of fallout is coming about from what I’m doing!? I can’t even go for a walk in the woods without putting up an illusion! You don’t know what you’re talking about, you pretentious little twit!”

Capella pulled back her left sleeve and held up her arm, showing Prickly Pear the scar that ran up it.

“Do you see that? I got that because I was trying to talk to someone! I was sitting in a chair just like we both are right now and they pulled a knife and tried to stick it in my chest! I put my arm in the way and that’s what happened! Run away and hide! You’re the one out here hiding, tending your little plants and telling your secrets to people alone in the woods because you’re too damn scared to do anything meaningful!” Capella said.

Prickly Pear looked back at her, her face calm as she watched Capella and Capella for a brief moment thought about smacking her.

“Say something, you coward! Anything!” Capella shouted at her.

“You just told me some of your problems you’ve been having and you did it without holding back, even if I did have to poke at you a little to get you to talk,” Prickly Pear said and Capella’s mouth fell open as she realized what Prickly Pear had done.

“You… you tricked me,” Capella whispered. Then she did her best to shove her anger down, realizing that giving it free reign had made her say things she shouldn’t have.

“If you want to look at it like that,” Prickly Pear said. “I just saw the Cappe I remember though, even if she was angry at me. What I see you doing now is trying to reel it back in. You’re right, I’m not a Listener but I grew up with them and I know the little techniques they use to get people talking and I know how to read people. Maybe it just reinforces your belief that people can’t be trusted but Cappe, you’re my friend and I just want to help.”

Capella stopped for a moment and thought about what she’d said and what Prickly Pear had said. She thought about what she’d told her and realized that it wasn’t like she’d said anything that gave a bunch of stuff away. She had tricked her though and she tried to decide if it was time to get out or not.

“What are you going to do when I leave?” Capella said.

“If you don’t trust me, what does it matter what I tell you?” Prickly Pear replied.

Capella started feeling suspicious as she said, “This isn’t like you.”

“Yeah, well, you haven’t seen me in awhile. We’ve both changed it would seem,” Prickly Pear said.

Capella suddenly realized that she'd proved who she was but she hadn't had Prickly Pear verify herself and now she was in a dark place all alone with just this person.

"Who are you?" Capella said, her hand sliding into her pocket for her brass knuckles.

"I'm P-Pear," Prickly Pear said, her face a little confused at the question.

Capella pulled her hand out of her pocket, the brass bright across her knuckles, as she said, "Prove it."

Prickly Pear looked down for a moment and a tear formed in her eye as she said, "I guess you want to know something only you and I would know?"

Capella nodded and Prickly Pear started to speak and then suddenly shook her head, her face becoming determined as she looked back up.

"No. I won't play that game. Either you trust me enough to take me at face value as we talk, as you were doing for a moment, or you don't trust me. I won't try and jump through hoops for you," Prickly Pear said.

Capella sighed and teleported out. She appeared on the path not too far from her temporary home and stood there for a moment as she quickly dropped an illusion into place and stuck the brass knuckles in her pocket. Then a little moment of irritation made her suddenly teleport back. Prickly Pear jumped as Capella appeared right back where she'd left from and let out a little squeak as Capella dropped the illusion again.

"What game are you trying to play with me, Plant Girl!? You get me happy to see you, then you get me mad, then you refuse to identify yourself, and it occurs to me that you're just messing with my head! Why!?" Capella said as Prickly Pear's face went through shock, fear, surprise, and then finally settled down to determined again.

"I'm not playing a game with you, Cappe," Prickly Pear said. "I'm just trying to help my friend. You can insult me all you want; I don't care. You know why? That means you're here in front of me doing it. Maybe that's not healthy for me but I don't care because I have my friend here for a moment."

Capella shook her head as she said, "No, you've got an angle. There's always an angle."

"Does Gress have one?" Prickly Pear said. "People suspect you keep in touch with him although he's never said so."

"Don't," Capella said, stepping forward to loom over her.

“Or what? Are you going to hurt me?” Prickly Pear said. “Is that why you’re trying to be threatening to me?”

“Don’t try and undermine my friendship with Gress,” Capella said, her voice tough as she stepped back a little and felt ashamed for trying to do exactly what Prickly Pear had said.

“I’m not! I’m trying to point out that he doesn’t have an angle! He’s your friend! So am I!” Prickly Pear said, gesturing with her hands in irritation.

Capella shook her head as she tried to think clearly and sat down in the willow chair.

“P-Pear… ok, listen, you don’t get it. Yes, it’s probably you but do you not understand… I just…. I just can’t *trust* you. I’d be out of my mind to do so. Do you not know about the whole Dark Moon thing?” Capella said. “Or that someone has put a price on my head? That if you’re really the head of your kingdom you’re supposed to be detaining me?”

“Wait… Dark Moon? That’s what you’re worried about?” Prickly Pear said. “They’re not real.”

Capella blinked once and then hung her head as she gave a tired laugh.

"P-Pear, yes, they very much are and you trying to deny it is not making me feel more comfortable," Capella said as she brought her head up. "I've *seen* them, multiple times. I know who some of them are by name. In Wheatland, they knew the passphrase my Bright Moon guard used to ID themselves. They killed at least one of my friends and tried real hard on the rest of them. This is what I mean when I say you don't get what's going on!"

"Do you really think that Aunt Glimmer, your *mother,* would do something like that?" Prickly Pear said.

"I don't have to! I saw it happen! I'd love to say otherwise but I saw it!" Capella said.

Prickly Pear sat back in her chair, looking at Capella as she very quietly said, "You doubt and question everything else in your life but you won't doubt that?"

"I was there," Capella said.

Prickly Pear sighed as she said, "OK, I won't argue it with you. Is there something you need? Something I can help you with?"

"Like what?" Capella said.

"I don't know. I told you that I want my kingdom involved or at least me," Prickly Pear said. "What do you need?"

Capella wasn’t sure how to take that. She kept turning over the request but she just wasn’t sure what her angle was to even ask such a thing. Finally, she slowly nodded.

“You really want to help?” Capella said, leaning forward.

“I do,” Prickly Pear replied.

“Then I ‘m going to tell you something, something that only a few people know and I want you to keep it to yourself,” Capella said.

Prickly Pear nodded a little as she said, “And you’re going to see if I tell someone you don’t trust and see what happens.”

Capella’s mouth opened a little in surprise because that had been her exact plan.

“Uh, no! That’s… seriously!?” Capella responded.

“I told you I won’t play a game with you like that,” Prickly Pear said.

Capella huffed in irritation and a little smile played across Prickly Pear's lips.

"What? Why are you smiling?" Capella said.

"Because that little huff was so much like the old Cappe. It was good to see," Prickly Pear said.

Capella leaned back in the chair, staring out at the little twinkling lights playing in the distance of the forest. She wasn't sure what to do at that moment. She knew she should leave, she knew she shouldn't be trusting Prickly Pear but she remembered a moment in the cave years before, when she was sure that she'd gotten Prickly Pear killed but had known she couldn't just give up and the feeling she was having, of just not wanting to let it go, felt similar.

"How come you never see the twinkling lights close up?" Capella asked absentmindedly, nodding at them.

Prickly Pear looked over her shoulder at them and shrugged.

"Well those are the lights of the Tremuloides family's camp but I know what you mean. It's a magical discharge from the plants. It doesn't happen around people and when you see it, you know no one is in that area. That's why you don't see it near the paths. Too many people walking through," Prickly Pear replied.

Capella looked at Prickly Pear and quietly said, “I’m sorry I tried to threaten you earlier.”

“Thank you for apologizing,” Prickly Pear. “So, does this mean you trust me?”

“No, I don’t,” Capella said, shaking her head.

“But you’re still here,” Prickly Pear said. “I heard that you bailed on Finn, Izzy, and Aunt Frosta earlier.”

Capella shrugged as she said, “Yeah, I’m still here. Make of it what you will I guess.”

“I think you enjoy having a friend around,” Prickly Pear said.

Capella nodded as she said, “Well, I said make of it what you will.”

“I’ll just take this moment as it comes and be happy that you may not trust me but you still are here with me,” Prickly Pear replied.

Capella shrugged and let the silence carry on for a little while. She thought about what Coalfire would say when she got back, she wondered what accusation Half-Ear would make, she wondered if

Alice would even notice she'd been gone, and she wondered if Dio had even made it back yet from her party to even notice.

Maybe I'll just say I was out partying like Dio, Capella thought with a little snort.

"Something funny?" Prickly Pear said.

"Thinking of something," Capella said and then she suddenly had an idea. "You really want to help?"

"As I keep saying, yes," Prickly Pear said with a little grin.

Capella rolled her eyes as she thought through what she was about to say.

"OK, fine. I'm going to get you involved and Mara help you. I am going to tell you something that a lot of people suspect but few know for sure. Yes, I stay in contact with Gress. We message each other multiple times a day. I want you to contact him and tell him you talked with me. He's not going to believe you. Tell him…," Capella said and trailed off as she tried to think of something. Then she noticed the twinkling lights again. "Tell him, 'The forest shows its lights when no one is around.' He'll tell you, 'You sure that's not just someone's home?' and that's how you know it's him. You got that?"

“Cappe… what are you talking about?” Prickly Pear said.

Capella sighed as she threw her head back for a moment and then looked at her again as she said, “It’s a passphrase that I just made up and I’ll tell Gress later. I know you don’t want to play games as you said but I’m trying to get you into this like you want and you have to be careful and I can 100% guarantee that Gress won’t talk to you if you don’t do it. Got it?”

Prickly Pear frowned as she said, “OK. Why am I contacting Gress?”

“You’re going to be part of my network and Gress is the idea person. He’ll probably ask you a bunch of questions and try to figure out what you can do,” Capella said. “Are you sure you want to do this?”

Prickly Pear didn’t hesitate as she said, “Yes, I am.”

“Well, I still don’t trust you but I’ve learned that we can still work together sometimes,” Capella said. “So what do you tell Gress?”

Prickly Pear blushed a little as she said, “Uh… I don’t remember.”

Capella tried not to sigh, failed, and said, “You say, ‘The forest shows its lights when no one is around’ and Gress will respond

back with ‘You sure that’s not just someone’s home?’ If he does not say that, you *do not* talk to him. Got it?”

“Yes, I say, ‘The forest shows its light when no one is around’ and he will tell me, ‘You sure that’s not someone’s home?’ And don’t talk to him if he doesn’t say that back,” Prickly Pear said, as if reciting a lesson. “But what if…”

Capella cut her off and said, “Nope. No what ifs. Just like that. Say it to me again so I know you remember.”

Prickly Pear recited it a few more times until Capella was sure she had it down.

“OK, I’m going to go on now,” Capella said. “Gress and I will talk once you’ve talked with him and we’ll figure something out that you can help with.”

The two stood up and stared at each other.

“It was good to see you again, Cappe,” Prickly Pear said. “Thank you for trusting me.”

“I’m not,” Capella said and then shook her head with a little laugh. “But I guess I am, sort of. We’ll see how it turns out. It was good to see you too, P-Pear.”

Capella reached forward and pulled Prickly Pear into a hug before teleporting away. She had her illusion up when she walked back into where she was staying and Half Ear was there with the rest.

"She finally returns," he replied. "Probably off trying to see if there's any good prices on us she can cash in on."

Capella felt the little bit of happiness she had from talking with Prickly Pear burn away as she growled out, "OK, I'm sick of you. Shut your damn mouth, back it up with steel right now, or get out and don't come back."

Dio sat up from where she was sprawled out on a futon, Alice raised her head from where she was sitting, and Coalfire raised an eyebrow. Half Ear's eyes were wide and then he laughed.

"Whatever, Princess, I just…," Half Ear started to say when Capella reached up into her clothes and pulled her dagger out.

"Not a princess anymore and I'm not kidding. Shut up, put up, or get out," Capella said as she held the dagger at her side.

The whole room was silent as they looked between the two. Capella didn't take her eyes off Half Ear, waiting to see what he was going to do.

“Damn, can’t even take a little joke,” Half Ear finally said, throwing his hands up in the air.

“You’re not taking shutting up so are you leaving or fighting?” Capella said.

“Fine, damn,” Half Ear said. “I’ll be quiet.”

Capella nodded and went over to grab her bags.

“Cappe, we need to talk,” Coalfire said as Alice and Dio traded looks.

“I’m going somewhere first,” Capella said. “I’ll be back later.”

“Cappe…,” Coalfire started to say and Capella turned around.

“Later,” Capella said bluntly. Coalfire moved her head back in surprise and then just nodded as Capella teleported away.

Chapter End Notes

This is gotta be the longest chapter in the whole fic. It originally was part of the last chapter but it just kept going and going and I knew I wanted everything in this chapter to be together so I picked a good split and then kept writing, figuring it'd be about as long as the last one. I was wrong.

That conversation with P-Pear turned HUGE but I don't regret it.

Gress

Chapter Summary

> Gress sits in Dryl, thinking of how Prickly Pear can help when he's reminded of an appointment.

Chapter Notes

> "How I wish, how I wish you were here./We're just two lost souls swimming in a fish bowl, year after year,/Running over the same old ground./What have we found?/The same old fears./Wish you were here." - Wish You Were Here by Pink Floyd
>
> Note: Brief mention of Micah, that he is not doing well, but no deep discussion of it, so no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Gress read the message from Prickly Pear and shook his head as he thought about it. Capella had sent him a message in the middle of the night with the passphrase and counter-response in it and Prickly Pear had sent a message not long after. He sent the counter-response and then hit call. It was late enough at night now that it could be called early morning but in the tunnels of Dryl, he'd found his own rhythm and it drifted in respect to the clock. Hort and Ulip hadn't been thrilled about him doing so. Then he'd moved into another dwelling, something else they hadn't been too thrilled about but hadn't fought him on, partly because it was right next to their home Gress believed, and he didn't give his schedule in regards to normal day and night a lot of thought any more.

He fiddled with his hair as the call went out, hoping Prickly Pear was still awake. The message had just come through so he was pretty sure and was quickly proven right as the call was answered

almost immediately. Gress was treated to a shaky camera as he heard Prickly Pear whispering something as she left a huge tent.

“P-Pear? Are you there?” Gress said.

Her face finally popped up onto the screen as she straightened up her data pad.

“I didn’t think you’d call,” she responded in a whisper.

“Why are you whispering?” Gress said.

“Because I was in my family's tent when you called and now I’m standing out around some more,” Prickly Pear replied.

“Go somewhere where no one can overhear and call me back immediately please,” Gress said and then cut the call.

About five minutes later, Prickly Pear called and Gress answered.

“Why did you hang up on me?” she said.

“Are you somewhere private?” Gress asked. Prickly Pear said she was and Gress went on. “OK, what’s the passphrase?”

“Seriously? I just sent it,” Prickly Pear said. Gress just stared at her and she finally sighed. “It’s, ‘The forest shows its lights when no one is around.’”

Gress nodded as he said, “You sure that’s not just someone’s home?”

“Are you going to do that every time?” Prickly Pear said. “It seems kind of rude.”

“No. We’ll arrange a better way of handling it on this call,” Gress said. “But get used to that kind of thing. Better rude than the alternative.”

“What? Polite?” Prickly Pear said.

“Dead,” Gress said, stone-faced. Prickly Pear’s eyes widened but she didn’t say anything else. “Yes, it’s that serious, P-Pear.”

“OK, so what do you need from me?”

“What can you offer? What are you willing to do?” Gress said as he pulled up a notes program.

Prickly Pear shrugged as she said, “I don’t know. I don’t think I have a lot to offer.”

Gress looked at her, his eyes obviously rolling even without visible pupils, as he said, “You’re a reigning princess. You have the entire kingdom’s resources at your command. How about this? Are you willing to make money available for the fight?”

“How?” Prickly Pear said. “Mom honestly still handles that part of it.”

“I can figure that out. Are you willing to do that?” Gress said. Prickly Pear nodded and Gress made a note. “How about information? Can you get people telling you things?”

Prickly Pear looked around and then leaned in as she said a little quieter, “Like what gets said in the Princess Council meetings?”

“More like what gets said behind the scenes, but yes,” Gress said.

Prickly Pear’s eyes were wide again but she nodded and Gress made another note. They continued talking and after about half an hour, Gress had a decent amount of notes.

“Thank you for this,” Gress said as he saved his notes. “You don’t have to do anything now but I appreciate you offering your help. Cappe and I will talk about this and you make sure you keep that program up to date like I said please so it can ID you easier.”

Prickly Pear had spent the last half hour going from nervous to scared to resigned to finally resolute and she nodded.

“Before I go, can I ask you something?” Prickly Pear said.

“Sure,” Gress said, absentmindedly working his notes into an outline.

“What about the others?” Prickly Pear said.

Gress looked at her with a confused look.

“What others?”

“The younger princesses,” Prickly Pear. “I know Cowrie is chomping at the bit to get involved. Oak and Chitin have talked about it as well. I didn’t ask Finn since they’re a pacifist but I think Izzy would be interested as well. A few of my other siblings I think would be willing to get involved as well. Artho might be but I haven’t talked with her since she moved.”

Gress sat up a bit straighter as his mind shot into overdrive.

"How do you know this?" Gress said.

"Just kind of talking among ourselves at parties and gatherings and over the data pad. Honestly, I think Cowrie is already involved somehow but she's not saying," Prickly Pear said with a shrug.

Gress managed not to let his jaw drop at the thought. He wasn't going to get Izzy involved but the others, well, he had to admit that they would be helpful and he wondered if Capella would feel the same way. At the very least, they needed some friends in their corner for once and Gress didn't really trust the four people Cappe was running around with.

"Just keep doing what you're doing, don't try and get them involved just yet. Just listen and remember and *don't take notes,"* Gress said. "This is good though. Thank you for mentioning it."

Prickly Pear smiled as she said, "You're welcome!"

"I have to think about this," Gress said. "I'll be in contact, alright?"

"Alright. Good night, Gress, and thank you," Prickly Pear said.

Gress tapped his fingers on the table after the call disconnected. He sent a message to Capella after some thought.

I need a chat asap. P-Pear has given me some interesting information and ideas.

Gress sat the data pad to idle and lay back on the couch in the small room he was using. He looked at the small digital calendar on the touch screen by the door as it chimed a reminder of an appointment and he saw beside the reminder that he hadn't been outdoors in almost a week. It bothered him that he was getting too used to living in the tunnels again. He still remembered the first time he remembered seeing the sky as a child. It'd been overcast and his caretakers had taken him out one of the tunnels that opened out onto the mountain above Dryl.

Gress hadn't understood what it was at first, even though they'd told him about the sky, because the reality turned out to be so much bigger than the idea that had lived in his mind. He still remembered sitting among the rocks, a warm breeze on his face as he watched the clouds scuttling past overhead. He thought about how that was probably the first time he remembered beginning to understand that there was so much more to the world than he had, or probably even could, imagine.

Now years later as he sat in the tunnels again, he stood up and left his room to go to the appointment. There were more families in the tunnels now, having requested it from Izzy when they'd fled to Dryl, and if it hadn't been the middle of the night, Gress would have had to answer dozens of questions. He'd never stopped

putting out videos and discussions against what he saw as the inaction of the overall power structure and the questions from the other clones ranged from interest to outright condemnation of his stances. Now, following the appointment reminder, he was going to speak his thoughts to someone he should have spoken them to much sooner.

Gress exited a tunnel into the back of Finn's theater and walked quietly through the back. Only a few lights were on and no one was around as planned. Izzy was waiting for him by the backstage entry to the stage, the light from the ghost light on the stage illuminating half of her face as she yawned and then took a long drink from a huge mug in her hand. Finn lay back in a chair to the side, not even trying to pretend like they were awake.

"You sure about this, Brother Gress?" she said quietly.

"I should have done it a long time ago," Gress said.

"Cappe know about this?" Izzy said.

Gress looked at her and said nothing. Gress knew it was just in Izzy's nature to try and find out information but he'd never let anyone know he was talking with her regularly. He'd promised Capella after all.

Izzy shrugged as she said, "OK, Glimmer is waiting in the lobby. I'll go get her and bring her back here."

Izzy gently woke Finn up and then left. Finn sleepily scratched at their stomach and then gave a huge long stretch before standing up.

"You want me to hang around and mediate?" Finn asked as they got up to pull a few chairs into a circle.

"No, but thank you for the offer," Gress said. He kept waiting to be nervous and when he heard Glimmer talking to Izzy in the auditorium, he was sure it was going to happen at any moment. However, it never came. He was calmly standing, hands held together in front of him, when Glimmer came in through a passageway with Izzy right beside her.

"Gress, thank you for meeting with me," Glimmer said.

"You're welcome. You keep asking Brother Izzy about it so I figured I should," Gress said. "Although you might not like anything I have to say."

Glimmer shook her head for a moment as she said, "Listen, I've read what you've been saying. If it's anything like that, well, I've managed so far."

Finn looked between the two and said, "Alright, I'm going to go out and sit down in the audience with Iz and try not to fall asleep

again. Aunt Glimmer, you should remember this rule so I'll tell Gress. If I can hear you out there, it's not a civil discussion. Understood?"

Gress agreed and Glimmer nodded her head and there was a brief pause before Izzy spoke up.

"OK, we're going now," Izzy said. "Unless you'd rather I stay, Brother Gress."

"No, thank you," Gress replied.

Finn and Izzy left holding hands and Gress sat down in a chair and waited for Glimmer to get her wings adjusted and seated.

"We can talk as long as you wish but I don't want to be gone long if possible. My father is… not doing well," Glimmer said, pausing before going on. "I imagine you have lots you want to say and I have questions. How do you want to proceed?"

"First, I'm sorry to hear about your father. I will keep this as short as possible for you. You have heard what I have said about your inaction. Nothing has changed in that regard so I do not feel like I need to repeat myself. Go ahead with your questions but depending on what they are, I will probably not answer them or answer them to your satisfaction," Gress said.

Glimmer knotted her hands together as she leaned forward and looked at the floor.

"I figured, so I'll start with the one you probably won't answer but I have to ask. Where is my daughter?" Glimmer said.

"Why do you assume I'm in contact with her?" Gress replied immediately.

Glimmer looked up at him as she said, "Because I know you're friends with her. Because I know how close you both are and I don't think she'd keep out of contact with you for long."

Gress thought for a second and then said, "What's your next question?"

Glimmer's face fell a little as she nodded in slow acceptance and said, "Is she OK?"

"Again, you assume I'm in contact with her," Gress said.

"I know you…," Glimmer started to say and then stopped and took a deep breath before going on. "Do you know if she's OK?"

Gress saw the sadness in her eyes and almost said something but just shook his head.

"Next question please," Gress said.

"Please? Just let me know?" Glimmer said and Gress saw the tears in her eyes she was fighting back. Gress felt a pang of guilt but squeezed his hands together as he looked away.

"I'm sorry, I can't say. What's your next question?" Gress said, swallowing a lump in his throat. Glimmer didn't speak for a minute before she asked her next question.

"What's happened? Why does she think that I sent Dark Moon after you all? Why do you think that's even a thing?" Glimmer said.

Gress fought back a shudder at the memory of the blonde woman stepping into the room. He'd had plenty of nightmares about the events of that day and she featured in a good portion of them.

"I know Dark Moon is real because we saw them that day at Wheatland," Gress replied.

"Why do you think that I sent them though?" Glimmer said. "Why do you think I'd do that to my daughter?"

“I don’t know,” Gress said. “That would be one of my questions to you. Why would you?”

“I wouldn’t!” Glimmer said, her voice rising in irritation. “Why do you think I would!?”

“Your Majesty, I can think of many reasons,” Gress said, trying to keep his voice calm.

“Give me one,” Glimmer spat out, her hands gripped together tight.

“The most obvious is that they were under orders to retrieve her if any accusations came out against her and if the accusations were severe enough, to take care of any witnesses,” Gress replied, looking her right in the eyes.

Glimmer blinked a few times in shock at the explanation and then began to laugh.

“What?” Gress said, surprised at the laughter.

“If you think I’m that ruthless, why did you agree to meet me in person!? What’s keeping me from killing you right now if you really think that’s true!?” Glimmer said as she shook her head.

“You promised Brother Izzy to keep this civil,” Gress said.

Glimmer gave a deep sigh as she leaned back and said, “Gress, you’re smart but you need to think a little harder there. You’re saying I’m cold blooded enough to have my daughter’s friends killed in front of her but I’m polite enough to honor a promise like that?”

“It could be as simple as my death is no longer useful,” Gress said. “And you wish to get information from me.”

Glimmer nodded slowly and said, “We could have used you in the war. Your security is impeccable; I’ll give you that. But your logic? Not so much.”

Gress said, “Listen, it’s a matter of life and death. Not only mine but my brother’s lives as well.”

Glimmer said, “You know, a few months back and I’d say you’re being melodramatic.”

“And now?” Gress replied.

“Well, now, I need to figure out who’s doing what and you’re not really helping in that,” Glimmer said.

“You want my help? Fine, I’ll give you a list of targets,” Gress replied. “Hit them hard, take prisoners, and use truth spells on them. You’ll find out soon enough.”

“So use Dark Moon for you, huh?” Glimmer said.

“So you do admit it exists and that you control them,” Gress said, leaning forward.

“I do not. I have nothing like that. I’m just pointing out that if I did you sure seem to be fine using it for your own purposes,” Glimmer said. “If you gave me a list of targets, I can’t do what you’re asking for multiple reasons. To be usable in any council, the Etherian Charter says the truth spells have to be agreed to for one. Another is that chances are pretty good I’d be invading a sovereign township and do you have any idea what kind of nightmare that would be?”

“Ah, the Charter,” Gress replied, not even trying to hide his disdain.

Glimmer sighed. She’d read what he’d said about how his enemies were using the Etherian Charter as a shield for their activities and the princesses were hiding behind it and using it as an excuse for their inaction.

“I know what you think about it but when we made the Charter after the war, it was made for a clearly defined reason. You’ve read Etherian history. The All Princess Ball has an invite that looks like it needs a cart to deliver because of that history. It wasn’t just a reaction to the war, it was an attempt to keep that from happening again,” Glimmer said.

“I’m aware of that and that’s one reason I’m careful. You’re a product of that history,” Gress said.

“What do you mean?” Glimmer said and Gress couldn’t help but think she seemed more interested then offended.

Gress replied, “As an example, one of the former princesses of Bright Moon struck down her opponent at a summer party and then took her land. It’s why Bright Moon extends through the Whispering Woods.”

“Yes, Princess Umbrate, I’m aware,” Glimmer said. “What’s your point?”

“That you come from a line of ruthless people and I’d be a fool not to take that into account,” Gress said.

“A line of ruthless people and so I’m not to be trusted?” Glimmer said.

“Partly, yes,” Gress said. “It’s in your interest to maintain your power base.”

Glimmer sat back and looked away for a moment and Gress waited to see what she was going to say. Finally she sighed and leaned back towards him.

“Gress, I see what you’re saying although I’m curious as to what you would say about yourself,” Glimmer said.

“I assume you mean that my people also have a similar background?” Gress replied.

“Yes,” Glimmer said. “I do mean that.”

“They don’t though. They were the victims of Prime,” Gress said. “Also, those of us here on Etheria don’t have a centuries deep power base like you do.”

Glimmer nodded a little as she said, “I don’t necessarily disagree with that or what you said about my ancestors. My ancestry is one reason I tried to raise Cappe with the knowledge that she has a duty as a princess to watch out for and to help others.”

“She’s not a princess anymore,” Gress said.

Glimmer grimaced as she said, “You didn’t have to remind me.”

“I will say, based on her actions I’ve heard about, that she does seem to have taken that duty to heart. Why haven’t you?” Gress said.

“I have,” Glimmer said. “So I’m going to say something in the hope that you’ll see it as what it is, me taking you into my confidence, and not spread it around. Izzy can come and go as she wishes. I’m not holding her, although we are trying to keep up that appearance as much as we can. Also, notice that the man that she suspects of being behind a lot of this is cooling his heels in Bright Moon, where it’s easier to keep an eye on him, because I’ve stalled the process of his recognition. It might not be on your timeline but every moment he stays there counts. Because if he does become princess that gives him a whole bunch of power he does not need. He’s made several complaints to the High Council of Etheria as well about it but we’ll deal with that when the time comes.”

“So behind the scenes and hidden,” Gress said. “Where it doesn’t threaten you too much. Games and politics.”

“Just like you’re doing right now,” Glimmer said. “Just like you do with your videos and posts and just like you’re doing with Cappe in helping her plan whatever it is she’s doing I presume.”

Gress just shook his head as he said, “It’s not the same. You have the freedom to do what you want. I can’t leave Dryl, or even

show my face around it, or I risk getting killed or captured for false charges."

Glimmer gave a little humorless laugh as she said, "I don't have the freedom to do what I want and I can see why you wouldn't see that but you are doing the same thing. Games and politics. You need to realize that because, Gress, you are involved and you are making a difference."

Gress looked at her suspiciously as he said, "That almost sounded like a compliment."

"It is," Glimmer said. "You might think I'm an enemy but I don't see you the same way. I want you to better understand what you're doing so you can make more of a difference."

"Why?" Gress said.

Glimmer looked down, her voice becoming almost a whisper as she said, "Because the sooner this is over, well, the sooner I can hope to see Cappe again."

Gress opened his mouth a few times to try and say something but finally just stayed quiet. They both sat in silence, neither quite looking at the other.

“What would you tell her if you thought it’d get back to her?” Gress finally said, his voice low and quiet.

Glimmer looked at him, her eyes a little wider and a hint of hope on her face.

“You’ll give her a message from me?” she said.

“I’m not saying I’m speaking with her; I’m just asking what you’d tell her,” Gress said.

Glimmer didn’t hesitate.

“I’d say that I told her on her ninth birthday that it’d be her decision to sit on the throne or not and it would seem she has decided that the answer is that she will not. That her father and I love her, we’re proud of what she’s doing in her fight, and I really wish we could talk. That I miss you, Cappe. I miss you so much and I love you and I wish you were here,” Glimmer said before she stood up and turned her back on Gress and walked a few feet away. Gress stood and walked out on the stage to give her privacy as she quietly wept.

“Everything alright?” Izzy asked from the audience, causing Gress to jump a little.

“It’s going,” Gress said but wouldn’t say more.

Glimmer came out onto the stage a few minutes later.

"Do we have more to talk about?" she said.

"What are you going to do about all of this?" Gress said.

"What I've said. I am trying to get him to do something more visible," Glimmer said. "Keeping him boxed up in Bright Moon makes it a little harder for him to work so I'll keep doing that as well and I'm doing my best to keep the Princess Council out of session for the moment. He's not happy about that. What are you going to do?"

Gress was about to say he didn't care how happy Aeron was when he suddenly saw what Glimmer was talking about. Aeron obviously wanted to be a princess for the power that it gave him and that was it right there. He didn't like being the weak person and having to dance attendance to Glimmer's whims just made him angry and Gress knew well that angry people made mistakes. He thought Glimmer could do more but he had to admit it wasn't an awful plan.

"I'm sorry but I won't tell you," Gress said. "However, since you are working with Brother Izzy I will pass on things I think you may need to act on through her."

“What about that group we talked about earlier? Or what you asked me just a few minutes ago?” Glimmer replied.

“The group, well, I’ll wait and see. As to the other, I said what I said,” Gress said, feeling guilty at causing someone distress like he had. “But if for some reason she does reach out to me, I’ll remember and pass it on.”

Glimmer gave a tired smile as she said, “Thank you, Gress.”

“You’re welcome,” Gress said. “And again, I’m sorry about your father. I’ll remember him at my evening meal.”

Gress could see that Glimmer was confused for a moment until she remembered the clone’s tradition of reciting the names of those who’d passed before dinner as well as remembering the Nameless Ones who’d died under Prime.

“Thank you again and I meant that compliment earlier. We may not be friends but I don’t consider you an enemy,” Glimmer said with a nod. “Iz? Finn? I’m ready to go. Are you?”

“Not really but we should before Frosta goes into terminal conspiracy overdrive. She was talking about having Izzy make bots of herself to throw people off,” Finn replied.

“Brother Izzy, before you go, is Emma alright?” Gress asked.

“Mom’s doing ok. She’s making progress a little at a time,” Izzy said. “Are you ok?”

“I’m fine,” Gress said, pausing for a moment before making a decision and turning back to Glimmer. “You may contact me by my data pad if you wish to talk again.”

Glimmer froze for a second before she said, “I will.”

After they left, Gress made his way back to his room. He wanted to call Capella and let her know how the meeting had gone but they hadn’t scheduled a call so he had to satisfy himself with just writing it up. He finished it with:

I know we don’t trust her and maybe I’m just being taken in by a person with decades of diplomatic savvy but Cappe, I think we may have made a mistake on her. I know you probably don’t want to hear that but I do want you to consider it. As I mentioned, I didn’t tell her I was talking with you but I did agree to hear a message from her to you. I won’t tell you until you want to know. Anyway, when you get a chance, please come by. I’d love to just hang out with you again. I’m a bit jealous of all these other people who are getting to see you. Hope to see you soon and I love you.

Friend Squared,

Gress

Gress sighed as he sat back in his chair. He stared at the ceiling for a few minutes before getting up and warmed up a few protein cubes, made a little sauce, and dumped it all over some rice. He sat it down on a little table, sat a spoon on top of a napkin and filled a glass with some water, and then sat a candle down in front of the plate. He then sat down and carefully folded his hands in his lap. He took a deep breath and then began to speak to the empty room.

"I remember those who have left me in the past year, either out of contact, about to pass on, or who have already passed on from this life," he said before saying the next names slowly.

"Tropistar, Sert, Micah," Gress recited before pausing and taking a deep breath, "and Capella. Now I shall have a moment of quiet to remember the Nameless Ones."

Gress sat and thought about the line of his people going back and how he'd never be able to fully know them, no matter how much they studied and dug. He knew he was but a small part of the whole of the spacebats that stretched back into the past but he knew that if he were to die today, he would be remembered by those who loved him. Then he did something out of the ordinary for the little ritual. He lit the candle in front of him.

Gress had read about how some Etherians lit candles in memory of their departed and he'd decided that he was going to do the same for the Nameless Ones. He'd started doing it by himself and he kept it burning all through dinner as he ate as a reminder. He began to eat and after a few minutes, he heard a knock at the

door. He looked at the clock and while it wasn't too early, it was still just early enough that he wondered who was there. He got up, made sure the calendar was turned off, and answered the door. His caretakers both stood on the other side.

"Oh, I'm sorry, we didn't mean to disturb you at… breakfast?" Ulip said as he looked around Gress to the table.

"It is dinner actually, and a late one for me, but as I have said before it's never a disturbance for you to come over. I simply wanted my own space and am more than capable of asking you to come back another time if I am not feeling like having guests," Gress replied. "Please come in on that note."

Gress stood aside and Hort and Ulip both walked in and Gress invited them to sit at the table. Gress watched them looking around as they always did when they came over. Hort and Ulip had moved into a more traditional home, with more distinct rooms, and Gress had moved into what had essentially been a maintenance caretakers room right next door to them when they'd done so. He'd expected an argument when he'd done so but it had never happened. Hort and Ulip had expressed their unhappiness but had assured him that they respected his decision.

"I'm sorry I don't have anything to offer you to eat right now," Gress said. "I've been up a long time and I'll be going to sleep soon."

“It’s OK, we just wanted to come by and say hello,” Hort replied. He looked down at the candle burning on the table in its little colorful glass jar. “The flame is a nice touch for the meal.”

Gress cleared his throat a little uncomfortably. It wasn’t as if there was anything that forbade changing the evening litany for the departed but he’d felt a bit weird doing so.

“That’s, um, part of my litany before my dinner,” Gress said.

Hort and Ulip gave him quizzical looks and Gress flushed a little as he tried to think what to say.

“In what way?” Ulip said and Gress looked for disapproval but just heard interest.

“At the end of remembering the Nameless Ones, instead of saying that I’m done, I light the candle. I’ve heard of Etherians who do so as a memory of their departed and I thought it would be nice to do so as a reminder through dinner of them. It also felt like a good transition between the litany and dinner,” Gress responded, fiddling with his napkin as he looked at the candle. Gress was surprised to see tears in their eyes suddenly.

“I’m sorry! I’ll put it out!” Gress said as he reached forward for the candle. Hort put his hand over Gress’ and shook his head.

“No, don’t,” Hort said. “It’s beautiful. They would have liked it I think.”

“They?” Gress said.

“The Nameless Ones,” Hort responded. “Remember, when we speak of them, we’re speaking of people we directly knew.”

Ulip nodded as a tear streaked down his face.

“We always worried that our children would eventually drift away from their remembrance but this,” Ulip said as he gestured at the candle, “it makes me feel good. You’re adding on your own things to the tradition; you’re making it your own.”

Gress nodded as he said, “I guess I am.”

“May we use this as well?” Hort asked.

“Of course,” Gress said. They sat quietly for a moment before Hort spoke up again.

“We’ve interrupted your dinner though. Eat please,” Hort said.

Gress smiled at them and as he picked up his spoon again said, “Could you… could you tell me about some of them that you knew? Some of the Nameless Ones?”

Hort and Ulip looked at each other and then back at Gress.

“Those aren’t happy stories,” Ulip said.

“They aren’t but they’re mine, they’re my heritage,” Gress replied. “I’d like to know as much as I can.”

Hort and Ulip linked hands and nodded.

“They are your stories,” Hort said and began to talk about those past. Ulip had been right. They weren’t happy stories but they were the heritage that led to Gress and so Gress slowly ate and listened as the candle burned.

Chapter End Notes

> If you didn't see the announcement, I have finished writing this and will try and post chapters quickly now as I finish the editing. It's been one hell of a journey, that's for sure, and I thank each and every one of you for reading along.

Juliet

Chapter Summary

> Juliet sits in Mystacor, watching over Micah in the late evening.

Chapter Notes

> Note: This chapter is heavy with Micah. Summary in the end notes.
>
> Note: Just a note to those reading as this gets posted, if the last chapter wasn't from Gress' standpoint, you missed a chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was late at night as Juliet sat beside Micah's bed reading or at least trying to do so. She'd volunteered to stay beside him through the night even though Micah wasn't responding to anyone anymore. The healers had told everyone that they were at the keeping him comfortable stage and everyone waited for the inevitable.

After Castaspella and Angella had both lingered long into the evening, Juliet had finally told them she'd get them at any change just so they'd go to bed for a little while. Glimmer had left with a promise to be back as soon as possible while Bow was in the next room asleep in a chair. Now it was just her and the night and a book of poetry and of course, her memories. She'd been a guard for years until shortly after the war, when she'd fallen in love with Castaspella and then retired and moved to Mystacor. Now she was remembering those long ago nights standing guard as she'd written poetry in her head and, looking at Micah and knowing impending death when she saw it, other less pleasant memories as well.

Her train of thought was interrupted as she looked up as a healer came into the room, decked out in her dark blue robes. Juliet wondered why they bothered to come in at all. The medical systems broadcast the data out to the healer's data pads after all. Juliet assumed their presence was a calming one, the presence of some kind of authority in the face of uncertainty, and the healers were well trained in their bedside manner.

The old guard in her ran the face through a quick mental background check but it was a healer she'd seen off and on for some time now. However, thinking about data pads, that night she stopped and thought a little more as she sat back and looked again at her.

"Should I get everyone?" Juliet asked the healer.

"I'm just checking a few things," the healer said as she looked at a data pad. "I'll let you know."

Juliet sat the poetry book down and stretched as she stood up. A few things popped and pinged as she did and though they hurt a little, she gave a silent thank you that they still did. She'd lived through too much and seen too much death to ever curse getting older.

"I'm going to go and get some water. Do you need some?" Juliet said.

“No, thank you,” the healer said absentmindedly as she made a few notes. Juliet looked at her again and went into the bathroom and filled a glass. She came back in to see the healer looking down at Micah and not doing much of anything. Juliet took a sip of the water as she said.

“Hard to see isn’t it?”

The healer looked up at her and cleared her throat.

“It… yes, it is,” she said.

“Listen, there’s been a lot going on lately and I haven't had a chance to stretch my legs. I’m going to step out for a moment if you could stay with him while I do,” Juliet said as she pulled a notepad to her and wrote down some information. “This is my contact information. Please let me know immediately if anything changes or before you leave. If you need help, I’ve left the emergency button on the table there.”

Juliet nodded at the small button for summoning the full team of healers on the table, then sat down her written information, and waited to see what the healer would say.

“Oh, of course,” she responded. “I can do that for you.”

Juliet nodded and walked out. As she did, she pulled the door shut so that it made a clacking noise like it was closed but kept the nob turned so it didn't latch. Then she pushed it open just a hair's breadth and waited. She peered through the tiny crack and watched as the healer pulled a chair over to the bed and took Micah's hand. Then the illusion fell and she saw Capella sitting there with tears streaking down her face as she leaned in to kiss her grandfather's forehead and whisper something to him. Juliet turned around and felt herself straighten up as her hands fell to her side as she took up a guard position on the door, determined to give Capella as much time with her grandfather as she needed.

A half hour had gone by when the door opened and Capella, with her illusion back in place, almost ran into Juliet as she came out. Juliet stepped back and turned around.

"Is everything alright?" Juliet asked. "Did you do everything you needed to do?"

Juliet watched Capella as she nodded and was amazed at how much she seemed to have her emotions shoved down as she responded in a professional voice.

"Yes, I did," she responded and Juliet listened as she tried to pick out Capella's normal voice and failed.

"I just wanted to say that I'm proud of what you're doing," Juliet said and Capella's illusion looked at her in confusion.

“What do you mean?” Capella said.

“The job you’re doing,” Juliet responded. “I’m proud of you for doing it. When should I expect to see you again?”

“I’ll have to check my shift posting to find out,” Capella responded.

“Of course, I understand,” Juliet said and stood to the side. She watched Capella start to leave. She probably technically had a duty to detain her but she had long ago decided she would never obey the wrong order and had taught her guards the same when she was still a general. However, right before Capella got to the end of the short hallway, Juliet spoke up again.

“You know, he loves you so much. Come back soon though; the healers are saying that he doesn’t have much longer. Maybe not even days,” Juliet said and watched Capella freeze in her tracks. She turned around and Juliet was again amazed at how calm she seemed.

“Well, of course, I know he doesn’t have much longer but I think you’re mistaken. He didn’t know me,” Capella said.

“Can I say one thing to you before you go?” Juliet said.

“Of course,” she responded.

“If your mother was really running Dark Moon, I would have found out by now and I already would have done my duty and gone back to Bright Moon to root them out,” Juliet said.

Again, Juliet watched Capella stand there, her face betraying nothing but her body language was suddenly screaming that she was ready to run.

“I’m… I’m sorry, I don’t know what you’re talking about,” Capella said.

“That’s alright. I said what needed to be said. Just remember, he doesn’t have much longer,” Juliet said. “You’re free to come back when you need to.”

Capella walked forward, the blue robes swishing and this time Juliet glanced down and saw the toe of a heavy boot poke out for a moment instead of the usual comfortable shoes the healers wore.

“Are you alright?” Capella asked as she pulled her data pad out. “I can get you something if you need it.”

Juliet blinked for a moment, surprised at her response, but she waited until Capella got closer and then she slowly reached out to take Capella’s data pad from her. The response was immediate.

Capella brought her other hand up to sweep Juliet's hand to one side.

As she did, Juliet concentrated extra hard for what she planned next. As Capella brushed Juliet's hand away, Juliet cast one of the few spells she knew, one to dispel illusions. She had only used it before to dispel the minor illusions she knew how to do. When she met Capella's illusion, full of so much more power than Juliet could channel and that Capella was actively trying to keep up, the feedback felt like she'd been punched in the brain by a steel fist.

Juliet grunted as she staggered backwards and hit the ground, shaking her head as she did so. She briefly saw Capella's illusion waver for a split second and then it snapped back in place but she didn't take much notice beyond that as she put both hands up to her head as waves of nausea and pain swept over her. Then Juliet felt a hand on her shoulder and she could vaguely hear Capella's voice whispering desperately.

"Aunt Juliet, are you alright? What did you try and do!?" Capella said. Juliet managed to get her eyes to focus as she gave a tight smile.

"That's way harder than you ever managed to hit me in training," Juliet said as Capella helped her sit up against the wall.

"Did you try and dispel my illusion!?" Capella said.

“Seemed a good idea,” Juliet said as she took stock of herself as she leaned back against the wall behind her as the pain and nausea began to wane.

“Well it’s protected against that,” Capella said. “You really caught me by surprise though.”

“Surprise is important,” Juliet replied. “You know that by now though from what I’ve heard.”

“How did you know it was me?” Capella said as she quickly glanced left and right to be sure no one else was around.

“Your data pad,” Juliet said as she took a few deep breaths. “It’s not the same as the one the other healers use but I never really paid attention until tonight. Then I realized I’d seen that face before but always at odd intervals. Just kind of put it together from there.”

Capella shook her head, the illusion showing a grim face as Capella said, “Does he really not have long?”

A tear went down Juliet’s face as she said, “No, he really doesn’t.”

Capella hung her head for a moment and then snapped it up when she heard a gasp and then her Aunt Castaspella came hurrying down the hall.

“Juliet! Are you alright!?”

Capella quickly got to her feet and got out of the way as Juliet watched her before turning to her wife.

“I’m fine, Cass,” Juliet said as she got to her feet. “I tripped coming back to the room and she heard and came out to make sure I was ok.”

Castaspella was fussing over her as Juliet got to her feet.

“I’m alright, I promise,” Juliet said as she kissed Castaspella’s hand.

Capella responded in her imitation voice as she said, “She’ll be OK.”

Castaspella turned around and looked at Capella and Juliet could see the uncomfortableness in Capella as Castaspella thanked her for helping. Capella responded in her imitation voice and Juliet wondered if she should say something but finally just kept her mouth shut. Capella went on after shooting a brief confused look at Juliet.

“I don’t see her much,” Castaspella said. “But she seems like a sweet person.”

“She is,” Juliet said as they linked hands and went back into Micah’s room.

As Juliet and Castaspella came in, Juliet stopped suddenly and listened to Micah’s breathing. It’d been a long time since she’d heard someone breath like that but it wasn’t something that she would ever forget. She let go of Castaspella’s hand and lunged for the emergency button.

Chapter End Notes

Summary: Juliet is sitting watch over Micah late in the evening, the healers having said he has not much longer, when a healer comes in. Juliet puts two and two together after some observation and thinks it's Cappe. She speaks to the healer, says she has to stretch her legs, and steps out. Peaking back in, she sees Cappe drop her illusion and kiss her grandfather. Juliet stands guard on the door so Cappe can spend as much time as possible with him. When Cappe comes out, Juliet speaks to her and then tries to dispel her illusion. This doesn't go well as Cappe's illusions are guarded, something Juliet isn't prepared for, and knocks her down. Cappe kneels down and reveals herself and Juliet tells her there's no way Dark Moon is out of Bright Moon because she would have stopped it already. Castaspella comes along then, Juliet makes up an excuse, doesn't give away Cappe, and then Cappe goes along. Castaspella and Juliet go back into the room and Juliet recognizes the sounds of failing breathing and calls for help.

End Note: This chapter... I actually really like this chapter, because I really like Juliet and have never given her enough

page time, but I really, really did not want to have to go through the part with Micah.

Just a note to those reading as this gets posted, if the last chapter wasn't from Gress' standpoint, you missed a chapter.

Eulogy and Remembrances

Chapter Summary

Note: This entire chapter is about Micah. Summary afterwards

Chapter Notes

Note: If you're reading along as this posts, this is the third chapter to be posted today. Be sure you've read the two before, starting at Chapter Forty-Four: Gress and then Chapter Forty-Five: Juliet.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

{Push Notification from Bright Moon to All Etherian Network}

It was with much sadness that the kingdom of Bright Moon announces the death of Micah of Mystacor. The former King of Bright Moon, Sorcerer of Mystacor, and General in the First Alliance, passed from this world last night with his wife Angella and other members of his family by his side in Mystacor.

Micah lived a life devoted to his family and in service to others. Believed lost during the final days of the First Alliance, he was rescued by She-Ra, Princess of Power, and King Bow of Bright Moon from Beast Island years later shortly before the arrival of Prime. After the end of the war, he was instrumental in bringing back his wife Angella and they rarely parted afterwards. After Angella's abdication, they travelled Etheria together, helping various charity projects, and enjoying the company of their friends and family. They settled in Mystacor as Micah's health began to deteriorate over the last several years.

Micah is survived by his wife Angella of Mystacor, his sister Castaspella, High Sorcerer of Mystacor and her wife Juliet of Mystacor, as well as his daughter Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon and her husband King Bow of Bright Moon and their daughter, Capella. Services in memory of Micah are to be held at a time and place to be announced and the family has asked that in lieu of memorial gifts that donations in his name be made to any worthy charity.

{End Push Notification from Bright Moon to All Etherian Network}

###

Capella had her head down on her knees as she quietly cried, her data pad on the floor beside her. She'd disappeared into a small closet near Micah and Angella's suite and changed into different clothes and had been halfway down the hall when she'd heard the commotion as a group of healers came rushing to the suite. She'd considered going back but instead had gone down to the hot springs area and found a little storage closet.

She'd sat there, her gut telling her what was later confirmed by the eulogy. When the eulogy had hit her data pad in the early morning hours, she'd read it once and then put her head down. She'd fought to keep quiet as she cried in her hiding place and hurt so badly because she knew her family was upstairs from her and with a thought, she could be there as well. However, she knew she couldn't. She knew it wouldn't go well.

“Then you carefully let it out and… there you go!” she remembered Micah telling her when she was a kid and he had been one of the people trying to teach her magic. She remembered laughing at the really basic image of Swift Wind she’d conjured up, the horse himself trying to stand and model for her and making compliments. The memory was painful though because the only magic she’d ever really picked up had been illusions and while she was glad to know it now, it was still painful to think that the little fun thing she’d picked up from her Grandpa Micah was now something that she had to use to stay alive.

After she’d let a crying jag pass, she sat back against the wall, staring at a rack full of cleaning supplies, not thinking of much of anything. Everything seemed so pointless at the moment. She’d been sneaking in to see Micah off and on almost immediately after she’d first gone into hiding but this seemed like a sudden gulf, another bit of her old life sloughing away and she felt like there was nothing left inside of her. She finally picked up her data pad, thinking about maybe actually calling Gress face to face, when she saw the message from him. She knew that Glimmer had gone to meet Gress the night before and Capella was trying to ignore the feeling of guilt she was carrying that was telling her that maybe Glimmer hadn’t made it back in time. She finally read the message and felt herself deflate.

A short time later and she was standing in Gress' room. He’d told her where he was staying when he’d moved and after several false jumps in the tunnels of Dryl, she’d finally managed to find his location. She looked down at her friend quietly sleeping and almost left again, not wanting to disturb him as she knew he’d been up late. Finally she sat down beside his bed and shook him gently. He blinked a few times and then a soft smile spread across his face.

“Hey there,” he said and then noticed her face. “What’s happened?”

“Grandpa died,” she said quietly, her face resting on the mattress, a few tears leaking out as she looked at Gress. Gress scooted over to put a hand on her shoulder and had the lights turn on low.

“What do you need?” he said.

Capella didn’t know what to say. She searched inside herself but she had tried so hard to hide her feelings lately that even crying in front of Gress felt wrong and finally she just shrugged.

“I don’t know,” Capella responded.

Gress squeezed her shoulder as he said, “Do you want to talk about it?”

“I… I was there right before he died,” Capella said and felt the tears fall a little faster. She buried her face into the mattress as they did, so Gress wouldn’t see.

“You don’t have to hide that you’re crying,” Gress said softly.

“I’m not, shut up,” Capella mumbled through the mattress.

“Hey, don’t do that,” Gress said. “Come up here.” Capella just shook her head and Gress went on. “OK, then I’m going to come down there.”

Capella didn’t say anything as he got off the bed and sat down beside her. He pulled the blanket down, wrapped her up in it, and then pulled her close. They sat that way for a little bit, Gress slipping in and out of sleep as Capella didn’t say anything. Finally she nudged him.

“You’re snoring,” Capella said.

“I am not,” Gress responded. “I’m sitting up. I can’t snore that way.”

“Well, whatever, I need to go,” Capella replied. “I didn’t mean to bother you.”

“Cappe, you’re not a bother to me,” Gress said. “Please, don’t leave.”

“I’m ok,” Capella said as she sat up and shrugged the blanket off herself and wiped at her eyes. “It was bound to happen. It’s just part of life.”

Gress took Capella's hand as he said, "That's not what you really feel."

"It doesn't matter," Capella said. "I have things I have to do."

"Stop," Gress said. "You need to stop and take a moment. You've been hit by one thing after another. It's OK to rest."

Capella sighed as she slowly slid flat on the floor, taking the blanket with her.

"Gress… I will, eventually, but I still have to go to Marasville, figure out what in the world is going on with Prickly Pear, I've probably really screwed up with that Half Ear guy and the rest as well now that I think about, and then on top of everything I have this and I just… I can't process it," Capella responded.

"Because you need a break," Gress replied as Capella rolled over onto her side and pulled the blanket closer to her. They both sat silent as Capella stared at the little penguins on Gress' pajamas. She remembered when he'd found them in some little store in Poview. He'd been thrilled, something about the little flightless cartoon birds cavorting about on the fabric had hit him just right, and he'd bought two sets that day. It hadn't been more than a year or so she thought but it seemed like she was remembering some long lost memory.

"How did the talk with, you know, Mom, go?" Capella asked.

“Did you read the message yet?” Gress said.

“Yeah,” Capella said.

“I don’t have a lot to add then,” Gress said. “I don’t know, she didn’t seem… she didn’t seem really dangerous I guess? That’d be the way she presents after all but she seemed pretty open.”

Capella nodded and kept staring at the penguins.

“Do you have any thoughts?” Gress said.

Capella shook her head but then began to speak anyway.

“Gress, I think I may have screwed up badly,” Capella said.

“How?” Gress asked.

Capella shrugged as she replied, “Juliet was there tonight when I… anyway, she was there and she figured out it was me and she told me that if she thought Dark Moon was really out of Bright Moon, she’d have done something about it.”

Capella went quiet as Gress said, “Well, she would say that. She’s not the commander anymore and hasn’t been for years though. You said it was recent from what you’re finding out with Coalfire. Maybe she doesn’t really know.”

Capella rolled onto her back to look at the ceiling as she said, “Yeah, but she keeps in touch with everyone there still. Gress, I think she’d know if it was out of Bright Moon. I might doubt a lot of people but Juliet, she’s always been, I don’t know, solid. Unmovable. The tone in her voice when she told me she’d have done something about it, I just really want to believe her.”

Gress stretched out beside Capella, putting his head on his hands as he looked up at the ceiling as well. A gentle quiet descended between the two and for a moment Capella thought Gress had gone back to sleep and so when she spoke again, it was soft and low, to avoid waking Gress if he had slipped off.

“I think maybe I need to speak with Mom as well. Somewhere neutral, somewhere safe,” Capella said.

Gress replied, “You sure?”

“Yeah,” Capella said. “Even enemies talk sometimes and I just… I’m beginning to think maybe she isn’t one.” She was quiet again before going on so quietly that Gress almost couldn’t hear her. “Grandpa Micah would have wanted us to try and reconcile.”

Capella felt Gress' hand rest on her arm and twitched as she fought the reflex to toss his hand off.

"What was that?" Gress replied.

"What do you mean?" Capella said.

"I was going to say something and when I put my hand on your arm, your whole arm twitched and then went stiff for a moment," Gress said.

"Sorry," Capella said as she looked at him. "You surprised me and I, uh, was fighting back throwing your hand off."

Gress took his hand back and started to say something and Capella shook her head as she took his hand and placed it back.

"It's alright," Capella said. "What did you want to say?"

"Just that, you don't have to reconcile with your mom if you don't want to do so. Your Grandpa may have wanted it but that's your decision," Gress said.

Capella sighed as she looked back at the ceiling and said, "I know. I still think I should. I think after Marasville I will."

Gress gave her arm a little squeeze and after another long moment of silence Capella spoke up.

"You know, I remember going on this one trip with Grandpa and Grandma. Mom and Dad were off planet for some crown thing and they took me on a tour by boat along the coast up towards the Kingdom of Snows in the summer. It wasn't a big boat and I remember laughing because Grandma Angella seemed so out of place among the crew. She's always so regal. Grandpa Micah though, he didn't seem to fit either but in a way I can't really describe but it didn't seem to bother him and the crew really loved him. He was always smiling, I remember that. When he really started going downhill a few years ago, that's how I knew something was really wrong because he wasn't smiling that much."

Capella stopped as she felt the tears returning and wiped at them.

"He really loved life," she managed to whisper before going quiet.

"From what I saw, he did. Can you tell me a memory of him that makes you laugh?" Gress said.

Capella shook her head as a sad smile drifted across her lips.

“That’s the most transparent Listener trick,” she said.

“I wouldn't say trick. Besides, I think you need a laugh,” Gress replied.

“I do,” Capella sighed. “I just keep thinking about sitting in the Bright Moon kitchens with him and having dried crickets and an orange fizzy drink with him as I told him about something I was interested in at the time and I just… I should have visited more.”

“You’ve been sneaking into Mystacor almost since you first went on the run,” Gress replied. “You did what you could.”

“That’s going to be on my gravestone,” Capella said with a sigh. “Here lies Capella, she did what she could and it was never enough.”

“You could have stopped before the last bit,” Gress said, uncomfortable at her mention of a gravestone. “You’ve made a lot of difference.”

“Not enough,” she said.

Gress gave her arm a little push as he said, “Don’t you dare try and pull that on me. I’ve been stuck in here this whole time while

you've been out running around. Yeah, it sucks, I get it, but you've done a lot and you're going to do a lot. Tell me something good you've done."

"Let it go, Gress," Capella said as she rolled over on her side.

"Hey, the tough person act might work with those other people but I've seen you cry over a grasshopper," Gress said. "So tell me something good you've done."

Capella looked over her shoulder as she said, "You said you wouldn't bring up the grasshopper again."

"And I won't if you tell me something good you've done and it has to be recent since you're being intransigent about it," Gress said.

"You've been in this hole too long," Capella grumbled. "Intransigent? Really?"

"It was my word of the day the other day," Gress said. "Now come on."

"Fine," Capella said as she flopped back onto her back. "I… I guess I did run Neral all the way out to Marasville."

"And you were there for Micah as much as you could be, you came to see me today, you are thinking through your problems and looking for answers…. well, you get the idea," Gress responded.

"Coming to see you for the first time in…," Capella started to say.

"Stop it," Gress said. "Yes, I wish you had come by before now but you did. Finally."

Capella gave a tired smile at Gress' little teasing "Finally" comment before sighing.

"What… what was the message that Mom gave you?" Capella asked.

"You sure you want to hear it right now?"

"Yes."

"I've got the full thing written down but the basic was she said that she had told you on your ninth birthday about how it'd be up to you whether or not you sat on the throne and she can see that you've decided that you won't but that her and your dad still love you, they're proud of what you're doing, she wishes she could talk to you, and she wished you were there," Gress said, watching Capella carefully.

Capella didn’t say anything at first. She just continued to stare at the ceiling. She wasn’t sure what to say because what Gress was saying was just confirming her belief that she’d messed up.

“I better go and make things right,” Capella said quietly.

“You’re going to go and see her?” Gress asked.

“I am. Not right now,” Capella replied. “I’m going to go and settle things with my team, then Marasville, and then after that, I’ll talk with her.”

“You want me to tell her?” Gress said.

Capella stared at the ceiling in thought before shaking her head.

“No, because what if I find out something that says she really was behind this?”

“Do you really think you will?” Gress asked.

“No, but I need to be careful,” Capella replied.

“Cappe…,” Gress started to say and Capella shook her head as she touched the scar on her arm without thinking.

“No, don’t. Step by step,” Capella said. “I’ll get there.”

“Don’t take too long,” Gress said as Capella sat up off the floor.

Capella stood looking at the door for a long moment as Gress stood up behind her. Gress’ data pad chirped as a message came through and Capella jumped a little bit before noticing his pad sitting on the table. She shook her head.

“I’m jumping at the sounds of data pads,” she said as she turned to Gress. “I couldn’t tell you the last time I had mine with the volume turned on.”

“You need a break,” Gress said.

“Don’t I know it,” Capella sighed before turning with her arms wide. Gress stepped forward into the hug. He felt Capella sag a little in his arms and when she finally stepped back her cheeks were damp from tears.

“Sure you don’t want to stay?” Gress said. “It’s safe here.”

"I know it is," Capella said. "I'll be back soon."

"Love you," Gress said.

"There's times I don't know why you still do but I love you too," Capella said.

"I might be incredibly angry with you sometimes but you're still my friend squared," Gress replied.

Capella's smile was one full of pain and sorrow but it was still a smile as she said, "Thank you."

Gress was about to ask her for what when she teleported out. He sat down on the bed with a sigh, looking at the spot she'd left, and turned the lights off again.

###

"Thank you to everyone for coming," Castaspella said, standing in the center of circles of chairs in a sunken garden at Bright Moon. The day was warm but promised rain after nightfall with clouds forming on the horizon. It'd only been a week since Micah's passing and they'd originally planned for his remembrance ceremony to be at Mystacor but after hearing of the various

people who'd planned on attending, it'd seemed best to have it at Bright Moon. The audience was immense, many standing at the back and more watching over data pad.

Castaspella had not known that her brother had been so beloved. She knew lots of people liked him but to see the physical representation of that in a crowd large enough that she wasn't sure she could see the edges of it, that was something else. It almost felt like the whole planet had been holding its breath during the ceremony. As people started to rise, talking quietly with each other, she walked over to where the family was sitting and couldn't help but notice the empty chair beside Glimmer. Glimmer had held it open, hoping that Capella would come and no one had tried to argue with her. Glimmer got up from her chair and came out to hug Castaspella as Juliet came over to her.

"You alright, Aunt Casta?" Glimmer said to her.

"I'll be OK and I could ask you the same," Castaspella said.

"I can't believe how many people showed up," Glimmer said as Juliet took Castaspella's hand.

"He was loved," Juliet said, her eyes flicking from person to person in the crowd.

"He was a good guy," Catra said as she came over to the group with Bow and Adora. "I remember after the war… well, I don't

want to talk about that. He was a good man."

The small group stood silently, the crowd staying away out of respect and followed the other princesses heading up towards the castle. They all quietly looked over at Angella occasionally where she was sitting and staring at the waist high pedestal that held several images of Micah. She hadn't said much since he'd passed, only answering direct questions for the most part. Glimmer had brought in Listeners and Angella had briefly spoken with them and then sent them on their way.

"How's your Mom?" Adora asked Glimmer.

"I don't know. She won't really talk with me," Glimmer replied. "I spent as much time with her as I can and we talked a little but I don't know what she's thinking."

Bow put his arm around Glimmer as she leaned into him.

"It's weird," Bow said. "I've never seen her be like this."

He nodded at one of the guards who'd come towards them.

"Are we ready to go inside?" Bow asked. "The dinner should be ready."

“No,” Glimmer said as she looked around the crowd. “We probably should though.”

“We can wait a minute longer, Starlight,” Bow said to her.

“It’s alright,” Glimmer said with a sigh as she watched the crowd again. “I was just hoping…”

“She’s probably here,” Catra said gently. “I can’t think she’d miss this.”

“I just wish she’d been able to be there more,” Glimmer said as she wiped at her eyes. Catra looked up to see Juliet looking back into the crowd again.

“You keep looking at the crowd, General,” Catra said. “Gotta admit, it makes me nervous.”

“Sorry,” Juliet said with a grimace. “Old habits and all that. Besides, he makes me nervous.”

They all turned to look at Aeron helping Carl to his feet, Carl’s leg in a huge brace and a cane in his hand. The two were surrounded by various people who all looked at them. Glimmer’s face had a flash of anger before she brought it under control.

“He all but accused me of timing Dad’s death so I could deny him his hearing,” Glimmer said.

“Well, I heard that he’s brought his case to the High Council of Etheria,” Bow said. “If we don’t do something soon…”

“OK, enough,” Castaspella said. “We’re not talking about that right now. Let’s go to the castle.”

“I’m going to stay behind with Mom,” Glimmer said. “We’ll come up when she’s ready.”

“Do you want me to stay with you?” Bow asked.

“No,” Glimmer said, pulling him down for a quick kiss. “We may take a while.”

Glimmer went over to where Angella still sat, not having moved, and settled into the chair next to her. Most of the chairs were empty around her by then, most of the people having moved on except for one woman who lingered and seemed to be looking at Angella. Glimmer gave her an odd look and the woman looked away and went on her way.

“Everyone’s going up for the dinner, Mom,” Glimmer said as she took Angella’s hand.

Angella squeezed her hand for a moment then said, “I’m not hungry, sweetheart. Go on without me.”

Glimmer let the silence between them stretch before speaking up again.

“Mom, I’m really worried about you,” Glimmer said. “You’re shutting down. You’re not talking and it’s scaring me. I’m losing too many people; I’m scared of losing you too.”

Angella looked down at Glimmer with tears in her eyes.

“Oh, Glimmer, I didn’t mean to do that to you. I’m sorry,” Angella said as she put an arm around her. “I’m just getting used to not having him around again and I have to keep telling myself there’s not some scrappy group of friends or magical technology solution that’s going to bring him back this time.”

Glimmer leaned into her mom’s arm as she said, “I know. I remember a few months back being so mad because I had to go through this again but of course you are as well.”

“I just don’t know what to say,” Angella replied. “And speaking with a Listener about it, before you suggest it, just doesn’t feel right.”

“Then talk to your daughter about it,” Glimmer said. “Otherwise you’re going to be getting bugged by her a lot.”

Angella turned and looked at Glimmer and cupped her face in a hand. She looked at her and sighed.

“You look so much like him,” she said. “You’re so much like him in other ways as well.”

“Stubborn you mean,” Glimmer said.

“That too,” Angella said. She paused a moment before going on. “Would you be alright if I moved back to Bright Moon?”

Glimmer sat back a little in surprise but was already nodding as well when she replied.

“Of course, Mom. I thought you liked living in Mystacor though,” Glimmer said.

“I did but now everything makes me think of him,” Angella said. “Would you mind having your mother around?”

“Of course not,” Glimmer said and then got to her feet as Angella did.

“I’m going to go on to my room,” Angella said. “Please make my apologies for not coming to the dinner.”

“Anyone who makes a fuss and requires an apology for you not being there doesn’t deserve one and won’t get one,” Glimmer said. “Want me to take you?”

“No, thank you,” Angella replied. “I’m going to walk through the gardens first. I love you, Glimmer.”

“I love you too, Mom,” Glimmer replied as she hugged her tight.

# # #

Later that evening, after Glimmer and Bow had gone on to bed, Finn, Izzy, and Elliepurr were sitting around in Catra and Adora’s room at Bright Moon. Finn was curled up beside Izzy as Elliepurr listened to a book through her data pad.

“I still can’t believe he’s gone you know,” Finn said as Izzy slowly scratched between their ears.

“I feel bad that I didn’t really get to know him,” Izzy said.

“Why not?” Elliepurr said as she shut the data pad down, took out the earpiece, and set both into her shoulder bag.

“I started dating Finn, then we went on that big adventure, then I just had to go and get the title of Dryl, and then it was running Dryl, and this and that, and I just never got to spend much time with him,” Izzy said.

Elliepurr nodded as Finn looked at her and finally spoke up.

“Ellie, you’ve talked about your parents a little but why have I never met them?” Finn asked.

Elliepurr shrugged as she said, “Because they’re dead, Finn.”

Finn blinked in surprise as they sat up and opened their mouth a few times before finally saying, “When!?”

Elliepurr shrugged again as she said, “Dad died when I was in the Waste. Mom wasn’t too long after I came to live in Bright Moon.”

“Ellie! Why are you so blase about this!?” Finn said and then stopped suddenly. “Oh.”

“Yes, oh,” Elliepurr said. “I bet Izzy put that together faster.”

Izzy was nodding but spoke up for Elliepurr's benefit as she said, "Yeah, I did as soon as Finn asked you."

"I'm sorry, Ellie," Finn said. "I wasn't thinking."

"It's alright. I'm glad you have a family you don't have to feel that way about," Elliepurr said before her voice got a little bitter. "It's what I always wanted to give you."

Finn got up and went to sit down by Elliepurr and hugged her.

"You might not have had a chance to do so when I was a kid but you do now and I thank you for it," Finn said as Elliepurr leaned into them.

Elliepurr hugged Finn back as she said, "We're not going to get into this again. I have enough to talk with my Listener as it is but I am glad I'm here. By the way, did anyone get to Cappe and speak to her at the funeral today?"

Finn and Izzy both looked at each other and then at Elliepurr.

"What are you talking about?" Izzy said. "She wasn't there."

“Yes she was; I could smell her,” Elliepurr said. “She was sitting downwind of us but not too far. Did you not see her?”

“Ellie, she’s been using illusion magic,” Izzy said. “And from what I’ve heard she’s got real good about disguising her voice as well.”

“I did not think of that,” Elliepurr said as she tapped beside her eyes. “Not used to thinking in those terms but Finn, I figured you’d be able to tell.”

“I’m not that good at distinguishing smells like that,” Finn said. “I can tell Izzy apart and you and Mom and Mother but I wouldn’t want to bet on doing it consistently. We need to tell Aunt Glimmer and Uncle Bow about this though!”

“Tell them what?” Adora said as she came in with her jacket over her arm. Catra came in behind her pushing a little cart with some food on it.

“Ellie says she smelled Cappe at the remembrance ceremony today,” Finn said.

“They already know she was there,” Catra said. “That’s why we took so long coming back. She sent a message to them through the Bright Moon guard.”

Everyone went quiet, everyone wanting to ask what it said but no one wanting to just come out and find out.

"OK, I hear everyone shifting uncomfortably so I'll just ask. What did it say?" Elliepurr said.

"It was really curt but she gave her condolences, said she'd been in the crowd, and then said that she wanted to meet with her parents at some point," Catra said. "She said she had things to do but would be in contact again."

"Well that's good!" Finn said and then noticed everyone's faces. "Right?"

"Glimmer and Bow are both taking it that way but it's still a lot," Adora said.

"I love that girl more than I can say but she needs to make up her mind and either be here or leave them be," Elliepurr said. "She's not being intentionally cruel I think but it doesn't matter."

"Ellie, I'm sure she has her reasons," Finn replied.

"Probably but it still hurts," Elliepurr said, her face grimacing and then softening as Finn gave her a hug again. The conversation lagged for a moment and Izzy took the moment to get up and make a small plate. Everyone else took that chance to do the

same, with Finn helping Elliepurr with hers, and the conversation drifted on late into the evening.

###

"You know, I thought there'd be something different, some kind of profound shift, now that he's gone," Glimmer said with a sigh. "It just feels the same except… I don't know, not."

Bow slowly stroked her hair as they both lay in bed and looked out into the dark.

"Honestly, the last week hasn't felt real," Bow said.

Glimmer sighed in agreement and said, "Then that note. If it hadn't had her thumbprint on it, I wouldn't have believed it was her. It didn't sound like her."

"She's obviously different now," Bow said, hugging Glimmer. "I can't imagine Cappe not coming to see us today but at least she said she wants to meet."

Glimmer snuggled up closer to Bow as she said, "What do you think it'll be like?"

“Seeing her?” Bow asked and Glimmer nodded. “I don’t know. It won’t be like we want; I think I can say that.”

“Your Listener said that too huh?” Glimmer said with a little laugh.

Bow didn’t laugh but smiled a little as he said, “Yeah, they did.”

They were quiet for a little bit, neither getting any closer to sleep, when Glimmer finally said, “I miss him.”

“I do as well,” Bow said.

Glimmer wiped at her eyes as she said, “I don’t think I’ll ever stop missing him. I remember once, right before we left on that trip and found that second Heart, sitting in his room with him putting a puzzle together. It was some puzzle of the Whispering Woods and he just stopped and stared at the big piece we had put together. ‘I remember taking you here,’ he said. I didn’t know what he meant at first. Then he pointed to a little spot and said, ‘When you were maybe two, we went there for a picnic. You ran around and kept getting your dress caught on branches and you finally stomped your foot, grabbed a stick, and started hitting the branches when they caught your dress. It didn’t take long before the trees started pulling back when you ran past.’ He laughed at the memory. We ended up leaving the puzzle and going to that spot for lunch that day.”

Glimmer went quiet as she remembered her father's happy face that day. She'd been robbed of him in her childhood but she had managed to have a good relationship with him over the following decades after he'd been found again. The memories were painful at the moment but even then, they were still a gift.

"We should go see your fathers soon," Glimmer said.

Bow replied, "I was thinking the same."

###

Angella sat on a ledge far up the mountain side above Bright Moon and watched the stars as she and Micah had done for years after they'd been reunited. She felt blank, like a strong wind had blown through her and cleared her out, body and soul. She had thought she'd cry more after the ceremony but it'd never seemed to come. She'd cried when he began to forget things. She'd cried as he forgot one thing after another as his memories seemed to swirl around a drain, popping up occasionally but ultimately sliding down and away for good. She'd wept when he forgot Glimmer and other friends and family.

When the day had come when he forgot her for the first time, she'd wept so hard she thought she'd never do anything but that. However, that had subsided and she'd carried on. Things continued on. Life continued on. She wasn't sure though what life she would carry on doing and so she sat on a ledge and watched the stars and wondered why she wouldn't cry.

Memories began to leak in then. Memories of him gently kissing her forehead after the birth of Glimmer. Memories of their first date and him nervously talking about magic for an hour before she'd smiled and gently steered him away to another subject. Memories of their wedding and memories of just sitting around doing nothing important but it had been important because they were together. Memories of her waking up after being pulled out from a frozen bubble of time and seeing his face hovering over her and for a moment not realizing who it was and then the overwhelming emotion when she realized what had happened and over the next few days realizing it wasn't a dream, that she was actually getting a second chance to be with him and live with him and love him as much as she could manage.

Then the tears came as she thought of the intervening years until his death, about their life traveling and working for good causes, all the while making sure to grasp every moment they could together, never letting a second pass without the other if at all possible. She realized then, even though neither had ever said it, they both knew that it could end at any moment, that the future hadn't been promised and that when they were finally parted for the last time, they wanted to be sure they'd drank down every second of every day that they could. As she wept at the loss she knew she could say they'd drank to the fullest. Her life would go on and she'd never regret a moment or regret any memory of him because it was a moment spent with him.

Chapter End Notes

Summary: The story is almost entirely dealing with Micah's death and funeral. The only part of story progress is that Capella attended in disguise and sent a note to her parents telling them that she wants to eventually meet with them.

Note: Hello, the last few paragraphs make me choke up every time.

Various

Chapter Summary

> We follow several different characters as they go about their day.

Chapter Notes

> "Pouring the fuel, fanning the flames / Breaking the habit and melting the chains / Embracing the fear, chasing the fight / The glow of the fire will light up the night / The bridges are burning, the heat's on my face / Making the past an unreachable place / Pouring the fuel, fanning the flames / I know, this is the point of no return" Point of No Return by Starset
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary
>
> Note: This chapter has some non-canon typical violence. Nothing that would require me to change the rating I think but just a heads up.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“You’ve put it off this long, you can put it off longer,” Coalfire said as Capella went through her bags one more time to make sure there was nothing incriminating in them. She was dressed like she did in the Waste, heavy canvas clothes and heavy boots, as she shook her head.

“All the more reason to do this,” Capella said. She’d been back from Bright Moon for only a day and Coalfire was starting to get on her nerves. Again.

When she'd come back after the big fight with Half Ear, there'd been some arguments but things had smoothed out finally. Then two days later, Half Ear had left, leaving a note that said he quit, and Capella hadn't had a problem with it. Coalfire though had blown up until Capella had finally put her foot down.

"He doesn't want to be involved, he's made it clear since the beginning how much he hates me, and he hasn't been of much help," Capella snapped back at her finally. "Why do you want him around so badly?"

"Because of what you're about to do for one!" Coalfire said. "When you go to Marasville, you're going to need backup!"

"Take Half Ear, the guy who hates me, into the place that hates spacebats?" Capella said. "You really think that's going to be useful?"

"We don't know that for certain!" Coalfire said and Capella had rolled her eyes at her. "Stop that! You know you're jumping to conclusions on this!"

"I'm the head of this thing," Capella said. "You didn't used to have a problem with that. Do you now?"

Dio had been watching the whole thing with a little grin on her face and Coalfire had finally backed down. She'd kept working with Capella on the illusion magic though, even though Capella

felt like they didn't really do that much progress anymore, and when Capella had gone on to Bright Moon, Coalfire had even argued that a little bit. Capella hadn't let that get far, stomping on the discussion fast.

"It's for my grandfather and you can just follow Half Ear if you think I'm going to listen to you on this," Capella had responded. "End of discussion."

Now, as she got ready to start her teleport jumps to Marasville, Coalfire was making one last plea.

"At least take me with you," Coalfire said.

"Why are you freaking out so much?" Capella replied. "You didn't used to worry this much about me going out."

"Because you weren't going that far. You did your little visits where you'd be gone for a while but Bright Moon… you were gone for two days! Out of contact at that! Then you get back and say you want to meet with the Queen when this is done! It's enough to make one worry that maybe you're making a mistake," Coalfire responded. "A dangerous one that might affect all of us."

"What are you worried about? If she's not who I think she is, then you're fine, you watched over me while I was on the run and she'll appreciate that. If she is behind Dark Moon after all, then better we know now," Capella responded.

“Fine. There’s one more thing. I think that maybe you’re being tracked,” Coalfire said. “Ask Alice about it.”

“I know I am. We both know how many people are looking for me,” Capella responded.

“No, tracked as in like if you had a tracker chip on you or something,” Coalfire said. “Ask Alice.”

“Alice?” Capella said as she strapped her bags shut and hung them over her arm, making sure her dagger was accessible at her hip.

“OK, so I have kind of noticed something. When you teleport somewhere, we tend to have that Iceson character show up in the area not too long after or what we’re doing there ends up being more difficult, like someone got a warning. But when we’ve flown in or drove in or whatever, we manage much easier and can operate longer,” Alice replied. “I haven’t put hard numbers to it but it’s definitely a pattern that says tracking.”

“OK, well, I’m going to Candila, a long way from nothing, so unless they’re waiting on me there, I should have a little time to operate,” Capella responded. “Alice, just pay attention to the comms. I’d tell Dio to be ready with a skiff but that would require her to be here.” Capella gave a little humorless laugh at that. Ever since they’d been in Plumeria, Dio had been at one party after another for the most part. “And Coalfire, you need to take a

breath. You've taught me well. I just spent two days in Bright Moon undetected, largely thanks to your teaching, and I don't see this being any different."

Coalfire started to say something and Capella didn't bother to wait to hear it as she teleported out.

# # #

Aeron sat in the office space that he'd leased in Bright Moon. He watched Carl come in on his cane and sit down. The knee was healing well and as soon as they could they had moved out of the castle.

"The High Council has approved hearings for the princess title as well as the rehabilitation hearing," Carl said. "I'm pushing for the date and time as we discussed."

"Think it'll make a difference?" Aeron said as he thought.

"The authority of it will matter and of course the disruption if we can time it correctly," Carl replied. "And I think we have enough votes to make a difference. Think they'll try and appeal to She-Ra?"

"I expect them to and if they don't, we'll get someone else to do so," Aeron said with a grin.

Carl, who knew about She-Ra being gone, grinned as he said, “By the way, our little friend Bryce is singing but for some reason they aren’t doing anything about it. He ID’d both of us from what I’ve heard.”

Aeron nodded as he pushed his data pad back and forth.

“I heard that as well,” he said. “I’m not sure why they haven’t done anything about it though.”

“Waiting to see how the rest of this plays out? Show it as evidence maybe? I can think of several ways it might work,” Carl said.

Aeron showed a surprised face as she said, “An ex-husband with a grudge against his ex-wife and it’s obvious he’s been coerced into naming his daughter’s enemies as the people who pushed him into it so his daughter can try and cover up the whole sordid mess is how I see it.”

“That’s certainly what we’ll say repeatedly,” Carl replied with a laugh. “Also, the groups for the attacks are in place. We’ll be ready to move soon.”

“You’ve kept it secret from everyone here?” Aeron said.

“Yes,” Carl said. “I still think you’re being paranoid about this.”

“I still think there’s a leak,” Aeron replied. “I know you thought it was Entary but he seems clean but I still don’t like it.”

“Well nothing we’ve given him has leaked,” Carl said. “That’s all I’ll say for it.”

“Tandini vouches for him, so I trust him for now,” Aeron said.

“Not going to argue this with you again,” Carl said as he picked up Aeron’s data pad and tapped on it for a moment and then slid it back to him. “OK, I’ve got the programming done that we talked about. It’s loaded and ready and I did some testing on it. It’ll run as designed.”

“You’re certain? The disruption is vital for our attacks to get far enough,” Aeron said.

“I’m 100% certain,” Carl said. “I even put in the bit that de-orbits the satellites.”

Aeron chuckled as he said, “Excellent. And we’ve secured our own communications?”

“Yes, we have,” Carl said.

“OK, clear up that loose end out in Marasville and give the command to move forward. Let’s make your dream a reality,” Aeron said.

Carl leaned across the desk and took his hand and squeezed it as he said, “Our dream.”

Aeron kissed Carl’s knuckles as he said, “Yes. Our dream.”

# # #

Izzy walked through the halls of Dryl as Harpi followed along with a little pep in his step.

“You’re in a good mood today,” Izzy responded. “Relationship going well?”

“It is,” Harpi responded. “We’re actually talking about moving in together.”

Izzy smiled as she said, “Congratulations! Does this mean you’re moving to Bright Moon?”

Harpi didn’t say anything for a long moment and Izzy stopped and looked at him.

“Brother Harpi?” she said as she looked at him, his face impassive but his ears going back a little in what she knew to be an awkward stance.

“We’d discussed it, yes,” Harpi said. “But don’t worry! I won’t leave without a proper replacement and plenty of notice!”

Izzy laughed as she said, “Harpi, if you want to leave right now and go be with him, I wouldn’t stop you. Heck, I’d get you the skiff myself. You’re invaluable to me but I’ll figure it out.”

“No, we will figure it out and he may very well decide to move here instead,” Harpi replied. “We have not decided.”

They started walking again as Izzy said, “Well, I’m happy for you.”

“Thank you,” Harpi responded. “We’re happy for ourselves.”

They settled into her office as Izzy said, “OK, we need to figure out this whole trial of me thing. Glimmer is being kind, letting me be here, but ultimately we do need to get it done. Aeron has already taken his princess status and the rehabilitation complaint

to the High Council of Etheria. If we don't make a move soon at the Princess Council level, they will bring us all in and they can compel compliance from us."

"What do you think will be the result?" Harpi said.

"I don't know," Izzy said. "This has honestly never been tested before. I'm betting on him actually winning on the princess thing. Glimmer's only holding him up now because he's being a jackass and we're hoping he'll slip somehow. The paperwork is more than in order and he's releasing those videos talking about how the crown 'found him' so public sympathy is swinging his way as well. The rehabilitation is a toss-up though and I don't like that any less for its uncertainty."

Harpi nodded as he flipped through his data pad.

"OK, in other information we still have a bunch of people camped out in front of the gates," Harpi said. "We've approached them several times to be sure they're comfortable and if they need anything. They're polite but all they seem really interested in doing is surveying the castle and its grounds and occasionally going into the theater."

Izzy frowned as she thought of that.

"Any Inner Circle people in that group?" she said, referring to people directly working with Aeron.

“No,” Harpi said. “Unless they’re staying very well hidden.”

“Well, Dryl is open to all,” Izzy said. “Although why they’d want to be in Dryl in the winter is anyone’s guess.”

“What do you mean? It’s nice,” Harpi said with a smile.

“It’s snowy and gray,” Izzy said. “We love it because it’s home but there’s much better tourist destinations. Still, as long as they’re happy, I’m happy.” Izzy sighed as she thought about information she’d just found out about. “On another note, we need to figure out how to talk with Snow-by. I still can’t believe he got himself next to Aeron. If we can get secure communications with him, we can wrap it up quickly.”

“Blu saw him in Bright Moon the other day,” Harpi replied. “She said he gave her the ‘Can’t Talk Under Watch’ sign.”

Izzy sighed as she nodded.

“It’s what it is but still, we need to think about it,” she said. “What’s the next order of business?”

“It’s…,” Harpi started to say and then poked at his data pad. Izzy sat up a little straighter as she listened to Pat in her headband say

something.

"Did you lose connectivity as well?" Izzy asked.

"I did. Can't get the main Etherian network either," Harpi said.

"Weird," Izzy replied.

# # #

Capella appeared in the wasteland that was Candila. She made sure her illusion was in place before taking a quick roll in the dust to give a little semblance of her having walked a long way before stepping out onto the dirt road that trailed off into the distance. She wasn't sure what she was expecting but relentless silence wasn't on the menu. The wind wasn't even blowing at the moment and the stillness and almost warm day even in the dead of winter around her made her nerves jump as she looked around at the curving dead brush that didn't seem to be rotting so much as getting mummified.

This isn't ominous at all, she thought as she began to walk. She didn't walk far before she could see Marasville off in the distance. The collection of low houses didn't seem that remarkable but on the hillside over the town she could see what looked like the curves of a greenhouse, the white of the fabric standing out starkly against the red landscape around it. As she walked along she couldn't help but feel like someone was watching her and she

occasionally looked around to see if she could spot someone. As she approached a wooden sign with Marasville carved into it, she was about ready to say that it was just the silence making her overly paranoid when someone stood up from behind a pile of rocks.

"Who are you?" they said with a suspicious look. Capella would have guessed they were from Salineas originally, since they seemed to be a sea elf from the coast near there, but the clothes they wore were a mix of heavy canvas and linens all done in earth tones. What definitely caught Capella's eye though was the old Horde laser cannon they had hung over their shoulder and the stun baton holstered at their waist.

Capella gave her best smile as she said, "My name is Almond and I've come a long way from Plumeria to say this. Mara was right."

Gress had dug deep into the Mara thing they kept running into and coached Capella about it so she knew exactly what she was saying when she said those words and it sickened her. Her old tutor, Raskin, had taught her about Mara and what she had done and her Aunt Adora had told her about meeting Mara in the Crystal Castle and finding her ship and her message during the war. To see Mara's sacrifice and wish twisted in such a way drove spikes of anger through Capella but she shoved those feelings down and didn't show any negative emotion as she said those three words. And the three words changed the person's whole attitude.

"Mara was right!" they said with a blossoming smile. "Welcome to Marasville, Almond. My name is Van and I'm out here to make sure we don't have any sneaky little people try to get in."

“Well they’d have to be dedicated to get up that road,” Capella said with a backwards nod of her head.

Van laughed as they said, “That’s true but we’re going to be big soon. You never know who’s going to be poking around. So how did you hear about us?”

Capella was tempted to just tell them she’d heard about them from former Children of Mara members who were probably twitchy around sparkles now but she kept it in check as she said, “I heard about you from SharpeiTropics on the Keeping It data board.”

Van didn’t respond at first and Capella started to sweat a little. Gress had infiltrated the data board and impersonated the person she was pretending to be so she’d have a cover and she began to wonder if maybe they should have held off longer and let that person’s digital persona get more of a polish. Then Van laughed again as they said, “Sorry! Took me a moment. I’m kind of surprised anyone on that board even knows about this place. They’re posers but I guess any friend is a good friend in the fight and you obviously took the time so at least you’re cool. I gotta say though, not a lot of us around right now.”

Capella desperately wanted to ask why, because she had noticed that even though it was just a little past mid-day, she hadn’t seen anyone moving around in the town but she just shrugged.

“No problem,” Capella said. “I honestly wasn’t even sure what I was going to do when I got here, I just knew that I heard you all were against the blankeyes and that you were building Mara’s dream out here. I figured I had to be in on that, even if it was digging a ditch or something.”

Capella inwardly cringed at the awful word but her outer exterior kept up as Van grinned and said, “I have to say, it’s good to hear that. We’ve had a few come out this way who thought it was just going to be a place to hang out. We work hard out here.”

“I never expected less. In fact, I’d question if it was worth it if you didn’t,” Capella said with a knowing nod.

Van said, “Listen, I gotta stay out here and there’s no one really in town to welcome you but you see that white building over there?” Van pointed at what Capella had thought looked like a greenhouse and she nodded. “That’s our aquaponics facility. Go on up there and talk to Skua, she’s in charge. She can probably find something for you to do and get you settled too.”

Capella nodded, feeling like she should know that name for some reason but not really making any connection.

“Can do,” Capella said. Capella started walking when Van suddenly called out to her. She carefully turned around. “What’s up?”

Van came over to her, keeping their voice low, as they said, "I forgot to mention it to you but her fiance is a Listener among other things. Skua isn't really into politics, she's here to run the facility but she's alright. That said, still best to keep things to yourself around her and definitely around her fiance."

"Can do," Capella said with a little salute.

"You'll do fine," Van said and turned to go trotting back to their hiding place.

Capella walked through the small town towards the greenhouse and as she did, she took mental notes of what she saw. It was well kept but very simple. The buildings all seemed to be made out of the same red stone, she assumed locally quarried somewhere, and there were no real decorations on any of them. As she turned up the path towards the greenhouse, she saw a small house set off a little bit and she heard the sound of wind chimes coming from it. It was one of the loudest things she'd heard in town because even though Gress had estimated the town to have just under two hundred people living there, she hadn't really seen anyone so far and it was setting her anxiety to screaming.

As she trudged up the hill, she wondered why the name Skua seemed so familiar. It kept nagging at her but she couldn't quite place it. She kept thinking maybe it was a name for one of the Children of Mara but she wasn't sure. She considered powering up her data pad to find out but remembered she was keeping electronic silence. Alice had advised her to do that unless she absolutely needed a connection because she'd argued that with so

few people, an additional electronic signal might stand out too much.

Let it go. Trying to force the memory isn't going to work, Capella thought as she came to the door of the greenhouse. She stepped through and found out the door was setup like an airlock. Capella shut the outer door, her gut twisting as she stood in the little room with no cover. She reached forward and let out a little sigh as the inner door opened with no problem and she stepped through. She expected to be met by the riotous smells of fish and the nutrient rich water flowing through the racks, like she'd experienced in Frosta's castle greenhouses, but instead she was met with very little of that. In fact, she noticed the air, while damper than outside, didn't seem much different.

"Hello?" she heard a voice call out and Capella started walking towards it.

"Hello," Capella responded in return as she turned a corner and saw a woman sitting down in a chair as she looked up from a data pad. "I'm new in town. Van sent me up here to see if you could use some help. Are you Skua?"

The woman before her was so familiar and Capella again tried to figure out why. She was almost sure that she'd seen her face before, maybe in a Children of Mara report that Gress had done or maybe somewhere else, and she spent a second trying to take mental notes so she could compare the face before her to any source Gress might have when she got a chance. For now though, she just kept calm and waited to see what would happen next.

"I am!" Skua said and stretched her arms out wide. "Welcome to my domain! I've managed to do some amazing things with this place!"

Capella looked around, not knowing really anything about the design of aquaponics, but she could see it really mattered to Skua and so she figured getting her talking wouldn't hurt.

"It's quite the place," Capella said. "I don't know much about this kind of thing though. What can you tell me about it?"

Skua grinned as she said, "What *can't* I tell you about this!? Let me start with what a basic setup normally looks like and then we can talk about the challenges!"

Capella nodded and was still nodding ten minutes later as they walked along the racks and Skua said, "And that's how you set up a basic aquaponics setup. However, here, you can't do that because water is incredibly scarce. That's why we have airlocks on the doors. Minimize water waste. It's why the fish trenches are enclosed as well. Recapture the water that evaporates off the surface." Skua gave a little kick at a white dome that ran along under the racks. "Makes for other issues with things like dissolved oxygen and proper lighting for the fish but I'll go into that in a moment. Do you have any questions for me yet?"

Capella, who was thinking that Skua was reminding her of Izzy when she went on an infodump, said with a laugh, "I'm not even sure where to start!"

Skua grinned as she said, "I understand. My fiance says the same thing when I start talking about it. I love this kind of thing and the chance to come out here and get this going was amazing. I'm originally from the Kingdom of Snows myself."

Capella nodded, her mind distant for a moment as she tucked away that bit of information and so her response was a bit distant than what she'd expected as she said, "Crimson Waste myself although I've been living in Plumeria before I came out here."

Skua's face changed as she said, "Oh, I'm sorry! I wasn't prying! You didn't have to share that!"

Capella was confused as she said, "It's OK, really."

Skua had a hand up in apology as she said, "Thank you for that. I keep forgetting people around here don't like talking about where they're from. Just a heads up for you."

Capella shrugged as she said, "Well, it doesn't bother me but I'll keep it in mind."

A little chirp sounded from Skua's data pad as she said, "Oh, there's not much to do right now. Honestly, most of this is automated so I don't know what I can have you doing but you're more than welcome to be here. Do you have a place to stay yet?"

Capella shook her head as she said, “I don’t. I’ve got a shelter cloth and food though. I can just set up somewhere.”

“Wouldn’t hear of it,” Skua said. “At the very least come and have lunch with us if you’re alright with that and then after we can find a place for you.”

Capella, seeing a chance to further question her and her fiance, grinned as she said, “Deal.”

# # #

Artho sat on her chair on the front porch. She never thought she’d hate a place like she hated Marasville. No one talked with her really and no one came to her for Listening sessions. It probably had to do with Artho getting into several heated arguments with the town’s inhabitants about their beliefs around Mara and clones and she knew the only reason she wasn’t just run out of town, or worse, was because Skua was getting their greenhouse setup for them. She and Skua had gone through several conversations, and one argument, about leaving as soon as possible but Artho understood that this kind of project would really help Skua in her job and Artho was holding on for her. She knew the greenhouse didn’t have much else that Skua needed to hang on for though and she was wondering if maybe it was time to bring up leaving again.

“Graaahhhhh!” a little voice roared behind Artho. Artho jumped to her feet, her tail quivering in mock fear, as she turned to see Puffin hiding behind the chair with her hands inside mittens that looked like polar bear paws.

“Oh, you startled me!” Artho said.

“I’m a polar bear! I’m going to get you Momma Artho!” Puffin said as she rushed forward at her.

Artho took several jumps backwards as she replied, “Oh no! Nothing can stop the Puffin Polar Bear except one thing!” As Puffin got close, Artho scooped her up in her arms and tickled her belly. “And that’s tickles!”

Puffin screeched with laughter as Artho tickled her.

“Ok! Ok! Stop!” Puffin laughed and Artho put her on her hip as she gave her a one armed hug.

“Your Mom is going to be home soon,” Artho said. “You want to help me get lunch ready?”

“No,” Puffin said, shaking her head. “Can I set the table though?”

“Sure,” Artho said as she sat her down and started towards the door. The windchimes that Oak had sent to her tinkled in the breeze and Artho had to fight back a feeling of homesickness. If she was honest, it wasn’t even homesickness, it was just a desire to be anywhere but Marasville.

“Can we have Dump It In Delight?” Puffin said as Artho sat her down in the doorway and watched her run in.

Artho grinned at the name and remembered telling Puffin about the meal Finn had cooked in Horror Hall one night during the big adventure to find Finn’s biological parents.

“OK, if we’re going to do that, then you’re going to have to help. You know the rule. Each of us has to pick what goes in the pot. You get two and I get two,” Artho said as she got a pot out from under the counter. Puffin nodded eagerly and started rummaging through the canned goods. As she did, Artho set the pot on the stove and then turned to see what Puffin had found.

“Let’s see, a can of hominy and a can of corn,” Artho said and resisted the urge to point out that it would be a whole lot of corn. “Sounds good. Now my turn.”

She dug around and pulled out two big cans of soup and set them next to the pot.

“Vegetable soup?” Puffin said with a raised eyebrow. Artho constantly wondered where she’d picked that habit up but just nodded.

“You wanted Dump It In,” Artho said. “That’s my two choices.”

“You’re just trying to get me to eat more veggies,” Puffin said, screwing her face up in disgust.

“That is very possible,” Artho said with a grin. “Or it could be that I grew up with a Plumerian mother who loves vegetables and so do I and I’m hoping to pass it on to you.”

Puffin sighed as she said, “No, you’re just trying to get me to eat veggies.”

Artho leaned over and beaconed her forward with her tail. Puffin stepped closer and Artho said in a whisper, “You found me out but it’s your choice for what to eat so I think you really wanted it anyway.”

Puffin giggled as Artho winked at her and Artho stood back up and began to open up the cans.

“Would you set the table please?” Artho said as she started the stove and dumped the cans into the pot. Puffin nodded and started picking up bowls and silverware and placemats and Artho

watched her stack them all together and resisted the urge to tell her to make more than one trip. Then Artho's face lit up as she heard Skua calling her name as she came in the door.

"Dump It In Delight for lunch I see," Skua said as she came over to give Artho a kiss. Artho kissed her back and then saw someone standing still as can be in the doorway. Skua noticed and said, "Almond, this is my fiance Artho and my daughter Puffin. Almond has just arrived in town today and Van sent her up to the greenhouse to work. We didn't get much done but I invited her for lunch and then to help her find a place to stay."

Artho looked at Almond who was still standing in the doorway with several beat up bags over her shoulder, a dagger at her hip, and heavy canvas clothes that reminded her of someone from the Crimson Waste, and couldn't help but feel like something felt familiar. She couldn't help but go into Listener mode as she looked at Almond's face. It seemed to be composed and just a bit shy, like you'd expect from someone entering someone else's home for the first time, but something about the eyes unsettled Artho.

Leery and watchful, Artho thought. *They look like someone who doesn't trust anyone.*

Having guessed a little bit about some of the people who'd come to town, Artho wasn't sure she liked a person like that, especially one who carried a dagger as easily as Almond did, in her home. However, Skua had invited her and she wasn't going to tell her no.

“Welcome,” Artho said. “Puffin, sweetheart, can you get another setting for our guest please?”

Puffin nodded, not taking her eyes off Almond as she quietly got the extra setting. Skua leaned down to give the little girl a kiss and a hug and Artho ached to see the girl become so withdrawn around strangers but all she could do was try and guide the little girl as best she could and let her work through it.

Almond still stood in the door, barely having moved since she’d stepped in, and Artho nodded at a little hall tree near the door.

“You can hang your bags, coat, and dagger right there,” she said. “Your boots can go on the rug next to our shoes please.”

For a moment, Artho wasn’t sure the woman heard her and then for another moment she wasn’t sure the woman was going to relinquish anything but finally the woman nodded, croaked out a thank you, and began to hang the bags on the hall tree. Artho noticed she hung the dagger last, where it would be very easy to access, and that was what made Artho finally notice how Almond was looking quickly around, as if she was making sure of all the exits and potential cover as she sat down on the little bench built into the hall tree.

What has this woman been through? Artho wondered as she stirred the food as it warmed on the stove. Artho knew a survivor of violence when she saw one. Her worry about the kind of person Almond might be stepped back a little for Artho wondering what she might be able to do to help her.

“Almond, why don’t you take that chair there,” Artho said, nodding at a chair sitting against the wall by the table. “What can we get you to drink? We have some fizzy drinks, water, and that’s about it.”

Puffin’s eyes snapped up at Artho and she looked at Almond before trotting over to Artho and whispering, “You said we couldn't drink the fizzy drinks.”

Artho leaned down to whisper back, “I said we should save them for a special occasion and we don’t often have guests so I’d say it’s a special occasion. Can you ask our guest what she’d like?”

Puffin looked back at Almond then nodded solemnly and turned around as she said, “Almond, what would you like to drink?”

The question was asked very quietly but Almond nodded as she replied, “I’d like an orange fizzy drink if you have one please.”

“We do,” Artho said, confused by the sudden manners. Skua got the drinks out and helped Puffin get the cups ready. “This will be ready in a moment. Old recipe a friend of mine taught me once called Dump It In Delight.” Artho saw a twitch on the woman’s face and turned to look at her a little closer. “Have you heard of it before?”

“No, but I saw the cans and then the name and I kind of put together what it is,” Almond said. “Funny.”

Almond wasn’t laughing but Artho laughed anyway, just to try and break the ice a little. She gave the pot one last stir as she saw it start to bubble, grabbed some pot holders, and brought the pot over to the table as Skua and Puffin sat the drinks on the table.

“I’m sorry, is there something I can help with?” Almond asked as she stood up and Artho’s opinion of the woman went up a little.

“No, thank you. This is the whole thing,” Artho said as went back to the cabinet and got the last of a loaf of bread and brought it back to the table before sitting down. Artho ladled out the food and Skua got each person some of the bread and they began to eat. Puffin kept looking at Almond out of the corner of her eye as everyone got seated and Artho noticed that Almond was doing the same to everyone at the table and the rest of the small room that made up the living room, kitchen, and dining area of the home. Artho desperately wanted to ask her story but she’d learned very quickly that people in the town, or who came to it, did not appreciate prying questions.

Finally, Skua said, “Almond has said she needs a place to stay tonight. Do you know anywhere in town she can stay?”

Artho shook her head as she said, “No need for that. We can put you up for the night if you want, Almond.”

Almond froze for a split second then gave a little strained smile as she said, “Thank you, really, but I have shelter packed with me.”

Artho gave a quick glance at her bags and saw they weren’t big enough to be hauling a tent and so she prodded a little as she said, “Tarp?”

“Yes,” Almond responded simply.

“Well, I’ve spent some time under one before,” Artho said. “There’s no need for you to do so if you don’t want to. Really, it’s not a problem.”

Almond looked at Artho and Artho looked right back. Artho knew the look. Almond was weighing her as a threat and Artho slipped into her non-threatening Listener persona.

“I do not mean to push, Almond. I apologize,” Artho said. “Whatever you decide is fine.”

Skua looked at Artho with a weird look. She’d rarely heard Artho speak like that and never at the table.

Almond broke eye contact as she said, “It’s alright. Just confirms my belief that I was right to come out here. Good people out here, not like elsewhere. I’ll think about it.”

Skua placed a hand on Artho's hand as she said, "There's some rough characters around here but you're right, there's good people as well."

Artho just gave a smile as she said, "I would say there's a few floating around."

The rest of the dinner was quiet and after it was over, Artho stepped aside with Skua as they placed the dishes in the sink.

"I need to talk to Almond by myself," Artho said. "I'm going to offer her my services."

"She does seem jittery," Skua said as she watched Almond sitting at the table, watching both of them.

Artho walked over, being sure to keep distance between her and Almond, and said, "Almond, did you want to stay here tonight or would you like me to go with you and find a place?"

Almond looked at her, judging, and then said, "How about you and I go and find a place and if we can't find something suitable, we'll come back here."

"Deal," Artho said. "After you."

For a moment, Artho wasn’t sure Almond was going to go in front of her but she finally did get up out of the chair and go over to her things. Artho took note of how she took the dagger down first and placed it beside her before putting on the boots and then getting up and putting on the dagger before getting her bags. It was very obvious that she felt more comfortable armed then she did unarmed as she stepped out onto the porch.

Artho slipped on her shoes and walked outside as well after giving Skua a kiss and Puffin a hug. Almond looked around, paying attention to every little clump of dead brush and rock pile around the house.

“You ready?” Artho said.

“Sure,” Almond replied as they began to walk. “Can I ask you a question?”

“Certainly,” Artho said.

“How do you like living out here?” Almond asked.

Artho looked at her out of the corner of her eye as she replied, “Not what I’m used to. I'm originally from Plumeria and the Fright Zone. Came from a big family. It’s a bit isolating for me out here.”

Almond nodded as she stopped in the path and turned to Artho.

"OK, I'm just going to be blunt," Almond said. "I don't want to see a place. I didn't want to have this conversation around the kid."

Artho tensed up as she watched Almond's hands to see what she was about to do.

"What conversation?" Artho said.

"I don't trust a lot of people and I was warned about you," Almond said. "What do you feel about the blankeyes?"

Artho scowled as she said, "I know that a lot of people around here don't mind that word but I do and I'm only going to ask you politely once not to ever use it around me or my family. I know it's not a popular opinion around here but I don't find them to be any kind of problem. They're good people."

Almond stepped back a little as she looked Artho up and down. Artho looked back at her and waited for the argument or even a fight when she heard Skua call for her from the house. Something about her voice didn't sound right though and Artho wasn't sure she wanted to turn her back on Almond all of a sudden. She was surprised when Almond suddenly went jogging past her up the path back towards the house. Artho followed right on her heels and it only took a few minutes to get back.

Standing on the front porch was Skua and she held Puffin tight in her arms. Her face was scared and Puffin had her face buried in her mother's jacket. Sitting down in Artho's chair on the porch was Van and another person named Tural stood off to the side. Both of them had laser cannons in their hands, pointing at nothing in particular.

"Ah! Almond! Glad you're with her!" Van said as they stood up. "You know, Tural and I were talking about you and wondering just how loyal you were and we have a job to do here so I think we can take care of two things at once."

"Van, what are you doing?" Artho said, striding forward and then froze when Van casually leveled the cannon at Skua.

"Shut your mouth, Princess," Van said, their voice cruel and gleeful. "You've been running your mouth off a lot but that's fine. Those of us in the know always knew how this would play out. Almond, come on over here."

Artho cursed silently as she saw Almond shrug and walk over nonchalantly to stand in front of Van.

"What's happening here?" Almond asked, her voice calm.

“Well, we checked and this one is done with the greenhouse. At least where we don’t need her anymore,” Van said. “So they’re all going to have a little accident and I want you to help.”

Almond looked quizzically at Van as she patted her dagger and Van grinned as she nodded.

“Done,” Almond said and pulled her dagger out and turned to Artho. “Come here.”

“I took you into my house and fed you,” Artho said, her voice tight.

“Doesn’t matter,” Almond said and pointed to a spot in front of her with the dagger point. “Now, come here.”

Artho started to walk slowly forward, looking into Almond’s eyes and saw not much there except stillness. She felt a chill run down her spine as she got close and said, “Don’t do this in front of my little girl. Please.”

“I’m sorry but it has to be done this way,” Almond said as Artho moved to the spot indicated. She couldn’t really see Van anymore but she could see Tural leaning against the side of the house at the end of the porch with her cannon pointed at the ground and almost laughing. Artho tried to think what to do but while she knew how to fight, this wasn’t anything like she’d ever been taught. She gritted her teeth and made a determination that she’d

try and get at least one of them. She tensed and got ready to grab Almond when suddenly Almond moved.

After it was over, Artho figured out what had happened but at the moment she couldn’t have said what was going on. One moment Almond was stillness and then she was still standing in front of her but at the same seemed to stretch into a blur. There was a scraping noise and Artho saw blood and heard a thud as a laser cannon hit the ground. Then there were two rapid flashes of light and then Tural and Almond were just gone. Everything was quiet for a second and she could see Van hunched over, holding their hands against their stomach, like they’d pinched them in a door. Then they suddenly began to scream, a high pitched shuddering wail, and Artho saw their mangled hand as they sagged to the ground. Something seemed different about the hand that she couldn't seem to place. Then she looked down at the laser cannon and saw the rest of the hand. She managed to hold her lunch down, barely, as she rushed over to Skua.

“They came around the corner after you left and threatened us if I didn’t call for you,” Skua said through tears.

“It’s alright, it’s alright,” Artho said. “Are you two OK?”

Skua was shaking so hard Artho was worried she wouldn’t be able to stand up and Puffin was trying to cover her ears when Almond came back around the corner of the house with her dagger in one hand and Tural’s laser cannon in the other. Artho moved in front of Skua and Puffin as she said, “Who are you!?”

“Can you use this?” Almond said as she held the cannon up and Artho couldn’t help but feel like her voice was different.

“What? I guess, yes,” Artho said and Almond walked over and jammed it into her arms.

“Trigger makes it shoot, there’s no safety, and the power meter is inline with the sight. Get in the house but keep the door open. Shoot anyone that isn’t me without warning. I have to have a quick chat with this thing,” Almond said as she looked down at Van with disgust as suddenly Artho recognized the voice.

“Cappe!?”

“Yes, Artho, but I don’t have time for that! Get in the house!” Capella said as she looked back up at Artho with Almond’s face.

“What are you going to do to them?” Artho said.

“Why do you care? They were going to kill the three of you,” Capella said.

“They’re helpless,” Artho said, gesturing at Van.

"Makes it easier to ask questions," Capella said and then her face softened. "I'm not going to torture them as much as I want to but I need to find out some stuff, find out fast, and I need to get you three out of here. Grab anything you can't do without." Van's screaming had died off to just moans and Capella swore a little under her breath. "Now hurry up. They're going into shock."

Artho finally turned and hurried Skua and Puffin inside, the unfamiliar weight of the weapon in her hand only adding to the uncomfortable moment.

# # #

Capella sighed as she watched Artho and the rest go inside. She looked down at Van and forced her hands to remain steady as she sheathed her dagger. She avoided the sight of Van's hand. She'd done it on the spur of the moment and she'd hated every moment of the fight. She figured she had a few minutes before Tural came around from getting hit with the stun rod Capella had yanked off of Tural and used on her. As she patted the side of Van's face she fought down the thought that kept popping up that she should have just made sure that Tural never stood back up.

No, you're not like that, Capella said and then flinched as Van started to come to and gasped in pain.

"Answer my questions and you'll get medical attention," Capella said as Van focused in on her. "Why did you come to kill them?"

“Ordered to,” Van panted as they.

“By who?” Capella said as she rummaged in her satchel for her small medical kit.

“It hurts,” Van gasped, her voice weak.

“I know it does. I’m sorry,” Capella said as she pulled out a painkiller, flicked the cap off of it, and then sank it into Van’s thigh just like Dio had shown her when she gave her the medical kit after she’d been slashed up. “That should make it hurt less.”

She watched Van’s eyes dilate as the drug shot through her system and she relaxed a little. Capella had no idea what it was, Dio had just laughed and told her not to operate any heavy machinery if she ever had to take it. As Van’s breathing evened out a little, Capella could see why Dio had made the joke.

“Thanks,” Van slurred.

“Who ordered you to come kill them? You can tell me,” Capella said softly as she took the triangle bandage out of the kit and handed it to Van. “Here, wrap that around your hand but be careful.”

“Who are you?” Van said as they clumsily tried to wrap their hand up.

Capella thought about what to say and finally settled on, “I’m a friend of the spacebats.”

Van looked up at her, their eyes trying to focus on Capella as they said, “You’re her aren’t you?”

“I don’t know who her is,” Capella said. “But I would like to know who gave you that order.”

“The Queen,” Van said. “Shadow… shadow… thing queen.”

“I’m not a queen,” Capella said.

“You blurred,” Van said, their speech thick with the effects of the painkiller and the pain it was suppressing. “I watched… you blurred… you got me. You’re her. You’re real.”

Capella gently placed her hand against Van’s face as she leaned in to talk to them. With a soft smile she said, “You’re right, Van. I’m real and I really need you to tell me who gave you that order please. It’s important.”

“Aeron,” Van said as they leaned forward into her hand and shook a little as they went on. “I feel weird, warm.”

“You’re ok, it’s the medicine,” Capella said. “Why did he order that?”

“He’s… moving…,” Van said. “The hands played.”

“Moving where?” Capella said, leaned in close and almost whispering and the answer that Van gave sent a shock through her whole body.

“Dryl.”

Capella sucked in her breath as Van started muttering something she couldn’t understand. She jumped to her feet and started towards the door as she shouted out, “Coming in!”

She heard Artho say something and carefully peaked around the corner to see Skua behind the turned over table with the cannon steadied across it. Artho was behind her, holding Puffin and gently rocking her as she whispered to her.

“Don’t you take another step,” Skua said as she shifted the cannon just a little to aim at Capella. Capella froze as she held her hands up.

“I don’t have time for this. I need to get Van to some medical attention,” Capella said. “More importantly, I need to get you three out of here right now. A very scary man has ordered your deaths and you need to be somewhere safe.”

“So why are you helping?” Skua replied. “Artho called you Cappe but I remember her. I met her at her birthday. You don’t look anything like her.”

Capella nodded and carefully twitched a finger to drop her illusion. Skua jumped a little and Capella tried not to flinch as the cannon moved.

“See? Me,” Capella said. “Listen, I can give you an in-depth overview later but for now, I need a little trust so I can get you out.”

“Honey, she did save us,” Artho said from behind her. Skua didn’t look back but reached one hand back and Artho reached forward and squeezed her hand. Then she pointed the cannon to the side and Capella let out a breath she hadn’t known she had been holding.

“OK, get anything you can’t do without,” Capella said. “Please. I’m going to try and teleport all three of you at once so don’t get too much please. I’m pushing it as it is with three of you over the distances we’ll be going.”

Artho nodded and handed Puffin off to Skua. Puffin looked at Capella for a split second before burying her head into Skua's shoulder again. Skua held Puffin close as Capella said, "I'm going to step outside for just a moment. I'll be right back."

Capella watched Artho run into the bedroom as Capella carefully backed out of the home. She turned to check on Van and saw they were slumped over. Capella cursed silently to herself and quickly knelt down beside them. She checked their breathing and pulse and found them both slow but steady and hoped that was a good sign. She finally picked up the hand and tied the bandage around it better, causing Van to shift and moan as the pain overrode the medicine.

"Hey! What happened here!?" Capella heard behind her and looked over her shoulder to see three armed people coming up the path and shouting at her.

"Van's been hurt!" Capella shouted back. "Get a doctor immediately!"

"Who are you!?" another one of the people shouted.

"Not a doctor!" Capella shouted again. "Go get one!"

One of the people went running down the path but the other two started forward and Capella again cursed under breath. Then Skua fired from inside. The blast missed everyone and hit a clump

of dead brush, blasting it into burning bits. Capella hit the ground, as did the two coming up the path, and then Capella figured that was it and teleported inside. She made sure to stay out of the line of fire and was happy she did when Skua fired again through the door. Puffin was screaming in fear and Artho had scooped her up, a duffel bag full of things slung over her shoulder.

"Don't fire!" Capella said as she scooted over to the door and kicked it shut. As she did, she heard several blasts from outside hit the stone of the house around the door.

Great, no one knows how to aim, Capella thought as she took a deep breath and made sure the door was locked and then got away from it.

"What are you doing!?" Skua yelled at her.

"Leaving! They can take care of Van!" Capella shouted back. "Do you have what you need?"

Artho nodded as Skua jumped up and said, "Give me two minutes."

Capella threw her hands up in the air and then flinched as more shots hammered at the house. Skua ran through the rooms one last time and then came back with a photo album under her arm. She threw the cannon on the floor and wrapped her arms around Artho and Puffin.

“Ready.”

Capella took a deep breath and stepped over to them and put her hands on Artho.

“Here we go,” Capella said and then teleported. It wasn’t hard at first, making each jump as she headed towards Plumeria, but she found it dragged on her the more it went on. It didn’t take very long but she finally arrived in Plumeria feeling worn out, like she’d run a fast mile.

The other three looked around and Capella stepped back as she pulled her data pad out of her satchel and started it up. While it started she dropped her illusion back in place and said, “Go find P-Pear. Tell her I sent you and that she can help me by helping you and by setting aside anything she’s got going on. I might need her today.” Then Capella looked down at her data pad and saw the little cupcake logo on the screen twirling as it tried to make a connection with the data network.

“Cappe…,” Artho started to say and Capella shook her head.

“Find your sister, now. I gotta go,” she replied and teleported out.

She appeared in front of the place she’d been staying with the rest of her little group and went charging in the door. Alice was

pacing the floor and muttering under her breath as she worked away at her data pad and Coalfire was asking questions that were getting ignored. They both looked up as Capella came in.

"You've got blood on you," Coalfire said, nodding at Capella.

"What's going on? I just found out that someone may be trying to attack Dryl," Capella said.

"Then you know more than we do," Alice said, irritation strong in her voice. "Every network seems to be out right now."

Capella felt her gut clench tighter as she said, "I'm going to Dryl."

"Wait!" Coalfire said and Capella, about to teleport, looked at her with irritation. "Give me two minutes."

"Fine," Capella said and Coalfire stepped through the door. Capella followed her and Coalfire went on.

"Something serious is happening, I don't know what, but you need to keep us in the loop somehow," Coalfire replied.

Capella thought for a moment and then said, "I've made contact with Princess Prickly Pear before. Get in touch with her, tell her I

sent you.” Capella told her the passphrase she’d used the first time when Prickly Pear had contacted Gress before going on. “First though, find Dio, tell her we need transportation immediately.”

“Why?” Coalfire said.

“I don’t know,” Capella replied. “I’m going to Dryl to find out what’s happening. We might need to all go there. I’ll be back soon to give you an update.”

Coalfire was about to say something when there was a gasp from someone standing down the path from their place. They both looked over at the person and saw them staring wide mouthed at the sky. The two looked up and saw several lines of fire slowly trailing across the sky.

“Hurry,” Coalfire said, not taking her eyes off the spectacle. Capella just nodded and was gone.

Chapter End Notes

I wonder what happens next?

Dryl

Chapter Summary

The attack begins against Dryl.

Note: If you're reading along, please be aware there was a chapter posted before this one today.

Chapter Notes

"Load up on guns and bring your friends" - Smells Like Teen Spirit by Mali J

Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The day that Dryl burned was overcast and cold. However, it was winter and Dryl was up in the mountains where it was often overcast and cold so the weather didn't have any narrative weight or foreboding to it. It would have been more foreboding for it to be bright and warm and if it had, maybe Izzy would have had more warning about what was about to happen to her and her Brother's home.

"Pat, do you have any connections at all?" Izzy said as she stood up and started pacing in her office. She listened as the AI tried to find one.

"Brother, I can't get one either," Harpi said and they both turned at a knock on the door. Izzy called the person in and one of the many clones who lived in Dryl stuck his head in.

“Brother Izzy, all our network connections are down,” he said.

“We’re having the same issue,” Izzy replied and then thought for a moment. “Even the main Etherian one?”

“Yes, all of them,” the clone said and Izzy looked nervously at Harpi.

“That’s…,” Izzy started to say but didn’t finish the sentence as another clone came rushing into the room.

“The visitors that have been camped by the gate have attacked the welcome booth people!”

Izzy didn’t hesitate, she grabbed her tiara off her desk, slapped it on her head and flipped her monocle down.

“Pat, get a connection however you can. Brothers, get everyone into the secondary tunnels,” Izzy said to the two clones that had come in. They nodded and went running. “Brother Harpi, when is the next ship coming through?”

“The next ship isn’t due to arrive in-system for at least another month but we should be able to hold a siege until then if necessary,” Harpi said.

Izzy nodded as she stepped out into the hallway and looked around. They both jumped as an explosion sounded outside. Izzy turned to Harpi and said, "Get to Finn. Get them to safety *now."*

Harpi nodded and went running as Izzy knelt down and turned to a little bot, what looked like a box with a face that was rolling around on one wheel.

"Could you come here please?" she said to the bot as she tried to keep her voice steady. The bot rolled over to her and the box leaned back on the wheel to present the printed-on face to her. Izzy gave a little sigh as she saw a connection pop up on her monocle from the bot. "Are you ready to receive an order?"

The little bot tilted back and forth as if nodding and she saw a confirmation pop up in her monocle.

"OK, here is my order. Start an active connection with the other bots to pass this on and only allow those on the secure list to access that connection," Izzy said before taking a deep breath. She'd set this contingency up almost from the beginning of her reign as princess with the hope that she'd never have to use it and had felt paranoid when she had done so. Now it was time to use it and she shook her head. She hated that what she had thought was paranoid over-preparation was being proven needed. "I, Izzy, Princess of Dryl, deed the castle of Dryl and its surroundings to the bots who inhabit it, to hold it and defend it from any intruders, until such a time that I request back control over it. Do you understand me?"

The bot titled back and forth again and a confirmation popped up. Izzy stood up as she said, “Go and spread the word and send me some help if you can spare it please.”

The bot went rocketing down the hall and suddenly Izzy saw Pat grab a connection. It was a strong signal and she wondered why when a bot the size and shape of a tarantula settled on her shoulder. It chirped at her as she looked sideways at it and she suddenly realized that the bot was hooked into an ever expanding network of other bots in Dryl and was acting as a network relay for her.

“Thank you, buddy,” Izzy said and then looked up as she heard scuttling. If Dryl had been a building with normal walls, she’d have said bots were literally coming out of the woodwork but Dryl’s halls were metal and so they were literally coming out of the metalwork. Bots walked, flew, creeped, and slid over to her and took up station around her as she began to jog and then eventually sprint down the hall. They followed her, forming a guard around her as the Princess of Dryl ran to war.

# # #

“OK, that one was good! I’ve got some notes here on what we can try next,” Finn said, as they walked out onto the stage towards the actors as they made a note on their data pad. It’d been a while since they’d directed a play and they were remembering just how much they loved it.

Running the theater is interesting but I forgot how fun this can be, Finn thought with a smile.

Caladium, Finn's backstage manager who'd started at Finn's first theater in Bright Moon with them as kids, walked out behind them as he pointed at members of the stage crew and made suggestions. As one of the actors came towards them, Finn saw a few people come into the theater. It wasn't unusual for that to happen and normally Finn didn't mind having people watch them rehearse but something about the way these people came hustling down the aisle seemed unusual.

"Hello there," Finn said as they projected their voice out towards them. "We're in the middle of something but feel free to have a seat and watch."

"Are you Finn?" one of the people said.

Finn looked closer at the woman, her feathers sticking up on her head in what Finn thought was probably agitation, and said, "Yes, that's me. Can I help you with something?"

"Yes, I need you to come with us please," the woman said as she got to the edge of the orchestra pit. Finn looked at their data pad and double checked that they hadn't forgotten an appointment before looking back up.

“Looks like I lost connectivity but I’m pretty sure I don’t have an appointment with you. As I said, I’m busy right now but if you’d like to wait, I can try and give you a little time after we’re done here,” Finn said and then heard one of the backstage hands shouting followed by a scream. Finn was looking towards the backstage and so didn’t really notice the next part. Caladium did though.

Caladium watched as the woman reached into her jacket and came out with a thin crystal mounted on a small frame with a handle and trigger. She started to point it at Finn and as Finn started to turn back to her to say something they were tackled by Caladium. As Finn fell to the stage, the actors started shouting, Finn heard a cracking noise like an electrical discharge, and then high pitched screeches followed by several screams further back in the audience and one backstage. Then the commotion was abruptly cut off.

“Cal, what are you doing!?” Finn hollered as Caladium looked around. Then Finn heard the actors and stage hands running off stage, a few of them screaming.

“Finn, we gotta get to the dorms,” Caladium said as he got up off of Finn and pulled them to their feet.

“Why did you… tackle… me…,” Finn started to say when they looked off the front of the stage towards where the woman had been. In the air floated a few feathers and they could see one of the woman’s legs, the back toe clutched forward towards the front toes and all of them jerking a little as they rested over the side of the orchestra pit’s front.

“Finn…,” Caladium started to say but Finn shook their head as they walked to the edge of the stage and looked down. From the front of the stage, they could see more of the woman and Finn immediately wished they hadn’t walked forward to see more. The bot that had hit her clearly did not intend for her to get back up and had done several things in quick order to make sure she didn’t. None of them were things that were good for the continued functioning of a person’s body. Finn didn’t look for more than second but could feel the image searing into their mind as they staggered back from the edge. They could see out in the auditorium several other bots moving around and they suddenly remembered there had been other people with the woman and Finn couldn’t see them anymore. They suddenly had the overwhelming urge not to try.

“Cal…,” Finn started to say and then had to stop as they choked down the gagging sensation in their throat as they turned away before continuing. “What is going on!?”

“I don’t know,” Caladium said. “But Iz was very clear if something like this happened that I was to get you to the dorms and try to contact her. Do I have to carry you?”

Finn shook their head no as they covered their mouth and Finn fell in beside Caladium as they quickly started walking. As they walked through the backstage area, they saw a backstage hand leaned up against a wall, moaning in pain as another backstage hand helped her with the slash that ran across her chest. Two others stood around with first aid kits and Finn couldn’t help but notice splashes of red trailing off into a side hall.

“Cal, Finn, what’s happening?” one of them said.

“Don’t know,” Caladium said. “We’re going to the dorms right now just like we’ve done in our drills. Are you OK, Ivars? Can you move?”

Ivars, the woman who’d been cut, managed to say through gritted teeth, “Do I look OK, Cal!?”

“Ok, stupid question, but we have to get to the dorms, they’re safe,” Caladium said and they all turned to look in the direction of the castle when they heard muffled thumps.

“Were those explosions?” one of the stagehands said.

“Yes,” Finn said, their ears twitching at the sound as they suddenly realized something bad was happening not just in the theater but all around. They immediately turned and started towards the doors as the thought of finding Izzy bubbled up. Caladium clapped a hand down on their shoulder as the other stagehands got Ivars to her feet and started heading towards the dorms.

“Nope, I know that look and you’re not going to go look for her,” Caladium said. “She told me to get you to the dorms in the event of something like this and I’m getting you to the dorms.”

“Cal, I’m going to go find Izzy, let me go please,” Finn said, trying to glare at Caladium.

“No, and get that look off your face you don’t have the practice to be intimidating. Besides, she’s way scarier than you are,” Caladium replied and then his voice got soft. “She’s not my partner but I’ve known her just as long as you have. You think I’m not scared for her too?”

“Then let me go,” Finn said.

“I promised her, Finn, I promised I’d get you to the dorms if something went wrong,” Caladium replied. Finn looked over their shoulder and finally seemed to deflate a little before starting to walk again towards the dorms. Caladium walked alongside them as Finn watched more bots than they had ever been aware of in their theater looking out at them from little nooks and crannies. They joined a steady stream of people into the dorms, everyone asking questions, but Finn didn’t have any answers for anyone. As far as they could tell, Ivars was the only person who’d been hurt from the crew so far and Finn was getting everyone to settle down when they heard their data pad chirp as it got a connection. They looked down at it and didn’t recognize the name of the connection as a message from Izzy came in to them.

Dryl is under attack. Get to the dorms and stay there. It’s protected. Send a message as soon as you get this and you’re in the dorms. I love you. - Iz

Finn almost accepted it but remembered Izzy telling them to always make sure a message from her was authentic and so they took a few extra seconds to check to see if it was her. When the data pad verified it, they gave a little sigh and with shaking hands shot back a quick response.

I love you too. I'm in the dorms and I'm ok. - Finn

"I got a message from Izzy," Caladium said quietly to Finn.

Finn looked up at him as they said, "I did as well. Get their attention Cal, I'm going to fill them in."

Caladium shoved his fingers in his mouth and gave a sharp whistle. Everyone went quiet as they looked over towards him.

"Finn's got a few words," Caladium said.

"OK, we all know something weird is going on. I've got word from Izzy that Dryl is under attack," Finn said and then wished they'd picked a better way to put it because the room suddenly was in uproar. They projected their voice over the crowd as they went on. "She's told me the dorms are protected and I've notified her we're here. Department heads, can I get a headcount and see if we're missing anyone please!?"

It didn’t take long before they found out a few people were still missing.

“I’m going to go find them,” Finn started to say and Caladium stepped in front of them.

“No, you’re not,” Caladium said. “I’ll send a few of my crew. You’re needed here.”

“You’re part of the guard Izzy has over me aren’t you?” Finn said and Caladium just gave a short grin before asking a few of his people to run through the theater.

Finn sighed and sat down at a table. Mel, the head costume designer, sat down with them as did Lucy, a senior stage hand and someone who’d known Finn as long as Mel and Caladium.

“What do we do?” Mel said as they fiddled with their hand sewn dress.

“Don’t know,” Finn replied as they stared at their data pad. They sent a short message that they had almost everyone in the dorms to Izzy but hadn’t heard anything back yet. They couldn’t seem to keep still, they felt like they’d drank too much coffee and stayed up all night.

“Iz will have it handled,” Lucy said as they both looked up at the sounds of more explosions. A few of them seemed to come from the back wall of the room but were muted.

Finn just nodded and then saw a message come up from Harpi.

Get everyone away from the back wall of the dorms please. - Harpi

Finn verified the message and then suddenly put together the explosion noises from the back wall. When they’d built the dorms, the clones had helped them with structural issues and had advised Finn the back wall needed to stay solid. As Finn jumped to their feet and told everyone to clear away from the wall, they began to realize that it didn't have anything to do with construction and that even back then, Izzy was thinking of ways to get to Finn in case of an emergency.

When the last person cleared back, a drill bit came through the wall and the face of a clone peered through.

“Stand clear!” he shouted and then disappeared from the hole. In just a few minutes, mining bots came through, making a large hole and Harpi came out peeling a filter mask off his face, covered in rock dust. A few of the clones in the theater went up to the little crew of clones coming out of the rock and began asking them questions while Harpi strode over to Finn.

“Have everyone pack quickly,” Harpi said. “We’re taking them into the tunnels and collapsing the entries to the dorms and then into the tunnels themselves.”

Finn wanted to argue but they could already see the bots gluing what looked like thick yellow rope around the couple of archways that led out of the area as well as drilling holes and inserting foot long tubes into them. They just nodded and shouted, “Everyone! Get a bag! We’re going into Dryl’s tunnels for safety!”

Everyone nodded and moved.

“We’re still missing some people,” Finn said. “We sent a few into the theater to get them.”

Harpi looked at his data pad and said, “I’ll give them ten minutes. I won’t risk the tunnels.”

Finn was about to ask why when they realized just what tunnels he was referring to and nodded.

“Thank you for that,” Finn said. Harpi just nodded as the clones that’d come with him started guiding people in. Finn watched Mel and Lucy go into the tunnel arm-in-arm and carrying a truly huge bag of fabric with a sewing machine perched on top between them. Caladium stood next to the archway going out into the backstage area, watching.

Finn turned to Harpi and said, “Can I give the command to detonate?”

Harpi looked at Finn, his ears going back a little in confusion as he said, “I guess.”

“It’s my theater,” Finn explained. “I should be the one who’s going to break it.”

Harpi seemed to understand and said, “OK. I’ll pass the command to you.” Harpi tapped on his data pad and Finn saw a little figure pop up on their data pad. “Tap that when it’s time.”

Finn nodded as they walked over to Caladium.

“We can’t wait much longer,” they said.

“I won’t leave without them,” Caladium said.

“Thought you were my guard,” Finn said with a strained smile.

“Harpi is here,” Caladium replied. “They can do it. Izzy can chew me out if I get through this.”

Finn looked sharply at Caladium as they said, “No, don’t say that.”

Caladium just rested a hand on Finn’s shoulder and squeezed and Finn was about to argue when the stagehands came staggering back up the tunnels with the few remaining missing people behind them.

“Sorry! They were hiding and it is a mess of bots out there! Explosions too!” one of the stagehands shouted.

“Get a bag,” Caladium said. “Follow the clones. We’re leaving.”

The little group almost argued but then saw the blasted open back wall and just nodded.

“OK, now you can leave,” Finn said.

“You too,” Caladium replied.

Finn nodded and strode to the center of the room, setting their data pad down on a table. It was almost empty now since most people had gone into the tunnel, and Harpi stood next to Finn.

“Is Izzy safe?” Finn said, looking at Harpi.

“She is as safe as she can make herself,” Harpi said. “We are under attack by a decent sized group. Hopefully it will be over soon but it’s already lasted longer than it should have.”

Finn nodded as Caladium helped the last few people run to their rooms and grab some things. Finn asked Harpi a few questions about the explosives as they waited.

“They’re set in a sequence to crack the rock and then bring it down. We’ll wait at this one to be sure the entrances are blocked and then we’ll blow this one,” Harpi said.

Finn nodded as Caladium returned with the rest and got them all into the tunnel. Finn stood on the edge of the tunnel entrance and looked out at the common room. Cups sat on tables, books and magazines were left around, and the whole room had a sense of loneliness that Finn couldn’t describe. They heard one of the clones talking to Caladium as they both compared counts.

“Everyone’s out, Finn,” Caladium said. Finn just nodded as they kept looking at the room.

“Finn, you need to set off the charges please,” Harpi said gently. Finn reached for their side where they kept their data pad before looking back up at Harpi.

“I gotta grab my data pad,” Finn said. “It’s on that table.”

Finn walked out into the room and picked up the data pad off the table. They turned and looked at Caladium, Harpi, and a few other clones watching them from the tunnel entrance. Finn turned and walked a little way forward, away from the tunnel.

“Finn, we have to go,” Harpi said.

Finn stopped near one of the entrances and looked up at the explosives and then back at Caladium.

“Take care of the troupe until I get back, Cal,” Finn said and then sprinted through the entrance. They heard the group shouting their name as they hit the button and set off the explosives. They had hoped they were far enough down the tunnel and while they had turned out to be right, it was a near thing.

The noise from the blast was excruciating, louder than anything Finn had heard in their life, and the dust and noise of the falling rock washed over Finn. They shook their head, trying to clear the ringing in their ears as they realized they were sprawled out in the corridor. They saw a wave of rock ending not too far from their feet and felt a chill run through down to their bones as they realized just how close they’d come to burying themselves in their own theater. Than a coughing fit ran through Finn as they sucked up a lungful of rock dust. When it subsided, they stood up to see the data pad cracked and dead in their hands. They shook their

head as they tossed it aside and started jogging to the front of the theater. They had a job to do.

# # #

"Brothers, I don't have time for this," Izzy said as she faced the ten people of the Clone Council. The ten's job was to give updates to the rest of the wider clone community throughout the universe on the Etherian clone community and to help the clones on Etheria know what their brothers spread far and wide were thinking and doing. They were also incredibly cautious and careful and while Izzy loved all of her brothers, this group was a tough one to deal with sometimes.

They'd found her as she strode through the halls, making sure everyone in the castle got to safety. The bots had kept the attackers out of the courtyard at first but then they'd started deploying some kind of electromagnetic pulse weapons that destroyed bots who weren't protected, which was most of them, and now the bots were having to be stealthier and the attackers had made it into the castle and were settling into the first hall.

"Brother Izzy, we need to make time," one of them, a clone named Salt replied. "We can't just hide all of the theater troupe in those tunnels."

"It's already in progress," Izzy said as she watched information coming in through her monocle. She was used to dealing with lots of things at once but between the information and the stress, she could feel her edges fraying. "I've always planned for enough

supplies for them as well so unless you're going to go down there and throw them out, it's pointless to discuss this."

"That's just one issue," another clone named Ertu spoke up. "We have never condoned you to use lethal force and we've seen the bots doing exactly that!"

Izzy stepped forward, her cloud of bots shifting with her, as she said, "You said I could not use lethal force in my clandestine work and I agreed and I still agree but this is in defense of the castle and our people and I will not simply raise our hands in surrender! Those people will kill us all!"

"What about the perception…," another clone started to say and Izzy cut him off.

"You think they care!?" Izzy said, pointing at the sound of blasts from a laser cannon. "We're cut off from the Etherian net! They've set off blasts inside the castle! They've fought into the castle and while they're losing people it's not enough! I can't call for help and we are on our own! This is intentional! Why are you fighting me on this!?"

"For the consideration of all clones and not just those on Etheria," Ertu replied.

"Brother Ertu, I am brother to all clones but I am brother to the ones here first and they are in my care," Izzy said. "I will not lose

any if it is in my power to do so. For now, follow my orders and you can throw me out of being your brother when this is done but I will make damn sure you are alive to do so."

The ten looked uncomfortably at each other as Salt spoke up again.

"You know we have no method of doing that."

"And I don't want you to but I won't let people die out of fear of how it might look if we fought to defend ourselves," Izzy said as she thought again of things Gress had said in the last few months. "We have the right to protect ourselves against those who would seek to annihilate us and I swear by everything I love, I will."

"Brother Izzy…," Ertu started to say when a loud popping noise sounded outside and a sensor Izzy had never seen tripped suddenly reported in to her.

"Someone just deployed a lot of magic," Izzy said. The only reason her hands didn't shake as she started moving towards a balcony was because of how tight she had them clenched. The Council followed her and she carefully edged out onto the balcony as she designated spots for some of her bots to go and defend them. Then she saw a camera feed on the main road and swore. "Cursed Prime! Someone brought in some old Horde tanks and more people."

“How!?” one of the Council members replied. “You told us earlier that the road down was blocked off!”

“It is,” Izzy said as she watched and noticed these people seemed more like troops. They wore what looked like repurposed Hordak-era Horde armor, everyone was armed, and they moved more precisely than the mob currently attacking the castle. “That must have been the magic. Someone must have teleported in about a hundred and fifty people.”

“That’s not possible!” Salt said. “Only… the… queen…”

Izzy shook her head as she said, “No, that’s not Glimmer. I’m not saying she couldn’t ever turn against us but I know her. She would go into battle with them and I don’t see her. Teleportation is possible just no one uses it because it’s difficult without a runestone to guide it. Doesn’t matter, they obviously managed. My Brothers, I suggest you get into the tunnels. I think Dryl is going to fall.”

Izzy said the last part in a matter of fact tone but she was holding back tears as she said it. Dryl was her home, the best home she’d ever had, the place she’d planned to live her entire life with Finn and her brothers and to think of anything happening to it hurt more than she thought possible. Then she saw a message come in from Harpi that Finn had run off, collapsed the tunnels behind themself, and Harpi couldn’t get to them. Izzy froze, staring at the message, as she tried to think what to do.

“Brother Izzy?” Ertu said as he reached out to nudge her.

Izzy shook her head as she held her hand up at Ertu to silence him for a moment as she said, “Pat, have the bots locate Finn immediately.” Then she turned to the Council. “Brothers, please, get to safety. Now.”

Pat put up Finn’s location and Izzy saw they were in the lobby of their theater. A handy video feed showed her Finn all by themself, crouched at a door as they looked out. She watched as Finn took a deep breath and then opened the door and walked out towards the road that ran in front of the theater and into the main gates of Dryl.

“Pat, public address system,” Izzy said and as it popped on she started shouting. “Finn! Get to cover! What are you doing!?”

She realized the system wasn’t working and started cursing and crying as she ran to the railing of the balcony in time to see the tanks roll around the corner of the mountain outside Dryl with squads of people alongside who immediately pointed their weapons at Finn. Finn came to a stop in the middle of the road, planted their feet, and turned to face them as they raised a hand in both greeting and a gesture to stop.

# # #

“Three, two, one, shift,” the whole group heard Inferna call out from on top of one of the tanks. She made the final gesture for the spell and clouds of energy drifted up around them all and then

suddenly they were on the road outside of Dryl. More than one of the troops let out a sigh as they realized they'd landed exactly where they'd planned. Inferna hadn't been the most accurate in her practice out in Candila and hitting the narrow mountain road had seemed outside her skill at one point. As soon as she saw they'd teleported, she jumped inside one of the tanks as the radio call went out to go forward.

The head of the group, a man named Zizzer who was one of Aeron's close confidants and who'd been with him from almost the beginning, was in one of the tanks and was whistling a happy tune as he gunned it forward. The old Horde tank clanked and rattled as they moved and Zizzer hoped it'd hold together long enough to do what needed doing. The squad almost immediately came into contact with bots but their weapons had excellent capacity against them and while they did immediately start taking losses, it was far less than they had feared in their original planning.

"Contact with the spearhead," a woman said sitting behind Zizzer. "They're in place and holding in the main hall. They're just waiting on us now."

Zizzer grinned as the tank came around a corner and he said, "Won't be much longer… who in the stars is that in the middle of the road?"

"Some cat person. They've got their hand up," the woman said as she checked the external video. "Wait… are they trying to get us to stop?"

Zizzer looked out and suddenly had a shock of recognition. He knew that face from making plans with Aeron before.

“That’s the Princess's partner!” he said as he settled the crosshairs of his sights on Finn. The cannon stuttered just a moment as it started to move but then flowed smoothly and a second later the crosshairs indicated the targeting system was in line with the huge laser cannon of the tank. “Not for much longer!”

He laughed as he hit the trigger and felt the tank shudder as the cannon fired.

Chapter End Notes

My wife straight up swore at me when I read this chapter to her.

The Fall of Dryl

Chapter Summary

> The attack on Dryl takes a turn for the worst.
>
> Note: If you're following along as this posts, this is the third chapter to be posted today. Be sure you read the two before this one.

Chapter Notes

> "And I will show you something different from either/Your shadow at morning striding behind you/Or your shadow at evening rising to meet you;/I will show you fear in a handful of dust." - The Waste Land (excerpt), T.S. Eliot
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izzy was screaming at the top of her lungs, trying to get bots to Finn, trying to get bots to the tanks and the attackers, trying anything, and none of it seemed to be enough. Time flowed like molasses as she watched Finn standing unprotected in the road as a tank turned its cannon on them. It was worse than any nightmare she'd ever had and she was screaming so loud she thought her throat would rip. Then a flash and the road exploded as the cannon fired and Izzy's scream seemed the only noise in the world, full of so much grief it seemed like it'd reach up and pull the sky down.

Izzy didn't hear the voice behind her at first until she felt furry arms throwing themselves around her. She jumped as they did and turned to see Finn and for a moment she wondered if she'd lost her mind but it didn't stop her from pulling them tight to her. Then she saw Capella behind Finn, covered in red dust and

splashes of blood, and realized just what had happened as tears of relief dropped from her eyes.

"What were you thinking!?" Izzy shouted at Finn as she held both sides of their face and kissed them.

"I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry," Finn said as they kissed her back. "I just… I thought maybe someone should try and talk with them."

"You're a damn idiot," Izzy said with a relieved, sobbing laugh as she pulled Finn in tight again before turning her head to Capella. "Cappe, I owe you everything."

"Well… I got word something was going on, saw streaks of fire in the sky, and thought, yeah, I need to go to Dryl. Then I saw that idiot in the road," Capella said with an affectionate nod at Finn, "and the tanks and I went for them." Capella suppressed the shudder that ran through her as she thought how close she'd gotten to being obliterated along with Finn.

They all ducked as the tanks fired into the castle itself. Izzy threw herself over Finn as small debris showered itself across the balcony.

"Brothers, are you going?" Izzy said to the ten clones who'd hit the ground. They all looked up and nodded as Izzy got up on her

knee and peaked over the balcony. “Cappe, can you teleport them to Entrapta’s old lab?”

“I think, give me a moment,” Capella said and then teleported out and was back a moment later. “Yeah, I still remember where it is.”

As Capella started taking the Council two at a time, Izzy turned to Finn, hugged them tight again as she said, “You’re not going with her, you’re staying with me if I have to tie you to my back.”

“It’s the only place I’d ever want to be,” Finn said. They said it suave but their shaking and tears in their eyes betrayed the fear they still felt. “I’m sorry I put you through that.”

“No more sorry for now,” Izzy said as she stayed crouched down and scooted towards the entryway, grabbing Finn’s hand so they’d come along with her. “We’ll talk about it later.”

As Capella took the last of the Council, Izzy shot off messages to Harpi and Caladium before ordering more bots to the courtyard. Capella appeared and crouched down next to Izzy.

“Get us to our place please?” Izzy said and Capella nodded and teleported into the rooms. “Finn, pack a bag of anything you absolutely can not lose. Anything that gets left behind is going to be destroyed more than likely.”

“We’re running!?” Finn said. “But the bots…”

“They’ll hold the corridors for a while but they’re getting cut down. When they get to a certain number, they’ll fall back into the deep tunnels. The attackers though will more than likely get to the main living areas,” Izzy said as she grabbed some photos. She tried not to cry as she realized she couldn’t take the plants her mother had given her but kept going. She had said everything in a matter of fact way but she shook a little as she stopped and looked around.

“I understand,” Finn said and disappeared into the bedroom.

“Cappe, I can use your help if you’ll allow it,” Izzy said.

“I’m going to go find Gress first,” Capella said.

“Gress isn’t where you probably think he is,” Izzy said. “I’ve had him moved. Could you do a few things first? It’ll help us evacuate if we have to do so.”

Izzy could see the look on Capella’s face, distrust warring with the urge to be helpful, and wondered which would win.

“Tell me where he is first and then I’ll listen to what you have to say,” Capella replied.

For a brief moment Izzy didn't want to tell her and then thought about how she felt just moments before with Finn. She knew that Capella and Gress weren't romantically involved but she also knew that their relationship of friendship was just as serious as her and Finn's relationship.

"He's right here," Izzy said as she pulled Pat out of her satchel and held the data pad out so Capella could see it. Capella stepped forward, carefully watching Izzy as she glanced down at the data pad. "Do you want to go and check on him?"

Capella stepped back as she said, "I do but I said to tell me where he is and I'll listen. So for now, I'm listening."

"OK, I need you to find Cowrie as well as Oak and Chitin. I've got the last known locations of both of their ships. Tell them I need as many ships as they can get together to come to the coastline here," Izzy said as she tapped at her data pad and showed Capella a location. "They need to be ready to fight if necessary but I want them to take any of my brothers who might show up there to safety."

"Where do you want them to go?" Capella replied.

"I don't know. They're all smart, I'll leave it to them," Izzy said.

“I know it’s a long haul but tell anyone who can hear to get to Plumeria,” Capella said.

Izzy frowned as she said, “P-Pear isn’t going to be much help I think.”

Capella grinned as she said, “Then I know something you don’t. Trust me, she’ll be plenty of help. Send them.”

Izzy nodded as she made a note.

“So you’ll help me?” Izzy replied.

“I’ll help you,” Capella replied.

# # #

Capella wanted to go down and grab Gress and take him immediately out to Plumeria but she didn’t. For now, she reasoned he was as safe as he could be in Dryl and so she took a deep breath, looked at the locations that she’d allowed Izzy to message her and then teleported.

First, she went looking for Cowrie and it ended up harder than she thought it’d be. Izzy had a close fix on her but it was a moving

target over a large open ocean and Capella ended up teleporting repeatedly over the water, falling for a while as she looked around, and then teleporting again. Finally, she spotted Cowrie's ship and teleported straight to the wheel.

"Cappe, it's been a while," Cowrie said as she gave a little wave from where she was draped over the wheel of the ship.

"Izzy needs your help right now," Capella said as she stepped forward and then stepped right back as Slick, Cowrie's first mate, suddenly loomed over her captain's shoulder.

Cowrie grinned as she said, "Yeah, maybe slow down a little there and tell me what's going on."

Capella looked at Cowrie as she said, "Dryl is under attack and Izzy needs you to head to the coast and bring in as many trustworthy ships as you can so you can pull out any spacebats that end up there. And you need to do this *now!"*

"You know, you didn't used to be so on edge," Cowrie said and then laughed as sparks started to fall from Capella's hair. "OK, calm down, I'm just needling you."

"Don't," Capella almost growled. "It's not the day for it."

Cowrie nodded as she stopped laughing and said, “That’s fair. I assume these comm problems have to do with Dryl?”

“I don’t know,” Capella said, “but it’s a safe assumption.”

“Then you’re our link,” Cowrie said. “Keep safe. Now let me know where to go.”

Capella showed her a location and Cowrie grinned as she said, “Ah, memories. That’s the same place I put Finn and crew back in the day. Well, now’s not the time for that, I’ve got a course. I assume you’re going for Oak and Chitin next?”

Capella nodded as she took a few breaths.

“OK… and Cappe… I don’t know exactly what’s been going on with you but you’re always welcome on my ship for whatever you need,” Cowrie said, low and serious.

Capella recognized her chance, dropped a random face over her own and said in a disguised voice, “Thank you but how do you know you haven’t helped me out already?”

Cowrie blinked for a moment before bursting out with laughter and Capella took that moment to teleport out to find Oak and Chitin.

“Queen of Shadows and Smoke indeed,” Cowrie said with a shake of her head before stepping up to the railing and whistling to get everyone’s attention. “Listen up! We got people to save! Let’s put on every bit of speed and get ready to hail anyone we pass for help! Move it!”

Out over another patch of ocean, Capella searched for Oak and Chitin’s ship. Again, it took her longer than she expected and when she set down on the deck of the ship, she could feel exhaustion starting to peek in on her. Then she suddenly felt very awake as she heard shouts and saw people pointing at her and drawing weapons. She saw Chitin at the railing and teleported up to her and then remembered to drop the illusion at the last second.

“Cappe! What in the world are you doing out here!?” Chitin shouted. Capella vaguely heard a thump under her feet as she answered.

“Izzy needs your help,” Capella said, remembering not to be too forceful this time.

“It’s Cappe! No need for worries!” Chitin shouted to the crew who were racing up to defend their co-captain. Capella looked around as they nodded and a few even shouted hellos at her as she started to fill Chitin in on what was going on. She had just started telling Chitin where to go and what to do when she saw Oak come running towards her. Oak came sliding to a halt when Capella instinctively went for her dagger.

“Ok! No hugs for Cappe right now, understood loud and clear,” Oak said as she put her hands up in front of her.

“No, absolutely not,” Capella said before going on and finished telling them both what was happening. “So I need you at this dock as quick as you can with as many trustworthy ships as you can get to show up.”

Oak’s face became terrified as she managed to stammer out, “Dryl is really under attack?” Capella nodded as Oak went on. “Are Finn and Izzy safe?”

“No, Oak, they’re under attack,” Capella said with a deadpan expression as Chitin put an arm around Oak. Capella left out the part of Finn trying to stare down a tank as she went on. “Are you going to help?”

Oak nodded as she said, “Adventure, excitement, yeah, we’ve got it, don’t we?”

Chitin gave her a hug as Oak’s tone certainly didn’t match the words. As Capella nodded, Chitin spoke up.

“Cappe, don’t be a stranger, alright?”

Capella looked at her but couldn't think of something to say and then teleported out.

"We've got a job to do," Chitin said as she kissed Oak's forehead. "You good?"

"I'm scared but yeah, let's do this," Oak said.

Capella meanwhile was getting into Plumeria. She didn't bother to put up her illusion as she barged into the place she'd been staying. Inside she found Coalfire, Prickly Pear, and Alice talking over Alice's data pad. As they all looked up, Prickly Pear was the only one to gasp at Capella's appearance.

"You're covered in stone dust now," Coalfire replied as she walked over and brushed some off Capella's jacket.

"Dryl is under attack and it's not looking good. They managed to teleport more troops in with tanks. They have more than enough to overrun Dryl I think," Capella said. "P-Pear, I've told Izzy to send people here if they have to evacuate. Be ready to receive them. Alice, what's new?"

Prickly Pear stood up straighter, her face getting serious again as Alice responded.

“Networks are down all over. It’s an attack on the software as far as I can tell,” Alice said. “I’m getting a few messages through but overall, it’s all local stuff. Those streaks of fire you and Coalfire saw were probably the communications satellites getting knocked out of orbit. This is serious.”

“Coalfire, tell Dio to hurry on that transport. We need it now and lots of it. Pilots too. We may have to go into Dryl and start pulling people out,” Capella said. “I’m about to head back. Is there anything I need to know?”

Prickly Pear said, “Artho, Skua, and Puffin are alright. They’re with Mom right now.”

Capella nodded as she said, “OK, that’s good but keep a close eye on Skua. Artho too for that matter. They were both living out there and while I think they’re not an immediate danger, I also think that’s where the troops attacking Dryl came from. Marasville was pretty much empty.”

“That’s my sister you’re talking about,” Prickly Pear replied.

“And you better realize that you can be betrayed by those closest to you,” Capella said. “Do I know for sure? Of course not but that doesn’t mean we can’t be careful.” Prickly Pear started to speak up and Capella shook her head. “P-Pear, I don’t have time. You wanted to help, fine, this is part of that. This is part of what we talked about that night. Anything else?”

Alice gave a shake of her head and Capella was about to leave when Coalfire stopped her.

“I’m coming with you,” Coalfire replied.

“No,” Capella said. “I need you here.”

“You need a sorcerer to fight. If they teleported then they have one themselves,” Coalfire said.

Capella thought for a second and then nodded.

“Fine, you’re coming along. Alice, get Dio and take P-Pear along so Dio knows she’s with you and then get back to working the comms issue. P-Pear, help Dio,” Capella said. “Questions? OK, let's move.”

Prickly Pear’s face was troubled as Capella teleported out with Coalfire but she had asked to be involved. She followed Alice out the door, looking over her shoulder at the space Capella had been in just a moment before, and then sat out to do the job before her.

# # #

“Their reinforcements are in the castle,” Harpi said as he looked at his data pad. “They’re taking losses from the bots but it’s slowed to almost nothing since the second wave arrived and they set up a fortified base in the main hall. The bots have pulled back but I don’t know why. They’ve certainly taken losses but not so many that they should be at the stage where they should be retreating yet but they have.”

Izzy leaned against a wall as she listened to the sounds of laser cannon fire echoing from up the corridor followed by an explosion. Finn flinched at the noise and she absentmindedly put a hand on their shoulder in comfort.

“They’re smart,” Izzy said. “And I did give them the run of the castle. I assume, unless we see otherwise, they’re working off a plan.”

Ertu, one of the clone council members that had attached himself to Izzy once she’d made it down to the secondary tunnels, spoke up.

“Do they have a source of supply?”

Harpi nodded as he said, “They do Brother Ertu. I do not know how long they’ll be able to hold that line but they do seem to have a way to get supplies in. They’re making sorties out into the rest of the castle…”

Harpi's reply was cut off as they all involuntarily flinched and looked up as a loud crashing noise sounded over their heads.

Izzy spoke up, her voice choked, as she looked up from her data pad and said, "They just knocked down the emergency beacon tower. The top of the castle is getting demolished although they seem to be leaving the theater alone except for a quick search they put through it."

"Iz, maybe we need to go," Finn said quietly. "Unless you have something that can stop them."

Izzy sighed as she looked at her data pad, looked up at Harpi, Ertu, and Finn, and then back down at her data pad.

"I thought the bots would be able to handle it," Izzy said. "I never planned for an army like this though. We need to get everyone in and seal up the secondary tunnels. I guess we go to siege mode."

Finn hugged Izzy as Harpi stepped forward and put a hand on her arm.

"You never planned for a fight like this because you always planned for retreat. Keep everyone safe was always your plan and fighting gets both sides killed," Harpi replied. "Remember?"

Izzy remembered the planning session Harpi talked about, many years in the past, and nodded.

"I didn't… I don't want to run though," she replied as she hugged Finn back before nodding as she knew her duty to her brothers. "Doesn't matter though. OK, get the last of our people into the secondary tunnels. Get the tunnel to the spaceport opened up. Leave the last few feet and we'll blast it when it comes time to open it."

"We've got a lot of extra people here," Harpi said. "More than I think we planned on."

"Then we go on short rations immediately and it gets a little crowded in there," Izzy said. "The other princesses might come to our aid but we plan for the next of our ships to come through the system and that's not for a while. We get a little skinny and grumpy at being so close at worst."

Harpi started sending out orders when they all turned as Capella appeared. They all saw the person standing next to her in orange robes with a veil over her face. Finn knew the look, had seen it on the statue of Light Spinner before it'd been removed at Mystacor, and raised an eyebrow.

"There you are!" Capella said as she walked forward to Izzy.

"We're retreating to deeper tunnels," Izzy said.

“The ones Gress used to live in before you brought the kids out?” Capella said.

Izzy gave a tired grin as she said, “The kids weren’t supposed to talk about that but yes.”

“Well, I’ve been to his room to visit him before,” Capella said. “So there’s that as well. Everyone, this is Coalfire. She’s a mercenary who’s been working with me and she’s a sorcerer as well.”

“I’m Izzy, this is my spouse Finn, Brother Harpi, and Brother Ertu,” Izzy said pointing around at everyone. “Are you here to help I assume?”

“I am,” Coalfire said as she gave a curt nod.

“Graduate of Mystacor?” Izzy asked.

“Yes, although not necessarily in good standing with them,” Coalfire responded.

“Doesn’t matter. Gives me an idea of what you can do,” Izzy replied. “Our attackers have a sorcerer as well. Let’s talk strategy while we walk.”

“I’m going to go see Gress,” Capella replied.

“That’s fair but please, check back in with me soon. I’ll have more for you to do if you’re still with me,” Izzy said.

“I’ve been fighting for the spacebats this whole time,” Capella said in an irritated voice. “I’m not stopping now.”

As she teleported out, Finn grinned as they said, “I love that kid.”

“Not a kid anymore,” Izzy said quietly before turning to Coalfire as they began to walk.

# # #

Capella was furious. She’d teleported to where Izzy had said Gress was and when she’d got there, he wasn’t there.

“Where is he?” she said, doing her best to keep her anger down as she talked to Hort. Still, little sparks kept forming in her hair as she spoke.

"He was here a little while ago but went away with someone," Hort said. "Brother Gress said he knew him."

"Where were they going?" Capella said.

"They went back up the tunnel before Izzy issued the order for everyone to get into the secondary tunnels," Hort replied. "The only reason we're still here is because we're waiting for them to return."

Capella looked back up the tunnel where Hort pointed before she turned back to him.

"Get into the tunnels. I know where Gress' room is and I'll bring him back there," Capella replied as she adjusted her bags with a sigh. "Who was with him?"

"He said his name was Brother Half Ear," Hort said and Capella's eyes snapped up to Hort.

"He… did?" Capella said as she felt her heart leap into her throat. She wasn't sure why but it felt entirely wrong that Half Ear was there at Dryl for some reason.

"Capella, what is wrong?" Hort said and Capella realized she hadn't tried to hide her surprise. "Is Gress in danger?"

“No,” Capella said, shoving down her emotions and giving a smile. “Just a rough day. I’ll go find them.”

She teleported away and called Izzy on the data pad connection the bots were still maintaining in the castle.

“Cappe, whatta got?” Izzy responded over a voice connection.

“Can you find Gress for me? He wasn’t where you said he’d be,” Capella asked.

“I swear that’s where…,” Izzy started to say when Capella cut her off.

“I know you told me the truth, just tell me if you know where he is right now,” Capella responded.

“Give me a moment,” Izzy said as she referenced the bot network. “OK, got him. What in the world is he doing down there? Sorry, he’s with a brother I don’t recognize down in the tunnel coming away from the beacon controls.”

“What’s down there?” Capella said.

“Nothing. It’s a tunnel that ultimately comes out to the surface above Dryl,” Izzy said. “I’m sending you the location now. Can you get them back into the secondary tunnels? The surface is not safe.”

Capella, hoping it was just something stupid, nodded as she said, “I’m on my way.”

She teleported to the location Izzy had sent her and saw in the dim light of the corridor Half Ear walking with Gress.

“She said to bring you up here,” Capella overheard Half Ear say.

“Who said that?” Capella said as she started towards them.

“Cappe!” Gress said as he turned around to see her. Then Half Ear grabbed Gress and yanked him backwards as Half Ear put his back to a wall.

“You stay right there, Princess,” Half Ear said as Capella saw a flash of steel in his hand. “The price on both of you is higher alive but I’ll happily turn him over dead for the lesser cost if you try and interfere.”

Capella slowly slid her dagger out of its sheath as she said, “Gress, you alright?”

“I’m…,” Gress started to respond before he had the words choked out of him as Half Ear yanked back on his shirt and twisted it.

“He’s going to be just fine if you do what I say,” Half Ear replied. “Teleport away. I’ll collect and you can go in and get him out. Don’t leave though and I’ll kill him and then you.”

Capella felt rage billowing in her mind as she looked at Half Ear’s cold face and sparks lit the corridor as they fell from her and a faint glow flickered around her outline.

“*You will let him go right now or I will kill you!”* Capella screamed at him.

“Throw a temper tantrum, I don’t care,” Half Ear said as the knife blade slipped up to the side of Gress’ face. “You’ll just kill him faster and he’ll suffer in the process.”

Capella thought her teeth were going to crack with how hard she had her jaw clenched shut. Tears were starting to run down Gress’ face and his ears were plastered back against his head in fear. Capella started to take a step forward when she froze as the blade creeped up towards Gress’ eye.

“You only have one choice,” Half Ear said, his voice almost crooning. “You’ll have a better chance of saving him if you just let

me collect his bounty."

"Gress, I'm going to save you," Capella said, her hands trembling in anger.

"I know," Gress said and though his eyes seemed to say otherwise it was all Capella needed. She stepped back.

"Take him but I am going to make sure you suffer for this before you die," Capella responded.

"Teleport away. Go fight the good fight like a good little princess," Half Ear said with a malicious laugh as he waved the knife blade at her.

Capella nodded as she saw the knife blade come away from Gress' face and teleported. Half Ear expected that though and was ready when she appeared in front of Gress and yanked him sideways, tossing him down the corridor. Half Ear was already going sideways and slashed the knife downwards, barely missing Capella's throat and slicing her across the top of her chest. Her bags fell away as she screamed in rage, not feeling the pain yet from the cut. She reached for him but Half Ear slid out of her reach, throwing the knife at her as he did.

Capella managed to dodge and tried to cut at him with her dagger but he parried with a steel baton that he dropped into his off hand. She teleported behind him, ready to cut him down but

when she appeared he was already moving and her stab went beside him. She saw him pull something out of his jacket, a frame with a handle and a trigger and a little crystal along the top and she knew it for what it was, a compact laser cannon, as he fired it at her. The cracking noise as she teleported away sounded loud in the corridor. She appeared to his side this time, hoping he wouldn't anticipate it and then had to immediately teleport as he fired again.

"Cappe!" Gress screamed as he got to his feet and started running towards the two. Capella didn't hear him as she reappeared and barely managed to avoid getting shot. She teleported back and that's when she heard Gress screaming in agony. He was on the ground, holding his right arm that was in shreds from the blast of the weapon.

For a moment, everything seemed to hold still. Capella would remember that moment as it seemed as if the world came to a halt as she saw her best friend, her friend squared, laying on the ground with a splash of blood behind them and screaming in agony. Half Ear was in the process of turning the weapon on her but again, nothing seemed to move at all. Then everything caught up to here as she felt a rushing feeling followed by a blinding flash of light.

Chapter End Notes

Not too many chapters left to go.

Bright Moon

Chapter Summary

Bow and Glimmer learn of the attack on Dryl.

Chapter Notes

"Hold Fast" - Tall ship sailors motto

Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra and Adora sat in the war room at Bright Moon. It'd been days since the communications had gone down and they were both exhausted. Since they'd received word of the attack on Dryl, Glimmer had promoted them to generals but they were long out of the practice of war and they weren't sure they were being of any help but they still tried. Melog was curled under the table as Catra watched Bow pacing the room, Bright Moon's general of the guard following along as she reported.

"We've registered more attacks on the clones in various independent towns. Because we're still working on getting reliable long range communications restored, we only have preliminary casualty and damage lists for you. While bad, they weren't as bad as expected. It seemed the Princess of Dryl had protections in place for those communities that were large enough. The attackers are claiming Mara as their guiding inspiration and have requested the Princess of Candila take them under his protection," the guard responded.

"He's not a princess yet," Bow said, snapping off his words.

“I’m aware but that’s how they’re referring to him,” the general said. “We’ve also found that most of the clones who got out of Dryl or left other towns have gone to Plumeria and another large contingent from towns near Dryl have been taken by a flotilla of ships to Salineas. There was a fight getting them off the shore but again, the people attacking did not expect it to be as stiff a resistance as was given. Princess Oak and Princess Cowrie led the last charge that allowed the final clones to get on board their ships. They both managed to leave with their ships but I have reports they were both seriously wounded. I do not know their status beyond that.”

“And my daughter?” Bow said.

“We have had no solid word,” the general said uncomfortably. “She may still be in Dryl. No one is able to get close. We believe there are still clones hidden in deep tunnels under Dryl but the castle itself is in ruins and the attackers have dug in for their own defense. From what we can see, they’re trapped in the ruins and bots of unknown construction attack them, and anyone who approaches, pretty relentlessly. We wish to save them, for information as well as the humanity of the act, but I am being told this is not likely if things do not change.”

Bow took a deep breath as he stopped, as he looked at the murals on the wall, and then quietly said, “General, do you have any idea at all where she may be? Anything?”

“Understand none of this is substantial,” the general replied. “We know she was in Dryl as has been reported. That is the last firm

location we have for her. People, including Princess Izzy and her spouse, were teleported into Plumeria after that confirmation but it would seem Dryl had a sorcerer helping them and while teleportation spells are very uncommon, it's not completely out of the realm of possibility. This was right after Princess Prickly Pear declared her kingdom no longer neutral and threw her entire kingdom squarely behind the clones."

Adora snorted a little from where she had her head down on the table. Even Bow appreciated what Adora was amused at, though he didn't smile. Prickly Pear's declaration had been one of the only things to go out across the long range Etherian network since it had fallen. It had been simply stated. "Plumeria does not stand for subjugation. We are a sanctuary for any spacebat who needs it. Those who seek to do them harm will be destroyed."

"I still can't believe she said that," Adora said, the words at odds with the memory she had of a young Prickly Pear, barely past her toddler years, kindly offering her Aunt Adora some soap because of how stinky Adora had been after a long survey.

"It has been effective so far but whether it is her threat or the fact it is a kingdom does remain to be seen," the general replied. "The kingdoms have not had any outbreaks of violence, other than Dryl. Back to the matter at hand, we know a small group of skiffs flew out from the Heart Stone heading south and we have not had contact with Princess Izzy since or the Clone Council or any sightings of Capella. That is all we know for certain at this time. I'm sorry, Bow."

Bow shook his head as he thought about getting the first fragmentary bits of information the day Dryl was attacked. He and

Glimmer had been in her office late in the day trying to figure out what was going on with the communications connections when the first report had arrived. They quickly moved to the war room and got Catra and Adora up to the castle. The holograph table had slowly started getting information as Glimmer tried to get things together. By the time the report of Dryl actually having been attacked by a large group came in, it was early evening. Bow knew he'd remember the next moments very clearly for a long time.

Catra had been talking with Glimmer and the general, laying out defense for the kingdom and preparing to send reinforcements to Dryl, her tail lashing back and forth in her worry over Finn and Izzy. Adora had been going down a long list of supplies and equipment the guard had stockpiled as she made plans while Bow fiddled with the holographic table, trying to get a good network connection. A guard had come rushing in, snapped to attention and said, "Your Majesties, Capella has been spotted in Dryl! It's a concrete sighting!"

It was the first one they'd had in some time and Bow perked up a little as he said, "We're a bit busy but thank you for letting us know."

The guard was shaking her head as she replied, "Sir, I don't think you understand. This was today. She's there in the fighting."

The whole room went quiet as Glimmer walked over to the guard.

"When was this?" she asked.

“I don’t know the exact time,” the guard said. “The duty officer sent me as soon as the information came in.”

Glimmer nodded as she turned around. Bow could see she was about to say something when her eyes went wide and she started shaking.

“What is it?” Bow said as he went rushing to her side.

“I can’t feel her,” Glimmer said as she turned haunted eyes to Bow and started to sink to the floor.

“What do you mean?” Bow said as he rushed to her, took her in his arms, and went to the floor with her.

“I can’t feel her through the Moonstone,” Glimmer said, her voice starting to rise. *“Bow, I can’t feel her through the Moonstone!”*

Adora and Catra were at her side by that point, Melog pacing around behind them as Adora replied, “Maybe it’s just…”

“She’s dead,” Glimmer said, her eyes going empty and her voice hollow before she buried her face in her hands and started weeping.

“Starlight, no, it can’t be that, she’s alive, there’s no way…,” Bow said as tears started streaming down his face.

“I can’t feel her anymore,” Glimmer said, her voice muffled but the wailing coming through.

The two held each other on the floor, weeping, as Catra and Adora came in and hugged them tight, crying right along with them. The general and the guard turned away, wiping at their eyes as Melog let out a long drawn out wail. After some time, Catra had got up from the floor and went to the general.

“You’re in command for now,” Catra had said, her voice husky and her eyes red and raw. “Do what you feel is needed.”

The general had nodded and gone off to bring in more help as Adora and Catra had helped Glimmer and Bow to their rooms. However, the monarchs couldn’t just disappear in the middle of what was turning into the biggest thing to happen on Etheria since possibly the Fall of Prime and Bow was the first to get up and go back to work later that evening. Adora had stayed behind with Glimmer as Catra had kept pace with Bow towards the war room.

“What are you doing?” Catra said. “If someone needs to handle something, I can do it.”

“I already talked with Glimmer about it,” Bow replied, his hands clenched tight as he walked. “I’ve got this.”

Catra had grabbed his shoulder and turned him to face her as she said, “Bow, I love you but this isn’t you. Why are you trying to hide your feelings? You need to deal with this, not run from it.”

“I’m not hiding my feelings,” Bow said. “I’ve got work to do.”

“No! You will not act like this is something that can be hidden in your work!” Catra said, loud enough that several Bright Moon guards started slowly heading towards them. “She’s… she’s gone and you need to face that!”

“No, she is not gone!” Bow shouted back in Catra’s face. “I will not accept it! She is too smart, too fast, too clever! She is just like her mother and Glimmer came through plenty! We were all in tough spots before and we came out of it! Capella is not dead!”

“Bow…,” Catra started to say and then stopped as he cut her off with a chopping motion of his hand.

“No. I refuse it. It is not so. She is not gone and we have work to do,” Bow replied, his eyes full of pain as he reached out and put a hand on Catra’s shoulder.

“OK, it’s not so,” Catra said as she placed her hand over his. “Let’s work.”

The following days were full of contradicting reports and confusing information. Some clones came into Bright Moon and citizens opened their homes to help them. Glimmer stayed out of sight for the most part, mourning, as Bow did his best to handle what duties she might have while he, Angella, and friends rotated out sitting with Glimmer. Things weren’t going well though and while the fighting seemed to have stopped for the moment, it was obvious a response was needed and needed soon. Now, as the general left the room after having given the latest update for Bow, he fell back into a chair with a sigh.

“What do we do now?” Bow said.

“We don’t have a standing army,” Catra said. “Even if we did, they haven’t attacked us and we can’t get close enough to Dryl because of the bots. Anything that looks like organized forces have been very careful about staying out of the kingdoms. None of the towns with the attacks going on have asked for us to help and if we go in without that, it’s an invasion.”

“Aeron had to have planned it that way,” Adora replied. They’d all begun to see his hand behind this, even if it was something they couldn’t prove. The day after the attacks, Catra and Adora had gone to the rented rooms he had been calling an embassy in Bright Moon to find everyone had left. “No way he didn’t plan it that way. I wish Izzy was here for this. She knew more about this than any of us.”

"And didn't share it very well," Bow said, anger in his voice that slid away as he let out a sigh. "But understandably so. I just wish we knew where she was and had more time."

The unspoken part was because then they might have news of Capella as well. Catra nodded as she grasped Adora's hand. They'd both been trying to keep calm since Finn had disappeared with Izzy but everything they'd seen had said that both of them had made it out of Dryl. The fact they didn't even have that for Capella was just another worry to add. Bow continued his belief that Capella had made it out of Dryl alright and that the loss of connection with the Moonstone was just a fluke.

They all looked up as Glimmer walked into the room, her wings furled tight behind her, as she went and sat down next to Bow. She handed him a scroll as she wearily said, "OK, the High Council of Etheria has called itself into session. Bow and I are ordered to report immediately with the rest of the princesses to report in three days."

"Why?" Catra replied as she sat up. "What in the world is so important that we all have to go to this?"

Bow cursed as he read the scroll and then threw it across the room.

"Aeron," he said, drawing the word out of his mouth with more venom than the obscenity he'd said right before it. "He's argued that because some of the independent kingdoms have asked for his protection by his so-called rightful title and because the

Princess Council has delayed the recognition that the High Council has no choice but to require an emergency session."

"What do we do?" Adora said and Catra could feel her hand trembling a little.

"We go," Glimmer said, her voice tired as she traced glowing symbols on the tabletop that faded from view as she finished each one. "We go and we deal with it. That's all we can do."

"The High Council has also ordered us to produce every princess required and we can't do that because we don't know where Izzy is right now," Bow replied.

"And they have the authority to take action against us if we don't," Adora said. "We can't even appeal to She-Ra for help."

Catra understood why Adora's hand was shaking now as she squeezed it tight.

"OK, we need to figure something out," Catra replied. "We've got three days to round everyone up you said. Chances are that Izzy is going to come out of wherever she's hiding before then. I can't see her staying completely underground… until…," Catra suddenly trailed off as she looked down at the table before her head came back up. "Where did the general say the group of skiffs was going when they flew away from the Heart Stone?"

“South I think she said,” Bow replied.

“Why does that matter?” Glimmer said.

“I think I know where she’s gone and I think Capella is alive and with her,” Catra responded.

Chapter End Notes

Moving right along.

Half Moon

Chapter Summary

Remembrance and conversations.

Note: If you're following along as these are being posted, please be aware there is a chapter called Bright Moon posted before this one.

Chapter Notes

"How did I get into this and this and how do I get out of it again, how does it end?" - Soren Kierkegaard

Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Drip.

Drip.

Drip.

The sound of water dripping was a constant in certain parts of the cave and Finn was starting to see why the former inhabitants of Half-Moon had set up their little gathering places in certain places in the main cavern. They were places away from water so the dripping wasn't a constant background to whatever it was they had done in the little circular gathering places. Finn approached one now, lit by a low-powered lantern that was still shockingly bright in the otherwise utter darkness of the cavern. The light threw long shadows out into the cavern to mingle with other

shadows from the few other gathering areas being used. Finn looked around the little circle of people before they sat down beside Izzy who was working on her data pad and tapped her on the shoulder as they held a plate of food out to her.

"Dinner, Iz," Finn said. "Just checked on Gress by the way. He's up and around with his caretakers."

"Good," Izzy mumbled as she continued to work. "Just put it next to me please,"

"No, it's dinner time, remember?" Finn said.

Izzy looked over at Finn, her eyes rimmed with dark shadows before she finally sat the data pad into her satchel.

"The tiara as well," Finn said with a gentle smile. She grumbled as she put the hood of her hoodie down but flipped the monocle up out of the way and pulled the tiara off, the line in her close cropped hair showing where it'd sat. She took the plate from Finn and waited while Harpi sat down a moment later next to Ertu and handed him a plate. Izzy looked at the others in the circle, took a deep breath, and began to speak.

"We remember those who have left us in the past year, out of contact or passed on," Izzy said and took a deep shuddering breath before each person at the circle began to speak out names in unison. The list lasted for many minutes, all new names from

the worst fighting in Dryl during their retreat. Izzy fought to concentrate on the names and not the images of the fighting in her mind. The attackers had done the unexpected. They'd somehow found out about the secondary tunnel systems and then breached them.

When they started on the names of those lost in towns throughout Etheria, she fought down the feeling of guilt of having left Dryl with the Clone Council, even though her brothers had suggested it. She didn't realize everyone there was having a similar thought, that those they loved had died to make sure they lived and each person in the circle took a deep breath before moving on to the rest of the names. The list finally ended with the few older names including Micah and then Izzy said, "Now a moment of quiet to remember the Nameless Ones, lost under Prime."

Izzy looked straight ahead, not bothering to wipe away the tears that streamed down her face, as they all waited. Finally, Ertu leaned forward and lit a small candle next to the lantern and only then did she wipe at her face as did others in the circle. Finn picked at their food for a moment before they seemed to make a decision. They looked up at a figure sitting back from the light a little and said, "So Mother, are you going to just sit there or are you going to say hello?"

Everyone looked at Finn and then turned to where Finn was looking. The shadowy figure was shaking her head as she pushed her hood back, to reveal furry ears. A few of the clones around the circle pulled away from her as Catra scooted forward into the light.

“I should have known you’d notice,” Catra said.

“How did you get in here!?” Izzy asked as he looked around in alarm.

“Calm down, it’s just me,” Catra said. “Your guards are very good but I’m also very sneaky.”

“Melog, where are you?” Finn said and was answered by a little chirping noise from behind them followed by a nudge at their elbow. They looked down and smiled at Melog and then looked up again to see Catra looming over them as she leaned down and pulled Finn into a hug.

“We were so scared,” Catra whispered as Finn sat their plate down and hugged her back.

“I’m sorry,” Finn said. “We tried to contact you but the comms…”

Catra nodded as Finn trailed off and she sat back on her heels.

“It’s OK,” Catra said with a relieved smile. She turned to Izzy and hugged her as well. “And you, we were scared for you as well and I need to speak with you right now.”

“It’s dinner time. It’ll have to wait,” Izzy replied. Catra looked like she was going to argue for a moment but she finally just nodded.

“OK, can you answer one question at least?” Catra said and Izzy nodded. “Is Capella OK? I didn’t hear her name in the list.”

Finn and Izzy both looked at each other before Izzy turned back to Catra.

“I wouldn’t say OK but she’s here. She spends most of her time by that last waterfall from your and Adora’s original entry to the cavern,” Izzy replied. “She’s blaming herself for a lot of stuff, including Gress getting hurt, and spends a lot of time up there thinking.”

“Mother, sit down,” Finn said as they held their plate out to her. “Eat with us.”

“I need to talk to her as well and I’m not eating your dinner, kiddo,” Catra said.

“Do you have something to eat?” Finn asked.

“As a matter of fact, I do,” Catra said as she reached inside her jacket and pulled out an energy bar. Finn rumpled their nose at it. Hordies, former Horde soldiers who’d set up a construction and engineering company after the war to repair damage and then

went on to build other things, had started making the things using an improved design from the old Horde ration bars. Catra and Adora loved them. Finn thought they were foul.

"That's not food, Mother," Finn said with a critical tone to their voice before they gave a sudden tired smile. "We can get you some applesauce if you want."

Catra grinned as tears pooled in her eyes and gently cupped Finn's face in her hand.

"I missed you," she said with a tired smile.

# # #

Catra heard the rush of the waterfall and shuddered a little as she remembered years before rappelling down the long drop next to it and getting soaked when she and Adora had first re-discovered the cavern of Half-Moon. Melog padded along beside her in the soft sand as Catra followed the tunnel by the light of a headlamp. As she got towards the end, she could see the waterfall, a large pool of water leading into a stream and sitting beside the stream was a hunched over figure.

"Cappe?" Catra said as she stopped some distance back, not wanting to send her teleporting away. It was also because Catra wasn't even sure it was the same person, the image before her so different from the one she had in her head of Capella. Then her

face turned towards Catra and Catra watched as grief and pain disappeared from it to be replaced by a neutral look.

"I should have known you'd find us here," Capella said.

Catra sat down in the sand and leaned back against the wall as she took off her headlamp and set it so it wasn't pointing at anyone. As she did that, Melog went up to Capella, circling her cautiously and chirping quizzically at her as they did. At first Capella watched them with a leery eye but then she carefully reached out her hand. Melog bumped up against it with their head and as they did so, Catra could see in the dim light a scar starting at Capella's wrist and disappearing into her rolled up sleeve. As she looked closer, she could see other cuts and scrapes visible on her arms and a fresh burn along the side of her head.

"So when are the King and Queen going to jump out with a gotcha? Can't see you tracking me down without them," Capella said as Melog nudged her hand again and then walked away, chirping at Catra as they went up the tunnel again.

"Thanks," Catra said to Melog before turning back to Capella. "They're not here and before you say something, it's not because they didn't want to be, big things are going on and they got stuck going to the High Council of Etheria. Of course, your Mom is pretty much sure you're dead but your Dad, he wasn't quite willing to believe until he'd seen a body."

Catra didn't bother to mention the huge argument that had come about when she'd mentioned her idea of coming to Half Moon to

look around. Bow and Glimmer had both wanted to come but a representative of the High Council had arrived with the scroll to escort the two and it was pretty obvious if they didn't go, there'd be serious repercussions. Even then, it had been a close argument that had only ended when Adora had very quietly pointed out that Capella may very well bolt at the sight of her parents if they went along.

"Mom thinks I'm dead," Capella said as she gave a short tired laugh. "Dark Moon tell her that?"

"No, she thinks that because she said you lost your connection to the Moonstone," Catra replied. "I was there when it happened. We all wept for hours."

Capella looked away, up the vertical tunnel carved by falling water over the centuries and didn't say anything for a long minute. As she did, Catra thought her face looked distressed but in the dim light, she wasn't sure and when Capella looked back at her again, her face was still and composed.

"I don't believe you," Capella replied. Catra shook her head as she looked down for a moment before looking back up at Capella.

"You know what? I don't care if you do at this point," Catra said. "It's hard to distinguish what you have done from what is just wild speculation and accusations but you could have said something." Catra took a long deep breath before going on. "You've left your parents hanging ever since you disappeared after Wheatland! Why!? If you'd involved us, we could have helped!"

Capella grunted as she said, "Yeah, I could have and maybe get to watch more of my friends get attacked or killed. The Dark Moon group that came after me in Wheatland? They knew my passphrase that only the Bright Moon squad was supposed to know. Everything points to Bright Moon on that and I'm just supposed to, I don't know, say, 'Oh, well, what a coincidence! We'll just get more people wiped out!' I know you know better."

"You couldn't send a message over a data pad? Try and have a sit down with them somehow? Why didn't you even try?" Catra said. She almost said something about Micah's funeral but bit her lip as she realized it wasn't a wise idea.

"It wasn't safe," Capella replied, almost muttering. "I was going to talk with them eventually. Something someone said to me recently made me start reconsidering what they may or may not have done."

"You think I'd have let my friend put together something like this rumored Dark Moon? I guess you don't know me as well as I thought you did. You know, I remember the day you were born. I've watched you grow up. You're incredibly smart and I love you so understand when I say that you have acted like an idiot recently, I say it only out of love," Catra said.

Catra had expected her to argue with her, or even teleport away, but what she wasn't ready for was for Capella to bury her face in her hands and start crying. Catra started to get up off the sand and go to her when Capella suddenly took a deep shuddering breath and looked up. Catra watched as an illusion dropped over

her face, one that was Capella's face but completely dry eyed and calm.

"I'm well aware of that," Capella said, her voice difficult to understand as she fought to keep it level. Then it evened out as she went on. "I've got people killed because of me. I've been hurt myself but worse of all, I almost got Gress killed and in the process he lost his arm. Because of me. All because of me. So yeah, I'm an idiot who set out to solve problems and in the process probably pushed Etheria into war."

"Yeah, no, I'm not letting you take credit for that," Catra replied. "Go talk to Izzy if you want more details but that's not your fault. The dead people probably aren't either. I don't know Gress' story but I'll bet *that* wasn't your fault either. In fact, it's a bit egotistical to think that an entire planet wide war is all your fault. Those people who attacked Dryl and who've attacked others didn't do it because of *you* . You're a player in this little tragedy, that's for certain, but that doesn't mean you started it. You might have even have stalled it a little."

Capella was shaking her head and pulled her legs in tighter as she said, "You just want me to trust you."

"You want to trust me," Catra said. "If you didn't, you would have teleported away by now."

Capella looked away as she said, "I can't."

“What do you mean you can’t?” Catra replied.

“I can’t. There’s a reason Mom doesn’t feel me through the Moonstone anymore. I cut myself off from it,” Capella replied.

Catra blinked in surprise and opened her mouth to reply before shutting it again. After a moment of thought, she finally said, “I, uh, wasn’t aware you could do that.”

“Well, it’s something that can be done, I found out,” Capella muttered. “I was being tracked somehow by my teleporting and it was dangerous. I might be able to teleport again one day, if I learn the spell. That’s better anyway. The Moonstone should only be for a princess of Bright Moon.”

Capella’s face was stoic but her body language was anything but and Catra carefully came up into a crouch as she said, “Can… I come closer? Do you need something?”

“I need a time machine,” Capella said bitterly before snapping it off and going on in a flat tone. “No. I don’t need something; I don’t need a hug or whatever. I just need to get things finished. Why are you even here if things are so bad?”

“Do you know who this Aeron character is?” Catra asked. Capella nodded. She’d learned even more since she’d been with Izzy. “Well, he’s going before the High Council of Etheria. Going to make an argument to become a princess and order us to hand

over Izzy to him. The council has ordered all princesses to be in attendance with Bright Moon to be penalized if we don't produce all of them. So I came to get Izzy and to find out what happened to you."

"So it's just politics. Again," Capella said, a slight ring of disgust in her voice.

"No, it's not," Catra said, her voice rising a little before she got it under control. "It was finding out what happened to Finn, Izzy, and you and everyone else still listed as missing from Dryl."

Capella stood up and once again starred up into the dark over her head, like she was looking for an answer in the darkness, before looking back to Catra. Then before she could say something, she looked back behind Catra in the tunnel. Catra turned to see Gress standing there. Her eyes widened to see his right arm was only partly flesh, everything from just above where the elbow had been on down was a skeletal looking prosthetic.

"You shouldn't be out of bed, buddy," Capella said and Catra heard the gentle tone in her voice, the first time she'd heard her sound like the old Capella since she'd started talking to her and watched as she dropped her illusion.

"As I have told you before, the danger is past and I am more than capable of being up and about," Gress said. "Just like I told you when I last saw you. I heard part of your conversation. Why do you blame yourself?"

Capella looked down at his arm before looking away.

"This? You didn't blast me. Half Ear did and you saved my life that day," Gress said. "Again."

"He never would have come for you if it hadn't been for me," Capella said as she looked at the ground. "And I barely remember what I did that day so I can't take credit."

Catra was watching Capella, who wasn't bothering to hide her emotions in front of Gress, and so she saw the lie on Capella's face as she said the last part.

"What do you remember?" Catra asked and she watched as Capella got her face under control before answering.

"Nothing I want to talk with you about," Capella responded.

"Fine, talk with me about it," Gress said as he walked forward past Catra. "Something happened down in that tunnel. What?" Capella looked away and Gress walked around into her field of view. "What happened? Do you feel bad about Half Ear?"

Capella gave a cold laugh as she said, "No, I was merciful to him. I let him continue to draw breath only because you still were."

“Stop that,” Gress said. “I know you’re not some cold-blooded mercenary, as much as you try and act it. Cappe, come on, talk with me.”

“I’ll just head on,” Catra said as Melog came up to circle around her feet. No one said anything as she picked up the headlamp and then looked at Gress. “Do you want this?”

“No,” Gress replied. “But thank you.”

Catra looked back and forth between the two before finally walking away. As she did, Gress pulled a small round light out of his pocket and set it on the ground as he sat down near her. It was a dim light but Capella had learned that the clones could see quite well in low light. She looked at Gress and his green eyes looked back at her.

“Cappe, come sit with me, please,” Gress said softly and patted the sand next to him. Capella hesitated and then moved over and sat down beside him, being sure she was on the left side of him. “This bothers you doesn’t it?”

Capella looked at him as he held up his right arm.

“Not like you think,” Capella replied. “It’s a reminder of how I failed you.”

Gress put his left hand on her knee as he said, “You did not fail me and I told you back in that field outside of Wheatland how I feel about you trying to act like you’re my protector.”

Capella took several deep breaths as she shoved down her sorrow before saying, “I watched them work on you when I brought you back. I had to watch them remove your arm because you were around me. You were in pain, you almost died, because of something I did.”

“I was in pain because of something Half Ear did. I guess I have to say this again. I was involved with this from the beginning. You met me because of this kind of thing. This is my fight, Cappe,” Gress said, his voice getting angry as he went on. “Why do you still not understand that? I am not a bystander to be protected and left out! I’m a spacebat and you need to stop acting like you can insulate me from the fight!”

“And you’re my friend!” Capella said. “If I can’t protect my friend what’s the point!?”

“The point is protecting everyone else just like me!” Gress said. “You think I don’t want to try and protect my caretakers or my other friends from Poview!? You think I just wanted to sit under Dryl giving out advice!? No! The only reason I did it, *the only reason,* is because you asked! Maybe if I had been out in the field with you though, things would have been different!”

“Yeah! Maybe you’d be dead now!” Capella yelled back at him.

“That’s a risk that I ran sitting in Dryl anyway!” Gress shouted back as he turned and held up his right arm. Capella grunted and looked away, shame across her face and Gress went on. “No, don’t you dare look away! Look at it! You think I’m happy to see scars on you!? You think I’m happy to see your eyes becoming hollow and far away as you become colder and colder!? I don’t but I accept it and you damn well better accept this!”

Everything was silent except for the sound of falling water before Capella finally looked back at Gress. He turned and held the arm out towards her. She shied away for a moment and he leaned forward and carefully laid it on her shoulder.

“Maybe one day I’ll have someone clone me another arm,” Gress said quietly. “Maybe I won’t. Either way you still need to know that this is not some badge of shame for me and this isn't a badge of failure for you. It’s a reminder that our enemies are serious. Do you think that during the last war that people didn’t have reservations about what they were doing? That they didn’t think they were failures?”

Capella shook her head as she slowly reached up and set her hand on Gress’ hand as it rested on her shoulder. Her voice was low and soft as she said, “Can you feel that?”

Gress nodded as he said, “It’s not the same, or at least I think it isn’t, but yeah, I feel it.”

Capella took his hand off her shoulder and held it both of her hands and then just sat there, looking down in the dim light at his hand. Neither moved. Neither knew just how long they sat like that, in the dark far beneath the surface, before Capella said, "I lied. I remember exactly what happened in that fight with Half Ear."

"I know you did," Gress said with a little smile. "Do you want to tell me?"

Capella nodded and began to speak, low and quiet.

Chapter End Notes

Getting close to the end now. Not much further to go.

The High Council of Etheria

Chapter Summary

> Things look grim as the High Council of Etheria starts into session.
>
> Note: To those reading this as it posts, there are two chapters posted before this today, one called Bright Moon and the second called Half Moon.

Chapter Notes

> "There's a darkened sky before me / There's no time to prepare / Salvage a last horizon / But no regrets from me" - No More Lies by Iron Maiden
>
> Note: No Micah, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora walked towards a large building, its many domes and spires rising above the grasslands around them. The Portal Plains was what people called the grasslands now and she remembered standing among the waving grass so many different times. Her life on Etheria had started there, though she had been an infant in Hordak's arms at the time. The first moment on the plains that she could remember was with Swift Wind trying to solve a puzzle. She also remembered standing on a miniscule piece of ground, the rest disappeared into a null void, watching Angella fly to her doom and then again years later watching Glimmer screaming as she pulled her mother out from that frozen moment of time.

Adora had come outside for a breath of air and watched the other people milling around in a little open square that was similar to many others that dotted the grounds around the building. Each person was watching her out of the corner of their eyes. Bow

walked with her in silence as they made their way to a little bench near a dry water feature in the square. Glimmer was inside arguing out the terms with the council. The High Council consisted of seven people who made the ultimate decisions for anything that came up before them. They weren't anyone of note and not much made it to them as most of the matters were handled at a lower level.

Glimmer, as queen, had a seat on the High Council to discuss matters that came before it to try and sway the seven to her point of view but the issue was that so did every other ruler of a town recognized by the Etherian Charter. Princesses however, did not sit on the council itself and were represented by Glimmer. Adora remembered hashing that out after the last war and how it had been seen as a good way to keep a good balance on the council. Of course, back then there weren't very many towns outside of kingdoms and now there were lots of them. The Council had indicated they would more than likely abide by a vote of the various members and Adora worried about how the vote would go on both issues.

"Have you heard from Catra?" Bow said as he stretched before pulling his coat in closer as a cold wind blew in across the plains to swirl around the open square.

Adora shook her head as she said, "No, I haven't heard anything since we got here. Even with the ongoing problems on the comms, I'd say that the comm system is being intentionally tampered with here."

Bow looked across the open square to a knot of people standing around. They all were glancing towards the two and every one of

them wore a shoulder badge with an image of a red flame on it. They were representatives of the various towns who were asking to be taken under Candila if Aeron won his title.

"I'm sure it's just a coincidence," Bow said in a voice Adora knew to mean he didn't mean a word of what he'd just said.

"How much longer does she have to be back with Iz?" Adora said.

"Twelve hours," Bow said with a grim look. "Twelve hours and then it's going to get ugly."

"Surely we can get an extension," Adora said. "I mean come on, it was hard enough getting P-Pear to show and we knew where she was already."

"Glimmer doesn't think they'll allow it," Bow said. "I've paid attention to those who are giving her the hardest time and who is voting which way on the rules and I think Aeron has a lot of them in his pocket."

"How did we miss this?" Adora said, not for the first time since the attack on Dryl and waved at Netossa as she walked through the courtyard towards them.

"We didn't think anyone would do something like this," Bow said. "I just can't believe the rules they've already talked the council

members into passing.”

Adora sighed as she said, “What good does no fraternization between individual towns and kingdoms do besides make this harder?”

“That’s the point,” Netossa said as she sat down beside them. “The rules determine how the game is played and the flavor of the play as well. Is it cooperative or is it cutthroat?”

Bow nodded as he said, “And this game seems to be cutthroat.”

“I’ve got the next round of rules that they’re arguing over right now,” Netossa said as she handed over copies to Adora and Bow. “I’ve made some notes for you if you can keep up.”

Adora gave a little grin as she said, “I think I can give you a run for your money.”

Netossa grinned back at her as she said, “Oh, I don’t doubt it.” Then her grin faded as she sighed. “However, the fact of the matter is that even though there’s supposed to be no fraternization between the various groups, there’s a faction on the council that is voting together and seem to be making almost identical arguments. They’re not a majority but they’re close enough not to matter. It’s not taking much to get the few extra votes they need. The worst news is anything that requires a supermajority isn’t going to happen if they’re against it.”

"That doesn't really matter," Bow said as he scanned through the papers. "Not a lot that requires that."

Netossa said, "It matters a lot. If we could do the Appeal to She-Ra, we could have Adora quash this or at least give a favorable ruling."

Adora looked down at the ground as she said, "That's not going to happen."

"I can think of a way we might be able to swing it, maybe, but…," Netossa said before Adora looked at her.

"I… I haven't told you something that I might as well tell you now," Adora said softly as her eyes flicked around. "She-Ra left me a while back. I can't call on her anymore."

Netossa sat there and her eyes blinked a few times before she said, "You're kidding me." Adora shook her head. "Adora… crap. Adora, if it gets to that vote and you can't adjudicate it… uh, I'm not even sure what happens at that point."

"At least they don't know," Bow replied. "They can't have planned for it at least."

"Let me think about it," Netossa replied. "Maybe we can work with that somehow. For now, I want to point a few things out to you."

They all began to read the paperwork at that point. An hour later, they were wrapping up and as they stood and stretched, Adora asked, "You doing alright without Spinne around?"

"I'm doing fine," Netossa replied. "That skiff relay you got set up for letters is keeping us in contact. She's grumpy that she's stuck out in the Fright Zone but happy she can help the refugees."

Adora said, "Elliepurr said something similar in her last letter to us. Said the place stank."

Netossa grinned as she said, "It does! Oh, and that reminds me, Spinne said that Ellie is having a ball. I guess some of the clones that came there for safety had little ones with them. A lot of them have taken an interest in Ellie and have basically latched onto her. She's telling them stories and teaching them songs and playing with them. Someone taught the kids the word grandma and now they're calling her Grandma Ellie."

Adora and Bow let a smile cross their faces at the thought and then they all turned their eyes skyward as they heard multiple skiffs approaching. They watched as they came in low towards a landing ground nearby and as they passed over, Adora suddenly heard Bow gasp and then began running as fast as he could towards the landing field. Adora didn't bother to ask, she just took off right on his heels. She heard Netossa fall in behind her and the three went racing along the broad path. Bow's long coat trailed

out behind him as he ran and soon they were coming up on the landing field and a group of guards stood in their way. Bow tried to go through them and several pushed him backwards.

"Cappe!" Bow screamed towards the group of skiffs that had landed. Adora saw Capella climbing down with Gress and several others. Capella's head snapped up and she saw Bow standing behind the guards.

"Your Majesty, that is the Dryl contingent and you are not allowed near them as you well know," one of the guards said. The look that flashed onto Bow's face had Adora moving quickly to get between him and the guard.

"We understand," Adora said quickly. "It's just… well, that's his daughter. He's been very worried about her."

"We're moving to apprehend her now. You may be able to speak with her later," the guard said and sure enough Adora saw a group of guards moving towards Capella. Capella saw them coming and her hand dropped to the dagger at her side. Then Adora watched Izzy stride over to the guards with her hand up and saying something she couldn't quite make out.

"Get out of my way," Bow said in a tone that sent a shiver up Adora's spine.

"Bow…," Adora started to say.

"Adora, get out of my way *now,"* Bow said and then they all saw the guards stop as an argument started between them and Izzy.

"Could you go find out what's going on, please?" Netossa said to the guard as she carefully put a hand on Bow's shoulder. "We'll stay right here."

There was a quick conference between the guards blocking them before one of them walked over to find out what was happening.

"Tossa…," Bow started to say and it was Netossa's turn to cut him off.

"Bow, take a moment. You're almost there, don't blow it in the endgame," Netossa said and Bow took a deep breath, his hands shaking as he looked at Capella before nodding. A few minutes passed before the guard came back.

"OK, we can't arrest her. Princess Izzy has claimed her as a member of her contingent and so she's covered by the immunity the rest have but that means you can not speak to her," the guard said. Bow started to step forward anyway when Capella looked him straight in the eye from where she stood and held up her hand, half in a stop gesture and half in a little wave before she dropped an illusion over her face, shouldered her bags and followed the rest of the group as they started walking. Several guards flanked Catra as they separated her from the group and started walking her towards Adora, Bow, and Netossa.

Bow stood there, tears streaming down his face, a half smile on his face as he said, “I told you she wasn’t dead. I told you it wasn’t true.”

Adora threw her arms around her friend and hugged him tight as she said through her own tears, “You did and you were right.”

As Catra joined the group, the four put their arms around each other and watched the group from Dryl walk away. Adora saw Finn and felt tension she wasn’t even aware of drain away. Once they were out of sight, they made their way to the temporary buildings on one side of the building that Hordies had put up for the various groups. Once inside, Catra made her way to the sink and got a big glass of water and then carefully sat down at the table.

“So they were in Half-Moon after all,” Adora said. Catra took a long drink of water before nodding.

“They were, right in the main cavern. I owe Izzy a thank you; she had an honor guard on the tomb,” Catra said before taking another sip. “That’s not what you all need to hear. Bow, Cappe said she had been making plans to speak with you and Glimmer but with whatever this stupid rule is, it might take a bit but take heart. I think she’s almost ready.”

Bow took a deep shuddering breath as he said, “I’m just glad she’s alright. Do you know what happened?”

“She said she cut herself off from the Moonstone because she was being tracked,” Catra said. “That’s not completely paranoid either. Entrapta figured out how to track Glimmer’s teleporting back in the war and maybe someone else figured it out for Cappe. I don’t know.” Catra paused before going on. “Also, I don’t know how close you could see her but you need to be ready. She’s pretty beat up. She’s got wounds of various ages on her and how she acts… it’s not the same Cappe. The stories are probably pretty true. She’s been through the ringer.”

“I don’t care,” Bow said as he wrung his hands as tears ran past the huge smile on his face. “She said she wants to possibly talk. *She’s alive!”*

“She is,” Catra said with a tired smile. “Listen, I’ve been on a skiff for a long time and I’ve got to take a quick rest and then I’ll fill you in on the rest. Deal?”

Bow got up off the couch and walked over to Catra where he leaned down and hugged her.

“I owe you more than I can ever repay you,” he whispered to her.

“You don’t owe me a thing,” Catra said back to him. “I’m just glad we found her finally.”

Glimmer came in a little while later while Catra was back in one of the small bedrooms.

"Is it true? Is Cappe really here?" she said as she went over to Bow. Bow stood up to meet her and caught her in a hug.

"It's true. Catra's seen and talked with her," Bow replied. "She wants to maybe talk with us."

Glimmer hugged him back, tears running down her face, as she tried to say something and finally just gave up with a little happy laugh. The laughter was short lived though as several hours later the meeting of the High Council of Etheria finally got into session. The room they had come to was round with comfortable seats on raised platforms going away from a central open section of floor. Hasty last minute barriers had been put in place between various sections to keep each group from talking to another next to them while still allowing a clear view of the open floor. A small circular table sat in the center of the floor where the council sat with a small podium near it for people to speak from.

Each group filed in, all the princesses off to the side and each in their own little section as they could observe but not participate, and got seated without much comment. Then the room went quiet as the contingent from Dryl, last to be seated before the council, walked to their section. Bow and Glimmer watched as Capella walked across the room with the group and noted how she carefully looked at everyone. They all recognized the look of someone making an assessment of risk of both the setting and the people in it. Everyone in the room had been disarmed and searched before they were allowed to enter but as Catra had said

before they were entered, that didn't matter much to someone who was determined.

Finally the council walked in, seven people dressed in various states from high fashion to casual, and sat down at the table. The chairperson, a sea elf from the town of Seaweed named Sireet, walked over to the podium and rapped it with a gavel.

"This session of the High Council of Etheria is called to order. We will hear two separate petitions, both from Aeron of Candila, and decide courses of action for both. The first petition is his request to have his title as Princess of Candila recognized by the Princess Council. The second is to have a decision as to what shall be done with Princess of Izzy of Dryl as she has been alleged to have assaulted him. No other business will be discussed," Sireet said slowly. She looked down at her notes for a moment before continuing. "You should all have copies of the rules that have been determined in the meetings over the last several days. They have all been agreed upon by a majority of the representatives of the sovereign groups present. The Council has agreed simply to be an arbiter of the process and will give approval to any final decisions that are made as a group. We shall begin now with the first issue, the title of the Princess of Candila."

The next few hours dragged past as arguments began. Netossa had put together the case against the issue for the Princess Council and argued against Carl, who was representing Aeron. It became obvious really quickly that Carl and Aeron had done their work well and Netossa was simply arguing minor points. Bow sighed as he sat back in his chair as Netossa went over another point, pointing at the holographic screen that floated over the floor for all to see. She'd warned them before they'd even entered the room that they didn't have a case against it but that she'd do

her best to stall for as long as possible. Finally, late into the evening, Sireet called for a halt to the proceedings.

"I call for a recess for eight hours," Sireet said. "As it seems that the Princess Council is only arguing minor points of the petition, I'll move that we dispense with additional discussion and move to closing arguments for this point first thing when we convene. Do I have a second?" Another councilmember seconded it with one hand while hiding a yawn with the other. "Make your votes known."

Everyone watched as the votes were tallied by a data pad system and while it was narrow, it was decided to close discussion and move to a vote. Sireet put the group into recess and each group were again allowed to leave one at a time.

Back in their temporary building, Glimmer paced the floor as Netossa griped.

"Damn it! I could have drawn that out longer! I think I could have even have swayed a few more people our way," Netossa said. "I won't swear Sireet is being influenced but I wouldn't swear against it either."

Catra yawned from where she was sprawled out on the floor as she said, "Let's be honest, we've all read his original petition. It was pretty airtight. If it hadn't been him we probably would have accepted it almost immediately."

“That doesn’t mean I want to give up on the argument!” Netossa replied.

“Don’t worry about it,” Bow said with a sigh. “Give the best opening statement you can but focus on the defense for Izzy for now. I think she is going to end up in rehabilitation but we need to make sure it’s not under Aeron.”

Netossa grumbled as she sat down at a table and put her head down. Her voice was muffled as she said, “And eight hours… I swear, this is stacked against us.”

“I’ve noticed,” Glimmer said as she continued to pace. “Did you see the list of the votes? This is turned against us and since our vote only counts once and each princess can’t vote individually, we’ve got an issue with that one voting bloc.”

Adora came out of the back and sat down on the floor by Catra as she said, “That seemed like a good idea when we put it in back in the day.”

“It wasn’t then,” Netossa replied, “but after the whole chipped princess thing, the fear was there and it didn’t seem like that big a deal. Besides, who would have thought it’d go this long without being amended?”

“And when I tried to at least get Izzy a vote, they shot it down,” Glimmer said with a sigh. They all went quiet as they heard a

quiet knock on the door. Bow got up and opened it up to see two guards of the High Council standing there.

"Can I help you?" Bow said in confusion.

One of them replied, "Yes, I've been told to tell Princess Catra that her skiff has been repaired."

Catra sat up off the floor as she said, "Let them in Bow and shut the door."

Bow looked at her in confusion and then stepped aside as the two guards walked in. Bow shut the door and then everyone but Catra jumped as Double Trouble turned back to their regular form.

"Amateur," the other guard said.

"Oh, hush," Double Trouble replied with a grin. "Blu here thinks they're hot stuff."

"I am," Blu's voice said, coming out of the guard's mouth. "Certainly better at this than you."

Catra shook her head as she said, "Blu, go ahead and change please."

Blu shifted into her default form as well as she said, “It’s not good to get used to shifting back and forth while working.”

“It’s not a problem at all,” Double Trouble replied before giving Blu a long look. “Unless you’re a hack.”

“Oh, Mara, there’s two of them,” Netossa said with a laugh. As she said Mara, everyone noticed that Blu seemed to move backwards a little before standing still.

“Catra, I assume this is your doing,” Glimmer said.

“Yep,” Catra replied. “Figured we needed our own communications since we can’t get the data pads working right. Whatta you two have for me?”

Both Double Trouble and Blu started to talk at the same time before they stopped and glared at each other.

“Sorry, I should let my elder speak first,” Blu said with a little smile.

“Oh, I’d say beauty over age but I’ve got you there as well,” Double Trouble said with a smile of their own back.

“I will separate you both,” Adora said with a groan. “Just tell us.”

The two looked at each other and finally Blu just nodded at Double Trouble.

“Izzy has said to not bother fighting too hard on the first point,” Double Trouble said. “The second one she says you should put up a fight for it but not so much that you cross a line. She says she understands she crossed a line and needs to do the rehabilitation but just make sure it’s not with Aeron. Oh, and she said she’d pay me extra but that you should cover it and she’ll pay you back.”

Catra snorted as she said, “Tell you what, I’ll wait until I can confirm it with her.”

“You don’t trust me? After all these years?” Double Trouble responded.

“No,” Catra and Adora both responded. Double Trouble grinned back and was about to say something when Blu started talking.

“Focus. You can get paid when the job is finished,” Blu said with a roll of her eyes. “Izzy did tell me that under no circumstance should you try and use the Appeal to She-Ra. She didn’t say why but she said you’d understand.”

“Oooo, that sounds juicy. Blondie, care to elaborate?” Double Trouble said as they turned towards Adora.

“No, I don’t,” Adora said in a flat tone of voice. Double Trouble and Blu gave a few more reports before Glimmer and Netossa gave them some information to pass on. They transformed back to guards and went out after not much longer. The five went and got some rest but were up a few hours later in the early morning hours. Blu came by and gave them some more information before leaving again.

“What if the High Council figures out what we’re doing?” Catra said after the door shut.

Glimmer leaned against a counter as she said, “I don’t care at this point. I think we’re out of luck on this one but we still need information to try and minimize damage.”

Adora and Catra looked at each for a long moment in silent conference before Adora turned to Glimmer.

“Catra and I have already discussed this. I think now is the time to tell you. If they decide to turn Izzy over to him… we’re not letting it happen,” Adora said, shifting in her seat a little. “We’ll be leaving and taking Iz with us.”

“We’re helping you then,” Bow said.

“No, you can’t,” Catra replied. “If we do it alone, we’re the in-laws saving their child's partner and you can label us as renegades. If you’re involved then it’s Bright Moon spitting on the Etherian Charter.”

“You think we’re just going to sit back and watch?” Glimmer said.

“I think your option is to give them help under the table while still blasting them in public for disregarding the process,” Netossa replied.

“Where would you even go?” Bow asked.

“We can make it off planet if needed,” Adora said, thinking of Mara’s old ship.

“Or just disappear into the shady side,” Catra said. “We’ve got options.”

“No, if it comes to that then it’ll be an open break,” Glimmer said as she thumped her hand onto the counter. “I’m tired of this shadowy bull.”

“This isn’t the war. We can’t just act and do whatever without a lot of thought,” Catra said. “If you back us, you know you’re

pulling the people of the kingdom of Bright Moon into it as well, right?"

Glimmer's eyes burned bright for a moment before she sagged a little and covered her eyes with one hand.

"I hate this," she muttered. "I hate all of this." Bow put an arm around her as she took her hand off her eyes and looked at the two. "Are you sure about this?"

"He can't have her," Catra said, her tail flicking a little.

"When was the last time either one of you was even in a fight?" Bow said. Adora nervously ran her hand through her hair, blonde streaked through with lighter white and Catra responded.

"Back when we had to go and rescue Finn and the kids when they were looking for Finn's biological parents," Catra said.

"That was ten years ago at least," Glimmer said. "And you had help."

"What's your plan at least?" Netossa asked.

Catra and Adora took hold of each other's hand as Adora said, "It's best if none of you know I think."

Bow wiped at a tear as he said, "You think we want to lose you as well?"

"Listen, I'll say this. If it goes right, there won't even be a fight," Catra said.

"And our plans always went so well," Glimmer said with a humorless laugh.

"Listen, we've got to get going," Netossa said as she looked at a clock. "The session starts soon. You two, rethink this. There's other ways than whatever it is you've planned out, I'm sure, that don't involve abandoning Izzy."

The five stood looking at each other and then finally started moving without meeting each other's eyes.

Back in the session, the closing arguments for the first point didn't last long. The Council put a time limit on each at the last second and while Netossa tried her best, after it was all said and done the vote finally came.

"The question now is whether Aeron of Candila will be confirmed as Princess of Candila and the Princess Council be required to seat

him as an equal member according to their rules. Make your votes known," Sireet said as the overhead holographic display came up and a countdown clock began.

Almost all eyes were on Aeron as the votes tallied on the overhead holographic display. At first it looked as if the vote would go towards rejecting the question but at the last moment, a large block of votes came in almost at once and flipped it over the threshold.

"The question is approved. The High Council accepts the vote and rules that Aeron of Candila is henceforth princess. Princess Aeron, you are a full member of the Princess Council," Sireet said before looking at Glimmer. "Queen Glimmer, I expect him to be brought up to speed without delay."

Izzy watched Aeron hug Carl tight as people in his little group patted them on the back. She watched as Snow-by stood back, a grin plastered on his face, and thought again about how to get in contact with him. She supposed if the next vote went against her, she might be able to ask him directly. She vaguely wondered again if he'd betrayed her but she doubted it. If he had, more things would have gone wrong than they already had. She had to keep trusting.

Several groups shouted out at Aeron, angry at the vote, while others applauded for him but the princesses around the room stayed quiet. Izzy felt Finn's hand on her leg, trembling. Capella sat behind her, her eyes locked on a blonde woman she'd called Iceson the night before that stood beside Aeron. Capella had stayed still and quiet through the whole thing while Gress had

kept muttering under his breath at various points during the proceedings.

"I can't believe this," Finn said in disgust. "I can't believe they'd approve him."

"Princess isn't a title that automatically grants nobility and honor," Izzy said to them. "It's just a title. The person gives it nobility and honor."

Finn looked at Izzy, her face so still they wondered for a brief moment if Capella had put an illusion over it. Then the room quieted down as Sireet brought the room back to order.

"We shall now hear petition two. There are two points to this petition. First point, whether or not Princess Izzy is guilty of attacking Princess Aeron without cause. Second point, whether she should be turned over to him for her rehabilitation," Sireet said. She was about to go on when Izzy stood and stepped up to the railing separating the little section they were in from the open floor.

"I would like to make a statement," she said, her voice carrying around the room.

"Your argument will be made by Queen Glimmer," Sireet said, looking down her nose at Izzy.

"I do not want an argument. I do not contest any part of the first part of the first point. I did attack Aeron and should go to rehabilitation. I ask the High Council to skip debate on that and rule to hand me to Bright Moon for rehabilitation as would be normal as Aeron was not yet a princess when the attack happened," Izzy said.

Carl stepped up to the podium and said, "Speaking on behalf of my husband, we agree to forgo debate on the first point and accept Princess Izzy's statement. We will not however agree to allow her to serve her rehabilitation at Bright Moon. The Charter and the Princess Council's own rules are quite clear on the matter and the fact that the attack was probably a forestalling action to keep Princess Aeron from claiming his rightful title should be taken into consideration. "

Sireet nodded as she looked down at a data pad and then back at Izzy.

"As it is not contested, we agree to accept your admittance on the first point, Princess Izzy. However, it is obvious the second point is contested and we will now move to discussion of where rehabilitation will take place," Sireet said before turning to Carl. "Carl of Candila, you may begin."

The argument raged back and forth between Carl and Netossa over the hours. Netossa made points from Etherian law, including the charter and Bright Moon's laws, showing that rehabilitation normally took place inside the kingdom where the offense occurred unless the ruler agreed to waive it. Carl pointed out the

dragging of the feet that the Princess Council had shown was proof that Bright Moon had no intentions of holding Izzy accountable and that even if Aeron wasn't a princess when it happened, he was now and so would be able to handle it himself. Back and forth it went, and Izzy watched the crowd and she could see it was pointless.

Behind Glimmer, Adora was so tense she felt like her shoulders were stone. Catra sat still, her ears half flattened back and her tail flicking back and forth. They both held each other's hand and as it went on, they both exchanged glances, mentally preparing themselves.

Finally, late into the afternoon, Sireet stepped in.

"I believe that both sides have made excellent points. I move to end debate and go to a vote," Sireet said. One of the other council members seconded it. "Vote now on whether Princess Izzy shall be remanded to Bright Moon or to Princess Aeron for rehabilitation."

Where previous votes had taken a little bit to come in, this time a huge block came in almost immediately.

"No," Finn whispered, clenching Izzy's hand tightly as they saw the votes already over the threshold in favor of sending her to Aeron.

“It’s alright,” Izzy said, her face even but her voice tight. “We’ll figure something out.”

She wasn’t looking at Finn though, she was looking at Aeron, his face set in a satisfied smile as he stared across the room at her. She remembered seeing that smile in her nightmares after he’d tried to kill her when she got the title of Dryl and her mind was in overdrive as Harpi leaned over her shoulder.

“Brother Izzy,” he said very quietly. “Do not worry. We will not let him take you.”

Izzy broke eye contact with Aeron and turned to look at him.

“Don’t do anything like that,” Izzy said. “You let this happen. I want you to help Brother Ertu and the rest run Dryl while I’m away. You can’t do that if you get involved in some half-cocked plan to save me.”

“I can assure you that the plan is not half-cocked and your brothers are not giving you a decision in this matter,” Gress said as he stepped up beside her as well and put a hand on her shoulder. “You once said you were with us even if the whole world was against us. Well, we’re with you even though the whole world is against you.”

Izzy started to say something but choked back her words as she found the lump in her throat wouldn’t let her say anything. The

last vote finally came in and the vote was sealed. Izzy was sentenced to be sent to Candila.

Several delegations that had voted in line with the princesses were on their feet shouting about how the whole thing was a travesty which prompted others who'd voted in line with Aeron to get to their feet and start shouting back. Sireet started pounding on the podium with the gavel as the High Council guards came into the room and started towards Izzy. Ertu stood up and moved up beside Harpi and Gress as did Capella. Finn hugged Izzy tight as they whispered something to her, fast and desperate. Catra and Adora looked at each other, squeezed the other's hand and took a deep breath as they got to their feet.

Then one voice finally managed to be heard. The representative from Wheatland was shouting, "Appeal to She-Ra! I invoke the Appeal to She-Ra!"

Aeron's smile got wider. Wheatland had voted in line with the princesses but this played right into what he needed. He heard others from the groups he controlled take up the shout just as he'd instructed them to do. He'd gauged how people were talking and voting. It took a supermajority to invoke the clause but he knew everyone on his side would vote for it and he was pretty sure that the opposing side would vote for it as well. Then they would expect She-Ra to make a ruling but there was no She-Ra.

He could see in his mind's eye what would happen next. Without her, he could demand Izzy, he'd have his crown, the system which was already twisted and tied up would falter even more, and then, as they tried to decide how to handle it, he could move forward with the rest. He'd have the chaos and indecision he needed to

drive the clones from the planet, the ones who survived at least, and be able to make sure they never returned. He and Izzy went back to staring at each other across the room as the shouting went on. He was ready.

"I agree! I call for She-Ra!" Aeron shouted out. "Let her guide us! Let us vote!"

Finally, Sireet managed to get the room quieted down and the voting began. Netossa quickly spoke with everyone in her little area before finally advising Glimmer to vote in favor. Izzy wasn't sure what to do until Gress leaned over and quietly advised her to vote in favor. The rest of the votes finally came in and everyone looked at the tally as the room went quiet. In the end, it was close but there were enough to require She-Ra to appear and make a decision.

Almost every eye in the room turned to look at Adora and saw Catra standing behind her with her hands on Adora's shoulder. Adora finally stood up, her face angry and sad, as she said, "She's not with me anymore. She hasn't been for some time, Mystacor can confirm this. I can't… I can't do what you're asking of me."

The quiet in the room seemed complete as everyone tried to process what was being said. Murmurs started up as Aeron stood up and approached the railing to say something. Then the murmurs got louder as Capella made her way to the front of the area for Dryl and stopped at the railing. She looked across at her parents first and tried to apologize for everything that had happened with her eyes, before she looked at Aeron and spoke in a quiet, level voice that still seemed to fill the space.

“For the honor of Grayskull.”

There was a flash of light and Capella suddenly loomed over everyone around her. As she reached her hand out to the side the Sword of Protection, shaped like her mother’s battle axe, flashed into it. Her hair appeared again and flowed out from her head, long and curly and throwing off purple and pink sparkles as it did. Her clothes were reminiscent of how she dressed in the Waste, heavy canvas but a soft cream color with a large purple heart in the center of her jacket. A copy of her mother’s crown sat on her head with a little half-moon shape at the apex while her boots showed the symbol of Dryl on them. Her eyes though, her eyes were the most striking. They were slightly larger now with no pupils and a brilliant green color. Capella slammed the pole of the axe into the ground so hard it was a shock it didn’t crack the floor as she looked directly at Aeron and spoke.

“I believe you asked for my assistance?”

Chapter End Notes

Well, whatta know? :)

The Heir

Chapter Summary

The Call to She-Ra has been made... and answered.

Chapter Notes

"In every loss in every lie / In every truth that you'd deny / And each regret and each goodbye / Was a mistake too great to hide / And your voice was all I heard / That I get what I deserve" - New Divide by Linkin Park

Note: Brief mention of Micah but nothing detailed, no summary

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The room was silent for a split second before exploding into the sounds of cheering, angry screaming and shouting, and over it all Gress could be heard laughing and laughing and laughing.

“This is a trick!” Aeron screamed, his voice carrying over the crowd. He pointed at Glimmer and screamed, “We all know you’re a sorcerer! This is an illusion! I saw her look at you before she looked like this!”

Gress shot to the rail beside Capella, pointed at Aeron with his metal hand, and shouted back, “You call for She-Ra, you want her help, and then when she appears you say it’s a trick? Why are you trying to get out of it now? She’s here to make a decision, just like you wanted!”

“She’s not even a princess anymore! She abdicated! She’s wanted in multiple towns and kingdoms! What is she even doing here!?” Aeron shouted back.

“I carry the mantle of She-Ra,” Capella said, her voice conversational in tone. “Do you deny my right under the Charter to do what you asked of me?”

As she spoke, Capella shifted her axe into both hands and the whole room went silent like someone had flicked a switch. Everyone knew what Adora could do as She-Ra, they knew what Glimmer was like in a fight, they knew how brilliant Bow was, and they’d all heard stories of Capella by now and realized all of that stood before them in one towering person. This led to a sudden rush as people started clearing out from behind and to the side of Aeron and Carl.

“I deny that you’re She-Ra,” Aeron said, not seeming to notice the people running away from him as he tried to stare her down. “I know Adora lost She-Ra. Convenient that suddenly she’s settled on the likes of you.”

Capella grabbed the railing in front of her and pulled it and the columns supporting it loose from their moorings like she was plucking a flower, stepped out onto the floor separating them, and advanced on Aeron as she tossed five feet of railing and columns to the side like a piece of paper.

“Oh, so you called on She-Ra, thinking she wouldn’t show up then. What was your plan when she didn’t? What did you plan to

do when she didn’t show? War? More suffering than you’ve already caused? Did you plan to take over Etheria to try and be the next Prime?” Capella said as she stopped at just the right distance for a swift axe strike and turned to look at Carl who was starting to cower backwards. “Come on Carl, you’re obviously his advisor. Please, advise the would be Prime.”

Aeron’s face went red as she called him Prime. Carl was about to say something when Aeron shouted back, “I would free this world and its rightful inhabitants from those filthy abominations who infect it!” He slammed his fists into the railing as he screamed even louder. “Mara was right!”

The axe fell like a meteor and split the railing directly between Aeron’s hands and buried itself in the floor in front of his toes.

“Don’t you *ever* let her name pass your lips again!” Capella screamed back. “Don’t you *ever* try to assign your sick beliefs to her again! Speak her name and it won’t be the railing that gets split!”

Aeron looked her dead in the eye and took a deep breath.

“Mara was right,” he said quietly, his eyes glittering with malice.

Capella drew the axe back again in a flash, when Gress shouted, “Cappe! Don’t!”

Capella held the weapon over her head and she could feel the power coursing through her. She knew the axe would fall and not even be slowed by his body. She could feel how easy it would be but still, she didn't move. She heard Gress coming up behind her as she looked into Aeron's eyes, the axe held steady over her head.

"Don't do it, Cappe," Gress said. "Don't put that on yourself."

"Mara was right," Aeron said with a sneer at her, seeing her faltering.

Gress didn't even look at Aeron as he moved in front of Capella. He reached up with his metal hand and cupped the side of Capella's cheek.

"Don't, please," Gress said as he looked into her eyes. Capella looked down at Gress, his eyes looking back at her, so different from Aeron's eyes, full of concern and love instead of hate, and she sighed as she carefully brought the axe down to her side.

Aeron laughed as he said, "And that's why I'll still win."

At that, Gress spun around and punched Aeron as hard as he could. Cappella heard the cracking of Aeron's nose as it broke under Gress' metal fist and he fell backwards screaming as Carl

dropped to the ground as he scuttled away trying to put his hands over his head as he did so.

Gress looked down at Aeron as he said, "Fuck you, I didn't stop her for you. I stopped her for herself."

Aeron reached into his suit jacket and his hand was closing on the weapon he'd hidden when there was a flash in front of Capella. Glimmer was suddenly standing between Capella and Aeron, a ball of light growing larger in one hand while a complicated sigil that flashed a deep purple and black was held in the other.

"Absolutely not," Glimmer growled out.

Capella could hear the rush of people coming up behind her to support her and saw Izzy come up beside her with her fists balled up. Bow came up on the other side of her with a thick roll of paper held with lethal intent as several varieties of vines crept over the railing, and all of it was suddenly lit by a flicker of red lightning. She could hear the rumble of water held back as well as a cold breeze blowing past and she knew that her friends and family were standing with her, no matter how they felt about her personally at the moment.

"You'd attack a sovereign princess? That's a declaration of war you know," Aeron said with a grin, his face coated in blood from his broken nose.

"I will burn you from this world, leave nothing but melted concrete where you sit and do the same to anyone who tries to stop me and whoever is left is more than welcome to declare war against me but *you will not hurt my daughter!"* Glimmer said, finishing it in a scream.

Aeron slowly pulled his hand from his jacket as he tried to give a little snide smile at Glimmer that never quite managed to happen.

"I ask the High Council to take note of this," Carl said from where he'd backed up against the wall separating the sections. "The Kingdom of Candila does not recognize this person who claims to be She-Ra or the people trying to get us to accept it by force!"

Capella looked at Carl and then turned around. That was when she realized the council guards were surrounding the little group that was backing her up. She almost smiled as she saw Finn at the back arguing with the guard captain. She looked at her mother and father for a moment, rested a hand on Gress' shoulder for a split second, and then took a deep breath as she started walking forward, not letting her eyes stray from the guard captain as she advanced on her until she was standing directly in front of her. Finn turned around to see Capella looming over them.

"Hey, Cappe," Finn said with a grin.

"Finn," she said with a little nod before looking at the captain. "I am going to go speak with Sireet to make my decision as is my right under the Etherian Charter. Are you going to impede me?"

“It remains to be seen if you have that right,” the guard captain said stubbornly.

Capella leaned forward until her eyes were level with the captain’s eyes.

“Then I suggest that you please get out of my way right now so I can go and find out.”

The captain looked at Capella before nodding as she said, “Alright, but you need to get everyone to return to their sections.”

Capella turned to Finn as she said in her most formal voice, “Princess Finn, can I leave you in charge of that?”

Finn started laughing as they said, “Of course!”

Capella stepped forward as the guard captain stood aside. Capella made her way to the table in the center of the room where Sireet and the rest of the High Council were standing. She took notice of some people, the ones who’d fled from the around and behind Aeron, forming a little crowd back behind them.

“I am Capella and I carry the mantle of She-Ra. What is it you require to prove this?” Capella said as she stood in front of them.

Sireet held her hands out in front of her as she shrugged her shoulders in confusion. She said, "It was always assumed that there would be some formal recognition before it ever came to this."

Capella nodded as she looked over and saw that the princesses were returning to their sections as Finn continued to argue with the guard captain about something. Capella assumed they were arguing on general principle at that point. Capella turned back to Sireet as Capella responded, "It is something to consider correcting in the Charter later. For now, this is too important to let wait. What would satisfy you?"

"No! We will not accept any judgment handed down from her!" Carl shouted as he came hobbling out on a cane.

Gress shouted from where he was standing in front of Dryl's section, "You've accepted everything else the High Council has done! So have we! Now that it goes against you, you won't take it!?"

"Those weren't blatant tricks!" Carl shouted back at Gress.

Sireet stepped around Capella as she said to Carl, "I do not like how the last few minutes have gone but it is obvious those you brought petitions against were accepting how the proceedings were going. Further, it's obvious that they were intending to adhere to the decisions even though they were going against

them.” Capella couldn’t help but notice Catra and Adora clearing their throat as they looked at the ground or Gress and Harpi’s faces suddenly going stone still as Sireet went on. “Now I expect you to do the same, especially since you are the ones who called this council into session.”

Carl turned to look at Aeron who made a furious gesture at him with one hand while he held a rag to his nose that Iceson had come over to give him.

“What proof are you going to require?” Carl said, as he turned back to Sireet.

One of the other council members stepped forward as they said to Sireet, “We can ask the sorcerers of Mystacor. We can also ask for others who have seen She-Ra before if this seems accurate.”

“The words of those fooled by this illusion mean nothing to us and we certainly won’t accept any word from Mystacor,” Carl said. “Their leader is the Queen’s aunt and is hardly impartial and any sorcerer she produces will be biased by her.”

Sireet looked at Carl long and hard for a moment before turning back to the council and pulling them to the side for a moment. After a minute’s whispered conversation, Sireet turned back around.

“We have come to a decision,” Sireet replied. “As we are the High Council of Etheria, we determine the functioning of our council. In this regard, we have decided that we will not require outside verification. We seven shall decide as we are considered impartial as described in the Charter. We shall begin a voice vote now. I vote she is She-Ra.” Carl and Aeron both started to shout and Sireet chopped her hand down. “No! You will not interrupt this vote! Guards, compel their silence if they interrupt again.”

Capella managed to keep a straight face but she could see that Izzy was doing nothing of the sort.

“I say she is She-Ra,” another council member said.

“I say she is She-Ra,” another spoke and so it went, each one speaking loudly and clearly with no dissent.

“The vote is unanimous and we recognize that She-Ra is here as requested by the vote of those present. That includes you,” Sireet said, looking at Carl and Aeron before turning to Capella. “She-Ra, we have a decision to be made and we turn it over to you to make. Princess Izzy of Dryl has said she attacked Princess Aeron of Candila. She is to attend rehabilitation. Where shall she attend it?”

Capella almost spoke out and said that Izzy had already finished it or that she didn’t need it or to just give it to Bright Moon but she stopped. She took a moment and looked around at the faces of people staring at her, all of them wondering what she was going to do. She could hear Carl and Aeron arguing with each other and

the guards between them and the rest of the group. She looked at her parents and in that moment she knew she'd made mistake after mistake and now wasn't the time to make another. While she now understood what Catra had said back in Half Moon was correct, that the attacks weren't her fault, she knew she had the power to make things worse now and that it would be her fault if she did so.

"Please give me a moment to consider this question," Capella said and then stood for a few minutes staring at the floor in thought as the murmurs in the room grew. When she looked up, the room went silent again.

"As She-Ra, it is my decree that Princess Izzy of Dryl will not attend her rehabilitation in Bright Moon but neither shall she attend it in Candila," Capella said. She then thought how to phrase the next bit for a split second before continuing. "As Princess Scorpia of the Fright Zone has long been a neutral arbiter between kingdoms, as shown in her involvement in the peace accords for Cowrie's War, I send Princess Izzy to her to for her rehabilitation."

Aeron and Carl both started shouting for a moment before the guards loomed over them again and they both went quiet as Sireet nodded.

"Thank you, She-Ra," Sireet said. "The council accepts your guidance as required under the Etherian Charter and we announce this satisfies all petitions as presented. We now consider these proceedings closed. May peace reign over all Etheria."

Carl and Aeron left immediately with their crowd, shouting that things weren't finished. Several other groups went out immediately as well while others mingled together, no longer restrained, to talk with friends or allies. Capella returned to her regular form as she walked over towards the Dryl contingent only to be intercepted by Gress racing across the floor towards her and catching her in a huge hug.

"You did great," he whispered to her.

"I just tried to do what we discussed at Half Moon when I told you I had her mantle," Capella whispered back.

"You still did great," Gress said with another hug.

Capella looked back at her parents. Glimmer had her arm around Bow, looking at Capella across the open room but not moving. Capella wanted to walk forward but she couldn't bring herself to do it.

"Go on," Gress said to her. "I know they'd be thrilled to speak with you."

"Not yet," she said before giving a tired smile and a wave at them both before turning away.

# # #

That evening, Bow and Glimmer stood hand in hand outside a small conference room inside the High Council's building. Catra stood behind them both, her hands on their shoulders in comfort. They all looked up as a door opened and Adora walked out with a smile on her face.

"Izzy says she's ready and to go on in," Adora replied. "We'll be out here waiting."

The four hugged, neither Bow nor Glimmer able to find words, before the two walked into the empty room. Inside the room, the holographic display against the wall was shut off, the small crystal of its projection apparatus the only feature on the blank wall. The center of the room held a round table with comfortable chairs surrounding it. They barely noticed any of that because they were focused on the only other door, across the room from where they'd come in.

It was opening as Capella walked in at about the same time. They let the doors shut and the three looked at each other. It was like Catra had told them before, this wasn't the same Capella they remembered. They could feel the wariness coming off of her as her left hand kept coming to rest on her hip where her dagger would normally sit and her eyes kept flicking back and forth between them and the rest of the room. She wore heavy canvas pants and boots and a sleeveless shirt and so they could see the little cuts and scratches on her face as well more on her arms alongside the big scar that ran up her left arm and the healing burn on her head. It took all their self-control not to go and hug her as tight as they could.

“Hello,” Capella quietly said.

“Hello,” Glimmer said with a smile as tears formed in her eyes. Bow stood behind Glimmer and hugged her close as he gave a little wave, unable to speak.

Silence fell again.

“I’m… I guess we can sit down,” Capella finally replied back as she slowly stepped forward and pulled a chair away from the round table and brought it back to a wall where she could see both doors. Glimmer and Bow both nodded and moved to sit down at the table.

“I don’t know what to say,” Bow said as he got settled.

Capella shrugged with as much nonchalance as she could manage as she said, “Say what you feel like you need to say.”

She immediately flinched a little inwardly as she realized how she sounded but didn’t move to say anything more. She watched as her parents looked at each other for a moment before Glimmer spoke up.

"I'm honestly terrified of saying the wrong thing and driving you away. I think Bow feels the same way," Glimmer said. "I'm glad you're here though. We love you and miss you."

Bow nodded as he held Glimmer's hand and Capella started to say something glib but cut herself off and took a deep breath as she told herself not to make a mistake here.

"I… I missed you too," Capella said as she looked down for a moment before looking back up. "I need to know what happened though. I've been scared for so long and I've been running and… I don't know. Some days it's clear as can be that I needed to speak with you and others it was so obvious I shouldn't. I guess what I'm trying to say is, say what you need to say, I'm not going anywhere at the moment."

Bow leaned forward as he said, "Are you ok? That burn…"

He trailed off as Capella started to reach up to touch it and then stopped herself with a little tired laugh.

"It hurts but not like it has. Probably not going to have hair grow there anymore without some kind of transplant. I imagine you probably got questions about all of this too," Capella said as she waved at her arm.

"We've got questions about so much," Glimmer said and her voice was in a monotone as she raised an eyebrow. Capella looked

across at her and gave a little smile as she realized her mother was trying to be disarming.

"Yeah, so do I when it comes down to it," she said. "Dad, the burn is from the fighting in Dryl. I don't know what you know but I got it when one of the attackers deployed a flamethrower in the tunnels. I got lucky…"

Capella trailed off as she remembered teleporting wounded back from the fighting and catching the splash back from the flaming liquid. The clone she had been pulling back hadn't been so lucky. She shook her head as she closed her eyes for a moment as the memory of that moment shoved forward and clenched her hands tight as she fought to clear the horrific image from her mind. His name came about halfway through the evening litany before dinner and her voice caught every time she said it.

"I got lucky," Capella said again in a strained voice as she opened her eyes and looked away. "Story of my life recently."

"We can get you some medical care right now," Bow said as he started to stand and Capella scooted back a little involuntarily.

"No!" Capella said before calming down. "No, I'm alright. Listen, I don't want to talk about my scars. I want to talk about what's happened… you know, Dark Moon."

She watched both of them closely, waiting to see how they'd react. Glimmer let out a long sigh and Bow grimaced as she said the name. Coalfire had suggested she bring it up as soon as she could, so she wouldn't be lulled into complacency by their presence, and so she figured she'd done it as soon as she could. Glimmer and Bow looked at each other for a moment before Glimmer spoke.

"It's not out of Bright Moon," Glimmer said. "Catra told us about how they had your passphrase which means either we have a leak in the guard or in our comms."

"Or both," Capella said with a raised eyebrow.

Glimmer gave her a little nod in acknowledgement as she said, "Yes, or both. But no, I do not have some hit squad and I certainly didn't send them after you. Why would I!?"

Capella shifted a little in her chair as she said matter-of-factly, "To protect the succession, to protect the reputation of the crown, to protect me in some misguided fashion, or a reason I haven't thought of. If you're going to ask why they would kill, same answers, or it could even be that they got out of hand and you weren't aware but that you decided the damage was done and doubled down."

Glimmer and Bow both looked at her a bit open-mouthed at her recitation before Bow said, "You know, when we had Raskin teach you logic, that wasn't what I was expecting."

Capella rolled her eyes as she said, “Stop trying to deflect with humor. Can you answer those possibilities?”

Glimmer and Bow looked at each other and then Capella, their faces getting a bit desperate as silence stretched out before Glimmer finally said, “I can’t think of a way. At least not in any airtight way.”

“You're asking us to prove a negative,” Bow said as he adjusted his glasses for a moment. “You know how hard that can be.”

Capella slowly nodded as she thought about Iceson sitting with Aeron. She thought about what Juliet had told her and what Catra had said and things Izzy had talked about with her. The two main voices of worry in her life about Dark Moon now, besides her own inner voice, were Gress and Coalfire and even Gress wasn’t so sure.

“Did Aunt Juliet tell you about meeting me?” Capella said. Bow shook his head while Glimmer looked angry for a moment before reigning it in and shaking her head as well. “The night… the night Grandpa died, the night you were in Dryl talking with Gress, Mom, I was in the room with Grandpa. Juliet figured out it was me and talked to me for a moment when I left the room. She told me that if Dark Moon was real, she would have already done something about it. She, uh, she got me thinking.”

“Juliet saw and talked with you that night?” Glimmer said and Capella could hear the barely contained anger in her voice.

“Don’t you dare be mad at her,” Capella said, pointing at Glimmer, her own anger coming up a little. “Her not immediately ratting me out that night is a big part of why I’m sitting here right now. She did you a favor. Gress as well.” Capella looked down and seemed to get a little smaller before she went on. “Also, I just… I’m sorry about Grandpa. The memorial was beautiful.”

“You were close to the family that day I heard. Ellie said she smelled you at one point,” Glimmer said. “Thank you for going.”

“You saw me that day you know,” Capella said softly. Glimmer seemed confused and Capella went on. “I was looking at Grandma, thinking, and you went up to her. You looked right at me with an odd look on your face and I realized that I had no cause, with the face I was wearing, to be looking at either one of you like that and left. I should have said something then maybe but I was scared. I did try to go and spend time by his side as much as I could though before.”

Capella wiped at her eye before the tear that formed could get out of her eye as Bow said, “Thank you.”

“I did it because I promised I would,” Capella said. “Is Grandma doing OK?”

“She’s mostly been in seclusion at Bright Moon,” Bow said. “She spends time with my dads as well.”

Capella nodded and went quiet as she thought. She finally looked at Glimmer as she said, “I guess I should say I don’t think you’re behind Dark Moon. Probably.”

“Probably?” Glimmer said with a raised eyebrow.

“Yes, probably,” Capella said. “My life has been full of uncertainty, lies, half-truths, and illusions for a while now, so probably. That being said, I…,” Capella faltered as she leaned forward, her eyes still on both her parents before she went on. “Well, I miss you. I know I’ve screwed up but I want to, I don’t know, fix this, give you a chance, give me a chance.”

Tears started down both of their faces as Glimmer and Bow nodded.

“We’d like that,” Bow replied.

Capella seemed to relax as she said, “I would as well. So understand when I say I’m not moving back to Bright Moon, it isn’t because I don’t want to fix this.”

“I will be thrilled if I just hear from you,” Glimmer said and then realized how that sounded as she went on. “Not criticizing! I’m

just happy to talk with you!”

Capella said, “No, you can criticize me a bit. Aunt Catra said you thought I was dead. That was terrible and I didn’t mean for that to happen. I was just trying not to get us tracked to Half Moon. Not that it worked.”

Capella looked away as she muttered the last sentence. Glimmer said, “That was actually a wild guess on Catra’s part. Trust me, the whole communications net breakdown and just the general chaos of the fighting had everything confused.”

“Is it ok if I ask where you’re going to stay?” Bow said hesitatingly.

Capella almost told them but then shut her mouth and shook her head as a thought popped up about being cautious.

“No, I’m not going to say,” Capella responded. “I can’t teleport anymore. I have to be extra careful. We will talk though. You can call me or write to me.”

She felt bad because she could see that Bow was hurt and Glimmer had a stoic face on but she felt like she had to hold on to that last little bit of caution.

"OK," Glimmer finally said. "Know that you will always have a place in our home."

"Thank you but that's a place for a princess," Capella said as she shook her head. "That's not me anymore."

"No, that's a place for our daughter," Glimmer said quietly. "That will always be you, for as long as you choose it, no matter what happens between us."

Capella felt a lump in her throat and found she couldn't respond.

"We're proud of what you've done, even if we hated how you went about it," Bow said. "I love you."

"I love you too," Glimmer said.

"I love you both too," Capella said as she choked back her emotions and made a decision. "I… I'll be staying in either Salineas or the Waste. I actually haven't decided yet. A lot of it is how the warrants work out."

Bow suddenly laughed for a moment before shaking his head.

“A wanted woman,” Bow said with a sad smile. “By us and everyone else.”

“Thank you for trusting us with that,” Glimmer said. “We’ll work to earn that trust.”

“I’ll work on trusting as well,” Capella replied as she stood up. “I have to go. Gress messed his arm up punching Aeron and I want to check on him.” She couldn’t help but smile a little at the thought of punching Aeron, as did the other two in the room. “My contact information is the same and you’re both on the accept list.”

Both of her parents were on their feet and they all stood there staring at each other for a moment. Finally Capella took a step backwards as she said, “I’m going now.”

“We love you,” Glimmer said again as she put her arm around Bow and leaned into him.

“I love you too,” Capella said. “We’ll talk again soon, I promise.”

“Thank you,” Bow said. They again stared at each other before Capella finally slowly turned to the door and walked out.

Chapter End Notes

Well, folks, it's just one more chapter after this. That'll be the epilogue. I'm sure I'll have more to say then but for now I'm

just going to say that this series is not finished. There will be more after this. I'm going to work on some short stories in this series and also work on some other stories my other series *Rage Against the Dying of the Light* that has been much neglected. First though, probably a short break, a chance to think about details for the rest of the series, and then on with the writing.

And most importantly though, thank you to each and every one of you who've read my work. I've said it before, I'll say it again, and I'll say it now. I write for myself. I post for all of you. Thank you.

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

It's all over except for the epilogue.

Note: No Micah, no summary.

Chapter Notes

"Breathe feel love / Give free / Know in your soul / Like your blood knows the way / From your heart to your brain / Knows that you're whole" - Midnight Radio, Hedwig and the Angry Inch

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"This is up-to-date information. Alice has confirmed it's at most a day old," Capella said as her data pad finished uploading its information. She pointed near a symbol of a flame that appeared on the holographic map in Bright Moon's war room as it began to move towards a town. "The troops consolidated here, set outposts here, here, and here, and then the main body went on into the town as shown. I'd say the town gave up without a fight but that implies they were going to fight. Pretty sure it was just a parade as they came in. Gress says every spacebat got safely out of town before they came in though so that's good at least."

Catra's eyes flicked back and forth as she looked over the map. She turned it a little bit as she said, "Not a good spot for us. He's got good supply lines back to Candila and with the other groups he's garrisoned, this means he's got several strike options into either the Kingdom of Snows or across that neutral ground towards either Plumeria or the Fright Zone."

Capella reached her hand into the hologram and zoomed out so they could see the surrounding area better. Then she pointed at the border of the Kingdom of Snows as she said, "He's still short of heavy lifting skiffs and Izzy's network says he's having trouble with parts for the others. So, unless he wants to try and slog through the mountain passes of the Snows in late winter, it'll be Plumeria or the Fright Zone. If I had to guess, I'd say that Plumeria is his target."

Catra agreed as Cowrie, fiddling with the eye patch she wore, said, "His people have been sniffing around Salineas as well. I'd say he'd never breach the Sea Gate but it's been done."

Catra looked up to see Cowrie grinning at her. Catra shifted a little as she cleared her throat and said, "Uh, yeah, it has, but speaking from experience, he doesn't have the capability at the moment. I'm more worried about raids on loyal towns along the coasts."

Cowrie leaned back in her chair and put her huge boots up on the table as she said, "The Salineas Navy has that covered."

Capella grinned as she thought of the fleet of ships that had come to the rescue of those who'd fled from Dryl to the coast. Most of the ships had stayed together after landing the rescued people in Salineas and even before Cowrie was out of the hospital, she'd already been organizing the crews together and they now patrolled the sea and coastlines.

"No issues with the coverage?" Catra asked as she flicked the hologram to show a view of the coastline around Salineas.

"Orca is taking her ship out of Bright Moon harbor this evening. That should close our last real gap," Cowrie responded. "She said thank you for the upgraded cannons by the way."

Catra squeezed her eyes shut at that. Orca had signed on within the last week and she still couldn't believe they'd outfitted the infamous smuggler with better hardware. She'd agreed to sail and fight for them though and she was one of the best on the oceans still so it'd happened.

"We're doing well I think. Oak and Chitin should be in port soon," Cowrie said as she looked at the map. "We'll get an update from them then but I don't think it'll be drastically different."

Capella sat back as she said, "I'll be happy when we get full comms back again. This piecemeal stuff isn't cutting it."

Catra had to laugh at that as she said, "This isn't that bad. It's about what it was in the old war."

Capella rolled her eyes. It was something that she heard a lot now as people compared what was turning into another war to the one with the Horde and Prime. Catra sat back from the table with a sigh as she put her hands out in front of her and rolled her wrists a few times. Everyone looked towards the door as the guards came to attention and Glimmer walked in.

“Hello, everyone. OK, two things. One, Izzy says Dryl will have the satellites ready to launch in three weeks. Bow says the coders in the Makers Guild have beefed up the software so hopefully the same thing won’t take them out this time and we’ll have full communications again. Two, it’s almost time for you all to clear out for the day,” Glimmer said as she went over and hugged Capella before nodding at Catra. “Your wife said to get home on time so you can be ready for the party tonight.”

Cowrie let her chair thump to the ground as she grabbed her saber from where it sat against the table and slipped the baldric holding it over her shoulder.

“In that case, I’m going to check on the crew. See you all tonight,” Cowrie said as she walked towards the door, one foot thumping a little louder than the other as she went. The limp she had picked up from the fight rescuing people fleeing Dryl was probably going to be permanent but she’d joked she walked oddly on land anyway after being at sea so much so she didn’t notice it.

“Is Gress going to be there tonight?” Catra said as she looked at Capella.

“Yes, he’ll be down with Izzy if they’re not there already,” Capella responded.

Capella remembered after the High Council when she and Gress, along with the rest of the contingent that had traveled with them that far, had accompanied Izzy to the Fright Zone. They’d stopped

for lunch in some field somewhere when Izzy had approached Gress. Harpi had stood by her side as she began to speak.

"Brother Gress, it's pretty obvious you not only know how to keep a secret," Izzy had said with a nod at Capella, "but also that you're pretty clever. You don't have any problem telling authority exactly what you think either."

Gress had looked at Capella for a moment before looking back at Izzy as he said, "It would seem that way, yes. What are you trying to imply?"

Harpi said, "We have a proposition for you, if you'll hear it." Gress nodded and Harpi went on. "I've been Brother Izzy's advisor for years now. However, things have changed. I wish to know if you would take my position."

Capella kept her face under control but Gress didn't even bother. His eyes widened as he said, "Brother Harpi, Brother Izzy, I… I don't know what to say."

"You don't have to answer right now," Izzy replied. "I'm not unhappy with Brother Harpi but something has some up that is more important for him and I would not hold him back from that."

"May I ask what has come up?" Gress asked.

“Of course,” Harpi said and broke into a huge smile. “Brother Dasi and I are joining our homes together. After the fight at Dryl, I thought it best not to wait and asked. He agreed. I’m moving to Bright Moon to be with him.”

Capella smiled as she remembered congratulating Harpi. Gress had accepted the position when they arrived in the Fright Zone but it now meant that her and Gress didn’t see each other nearly enough. He’d been brought up to speed by Harpi and now was by Izzy’s side or running messages to the Clone Council.

Capella and Gress had parted at Dryl, when they’d gone back to reclaim the castle and rescue the people who’d sealed themselves tight under Dryl. Even getting to the castle had been a trial as the bots had put up air defenses and so Izzy, Capella, and Gress along with others had finally walked in on foot after the third time a skiff had barely avoided getting shot out of the air. When they got close, Izzy had gone ahead alone, Finn hanging nervously back as she’d slowly made her way up the road.

Capella had watched from behind Finn as Izzy had begun the final walk to the gates. The castle was a pile of rubble, not much standing, but what Capella would always remember was seeing Izzy becoming surrounded by bots as she walked forward. Capella could see her speaking to them as she went along and soon she was engulfed by a cloud of them so thick that there were moments when she was almost not visible. She’d stopped at the gates as a huge bot that no one recognized the make of came out of the rubble. Everyone recognized what appeared to be a very functional cannon from a Horde tank that it had over its shoulder though and Capella had fought the urge to suddenly transform to

protect Izzy. After a long moment, where Izzy had spoken with the bot in a low voice no one could hear, she'd turned around and come back, the bots still around her.

"They've agreed that I may have the castle back and that they'll cease hostilities for the moment," Izzy said as she patted a little tarantula looking bot that sat on her shoulder. "Now let's get my brothers out of there. Spacebat or not, they would probably like to see some natural light."

The first thing they'd found though was that, miraculously, there had been a contingent of the invaders still alive when they'd gone in. They'd been half-starved and dehydrated because they'd finally locked themselves into a room and blocked any spot something could come in. Izzy hadn't been sure what to do with them. If they were enemy soldiers then they were prisoners and that wasn't something Etherians were very comfortable with. If they were just people who'd attacked though, they were due for rehabilitation. It was Finn who'd made the suggestion.

"There's no reason they can't be our enemies who we give rehabilitation and decency towards while also holding them," Finn had said. "We're not monsters and despite what they did, neither are they."

There weren't many miracles though in the recovery effort. The next few days had been grim, even with the bright spots of rescuing those still alive under Dryl, as they began to figure out what had happened to those who were listed as missing. While there were those who'd been listed as missing that were found safe, there were still too many who were identified among the dead.

Capella remembered using her new found strength in She-Ra to move rubble in a collapsed section of tunnel and finding three people who'd stayed behind to hold the attackers off long enough that it could be sealed and in doing so, had been killed when the roof had collapsed. She'd sat to the side as their brothers had solemnly wrapped them up and carried them off. She'd wept, not caring who saw her in the moment as Gress held her and wept with her. The memories of that, and everything else they'd seen, had been keeping her from sleep, or waking her in panic, ever since.

Now standing in the tactical room at Bright Moon, as Catra spoke to Glimmer for a moment before she left, she looked at what she considered her biggest accomplishment of the last month.

"You're still not sleeping well," Glimmer said with soft concern.

"I'm doing ok," Capella said as she gave her a hug again. "Thank you for checking though."

Capella shoved the guilt down at the happiness on Glimmer's face from the hug. With Iceson spotted by Aeron's side, among other things Gress was investigating, it was becoming obvious that Dark Moon was an invention of Aeron and Capella was having to deal with the guilt every day of having been suckered so completely. Izzy and Harpi had both consoled her, telling her that he was quite good at that kind of thing and she should forgive herself. It still meant she'd screwed up though. Coalfire was the only one who still told her to be on guard.

“Even if it’s not from Bright Moon, doesn’t mean there isn’t something else you haven’t spotted yet,” she’d told her when Capella had started going back to Bright Moon.

Now Glimmer reached out a hand and briefly touched Capella on her arm before saying, “Well, your Dad isn’t as easy a touch as I am on that. Be prepared for questions on both your sleep and whether or not you’re seeing a Listener yet.”

Glimmer hooked her arm into Cappela’s as they began to walk towards Capella’s room. Capella hadn’t stayed the night there yet since she’d begun talking with them but she’d been using it while she was in the castle. The first time she’d stepped in and seen that it’d been cleaned, and by who and why, had actually gone a long way towards her trust being restored.

“I’ll tell you the same, and don’t think I don’t know what you did there, that no, I’m not seeing a Listener yet. Who could even know what I’m going through anyway?” Capella said as she thought about being She-Ra on top of everything else.

“You know better than that,” Glimmer said. “It’s not having someone who knows exactly what you’ve been through, it’s someone who can sympathize and guide you while still being neutral.”

“Alright, enough,” Capella said and her voice came out a little rougher than she intended. She shook her head as she went on.

“Sorry, didn’t mean to say it like that but I don’t feel alright talking about that right now.”

Glimmer, while not happy with it, was used to the harshness that would suddenly pop out of Capella now.

“It’s ok,” Glimmer said as she gave Capella’s arm a hug as they got to Capella’s room. “Do you want to come down to the party with your Dad and me?”

Capella thought about her mother teleporting them and knew it’d just hurt as a reminder of something she’d lost as she said, “No, I’m going to walk.”

As Capella started to open the door Glimmer touched her hand as it went to the doorknob.

“Would it be OK if we walked with you?” Glimmer asked.

Capella looked at her for a moment, fought down the anxiety that popped up before saying, “OK.”

“See you in an hour then?” Glimmer said and Capella nodded before going into her room. She sat down at the balcony and looked out for a little while. It didn’t feel nearly as weird as it had the first time she’d walked back in and she found the silence of

the room comforting. As time to leave came, she grabbed a drink of water and picked up her bags.

She ran her fingers over where the straps had been sewn back together by Mel and Lucy. The colorful thread made simple patterns and she looked at them in her hand as she stood for a moment. She'd be back early the next day for more planning and talks and as she looked around the room she thought about the little hostel room she was staying at in Bright Moon with Alice and Coalfire. Dio had stayed in Plumeria but even with the three, the room was pretty crowded. Capella waffled a moment before putting her bags back down. She figured it was time to try and stay the night and she felt better as she went out to go meet her parents.

The walk to Catra and Adora's house was a relatively quiet one. The conversation had mostly been Bow asking her how she was sleeping and as promised, probed and questioned about it more than Glimmer had. He'd also looked at her dagger but hadn't said anything except for a shake of his head.

As they were leaving, the guards had offered to send a few people along with them. Capella was still nervous around the guards though and they still hadn't found the leak in the guards. She had to admit, there might not be one but that didn't change her nerves around the situation. Glimmer had just smiled as they started to walk and said, "No, thank you. Besides, we've got She-Ra with us. We'll be fine."

Capella was thinking about that as they approached Catra and Adora's house. She wasn't sure what was expected of her as She-

Ra or what she could do. The day they'd left the High Council, Adora had finally managed to speak to Capella for a moment.

"I'm so sorry," were the first words out of her mouth to Capella.

"What do you mean?" Capella had said, backing up a little, the tears forming in Adora's eyes confusing her.

"She-Ra," Adora had said. "You have the mantle of She-Ra and I'm sorry you have that on you."

"You seem the last person who'd be apologizing for that," Capella replied.

"I miss her," Adora had said. "But I also have tried for the last thirty years or so to be something more than just her. That's not why I'm sorry." Adora had stopped, wiped at her eyes, and gone on. "Cappe, every She-Ra I know of has lived a life full of power and amazing deeds but they also all died very young and it terrifies me that now you have this."

"I'm not planning on dying," Capella said. Adora sighed as she looked down for a moment and then back at Capella.

"Neither did Mara," Adora said. "But she did what she thought was right and it killed her." Adora frowned as she thought about the lies being spread about Mara now before going on. "Neither did I,

multiple times, and they were all close calls that still haunt me. I guess what I'm trying to say is that, if you want it, I want to talk with you, give you guidance. I don't want to see you die young."

Capella had politely declined it at the time and gone on but now she thought of it as she walked up to the house and saw Catra and Adora outside talking with Emma. Emma turned in her wheelchair and waved along with Catra and Adora as they came up to the house. Capella could see the new ramp up the stairs to the house that had been built recently as they walked up.

"Good to see you out and about," Glimmer said as she leaned down to hug Emma.

"First trip since I got released from the hospital last week," Emma replied, her voice slurred a little but her smile was strong. "I still get run down real easy which is why I'm in the chair instead of the exo today."

"I'm serious, Emma," Adora said. "You tell us if you need to rest and we'll help you."

Emma looked up at Adora as she said, "I know."

They chatted for a minute more before they all started inside. Capella put her hand on Adora's shoulder and as she turned around, said, "Can I talk to you for a moment, Aunt Adora?"

“Sure,” she said as Bow and Glimmer looked at Capella but went on inside.

When it was just the two of them, Capella said, “I’ve been thinking about what you said back at the High Council. I want to maybe talk with you about, you know, She-Ra. If that’s alright.”

“Of course,” Adora said with a solemn look. “Right now?”

“No. I’m going to go in there and try not to be awkward around a crowd for now,” Capella said. “I just wanted to ask you that.”

“Listen, I know you’re not seeing a Listener,” Adora started to say and Capella managed not to roll her eyes as Adora went on. “No, give me a moment. At the very least, talk to your Mom or Catra. I know guilt and I can see it all over you. Those two both understand what it means to make a decision with big repercussions that wasn’t planned on. For that matter, so do I. Just putting that out there.”

Capella didn’t say anything for a moment before nodding.

“I’ll think about it,” Capella said.

"Fair enough," Adora said and they went inside. Over the course of the evening, Capella spent a lot of time going out the front or back door and pacing in the yard. Gress had come with Izzy and he would pace with Capella in quiet, holding her hand, as she worked through her anxiety before going back inside. During one time, Bow had quietly gone out with them and walked along. Capella had quietly asked Gress to go back inside and Bow looked a bit surprised as Gress left, leaving just the two of them pacing in the front yard.

"I asked Gress to go inside because I thought you might want some time with me," Capella said.

"I do," Bow said with a smile as they made their way around a low collection of bushes by the fence and his gaze turned to the gate that never closed at the front of the yard. "Did I ever tell you that right there is where I think I saw Izzy for the first time?"

Capella shook her head as she said, "No, I don't remember that."

"It was when she and Finn started dating," Bow said as they walked past the gate. "They had a big misunderstanding and that was the night they made up. They had more bumpy roads after but look at them now."

Capella looked at her father and saw that the gray hair that streaked his beard and hair was noticeable thicker than she remembered.

“Trying to make a comment about misunderstandings?” Capella remarked.

“Just pointing out they can be mended and moved past,” Bow said with a little smile. Capella gave a tired smile back to him as she hugged him.

“I know, Dad, and thank you for putting up with me.”

Bow hugged her tight as he said, “It’s my honor.”

Glimmer came out as they were hugging and came over to them to join in. Capella still felt uneasy but at the same time, there was nowhere else she’d want to be at the moment.

“Everything alright?” Glimmer asked as they stepped apart. “I saw Gress come in without you and finally decided to come check up on you.”

“It’s fine,” Capella said. “In fact, I think I know the answer but I’m going to ask anyway. Is it alright if I stay at the castle tonight?”

Bow’s smile went from ear to ear, as did Glimmer’s, as he said, “Of course! What do you want for breakfast! Anything you want!”

Capella looked away, her face hot, as she said, “Stop. Just whatever.”

“I will have a banquet ready,” Glimmer said.

Shortly after, they went inside. Gress looked up from where he sat to see Cappe’s relaxed face and gave a little sigh of relief.

Later in the evening, Finn was talking with the rest of the adults. They’d all gathered in the living room and the kids had all gone to sleep by that point, tucked away around the house, as Finn answered a question Cowrie had asked.

“The theater could actually open right now if we wanted. Maybe the attackers had a plan to go after it later but as it was, the worst damage was from the blasting we did to seal off our escape,” Finn replied.

“No, not your escape,” Izzy said as she squeezed Finn’s hand. “You got clever.”

Everyone heard Izzy’s sarcastic inflection on clever and Finn went quiet for a moment as they remembered the crashing rock right behind them before saying, “But you know what I mean. We’re going to hold off though. The theater works as a good staging area for reconstruction and lodging. It’s a bit crowded with all of that since pretty much the whole troupe came back though. Still can’t believe they did.”

Perfuma spoke up as she said, “They’re dedicated to their work. Just like a lot of people I could mention.”

She looked around the room with a smile as Scorpia patted her on the shoulder.

“Our own daughter being one of them,” Scorpia responded. Prickly Pear was still in Plumeria, which had one of the largest populations of clones on the planet now, and was having to deal with people making attacks on them. Nothing had been tied back to Aeron yet but people knew and one of the big pushes of Izzy’s network was to prove it.

“She certainly didn’t take the path I would have but that’s what kids do, they surprise you,” Perfuma responded.

Elliepurr laughed from where she sat in the kitchen as she said, “That they do.”

Everyone sat up as a loud scream sounded from down the hall from Finn’s old bedroom followed by the sounds of crying. Izzy was on her feet almost immediately but so was Finn as they put a hand on her arm.

“I’ve got it,” they said as they went down the hall. A few minutes later Finn came walking back into the living room with a small

child held in one arm, wearing some of Finn's old pajamas, while another walked along beside them holding Finn's other hand and clutching a stuffed Whispering Woods toy boar. The pale face of the one in Finn's arms was red from crying and both of the children's ears sat back in discomfort. Their pupiless green eyes scanned the room as they came in before the child in Finn's arms buried his face into Finn's shoulder. He still occasionally peaked out at the room as Finn sat down, quietly talking to him as they rocked them a little. The other child, dressed in a set of Finn's old pajamas as well, climbed up into Izzy's lap and laid his head on her shoulder. Elliepurr had got up and made her way carefully over to Izzy, who helped her sit down. Emma rolled a little closer to Izzy as well.

"You OK, Risp?" Elliepurr said as she leaned over and carefully felt Risp's shoulder before moving up to smooth back Risp's hair.

"Yes, Grandma Ellie," the child said quietly. "Brother Oney had a bad dream and I couldn't get him to calm down."

Izzy hugged Risp tight as she said, "It's noble you look out for him, Brother Risp, but remember that it's OK to get help from people."

Risp nodded his head as everyone watched Oney relax and then start to fall asleep in Finn's arms. Talk resumed, quietly, around the room and after fifteen minutes, Finn stood up.

"Risp, I'm going to put Oney back to bed. Do you want to go back to bed as well?" Finn said as they held out their hand. Risp

nodded as Izzy kissed him on the cheek and hugged him as did Elliepurr.

He got up and went over to Catra and Adora and gave them both hugs as he said, "Good night, Grandma Catra and Grandma Adora."

"Good night, sweetheart," Adora said.

"Sleep tight, kiddo," Catra said as she tickled his ear and got a little giggle out of him.

He then went over and gave Emma a hug as well as he said, "Good night, Grandma Emma."

Emma smiled as she looked at him and then around the room at the various people for a moment before saying, "Good night to you too. Sleep well. There's nothing to fear here."

Capella could feel duty settle on her shoulders at Emma's words. She knew that Emma was doing her best to make the child feel safe but as she looked at him, looking like Gress around the time she met him, she mentally swore she'd make sure that was true for not just this home but for anywhere.

"I'm going to lay down with them both," Finn said as Risp came over and took their hand. "Probably won't be back out tonight.

Good night, everyone.”

Everyone wished them good night as Finn walked on. After a brief moment of silence, Emma turned to Izzy and spoke up.

“Still not sleeping through the night?”

“No,” Izzy said, her eyes a little haunted. Both of the children were siblings whose caretakers had been killed defending the tunnels. While they hadn’t seen that, they had seen enough and it would be a long time working with them. They weren’t the only children who’d lost caretakers, it wasn’t an uncommon story among those who’d lived through the attack on Dryl, and when others had stepped up to take on the honor of raising the children, Izzy and Finn had been right beside the rest. “It’s better when we’re in the Fright Zone since we’ve been staying there. Any change really throws them off. Artho is doing amazing work with them though but I’m terrified to see how they’re going to react whenever we move back to Dryl permanently.”

Adora smiled as she said, “You’ll do your best.”

The conversation went on at that point, a few questions getting asked about how Artho was doing with her family and others about how Izzy was finding rehabilitation. Artho had settled with Puffin and Skua in the Fright Zone for the moment and while Capella still didn’t fully trust them, she had to admit that neither Skua nor Artho seemed to be a danger.

Even though Capella thought that perhaps Skua had maybe had sympathies towards the other people of Marasville at one time and their beliefs, Capella had to admit having yourself, your child, and your partner threatened with murder by your neighbors certainly had a way of realigning a person's perceptions. Either way, they'd both answered a lot of questions that had filled in some gaps. That and it'd turned out that one of the things that had gone in the bag before they'd fled Marasville had been full details on Skua's contract, which had given them a shell company that Aeron used, as well as plans for the greenhouse and the surrounding town.

As Izzy talked about doing rehabilitation under Perfuma, taking a moment to tease her a little, Capella stood up and went out back. Gress followed along as Capella looked up at the stars.

"You doing alright?" Gress said.

"Yeah, I am," Capella responded. "I talked with Sert the other day."

"Finally," Gress said. Capella gave him a look as he grinned back at her. "You saved their life, Cappe. Avoiding them wasn't doing you any good."

"Well, it wasn't a long conversation," Capella said. "They're going to live in Salineas now. They're in denial about some of the stuff that's happened. They're convinced Tropistar is alive and in hiding for one. Said that's what that weird phrase they had Aunt Mista deliver for them was supposed to mean."

“You think he is?” Gress said.

Capella looked up at the stars as she remembered him on the floor, unmoving, and shook her head.

“No,” she said quietly as she shoved down the pain. “I wish he was. I wish I could admit that but… no.”

“Well, we’ll go visit them sometime,” Gress said. “Maybe we’ll ask them more.”

Capella sat down in a lawn chair, Gress taking the one next to her, and reached out to squeeze his hand.

“If you ever get some free time,” Capella said with a smile.

“I have a whole new appreciation for what Brother Harpi did,” Gress said. “Maybe this will become a rotating position. In ten years or so I’ll hand it off to someone else.”

Quiet fell as they watched the shifting Etherian night sky. Capella realized she felt good with no reservations, the first time in a long time, and gave a contented sigh.

“Where are we going to be in ten years you think?” Capella asked.

“I don’t know,” Gress said. “If this ends, I think I might go work for Finn’s theater.” Capella grinned as she remembered him having a fanboy moment over one of Finn’s actors years before. Gress went on. “I know at one point I’ll probably have a child as well but that’s a *long* way off.”

Capella gave his shoulder a push as she said, “You sure about that?”

Gress nodded as he said, “I’m not looking forward to the months and months of carrying him to term but yeah, I think it’s something I want to do. Again, *long* way off though.” Capella laughed and Gress smiled at her. It was a rare moment for her to laugh unguardedly now and he treasured the moment he heard his friend do so. “What are you going to do?”

Capella’s grin faded as she said, “I don’t know. I really have no idea. Everything has changed. To be honest, until recently I wasn’t even sure if there would be a future for me.”

“There will be,” Gress said, squeezing her hand tightly. “I expect to have you in mine.”

“And you’ll be in mine as well, buddy,” Capella said as they both leaned forward, touched their foreheads together for a moment

and then went back to watching the night sky.

The End

Author's Note

"I am glad you are here with me. Here at the end of all things, Sam." - J.R.R. Tolkien, The Return of the King

Well, here we are at the end of 245,000+ words. This is the longest thing I have ever written. I'm pretty sure this is the longest single project I have ever undertaken. When I started writing this, I did not expect it to run this long and honestly, I very well could have run it a bit longer I think but I also think the presentation would have suffered. Hell, this ran so long my gender changed (I came out as nonbinary, he/they, a couple of months back if you hadn't heard). I'm happy with what I've put out here and based on your comments from the last few chapters, I feel like the end was a good pay off.

That's going to be the first thing I address here. As I said in the end notes of the last chapter, I write for myself but I post for you. Thank you to each and every one of you for taking part of your time to read what I have posted here. It means a lot to me that you've found something you enjoy in something I've produced.

Let's talk a bit about the story, where it did go and where it did not go.

OK, first, I was originally going to set Glimmer up as being suspected of sympathizing with Aeron's aims. Not that she *did,* but that everyone thought she had been a prisoner of Prime and so of course she must hate clones because of it. I found it was a subplot that I couldn't really fit in and in the end, didn't really want to do anyway. Dark Moon was going to be part of that. Just

assume it’s background propaganda that Aeron probably threw out there.

Another thing I intended to do, and would have made this way longer if I had, was to have more viewpoints of scenes from varying people. I did it a little with Cappe’s abdication and with her birthday but in the end, it was actually more of a pain than I wanted because if I changed dialogue in an edit, I had to go back and change it twice. I still like this idea and I’m glad I did it where I did but yeah, it happened way less than I planned. I also expected to use way more risque language but I could never bring myself to really do so. Gress’ one F-bomb was incredibly satisfying however.

Speaking of Gress, my original plan was to kill him in the battle of Dryl. Yep, you read it right, Gress was marked for death and it would have been Half Ear who did it. However, I wrote the scene with Cappe becoming She-Ra at the High Council first, before almost anything else, and I thought, “No, Gress has to be here for that.” So his death sentence was short-lived. I never really liked the idea anyway so it wasn’t like it was hard to let go. Death of a person's partner to drive the story forward has a place but it’s a really well traveled place and I don’t have anything new to add to it so really, there was no reason to do it. Emma was one that I almost killed as well but didn’t for roughly the same reason. Besides, it felt cheap to finally get her and Izzy to a good spot and then wipe her out.

For those who might wonder, and the setup is there for all of these, Skua had three options for her character. One, what she ended up being, was just an apolitical person who might not really care for clones but can’t really bring herself to hate them. Two, someone who did dislike clones but just kept it under wraps because she loved Artho and knew how she felt. Three, yep, those of you who were worried, she was going to be a plant from Aeron. Two was never very likely. Three came really close to winning but in the end I preferred one and I think it was the better choice. Besides, I’ve picked on poor Artho enough with her

unrequited love for Izzy from *Entrapta's Prize* that she was still dealing with just a little all the way up to Finn and Izzy's wedding.

The ending was slightly different than I planned. I never intended for Cappe to still be struggling in her relationship with her parents at the end but as I worked through this one of the things I kept noticing I was doing was showing the consequences of violence, mentally as well as physically. It's why Carl had to be under observation after getting stunned. It's why Emma has slurred speech from getting smashed in the head. It's why Cappe has her distrust, scars, and the burn and Cowrie is missing an eye and limping. It's why Finn and Izzy's adopted children have issues sleeping. I could go on and on. The original show addressed this a little but with me kicking the rating on this up to Teen, I saw a chance to do it more. Because of that, it didn't feel right to have Cappe be all smiles and fully healed relationships at the end.

OK, this is getting long but I just remembered this and had to put it in. What was Catra and Adora's plan to save Izzy and what was her brothers? Her brother's plan was pretty straightforward. Grab Iz and fight their way out with Blu holding up the guards as long as she could and feeding them false information. They'd all just lived through the fall of Dryl. There was no way they were going to be squeamish. Then they hop on skiffs and just bounce on back out of there, either back to Dryl, Plumeria, or Half Moon.

Catra and Adora's was more subtle. Remember that Double Trouble was running around impersonating a guard. They paid them to be on the guard detail that took Izzy. They were basically going to have them fake orders to move Izzy to a skiff. Then they climb on board and fly off with her and drop out of sight in either the Waste or Seaworthy. Whether two of the biggest figures in recent Etherian history, as well as Izzy being the most wanted person on Etheria at that moment, could disappear is another story.

Now what is happening going forward? Well, *The Heir Apparent* series is very much not finished. There's a freaking war on again for one. Capella is She-Ra and needs to figure that out, and of

course her relationship with those close to her as well, not to mention the warrants. I'd also like to do at least a couple stories of younger Capella, although it's definitely going to be odd getting into that headspace again.

Now with that said, first I'm going to do at least one story in *Rage Against the Dying of the Light* , my very much neglected post-war Horde kids series I started last year, and I have a church camp AU that I've been poking at for a while I'd like to get up as well. So, probably a short break, then some stories elsewhere, and then I'm back with Cappe and gang. And let's be honest. I'll probably be back and forth on everything so I'll be back here sooner rather than later.

To close out, thank you again to all of you for reading and I'm looking forward to getting more out for you all

Chapter End Notes

> It is finished. See the body of the text for my main note and thank you for reading!

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